THE BIBLE

in Plain Language

NEW TESTAMENT

THE BIBLE

IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

VOLUME 4

Matthew to Revelation

With an explanation for every section

EDITED BY ANDREAS RUPP

The Bible in Plain Language
Volume 4: Matthew to Revelation

Edited by Andreas Rupp.

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Volume 1: Genesis to 1 Samuel
Volume 2: 2 Samuel to Psalms
Volume 3: Proverbs to Malachi
Volume 4: Matthew to Revelation

How to read this book

The Bible is the most important book in the world.

It is old. But its message is still true today.

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No verse is left out. No name and no number.

Short sentences

Every line is one short thought.

So you can read in peace.

The numbers

[1] The small numbers are the verse numbers.
With them you can find every passage.
Just like in every other Bible.

The boxes

> **WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?**
> After every section there is a box like this.
> It explains what you have read.
> And what it can mean for us today.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Some passages in the Bible are hard.
They have also been misused, for example against Jews, against women, or to justify violence.
At such passages you will find a note like this.

The Psalms

Some Bibles number the Psalms differently.

Then the other number is given in brackets.

Help

The Bible also tells of suffering and violence.

If something weighs on you: At the end of every volume you will find phone numbers where you can get help.

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MATTHEW

28 CHAPTERS

MATTHEW

Chapter 1

The family tree and the birth of Jesus

Before we begin: The New Testament and the Gospel of Matthew

Now the second large part of the Bible begins: the New Testament. It has 27 books and was written in Greek in the 1st century AD.

At its center is Jesus of Nazareth. He was a Jew and lived from about 4 BC until around the year AD 30 in Galilee and Judea, which at that time were part of the Roman Empire. His followers believe that he is the Messiah (in Greek "Christ"), the Savior sent by God, whom the prophets had announced.

The New Testament begins with four "Gospels." The word means "good news." Each Gospel tells about the life, the teaching, the death, and the resurrection of Jesus, each in its own way: Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John.

The Gospel of Matthew was probably written between AD 70 and 90, probably for Christians with a Jewish background. According to an old church tradition, it comes from Matthew, one of the 12 apostles, who had been a tax collector before (Matthew 9:9). Many scholars today think the author was an unknown teacher who was a Jewish Christian.

Matthew especially shows: Jesus is the promised Messiah of Israel. Again and again he quotes the Old Testament and says that something happened so that what the Lord had spoken through the prophet would come true. Famous parts are the Sermon on the Mount (Chapters 5–7) with the Lord's Prayer, and the Great Commission at the end (28:19–20).

Important note: Matthew tells about fierce arguments between Jesus and other Jewish groups of his time, especially the Pharisees. These were arguments within Judaism. Later these texts were often misused to stir up hatred against Jews. That is a grave injustice. Jesus, Mary, Joseph, and all the apostles were Jews. Hatred of Jews has no place in the Christian faith.

The Gospel has 28 chapters.

The family tree of Jesus VERSES 1–17

1 The book of the family history of Jesus Christ,
the son of David, the son of Abraham.
2 Abraham became the father of Isaac.
Isaac became the father of Jacob.
Jacob became the father of Judah and his brothers.
3 Judah became the father of Perez and Zerah, by Tamar.
Perez became the father of Hezron.
Hezron became the father of Ram.
4 Ram became the father of Amminadab.
Amminadab became the father of Nahshon.
Nahshon became the father of Salmon.
5 Salmon became the father of Boaz, by Rahab.
Boaz became the father of Obed, by Ruth.
Obed became the father of Jesse.
6 Jesse became the father of King David.
King David became the father of Solomon,
by the woman who had been Uriah's wife.
7 Solomon became the father of Rehoboam.
Rehoboam became the father of Abijah.
Abijah became the father of Asa.
8 Asa became the father of Jehoshaphat.
Jehoshaphat became the father of Joram.
Joram became the father of Uzziah.
9 Uzziah became the father of Jotham.
Jotham became the father of Ahaz.
Ahaz became the father of Hezekiah.
10 Hezekiah became the father of Manasseh.
Manasseh became the father of Amon.
Amon became the father of Josiah.
11 Josiah became the father of Jechoniah and his brothers
at the time of the exile to Babylon.
12 After the exile to Babylon,
Jechoniah became the father of Shealtiel.
Shealtiel became the father of Zerubbabel.
13 Zerubbabel became the father of Abiud.
Abiud became the father of Eliakim.
Eliakim became the father of Azor.
14 Azor became the father of Zadok.
Zadok became the father of Achim.
Achim became the father of Eliud.
15 Eliud became the father of Eleazar.
Eleazar became the father of Matthan.
Matthan became the father of Jacob.
16 Jacob became the father of Joseph,
the husband of Mary,
from whom Jesus was born,
who is called Christ.
17 So there are 14 generations in all from Abraham to
David,
14 generations from David to the exile to Babylon,
and 14 generations from the exile to Babylon to the
Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The New Testament begins with a long list of names. To us this may sound boring. But for the first readers it was very important: It shows that Jesus is firmly rooted in the history of Israel.

Verse 1: Jesus is the "son of David," that is, from the royal family, as was promised for the Messiah (2 Samuel 7). And he is the "son of Abraham," that is, an heir of the promise that all nations will be blessed through Abraham (Genesis 12:3).

"Christ" is not a last name, but a title. It is the Greek word for "Messiah," which means "the anointed one."

What is special: Besides the men, this family tree also names four women, which was unusual at that time:

Tamar (verse 3), who fought back against a wrong done by her father-in-law (Genesis 38).

Rahab (verse 5), a woman from Jericho, so not an Israelite (Joshua 2).

Ruth (verse 5), a Moabite, so also a foreigner (book of Ruth).

"Uriah's wife" (verse 6), Bathsheba, to whom King David had done a great wrong (2 Samuel 11).

All four women have unusual stories, and at least two came from other peoples. In this way Matthew shows: Foreigners and people with hard life stories belong to Jesus' family. God writes his story with them too.

Verse 16: It is striking: For everyone else it says "became the father of." About Joseph it only says that he was "the husband of Mary, from whom Jesus was born." In this way Matthew prepares for what comes in the next section.

Verse 17: Three times 14 generations. This is a carefully planned order in which some names have been left out. Maybe the number 14 points to David: The Hebrew letters of "David" add up to the number 14.

The Gospel of Luke has a different family tree of Jesus (Luke 3:23–38). The differences are explained in different ways, for example that Luke shows the line through Mary.

The birth of Jesus VERSES 18–25

18 This is how the birth of Jesus Christ happened:
His mother Mary was engaged to Joseph.
Before they came together,
she was found to be pregnant by the Holy Spirit.
19 Joseph, her husband, was a righteous man
and did not want to put her to shame in public.
So he planned to end the engagement quietly.
20 While he was thinking about this,
an angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream and said,
"Joseph, son of David, don't be afraid
to take Mary as your wife.
For the child she has conceived is from the Holy Spirit.
21 She will give birth to a son.
You shall name him Jesus,
for he will save his people from their sins."
22 All this happened
so that what the Lord had spoken through the prophet would come true:
23 "The virgin will become pregnant
and give birth to a son,
and they will call him Immanuel,"
which means "God with us."
24 When Joseph woke up from his sleep,
he did what the angel of the Lord had commanded him
and took his wife home.
25 And he did not sleep with her
until she had given birth to her firstborn son.
And he named him Jesus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: At that time an engagement was already almost like a marriage. It often lasted a year, and then the woman moved in with her husband. Mary becomes pregnant before she lives together with Joseph. The faith of the church says: The child came into being through the work of the Holy Spirit, without a human father.

Verse 19: For Joseph this was a shock. He had to assume that Mary had been unfaithful to him. According to the law he could have accused her in public. But he was "righteous." Righteous means: living right before God. Here it also means merciful: He did not want to put her to shame, and he wanted to end the engagement quietly.

Verses 20–21: In a dream an angel explains to him what has happened. "Jesus" is the Greek form of the Hebrew name "Yeshua" (Joshua). It means: "The LORD saves." The name says what he will do: He will save his people from their sins.

Verses 22–23: Matthew quotes Isaiah 7:14. The Hebrew text there has the word "almah," which means "young woman." The old Greek translation, which Matthew uses, says "parthenos," "virgin." Christians see in this a pointer to the birth of Jesus; Isaiah himself was probably also thinking at first of a child in his own time.

"Immanuel" means "God with us." This is a basic idea of the whole Gospel of Matthew. At the end Jesus promises that he will be with his disciples always, to the end of the age (28:20).

Verses 24–25: Joseph trusts God, even when he does not understand everything. He takes Mary home and accepts Jesus as his son. He gives him his name, and so, by law, Jesus belongs to the family of David.

"Firstborn son": Christians have different views about whether Mary had more children later. The Gospels mention brothers and sisters of Jesus (13:55–56). Protestant Christians usually understand them as real brothers and sisters, Catholic and Orthodox Christians as close relatives, for example cousins.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 2

The wise men from the east

The wise men come to Jerusalem VERSES 1–8

1 Jesus was born in Bethlehem in Judea,
in the days of King Herod.
Then wise men from the east came to Jerusalem
2 and said,
"Where is the newborn King of the Jews?
For we saw his star in the east
and have come to worship him."
3 When King Herod heard this,
he was troubled, and all Jerusalem with him.
4 He gathered all the chief priests and scribes of the people
and asked them where the Christ would be born.
5 They said to him,
"In Bethlehem in Judea,
for this is what the prophet wrote:
6 'You Bethlehem, land of Judah,
are in no way least among the princes of Judah.
For out of you will come a ruler
who will shepherd my people Israel.'"
7 Then Herod secretly called the wise men
and learned from them exactly when the star had

appeared.
8 He sent them to Bethlehem and said,
"Go and search carefully for the young child.
When you have found him, bring me word,
so that I can also come and worship him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Herod the Great was king over Judea by the favor of Rome. He died in the year 4 BC. So Jesus was born a few years before the start of our calendar. (Our calendar was only fixed in the 6th century, and at that time people miscalculated by a few years.)

The "wise men" (in Greek "magoi") were probably star readers and scholars from Persia or Babylonia. The Bible does not say that there were three of them or that they were kings. Later tradition concluded that from the three gifts.

Important: The first people who worship Jesus are people from foreign nations. This fits with the women from foreign peoples in the family tree (Chapter 1). Jesus came for all nations.

Verse 2: We do not know exactly what the "star" was. Some think of a special position of the planets (Jupiter and Saturn in the year 7 BC), of a comet, or of a miraculous sign.

Verse 3: Herod is troubled. He was known for having even members of his own family killed because he was afraid of losing his power. A new "King of the Jews" was a threat to him.

Verses 5–6: The scribes know the answer from the prophet Micah (Micah 5:2; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 5:1). They know where the Messiah is to be born, but they do not set out themselves.

Verse 8: Herod is lying. He does not want to worship the child, but to kill him.

The wise men find Jesus VERSES 9–12

9 After they had heard the king, they went on their way.
And the star that they had seen in the east
went ahead of them,
until it came and stopped over the place where the
young child was.
10 When they saw the star,
they rejoiced with very great joy.
11 They went into the house
and saw the young child with Mary, his mother.
They fell down and worshiped him.
They opened their treasures
and offered him gifts:
gold, frankincense, and myrrh.
12 In a dream they were warned
not to go back to Herod.
So they went back to their own country another way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: The joy of the wise men is enormous, "very great joy."

Verse 11: It is striking: They come into a "house," not into a stable. The wise men probably came some time after the birth, perhaps months later (compare verse 16: "two years old and under"). Only Luke mentions the manger (Luke 2:7).

Early on, the three gifts were understood like this:

Gold for a king.

Frankincense for God, because frankincense was burned in worship.

Myrrh, a precious resin that was also used for anointing the dead, as a pointer to Jesus' suffering and death.

Frankincense: a sweet-smelling resin that gives off fragrant smoke when burned.

Christians remember this on January 6 (Epiphany, also called Three Kings' Day). In Germany, on this day "star singers" go from house to house and collect donations for children in need.

Verse 12: God protects the child and warns the wise men.

The escape to Egypt VERSES 13–15

13 When they had left,
an angel of the Lord appeared to Joseph in a dream and
said,
"Get up, take the young child and his mother,
and flee to Egypt.
Stay there until I tell you.
For Herod will look for the young child to kill him."
14 So he got up,
took the young child and his mother by night,
and went to Egypt.
15 He stayed there until the death of Herod,
so that what the Lord had spoken through the prophet
would come true:
"Out of Egypt I called my son."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus becomes a refugee as a baby. His family has to flee in the middle of the night from a violent ruler and look for safety in a foreign land. At that time Egypt was a common place of refuge for Jews; a large Jewish community lived in the city of Alexandria.

For today: Many people in the world have to flee from violence and war, like Jesus and his family. Jesus knows what they go through.

Verse 15: Matthew quotes Hosea 11:1. There "my son" means the people of Israel, whom God set free from Egypt. Matthew shows: Jesus lives through the history of Israel once more. Like Israel, he comes out of Egypt.

Joseph obeys God at once, "by night." He protects his family.

The killing of the children in Bethlehem VERSES 16–18

16 When Herod saw that the wise men had tricked him,
he was very angry.
He sent soldiers and had all the boys killed
who were in Bethlehem and in all the surrounding
area,
from two years old and under,
according to the exact time he had learned from the
wise men.
17 Then what the prophet Jeremiah had said came true:
18 "A voice was heard in Ramah,
lamentation, weeping, and great mourning.
Rachel is weeping for her children
and will not be comforted,
because they are no more."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A terrible crime: Herod has all the little boys in Bethlehem killed. Bethlehem was a small place; scholars estimate that there were perhaps 10 to 30 children. Other sources do not report it, but it fits with what we know about Herod's cruelty.

Churches remember this on December 28 (the Feast of the Holy Innocents).

Verse 18: Matthew quotes Jeremiah 31:15. Rachel was Jacob's favorite wife and the "mother" of the people. According to tradition, her grave was near Bethlehem. She weeps for her children. The Bible does not hide the suffering. It lets the pain and the lament stand.

For today: Even today children suffer from violence, war, and the abuse of power. God is on their side. If you are a child or teenager and you experience violence: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

The return to Nazareth VERSES 19–23

19 When Herod had died,
an angel of the Lord appeared in a dream to Joseph in Egypt
20 and said,
"Get up, take the young child and his mother,
and go to the land of Israel.
For those who wanted to kill the young child are dead."
21 So he got up,
took the young child and his mother,
and came into the land of Israel.
22 But when he heard
that Archelaus was ruling over Judea in the place of his father Herod,
he was afraid to go there.
After he was warned in a dream,
he went away into the region of Galilee
23 and came and lived in a town called Nazareth,
so that what the prophets had said would come true:
He will be called a Nazarene.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 19–21: After Herod's death the family can return.

Verse 22: Archelaus, a son of Herod, was just as cruel as his father. The Romans removed him after about 10 years. That is why Joseph moves to Galilee, in the north, where another son of Herod ruled.

Verse 23: Nazareth was a small, unimportant village. It is not mentioned in the Old Testament. "He will be called a Nazarene" is not found word for word anywhere in the prophets. Matthew also says "the prophets" (plural). Perhaps he is thinking of a play on words with the Hebrew word "netzer," which means "branch" (Isaiah 11:1): Jesus is the branch from the root of Jesse. Others think of the "Nazirites," people who were set apart for God in a special way (Judges 13:5).

So Jesus grows up in a small village, far from the capital city. He will be called "Jesus of Nazareth."

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 3

John the Baptizer and the baptism of Jesus

John calls people to repent VERSES 1–6

1 In those days John the Baptizer came
and preached in the wilderness of Judea.
2 He said,
"Repent, for the Kingdom of Heaven is near!"
3 For he is the one the prophet Isaiah spoke about when he said,
"The voice of one crying in the wilderness:
Make the way of the Lord ready!
Make his paths straight!"
4 John himself wore clothing made of camel's hair
and a leather belt around his waist.
His food was locusts and wild honey.
5 Then people went out to him from Jerusalem, from all of Judea,
and from all the region around the Jordan.
6 They were baptized by him in the Jordan
and confessed their sins.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

John the Baptizer is the messenger whom Malachi had announced (Malachi 3:1; 4:5). He was a relative of Jesus (Luke 1:36).

Verse 2: His message: "Repent!" The Greek word means: Change your thinking, change your life, turn to God. "The Kingdom of Heaven" is the Kingdom of God. Matthew says "Heaven" instead of "God," like many Jews at that time, out of deep respect for the name of God.

Verse 3: Matthew quotes Isaiah 40:3. John prepares the way for the one who comes after him.

Verse 4: His clothing reminds us of the prophet Elijah (2 Kings 1:8). Locusts were a common food in the wilderness and were allowed by the law (Leviticus 11:22).

Locusts: large grasshoppers.

Verse 6: Baptism in the Jordan was a sign: I want to make a new start; God should wash me clean. The people openly confessed their guilt while doing it.

Produce fruit that shows you have repented! VERSES 7–12

7 But when he saw many of the Pharisees and Sadducees coming to be baptized,
he said to them,
"You offspring of vipers!
Who warned you to flee from the coming anger of God?
8 So produce fruit that shows you have repented!
9 And don't think you can say to yourselves,
'We have Abraham as our father.'
For I tell you that God is able to raise up children for Abraham from these stones.
10 The ax is already lying at the root of the trees.
Every tree that doesn't produce good fruit
is cut down and thrown into the fire.
11 I baptize you with water for repentance.
But the one who comes after me is mightier than I am.
I am not worthy to carry his sandals.
He will baptize you with the Holy Spirit.

12 His winnowing fork is in his hand,
and he will thoroughly clean his threshing floor.
He will gather his wheat into the barn,
but he will burn up the chaff with fire that can never be put out."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: Pharisees and Sadducees were two important religious groups in the Judaism of that time. The Pharisees thought it was very important to keep the law exactly in everyday life. The Sadducees often belonged to the priests at the temple. John criticizes them harshly, the way the prophets in earlier times criticized the powerful. This is an argument within Judaism. It is not a statement about "the Jews" or about Judaism as a whole. John, Jesus, and the disciples were Jews themselves.

Offspring of vipers: children of poisonous snakes. A very harsh insult.

Verses 8–9: Repentance has to show itself in life, in good deeds. It is not enough to rely on the right ancestry ("We have Abraham as our father"). The same is true for Christians: It is not enough to be baptized or to belong to a church.

Verses 10 and 12: Pictures from farming. A tree without fruit is cut down. When threshing, people throw the grain into the air with a fork: The heavy kernels fall down, the light chaff blows away and is burned. In the same way God will one day separate what lasts from what is worthless.

Chaff: the dry, useless husks around the grain.

Verse 11: John is humble: He does not even think he is worthy to carry the sandals of the one who is coming, a job for slaves. John baptizes with water; the one who is coming will baptize with the Holy Spirit.

Jesus is baptized VERSES 13–17

13 Then Jesus came from Galilee to the Jordan to John to be baptized by him.

14 But John tried to stop him and said,
"I need to be baptized by you,
and you come to me?"

15 But Jesus answered him,
"Allow it now,
for this is the fitting way for us
to fulfill all righteousness."
Then John allowed it.

16 When Jesus had been baptized,
he came up out of the water at once.
The heavens were opened to him,
and he saw the Spirit of God coming down like a dove and coming on him.

17 And a voice out of the heavens said,
"This is my Son. I love him.
I am very pleased with him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–14: Jesus comes to be baptized. John is amazed: Really, Jesus should baptize him!

Verse 15: Jesus answers: In this way we fulfill "all righteousness," that is, what God wants. Jesus stands beside the people who come to be baptized. He joins the line, even though, according to Christian faith, he himself had no need to repent.

Verse 16: Heaven opens, and the Spirit of God comes on Jesus like a dove. Since then the dove has been a sign of the Holy Spirit and also of peace.

Verse 17: God's voice says: "This is my Son. I love him." The words remind us of Psalm 2:7 and Isaiah 42:1. Christians see the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit together in this scene.

For today: Before Jesus has done anything at all, God already says: I love you. Many Christians understand their own baptism in a similar way: God's love comes first, not later as a reward.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 4

The temptation and the first disciples

Jesus is tempted in the wilderness VERSES 1–11

1 Then the Spirit led Jesus up into the wilderness.
There the devil was going to tempt him.
To tempt means: to try to get someone to do wrong.

2 Jesus fasted for 40 days and 40 nights.
After that he was hungry.

3 The tempter came to him.
He said, "If you are the Son of God,
tell these stones to become bread."

4 But Jesus answered,
"It is written:
'People do not live by bread alone.
They live by every word that comes out of God's mouth.'"

5 Then the devil took him into the holy city.
He put him on the highest point of the temple.

6 He said to him,
"If you are the Son of God, throw yourself down!
For it is written:
'He will command his angels to take care of you.'
And:
'They will carry you in their hands,
so that you do not hit your foot against a stone.'"

7 Jesus said to him,
"It is also written:
'Do not test the Lord your God.'"

8 Again the devil took him along, to a very high mountain.
He showed him all the kingdoms of the world and how great they are.

9 He said to him,
"I will give you all these things
if you fall down and worship me."

10 Then Jesus said to him,
"Get away from me, Satan!
For it is written:
'Worship the Lord your God.
Serve only him.'"

11 Then the devil left him.
And angels came and took care of him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: After his baptism Jesus goes into the wilderness and fasts for 40 days. This reminds us of the 40 years that Israel was in the wilderness, and of Moses and Elijah, who fasted for 40 days (Exodus 34:28; 1 Kings 19:8). The Christian season of fasting before Easter (Lent) remembers this.

To fast: to go without food for a time, often in order to pray.

The devil tempts Jesus three times:

1. Bread from stones (verses 3–4): Use your power for yourself! Jesus answers with Deuteronomy 8:3: People need more than bread; they need God's word.

2. Jumping from the temple (verses 5–7): Force God to rescue you in a spectacular way! The devil even quotes the Bible (Psalm 91:11–12). Jesus answers with Deuteronomy 6:16: You should not put God to the test.

3. Power over the world (verses 8–10): Worship me, then you will get everything! Jesus answers with Deuteronomy 6:13: Only God should be worshiped.

Each time Jesus answers with a word from the Bible. Where Israel often failed in the wilderness, Jesus stays faithful.

For today: Everyone knows temptations, for example power, reputation, or quick solutions at the cost of others. Jesus shows that you can say no.

Jesus begins in Galilee VERSES 12–17

12 Jesus heard that John had been arrested.
Then he went back to Galilee.
13 He left Nazareth.
He went to live in Capernaum, a town by the lake,
in the area of Zebulun and Naphtali.
14 This happened so that the words of the prophet Isaiah
would come true.
Isaiah had said:
15 "The land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali,
toward the sea, on the other side of the Jordan,
Galilee of the Gentiles:
16 The people who sat in darkness
saw a great light.
Some people sat in the land where death throws its
shadow.
For them a light has dawned."
17 From then on, Jesus began to preach.
He said,
"Repent! The Kingdom of Heaven is near."
Repent means: turn away from wrong and turn back
to God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: John the Baptizer was thrown into prison by Herod Antipas, the ruler of Galilee (Matthew 14:3–4).

Verse 13: Jesus moves to Capernaum, a town on the Sea of Galilee (also called Lake Gennesaret). He will often be there.

Verses 15–16: The region was called "Galilee of the Gentiles" because many non-Jews lived there. Matthew quotes Isaiah 9:1–2 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles Isaiah 8:23–9:1). It is right there, on the edge, that Jesus begins. He is the "great light" for people in the dark.

Gentiles: people who are not Jews.

Verse 17: Jesus begins with the same message as John: "Repent! The Kingdom of Heaven is near."

The first disciples VERSES 18–22

18 Jesus was walking by the Sea of Galilee.
There he saw two brothers:
Simon, who is called Peter, and his brother Andrew.
They were throwing a net into the lake.
They were fishermen.
19 Jesus said to them,
"Come, follow me.
I will make you fishers of people."
20 At once they left their nets
and followed him.
21 Jesus went on from there.
He saw two other brothers:
James, the son of Zebedee, and his brother John.
They were in the boat with their father Zebedee.
They were fixing their nets.
Jesus called them.
22 At once they left the boat and their father
and followed him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus calls simple fishermen, not scholars or powerful people. They are to become "fishers of people," that is, to win people for God's Kingdom.

They leave everything "at once." This shows how strongly Jesus attracted them. Perhaps they had already known him before (compare John 1:35–42).

Simon receives the extra name "Peter," which means "rock" (compare Matthew 16:18).

Verse 22: James and John even leave their father behind. Their father is not left alone: He has hired workers who help him (Mark 1:20).

Jesus teaches and heals VERSES 23–25

23 Jesus went all around Galilee.
He taught in their synagogues.
He preached the Good News of the Kingdom.
And he healed every disease and every sickness among
the people.
24 The news about him spread through all of Syria.
People brought to him all who were sick.
They had all kinds of diseases and pains.
Some had demons in them.
Some had epilepsy.
Some could not move their bodies.
And Jesus healed them.
25 Large crowds followed him.
They came from Galilee, from the Decapolis, from
Jerusalem, from Judea,
and from the other side of the Jordan.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Matthew sums up what Jesus does: He teaches, he preaches the Good News of the Kingdom of God, and he heals the sick. Words and deeds belong together.

Synagogues were Jewish meeting houses for praying and reading the Holy Scriptures.

Verse 24: At that time many illnesses that we understand medically today were explained as being possessed. Epilepsy, for example, is an illness of the brain, not a

person's fault and not a sign of something evil. Sick people deserve help and respect.

Verse 25: The Decapolis ("Ten Cities") was a region east of the Jordan where mostly non-Jews lived. People come to Jesus from all directions. From Chapter 5 on, his great speech on the mountain follows, the Sermon on the Mount.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 5

The Sermon on the Mount (Part 1): Blessed are …

The Beatitudes VERSES 1–12

1 When Jesus saw the crowds,
he went up onto the mountain.
When he had sat down,
his disciples came to him.
2 He began to speak and taught them. He said,
3 "Blessed are those who are poor in spirit,
for the Kingdom of Heaven belongs to them.
4 Blessed are those who mourn,
for they will be comforted.
5 Blessed are the gentle,
for they will inherit the earth.
6 Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for
righteousness,
for they will be filled.
7 Blessed are those who show mercy,
for they will receive mercy.
8 Blessed are those whose hearts are pure,
for they will see God.
9 Blessed are those who make peace,
for they will be called children of God.
10 Blessed are those who have been persecuted because
they do what is right,
for the Kingdom of Heaven belongs to them.
11 "Blessed are you when people insult you and persecute
you because of me,
and when they lie and say all kinds of evil things
against you.
12 Be joyful and very glad,
for your reward in heaven is great.
That is how they persecuted the prophets who lived
before you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the Sermon on the Mount begins (Chapters 5–7). It is Jesus' best-known speech. Moses received the law on Mount Sinai. In the same way, Jesus teaches on a mountain. He sits down, the way teachers sat when they taught back then.

"Blessed" means: You can be called happy. God gives you his gifts.

The surprise: Jesus does not call the rich, the strong, and the successful happy. He calls the poor, those who mourn, the gentle, those who show mercy, and those who make peace happy. God's Kingdom turns the standards of the world upside down.

Verse 3: "Poor in spirit" means people who know that they need God, and who do not proudly trust in themselves.

Verse 5: This reminds us of Psalm 37:11.

Verse 9: "Those who make peace" means: not only being peaceful, but actively making peace, settling conflicts, and seeking to make up.

Verses 10–12: Whoever stands up for what is right often meets resistance. Jesus says: In this, you stand in the line of the prophets.

For today: The Beatitudes tell people who are having a hard time: God cares about you. If you are sad and need someone to talk to: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Salt of the earth and light of the world VERSES 13–16

13 "You are the salt of the earth.
But if the salt has lost its flavor,
how can it be made salty again?
Then it is good for nothing
except to be thrown out and walked on by people.
14 "You are the light of the world.
A city that is built on a hill cannot be hidden.
15 And people do not light a lamp
and put it under a measuring basket.
They put it on a stand,
and it shines for everyone in the house.
16 In the same way, let your light shine before people,
so that they may see your good works
and praise your Father who is in heaven.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Salt gives flavor and keeps food from going bad. Light makes the darkness bright. Jesus says to his disciples: This is what you are to be for the world.

Important: Jesus does not say, "You are to become salt." He says, "You are the salt." This is a promise, not only a demand.

Verse 13: Real salt does not actually lose its flavor. But back then, salt was often mixed with other things. When the salt was washed out, only worthless leftovers remained.

Verse 15: A "measuring basket" is a container for measuring grain. If you put a lamp under it, it is useless.

Verse 16: Good deeds should not be done for your own honor, but so that people praise God.

Jesus and the law VERSES 17–20

17 "Do not think that I came to do away with the law or the
prophets.
I did not come to do away with them,
but to fulfill them.
18 For I tell you the truth:
Until heaven and earth pass away,
not even the smallest letter or one tiny pen stroke will
pass away from the law
until everything has happened.

19 So whoever breaks one of the least of these
commandments
and teaches others to do the same
will be called least in the Kingdom of Heaven.
But whoever does them and teaches them
will be called great in the Kingdom of Heaven.
20 For I tell you:
If your righteousness is not greater
than that of the scribes and Pharisees,
you will never enter the Kingdom of Heaven.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Jesus does not want to do away with the law of Moses ("the Torah") and the prophets. He wants to "fulfill" them. That means: He wants to show their real meaning and live it out completely.

Verse 18: In Hebrew, "the smallest letter" is the yod (י), a tiny letter. The "tiny pen stroke" is a small hook on a letter. God's word is valid down to the smallest detail.

Verse 20: The scribes and Pharisees took the law very seriously. Jesus says: Your righteousness must be even greater. By this he does not mean even more rules. He means a life that does God's will from the inside, from the heart. The following examples show what that means.

About anger and making peace VERSES 21–26

21 "You have heard that it was said to the people of long
ago:
'You shall not murder,'
and: 'Whoever murders will be in danger of
judgment.'
22 But I tell you:
Everyone who is angry with his brother without a
cause
will be in danger of judgment.
Whoever says to his brother, 'Raca!'
will be in danger of the council.
Whoever says, 'You fool!'
will be in danger of the fire of Gehenna.
23 "So if you are bringing your gift to the altar
and you remember there
that your brother has something against you,
24 then leave your gift there in front of the altar
and go away.
First make peace with your brother.
Then come and offer your gift.
25 Quickly come to an agreement with your opponent
while you are still with him on the way.
Otherwise the one who accuses you may hand you over
to the judge,
and the judge may hand you over to the officer,
and you may be thrown into prison.
26 I tell you the truth:
You will not get out of there
until you have paid the last penny.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Now six examples follow: "You have heard … But I tell you." Jesus shows what the commandments mean at their deepest.

Verses 21–22: The commandment "You shall not murder" is one of the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:13). It already begins with anger and with hurtful words. "Raca" is an Aramaic insult, something like "empty head." Words can hurt people deeply.

"Without a cause" is not in all the old manuscripts. The WEB, our English source text, has it; many other translations leave it out.

"Gehenna" was a valley near Jerusalem. Long ago, children were sacrificed there, and later, garbage was burned there (compare Jeremiah 7:31). It became a picture for God's judgment.

Verses 23–24: For Jesus, making peace is more important than worship! If you live in conflict with someone, you should first seek peace.

Verses 25–26: A picture from the courts: Settle a conflict early, before everything gets worse.

About adultery VERSES 27–30

27 "You have heard that it was said:
'You shall not commit adultery.'
28 But I tell you:
Everyone who looks at a woman with desire for her
has already committed adultery with her in his heart.
29 If your right eye causes you to sin,
tear it out and throw it away from you.
For it is better for you to lose one part of your body
than for your whole body to be thrown into Gehenna.
30 If your right hand causes you to sin,
cut it off and throw it away from you.
For it is better for you to lose one part of your body
than for your whole body to be thrown into Gehenna.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 28: Jesus puts the responsibility on the man, not on the woman. It is not the woman's fault when a man desires her. The man is responsible for how he looks at her and for his thoughts. Women are not objects.

Verses 29–30: This is picture language that exaggerates on purpose, as teachers often did back then. Jesus means: Take sin so seriously that you break completely with what leads you to do evil. He does not mean that you should hurt yourself. The church has never taught that these words should be taken literally.

If you have thoughts of hurting yourself: Please talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

About divorce VERSES 31–32

31 "It was also said:
'Whoever sends his wife away
must give her a certificate of divorce.'
32 But I tell you:
Whoever sends his wife away,
except because of sexual immorality,
makes her commit adultery.
And whoever marries a woman who has been sent
away
commits adultery.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, a man could send his wife away very easily, sometimes for small reasons (compare Deuteronomy 24:1). The woman was then often left without support and

protection. Jesus stands against this unfairness and so protects the women.

"Except because of sexual immorality": This means serious unfaithfulness in marriage. Churches have different views on how exactly to understand this exception.

Important: Jesus wants to protect the weaker ones. These words must never be used to keep someone in a marriage where he or she experiences violence. If you experience violence at home, get help. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

About swearing oaths VERSES 33–37

33 "Again, you have heard that it was said to the people of
long ago:
'You shall not make false vows.
But you shall keep your vows to the Lord.'
34 But I tell you:
Do not swear an oath at all.
Do not swear by heaven, for it is God's throne.
35 Do not swear by the earth, for it is the footstool for his
feet.
Do not swear by Jerusalem, for it is the city of the
great King.
36 And do not swear by your head,
for you cannot make even one hair white or black.
37 Let your 'Yes' be 'Yes' and your 'No' be 'No.'
Anything more than this comes from the evil one.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then, people often swore oaths to make their words stronger. And they used detours ("by heaven," "by Jerusalem") to leave themselves a back door.

Jesus says: Be so honest that you do not need an oath at all. A simple yes or no should be enough.

Churches have different views on whether Christians may take an oath in court. Some groups (for example Mennonites and Quakers) refuse every oath.

About paying back VERSES 38–42

38 "You have heard that it was said:
'An eye for an eye, and a tooth for a tooth.'
39 But I tell you:
Do not resist the person who does evil to you.
If someone hits you on your right cheek,
turn the other cheek to him as well.
40 If someone sues you to take your coat,
let him have your cloak too.
41 If someone forces you to go one mile with him,
go two miles with him.
42 Give to the one who asks you.
And do not turn away from the one who wants to
borrow from you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 38: "An eye for an eye" was first a rule for courts (Exodus 21:24), to limit revenge: The punishment must not be greater than the harm.

Verses 39–41: Jesus goes further: Give up revenge completely. Do not answer violence with violence, but break the cycle.

A blow on the right cheek, given with the right hand, was probably a blow with the back of the hand. That was meant to shame someone. Some Bible scholars think: Whoever turns the other cheek then shows: I am still a human being with dignity.

Verse 40: The "coat" was the shirt-like garment worn next to the body. The "cloak" was the warm outer garment.

Verse 41: Roman soldiers were allowed to force local people to carry their baggage for one mile.

Very important: These words do not mean that you have to put up with violence in the family, in a relationship, or anywhere else. They must never be used to silence victims. It is right to protect yourself, to get help, and to report wrongdoing. Help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Love your enemies VERSES 43–48

43 "You have heard that it was said:
'You shall love your neighbor
and hate your enemy.'
44 But I tell you:
Love your enemies.
Bless those who curse you.
Do good to those who hate you.
And pray for those who treat you badly and persecute
you.
45 Then you will be children of your Father who is in
heaven.
For he makes his sun rise on the evil and the good.
And he sends rain on those who do right and on those
who do wrong.
46 If you love those who love you,
what reward do you have?
Don't even the tax collectors do the same?
47 And if you only greet your friends,
what more are you doing than others?
Don't even the tax collectors do the same?
48 So you shall be perfect,
just as your Father in heaven is perfect.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 43: "You shall love your neighbor" (Leviticus 19:18) is in the law of Moses. "Hate your enemy" is not written like this in the Old Testament. Jesus is probably taking up a common opinion of his time. The Old Testament even says: Help your enemy's animal (Exodus 23:4–5), and give your enemy something to eat when he is hungry (Proverbs 25:21).

Verse 44: "Love your enemies" is one of Jesus' most famous and most difficult sayings. Love here does not mean a warm feeling. It means: wishing the other person well, praying for him, not wanting to harm him.

Verse 45: God himself is like this: He lets the sun shine for everyone, for good people and for evil people.

Verse 46: Back then, tax collectors were seen as cheats and traitors, because they collected taxes for the Romans.

Verse 48: "Perfect" here means: whole, undivided in love. Just as God's love leaves no one out, our love should leave no one out.

Loving your enemies does not mean approving of wrong or not protecting yourself. You can pray for someone and still

keep your distance and set limits.

MATTHEW

Chapter 6

The Sermon on the Mount (Part 2): The Lord's Prayer

Doing good in secret VERSES 1–4

1 "Be careful that you don't do your giving to the poor in front of people
in order to be seen by them.
Otherwise you have no reward from your Father in heaven.
2 So when you do merciful deeds,
don't sound a trumpet in front of you,
as the hypocrites do in the synagogues and in the streets,
so that people will praise them.
Most certainly I tell you,
they have already received their reward.
3 But when you do merciful deeds,
don't let your left hand know what your right hand is doing,
4 so that your merciful deeds may be done in secret.
Then your Father, who sees in secret, will reward you openly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Chapter 6 Jesus speaks about three important ways of living out faith in Judaism: giving to the poor (verses 1–4), praying (verses 5–15), and fasting (verses 16–18). Jesus does not reject them. He only says: Do them for God, not in order to be admired.

"Hypocrite" was originally the Greek word for an actor. It means people who put their faith on show as if they were on a stage. That happens in every religion, among Christians too.

Verse 3: "Don't let your left hand know what your right hand is doing" means: Don't make a big fuss about your good deeds, not even to yourself.

Praying in secret VERSES 5–8

5 "And when you pray,
you shall not be like the hypocrites.
For they love to stand and pray in the synagogues and on the street corners,
so that people will see them.
Most certainly I tell you,
they have already received their reward.
6 But you, when you pray,
go into your room,
shut the door,
and pray to your Father who is in secret.
And your Father, who sees in secret, will reward you openly.
7 When you pray, don't keep repeating empty words as the Gentiles do.
For they think they will be heard because they use many words.
8 So don't be like them,
for your Father knows what you need before you ask him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: Prayer is a personal conversation with God. You don't need an audience for it. This does not forbid praying together in worship; Jesus himself also prayed with others.

Verses 7–8: You don't have to talk God into something with many words. He already knows what we need. Prayer is not a magic trick, but trust.

The Lord's Prayer VERSES 9–15

9 So pray like this:
'Our Father in heaven,
may your name be kept holy.
10 Let your Kingdom come.
Let your will be done on earth as it is in heaven.
11 Give us today our daily bread.
12 Forgive us our debts,
as we also forgive our debtors.
13 Do not bring us into temptation,
but deliver us from the evil one.
For yours is the Kingdom, the power, and the glory forever.
Amen.'
14 "For if you forgive people their wrongdoings,
your heavenly Father will also forgive you.
15 But if you don't forgive people their wrongdoings,
your Father will not forgive your wrongdoings either.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Lord's Prayer is the most important prayer of Christians. It is prayed in all churches around the world. Many of its requests have parallels in Jewish prayers of that time.

"Our Father": We may speak to God like a loving father, not like a distant ruler. "Our" shows: We do not pray alone, but as a community.

The first three requests are about God: his name, his Kingdom, his will. The next requests are about us: bread, forgiveness, protection.

Verse 11: "Our daily bread" means everything we need to live today.

Verse 12: "Debts" is a picture for guilt before God and before people. Whoever receives forgiveness should also forgive others.

Verse 13: "Do not bring us into temptation" means: Keep us from getting into situations in which we fail. God does not lead anyone into evil (James 1:13). That is why some churches pray this request in other words: God should keep us from falling into temptation.

The ending "For yours is the Kingdom ..." is not found in the oldest manuscripts of the Gospel of Matthew. It was added early on in worship. The WEB has it, so it is here. In Catholic services it is prayed in a slightly different way.

Verses 14–15: Forgiveness is very important. But forgiving does not mean approving of wrong, or having to stay in

contact with people who harm you. Forgiving can take time. Victims of violence may take their time and get help.

Fasting in secret VERSES 16–18

16 "And when you fast,
don't be like the hypocrites with gloomy faces.
For they change the look of their faces
so that people will see that they are fasting.
Most certainly I tell you,
they have already received their reward.
17 But you, when you fast,
put oil on your head and wash your face,
18 so that people don't see that you are fasting,
but your Father who is in secret.
And your Father, who sees in secret, will reward you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

To fast means to go without food or other things for a time in order to focus on God. Jesus says: Don't make a show of it. Take care of yourself as on a normal day.

Note: Fasting is not healthy for everyone, for example for people with certain illnesses or with eating disorders. Whoever suffers from an eating disorder should get help from a doctor or therapist. If you need someone to talk to, day or night: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Treasures in heaven VERSES 19–24

19 "Don't store up treasures for yourselves on the earth,
where moths and rust destroy them,
and where thieves break in and steal.
20 Instead, store up treasures for yourselves in heaven,
where neither moths nor rust destroy them,
and where thieves don't break in and steal.
21 For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.
22 "The eye is the lamp of the body.
So if your eye is healthy,
your whole body will be full of light.
23 But if your eye is evil,
your whole body will be full of darkness.
So if the light in you is darkness,
how great that darkness is!
24 "No one can serve two masters.
Either he will hate the one and love the other,
or he will be devoted to one and despise the other.
You can't serve both God and Mammon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 19–21: Everything we own on earth does not last. "Treasures in heaven" are what lasts before God: love, justice, mercy. "Where your treasure is, there your heart will be also": What we hold on to shapes our life.

Verses 22–23: A "healthy" eye here means a generous, honest way of looking at things. An "evil eye" was an expression for envy and greed.

Verse 24: "Mammon" is an Aramaic word for money and possessions. Jesus says: Money can become an idol that rules our life. You cannot serve God and money at the same time.

Don't worry VERSES 25–34

25 "So I tell you,
don't worry about your life,
what you will eat or what you will drink,
or about your body, what you will wear.
Isn't life more than food,
and the body more than clothing?
26 Look at the birds of the sky:
They don't sow, they don't reap,
and they don't gather into barns,
yet your heavenly Father feeds them.
Aren't you worth much more than they are?
27 "Which of you by worrying
can add even one moment to your lifetime?
28 And why do you worry about clothing?
Look at the lilies of the field, how they grow.
They don't work, and they don't spin.
29 Yet I tell you
that even Solomon in all his glory was not dressed like one of these.
30 But if God dresses the grass of the field like this,
which is here today and tomorrow is thrown into the oven,
won't he much more dress you,
you of little faith?
31 "So don't worry, saying,
'What will we eat?',
'What will we drink?'
or, 'What will we wear?'
32 For the Gentiles run after all these things.
Your heavenly Father knows that you need all these things.
33 But seek first God's Kingdom and his righteousness,
and all these things will be given to you as well.
34 So don't worry about tomorrow,
for tomorrow will worry about itself.
Each day has enough trouble of its own.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus is speaking to people who were often really poor and did not know whether they would have enough to eat tomorrow. He does not say that their worries are unimportant. He invites them to trust God.

Verses 26 and 28: The birds and the flowers: God even takes care of them. How much more will he take care of you!

Verse 27: Worrying does not make life longer. It only takes away strength.

Verse 33: A key sentence: "Seek first God's Kingdom and his righteousness …" When God comes first, many other things fall into place.

Verse 34: Live today. Each day has its own challenges.

Important: These words are an invitation to trust, not a reproach. Whoever suffers from fears or an anxiety disorder is not someone "of little faith." Fears are often an illness, and it is good and right to get help from a doctor or therapist. If you need someone to talk to: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

For Christians, trusting God also includes helping others in need. In this way God's care often becomes visible through people.

Chapter 7

The Sermon on the Mount (Part 3): The house on the rock

Don't judge VERSES 1–6

1 "Don't judge,
so that you won't be judged.
2 For with the judgment you use to judge others,
you will be judged,
and with the measure you use to measure,
it will be measured to you.
3 Why do you see the speck in your brother's eye,
but don't notice the beam in your own eye?
4 Or how can you say to your brother,
'Let me take the speck out of your eye,'
when there is a beam in your own eye?
5 You hypocrite!
First take the beam out of your own eye,
and then you can see clearly
to take the speck out of your brother's eye.
6 "Don't give what is holy to the dogs,
and don't throw your pearls to the pigs,
or they may trample them under their feet,
and turn and tear you to pieces.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: "Don't judge" means: Don't condemn other people harshly and without love. Whoever condemns others strictly will be judged by the same standard. It does not mean that you may no longer call wrong what it is.

Verses 3–5: A funny, exaggerated picture: Someone has a whole wooden beam in his eye and wants to pull a tiny speck out of someone else's eye. We often see the faults of others more quickly than our own. First look honestly at yourself; then you can really help others.

Verse 6: A verse that is hard to understand. It probably means: Be wise with the most precious thing you have. Don't force it on people who mock it and attack you. The pictures "dogs" and "pigs" are not names for certain groups of people or nations, and no one may use them that way.

Ask, and it will be given to you VERSES 7–12

7 "Ask, and it will be given to you.
Seek, and you will find.
Knock, and the door will be opened to you.
8 For everyone who asks receives.
Whoever seeks finds.
And to whoever knocks, the door will be opened.
9 Or who among you
will give his son a stone
if he asks him for bread?
10 Or if he asks for a fish,
who will give him a snake?
11 If you, then, though you are evil,
know how to give good gifts to your children,
how much more will your Father in heaven give good things
to those who ask him!
12 So whatever you want people to do to you,
you shall also do to them.
For this is the law and the prophets.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–8: An invitation to pray: Ask, seek, knock! God is listening.

Verses 9–11: No good father gives his child a stone instead of bread. If even people who are not perfect give good things to their children, how much more will God do so.

This does not mean that God fulfills every wish exactly the way we express it. Many people experience that prayers are answered differently, or not in the way they wish. Jesus promises: God gives "good things," that is, what is really good for us. Whoever does not receive what they asked for is not to blame and did not have "too little faith."

Verse 12: The "Golden Rule": Treat others the way you yourself want to be treated. Similar sentences exist in many religions and cultures. The famous Jewish teacher Hillel, who lived shortly before Jesus, is said to have said: What is hateful to you, do not do to your neighbor. That is the whole Torah. Jesus puts the rule in a positive way: Actively do good!

The narrow gate VERSES 13–14

13 "Enter through the narrow gate.
For the gate is wide and the road is broad
that leads to destruction,
and there are many who go in by it.
14 How narrow is the gate
and how hard the road that leads to life,
and there are few who find it!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A picture of two ways: a broad, comfortable road on which many walk, and a narrow road that leads to life. This reminds us of the two ways in Psalm 1 and Deuteronomy 30:15–20.

The way of Jesus is not always the comfortable way that the crowd takes. It takes decision and courage.

Here Jesus does not give an exact number of how many people will be saved in the end. It is a call to look for the right way yourself, not a reason to judge others (compare verse 1).

You will know them by their fruits VERSES 15–23

15 "Beware of false prophets,
who come to you in sheep's clothing,
but inside they are hungry wolves.
16 By their fruits you will know them.
Do people gather grapes from thorns
or figs from thistles?
17 In the same way, every good tree produces good fruit,
but the rotten tree produces bad fruit.
18 A good tree can't produce bad fruit,
and a rotten tree can't produce good fruit.
19 Every tree that doesn't produce good fruit
is cut down and thrown into the fire.
20 So by their fruits you will know them.

21 "Not everyone who says to me, 'Lord, Lord,'
will enter into the Kingdom of Heaven,
but the one who does the will of my Father in heaven.
22 Many will say to me on that day,
'Lord, Lord, didn't we prophesy in your name,
cast out demons in your name,
and do many mighty works in your name?'
23 Then I will tell them,
'I never knew you.
Go away from me, you who do evil!'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 15–20: From the outside, false prophets look harmless and devout like sheep, but inside they want to harm others. How can you recognize them? By their "fruits," that is, by how they live and what their actions bring about.

For today: When religious leaders take advantage of people, put them under pressure, squeeze money out of them, or abuse them, those are bad fruits, no matter how devoutly they talk. Whoever experiences pressure, manipulation, or abuse in a religious group may get help, for example from counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673.

Verses 21–23: Devout words and even spectacular deeds are not enough. What matters is whether someone does God's will: justice, mercy, and love.

The house on the rock VERSES 24–29

24 "So everyone who hears these words of mine and does them
is like a wise man
who built his house on the rock.
25 The rain came down,
the floods came,
and the winds blew and beat against that house,
but it did not fall,
for it was built on the rock.
26 And everyone who hears these words of mine and doesn't do them
will be like a foolish man
who built his house on the sand.
27 The rain came down,
the floods came,
and the winds blew and beat against that house,
and it fell,
and its fall was great."
28 When Jesus had finished saying these things,
the crowds were amazed at his teaching.
29 For he taught them like someone who has authority,
and not like the scribes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The parable of the two houses ends the Sermon on the Mount. Two men build a house. From the outside both houses may look the same. You only notice the difference when the storm comes.

The rock is: hearing Jesus' words and acting on them. Whoever lives like this has a firm foundation, even in the storms of life such as illness, loss, or crises.

Verses 28–29: The people are amazed. The scribes usually explained the Scriptures by pointing to earlier teachers. Jesus speaks with his own authority: "But I tell you." This does not put down the Jewish scribes. Many of them were serious and devout teachers, and Jesus himself was called "Rabbi" (teacher).

Looking back: What have we read in the Sermon on the Mount (Chapters 5–7)?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Beatitudes: God turns to the poor, to those who mourn, to the gentle, to those who show mercy, and to those who make peace (5:3–12).

Salt and light: "You are the salt of the earth. … You are the light of the world" (5:13–14).

God's commandment from the heart: Not only not killing, but making peace. Not only not committing adultery, but being faithful in your heart. No revenge, but love for your enemies (5:21–48).

True faith: Doing good, praying, and fasting, not for show, but for God (6:1–18).

The Lord's Prayer: The prayer that Jesus taught his disciples (6:9–13).

Trust instead of worry: "Seek first God's Kingdom" (6:33).

The Golden Rule: "Whatever you want people to do to you, you shall also do to them" (7:12).

Hearing and doing: Whoever hears Jesus' words and does them builds his house on the rock (7:24).

For today: The Sermon on the Mount has moved people all over the world, even beyond Christianity. Mahatma Gandhi and Martin Luther King Jr., for example, were inspired by it to resist without violence.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 8

Jesus heals and calms the storm

A man with leprosy is healed VERSES 1–4

1 Jesus came down from the mountain.
Large crowds followed him.
2 A man with leprosy came to him.
He knelt down in front of Jesus to honor him.
He said, "Lord, if you want to, you can make me clean."
3 Jesus reached out his hand and touched him.
He said, "I want to. Be clean!"
At once the man was healed of his leprosy.
4 Jesus said to him,
"Make sure you do not tell anyone.
But go and show yourself to the priest.
Bring the gift that Moses commanded.
That will show them that you are healed."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At that time "leprosy" was a name for various serious skin diseases. Whoever had leprosy was considered unclean and had to live outside the villages, separated from family and friends (Leviticus 13:45–46). No one was allowed to touch him.

Verse 3: Jesus does something unheard of: He touches the sick man. For this man it was perhaps the first touch in years. Then Jesus says: "I want to."

Verse 4: Jesus sends the healed man to the priest. That way the priest could confirm the healing, and the man was allowed back into the community (Leviticus 14). Jesus respects the law of Moses.

For today: People are still shut out today because of illnesses. Jesus shows: Sick people belong.

The faith of a Roman officer VERSES 5–13

5 Jesus came into Capernaum.
There a centurion came to him and asked him for help.
6 He said,
"Lord, my servant is lying at home.
He cannot move, and he is suffering terribly."
7 Jesus said to him,
"I will come and heal him."
8 The centurion answered,
"Lord, I'm not worthy for you to come under my roof.
Just say the word, and my servant will be healed.
9 I also have people over me who give me orders.
And I have soldiers under me.
I tell this one, 'Go,' and he goes.
I tell another one, 'Come,' and he comes.
I tell my servant, 'Do this,' and he does it."
10 Jesus heard this and was amazed.
He said to the people who were following him,
"I tell you the truth:
I have not found such great faith in anyone, not even in Israel.
11 I tell you:
Many people will come from the east and from the west.
They will sit at the table with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob in the Kingdom of Heaven.
12 But the children of the Kingdom will be thrown out into the darkness outside.
There will be weeping and grinding of teeth there."
13 Then Jesus said to the centurion,
"Go! What you believed will happen for you."
And his servant was healed in that very hour.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A centurion was a Roman officer who commanded about 100 soldiers. He was not a Jew, and he belonged to the occupying power. Even so, he comes to Jesus, and not for himself, but for his sick servant.

Verse 8: The centurion knows that according to the rules of that time, a devout Jew did not like to enter the house of a non-Jew. He says: You don't have to come. One word from you is enough. These words are still prayed today in the Catholic Mass: "Lord, I'm not worthy …"

Verse 9: He knows about giving orders and trusts that Jesus speaks with authority.

Verses 10–12: Jesus is amazed at the faith of this foreigner. Many people from all nations will sit at the table with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob in the Kingdom of God. "The children of the Kingdom" are those who were sure of their place. This is a warning to everyone who thinks their place with God is safe, Christians too. It is not a statement that God has rejected the Jewish people (compare Romans 11:1–2).

"Weeping and grinding of teeth" is a picture for despair and regret.

Peter's mother-in-law and many others VERSES 14–17

14 Jesus came into Peter's house.
There he saw Peter's mother-in-law.
She was lying in bed with a fever.
15 He touched her hand,
and the fever left her.
Then she got up and served him.
16 In the evening, people brought to him many who were possessed by demons.
With a word he drove out the spirits.
And he healed all who were sick.
17 This happened so that the words of the prophet Isaiah would come true:
"He took our weaknesses on himself.
He carried our diseases."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: Peter was married (compare 1 Corinthians 9:5).

Verse 15: After she is healed, the woman gets up and "serves" Jesus, that is, she takes care of him as a guest. The Greek word "diakonein" is the same word from which "deacon" later came. She is one of the first people who serve Jesus.

Verse 17: Matthew quotes Isaiah 53:4. Jesus takes on the suffering of people.

About people "possessed by demons": At that time some illnesses, especially mental illnesses, were explained as being possessed. Mental illnesses are not a person's fault and not a sign of something evil. People with mental illnesses deserve help and respect.

What it means to follow Jesus VERSES 18–22

18 Jesus saw the many people around him.
So he gave the order to go across to the other side of the lake.
19 Then a scribe came to him.
He said, "Teacher, I will follow you wherever you go."
20 Jesus said to him,
"Foxes have holes.
Birds have nests.
But the Son of Man has no place to lay his head."
21 Another one of his disciples said to him,
"Lord, let me first go and bury my father."
22 But Jesus said to him,
"Follow me!
Let the dead bury their own dead."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: Interesting: A scribe wants to follow Jesus. Not all scribes were against Jesus.

Verse 20: Jesus says honestly: With me there is no security, no fixed home. "Son of Man" is the title Jesus uses most often when he speaks about himself. It reminds us of Daniel 7:13.

Verses 21–22: An answer that is hard to understand. Burying your father was a holy duty. Perhaps the father was not even dead yet, and the man wanted to wait until he had died, which might be years. With sharp words Jesus says: Following him cannot be put off. "The dead" are probably those who have not yet spiritually woken up to life in God's Kingdom. Jesus is not rejecting honor for parents (compare Matthew 15:4).

Jesus calms the storm VERSES 23–27

23 Jesus got into a boat.
His disciples followed him.
24 Suddenly a violent storm came up on the lake.
The waves covered the boat.
But Jesus was asleep.
25 The disciples came and woke him up.
They said, "Save us, Lord! We are dying!"
26 He said to them,
"Why are you so afraid? Your faith is so small!"
Then he got up.
He gave orders to the wind and the lake.
And it became completely calm.
27 The men were amazed.
They said,
"What kind of man is this?
Even the wind and the lake obey him!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

To this day there are sudden, violent storms on the Sea of Galilee, because cold winds come down from the mountains.

Verse 24: Jesus sleeps in the middle of the storm. He is completely calm because he trusts God.

Verses 25–26: The disciples are afraid they will die. Jesus asks them why they are afraid, and then he calms the storm.

Verse 27: In the Old Testament it is God who rules over the sea (Psalm 107:23–30). The disciples ask themselves: Who is this man?

For today: Many people go through storms in their lives. The story gives courage: Jesus is in the boat with us. Being afraid is human. The disciples were afraid too, and Jesus helped them anyway.

Two men possessed by demons in the country of the Gergesenes VERSES 28–34

28 Jesus came to the other side of the lake, into the country of the Gergesenes.
There two men came out of the tombs to meet him.
They were possessed by demons.
They were so wild and dangerous
that no one could go along that road.
29 They shouted,
"What do you want with us, Jesus, Son of God?
Have you come here to torture us before the time?"
30 Far away from them a large herd of pigs was feeding.
31 The demons begged Jesus,
"If you drive us out,
let us go into the herd of pigs."
32 He said to them,
"Go!"
They came out and went into the pigs.
And the whole herd rushed down the steep bank into the lake.
They died in the water.
33 The men who took care of the pigs ran away.
They went into the town.
They told everything,
also what had happened to the men possessed by demons.
34 Then the whole town came out to meet Jesus.
When they saw him,
they begged him to leave their area.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 28: The region lay on the east side of the lake, where mostly non-Jews lived. That is why there were herds of pigs there, which were unclean for Jews. The name of the place is written differently in the old manuscripts: "Gergesenes" (as in the WEB, our English source text), "Gadarenes," or "Gerasenes" (compare Mark 5:1; Luke 8:26).

The two men lived in tombs, cast out and feared. Matthew speaks of two men; Mark and Luke tell about one.

Tombs: graves carved into the rock, like small caves.

Verse 29: The demons recognize at once who Jesus is: the Son of God.

Verse 32: Jesus sets the men free. The pigs rush into the lake. For people at that time this was a sign that evil has really been defeated.

Verse 34: A sad ending: The people of the town are not happy about the healing of the men. They ask Jesus to go away. Perhaps the loss of the herd was more important to them, or they were afraid of his power.

About people "possessed by demons": What the Bible describes as being possessed would today often be understood as a severe mental illness. Whoever is mentally ill is not evil and deserves help. If you need someone to talk to, day or night: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 9

Jesus forgives, calls, and heals

A paralyzed man is healed VERSES 1–8

1 Jesus got into a boat,
crossed over
and came into his own town.
2 Some people brought to him a man who was paralyzed, lying on a mat.
When Jesus saw their faith,
he said to the paralyzed man,
"Cheer up, son!
Your sins are forgiven."

3 Some of the scribes said to themselves,
"This man is blaspheming."
4 Jesus knew their thoughts and said,
"Why do you think evil in your hearts?
5 Which is easier, to say,
'Your sins are forgiven,'
or to say,
'Get up and walk'?
6 But so that you may know
that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins—"
then he said to the paralyzed man,
"Get up, take your mat,
and go home."
7 And he got up
and went home.
8 When the crowds saw this,
they were amazed and praised God,
who had given such authority to people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "His own town" is Capernaum, where Jesus lived (4:13).

Verse 2: Friends bring the paralyzed man to Jesus. Jesus sees "their faith," that is, the faith of the friends too. Sometimes others carry us when we cannot do it ourselves.

First Jesus says: "Your sins are forgiven." He is not saying that the illness was a punishment for sins. He shows: He wants to make the whole person well, body and soul.

Verse 3: The scribes are outraged. According to Jewish faith, only God can forgive sins. When a human being says that, it is blasphemy, unless he really has God's authority.

To blaspheme: to speak against God or to dishonor God.

Verses 5–7: Jesus shows his authority: The paralyzed man gets up and goes home.

Jesus calls Matthew VERSES 9–13

9 As Jesus went on from there,
he saw a man called Matthew sitting at the tax office.
He said to him,
"Follow me!"
And he got up and followed him.
10 As Jesus was sitting at the table in the house,
many tax collectors and sinners came
and sat at the table with Jesus and his disciples.
11 When the Pharisees saw this,
they said to his disciples,
"Why does your teacher eat with tax collectors and sinners?"
12 When Jesus heard it, he said,
"Those who are healthy don't need a doctor,
but those who are sick do.
13 But go and learn what this means:
'I desire mercy, and not sacrifice.'
For I came not to call the righteous,
but sinners to repentance."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: Tax collectors collected taxes and fees for the rulers and often kept more than they were owed. People saw them as cheats and traitors. Of all people, Jesus calls someone like that. According to tradition, this Matthew is the author of this Gospel.

Verses 10–11: Jesus eats with people who were shut out as "sinners." At that time, eating together was a sign of fellowship and acceptance. For devout people this was offensive.

Verse 12: "Those who are healthy don't need a doctor, but those who are sick do." Jesus is there for those who need him.

Verse 13: Jesus says: "I desire mercy, and not sacrifice." This is a quote from Hosea 6:6. Mercy is more important to God than religious rituals.

For today: Jesus shuts no one out. No one is too "bad" for God.

The question about fasting VERSES 14–17

14 Then John's disciples came to him and said,
"Why do we and the Pharisees fast often,
but your disciples don't fast?"
15 Jesus said to them,
"Can the friends of the bridegroom mourn
as long as the bridegroom is with them?
But the days will come
when the bridegroom will be taken away from them,
and then they will fast.
16 No one puts a piece of new, unshrunk cloth on an old garment.
For the patch would tear away from the garment,
and the hole would get worse.
17 People also don't put new wine into old wineskins.
Otherwise the skins burst,
the wine is spilled,
and the skins are ruined.
No, they put new wine into fresh wineskins,
and both are kept safe."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: Jesus compares his time to a wedding. At a wedding no one fasts; people celebrate. But he hints that he will be "taken away," a pointer to his death. Then his disciples will fast too.

Verses 16–17: Two pictures from everyday life. New cloth shrinks when it is washed and tears old cloth apart. New wine is still fermenting and expands. Old, stiff leather wineskins would burst. The new thing that comes with Jesus needs new forms.

Wineskins: bags made of animal skin, used to hold wine.

A girl comes back to life, a woman is healed VERSES 18–26

18 While he was saying these things to them,
a ruler came, knelt down in front of him and said,
"My daughter has just died.
But come and lay your hand on her,
and she will live."
19 Jesus got up and followed him,
and so did his disciples.
20 A woman who had suffered from bleeding for 12 years
came up behind him
and touched the fringe of his garment.
21 For she said to herself,
"If I just touch his garment,
I will be made well."
22 But Jesus turned around,
saw her and said,
"Cheer up, daughter!

Your faith has made you well."
And the woman was well from that hour on.
23 When Jesus came into the ruler's house
and saw the flute players and the noisy crowd,
24 he said to them,
"Go away! The girl isn't dead,
but sleeping."
They laughed at him.
25 But when the crowd had been sent out,
he went in,
took the girl by the hand,
and the girl got up.
26 And the news about this spread through all that land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: A "ruler," probably the leader of a synagogue, comes to Jesus. Mark and Luke give his name: Jairus (Mark 5:22). His daughter has just died, but he trusts Jesus.

Verse 20: The woman had suffered from bleeding for 12 years. According to the law, this made her unclean (Leviticus 15:25). She was probably shut out and lonely. That is why she only dares to come up secretly from behind. The "fringe" was a tassel on the corner of the garment that devout Jews wore (Numbers 15:38).

Verse 22: Jesus lovingly calls her "daughter." She does not have to be ashamed. He heals her and gives her back her dignity.

"Your faith has made you well": This does not mean that people who do not get well have too little faith. Illness is not a punishment for a lack of faith.

Verse 23: At that time flute players and women who mourned aloud were part of every funeral.

Verse 24: "Sleeping": For Jesus, death is not the end, but like a sleep from which he can wake people up.

Verse 25: Jesus takes the girl by the hand, and she gets up. He is not afraid to touch a dead person, even though according to the law that made a person unclean.

Two blind men and a man who could not speak
VERSES 27–34

27 As Jesus went on from there,
two blind men followed him.
They called out and said,
"Have mercy on us, son of David!"
28 When he had come into the house,
the blind men came to him.
Jesus said to them,
"Do you believe that I am able to do this?"
They said to him,
"Yes, Lord."
29 Then he touched their eyes and said,
"Let it be done to you according to your faith."
30 And their eyes were opened.
Jesus strictly warned them,
"See that no one finds out about this!"
31 But they went out
and spread the news about him in all that land.
32 As they were going out,
people brought to him a man who could not speak,
who was possessed by a demon.
33 When the demon had been cast out,
the man who could not speak began to talk.
And the crowds were amazed and said,
"Nothing like this has ever been seen in Israel!"
34 But the Pharisees said,
"He casts out demons by the prince of the demons."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 27: "Son of David" is a title for the Messiah. The blind men recognize who Jesus is, even though they cannot see anything.

Verse 30: Jesus does not want the news of the healing to spread. Perhaps he did not want to be celebrated as a miracle healer or to raise false political hopes.

Verses 33–34: The people are thrilled. But some Pharisees claim that Jesus is working together with the devil. At that time the Pharisees had different attitudes toward Jesus; some were friendly toward him later (compare John 3:1–2; Acts 5:34–39).

Note: Being unable to speak is a disability or an illness, not the result of something evil. People with disabilities deserve respect and an equal place in the community.

The harvest is great VERSES 35–38

35 Jesus went through all the towns and villages.
He taught in their synagogues,
preached the Good News of the Kingdom,
and healed every disease and every sickness among the people.
36 When he saw the crowds,
he was moved with compassion for them,
because they were worn out and scattered
like sheep without a shepherd.
37 Then he said to his disciples,
"The harvest is great,
but the workers are few.
38 So pray to the Lord of the harvest
that he will send out workers into his harvest."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 36: Jesus sees the people and is moved with compassion for them. The Greek word means a deep feeling of sympathy that goes all the way into your gut. The people are like sheep without a shepherd (compare Zechariah 10:2; Ezekiel 34:5).

Verses 37–38: A picture from farming: The field is ripe, but there are too few helpers for the harvest. Many people are waiting for help and for the good news. Jesus asks his disciples to pray that God will send helpers. In the next chapter he then sends out the 12 apostles.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 10

Jesus sends out the 12 apostles

The 12 apostles VERSES 1–4

1 Jesus called his 12 disciples to himself
and gave them authority over unclean spirits,
to cast them out,
and to heal every disease and every sickness.
2 These are the names of the 12 apostles:
first, Simon, who is called Peter,
and Andrew, his brother;
James the son of Zebedee,
and John, his brother;
3 Philip and Bartholomew;
Thomas and Matthew the tax collector;
James the son of Alphaeus,
and Lebbaeus, who was also called Thaddaeus;
4 Simon the Zealot,
and Judas Iscariot, who also betrayed him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus chooses 12 disciples. The number 12 reminds us of the 12 tribes of Israel. With them God begins to gather his people anew.

"Disciple" means student. "Apostle" means "someone who is sent." Now the students become messengers.

The group is very mixed: fishermen, a tax collector (Matthew), who had worked together with the Romans, and a "Zealot" (Simon). Zealots were people who were passionately zealous for God; some of them fought against the Romans. With Jesus, people sit together who would otherwise have been enemies.

"Lebbaeus, who was also called Thaddaeus": In old manuscripts, sometimes one name appears here and sometimes the other. The WEB, our English source text, gives both.

Already here we are told that Judas will later betray Jesus.

The task VERSES 5–15

5 Jesus sent out these 12
and commanded them,
"Don't go among the Gentiles,
and don't enter any town of the Samaritans.
6 Instead, go to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.
7 As you go, preach:
'The Kingdom of Heaven is near!'
8 Heal the sick,
make people with leprosy clean,
and cast out demons.
Freely you received,
so freely give.
9 Don't take any gold, silver, or copper coins in your
money belts,
10 no bag for your journey,
no second coat,
no sandals, and no walking stick.
For the worker deserves his food.
11 Whenever you come into a town or village,
find out who in it is worthy,
and stay there until you go on.
12 When you go into the house,
greet it.
13 If the household is worthy,
let your peace come on it.
But if it isn't worthy,
let your peace come back to you.
14 If anyone doesn't welcome you
or listen to your words,
leave that house or that town
and shake the dust off your feet.
15 Most certainly I tell you,
it will be easier for the land of Sodom and Gomorrah
on the day of judgment
than for that town.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6: At first the apostles are to go only to Israel. God's promises were given first to his people. Later, after the resurrection, Jesus sends his disciples to all nations (28:19).

Verse 8: The disciples do the same as Jesus: preaching and healing. "Freely you received, so freely give": They should not make a business out of it.

Verses 9–10: They are to set out without luggage and trust completely in God and in people's hospitality. "The worker deserves his food": Whoever welcomes them should take care of them.

Verses 12–13: The greeting was "Shalom" (peace). This wish for peace is like a gift.

Verse 14: Shaking the dust off your feet was a sign: We have nothing more to do with you. The responsibility is yours. Violence against those who do not want to listen is not allowed; the disciples should simply move on.

Verse 15: Sodom and Gomorrah (Genesis 19) were a well-known example of God's judgment.

Like sheep among wolves VERSES 16–25

16 "I am sending you out like sheep among wolves.
So be wise as snakes
and innocent as doves.
17 But watch out for people.
For they will hand you over to the courts
and whip you in their synagogues.
18 Yes, you will be brought before governors and kings
because of me,
as a testimony to them and to the nations.
19 But when they hand you over,
don't worry about how or what you will say.
For you will be given what to say in that hour.
20 For it is not you who speak,
but the Spirit of your Father who speaks in you.
21 "Brother will hand over brother to death,
and a father his child.
Children will rise up against their parents
and have them put to death.
22 You will be hated by everyone because of my name.
But whoever endures to the end will be saved.
23 But when they persecute you in this town,
flee into another one.
For most certainly I tell you,
you will not have gone through all the towns of Israel
before the Son of Man comes.
24 "A disciple is not above his teacher,
and a servant is not above his master.
25 It is enough for the disciple to be like his teacher,
and for the servant to be like his master.
If they have called the master of the house Beelzebul,

how much more will they call the members of his household that!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: A well-known saying: "Be wise as snakes and innocent as doves." The disciples should not be naive, but not sneaky either. Wise and honest at the same time.

Verse 17: Jesus announces persecution. In the early days, followers of Jesus really were sometimes punished by Jewish courts, and later also by Roman authorities. At that time most followers of Jesus were Jews themselves; it was a conflict within the same community. These verses must never be used to justify hatred of Jews. On the contrary, in history Jews were persecuted by Christians for centuries, a grave injustice.

Verses 19–20: Whoever stands before a court does not need to worry: God's Spirit will give them the right words.

Verses 21–22: Faith can even divide families. That is a painful experience that many people still go through today, for example in countries where Christians are persecuted.

Verse 23: Fleeing is allowed. No one has to put themselves in danger without need.

Verse 25: "Beelzebul" was a name for the prince of the demons. People had insulted Jesus by saying he worked with the devil (9:34). Things will not go better for his disciples.

Don't be afraid VERSES 26–33

26 So don't be afraid of them.
For there is nothing hidden that will not be revealed,
and nothing secret that will not be known.
27 What I tell you in the dark,
say in the light.
And what you hear whispered in your ear,
proclaim on the housetops.
28 Don't be afraid of those who kill the body
but are not able to kill the soul.
Rather, fear him who is able to destroy both soul and body in Gehenna.
29 "Aren't two sparrows sold for one small coin?
Yet not one of them falls to the ground apart from your Father's will.
30 But even the hairs of your head are all counted.
31 So don't be afraid.
You are worth more than many sparrows.
32 So everyone who acknowledges me before people,
I will also acknowledge before my Father in heaven.
33 But whoever denies me before people,
I will also deny before my Father in heaven.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Three times Jesus says: "Don't be afraid."

Verse 28: People can kill the body, but not the soul. Only God has power over the whole of life. That is why we should respect God more than we fear people.

Gehenna: a valley near Jerusalem; it became a picture for the place of God's final judgment.

Verses 29–31: A tender picture: Sparrows were the cheapest birds at the market. The small coin (in the WEB: "assarion") was worth very little. Even so, God cares about every single sparrow. And he even knows every hair on your head. You are endlessly precious to him.

Verses 32–33: Whoever stands up for Jesus, Jesus will stand up for too. Peter later denied Jesus three times, and Jesus forgave him anyway (John 21:15–19). There is a way back.

Not peace, but a sword VERSES 34–39

34 "Don't think that I came to bring peace on the earth.
I didn't come to bring peace, but a sword.
35 For I came to set a man against his father,
and a daughter against her mother,
and a daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law.
36 And a person's enemies will be the members of his own household.
37 Whoever loves father or mother more than me
is not worthy of me.
And whoever loves son or daughter more than me
is not worthy of me.
38 And whoever doesn't take up his cross and follow me
is not worthy of me.
39 Whoever tries to find his life will lose it.
And whoever loses his life for my sake will find it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 34: A difficult saying. The "sword" here is a picture for separation and decision, not for violence. Jesus rejected violence (compare 5:39; 26:52, where he tells Peter to put his sword away). What it means is: The message of Jesus calls for a decision, and this decision can divide people, even in families. No one may use this verse to justify violence in the name of faith.

Verses 35–36: Jesus quotes Micah 7:6.

Verse 37: Jesus does not demand that people neglect or hate their families. He says: God should come first. Those who follow Jesus often love their families even more and better.

Verse 38: "Whoever doesn't take up his cross …": The cross was the cruelest way the Romans executed people. Jesus is hinting at his own death. Following him can mean suffering. But that does not mean you should patiently put up with injustice, violence, or abuse. Whoever experiences violence may and should get help.

Verse 39: A paradox: Whoever desperately tries to hold on to their life loses it. Whoever gives it for God and for others gains true life.

Whoever welcomes you VERSES 40–42

40 "Whoever welcomes you welcomes me.
And whoever welcomes me
welcomes him who sent me.
41 Whoever welcomes a prophet because he is a prophet
will receive a prophet's reward.
And whoever welcomes a righteous person because he is righteous
will receive a righteous person's reward.
42 And whoever gives one of these little ones even a cup of cold water to drink
because he is a disciple,
most certainly I tell you,
he will not lose his reward."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the end comes a comforting promise: Whoever welcomes the messengers of Jesus welcomes Jesus himself, and so welcomes God.

Verse 42: Even a very small kindness, a cup of cold water, is not forgotten by God. "The little ones" are the simple disciples who are not great and powerful.

For today: Small acts of hospitality and help count with God.

MATTHEW

Chapter 11

Come to me

John the Baptizer's question VERSES 1–6

1 When Jesus had finished giving instructions to his 12
disciples,
he went on from there
to teach and preach in their towns.
2 When John heard in prison about the works of the
Christ,
he sent two of his disciples
3 to ask him,
"Are you the one who is to come,
or should we look for someone else?"
4 Jesus answered them,
"Go and tell John the things you hear and see:
5 The blind see,
the lame walk,
people with leprosy are made clean,
the deaf hear,
the dead are raised up,
and the poor have good news preached to them.
6 Blessed is the one who does not stumble because of me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

John the Baptizer is in prison (4:12). He had announced a Messiah who comes with the fire of judgment (3:10–12). But Jesus heals and eats with sinners. John has doubts: Are you really the one?

It is all right to doubt. Even John, the great prophet, had doubts. Jesus does not scold him.

Verses 4–5: Jesus does not answer with "Yes," but invites them to look: What is happening fulfills the promises of the prophet Isaiah (Isaiah 35:5–6; 61:1). And the good news is brought to the poor.

Verse 6: "Blessed is the one who does not stumble because of me," that is, the one who is not put off because Jesus is different than expected.

Jesus speaks about John VERSES 7–15

7 As they were leaving,
Jesus began to speak to the crowds about John:
"What did you go out into the wilderness to see?
A reed shaken by the wind?
8 Or what did you go out to see?
A man in soft clothing?
Those who wear soft clothing are in kings' houses.
9 Or why did you go out?
To see a prophet?
Yes, I tell you, he is even more than a prophet.
10 For he is the one about whom it is written,
'I am sending my messenger ahead of you,
who will prepare your way before you.'
11 Most certainly I tell you,
among those born of women
no one has arisen who is greater than John the
Baptizer.
Yet the least in the Kingdom of Heaven is greater than
he is.
12 From the days of John the Baptizer until now,
the Kingdom of Heaven suffers violence,
and violent people take it by force.
13 For all the prophets and the law prophesied until John.
14 And if you are willing to accept it,
he is Elijah, who was to come.
15 Whoever has ears to hear, let him hear!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–9: John is not a swaying reed that bends with every wind, and not a pampered man from the royal court. He is a prophet, and even more than that.

Verse 10: Jesus quotes Malachi 3:1. John is the messenger who prepares the way.

Verse 11: John is the greatest of the old time. But with Jesus something new begins: the Kingdom of Heaven. Whoever belongs to it has an even greater dignity.

Verse 12: A difficult verse that is understood in different ways. Perhaps it means: The Kingdom of God is attacked by violent people, as with John, who was thrown into prison. Or: People push their way in with all their strength. The exact meaning is uncertain.

Verse 14: John is the Elijah who was announced (Malachi 4:5; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 3:23).

This generation VERSES 16–19

16 "But what shall I compare this generation to?
It is like children sitting in the marketplaces
who call out to their playmates:
17 'We played the flute for you,
and you didn't dance.
We sang songs of mourning,
and you didn't mourn.'
18 For John came,
not eating and not drinking,
and they say, 'He has a demon.'
19 The Son of Man came,
eating and drinking,
and they say, 'Look, a glutton and a drunkard,
a friend of tax collectors and sinners!'
Yet wisdom is proved right by her children."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A picture from children's games: Some want to play wedding, the others want to play funeral, and nobody joins in. Nothing is good enough for these people.

John lived strictly and fasted. Then they said: "He has a demon." Jesus celebrates with people. Then they said he was "a glutton and a drunkard."

Glutton: someone who eats far too much.

Verse 19: "Yet wisdom is proved right by her children," that is: You can tell by the fruits whether something comes from

God.

How terrible for the towns that did not repent
VERSES 20–24

20 Then he began to scold the towns
in which most of his mighty works had been done,
because they had not repented:
21 "How terrible it will be for you, Chorazin!
How terrible for you, Bethsaida!
For if the mighty works had been done in Tyre and Sidon
that were done in you,
they would have repented long ago in sackcloth and ashes.
22 But I tell you,
it will be easier for Tyre and Sidon on the day of judgment than for you.
23 And you, Capernaum,
you who are lifted up to heaven,
you will go down to Hades.
For if the mighty works had been done in Sodom
that were done in you,
it would still be standing today.
24 But I tell you,
it will be easier for the land of Sodom on the day of judgment than for you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Chorazin, Bethsaida, and Capernaum were small places on the Sea of Galilee. Jesus had done many miracles there. Even so, the people had not changed their lives.

Tyre and Sidon were pagan port cities; Sodom was a well-known example of a place far from God. Jesus says: Even these cities would have repented if they had experienced so much.

Sackcloth and ashes: rough clothing and ashes on the head, signs of sorrow and repentance.

Whoever has received much from God carries more responsibility. That is true for everyone, Christians today too.

"Hades" (the realm of the dead) is a picture here for the deepest fall. In some manuscripts the beginning of verse 23 is a question. Then Jesus asks Capernaum whether it will really be lifted up to heaven.

Come to me
VERSES 25–30

25 At that time Jesus said,
"I praise you, Father, Lord of heaven and earth,
that you have hidden these things from the wise and understanding
and revealed them to little children.
26 Yes, Father, for that is what pleased you.
27 All things have been handed over to me by my Father.
No one knows the Son except the Father,
and no one knows the Father except the Son
and anyone to whom the Son wants to reveal him.
28 "Come to me, all you who are weary and heavily burdened,
and I will give you rest.
29 Take my yoke on you and learn from me,
for I am gentle and humble in heart.
And you will find rest for your souls.
30 For my yoke is easy,
and my burden is light."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 25–26: Jesus thanks God: It is not the scholars and clever people who understand God's secret, but the "little children," the small and simple people. To know God you don't need education, but an open heart.

Verse 27: Jesus has a unique relationship with God the Father. Through him people can come to know God.

Verse 28: One of the most beautiful and best-known sayings of Jesus: "Come to me, all you who are weary and heavily burdened." Jesus invites everyone who is tired, worn out, overwhelmed, weighed down by worries, guilt, or suffering.

Verses 29–30: A yoke was a wooden beam with which two oxen pulled a plow together. It was also a picture for a teaching or a law that you follow. Jesus says: My yoke is easy. He is not harsh and strict, but "gentle and humble in heart." With him you find rest.

If you feel worn out and overloaded and would like to talk to someone: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 12

The Lord of the Sabbath

Heads of grain on the Sabbath
VERSES 1–8

1 At that time Jesus went through the grain fields on the Sabbath.
His disciples were hungry
and began to pick heads of grain and eat them.
2 When the Pharisees saw this,
they said to him,
"Look, your disciples are doing what is not allowed on the Sabbath."
3 But he said to them,
"Haven't you read what David did
when he and those who were with him were hungry?
4 How he went into God's house
and ate the bread of the Presence,
which neither he nor those with him were allowed to eat,
but only the priests?
5 Or haven't you read in the law
that on the Sabbath the priests in the temple break the Sabbath
and yet are not guilty?
6 But I tell you
that someone greater than the temple is here.

7 But if you had understood what this means,
'I desire mercy, and not sacrifice,'
you would not have condemned those who are not guilty.
8 For the Son of Man is Lord of the Sabbath."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Sabbath is the seventh day of the week, a holy day of rest for God (Exodus 20:8–11). It is a great gift: a day on which the poor, servants, and animals may also rest. In Judaism it is still celebrated today.

Verses 1–2: Picking heads of grain at the edge of a field was allowed (Deuteronomy 23:25). But some teachers counted picking grain on the Sabbath as "harvest work," which was forbidden on the Sabbath. Jewish teachers had different opinions about this.

Verses 3–4: Jesus reminds them of King David, who in a time of need ate the holy bread from the sanctuary (1 Samuel 21:1–6).

Bread of the Presence: 12 loaves of bread that were laid out before God in the sanctuary.

Verse 5: The priests also work in the temple on the Sabbath, and that is right.

Verse 7: Again Jesus quotes Hosea 6:6: Mercy is more important to God than rules. Hungry people are more important.

Verse 8: Jesus claims great authority: He is "Lord of the Sabbath."

A healing on the Sabbath VERSES 9–14

9 He went on from there
and came into their synagogue.
10 There was a man there who had a withered hand.
They asked Jesus,
so that they could accuse him,
"Is it allowed to heal on the Sabbath?"
11 He said to them,
"Which of you who has just one sheep
will not grab it and lift it out
if it falls into a pit on the Sabbath?
12 How much more valuable is a person than a sheep!
So it is allowed to do good on the Sabbath."
13 Then he said to the man,
"Stretch out your hand!"
He stretched it out,
and it was made healthy again, just like the other one.
14 But the Pharisees went out
and made plans against him,
how they could kill him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–12: Jesus says: If you rescue a sheep from a pit on the Sabbath, how much more may you help a human being! Even at that time Jewish law allowed people to save a life on the Sabbath. Jesus says: It is always allowed to do good.

Withered: shrunken and unable to move.

Verse 14: Some Pharisees decide to kill Jesus. That is a sad turning point. Important: These were individual opponents, not "the Jews" as a whole. Many ordinary people from the Jewish people followed Jesus with enthusiasm (verse 15).

God's beloved servant VERSES 15–21

15 When Jesus found out about this,
he went away from there.
Large crowds followed him,
and he healed them all.
16 And he commanded them
not to make him known.
17 This happened so that what the prophet Isaiah had said would come true:
18 "Here is my servant whom I have chosen,
my beloved, in whom my soul is well pleased.
I will put my Spirit on him,
and he will proclaim justice to the nations.
19 He will not quarrel or shout,
and no one will hear his voice in the streets.
20 He will not break a bruised reed,
and he will not put out a smoldering wick,
until he leads justice to victory.
21 And in his name the nations will hope."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Matthew quotes Isaiah 42:1–4. Jesus is the "servant of God" on whom God's Spirit rests (compare 3:16–17).

Verse 19: He is not a loud, power-hungry man who gets his way by force.

Verse 20: A beautiful picture: A bruised reed is almost broken; a smoldering wick has almost gone out. Jesus does not throw such people away. He treats the weak and the wounded gently.

Verse 21: The nations, that is, the non-Jews, will also hope in him.

For today: If you feel like a bruised reed, weak and at the end of your strength: God has not given up on you.

Jesus and Beelzebul VERSES 22–37

22 Then people brought to him a man possessed by a demon,
who was blind and could not speak.
And he healed him,
so that the man could speak and see.
23 All the crowds were amazed and said,
"Can this be the son of David?"
24 But when the Pharisees heard this,
they said,
"This man casts out demons only by Beelzebul,
the prince of the demons."
25 Jesus knew their thoughts and said to them,
"Every kingdom divided against itself is ruined,
and every town or house divided against itself will not stand.
26 If Satan casts out Satan,
he is divided against himself.
How then will his kingdom stand?
27 And if I cast out demons by Beelzebul,
by whom do your own people cast them out?
So they will be your judges.
28 But if I cast out demons by the Spirit of God,
then God's Kingdom has come upon you.
29 Or how can anyone go into the strong man's house
and steal his goods

unless he first ties up the strong man?
Only then will he rob his house.
30 "Whoever is not with me is against me,
and whoever doesn't gather with me scatters.
31 So I tell you,
every sin and blasphemy will be forgiven people,
but blasphemy against the Spirit will not be forgiven people.
32 Whoever speaks a word against the Son of Man
will be forgiven.
But whoever speaks against the Holy Spirit
will not be forgiven,
either in this age or in the age to come.
33 "Either make the tree good, and its fruit will be good,
or make the tree rotten, and its fruit will be rotten.
For the tree is known by its fruit.
34 You offspring of vipers!
How can you speak good things when you are evil?
For the mouth speaks what the heart is full of.
35 The good person brings good things out of his good treasure,
and the evil person brings evil things out of his evil treasure.
36 But I tell you
that people will have to give an account on the day of judgment
for every careless word they speak.
37 For by your words you will be declared right,
and by your words you will be condemned."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 24–26: Some Pharisees claim that Jesus works with the devil. Jesus shows how senseless that is: The devil would not fight against himself.

Verse 27: Other Jewish healers also cast out demons at that time. The opponents are using a double standard.

Verses 28–29: If Jesus drives out evil by God's Spirit, then God's Kingdom is already here. Jesus is stronger than "the strong man," that is, evil.

Verses 31–32: "Blasphemy against the Spirit" is a serious saying. It probably means a person who knowingly and constantly calls God's good work devilish. In this way they close themselves off completely from God's forgiveness.

Important: Many people are afraid that they have committed this sin. Pastoral counselors say: Whoever worries about it and looks for forgiveness has precisely not committed it. God forgives everyone who comes to him. If such fears torment you, talk with a pastor or call a crisis line: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verses 34–37: "The mouth speaks what the heart is full of." Our words show what is inside us. Words carry weight.

The sign of Jonah VERSES 38–45

38 Then some of the scribes and Pharisees said to him,
"Teacher, we want to see a sign from you."
39 But he answered them,
"An evil and adulterous generation asks for a sign,
but no sign will be given to it
except the sign of the prophet Jonah.
40 For as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the huge fish,
so the Son of Man will be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth.
41 The people of Nineveh will stand up at the judgment
with this generation
and will condemn it,
for they repented at the preaching of Jonah.
And someone greater than Jonah is here.
42 The Queen of the South will rise up at the judgment
with this generation
and will condemn it,
for she came from the ends of the earth
to hear the wisdom of Solomon.
And someone greater than Solomon is here.
43 "When an unclean spirit has gone out of a person,
it wanders through dry places, looking for rest, and doesn't find it.
44 Then it says,
'I will go back to my house that I came out of.'
And when it comes, it finds the house empty, swept, and put in order.
45 Then it goes and takes along seven other spirits
more evil than itself.
They go in and live there.
And in the end that person is worse off than before.
That is how it will also be with this evil generation."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 39: "Adulterous" is a picture from the prophets for unfaithfulness to God (compare Hosea). It is not about adultery in the literal sense.

Verse 40: The "sign of Jonah": As Jonah was in the fish for three days, so Jesus will be in the grave for three days and then rise again (compare Jonah 1:17; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 2:1). "Three days and three nights" was a way of speaking; in Jewish counting, a day that had only begun also counted.

Verses 41–42: The pagan people of Nineveh (book of Jonah) and the Queen of Sheba (1 Kings 10) listened to God's messengers. With Jesus, even more is here.

Verses 43–45: A picture: It is not enough just to throw evil out. If the "house" stays empty, evil comes back. You have to fill your life with good things.

The true family of Jesus VERSES 46–50

46 While he was still speaking to the crowds,
his mother and his brothers stood outside
and wanted to speak with him.
47 Someone said to him,
"Look, your mother and your brothers are standing outside
and want to speak with you."
48 But he answered the man who had told him,
"Who is my mother,
and who are my brothers?"
49 He stretched out his hand toward his disciples and said,
"Here are my mother and my brothers!
50 For whoever does the will of my Father in heaven
is my brother and sister and mother."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus does not reject his family. He says: There is a new, larger family, the family of God. Everyone who does God's

will belongs to it. He also names "sister" on purpose: Women naturally belong to it.

About the "brothers of Jesus," see the box on 1:25: Protestant Christians usually understand them as real brothers, Catholic and Orthodox Christians as close relatives.

Verse 47 is missing in some old manuscripts. The WEB, our English source text, has it.

For today: People who have no family, or who were hurt by their family, can find a home in God's family.

MATTHEW

Chapter 13

The parables of the Kingdom of Heaven

The parable of the farmer who sows VERSES 1–9

1 On that day Jesus went out of the house
and sat down by the lake.
2 Many people gathered around him.
So he got into a boat and sat down.
The whole crowd stood on the shore.
3 He told them many things in parables.
He said,
"A farmer went out to sow.
4 As he sowed, some seeds fell along the road.
The birds came and ate them up.
5 Others fell on rocky ground,
where they didn't have much soil.
They sprang up at once,
because the soil was not deep.
6 When the sun had risen,
they were scorched.
Because they had no root,
they dried up.
7 Others fell among thorns.
The thorns grew up and choked them.
8 Others fell on good soil
and produced fruit:
some 100 times as much,
some 60,
and some 30.
9 Whoever has ears to hear, let him hear!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A parable is a short story from everyday life. It shows something about God and his Kingdom. You have to think about it in order to understand it.

Jesus sits in the boat; the people stand on the shore. That way many can hear him well.

At that time people sowed by throwing the seeds over the field by hand. Some of it also fell on the road, on stones or among thorns.

The amazing thing is the ending: In spite of all the losses, there is a great harvest. A harvest of 100 times as much was a huge amount.

Jesus himself explains the parable further below (verses 18–23).

Why Jesus speaks in parables VERSES 10–17

10 The disciples came and asked him,
"Why do you speak to them in parables?"
11 He answered them,
"You have been given the gift
of knowing the secrets of the Kingdom of Heaven.
But they have not been given it.
12 For whoever has will be given more,
and he will have more than enough.
But whoever does not have,
even what he has will be taken away from him.
13 That is why I speak to them in parables:
because seeing, they don't see,
and hearing, they don't hear,
and they don't understand.
14 In them the prophecy of Isaiah comes true,
which says,
'You will keep on hearing
but will not understand at all.
You will keep on seeing
but will not perceive at all.
15 For the heart of this people has grown hard.
Their ears hardly hear,
and they have closed their eyes.
Otherwise they might see with their eyes,
hear with their ears,
understand with their heart,
and turn back,
and I would heal them.'
16 But blessed are your eyes, because they see,
and your ears, because they hear.
17 For most certainly I tell you,
many prophets and righteous people wanted to see
what you see,
and didn't see it.
They wanted to hear what you hear,
and didn't hear it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Secrets of the Kingdom of Heaven": This means how God's Kingdom comes. People do not understand that on their own. God gives this understanding as a gift.

Verse 12: Whoever opens up to Jesus' words understands more and more. Whoever closes himself off loses even the little he had. This is not a rule about money and possessions.

Verses 14–15 quote Isaiah 6:9–10. Already the prophet Isaiah had to experience that many did not accept his message. Jesus says: It is the same now.

Important: This does not apply to "the Jews" as a whole. Jesus and all his disciples were Jews themselves. It is about all people who close their hearts, then as now, in the church too.

At the end there is hope: "I would heal them." God wants to heal.

Verses 16–17: The disciples are allowed to experience what many before them had waited for.

Jesus explains the parable of the farmer VERSES 18–23

18 "So listen to what the parable of the farmer means.

19 When anyone hears the word of the Kingdom
and doesn't understand it,
the evil one comes
and snatches away what was sown in his heart.
This is what was sown along the road.
20 What was sown on rocky ground
is the person who hears the word
and at once receives it with joy.
21 But he has no root in himself.
He lasts only for a while.
When trouble or persecution comes because of the word,
he falls away at once.
22 What was sown among the thorns
is the person who hears the word.
But the worries of this life
and the deceitfulness of riches choke the word,
and he produces no fruit.
23 What was sown on good soil
is the person who hears the word and understands it.
He most certainly bears fruit
and produces a crop:
some 100 times as much,
some 60,
and some 30."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The seed is God's word. The different kinds of soil are different people, or also different times in a person's life.

The road: The word does not get through at all.

The rocky ground: Great enthusiasm, but no depth. When things get hard, people give up.

The thorns: Worries and the wish for riches leave no room for God.

The good soil: The word is heard, understood, and changes a person's life.

For today: The parable does not want us to judge other people. It asks each person: How do I listen? What chokes the good in me? And it gives courage: In spite of everything, God's word bears fruit.

Someone who has many worries is not a bad person because of it. Worries are part of life. It is right to look for help.

The weeds among the wheat VERSES 24–30

24 He told them another parable.
He said,
"The Kingdom of Heaven is like a man
who sowed good seed in his field.
25 But while people were sleeping,
his enemy came,
sowed darnel weeds among the wheat,
and went away.
26 When the plants grew and formed grain,
the weeds appeared too.
27 The servants of the owner came to him and said,
'Sir, didn't you sow good seed in your field?
Where did the weeds come from?'
28 He said to them,
'An enemy has done this.'
The servants asked him,
'Do you want us to go and pull them up?'
29 But he said,
'No. If you pull up the weeds,
you might pull up the wheat with them.
30 Let both grow together until the harvest.
At harvest time I will tell the harvest workers,
"First gather up the weeds
and tie them in bundles to burn them.
But gather the wheat into my barn."'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The WEB says "darnel weeds." Darnel is a weed. When it is young, it looks almost exactly like wheat. Only when the grain grows can you see the difference.

The servants want to clean up at once. The owner says: No! Wait! Otherwise you will do damage.

For today: People should not decide for themselves who is a "weed" and who is "wheat." We cannot see into people's hearts. Judgment belongs to God alone.

This parable is a strong warning against everyone who wants to persecute, shut out or kill others in the name of God. Sadly, Christians have often forgotten this in history.

Jesus explains the parable himself in verses 36–43.

The mustard seed and the yeast VERSES 31–35

31 He told them another parable.
He said,
"The Kingdom of Heaven is like a mustard seed.
A man took it and sowed it in his field.
32 It is the smallest of all seeds.
But when it has grown,
it is bigger than the garden plants
and becomes a tree,
so that the birds of the sky come
and live in its branches."
33 He told them another parable:
"The Kingdom of Heaven is like yeast.
A woman took it
and mixed it into about 30 pounds of flour,
until it was all leavened."
34 Jesus told the crowd all these things in parables.
He did not speak to them without a parable.
35 This happened so that what the prophet had said would come true:
"I will open my mouth in parables.
I will speak about things
that have been hidden since the creation of the world."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The mustard seed was known as the smallest seed people knew in daily life. A large bush grows from it, up to about 10 feet tall. Jesus calls it a tree.

The message: God's Kingdom begins very small, with Jesus and a few disciples. But it becomes great. Many find room in it, like the birds in the branches. This reminds us of pictures in the prophets (for example Ezekiel 17:23).

The yeast: A small amount changes the whole dough. The Bible says "three measures" of flour. That is a lot, about 30 pounds, enough bread for many people. That is how God's Kingdom works: quietly, invisibly, but it changes everything.

Leavened: made to rise by yeast.

What is beautiful: Here a woman at her everyday work is the picture for what God does.

Verse 35 quotes Psalm 78:2. There the psalm is linked to Asaph. Matthew calls him a "prophet." Some old manuscripts name the prophet Isaiah here. The WEB does not have that.

Jesus explains the parable of the weeds VERSES 36–43

36 Then Jesus sent the crowd away
and went into the house.
His disciples came to him and said,
"Explain to us the parable of the weeds in the field."
37 He answered them,
"The one who sows the good seed is the Son of Man.
38 The field is the world.
The good seeds are the children of the Kingdom.
The weeds are the children of the evil one.
39 The enemy who sowed them is the devil.
The harvest is the end of the age.
The harvest workers are angels.
40 As the weeds are gathered up and burned in the fire,
so it will be at the end of this age.
41 The Son of Man will send out his angels.
They will gather out of his Kingdom everything
that causes people to stumble,
and all who do evil.
42 They will throw them into the furnace of fire.
There will be weeping and grinding of teeth.
43 Then the righteous will shine like the sun
in the Kingdom of their Father.
Whoever has ears to hear, let him hear!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus explains the picture: God sows good things in the world. But there is evil too. Both grow side by side until the end.

Important: It is not the servants (people) who sort things out, but God's angels, and only at the end. Until then, patience is needed.

"Furnace of fire" and "weeping and grinding of teeth" are strong pictures for judgment (compare 8:12). They show: Evil and injustice have no future. Christians understand in different ways what exactly that will be like. Many see picture language in it, not an exact description.

Verse 43 reminds us of Daniel 12:3: The righteous will shine. That is the goal: light, joy, fellowship with God.

For today: These words are not meant to frighten, but to take seriously how important our actions are. And they comfort everyone who suffers injustice: God does not look away.

The treasure, the pearl and the net VERSES 44–50

44 "Again, the Kingdom of Heaven is like a treasure
hidden in a field.
A man found it and hid it again.
In his joy he goes
and sells everything he has
and buys that field.
45 Again, the Kingdom of Heaven is like a merchant
who is looking for fine pearls.
46 When he had found one very valuable pearl,
he went and sold everything he had
and bought it.
47 Again, the Kingdom of Heaven is like a large net
that was thrown into the sea
and caught fish of every kind.
48 When it was full,
the fishermen pulled it up on the beach.
They sat down
and gathered the good fish into containers.
But the bad ones they threw away.
49 That is how it will be at the end of the world.
The angels will come
and separate the wicked from among the righteous.
50 They will throw them into the furnace of fire.
There will be weeping and grinding of teeth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The treasure and the pearl: Two men find something unbelievably valuable. They give everything for it, and they do it with joy! One finds the treasure by chance; the other searches for a long time. Both happen: Some people find God suddenly, others after a long search.

At that time people often hid their money in the ground, especially in times of war. According to the understanding of that time, whoever bought the field also owned the treasure.

The message: God's Kingdom is the most valuable thing there is. Whoever discovers it is glad to give up other things for it.

The net: At first it catches "fish of every kind." The sorting happens at the end, and it is done by God's angels. As with the weeds: We humans do not do the sorting.

"Bad" fish were, for example, fish that were not allowed to be eaten according to the Jewish food laws (Leviticus 11:9–12), or fish that could not be eaten.

New and old VERSES 51–52

51 Jesus asked them,
"Have you understood all these things?"
They answered him,
"Yes, Lord."
52 He said to them,
"So every scribe
who has become a disciple in the Kingdom of Heaven
is like the owner of a house
who brings new and old things out of his treasure."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A scribe knew the Holy Scriptures very well, that is, what Christians today call the Old Testament. Jesus says: Whoever knows the old and understands the new from Jesus has a great treasure.

The new does not replace the old. Both belong together. That is also one reason why the Christian Bible keeps the Old Testament.

Some interpreters think that Matthew is also describing himself here: a Jewish scholar who follows Jesus.

Jesus in his hometown VERSES 53–58

53 When Jesus had finished these parables,
he went away from there.
54 He came to his hometown
and taught the people in their synagogue.
They were amazed and said,
"Where did this man get this wisdom
and these mighty works?

55 Isn't this the carpenter's son?
Isn't his mother called Mary,
and his brothers James, Joses, Simon, and Judas?
56 Aren't all his sisters here with us?
Where did this man get all these things?"
57 And they took offense at him.
But Jesus said to them,
"A prophet is not without honor
except in his own hometown
and in his own house."
58 And he did not do many mighty works there
because of their unbelief.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

His hometown is Nazareth. There everyone knows him as the son of a craftsman. The Greek word for "carpenter" can also mean a builder in general, who works with wood or stone.

The people think: We know him! That is why they cannot believe that God is working through him.

About the "brothers" and "sisters" of Jesus, see the boxes on 1:25 and 12:46–50: Protestant Christians usually understand them as real brothers and sisters, Catholic and Orthodox Christians as close relatives. Instead of "Joses," some manuscripts have "Joseph."

Verse 58: Jesus does not force anyone. Where people do not trust him, he does few miracles.

Important: This does not mean that sick people today are to blame if they do not get well. Illness is not a sign of too little faith.

For today: Sometimes it is hard to see the good in people you have known for a long time.

MATTHEW

Chapter 14

Bread for thousands and a walk on the water

The death of John the Baptizer VERSES 1–12

1 At that time Herod the tetrarch heard
what people were saying about Jesus.
2 He said to his servants,
"This is John the Baptizer.
He has risen from the dead.
That is why these powers are at work in him."
3 For Herod had arrested John.
He had tied him up and put him in prison.
He did this because of Herodias,
the wife of his brother Philip.
4 For John had said to him,
"It is not lawful for you to have her."
5 Herod wanted to kill him.
But he was afraid of the people,
because they thought John was a prophet.
6 Then Herod's birthday came.
The daughter of Herodias danced in front of the guests,
and she pleased Herod.
7 So he promised her with an oath
to give her whatever she would ask for.
8 Her mother had told her what to say.
So she said,
"Give me here on a platter
the head of John the Baptizer."
9 The king was sad.
But because of his oaths
and because of the guests who were sitting at the table with him,
he ordered that it be given to her.
10 He sent men
and had John beheaded in the prison.
11 His head was brought on a platter
and given to the girl.
And she brought it to her mother.
12 John's disciples came,
took the body and buried it.
Then they went and told Jesus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This Herod is Herod Antipas, a son of Herod the Great (from Chapter 2). He ruled over Galilee and Perea. The WEB calls him "tetrarch," which means "ruler over a fourth part," that is, a regional ruler. Even so, in verse 9 he is called "king," as people at that time often called him.

Herodias had been married before to a half-brother of Herod. John said: This marriage is not allowed by God's law (Leviticus 18:16). For this brave criticism of a powerful man he had to go to prison.

The daughter's name is not given here. The Jewish historian Josephus names a daughter of Herodias "Salome." That is why she became known by this name.

Herod made a careless oath. He does not want to look weak in front of his guests. That is why he has an innocent man killed. Keeping a wrong promise does not make a wrong thing right (compare 5:33–37).

Important: The story is no proof that women are "seductive" or "evil." The main guilt lies with the powerful man who orders the murder.

John is an example for people who speak the truth against injustice, even when it is dangerous.

Verse 12: John's disciples go to Jesus. In their grief they look for him.

Jesus feeds more than 5,000 people VERSES 13–21

13 When Jesus heard this,
he went away from there in a boat
to a lonely place to be alone.
When the people heard about it,
they followed him on foot from the towns.
14 Jesus got out and saw a large crowd.
He had compassion on them
and healed their sick.
15 When evening came,
his disciples came to him and said,
"This is a lonely place,
and it is already late.
Send the people away,

so that they can go into the villages
and buy themselves something to eat."
16 But Jesus said to them,
"They don't need to go away.
You give them something to eat!"
17 They said to him,
"We only have five loaves of bread and two fish here."
18 He said,
"Bring them here to me."
19 He told the people
to sit down on the grass.
He took the five loaves and the two fish,
looked up to heaven and said the blessing.
He broke the loaves
and gave them to the disciples.
And the disciples gave them to the people.
20 They all ate and were full.
They picked up the pieces that were left over:
12 baskets full.
21 Those who had eaten
were about 5,000 men,
besides women and children.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the terrible news, Jesus wants to be alone. He is grieving for John. Even so, he does not send the people away. He has compassion on them.

The disciples think in practical terms: Send them away; they should take care of themselves. Jesus says: "You give them something to eat!" He makes his disciples take responsibility.

What looks like little becomes enough for everyone in Jesus' hands. In the end there is even a lot left over.

Jesus says the blessing, as was usual at Jewish meals: You thank God for the bread. The words "took, looked up, blessed, broke, gave" remind Christians of the Lord's Supper (26:26).

The 12 baskets: The number 12 reminds us of the 12 tribes of Israel and the 12 disciples.

Verse 21: According to the custom of that time, only the men were counted. But Matthew says clearly: Women and children were there too, and they were also filled. So there were many more people.

The miracle reminds us of God, who fed Israel in the wilderness with manna (Exodus 16), and of the prophet Elisha (2 Kings 4:42–44).

For today: Many people still go hungry today. Jesus' words "You give them something to eat" still apply.

Jesus walks on the water VERSES 22–33

22 Right after this, Jesus made the disciples
get into the boat
and go ahead of him to the other side.
Meanwhile he sent the people away.
23 After he had sent the people away,
he went up the mountain by himself to pray.
When evening came, he was there alone.
24 By now the boat was in the middle of the lake.
It was tossed about by the waves,
for the wind was against them.
25 In the fourth watch of the night,
Jesus came to them.
He was walking on the lake.
26 When the disciples saw him walking on the lake,
they were terrified and said,
"It's a ghost!"
And they cried out in fear.
27 But at once Jesus spoke to them:
"Cheer up! It is I!
Don't be afraid!"
28 Peter answered him,
"Lord, if it is you,
command me to come to you on the water."
29 He said,
"Come!"
Peter got out of the boat
and walked on the water
to come to Jesus.
30 But when he noticed how strong the wind was,
he became afraid.
He began to sink
and cried out,
"Lord, save me!"
31 At once Jesus stretched out his hand,
took hold of him and said to him,
"You of little faith, why did you doubt?"
32 When they had climbed into the boat,
the wind stopped.
33 Those who were in the boat
came and worshiped him.
They said,
"You are truly the Son of God!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23: Jesus takes time alone with God in prayer. He too needs rest and prayer.

Verse 25: The "fourth watch of the night" is the time between about 3 and 6 in the morning. So the disciples have been fighting against the wind all night.

"It is I" literally means "I am." This reminds us of the name by which God introduced himself to Moses (Exodus 3:14). In the Old Testament it is God who walks on the sea (Job 9:8).

Peter is brave: He dares to step out of the boat. When he looks at the wind instead of at Jesus, he becomes afraid and sinks. But he calls for help, and Jesus holds on to him at once.

"You of little faith" is not a verdict Jesus gives to put someone down. He says it while he is already holding on to Peter. Doubt and fear are part of faith. What matters is: Peter calls out to Jesus.

Verse 33: For the first time the disciples confess together: Jesus is God's Son.

For today: When you are about to "go under" in life, you may call out: "Lord, save me!" Whoever is in a crisis may also get help from people, for example from a crisis line: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Healings in Gennesaret VERSES 34–36

34 When they had crossed over,
they came to the land of Gennesaret.
35 The people there recognized him.
They sent messengers into all the surrounding region
and brought all the sick to him.
36 They begged him
that they might just touch the fringe of his garment.

And all who touched it were made well.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gennesaret is a fertile plain on the west side of the Sea of Galilee, south of Capernaum.

The "fringe" probably means the tassels on the garment. Jewish men wore them because God had commanded it (Numbers 15:38–39). They remind people of God's commandments. Jesus also wore them as a devout Jew. Compare the woman in 9:20.

The people trust Jesus so much that even a small touch is enough.

For today: Whoever is sick may pray and look for help from doctors. Both belong together. Someone who does not get well does not have less faith because of it.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 15

What really makes a person unclean

An argument about tradition VERSES 1–9

1 Then Pharisees and scribes
came to Jesus from Jerusalem and said,
2 "Why do your disciples break the tradition of the elders?
For they don't wash their hands
when they eat bread."
3 He answered them,
"Why do you also break the commandment of God
because of your tradition?
4 For God commanded,
'Honor your father and your mother,'
and,
'Whoever speaks evil of father or mother
must be put to death.'
5 But you say,
'If anyone tells his father or his mother,
"Whatever help you might otherwise have gotten from me
is a gift devoted to God,"
6 he does not have to honor his father or mother.'
So you have made the commandment of God worthless
because of your tradition.
7 You hypocrites!
Isaiah prophesied well about you when he said,
8 'These people come near to me with their mouth
and honor me with their lips.
But their heart is far from me.
9 They worship me in vain,
for they teach as doctrine
rules made by people.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "tradition of the elders" was rules that Jewish teachers passed on in addition to the law of Moses. They wanted to help people keep God's commandments exactly in everyday life. Washing hands before eating was a religious cleansing, not mainly a matter of hygiene.

Jesus does not criticize hand washing itself. He criticizes this: When a human rule is used to get around a commandment of God, something is wrong.

Verse 4: Jesus quotes the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:12) and Exodus 21:17. The WEB says "speaks evil of," that is: speaks badly about or curses. The death penalty is a law from ancient times. Jesus quotes it to show how seriously God takes caring for parents. It is not a call to use violence today.

Verses 5–6: A person could "devote" his money "to God" (compare Mark 7:11: "Corban"). Then, supposedly, it could no longer be used to help his old parents. Jesus says: That is how God's commandment is undermined. Many Jewish teachers later also viewed such vows critically.

Verses 8–9 quote Isaiah 29:13.

Important: This is not a judgment on "the Jews" or "the Pharisees" as a whole. Here Jesus, as a Jew, is arguing with other Jewish teachers about the right interpretation. The warning against devout words without heart applies to all religions, Christians too.

For today: Caring for old parents is a duty before God. Devout excuses don't count.

What makes a person unclean VERSES 10–20

10 He called the crowd to himself and said to them,
"Listen and understand!
11 It is not what goes into the mouth
that makes a person unclean.
But what comes out of the mouth,
that is what makes a person unclean."
12 Then the disciples came and said to him,
"Do you know that the Pharisees were offended
when they heard this saying?"
13 But he answered,
"Every plant that my heavenly Father did not plant
will be pulled up by the roots.
14 Leave them alone!
They are blind guides of the blind.
If a blind person guides a blind person,
both will fall into a pit."
15 Peter answered him,
"Explain the parable to us."
16 So Jesus said,
"Do you still not understand either?
17 Don't you understand
that whatever goes into the mouth
passes into the stomach
and then out of the body?
18 But what comes out of the mouth
comes from the heart.
And that is what makes a person unclean.
19 For out of the heart come evil thoughts,
murders, adultery, sexual sins,
thefts, false testimony,
and blasphemies.
20 These are the things that make a person unclean.
But eating with unwashed hands

does not make a person unclean."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Unclean" here means: not ready to come before God. Jesus says: What really makes a person unclean is not food, but the evil that comes from the heart.

Verses 13–14: Jesus says: God himself will decide what remains. The disciples should not get into an argument. "Blind guides" is a harsh picture for teachers who want to show others the way, but do not see it themselves.

Important: The picture of the "blind" is not a judgment on people with visual impairments. It is a picture for spiritual blindness.

Verse 19 names things that match many of the Ten Commandments. Evil begins inside, in our thoughts.

The food laws in the Old Testament are God's gift to Israel. Jews still keep them today as a sign of their faithfulness to God. Christians usually understand this saying of Jesus to mean that the food laws are no longer binding for them. That is no reason to look down on the Jewish way of life.

For today: The most important thing is what is in our hearts and how we speak with others.

The Canaanite woman VERSES 21–28

21 Jesus went away from there
into the region of Tyre and Sidon.
22 A Canaanite woman came from that region.
She cried out,
"Have mercy on me, Lord, you son of David!
My daughter is badly tormented by a demon!"
23 But he did not answer her a word.
His disciples came and begged him,
"Send her away,
for she keeps crying out after us."
24 But he answered,
"I was sent only to the lost sheep
of the house of Israel."
25 But she came,
worshiped him and said,
"Lord, help me!"
26 But he answered,
"It is not right
to take the children's bread
and throw it to the dogs."
27 But she said,
"Yes, Lord,
but even the dogs eat the crumbs
that fall from their masters' table."
28 Then Jesus answered her,
"Woman, great is your faith!
Let it be done for you as you want."
And her daughter was healed from that hour on.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tyre and Sidon are cities on the Mediterranean Sea, north of Israel, in today's Lebanon. Mostly people who did not belong to the people of Israel lived there.

"Canaanite": That was the name for the ancient inhabitants of the land. So the woman is a foreigner, not a Jew. Even so, she calls Jesus "son of David."

This story is hard. At first Jesus is silent; then he says a harsh word. At that time "dogs" was an insulting word for people who did not belong to the people. The Greek word literally means "little dogs," that is, house dogs. Interpreters understand the scene very differently: Some think Jesus is testing her faith. Others think Jesus lets himself be moved and convinced by her.

Verse 24: Jesus' task was first for Israel (compare 10:6). At the end of the Gospel he sends the disciples to all nations (28:19).

The woman does not give up. She is clever, brave and quick-witted. She fights for her daughter.

At the end Jesus praises her with very big words: "Great is your faith!" In the Gospel of Matthew he says this only about this foreign woman. He often calls his disciples people of little faith.

Important: This story is no justification for looking down on people of another background. On the contrary: The foreigner becomes an example of faith.

About "demon": People at that time explained many illnesses this way. Mental illnesses or disabilities are not sin and not a punishment.

Jesus heals many people VERSES 29–31

29 Jesus went away from there
and came to the Sea of Galilee.
He went up on the mountain and sat down there.
30 Many people came to him.
They brought with them people who could not walk,
people who were blind,
people who could not speak,
people who were disabled,
and many others.
They laid them down at his feet.
And he healed them.
31 The people were amazed
when they saw it:
People who could not speak were talking,
the disabled were made healthy,
those who could not walk were walking,
and the blind were seeing.
And they praised the God of Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here what the prophet Isaiah announced comes true: The blind see, the lame leap, those who cannot speak shout for joy (Isaiah 35:5–6).

"They praised the God of Israel": Some interpreters think many non-Jewish people were there, because Jesus has just come from foreign territory. But that is not certain.

Important: People with disabilities are loved by God just as they are. Disability is not a punishment.

Jesus feeds more than 4,000 people VERSES 32–39

32 Jesus called his disciples to himself and said,
"I have compassion on these people.
They have already been with me for three days
and have nothing to eat.
I don't want to send them away hungry,
or they might collapse on the way."
33 The disciples said to him,
"Where could we get so many loaves of bread in this lonely place
to feed such a large crowd?"
34 Jesus said to them,
"How many loaves do you have?"

They said,
"Seven, and a few small fish."
35 He told the people
to sit down on the ground.
36 He took the seven loaves and the fish,
gave thanks, broke them
and gave them to the disciples.
And the disciples gave them to the people.
37 They all ate and were full.
They picked up the pieces that were left over:
seven baskets full.
38 Those who had eaten
were 4,000 men,
besides women and children.
39 Then he sent the people away,
got into the boat
and came to the region of Magdala.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is similar to the feeding of the 5,000 (14:13–21). Matthew tells both. Later Jesus himself reminds them of both feedings (16:9–10).

Again Jesus has compassion. He cares about very everyday things: that the people do not have to go home hungry.

The disciples have already seen once how Jesus fed many people. Even so, they ask again where they could get enough bread. People who believe can forget quickly too.

Seven baskets: Some interpreters see the seven as a sign of completeness or of the nations. That is an interpretation, not certain knowledge.

Verse 38: Again women and children are clearly included.

Magdala lies on the west side of the Sea of Galilee. Instead of "Magdala," some old manuscripts have "Magadan."

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 16

"You are the Christ"

The demand for a sign VERSES 1–4

1 The Pharisees and Sadducees came.
They wanted to test him
and asked him
to show them a sign from heaven.
2 But he answered them,
"When it is evening, you say,
'It will be fair weather,
for the sky is red.'
3 And in the morning you say,
'Today there will be bad weather,
for the sky is red and threatening.'
You hypocrites!
You know how to read the look of the sky,
but you can't read the signs of the times!
4 An evil and adulterous generation
asks for a sign.
But no sign will be given to it
except the sign of the prophet Jonah."
And he left them and went away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Pharisees and Sadducees were two Jewish groups with very different views. The Sadducees belonged mainly to the leading priestly families at the temple. Here both appear together.

They ask for a "sign from heaven": proof that Jesus comes from God. Jesus refuses. Faith cannot be forced.

Verses 2–3: Jesus uses a weather rule from everyday life. The people can read the sky, but they cannot recognize what God is doing right now. The "signs of the times" are Jesus' words and deeds.

Verses 2b–3 (from "When it is evening" to "the signs of the times") are missing in some important old manuscripts. The WEB has them.

Verse 4: "Adulterous" is a picture from the prophets. It means: unfaithful to God. The "sign of Jonah" was already explained in 12:39–41: Jonah was in the fish for three days. Christians see in this a pointer to Jesus' death and resurrection.

Important: This is not a judgment on the Jewish people. It is about those who want to test Jesus here.

The yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees VERSES 5–12

5 The disciples came to the other side of the lake.
They had forgotten to bring bread.
6 Jesus said to them,
"Watch out and beware
of the yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees!"
7 They discussed this among themselves and said,
"We didn't bring any bread."
8 Jesus noticed it and said,
"You of little faith,
why are you discussing among yourselves
that you have no bread?
9 Don't you understand yet?
Don't you remember the 5 loaves for the 5,000,
and how many baskets you picked up?
10 And the 7 loaves for the 4,000,
and how many baskets you picked up?
11 How is it that you don't understand
that I was not talking to you about bread?
Beware of the yeast of the Pharisees and Sadducees!"
12 Then they understood:
He had not told them
to beware of the yeast in bread,
but of the teaching of the Pharisees and Sadducees.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here yeast is a picture for something that spreads without being noticed and goes through everything. In 13:33 it was a good picture for God's Kingdom. Here it is a warning.

The disciples are only thinking about the bread they forgot. Jesus reminds them: You have seen that I can provide bread! Don't worry about it.

Verse 12: He means a certain "teaching." Jesus probably means the attitude of demanding signs and rejecting him

(verses 1–4). He does not mean that everything these teachers say is wrong. In 23:2–3 Jesus even says: Do what they teach.

Important: Judaism is not "yeast." Jesus and his disciples were Jews. In history Christians have often misused passages like this to speak badly of Jews. That is wrong.

Peter confesses: You are the Christ VERSES 13–20

13 Jesus came into the region of Caesarea Philippi.
There he asked his disciples,
"Who do people say that I, the Son of Man, am?"
14 They said,
"Some say John the Baptizer.
Others say Elijah.
And still others say Jeremiah or one of the prophets."
15 He said to them,
"But who do you say that I am?"
16 Simon Peter answered,
"You are the Christ,
the Son of the living God."
17 Jesus answered him,
"Blessed are you, Simon Bar Jonah.
For flesh and blood has not revealed this to you,
but my Father in heaven.
18 And I tell you
that you are Peter,
and on this rock I will build my church.
And the gates of Hades
will not overpower it.
19 I will give you the keys of the Kingdom of Heaven.
Whatever you bind on earth
will have been bound in heaven.
And whatever you release on earth
will have been released in heaven."
20 Then he commanded the disciples
to tell no one
that he was Jesus the Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Caesarea Philippi is a town in the north, at the foot of Mount Hermon, near the springs of the Jordan.

"Christ" is Greek and means the same as the Hebrew "Messiah": "the anointed one." That is the king God promised.

Verse 17: "Flesh and blood" means: no human being. Peter did not figure this out himself. God showed it to him. "Bar Jonah" means "son of Jonah."

Verse 18: There is a play on words here. "Peter" comes from the Greek word for "rock" or "stone." The WEB, our English source text, says "assembly," that is, a gathering or congregation. Here we say "church," as many Bibles do.

"The gates of Hades" (the realm of the dead): Not even death will defeat the church.

Christians understand verses 18–19 in different ways. Catholic Christians see here the task given to Peter and his successors, the popes. Protestant Christians often see the "rock" in Peter's faith or confession, or in Christ himself. Orthodox Christians see Peter as the first among the apostles. All agree: Jesus builds his church, not a single human being.

Verse 19: "Binding and releasing" was a way of speaking used by Jewish teachers. It means, for example: forbidding or allowing something, or holding on to guilt or forgiving it. In 18:18 all the disciples receive this task.

Verse 20: Jesus does not want false hopes to arise. Many thought the Messiah would be a war hero. Jesus goes a different way, as the next verses show.

Jesus announces his suffering VERSES 21–23

21 From that time on, Jesus began to show his disciples
that he must go to Jerusalem
and suffer many things from the elders,
the chief priests and the scribes.
He must be killed
and be raised up on the third day.
22 Peter took him aside
and began to scold him.
He said,
"Far be it from you, Lord!
This must never happen to you!"
23 But he turned around
and said to Peter,
"Get behind me, Satan!
You are a stumbling block to me.
For you are not thinking about the things of God,
but about the things of people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For the first time Jesus speaks openly about his death and his resurrection. The word "must" shows: This is God's way.

The opponents Jesus names are certain leaders in Jerusalem, not the Jewish people. According to the report of the Gospels, in the end it was the Roman governor Pilate who had Jesus crucified. Crucifixion was a Roman punishment. For centuries Christians wrongly insulted Jews as "Christ killers" and persecuted them. That is a grave guilt of the church.

Peter has just said: You are the Christ. But he cannot imagine that the Christ must suffer.

In Hebrew, "Satan" means "opponent" or "accuser." Here Peter is like the tempter in the wilderness (4:1–11): He wants to turn Jesus away from the way of suffering. "Behind me" can also mean: Get back behind me, as my disciple.

A moment ago Peter was the "rock." Now he is a "stumbling block." Even so, he remains Jesus' disciple.

Stumbling block: something that makes someone trip and fall.

For today: People who believe can also be wrong. Jesus does not give up on them because of it.

What it means to follow Jesus VERSES 24–28

24 Then Jesus said to his disciples,
"If anyone wants to follow me,
let him deny himself,
take up his cross,
and follow me.
25 For whoever wants to save his life
will lose it.
But whoever loses his life for my sake
will find it.
26 For what will it profit a person
if he gains the whole world
but loses his life?
Or what can a person give
in exchange for his life?

27 For the Son of Man will come
in the glory of his Father
with his angels.
And then he will repay everyone
according to his deeds.
28 Most certainly I tell you,
some of those who are standing here
will not taste death
until they see the Son of Man
coming in his Kingdom."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"To deny yourself" means: no longer putting yourself at the center, but Jesus. "To take up your cross": Whoever follows Jesus must be ready to bear disadvantages or suffering too.

Important: This does not mean that you simply have to put up with violence, abuse or injustice. Whoever experiences violence may and should get help. That is not against Jesus' will. Help is available, for example: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For domestic violence: US: 1-800-799-7233. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verses 25–26: The Greek word for "life" can also mean "soul." A life only for possessions and success is lost in the end. A life for God and for others is never wasted.

Verse 27: Jesus will come again as judge. This reminds us of Psalm 62:12 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 62:13).

Verse 28 is hard to understand. Some interpreters think it is about the transfiguration, which is told right after this (17:1–8). Others think of the resurrection or of Pentecost. There are different interpretations.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 17

Jesus is changed on the mountain

The transfiguration on the mountain VERSES 1–8

1 Six days later, Jesus took Peter, James and John with him.
John was the brother of James.
He led them up a high mountain.
They were alone there.
2 There Jesus was changed in front of them.
His face shone like the sun.
His clothes became as white as light.
3 Suddenly Moses and Elijah appeared to them.
They were talking with Jesus.
4 Peter said to Jesus,
"Lord, it is good for us to be here.
If you want, let's make three tents here:
one for you, one for Moses and one for Elijah."
5 Peter was still speaking
when a bright cloud came over them.
A voice came out of the cloud.
It said,
"This is my Son. I love him.
I am very pleased with him.
Listen to him!"
6 When the disciples heard this,
they threw themselves face down on the ground.
They were very afraid.
7 Jesus came and touched them.
He said, "Get up. Don't be afraid!"
8 They looked up.
They saw no one except Jesus alone.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This event is called the "transfiguration." For a moment three disciples see Jesus' divine glory.

Transfiguration: a change in appearance that shows someone's true glory.

Matthew does not say which mountain it was. According to an old tradition it was Mount Tabor. Some interpreters think rather of Mount Hermon, because it is close to Caesarea Philippi (16:13).

Moses stands for the law, Elijah for the prophets. Both belong to the greatest figures of Israel. They show: Jesus stands in the history of God with Israel.

Moses saw God on Mount Sinai, and his face shone afterward (Exodus 34:29–35). Elijah also met God on a mountain (1 Kings 19).

Peter wants to build tents. Perhaps he is thinking of the Jewish Feast of Tabernacles (Feast of Booths). He would like to hold on to the beautiful moment.

The voice says the same as at the baptism (3:17) and adds: "Listen to him!" This reminds us of Deuteronomy 18:15, where God promises a prophet like Moses.

Verse 7: Jesus touches the frightened disciples and says: "Don't be afraid!" God's glory is not meant to frighten, but to give courage.

The question about Elijah VERSES 9–13

9 They were coming down from the mountain.
On the way Jesus gave them an order.
He said, "Don't tell anyone what you have seen
until the Son of Man has risen from the dead."
10 His disciples asked him,
"Then why do the scribes say
that Elijah must come first?"
11 Jesus answered them,
"It is true: Elijah comes first.
He will set everything right again.
12 But I tell you:
Elijah has already come.
People did not recognize him.
They did to him whatever they wanted.
In the same way they will make the Son of Man suffer too."
13 Then the disciples understood:
Jesus was talking to them about John the Baptizer.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The scribes pointed to the prophet Malachi. There it says: God will send Elijah before the great day of the LORD comes

(Malachi 4:5–6; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles Malachi 3:23–24).

Jesus confirms this. But he says: Elijah has already been here, namely in John the Baptizer (compare 11:14).

"They did to him whatever they wanted": John was killed by Herod (14:1–12). Jesus says: I too will suffer.

To this day Elijah is part of Jewish hope. At the Passover feast, many Jewish families set out a cup for Elijah.

Jesus heals a sick boy VERSES 14–21

14 They came back to the crowd.
A man came to Jesus.
He knelt down in front of him
15 and said,
"Lord, have mercy on my son!
He has epilepsy.
He suffers terribly.
He often falls into the fire
and often into the water.
16 I brought him to your disciples,
but they could not heal him."
17 Jesus answered,
"You people of today do not believe.
You have gone the wrong way!
How long do I still have to be with you?
How long do I have to put up with you?
Bring him here to me!"
18 Jesus spoke sharply to the demon.
It went out of the boy.
From that hour on the boy was healed.
19 Then the disciples came to Jesus when they were alone with him.
They asked,
"Why were we not able to drive it out?"
20 He said to them,
"Because you do not believe enough.
For most certainly I tell you:
If you have faith like a mustard seed,
you will say to this mountain,
'Move from here to there,'
and it will move.
Nothing will be impossible for you.
21 But this kind only goes out through prayer and fasting."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The father is desperate. His son's life is in danger, because during his seizures he falls into the fire or into the water. He looks for help from Jesus.

The WEB says "epileptic." The Greek word literally means "moonstruck," because at that time people believed the moon caused such seizures. People at that time also explained it as the work of a demon.

Very important: Epilepsy is an illness of the brain. It has nothing to do with demons or with sin. People with epilepsy need medical help and understanding, not an exorcism. No one may use this story to try to "cast out" something from sick people or to refuse them medicine.

Exorcism: a ritual to drive out an evil spirit.

Verse 17: Jesus is disappointed about the lack of faith, probably above all among his disciples. But he does not turn away; he helps at once.

Verse 20: Even a tiny faith, as small as a mustard seed (13:31–32), can do great things. "Moving mountains" is a picture for something that seems impossible.

Important: This does not mean that someone is to blame if they do not get well. Illness is not a sign of too little faith.

Verse 21 is missing in many old manuscripts. Something similar is found in Mark 9:29. The WEB has it.

Jesus announces his suffering again VERSES 22–23

22 They were staying in Galilee.
There Jesus said to them,
"The Son of Man will soon be
handed over to people.
23 They will kill him.
And on the third day he will be raised to life."
The disciples were very sad.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the second time he announces his suffering (the first was in 16:21).

The disciples hear only the hard part, the death. They do not yet understand that Jesus also speaks about being raised up.

The temple tax VERSES 24–27

24 They came to Capernaum.
There the men who collected the didrachma coins came to Peter.
They said,
"Doesn't your teacher pay the didrachma?"
25 Peter said,
"Yes, he does."
Peter came into the house.
Before he could say anything, Jesus spoke to him.
He said,
"What do you think, Simon?
The kings of the earth collect fees and taxes.
From whom do they collect them?
From their own children, or from strangers?"
26 Peter said to him,
"From strangers."
Jesus said to him,
"Then the children do not have to pay.
27 But we do not want to upset these people.
So go to the lake and throw out a fishing line with a hook.
Take the first fish that you pull up.
Open its mouth.
You will find a stater coin there.
Take it and give it to them for me and for you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The didrachma (a coin worth two drachmas) was the temple tax. Every adult Jewish man paid it once a year for the temple in Jerusalem (compare Exodus 30:11–16). It was about two days' wages.

Jesus says: The children of a king don't have to pay taxes to their own father. Jesus is God's Son; the temple is his Father's house.

Even so, he pays. He does not want to upset anyone without need. He respects the temple and the Jewish community.

A stater was worth exactly as much as two didrachmas, so it was enough for Jesus and Peter together.

Matthew only tells Jesus' instruction, not how Peter catches the fish.

For today: You can be free and still give something up out of respect for others.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 18

How Jesus' disciples should live together

Who is the greatest? VERSES 1–5

1 At that time the disciples came to Jesus and asked,
"Who then is the greatest in the Kingdom of Heaven?"
2 Jesus called a little child to himself
and stood the child in the middle of them.
3 He said,
"Most certainly I tell you,
unless you turn around
and become like little children,
you will never enter the Kingdom of Heaven.
4 Whoever makes himself as humble as this little child
is the greatest in the Kingdom of Heaven.
5 And whoever welcomes one such little child
in my name
welcomes me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The disciples want to know who is most important. Jesus puts a child in the middle.

At that time children had no rights and no power. They had nothing to show for themselves and depended on others.

Jesus says: That is how you should be before God. Not great and proud, but ready to receive gifts. It is not about being "childish," but about trust and humility.

Verse 5: Whoever takes care of children takes care of Jesus himself. Children have a special place with God.

A warning against leading others into sin VERSES 6–9

6 "But whoever causes one of these little ones
who believe in me
to stumble,
it would be better for him
if a huge millstone were hung around his neck
and he were sunk in the depths of the sea.
7 How terrible it will be for the world
because of the things that cause people to stumble!
Such things have to come.
But how terrible it will be for the person
through whom they come!
8 If your hand or your foot causes you to stumble,
cut it off and throw it away.
It is better for you
to enter into life disabled or lame
than to have two hands or two feet
and be thrown into the eternal fire.
9 And if your eye causes you to stumble,
pull it out and throw it away.
It is better for you
to enter into life with one eye
than to have two eyes
and be thrown into the fire of Gehenna."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The little ones" are children, but also all weak and simple people who believe in Jesus.

Verse 6: Jesus uses very harsh words for everyone who harms such people or turns them away from faith. A millstone was a very heavy stone. This is a picture, not an instruction to use violence.

Millstone: a large, round stone used to grind grain into flour.

This saying is especially important today: Children were abused in churches too, and abusers were protected. Jesus clearly takes the side of children. Whoever has experienced abuse or knows about it can find help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673.

Verses 8–9 are picture language, just as in 5:29–30. Jesus wants to say: Take evil very seriously and separate yourself from everything that leads you to evil. He does not mean that anyone should really hurt themselves.

If you have thoughts of hurting yourself, please get help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

"Gehenna" was a valley near Jerusalem. It became a picture for God's judgment (see the box on 5:22).

The lost sheep VERSES 10–14

10 "Make sure that you don't look down on one of these
little ones!
For I tell you
that in heaven their angels
always see the face of my Father in heaven.
11 For the Son of Man came
to save what was lost.
12 What do you think?
If a man has 100 sheep,
and one of them wanders away,
doesn't he leave the 99,
go into the mountains,
and look for the one that wandered away?
13 And if he finds it,
most certainly I tell you,
he is happier about that one
than about the 99
that did not wander away.
14 In the same way, it is not the will of your Father in
heaven
that one of these little ones should be lost."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: Jesus says that the little ones have "angels" with God. The idea of the "guardian angel" came from this. The message is: God keeps a special eye on the little ones. No one may look down on them.

Verse 11 is missing in many old manuscripts. Something similar is found in Luke 19:10. The WEB has it.

The parable of the lost sheep: Every single person counts for God. He gives up on no one. He looks for them until he finds them.

In the Old Testament God himself is the good shepherd who looks for his lost sheep (Ezekiel 34:11–16; Psalm 23).

For today: If you feel lost, you can know: God is looking for you. And the church should care for people who are on the edge.

If someone sins against you VERSES 15–20

15 "If your brother sins against you,
go
and show him his fault,
just between you and him alone.
If he listens to you,
you have won back your brother.
16 But if he doesn't listen,
take one or two others with you.
For every matter is to be settled by the testimony
of two or three witnesses.
17 If he refuses to listen to them,
tell it to the church.
If he refuses to listen to the church too,
let him be to you
like a Gentile or a tax collector.
18 Most certainly I tell you,
whatever you bind on earth
will have been bound in heaven.
And whatever you release on earth
will have been released in heaven.
19 Again I assure you,
if two of you on earth
agree about anything
they ask for,
it will be done for them by my Father in heaven.
20 For where two or three
are gathered together in my name,
there I am in the middle of them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Brother" here means every person in the church, men and women.

Jesus describes a way to deal with conflict and guilt: first talk privately, without putting the other person to shame in front of others. Then with witnesses. Then before the church. The goal is always: to win the other person back.

Verse 16 refers to Deuteronomy 19:15.

Verse 17: "Gentiles" (people who did not belong to God's people) and tax collectors were seen as outsiders. But Jesus himself went to tax collectors and foreigners with love (9:9–13; 15:21–28). So this does not mean: hate them, but: invite them anew.

Important: This way does not apply to violence, abuse or crimes. Victims do not have to go to the abuser alone. They may get help at once and report it to the police. That is not against Jesus' will.

Verse 18: What was said to Peter in 16:19 applies here to all the disciples together.

Verse 20: A great promise: Even two or three people who meet in Jesus' name are not alone. Jesus is with them.

Jewish teachers said something similar: Where two study the Torah together, God's presence is with them.

How often should I forgive? VERSES 21–22

21 Then Peter came to him and asked,
"Lord, how often should I forgive my brother
when he sins against me?
Up to seven times?"
22 Jesus said to him,
"I don't tell you up to 7 times,
but up to 70 times 7.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Peter thinks seven times is already very generous. Jesus says: 70 times 7! That means: Never stop forgiving. You should not keep count.

The Greek words can also mean "77 times." Many Bibles translate it that way. The WEB says "seventy times seven." The meaning is the same: without limit.

This reminds us of Genesis 4:24. There Lamech wanted to take revenge 77 times. Jesus turns this around: not unlimited revenge, but unlimited forgiveness.

Important: Forgiving does not mean approving of wrong. Nor does it mean that you have to stay with a person who hurts or hits you again and again. You may protect yourself and set boundaries. Forgiveness often takes time.

The servant who would not forgive VERSES 23–35

23 So the Kingdom of Heaven is like a king
who wanted to settle accounts with his servants.
24 When he began to settle accounts,
someone was brought to him
who owed him 10,000 talents
(about 750,000 pounds of silver).
25 Because he couldn't pay,
his master ordered
that he be sold,
with his wife, his children and everything he had,
and that the debt be paid.
26 So the servant fell down,
knelt before him and said,
'Master, have patience with me,
and I will pay you back everything!'
27 The master of that servant was moved with
compassion.
He let him go
and forgave him the debt.
28 But that servant went out
and found one of his fellow servants
who owed him 100 denarii.
He grabbed him,
took him by the throat
and said,
'Pay what you owe!'
29 So his fellow servant fell down in front of him
and begged him,
'Have patience with me,
and I will pay you back!'
30 But he refused.
He went and had him thrown into prison
until he paid back what he owed.

31 When his fellow servants saw what had happened,
they were very sad.
They went to their master
and told him everything that had happened.
32 Then his master called him in
and said to him,
'You wicked servant!
I forgave you all that debt
because you begged me.
33 Shouldn't you also have had mercy on your fellow servant,
just as I had mercy on you?'
34 His master was angry
and handed him over to the torturers
until he paid back everything he owed.
35 That is how my heavenly Father will also treat you
if each of you does not forgive your brother
from your heart."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

10,000 talents is an unimaginably large sum. One talent was about 75 pounds of silver. That was as much as the wages for many years of work. No one could ever pay back this debt.

100 denarii, on the other hand, is the wages for about 100 days of work. That is a lot of money, but tiny by comparison.

The king forgives the huge debt completely. But the servant has learned nothing from it. He is harsh with his fellow servant because of a small sum.

The message: God has forgiven us an endless amount. Whoever has experienced that should forgive others too. This reminds us of the Lord's Prayer: "Forgive us our debts, as we also forgive our debtors" (6:12, 14–15).

Verse 25: At that time, in many countries people could be sold together with their families because of debts. Jesus tells this because his listeners knew it. He is not saying that it is good. Slavery is wrong.

Verses 34–35 are harsh words. They show how seriously God means it. It is a picture from the parable, not an exact description of what God does. God is gracious, but grace should be passed on.

"From your heart": Forgiveness should be real. Whoever has been badly hurt often needs a long time for it. God knows that.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 19

Marriage, children and riches

The question about divorce VERSES 1–12

1 When Jesus had finished saying these things,
he left Galilee
and came into the region of Judea on the other side of the Jordan.
2 Large crowds followed him,
and he healed them there.
3 Pharisees came to him.
They wanted to test him and asked,
"Is it lawful for a man to divorce his wife
for any reason?"
4 He answered,
"Haven't you read
that he who made them at the beginning
made them male and female?
5 And he said,
'For this reason a man shall leave his father and mother
and shall be joined to his wife,
and the two shall become one flesh.'
6 So they are no longer two,
but one flesh.
So what God has joined together,
let no one separate."
7 They asked him,
"Why then did Moses command us
to give her a certificate of divorce
and divorce her?"
8 He said to them,
"Because your hearts were so hard,
Moses allowed you
to divorce your wives.
But it was not like that from the beginning.
9 I tell you
that whoever divorces his wife,
except for sexual unfaithfulness,
and marries another woman,
commits adultery.
And whoever marries a divorced woman
commits adultery."
10 His disciples said to him,
"If that is how it is between a man and his wife,
it is better not to marry."
11 But he said to them,
"Not everyone can accept this saying,
but only those to whom it is given.
12 For there are eunuchs
who were born that way.
And there are eunuchs
who were made that way by people.
And there are eunuchs
who made themselves that way
for the sake of the Kingdom of Heaven.
Whoever is able to accept this, let him accept it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At that time there was an argument among Jewish teachers: For what reasons may a man divorce his wife? Some said: only for serious unfaithfulness. Others said: for almost any reason. The question "for any reason" refers to this argument.

At that time in Israel it was usually only the man who could get a divorce. After a divorce, women were often poor and without protection. With his answer, Jesus mainly protects women from being divorced for no good reason.

Verses 4–5 quote Genesis 1:27 and 2:24. Jesus goes back to the beginning: God wants marriage to last.

Verse 7: Moses allowed divorce and set rules for it (Deuteronomy 24:1–4). The certificate of divorce protected the woman: She could marry again.

Verse 9: Compare 5:31–32. Christians understand this saying in different ways. The Catholic Church holds that marriage cannot be dissolved. Protestant and Orthodox churches allow divorce and a new marriage under certain circumstances.

Very important: No one has to stay in a marriage in which he or she is hit, threatened or abused. Violence harms everything marriage is meant to be. Help is available: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For domestic violence: US: 1-800-799-7233. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

People who are divorced are not "worse" Christians. Many have suffered a lot. God loves them.

Verse 12: Eunuchs were men who could not father children, often because they had been mutilated. Jesus speaks about them with respect. "For the sake of the Kingdom of Heaven" probably means people who choose to stay unmarried in order to be there fully for God. It is not a call to hurt yourself.

Jesus says: Not everyone can live like this. Marriage and staying single are both good ways.

Jesus blesses the children VERSES 13–15

13 Then people brought little children to him,
so that he would lay his hands on them and pray.
But the disciples scolded them.
14 But Jesus said,
"Let the little children come,
and don't stop them from coming to me!
For the Kingdom of Heaven belongs to people like these."
15 And he laid his hands on them
and went on from there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The disciples think children are a bother. Jesus sees it completely differently. He takes time for them and blesses them.

Compare 18:1–5: Children have a special place with God.

These verses are often read at baptisms and blessings of children.

For today: Children should be welcome in the church, not just put up with.

The rich young man VERSES 16–22

16 Someone came to him and said,
"Good teacher, what good thing shall I do
to have eternal life?"
17 He said to him,
"Why do you call me good?
No one is good but one, that is, God.
But if you want to enter into life,
keep the commandments."
18 He asked him,
"Which ones?"
Jesus said,
"'You shall not murder.'
'You shall not commit adultery.'
'You shall not steal.'
'You shall not give false testimony.'
19 'Honor your father and your mother.'
And, 'You shall love your neighbor as yourself.'"
20 The young man said to him,
"I have kept all these things since I was young.
What do I still lack?"
21 Jesus said to him,
"If you want to be perfect,
go,
sell what you have,
and give to the poor.
Then you will have treasure in heaven.
And come, follow me!"
22 When the young man heard this,
he went away sad.
For he had great possessions.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 16–17: In the WEB the man asks: "Good teacher, what good thing shall I do," and Jesus answers: "Why do you call me good?" Many old manuscripts have a slightly different form here: The man only says Teacher, and Jesus asks why he is asking him about what is good. The meaning is similar: Only God is truly good.

Jesus names commandments from the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:12–16) and the commandment to love your neighbor (Leviticus 19:18). These are the commandments about life with other people.

The young man is serious and devout. But he senses: Something is still missing.

Jesus invites him to follow him. But his wealth holds him back. He goes away sad. Matthew does not tell what became of him later.

"Perfect" here means: whole, undivided for God (compare 5:48).

Christians understand verse 21 in different ways. Some, for example monks and nuns, really give up everything they own. Most Christians understand it this way: Nothing may be more important to us than God. Whoever has a lot should share generously with the poor.

Riches and God's Kingdom VERSES 23–30

23 Jesus said to his disciples,
"Most certainly I tell you,
it is hard for a rich person to enter the Kingdom of Heaven.
24 Again I tell you,
it is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle
than for a rich person to enter God's Kingdom."
25 When the disciples heard this,
they were very shocked and said,
"Then who can be saved?"
26 Jesus looked at them and said,
"With people this is impossible,
but with God all things are possible."
27 Then Peter answered,
"Look, we have left everything
and followed you.
What then will we have?"
28 Jesus said to them,
"Most certainly I tell you,
you who have followed me,

in the renewal of the world,
when the Son of Man sits on the throne of his glory,
you will also sit on 12 thrones,
judging the 12 tribes of Israel.
29 And everyone who has left houses,
or brothers or sisters,
or father or mother,
or wife or children,
or fields,
for my name's sake,
will receive 100 times as much
and will inherit eternal life.
30 But many who are first will be last,
and the last will be first.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 24: The camel was the largest animal people knew in Israel. The eye of a needle is the smallest hole. Jesus exaggerates on purpose so that people will remember it: This is impossible. Some explain that there was a small city gate called "the Needle's Eye." But there is no reliable evidence for this.

The disciples are shocked. At that time many thought: Wealth is a sign of God's blessing. If even the rich have a hard time, then who can be saved?

Verse 26: The answer is a comfort: No one can save himself, whether poor or rich. God can. Salvation is a gift.

Verse 28: "Renewal" (in the WEB: "regeneration") means the new world that God will create at the end. The 12 disciples match the 12 tribes of Israel. The word "judging" here probably also means "leading" and "ruling," as with the judges in the Old Testament.

Verse 29: Whoever gives something up for Jesus finds a new, large family in the church. That does not mean you should abandon your family. In 15:4–6 Jesus stressed how important it is to care for your parents.

Verse 30: With God, different standards apply. Whoever counts for little here below can be right at the front with God. The next chapter tells a parable about this.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 20

The last will be first

The workers in the vineyard VERSES 1–16

1 "For the Kingdom of Heaven is like the owner of a house.
He went out early in the morning
to hire workers for his vineyard.
2 He agreed with the workers
on one denarius for the day
and sent them into his vineyard.
3 About the third hour he went out again
and saw others standing in the marketplace
who had no work.
4 He said to them,
'You go into the vineyard too.
I will give you whatever is right.'
So they went.
5 About the sixth and the ninth hour
he went out again
and did the same.
6 About the eleventh hour he went out
and found still others standing around with no work.
He said to them,
'Why are you standing here all day doing nothing?'
7 They said to him,
'Because no one has hired us.'
He said to them,
'You go into the vineyard too,
and you will receive whatever is right.'
8 When evening came,
the owner of the vineyard said to his manager,
'Call the workers and pay them their wages.
Begin with the last and end with the first.'
9 Those who had started at about the eleventh hour
came.
Each of them received a denarius.
10 When the first ones came,
they thought they would receive more.
But each of them also received a denarius.
11 When they received it,
they grumbled against the owner of the house.
12 They said,
'These last ones have worked only one hour,
and you have made them equal to us,
who have carried the burden of the day and the
scorching heat!'
13 But he answered one of them,
'Friend, I am doing you no wrong.
Didn't you agree with me on one denarius?
14 Take what belongs to you and go!
I want to give this last one just as much as you.
15 Isn't it lawful for me to do what I want with what
belongs to me?
Or is your eye evil because I am good?'
16 So the last will be first,
and the first will be last.
For many are called,
but few are chosen."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A denarius was the usual wage for a day of work. A family could live on it for one day.

At that time the hours were counted from sunrise, at about 6 in the morning. So the third hour is about 9 in the morning, the sixth about 12 noon, the ninth about 3 in the afternoon, and the eleventh about 5 in the afternoon. The last ones worked only one more hour.

Day laborers stood in the marketplace in the morning and waited for work. Whoever found none had no money for food in the evening. The last ones were not lazy. No one had hired them.

The owner gives everyone what they need to live. The first ones receive exactly what was agreed. No wrong is done to

them. But they are annoyed because the owner is generous to others.

"Is your eye evil" is an old way of speaking about envy.

The message: God's goodness is not like wages that you earn. It is a gift. Whoever finds God late is just as welcome to him as someone who has always been there.

For today: We should be glad when God does good to others, instead of being envious. And the parable also shows: People without work are not worth less.

Verse 16: The sentence "For many are called, but few are chosen" is missing here in many old manuscripts. It is certainly found in 22:14. The WEB has it here too.

Jesus announces his suffering a third time VERSES 17–19

17 As Jesus was going up to Jerusalem,
he took the 12 disciples aside.
On the way he said to them,
18 "We are going up to Jerusalem.
There the Son of Man
will be handed over to the chief priests and scribes.
They will condemn him to death
19 and hand him over to the Gentiles.
They will mock him, whip him and crucify him.
And on the third day he will be raised up."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the third and most exact announcement (compare 16:21 and 17:22–23). For the first time Jesus says: He will be crucified.

"The Gentiles" here are the Romans. Crucifixion was a Roman punishment. According to John 18:31, the Jewish leaders at that time were not allowed to have anyone executed themselves. That was decided by the Romans.

Important: Jesus names certain leaders, not the Jewish people. Blaming "the Jews" for Jesus' death is wrong and has led to terrible injustice in history.

Again the announcement ends with hope: He will be raised up.

The request of the mother of James and John VERSES 20–28

20 Then the mother of the sons of Zebedee came to him
with her sons.
She knelt down in front of him
and wanted to ask him for something.
21 He said to her,
"What do you want?"
She said to him,
"Command that these two sons of mine may sit
next to you in your Kingdom,
one on your right and one on your left."
22 But Jesus answered,
"You don't know what you are asking.
Are you able to drink the cup
that I am about to drink,
and be baptized with the baptism
that I am baptized with?"
They said to him,
"We are able."
23 He said to them,
"You will indeed drink my cup,
and be baptized with the baptism
that I am baptized with.
But the places on my right and on my left
are not mine to give.
They belong to those
for whom my Father has prepared them."
24 When the other 10 heard this,
they were angry with the two brothers.
25 But Jesus called them to himself and said,
"You know
that the rulers of the nations lord it over them,
and their great ones use their power over them.
26 It shall not be so among you!
But whoever wants to become great among you
shall be your servant.
27 And whoever wants to be first among you
shall be your slave,
28 just as the Son of Man did not come
to be served,
but to serve
and to give his life
as a ransom for many."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The sons of Zebedee are James and John (4:21). Their mother asks for the places of honor for them. The sons are standing there and obviously want this too.

The "cup" is a picture from the Old Testament for a hard fate that God sends (for example Isaiah 51:17). Jesus means his suffering. The "baptism" is also a picture for suffering here: like going under deep water.

The words about baptism (in verses 22 and 23) are missing in many old manuscripts. Something similar is found in Mark 10:38–39. The WEB has them.

Verse 23: James was later actually killed because of his faith (Acts 12:2).

Verse 25: The rulers "lord it over" the nations. That means: Powerful people rule from above and take advantage of their power.

Verses 26–28: With Jesus it is the other way around. Great is the one who serves others. Jesus himself is the example.

"Ransom": At that time people paid money to buy prisoners or slaves free. Jesus gives his life to set people free. In Hebrew ways of speaking, "for many" means: for the great crowd, for all. This reminds us of Isaiah 53:11–12.

For today: In the church and everywhere, no one should misuse their power. Whoever leads should serve.

Two blind men near Jericho VERSES 29–34

29 As they were leaving Jericho,
a large crowd followed him.
30 Two blind men were sitting by the road.
When they heard that Jesus was passing by,
they cried out,
"Lord, have mercy on us, you son of David!"
31 The crowd scolded them
and told them to be quiet.
But they cried out even louder,
"Lord, have mercy on us, you son of David!"
32 Jesus stood still,
called them
and asked,
"What do you want me to do for you?"
33 They said to him,
"Lord, that our eyes may be opened."

34 Jesus was moved with compassion for them
and touched their eyes.
At once they could see again,
and they followed him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jericho lies in the Jordan Valley. From there the road goes up to Jerusalem.

The crowd wants to silence the blind men. They are a bother. But they will not be stopped.

Jesus stands still. He asks: "What do you want me to do for you?" He takes them seriously and lets them say for themselves what they need. That is an attitude of respect.

Just before this the disciples had asked for places of honor (verse 21). The blind men ask for mercy. Jesus helps them, and they follow him.

In Mark 10:46–52 and Luke 18:35–43 we are told about one blind man (in Mark his name is Bartimaeus). Matthew tells about two blind men. The Gospels tell some stories a little differently.

Important: Blindness is not a punishment. People with disabilities should not be silenced, but heard.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 21

Jesus comes to Jerusalem

The entry into Jerusalem VERSES 1–11

1 When they came near Jerusalem,
to Bethsphage at the Mount of Olives,
Jesus sent out two disciples.
2 He said to them,
"Go into the village ahead of you.
There you will at once find a donkey
tied up,
and a colt with her.
Untie them and bring them to me.
3 If anyone says anything to you,
say,
'The Lord needs them.'
Then he will send them at once."
4 All this happened
so that what the prophet had said would come true:
5 "Tell the daughter of Zion:
Your King is coming to you,
humble, and riding on a donkey,
on a colt, the foal of a donkey."
6 The disciples went
and did just as Jesus had commanded them.
7 They brought the donkey and the colt
and laid their clothes on them.
And he sat on them.
8 A very large crowd
spread their clothes on the road.
Others cut branches from the trees
and spread them on the road.
9 The crowds who went ahead of him
and those who followed
kept shouting,
"Hosanna to the son of David!
Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!
Hosanna in the highest!"
10 When he came into Jerusalem,
the whole city was stirred up.
People asked,
"Who is this?"
11 The crowds said,
"This is the prophet Jesus from Nazareth in Galilee."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bethsphage (usually spelled Bethphage) was a small village on the Mount of Olives, a hill east of Jerusalem.

Verse 5 quotes Zechariah 9:9 (with a beginning taken from Isaiah 62:11). A king on a donkey, not on a war horse: This is a king of peace. Jesus does not come with violence.

Colt: a young donkey.

Matthew names two animals, the donkey and her colt. The prophet Zechariah describes one animal with two expressions. Matthew tells about two animals. "He sat on them" probably means: on the clothes.

Spreading clothes and branches on the road: That is how people welcomed a king (compare 2 Kings 9:13).

"Hosanna" is Hebrew and originally means "Please help!" or "Please save!" Later it also became a shout of joy.

"Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord" comes from Psalm 118:25–26. Pilgrims sang this psalm when they came to Jerusalem for the feast.

Christians remember this day on Palm Sunday, one week before Easter.

Jesus in the temple VERSES 12–17

12 Jesus went into the temple of God.
He drove out all those
who were selling and buying in the temple.
He overturned the tables of the money changers
and the seats of those who sold doves.
13 He said to them,
"It is written,
'My house shall be called a house of prayer.'
But you have made it a den of robbers!"
14 People who could not walk
and blind people
came to him in the temple,
and he healed them.
15 But the chief priests and scribes
saw the wonderful things he did.
And they saw the children
who were shouting in the temple,
"Hosanna to the son of David!"
Then they became angry
16 and said to him,
"Do you hear what these children are saying?"
Jesus said to them,

"Yes.
Have you never read,
'Out of the mouth of children and nursing babies
you have prepared praise for yourself'?"
17 He left them,
went out of the city to Bethany,
and spent the night there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the outer court of the temple, animals were sold for the sacrifices, for example doves, the offering of the poor. The money changers exchanged foreign money for the coins people used to pay the temple tax (compare 17:24). That in itself was necessary.

But Jesus criticizes that the place of prayer has become a place of business and profit. Verse 13 combines two sayings of the prophets: Isaiah 56:7 ("house of prayer") and Jeremiah 7:11 ("den of robbers"). The prophets had already criticized what went on at the temple. Jesus stands in this Jewish tradition.

Important: Jesus does not attack people here or hurt anyone. He overturns tables. This story is no justification for violence against people.

Verse 14: In 2 Samuel 5:8 there is an old saying: The blind and the lame shall not come into the house. Jesus heals the lame and the blind right in the temple. They are welcome.

Verse 16 quotes Psalm 8:2 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 8:3). Children sometimes understand what adults do not want to see.

Bethany is a village on the Mount of Olives, about 2 miles from Jerusalem. Friends of Jesus lived there.

Matthew names the chief priests and scribes, that is, certain leaders, not the Jewish people. The crowd and the children cheer for Jesus.

The fig tree VERSES 18–22

18 In the morning,
as he was going back to the city,
he was hungry.
19 He saw a fig tree by the road
and went up to it.
But he found nothing on it except leaves.
He said to it,
"May no fruit ever grow on you again!"
And at once the fig tree withered.
20 When the disciples saw this,
they were amazed and said,
"How did the fig tree wither so quickly?"
21 Jesus answered them,
"Most certainly I tell you,
if you have faith and don't doubt,
you will not only be able to do
what was done to the fig tree.
But even if you say to this mountain,
'Be lifted up and thrown into the sea,'
it will happen.
22 And whatever you ask for in prayer,
you will receive
if you believe."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is hard to understand. The fig tree is a sign, a kind of parable acted out. It has leaves, so it looks healthy, but it bears no fruit.

In the prophets the fig tree is sometimes a picture for God's people (Jeremiah 8:13; Micah 7:1). The question is: Does faith bear fruit, or does it only look good from the outside? This question applies to everyone, Christians too.

Important: This is not God's judgment on the Jewish people. In the past Christians often interpreted this story that way. That was wrong.

Verses 21–22: Again Jesus speaks about the power of faith (compare 17:20).

Important: This does not mean that you get every wish if only you believe strongly enough. And whoever stays sick or goes through suffering is not to blame for having too little faith. Prayer is trust in God, not a tool to force something. Jesus himself prays in the garden that not his will but God's will may be done (26:39).

The question about Jesus' authority VERSES 23–27

23 When he had come into the temple and was teaching,
the chief priests and the elders of the people came to him
and said,
"By what authority do you do these things?
Who gave you this authority?"
24 Jesus answered them,
"I will also ask you a question.
If you answer me,
I will also tell you
by what authority I do these things.
25 The baptism of John,
where did it come from?
From heaven or from people?"
They discussed this among themselves and said,
"If we say, 'From heaven,'
he will ask us,
'Then why didn't you believe him?'
26 But if we say, 'From people,'
we have to be afraid of the crowd.
For everyone thinks John was a prophet."
27 They answered Jesus,
"We don't know."
Then he also said to them,
"Then I won't tell you either
by what authority I do these things."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The leaders of the temple are upset about what Jesus did in the temple. They ask: Who gives you the right to do this?

Jesus answers with a question of his own. That was a common way for Jewish teachers to discuss things.

"From heaven" means: from God. Whoever accepts John as God's messenger would also have to listen to Jesus, because John had pointed to Jesus (3:11).

The leaders do not want to commit themselves. That is why Jesus does not answer directly either. But the answer is actually clear: His authority comes from God.

The parable of the two sons VERSES 28–32

28 "What do you think?
A man had two sons.
He went to the first and said,
'Son, go and work in my vineyard today.'
29 He answered,
'I will not.'

But afterward he was sorry
and went.
30 Then the father went to the second son
and said the same thing.
He answered,
'I'm going, sir.'
But he didn't go.
31 Which of the two did
what his father wanted?"
They said to him,
"The first."
Jesus said to them,
"Most certainly I tell you,
the tax collectors and the prostitutes
are entering God's Kingdom before you.
32 For John came to you
and showed you the way of righteousness,
and you didn't believe him.
But the tax collectors and the prostitutes believed
him.
And even when you saw this,
you did not change your minds afterward
and believe him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The first son says no, but then he does what his father wants after all. The second son says yes in a friendly way, but does not do it.

The message: It is not beautiful words that count, but actions. And it is never too late to turn around.

The order and the answer in verses 29–31 are not the same everywhere in the old manuscripts. The WEB follows the form translated here.

Tax collectors and prostitutes were seen as the worst sinners. Jesus says: It was precisely they who listened to John and changed their lives. God's Kingdom is open to everyone who turns around.

For today: Many women in prostitution are exploited, forced, or victims of human trafficking. Jesus does not look down on these people. He names them as an example of faith. Whoever needs help can find it: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US, the National Human Trafficking Hotline is 1-888-373-7888.

The parable of the wicked farmers VERSES 33–46

33 "Listen to another parable.
There was an owner of a house.
He planted a vineyard,
put a fence around it,
dug a winepress in it,
and built a tower.
Then he rented it out to farmers
and went to another country.
34 When harvest time came near,
he sent his servants to the farmers
to collect his share of the fruit.
35 The farmers grabbed his servants.
They beat one,
killed another,
and stoned another.
36 Then he sent other servants again,
more than the first time.
And they treated them the same way.
37 Finally he sent his son to them.
He said to himself,
'They will respect my son.'
38 But when the farmers saw the son,
they said to one another,
'This is the heir.
Come, let's kill him
and take his inheritance!'
39 They grabbed him,
threw him out of the vineyard
and killed him.
40 So when the owner of the vineyard comes,
what will he do to those farmers?"
41 They said to him,
"He will bring those evil men to a miserable end.
And he will rent out the vineyard to other farmers
who will give him his share of the fruit at the right
time."
42 Jesus said to them,
"Have you never read in the Scriptures,
'The stone that the builders rejected
has become the cornerstone.
This was from the Lord,
and it is marvelous in our eyes'?
43 So I tell you,
God's Kingdom will be taken away from you
and given to a people
that produces its fruit.
44 Whoever falls on this stone
will be broken to pieces.
And whoever it falls on
will be crushed to dust."
45 When the chief priests and the Pharisees heard his
parables,
they realized that he was speaking about them.
46 They wanted to arrest him.
But they were afraid of the crowds,
because the people thought he was a prophet.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The parable reminds us of the "song of the vineyard" in the prophet Isaiah (Isaiah 5:1–7). There the vineyard is the people of Israel, whom God planted with love.

The servants are the prophets whom God sent again and again. The son is Jesus himself. Here Jesus announces his death again.

Verse 42 quotes Psalm 118:22–23. The rejected stone becomes the most important stone of the house. Christians see in this a picture of Jesus: rejected and killed, but raised up by God.

Cornerstone: the most important stone in a building, which holds the walls together.

Verses 43–45: Jesus is speaking to the leaders who reject him. Matthew says clearly: The chief priests and Pharisees realized that he was speaking "about them." The people, on the other hand, thought he was a prophet (verse 46).

Very important: For a long time Christians interpreted verse 43 to mean that God had rejected the Jewish people and that the church had taken its place. This interpretation helped cause a great deal of suffering and hatred of Jews. After the Holocaust many churches clearly rejected it. Paul writes: God has not rejected his people (Romans 11:1–2, 29).

The "people that produces its fruit" means everyone who does God's will, Jews and non-Jews. Today the question about fruit is also for the church.

Verse 44 is missing in some old manuscripts. The WEB has it. It reminds us of Isaiah 8:14–15 and Daniel 2:34–35.

Important: The violence in the parable is a warning, not permission for revenge or violence.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 22

The greatest commandment

The parable of the wedding feast VERSES 1–14

1 Jesus answered
and spoke to them again in parables.
He said,
2 "The Kingdom of Heaven is like a king
who gave a wedding feast for his son.
3 He sent out his servants
to call those who had been invited to the wedding
feast.
But they would not come.
4 Then he sent out other servants
and said,
'Tell those who are invited,
"I have prepared my dinner.
My cattle and my fattened animals have been killed,
and everything is ready.
Come to the wedding feast!"'
5 But they paid no attention
and went away,
one to his farm,
another to his business.
6 The rest grabbed his servants,
treated them shamefully
and killed them.
7 When the king heard this,
he was angry.
He sent his armies,
destroyed those murderers
and burned their city.
8 Then he said to his servants,
'The wedding is ready,
but those who were invited were not worthy.
9 So go to the places where the roads meet
and invite to the wedding feast anyone you find.'
10 The servants went out into the roads
and gathered all the people they found,
both bad and good.
And the wedding hall was filled with guests.
11 But when the king came in
to look at the guests,
he saw a man there
who was not wearing wedding clothes.
12 He said to him,
'Friend, how did you get in here
without wedding clothes?'
The man was speechless.
13 Then the king said to the servants,
'Tie him up hand and foot,
take him away,
and throw him out into the outer darkness.
There will be weeping and grinding of teeth.'
14 For many are called,
but few are chosen."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Bible a wedding feast is often a picture for the great joy in God's Kingdom (compare Isaiah 25:6).

Those who were invited first have more important things to do. Some even become violent. This reminds us of the parable before it (21:33–46). Again it means the leaders who reject Jesus.

Verse 7: Some interpreters see in this a pointer to the destruction of Jerusalem by the Romans in the year AD 70. But it remains a picture in the parable.

Important: This parable is not a judgment on the Jewish people. Jesus and his first disciples were Jews. God has not rejected his people (Romans 11:1–2).

Verses 9–10: Now everyone is invited, "both bad and good." God's invitation is for everyone, without conditions.

Verses 11–13: The man without wedding clothes is hard to understand. He accepted the invitation but did not take it seriously. Many interpreters say: The "clothes" are a picture for a changed life, for repentance and good deeds. The invitation is a gift, but it wants to change our lives.

Important: This is not about real clothing. No one should be turned away from church because they are poor or have no nice clothes.

"Outer darkness" and "weeping and grinding of teeth" are pictures for judgment (compare 8:12; 13:42).

Verse 14: Many are invited. But what matters is how you respond to the invitation.

The question about taxes for Caesar VERSES 15–22

15 Then the Pharisees went away
and made plans how they could trap him
with his own words.
16 They sent their disciples to him,
together with the Herodians.
They said,
"Teacher, we know that you are honest
and teach the way of God in truth,
no matter whom you teach.
For you don't favor anyone.
17 So tell us:
What do you think?
Is it lawful to pay taxes to Caesar, or not?"
18 But Jesus saw their wickedness and said,
"Why are you testing me, you hypocrites?
19 Show me the coin used for the tax!"
They brought him a denarius.

20 He asked them,
"Whose image and inscription is this?"
21 They said to him,
"Caesar's."
Then he said to them,
"Then give to Caesar the things that are Caesar's,
and to God the things that are God's."
22 When they heard this,
they were amazed,
left him and went away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "Herodians" supported the ruling family of Herod, which worked together with the Romans. The Pharisees were more against the Romans. Here both groups work together to set a trap for Jesus.

The trap: If Jesus says, "Yes, pay taxes," he angers the people who suffer under the Romans. If he says "No," they can report him to the Romans as a rebel.

Caesar: the title of the Roman emperor.

The denarius had the image of the Roman emperor on it, at that time Tiberius. The inscription called him a son of the divine Augustus.

Jesus' answer: Give Caesar what belongs to him, that is, the coin with his image. But give God what belongs to God. And human beings are created in God's image (Genesis 1:27). So the whole person belongs to God.

For today: Christians should pay taxes and respect the state. But no state and no ruler stands above God. Where a state demands injustice, this applies: We must obey God rather than people (Acts 5:29).

The question about the resurrection VERSES 23–33

23 On that day Sadducees came to him.
They say that there is no resurrection.
They asked him,
24 "Teacher, Moses said,
'If a man dies and has no children,
his brother shall marry his wife
and have children for his brother.'
25 Now there were seven brothers among us.
The first married and died.
Because he had no children,
he left his wife to his brother.
26 It was the same with the second and the third,
up to the seventh.
27 After them all, the woman died too.
28 So in the resurrection,
whose wife will she be of the seven?
For they all had her as their wife."
29 But Jesus answered them,
"You are mistaken,
because you don't know the Scriptures
or the power of God.
30 For in the resurrection
people don't marry
and are not given in marriage,
but are like God's angels in heaven.
31 And about the resurrection of the dead:
Haven't you read
what God said to you?
32 'I am the God of Abraham,
and the God of Isaac,
and the God of Jacob.'
God is not the God of the dead,
but of the living."
33 When the crowds heard this,
they were amazed at his teaching.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Sadducees were a group mainly from the leading priestly families. They accepted mainly the five books of Moses as Holy Scripture. They did not believe in a resurrection of the dead. The Pharisees, on the other hand, believed in it, just as Jesus did.

Verse 24: The law about a brother marrying his dead brother's widow is found in Deuteronomy 25:5–6. It was meant to keep a widow without children from being left without protection, and to keep the dead man's name from being lost.

The Sadducees tell a made-up, exaggerated story to make faith in the resurrection look ridiculous.

The question "Whose wife will she be" treats the woman almost like property. Jesus does not go along with that. He says: With God, different rules apply. There no one belongs to someone else.

Verse 30: Life after the resurrection is different from our life now. That does not mean that people will then forget their love for each other.

Verse 32 quotes Exodus 3:6. Jesus takes a passage from the books of Moses, which the Sadducees also accept. God says: "I am" (not: I was) the God of Abraham. So Abraham, Isaac and Jacob live on for God.

For today: A great comfort for everyone who is grieving for someone. For God, those who have died are not lost.

The greatest commandment VERSES 34–40

34 When the Pharisees heard
that he had silenced the Sadducees,
they got together.
35 One of them, an expert in the law,
wanted to test him
and asked him,
36 "Teacher, which commandment in the law is the
greatest?"
37 Jesus said to him,
"'You shall love the Lord your God
with all your heart,
with all your soul,
and with all your mind.'
38 This is the first and greatest commandment.
39 The second is like it:
'You shall love your neighbor as yourself.'
40 The whole law and the prophets
depend on these two commandments."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

According to Jewish counting there are 613 commandments in the law of Moses. Jewish teachers often discussed: Which is the most important? Which one sums up all the others?

Verse 37 quotes Deuteronomy 6:5. It is part of the "Shema Yisrael" ("Hear, O Israel"). Devout Jews still pray this prayer every morning and every evening today. Jesus prays it too.

Verse 39 quotes Leviticus 19:18.

Jesus connects love for God and love for your neighbor. The two belong together and cannot be separated. Other Jewish teachers taught something similar. The famous teacher Hillel is said to have said: What is hateful to you, do not do to your neighbor. That is the whole Torah.

"As yourself": Treating yourself well is part of it too. Whoever despises himself finds it hard to love others.

"The law and the prophets" means the whole Holy Scripture of Israel (compare 5:17; 7:12).

For today: This is the heart of faith for Jews and Christians: loving God and loving your neighbor.

Whose son is the Christ? VERSES 41–46

41 While the Pharisees were gathered together,
Jesus asked them a question.
42 He said,
"What do you think about the Christ?
Whose son is he?"
They said to him,
"The son of David."
43 He said to them,
"Then how can David, led by the Spirit,
call him 'Lord'?
For he says,
44 'The Lord said to my Lord,
Sit at my right hand,
until I make your enemies
a footstool for your feet.'
45 So if David calls him 'Lord,'
how can he be his son?"
46 No one was able to answer him a word.
And from that day on, no one dared
to ask him any more questions.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Many expected: The Messiah (Christ) will be a descendant of King David. That is correct. At the beginning, Matthew showed that Jesus is the "son of David" (1:1).

Verse 44 quotes Psalm 110:1. This psalm is linked to David. The first "Lord" is God. The second "Lord" is the king who sits at God's right hand.

Jesus asks: If David calls the Messiah "my Lord," then the Messiah is more than just a descendant of David. Christians understand it this way: Jesus is the son of David and at the same time the Son of God.

"A footstool for your feet": An ancient picture for a victory. It means: All evil will be defeated in the end.

Psalm 110:1 is quoted very often in the New Testament. It is one of the most important passages about Jesus.

Jewish interpreters usually understand this psalm differently, for example as a song about King David himself or about another king. Both readings should be seen with respect.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 23

A warning against hypocrisy

BEFORE YOU READ THIS CHAPTER – AN IMPORTANT NOTE

In this chapter Jesus speaks very harsh words against "scribes and Pharisees." In the history of the church these words were often misused to despise, persecute and kill Jews. That is a grave guilt.

That is why this is important:

Jesus himself was a Jew. Here he speaks as a Jewish teacher to other Jews, just as the prophets of Israel often spoke harshly to their own people (for example Isaiah 1 or Amos 5).

Jesus does not criticize Judaism or the Torah. He even says: Do what they teach (verse 3).

He criticizes an attitude: talking devoutly but acting differently. This danger exists in every religion, among Christians too, in the church today too.

Many Pharisees were devout, honest people. Later rabbinic Judaism grew out of their movement. Jewish writings themselves also criticize hypocritical Pharisees.

Whoever reads this chapter should not point a finger at others, but ask themselves: Am I like this?

They talk, but they don't do it VERSES 1–12

1 Then Jesus spoke to the crowds and to his disciples.
2 He said,
"The scribes and the Pharisees
sit on Moses' seat.
3 So whatever they tell you,
keep it and do it.
But don't do what they do.
For they say things, but they don't do them.
4 They tie up heavy loads
that are hard to carry
and put them on people's shoulders.
But they themselves will not lift a finger
to help them.
5 Everything they do,
they do to be seen by people.
They make their phylacteries wide
and the fringes of their garments long.
6 They love the places of honor at feasts
and the best seats in the synagogues.
7 They love to be greeted in the marketplaces
and to be called 'Rabbi, Rabbi' by people.
8 But you are not to be called 'Rabbi.'
For only one is your teacher, the Christ.
You are all brothers and sisters.
9 And call no one on earth your father.
For only one is your Father,
he who is in heaven.
10 And don't let yourselves be called 'master.'
For only one is your master, the Christ.
11 The greatest among you
shall be your servant.

12 Whoever lifts himself up
will be brought low.
And whoever makes himself low
will be lifted up."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Moses' seat" is a picture for the task of teaching and explaining the law of Moses.

Verse 3: Jesus says clearly: What they teach is right. Keep it! But he criticizes that some do not live by it.

Verse 4: Some teachers make life hard for others with many rules, but do not help themselves.

Verse 5: "Phylacteries" (Tefillin) are small boxes containing words from the Bible that devout Jews wear on their forehead and arm when they pray (based on Deuteronomy 6:8). The "fringes" (Tzitzit) remind people of God's commandments (Numbers 15:38–39). Jesus also wore such fringes (9:20). Jesus does not criticize these signs, but using them to look devout in front of others.

Verses 8–10: In the community of Jesus, everyone should be equal, "brothers and sisters." No one should put himself above others. This also applies to Christians with titles such as "Pastor," "Father" or "Bishop."

Verse 12: A principle that Jesus often states (compare 18:4; Luke 14:11).

"How terrible it will be for you" VERSES 13–22

13 "How terrible it will be for you, scribes and Pharisees,
you hypocrites!
For you eat up widows' houses
and make long prayers for show.
That is why you will receive a harsher judgment.
14 But how terrible it will be for you, scribes and
Pharisees, you hypocrites!
For you shut the Kingdom of Heaven in people's faces.
You don't go in yourselves,
and you don't let those who want to go in
enter.
15 How terrible it will be for you, scribes and Pharisees,
you hypocrites!
For you travel over sea and land
to win a single person over to your faith.
And when he has become one,
you make him a son of Gehenna,
twice as bad as yourselves.
16 How terrible it will be for you, you blind guides!
You say,
'If anyone swears by the temple,
it means nothing.
But if anyone swears by the gold of the temple,
he is bound by it.'
17 You blind fools!
Which is greater:
the gold, or the temple
that makes the gold holy?
18 And you say,
'If anyone swears by the altar,
it means nothing.
But if anyone swears by the gift
that is on the altar,
he is bound by it.'
19 You blind fools!
Which is greater:
the gift, or the altar
that makes the gift holy?
20 So whoever swears by the altar
swears by it
and by everything on it.
21 And whoever swears by the temple
swears by it
and by him who lives in it.
22 And whoever swears by heaven
swears by the throne of God
and by him who sits on it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"How terrible it will be for you" (in the WEB: "Woe to you") is a cry of lament, as the prophets of Israel often used it (for example Isaiah 5:8–23). It is a serious warning, but also a lament full of pain.

Verses 13 and 14: The verse numbering differs in Bibles here. The cry about "widows' houses" is missing in many old manuscripts. Something similar is found in Mark 12:40 and Luke 20:47. In the WEB it is verse 13. Many Bibles leave it out or put it in brackets as verse 14.

"Eating up widows' houses": Widows were often poor and without protection. Whoever takes advantage of them while acting devout does something especially bad.

Verse 15: The WEB says "proselyte." A proselyte is a person who converts to Judaism. Jesus does not criticize converting, but training people in a harsh, loveless kind of faith. About "Gehenna," see the box on 5:22.

Verses 16–22: Some people made a difference between oaths that count and oaths that don't count. Jesus says: Such tricks are dishonest. Every oath is valid before God. Compare 5:33–37: It is best simply to say an honest yes or no.

Important: "Blind guides" and "blind fools" are pictures for spiritual blindness. They say nothing about people with visual impairments.

The most important things in the law VERSES 23–28

23 "How terrible it will be for you, scribes and Pharisees,
you hypocrites!
For you give a tenth of mint, dill, and cumin.
But you have neglected the more important things of
the law:
justice, mercy, and faithfulness.
You should have done these things,
without neglecting the others.
24 You blind guides!
You strain out a gnat,
but you swallow a camel.
25 How terrible it will be for you, scribes and Pharisees,
you hypocrites!
For you clean the outside of the cup and of the dish.
But inside they are full of robbery and injustice.
26 You blind Pharisee!
First clean the inside of the cup and of the dish,
so that the outside may become clean too.
27 How terrible it will be for you, scribes and Pharisees,
you hypocrites!
For you are like tombs painted white.
On the outside they look beautiful,
but inside they are full of dead people's bones
and all kinds of uncleanness.

28 In the same way, on the outside you look righteous to
people.
But inside you are full of hypocrisy and injustice."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23: The "tenth" (tithe) was an offering for God: a tenth of the harvest (Deuteronomy 14:22). Some were so exact that they even gave a tenth of small herbs.

Jesus does not say: That is wrong. He says they should do it "without neglecting the others." But the most important things are justice, mercy and faithfulness. The prophets already said this (Micah 6:8).

Verse 24: A funny picture. People strain out a little gnat from their drink so that they don't drink anything unclean, but they swallow a whole camel. Gnats and camels were both considered unclean. In Aramaic the words for gnat and camel may sound similar. But that is not certain.

Gnat: a tiny fly.

Verse 27: Tombs were painted white with lime so that no one would touch them by accident and become unclean.

The message: What counts is what is inside, the heart. Not only what others see.

For today: This warning applies to everyone. Christians and churches can also look devout on the outside and be unjust inside.

The tombs of the prophets VERSES 29–36

29 "How terrible it will be for you, scribes and Pharisees,
you hypocrites!
For you build tombs for the prophets
and decorate the graves of the righteous.
30 And you say,
'If we had lived in the days of our ancestors,
we would not have taken part with them
in shedding the blood of the prophets.'
31 So you testify against yourselves
that you are children of those
who killed the prophets.
32 Go on, then, and finish what your ancestors started!
33 You snakes, you offspring of vipers!
How will you escape the judgment of Gehenna?
34 So:
I am sending you prophets, wise men and scribes.
Some of them you will kill and crucify.
Others you will whip in your synagogues
and persecute from town to town.
35 So all the righteous blood
that has been shed on the earth will come on you,
from the blood of righteous Abel
to the blood of Zachariah son of Barachiah,
whom you killed between the sanctuary and the altar.
36 Most certainly I tell you,
all these things will come on this generation."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 29–31: The people honor the prophets who were persecuted in earlier times. But Jesus says: You are no better than your ancestors. You reject God's messengers today in the same way.

"Offspring of vipers": John the Baptizer also spoke this way (3:7). It is the harsh language of the prophets.

Verse 34: Jesus is speaking about his own messengers, who will be persecuted. Later some disciples really were persecuted (for example Acts 5:40; 2 Corinthians 11:24).

Verse 35: Abel is the first murder victim in the Bible (Genesis 4:8). A man named Zechariah was stoned in the courtyard of the temple. The last book of the Hebrew Bible tells about this (2 Chronicles 24:20–22). So the sentence covers the whole Bible from beginning to end. But there Zechariah is called the son of Jehoiada. The prophet Zechariah was the son of Berechiah (Zechariah 1:1). There are different explanations for this difference.

Verse 36: "This generation": Many interpreters think of the destruction of Jerusalem in the year AD 70.

Very important: Christians turned these verses into the idea that "the Jews" are guilty for all time. That is wrong and has brought terrible suffering. The Bible says: Every person is responsible for their own guilt, not for that of their ancestors (Ezekiel 18:20).

The lament over Jerusalem VERSES 37–39

37 "Jerusalem, Jerusalem,
you who kill the prophets
and stone those who are sent to you!
How often I wanted to gather your children together,
just as a hen gathers her chicks
under her wings.
But you were not willing!
38 Your house is left to you deserted and empty.
39 For I tell you,
from now on you will not see me
until you say,
'Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The chapter does not end with anger, but with a sad lament. Jesus loves Jerusalem. He weeps over the city (compare Luke 19:41).

The picture of the hen is tender and motherly. That is how Jesus describes himself and God's love. In the Psalms, too, people find shelter "under God's wings" (Psalm 91:4).

Verse 38: "Your house" probably means the temple. The saying reminds us of Jeremiah 22:5.

Verse 39: At the end there is hope. Jesus quotes Psalm 118:26, as at the entry into Jerusalem (21:9). There will be a day when they welcome him with joy. The story between God and Jerusalem is not over.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 24

The speech about the end times

Jesus announces the destruction of the temple

VERSES 1–2

1 Jesus went out of the temple
and was on his way.

Then his disciples came to him
to show him the buildings of the temple.
2 But he answered them,
"You see all these things, don't you?
Most certainly I tell you,
not one stone here will be left on another.
Everything will be torn down."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At that time the temple in Jerusalem was one of the largest and most beautiful buildings in the world. King Herod the Great had it splendidly enlarged. The disciples are proud and excited.

Jesus announces: The temple will be destroyed. That happened in the year AD 70. The Romans conquered Jerusalem and burned the temple.

For the Jewish people this was a great catastrophe. To this day Jews remember it on the day of mourning called Tisha B'Av. The Western Wall (the "Wailing Wall") is a remnant of the old wall around the Temple Mount.

Jesus is not happy about the destruction. He lamented over Jerusalem (23:37).

The beginning of the birth pains VERSES 3–14

3 As he was sitting on the Mount of Olives,
the disciples came to him privately and asked,
"Tell us: When will these things happen?
And what is the sign of your coming
and of the end of the age?"
4 Jesus answered them,
"Be careful that no one leads you astray!
5 For many will come in my name
and say, 'I am the Christ.'
And they will lead many astray.
6 You will hear of wars
and rumors of wars.
See that you are not frightened!
For all this must happen,
but it is not yet the end.
7 For nation will rise against nation,
and kingdom against kingdom.
And there will be famines, plagues, and earthquakes
in various places.
8 But all these things are only the beginning of the birth
pains.
9 Then they will hand you over to be oppressed
and will kill you.
You will be hated by all nations
because you belong to me.
10 Then many will fall away from the faith.
They will betray one another
and hate one another.
11 Many false prophets will appear
and lead many astray.
12 And because wickedness will increase,
the love of many will grow cold.
13 But whoever endures to the end
will be saved.
14 And this Good News of the Kingdom
will be preached in the whole world
as a testimony to all nations.
And then the end will come."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The disciples ask about two things: When will the temple be destroyed? And when will the end of the world come? Jesus answers in a way that blends the two together. That makes this speech hard to understand.

The first and most important message: "Be careful that no one leads you astray!" Jesus warns against people who claim to know exactly when the end will come, or who present themselves as the savior.

Verses 6–8: There have been wars, famines, plagues and earthquakes at all times. Jesus says: Don't be frightened! This is not yet the end. "Birth pains" are the pains when a baby is born. The picture says: After the pain, something new comes.

Verses 9–13: Whoever believes in Jesus may face disadvantages and persecution because of it. That is still the case in some countries today. Jesus encourages: Stand firm.

Important for today: Again and again groups have claimed that the end would come on a certain date. They frightened people and took advantage of them. Jesus warns against exactly that. Whoever is in a group that puts pressure on people with fear of the end of the world may get help, for example from counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse.

The great distress VERSES 15–28

15 "So when you see the 'abomination of desolation'
standing in the holy place,
which the prophet Daniel spoke about
(let the reader understand!),
16 then those who are in Judea
should flee to the mountains.
17 Whoever is on the housetop
should not go down
to take anything out of his house.
18 Whoever is in the field
should not go back
to get his clothes.
19 But how terrible it will be in those days
for pregnant women
and for mothers who are nursing a baby!
20 Pray that you won't have to flee in the winter
or on a Sabbath.
21 For then there will be great suffering,
such as there has not been from the beginning of the
world until now,
and never will be again.
22 And if those days were not cut short,
no one would be saved.
But for the sake of the chosen ones
those days will be cut short.
23 Then if anyone says to you,
'Look, here is the Christ!' or, 'There he is!'
don't believe it.
24 For false christs
and false prophets will appear.
They will do great signs and wonders
to lead astray, if possible, even the chosen ones.
25 I have told you ahead of time.
26 So if they say to you,
'Look, he is in the wilderness,'
don't go out there.

Or, 'Look, he is in the inner rooms,'
don't believe it.
27 For as the lightning flashes in the east
and is seen all the way to the west,
so will the coming of the Son of Man be.
28 For wherever the dead body is,
that is where the vultures gather."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: The "abomination of desolation" is an expression from the book of Daniel (Daniel 9:27; 11:31; 12:11). There it means a desecration of the temple. In the year 167 BC the Greek king Antiochus IV had a foreign altar set up in the temple. Jesus announces: Something like this will happen again. Many interpreters think of the events around the year AD 70.

Abomination: something disgusting and shameful. Desolation: destruction, leaving a place empty.

"Let the reader understand": This is a note to the readers of the Gospel.

Verses 16–20: When the time comes, people should flee at once, without losing time. Jesus thinks especially of pregnant women and mothers with small children, for whom fleeing is especially hard. In winter the roads are hard to travel. On the Sabbath devout Jews did not want to travel long distances.

Verse 22: God does not forget people in distress. He puts a limit on suffering.

Verses 23–27: Jesus says: When he comes again, no one will be able to miss it. It is like lightning across the whole sky. You don't have to search for him or run after people who say he is here or there.

Verse 28 is a proverb. It probably means: When the time comes, it will be as clear as seeing vultures over a dead animal. Instead of "vultures," it can also be translated "eagles."

The coming of the Son of Man VERSES 29–31

29 "But immediately after the suffering of those days,
the sun will be darkened,
and the moon will not give its light.
The stars will fall from the sky,
and the powers of the heavens will be shaken.
30 Then the sign of the Son of Man
will appear in the sky.
Then all the tribes of the earth will mourn.
And they will see the Son of Man
coming on the clouds of the sky
with power and great glory.
31 He will send out his angels
with a loud trumpet call.
And they will gather his chosen ones
from the four winds,
from one end of the sky to the other."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 29 takes up pictures from the prophets (Isaiah 13:10; 34:4; Joel 2:10). These pictures describe how God steps in and the whole world changes. It is picture language, not an exact description of what will happen in the sky.

Verse 30 reminds us of Daniel 7:13–14: One like a son of man comes with the clouds of the sky and receives eternal rule from God. Jesus says: That is me.

We are not told what the "sign of the Son of Man" is.

Verse 31: In ancient Israel the trumpet (a horn) called the people together. At the end God gathers everyone who belongs to him from all over the world.

For today: Christians believe that Jesus will come again. That is a hope, not a threat. In the end it is not evil that wins, but God.

The parable of the fig tree VERSES 32–35

32 "Learn this parable from the fig tree:
When its branches become tender
and put out leaves,
you know that summer is near.
33 In the same way,
when you see all these things,
you know that he is near,
right at the door.
34 Most certainly I tell you,
this generation will not pass away
until all these things have happened.
35 Heaven and earth will pass away,
but my words will not pass away."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Many trees in Israel, for example the olive tree, keep their leaves in winter. The fig tree loses them. When it gets new leaves, everyone knows: Summer will soon be here.

Verse 34 is hard. "This generation" probably means the people who were alive at that time. Many interpreters say: This refers to the destruction of Jerusalem, which came about 40 years later. Others understand "generation" differently. There are different interpretations.

Verse 35: Everything in the world passes away. But you can rely on Jesus' words.

No one knows the day or the hour VERSES 36–44

36 "But no one knows that day and that hour,
not even the angels of heaven,
but only my Father.
37 As it was in the days of Noah,
so it will be when the Son of Man comes.
38 For in the days before the flood
people were eating and drinking,
marrying and giving in marriage,
until the day Noah went into the ship.
39 And they didn't notice anything
until the flood came
and swept them all away.
That is how it will be when the Son of Man comes.
40 Then two men will be in the field:
One will be taken,
and one will be left.
41 Two women will be grinding grain at the mill:
One will be taken,
and one will be left.
42 So keep watch!
For you don't know
at what hour your Lord is coming.
43 But know this:
If the owner of the house had known
in which watch of the night the thief was coming,
he would have stayed awake
and would not have let his house be broken into.

44 So you also must be ready!
For the Son of Man is coming at an hour
when you don't expect him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 36 is very important: No one knows the day. Not the angels, not any human being, only God. That is why every calculation of a date for the end of the world is wrong.

In verse 36 many old manuscripts also say that not even the Son knows it (compare Mark 13:32). In Mark these words are certainly there. The WEB does not have them here.

Verses 37–39: The people in Noah's time lived their everyday lives and did not reckon with God (Genesis 6–7). Eating, drinking and marrying are not bad. But you should not forget God while doing them.

Verses 40–41: Life goes on quite normally, and suddenly the time has come. Some groups teach from this a "rapture," in which believers suddenly disappear. That is one particular interpretation. Many churches do not share it.

Verse 41: At that time grinding grain was women's work. Jesus names men and women equally.

Verses 42–44: "Keeping watch" does not mean being anxious. It means: living every day in such a way that you could meet God. Doing good, being honest, loving others.

The faithful servant and the evil servant VERSES 45–51

45 "Who then is the faithful and wise servant?
His master has put him in charge of the people in his household,
to give them their food at the right time.
46 Blessed is that servant
if his master comes
and finds him doing this work.
47 Most certainly I tell you,
he will put him in charge of everything he owns.
48 But if that evil servant says in his heart,
'My master is taking a long time to come,'
49 and begins to beat his fellow servants
and to eat and drink with the drunkards,
50 then the master of that servant will come
on a day when he doesn't expect it,
and at an hour he doesn't know.
51 He will cut him to pieces
and give him his place with the hypocrites.
There will be weeping and grinding of teeth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A servant is given responsibility for others. The faithful servant takes good care of the people entrusted to him.

The evil servant thinks: My master won't come so soon anyway. He misuses his power, beats others and lives without caring about anyone.

The message: Whoever has responsibility for others, whether in the family, at work or in the church, should use it well and faithfully. Violence and the abuse of power are against God's will.

Verse 51: "Cut him to pieces" is a harsh picture from the parable. It shows how seriously God takes the abuse of power. It is not an instruction to use violence. The word can also mean: punish severely, or cut off from himself.

For today: Whoever is beaten or oppressed by someone who has power over them may get help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For domestic violence: US: 1-800-799-7233. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 25

What you did for one of the least

The 10 young women VERSES 1–13

1 "Then the Kingdom of Heaven will be like 10 young women.
They took their lamps
and went out to meet the bridegroom.
2 Five of them were foolish,
and five were wise.
3 The foolish ones took their lamps,
but they took no oil with them.
4 But the wise ones took oil in jars
along with their lamps.
5 The bridegroom took a long time to come,
so they all became drowsy and fell asleep.
6 But at midnight there was a cry:
'The bridegroom is coming!
Come out to meet him!'
7 Then all the young women got up
and got their lamps ready.
8 The foolish ones said to the wise ones,
'Give us some of your oil,
for our lamps are going out.'
9 But the wise ones answered,
'What if there isn't enough for us and for you?
Go instead to those who sell oil
and buy some for yourselves.'
10 While they were going away to buy oil,
the bridegroom came.
Those who were ready
went in with him to the wedding feast.
And the door was shut.
11 Later the other young women also came and said,
'Lord, Lord, open the door for us!'
12 But he answered,
'Most certainly I tell you,
I don't know you.'
13 So keep watch!
For you don't know the day or the hour
when the Son of Man is coming."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At a wedding in those days, the bridegroom went to fetch the bride and brought her to his house. Young women from the town went with him carrying lamps or torches. The WEB says virgins, meaning young, unmarried women, bridesmaids.

The bridegroom is a picture of Jesus, who will come again. He comes later than expected.

All 10 fall asleep, even the wise ones. That is not criticized. The difference is: The wise ones were prepared.

The "oil" is a picture. Many interpreters say: It stands for what you cannot lend, for example your own faith, good deeds or a living relationship with God. No one can give that to you.

Verse 12: "I don't know you" is a serious word (compare 7:23). It shows: You should not keep putting off God's invitation.

Important: This parable does not teach that you should not help others. It is about something every person has to do for themselves.

The parable of the entrusted talents VERSES 14–30

14 "For it is like a man
who was going to travel to another country.
He called his servants
and entrusted his wealth to them.
15 To one he gave five talents
(about 375 pounds of silver),
to another two
(about 150 pounds),
to another one
(about 75 pounds),
to each according to his own ability.
Then he went on his journey.
16 The one who had received the five talents
went at once,
traded with them,
and gained five more talents.
17 In the same way, the one with the two talents
gained two more.
18 But the one who had received only one talent
went away,
dug a hole in the ground,
and hid his master's money.
19 After a long time the master of those servants came
back
and settled accounts with them.
20 The one who had received the five talents
came and brought five more talents.
He said,
'Master, you gave me five talents.
Look, I have gained five more talents.'
21 His master said to him,
'Well done, good and faithful servant!
You have been faithful over a few things,
I will put you in charge of many things.
Come and share your master's joy!'
22 The one with the two talents also came and said,
'Master, you gave me two talents.
Look, I have gained two more talents.'
23 His master said to him,
'Well done, good and faithful servant!
You have been faithful over a few things,
I will put you in charge of many things.
Come and share your master's joy!'
24 Then the one who had received one talent also came
and said,
'Master, I knew that you are a hard man.
You reap where you didn't sow,
and gather where you didn't scatter seed.
25 I was afraid.
So I went away
and hid your talent in the ground.
Here, you have what is yours.'
26 But his master answered him,
'You wicked and lazy servant!
You knew that I reap where I didn't sow,
and gather where I didn't scatter seed.
27 Then you should have put my money in the bank.
Then when I came back
I would have received what is mine with interest.
28 So take the talent away from him
and give it to the one who has the 10 talents.
29 For to everyone who has, more will be given,
and he will have more than enough.
But from the one who doesn't have,
even what he has will be taken away.
30 And throw the useless servant
out into the outer darkness.
There will be weeping and grinding of teeth.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In those days a "talent" was not a gift or ability, but a large sum of money: about 75 pounds of silver, as much as the wages for many years of work. Because this parable is so well known, today we use the word "talent" for an ability.

The master entrusts a lot to his servants, "to each according to his own ability." No one gets too much. And the one with two talents is praised just like the one with five. What matters is not how much you have, but what you do with it.

The third servant is afraid. He sees his master as hard and harsh. That is why he risks nothing. The parable shows: A false, fearful picture of God can paralyze you.

The message: God has given every person gifts. We should use them boldly, for God and for others.

Verse 29: Compare 13:12. Whoever uses their gifts receives even more. Whoever buries them loses them. This is not a rule for business or money.

Important: The parable does not say that people with a disability, an illness or little strength are worth less. Every person has gifts, even if they don't look like achievements.

Verse 30: A harsh picture for the judgment (compare 8:12; 22:13).

The final judgment VERSES 31–46

31 "But when the Son of Man comes in his glory,
and all the holy angels with him,
then he will sit on the throne of his glory.
32 All the nations will be gathered before him.
And he will separate them from one another,
as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats.
33 He will put the sheep on his right side,
but the goats on his left.
34 Then the King will say to those on his right side,
'Come, you who are blessed by my Father!
Inherit the Kingdom
that was prepared for you from the creation of the
world.
35 For I was hungry,
and you gave me food to eat.

I was thirsty,
and you gave me something to drink.
I was a stranger,
and you took me in.
36 I was naked,
and you gave me clothes.
I was sick,
and you visited me.
I was in prison,
and you came to me.'
37 Then the righteous will answer him,
'Lord, when did we see you hungry
and feed you?
Or thirsty
and give you something to drink?
38 When did we see you as a stranger
and take you in?
Or naked
and give you clothes?
39 When did we see you sick or in prison
and come to you?'
40 The King will answer them,
'Most certainly I tell you,
whatever you did for one of the least of these my
brothers and sisters,
you did for me.'
41 Then he will also say to those on his left side,
'Go away from me, you who are cursed,
into the eternal fire
that is prepared for the devil and his angels!
42 For I was hungry,
and you didn't give me food to eat.
I was thirsty,
and you gave me nothing to drink.
43 I was a stranger,
and you didn't take me in.
I was naked,
and you didn't give me clothes.
I was sick and in prison,
and you didn't visit me.'
44 Then they will also answer,
'Lord, when did we see you hungry or thirsty,
or a stranger or naked,
or sick or in prison,
and didn't help you?'
45 Then he will answer them,
'Most certainly I tell you,
whatever you didn't do for one of the least of these,
you didn't do for me.'
46 And these will go away into eternal punishment,
but the righteous into eternal life."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the last great speech of Jesus in the Gospel of Matthew. It shows a picture of the end of time: All nations stand before Jesus as King and Judge.

In Israel sheep and goats often grazed together. In the evening the shepherd separated them. The picture says nothing bad about goats as animals.

The standard at the judgment is surprising: People are not asked what they believed or knew, but how they treated people in need.

The six deeds are: giving food to the hungry, giving drink to the thirsty, taking in strangers, clothing the naked, visiting the sick and visiting prisoners. In the church they are counted among the "works of mercy." Later a seventh work was added: burying the dead. In Judaism, too, such deeds are considered very important (compare Isaiah 58:6–7).

The amazing thing: Neither group knew that they had met Jesus. Jesus is hidden in the poor, the strangers, the sick and the prisoners.

"My brothers and sisters" (the WEB says brothers; men and women are meant): Some interpreters think this means Jesus' disciples. Most understand it this way: It means all people in need.

Verses 41 and 46 are very serious words. Christians understand the "eternal fire" in different ways. What is certain: God cares how people treat each other. The fire is "prepared for the devil," not for people. God wants all people to be saved (1 Timothy 2:4).

For today: Whoever helps refugees, cares for the sick, gives food to homeless people or visits prisoners meets Jesus. These verses have moved many people to found hospitals, charities and food banks.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 26

The Last Supper and the night of the betrayal

The plan against Jesus VERSES 1–5

1 When Jesus had finished all these speeches,
he said to his disciples,
2 "You know that in two days it will be the Passover.
Then the Son of Man will be handed over
to be crucified."
3 Then the chief priests, the scribes,
and the elders of the people gathered
in the courtyard of the high priest,
who was called Caiaphas.
4 They made plans together
about how they could arrest Jesus by a trick
and kill him.
5 But they said,
"Not during the feast,
so that there won't be a riot among the people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Passover (in Hebrew "Pesach") is one of the most important Jewish feasts. It recalls how God freed the people of Israel from slavery in Egypt (Exodus 12). To this day Jews celebrate it every year in the spring.

Caiaphas was high priest from about AD 18 to 36. He was the highest priest at the temple and worked closely with the Romans.

Important: Here a small group of leaders makes plans against Jesus. The people are more on Jesus' side. That is why the leaders are afraid of a riot. It is wrong to blame "the Jews" for the death of Jesus.

Jesus is anointed in Bethany VERSES 6–13

6 When Jesus was in Bethany,
in the house of Simon the leper,
7 a woman came to him.
She had an alabaster jar
of very expensive ointment.
She poured it on his head
as he was sitting at the table.
8 When his disciples saw this,
they were angry and said,
"Why this waste?
9 This ointment could have been sold for a lot of money,
and the money could have been given to the poor."
10 Jesus knew this and said to them,
"Why are you troubling the woman?
She has done a good thing for me.
11 For you always have the poor with you,
but you don't always have me.
12 When she poured this ointment on my body,
she did it to prepare me for my burial.
13 Most certainly I tell you,
wherever this Good News is preached
in the whole world,
what this woman has done will also be told
in memory of her."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Simon "the leper" was perhaps a man whom Jesus had healed. Matthew does not explain this.

Alabaster is a light-colored, soft stone. Precious jars for ointment were made from it.

Ointment: a fragrant oil that was rubbed or poured on the body.

The woman anoints Jesus like a king. In the Old Testament kings were anointed with oil. "Christ" means "the Anointed One."

The disciples think it is a waste. Jesus defends the woman. She has understood what the disciples do not yet understand: Jesus will soon die.

Verse 11: Jesus is not saying that the poor are unimportant. He is quoting Deuteronomy 15:11. There it goes on to say: That is why you shall open your hand to the poor. Jesus means: You can always help the poor, and you should.

Verse 13: Jesus promises that this woman will be remembered everywhere. Matthew does not give her name. In John 12:3 it is Mary of Bethany.

Judas wants to betray Jesus VERSES 14–16

14 Then one of the 12 disciples,
who was called Judas Iscariot,
went to the chief priests
15 and said,
"What are you willing to give me
if I hand him over to you?"
They weighed out 30 pieces of silver for him.
16 From then on he looked for a good opportunity
to betray him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Matthew does not say exactly why Judas betrayed Jesus. Here it is about money. Other reasons have been suggested, but they are not certain.

30 pieces of silver remind us of Zechariah 11:12. There it is the wage with which the shepherd is fobbed off. According to Exodus 21:32 it was the price of a slave.

Very important: In many languages the name "Judas" sounds like the word for "Jew." For centuries Christians used Judas as a picture for "the Jews." That was wrong and caused great injustice. All 12 disciples were Jews, Peter too, John too. And Jesus himself was a Jew.

The last Passover meal VERSES 17–25

17 On the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread,
the disciples came to Jesus and asked him,
"Where do you want us to prepare the Passover meal
for you?"
18 He said,
"Go into the city to a certain man
and tell him,
'The Teacher says,
"My time is near.
I will celebrate the Passover at your house with my
disciples."'"
19 The disciples did as Jesus had told them
and prepared the Passover meal.
20 When evening came,
he was reclining at the table with the 12 disciples.
21 While they were eating, he said,
"Most certainly I tell you,
one of you will betray me."
22 They became very sad,
and each one began to ask him,
"It isn't me, is it, Lord?"
23 He answered,
"The one who dipped his hand into the dish with me
will betray me.
24 The Son of Man is going his way,
as it is written about him.
But how terrible it will be for that man
through whom the Son of Man is betrayed!
It would be better for that man
if he had not been born."
25 Then Judas, who betrayed him, answered,
"It isn't me, is it, Rabbi?"
He said to him,
"You said it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Feast of Unleavened Bread is part of the Passover. For one week people eat bread without yeast (matzah), in memory of the hurried departure from Egypt.

Unleavened: made without yeast, so the bread stays flat.

At festive meals in those days people reclined on cushions around a low table.

Jesus celebrates the Passover meal with his disciples, as devout Jews do. There is an order with prayers, bread, wine and songs.

Verse 22: All the disciples ask: "It isn't me, is it, Lord?" Each one knows that he can be weak.

Verse 23: Everyone dipped their bread into the same dish. Eating together was a sign of friendship and trust. That makes the betrayal all the worse.
Verse 25: Judas calls Jesus "Rabbi" (teacher), not "Lord" like the others.

The Lord's Supper VERSES 26–30

26 While they were eating,
Jesus took bread,
gave thanks to God for it,
and broke it.
He gave it to the disciples and said,
"Take, eat;
this is my body."
27 Then he took the cup,
gave thanks,
gave it to them, and said,
"All of you drink from it,
28 for this is my blood of the new covenant,
which is poured out for many
for the forgiveness of sins.
29 But I tell you,
from now on I will not drink of this fruit of the vine
until that day
when I drink it new with you
in my Father's Kingdom."
30 When they had sung a hymn,
they went out to the Mount of Olives.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here begins what Christians still celebrate today: the Lord's Supper, also called the Eucharist or Holy Communion. All Christian churches remember these words.

Jesus takes bread and wine from the Passover meal and gives them a new meaning: His body and his blood are given for people.

Christians understand this in different ways. Catholic and Orthodox Christians believe that the bread and wine really become the body and blood of Christ. Lutheran Christians believe that Christ is present in, with and under the bread and wine. Reformed and many other Protestant Christians understand it more as a sign and a remembrance, in which Christ is spiritually present.

Covenant: a binding agreement, a promise of faithfulness between God and people.

Verse 28: "My blood of the new covenant" reminds us of Exodus 24:8. There God made a covenant with Israel at Mount Sinai. The new covenant reminds us of Jeremiah 31:31–34. The word "new" is missing in some old manuscripts. The WEB has it.

Important: The new covenant does not cancel God's covenant with Israel. God stays faithful to his people (Romans 11:29).

In Hebrew ways of speaking, "for many" means: for the great multitude, for all (compare 20:28).

Verse 30: At the Passover meal people still sing psalms today, the "Hallel psalms" (Psalms 113–118). This hymn probably means them.

Jesus predicts that Peter will deny him VERSES 31–35

31 Then Jesus said to them,
"Tonight all of you will fall away because of me.
For it is written,
'I will strike the shepherd,
and the sheep of the flock will be scattered.'
32 But after I am raised up,
I will go ahead of you into Galilee."
33 But Peter answered him,
"Even if all fall away because of you,
I will never fall away."
34 Jesus said to him,
"Most certainly I tell you,
tonight,
before the rooster crows,
you will deny me three times."
35 Peter said to him,
"Even if I must die with you,
I will not deny you."
All the other disciples said the same.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 31 quotes Zechariah 13:7.

Deny: to say that you don't know someone or don't belong to him.

Jesus knows: His friends will leave him alone. But he already gives them a promise now: After the resurrection we will meet again in Galilee. He does not give up on them.

Peter means it honestly. But he overestimates himself.

Jesus prays in Gethsemane VERSES 36–46

36 Then Jesus came with them to a place
called Gethsemane.
He said to the disciples,
"Sit here,
while I go over there and pray."
37 He took Peter and the two sons of Zebedee with him.
And he began to be sad
and deeply troubled.
38 Then Jesus said to them,
"My soul is so sad that I could die.
Stay here and keep watch with me!"
39 He went a little farther,
fell with his face to the ground, and prayed,
"My Father,
if it is possible,
let this cup pass away from me.
But not what I want,
but what you want."
40 He came back to the disciples
and found them sleeping.
He said to Peter,
"Couldn't you keep watch with me for one hour?
41 Watch and pray,
so that you don't fall into temptation!
The spirit indeed is willing,
but the flesh is weak."
42 Again he went away,
a second time,
and prayed,
"My Father,
if this cup can't pass away from me
unless I drink it,
your will be done."
43 He came again
and found them sleeping,

for their eyes were heavy.
44 He left them,
went away again,
and prayed a third time,
saying the same words.
45 Then he came to his disciples and said to them,
"Are you still sleeping and resting?
The hour has come,
and the Son of Man is betrayed into the hands of sinners.
46 Get up, let's go!
The one who betrays me is here."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gethsemane means "oil press." It was a garden with olive trees on the Mount of Olives.

Here we see Jesus as completely human. He is very afraid and deeply sad. He asks his friends to stay with him.

The "cup" is a picture of the heavy suffering that lies ahead of him (compare 20:22).

Jesus prays honestly: "If it is possible, let this cup pass away from me." But he entrusts himself to God: "Your will be done" – as in the Lord's Prayer (6:10).

For today: Jesus, too, was afraid. Fear and despair are not signs of weak faith. You may tell God everything. Whoever has great fear or dark thoughts should not stay alone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 41: The disciples want to stay awake, but they can't manage it. Jesus is disappointed, but he understands their weakness.

Jesus is arrested VERSES 47–56

47 While he was still speaking,
Judas, one of the 12 disciples, came.
With him came a large crowd with swords and clubs,
sent by the chief priests and the elders of the people.
48 The betrayer had given them a sign:
"The one I kiss is the man.
Arrest him!"
49 At once he went to Jesus and said,
"Greetings, Rabbi!"
And he kissed him.
50 Jesus said to him,
"Friend, why are you here?"
Then they came,
laid hands on Jesus,
and arrested him.
51 And one of those who were with Jesus
stretched out his hand,
drew his sword,
struck the servant of the high priest,
and cut off his ear.
52 Then Jesus said to him,
"Put your sword back into its place!
For all those who take the sword
will die by the sword.
53 Or do you think
that I couldn't ask my Father,
and he would at once send me more than 12 legions of angels?
54 But then how would the Scriptures be fulfilled
that say it must happen this way?"
55 At that hour Jesus said to the crowd,
"Have you come out with swords and clubs to arrest me,
as if I were a robber?
Every day I sat in the temple teaching,
and you didn't arrest me.
56 But all this has happened
so that the Scriptures of the prophets would be fulfilled."
Then all the disciples left him and fled.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In those days a kiss was a normal greeting among friends and from students to their teacher. Judas misuses this sign of love.

Even so, Jesus calls Judas "Friend."

Verse 51: John 18:10 tells us that it was Peter.

Verse 52 is a very important word: Jesus forbids violence, even to defend himself. "All those who take the sword will die by the sword." Violence brings new violence. No one may use violence in the name of Jesus.

Verse 53: A Roman legion had about 5,000 to 6,000 soldiers. Jesus could defend himself, but he does not. He goes this way of his own free will.

Verse 56: All the disciples flee. Jesus is completely alone.

Jesus before the Council VERSES 57–68

57 Those who had arrested Jesus
led him to Caiaphas the high priest.
The scribes and the elders had gathered there.
58 But Peter followed him at a distance
as far as the courtyard of the high priest.
He went in
and sat down with the guards
to see how it would end.
59 The chief priests, the elders, and the whole council
were looking for false testimony against Jesus,
so that they could put him to death.
60 But they found none,
even though many false witnesses came forward.
At last two false witnesses came forward
61 and said,
"This man said,
'I am able to destroy the temple of God
and to build it again in three days.'"
62 Then the high priest stood up and said to him,
"Have you no answer?
What is this that these men are saying against you?"
63 But Jesus stayed silent.
Then the high priest said to him,
"I command you by the living God:
Tell us whether you are the Christ, the Son of God!"
64 Jesus said to him,
"You have said so.
But I tell you,
from now on you will see the Son of Man
sitting at the right hand of Power
and coming on the clouds of the sky."
65 Then the high priest tore his clothes and said,
"He has spoken blasphemy!

Why do we need any more witnesses?
Look, now you have heard his blasphemy.
66 What do you think?"
They answered,
"He deserves to die!"
67 Then they spat in his face
and beat him with their fists.
Others slapped him
68 and said,
"Prophesy to us, you Christ!
Who hit you?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Council (in Greek "Synedrion," in Hebrew "Sanhedrin") was the highest Jewish authority in Jerusalem. It was made up of priests, elders and scribes.

Matthew tells us that the trial was not fair: They looked for false witnesses. According to the Law of Moses, two witnesses who agree are needed (Deuteronomy 19:15).

Verse 63: Jesus stays silent. That reminds us of Isaiah 53:7: Like a lamb that is led to the slaughter, he did not open his mouth.

Verse 64: Jesus combines Psalm 110:1 and Daniel 7:13. "Power" is a respectful way of speaking about God. Out of reverence, Jews often avoid saying the name of God.

Blasphemy: speaking against God or insulting God.

Verse 65: Tearing one's clothes was a sign of great horror and grief.

Very important: Here a particular group of leaders acts on a particular night. The Jewish people as a whole were not involved. In 1965 the Catholic Church declared in the council document *Nostra Aetate*: The suffering of Jesus may not be blamed on all the Jews living then, nor on the Jews of today. Protestant churches have also said this clearly.

Verses 67–68: Jesus is mocked and beaten. He does not fight back.

Peter denies Jesus VERSES 69–75

69 Peter was sitting outside in the courtyard.
A servant girl came to him and said,
"You were also with Jesus, the Galilean!"
70 But he denied it in front of everyone and said,
"I don't know what you are talking about."
71 When he had gone out onto the porch,
someone else saw him
and said to the people who were there,
"This man also was with Jesus of Nazareth."
72 Again he denied it
with an oath:
"I don't know the man!"
73 A little while later the people standing there came
and said to Peter,
"Surely you are also one of them,
for the way you speak gives you away."
74 Then he began to curse and to swear,
"I don't know the man!"
And at once the rooster crowed.
75 Then Peter remembered the word
that Jesus had said to him:
"Before the rooster crows,
you will deny me three times."
And he went out and wept bitterly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

While inside Jesus bravely tells the truth, outside Peter says three times: I don't know him.

Verse 71: The WEB says someone else. In the Greek text it is another servant girl.

Verse 73: Peter came from Galilee. The people there spoke with a different sound than the people in Jerusalem, just as there are accents today.

Verse 74: Peter begins "to curse and to swear." That means: He insists by every means that he has nothing to do with Jesus.

Verse 75: Peter weeps bitterly. He sees his failure.

For today: Peter, the rock (16:18), has fallen deeply. But the story goes on. Jesus did not give up on him (compare 26:32; 28:7; John 21:15–19). Even someone who has failed can make a new start. Whoever feels very bad because of their own guilt may talk with someone about it. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 27

Jesus is crucified

Jesus is handed over to Pilate VERSES 1–2

1 When morning had come,
all the chief priests and the elders of the people
made plans against Jesus
to have him put to death.
2 They tied him up,
led him away,
and handed him over to Pontius Pilate, the governor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Pontius Pilate was the Roman governor of Judea from about AD 26 to 36. He was the highest representative of the Roman emperor in the land. Only he could have a death sentence carried out (compare John 18:31).

Other sources from this time also tell about Pilate, for example the Jewish historian Josephus and the Roman historian Tacitus. They describe him as a harsh and cruel ruler.

The end of Judas VERSES 3–10

3 Judas, who had betrayed him, saw
that Jesus had been condemned.
Then he felt sorry for what he had done.
He brought the 30 pieces of silver
back to the chief priests and elders
4 and said,
"I have sinned.
I have betrayed innocent blood."
But they said,

"What is that to us?
That is your problem."
5 Then he threw the pieces of silver down in the sanctuary,
left,
and went away and hanged himself.
6 The chief priests took the pieces of silver and said,
"It is not lawful
to put them into the treasury,
because it is the price of blood."
7 They talked it over
and with the money bought the potter's field
as a place to bury strangers.
8 That is why that field has been called
"The Field of Blood" to this day.
9 Then what was spoken through Jeremiah the prophet was fulfilled:
"They took the 30 pieces of silver,
the price of the one on whom a price had been set,
whom some of the people of Israel priced,
10 and they gave them for the potter's field,
as the Lord commanded me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Judas regrets what he has done. He says honestly: "I have sinned." But the priests leave him alone. No one helps him.

Judas takes his own life. That is very sad. Matthew tells it without passing judgment.

Important: Whoever is thinking about suicide is not alone. There is help, even if you feel great guilt. Please reach out: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Christians believe: No guilt is so great that God cannot forgive it. Peter failed too, and he found a new beginning.

Whoever has lost someone to suicide should know: Today the churches no longer condemn people who have taken their own lives. They are usually given a Christian funeral today. God is merciful.

Verses 9–10: Matthew names the prophet Jeremiah. But the words about the 30 pieces of silver are mainly found in Zechariah (Zechariah 11:12–13). Jeremiah tells about a potter and about buying a field (Jeremiah 18:1–4; 19:1–2; 32:6–9). Matthew probably combines these passages and names the better-known prophet.

The book of Acts tells about the death of Judas somewhat differently (Acts 1:18–19).

Jesus before Pilate VERSES 11–26

11 Now Jesus stood before the governor.
The governor asked him,
"Are you the King of the Jews?"
Jesus said to him,
"So you say."
12 When the chief priests and elders accused him,
he answered nothing.
13 Then Pilate said to him,
"Don't you hear how many things they are saying against you?"
14 But he didn't answer him, not even one word,
so that the governor was greatly amazed.
15 At the feast the governor was used to
releasing to the crowd one prisoner
whom they wanted.
16 At that time they had a well-known prisoner
called Barabbas.
17 So when they had gathered,
Pilate said to them,
"Whom do you want me to release to you?
Barabbas, or Jesus
who is called Christ?"
18 For he knew
that they had handed him over out of envy.
19 While he was sitting on the judgment seat,
his wife sent him a message:
"Have nothing to do with that righteous man!
For today I have suffered many things in a dream
because of him."
20 But the chief priests and the elders
persuaded the crowds
to ask for Barabbas
and to have Jesus killed.
21 The governor asked them,
"Which of the two do you want me to release to you?"
They said,
"Barabbas!"
22 Pilate said to them,
"Then what shall I do with Jesus
who is called Christ?"
They all said,
"Let him be crucified!"
23 But the governor asked,
"Why? What evil has he done?"
But they shouted even louder,
"Let him be crucified!"
24 Pilate saw
that he was getting nowhere,
but that a riot was starting.
So he took water,
washed his hands in front of the crowd, and said,
"I am innocent of the blood of this righteous person.
That is your problem."
25 All the people answered,
"May his blood be on us and on our children!"
26 Then he released Barabbas to them.
But he had Jesus flogged
and handed him over to be crucified.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: For the Romans, "King of the Jews" was a political charge. Anyone who called himself king without the emperor's permission was considered a rebel.

Verses 16–17: Many old manuscripts give Barabbas his full name, Jesus Barabbas. "Barabbas" means "son of the father." The WEB has only "Barabbas."

Verse 19: Pilate's wife warns her husband. She calls Jesus a "righteous man."

Flogged: beaten hard with a whip.

Verse 20: The crowd is persuaded by some leaders.

Verse 24: Pilate washes his hands. From this comes the saying that someone washes their hands of something. But Pilate is not innocent. He had the power, and he gave the

sentence. The Christian creed says that Jesus suffered under Pontius Pilate.

A VERY IMPORTANT NOTE ON VERSE 25

This verse is one of the most terribly misused verses in the Bible. For almost 2,000 years Christians used it to insult Jews as God-killers, to persecute them, to drive them from their homes and to kill them. This hatred of Jews helped prepare the way for the Holocaust, the murder of 6 million Jews.

That is a terrible guilt of Christians.

That is why it must be said clearly:

What is meant is a crowd on one particular morning in Jerusalem that was persuaded by some leaders (verse 20). It was not "the Jewish people" of all times.

No one can declare their children or grandchildren guilty by shouting something. The Bible says: Each person is responsible for their own guilt (Ezekiel 18:20).

Jesus himself prayed for those who crucified him (Luke 23:34). Christians believe: Jesus' blood brings forgiveness (26:28), not a curse.

In 1965 the Catholic Church declared (*Nostra Aetate*): The Jews must not be presented as rejected or cursed by God. The Protestant churches in Germany and many other churches have also clearly confessed this.

Whoever uses this verse against Jews acts against the will of Jesus.

The soldiers mock Jesus VERSES 27–31

27 Then the governor's soldiers
took Jesus into the Praetorium
and gathered the whole company of soldiers around him.
28 They stripped him
and put a scarlet robe on him.
29 They twisted together a crown of thorns
and put it on his head.
They put a reed in his right hand.
They knelt down in front of him,
mocked him, and said,
"Hail, King of the Jews!"
30 They spat on him,
took the reed,
and hit him on the head with it.
31 When they had mocked him,
they took the robe off him
and put his own clothes back on him.
Then they led him away
to crucify him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "Praetorium" was the residence of the governor in Jerusalem.

Scarlet: bright red.

The Roman soldiers make fun of Jesus. They dress him up as a king: a red robe like a royal robe, a crown of thorns, a reed as a scepter.

Jesus is humiliated, beaten and mocked. He suffers violence and torture.

For today: Jesus stands by all people who are tortured, humiliated or abused. Whoever suffers violence is not abandoned by God.

The crucifixion VERSES 32–44

32 As they were going out,
they met a man from Cyrene
named Simon.
They forced him
to go with them
and carry Jesus' cross.
33 They came to a place
called Golgotha,
which means "The place of a skull."
34 There they gave him sour wine to drink mixed with gall.
When he had tasted it,
he would not drink it.
35 When they had crucified him,
they divided his clothes among them
by casting lots.
36 Then they sat down
and kept watch over him there.
37 Above his head they put up a sign
with the charge against him:
"THIS IS JESUS, THE KING OF THE JEWS."
38 Two robbers were crucified with him,
one on his right and one on his left.
39 The people who passed by
insulted him.
They shook their heads
40 and said,
"You who destroy the temple
and build it in three days,
save yourself!
If you are the Son of God,
come down from the cross!"
41 In the same way the chief priests also mocked him,
together with the scribes, the Pharisees, and the elders.
They said,
42 "He saved others,
but he can't save himself.
If he is the King of Israel,
let him come down from the cross now,
and we will believe in him.
43 He trusts in God.
Let God rescue him now,
if he wants him.
For he said,
'I am the Son of God.'"
44 The robbers who were crucified with him
insulted him in the same way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Cyrene was a city in North Africa, in today's Libya. Many Jews lived there. Simon had probably come to Jerusalem for the Passover.

Golgotha (Aramaic) means "skull." The Latin name is "Calvary." At that time the place was outside the city wall.

Crucifixion was the cruelest death penalty of the Romans. It was mainly meant for slaves and rebels. A person on a cross often died only after many hours.

Verse 34: Jesus is given "sour wine to drink mixed with gall." That is what the WEB says. Gall: a bitter liquid. Some manuscripts have wine instead of sour wine. This reminds

us of Psalm 69:21 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 69:22).

Casting lots: a way of deciding something by chance, a bit like rolling dice.

Verse 35: Dividing the clothes reminds us of Psalm 22:18 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 22:19). Older Bible editions still have a quotation from this psalm in the text here. It is missing in the best manuscripts and also in the WEB.

Verses 39–43: Jesus is mocked. This reminds us of Psalm 22:7–8 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 22:8–9).

Verse 41: Again it is certain leaders, not the whole people.

Jesus dies VERSES 45–56

45 From the sixth hour
there was darkness over all the land
until the ninth hour.
46 About the ninth hour
Jesus cried out with a loud voice,
"Eli, Eli, lima sabachthani?"
That means,
"My God, my God,
why have you forsaken me?"
47 Some of those who were standing there
heard it and said,
"This man is calling Elijah."
48 At once one of them ran,
took a sponge,
filled it with vinegar,
put it on a reed,
and gave him a drink.
49 But the others said,
"Leave him alone!
Let's see whether Elijah comes to save him."
50 Jesus cried out again with a loud voice
and gave up his spirit.
51 And the curtain of the temple
was torn in two from top to bottom.
The earth shook,
and the rocks split apart.
52 The tombs were opened,
and many bodies of the saints
who had died
were raised.
53 After his resurrection they came out
of the tombs,
went into the holy city,
and appeared to many people.
54 The centurion
and those who were with him guarding Jesus
saw the earthquake
and the things that happened.
They were terrified and said,
"Truly this was the Son of God!"
55 Many women were there,
watching from a distance.
They had followed Jesus from Galilee
and had served him.
56 Among them were Mary Magdalene,
Mary the mother of James and Joses,
and the mother of the sons of Zebedee.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The sixth hour is about 12 noon, the ninth hour about 3 in the afternoon. Three hours of darkness in broad daylight: All of creation mourns.

Verse 46: Jesus prays the first words of Psalm 22 in his native language, Aramaic (with Hebrew echoes). This psalm begins with a lament about being forsaken by God. But it ends with trust and praise of God.

Forsaken: left completely alone, abandoned.

Jesus really felt the deepest pain, including the feeling of being abandoned by God. That is why we, too, may lament to God like this. Whoever feels abandoned by God is not alone with this feeling. Jesus knows it.

Verse 47: "Eli" sounds similar to "Elijah." That is why some misunderstand him.

Verse 51: The curtain in the temple separated the Most Holy Place from the rest of the temple. Christians understand its tearing like this: Through Jesus' death the way to God is open for everyone.

Verses 52–53 are told only by Matthew. These verses are hard to understand. Some see a picture in them: Jesus' death and resurrection defeat death. This reminds us of Ezekiel 37:12–13.

Verse 54: A centurion is a Roman officer in charge of about 100 soldiers. Of all people, a Roman officer, a non-Jew, confesses: This was the Son of God.

Verses 55–56: The disciples have fled. But the women stay with Jesus to the very end. They are faithful disciples. Later they will be the first witnesses of the resurrection.

Jesus is buried VERSES 57–61

57 When evening had come,
a rich man from Arimathaea came.
His name was Joseph,
and he too was a disciple of Jesus.
58 He went to Pilate
and asked for Jesus' body.
Then Pilate ordered
that the body be given to him.
59 Joseph took the body
and wrapped it in a clean linen cloth.
60 He laid it in his own new tomb,
which he had cut out in the rock.
Then he rolled a large stone against the entrance of the tomb
and went away.
61 Mary Magdalene and the other Mary
were there,
sitting opposite the tomb.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Arimathaea was a town in Judea. Joseph was a Jewish man, rich and respected. According to Mark 15:43 he was a member of the Council. He shows: Not all the leaders were against Jesus.

According to Jewish law, someone who had been executed was to be buried on the same day (Deuteronomy 21:22–23). Joseph makes sure Jesus has a dignified burial.

A tomb cut in the rock was like a small cave. A large round stone was rolled in front of the entrance.

The women see where Jesus is buried. That is why on Easter morning they can go to the right tomb.

The guard at the tomb VERSES 62–66

62 On the next day,
the day after the Preparation Day,
the chief priests and the Pharisees gathered
before Pilate
63 and said,
"Sir, we remember
that this deceiver said
while he was still alive,
'After three days I will rise again.'
64 So give orders
that the tomb be made secure until the third day.
Otherwise his disciples may come at night,
steal him away,
and tell the people,
'He is risen from the dead.'
Then the last deception would be worse than the first."
65 Pilate said to them,
"You have a guard.
Go and make it as secure as you can."
66 So they went
and made the tomb secure by sealing the stone
and setting the guard.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "Preparation Day" was the day before the Sabbath, when everything was prepared for the Sabbath. So the day after it is the Sabbath.

The opponents want to prevent anyone from claiming that Jesus has risen. That is why they have the tomb sealed and guarded.

Only Matthew tells this story. It shows: No seal and no guard can stop God. The next chapter tells about the resurrection.

Verse 65: In the WEB Pilate says: "You have a guard." This can also be understood as an order: Take a guard! Then they would have been Roman soldiers.

MATTHEW

CHAPTER 28

Jesus has risen

The empty tomb VERSES 1–10

1 After the Sabbath,
as the first day of the week was dawning,
Mary Magdalene and the other Mary came
to see the tomb.
2 There was a great earthquake.
For an angel of the Lord came down from the sky,
came to the tomb,
rolled away the stone from the entrance,
and sat on it.
3 He looked like lightning,
and his clothes were white as snow.
4 The guards shook with fear of him
and became like dead men.
5 The angel said to the women,
"Don't be afraid!
I know that you are looking for Jesus,
who was crucified.
6 He is not here.
For he has risen,
just as he said.
Come and see the place
where the Lord was lying.
7 Go quickly
and tell his disciples,
'He has risen from the dead.
He is going ahead of you into Galilee.
There you will see him.'
Now I have told you."
8 They left the tomb quickly,
with fear and great joy,
and ran to tell his disciples.
9 As they were on their way
to tell his disciples,
Jesus met them and said,
"Rejoice!"
They came to him,
took hold of his feet,
and worshiped him.
10 Then Jesus said to them,
"Don't be afraid!
Go and tell my brothers
that they should go to Galilee.
There they will see me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Jewish way of counting, the "first day of the week" is Sunday. Because Jesus rose on this day, Christians celebrate Sunday as a special day. Easter is the most important feast of Christians.

The women are the first witnesses of the resurrection. In those days the testimony of women often counted for little in court. But God chooses them of all people. They are given the task of bringing the good news to the men. That is why some call Mary Magdalene the "apostle to the apostles."

The angel does not open the tomb so that Jesus can come out, but so that the women can see: The tomb is empty.

The guards who were supposed to guard Jesus "became like dead men." But the dead man is alive.

"Don't be afraid!" say the angel and Jesus. The resurrection is a message against fear.

Verse 8: "With fear and great joy": Both are there. Something too great to grasp can also be frightening.

Verse 10: Jesus calls the disciples "my brothers," even though they left him. He forgives them.

The Bible does not describe exactly how the resurrection happened. No one saw the moment itself. The Gospels tell of the empty tomb and of meetings with the risen Jesus. The four Gospels tell the events of Easter morning somewhat differently.

The guards' report VERSES 11–15

11 While the women were on their way,
some of the guards came into the city

and told the chief priests everything
that had happened.
12 The chief priests met with the elders
and made a plan.
Then they gave a large amount of silver to the soldiers
13 and said,
"Say,
'His disciples came at night
and stole him away
while we were sleeping.'
14 And if the governor hears about this,
we will persuade him
and make sure you don't get into trouble."
15 So they took the money
and did as they were told.
And this story spread among the Jews
and is still told today.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Matthew tells this story. It answers a rumor that existed in Matthew's time: that the disciples had stolen the body.

It is a small group of leaders who pay money for a lie. Just as Judas got money for the betrayal (26:15), now the soldiers get money for their silence.

Verse 15: "Among the Jews" here means people in Matthew's time who did not believe in Jesus. Matthew and the first Christians were mostly Jews themselves. The sentence is not a judgment on the Jewish people.

For today: The truth cannot be bought. Lies and bribes cannot stop what God does.

The great commission VERSES 16–20

16 But the 11 disciples went to Galilee,
to the mountain
where Jesus had told them to go.
17 When they saw him,
they bowed down to him.
But some doubted.
18 Jesus came to them and spoke to them.
He said,
"All authority has been given to me
in heaven and on earth.
19 So go
and make disciples of all nations.
Baptize them in the name of the Father
and of the Son
and of the Holy Spirit.
20 And teach them
to obey everything
that I have commanded you.
Look!
I am with you always,
even to the end of the age."
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Commission: an important task that someone is given.

There are only 11 disciples now, because Judas is dead.

Verse 17: "But some doubted": Even when the disciples see the risen Jesus, some doubt. Jesus sends them out anyway. Doubts are part of faith. Even someone who doubts belongs.

Verse 18: Jesus has received all authority from God. This reminds us of Daniel 7:14.

Verse 19: At the beginning the disciples were sent only to Israel (10:5–6). Now they are to go to all nations. The good news is for all people.

"In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit": These words are still spoken at every Christian baptism today. From them Christians later developed the teaching of the Trinity, the one God as Father, Son and Holy Spirit.

Important: "Make disciples" does not mean bringing people to faith by force or violence. In history Christians baptized people by force, including many Jews. That was a grave injustice and against the will of Jesus. Faith can only be freely given and freely accepted.

Verse 20: Jesus' last word is a promise: "I am with you always." At the beginning of the Gospel, Jesus was called "Immanuel," which means "God with us" (1:23). At the end he promises exactly that. So the circle closes.

"Amen" means "So it is" or "So be it." Some old manuscripts do not have this Amen at the end. The WEB has it.

Looking back: What have we read in the Gospel of Matthew?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus, the son of David and of Abraham: Matthew begins with the family tree (Chapter 1). He shows: Jesus belongs completely to the history of Israel. He is the promised Messiah. Again and again Matthew says that something happened so that what the prophets had said would be fulfilled.

God with us: Jesus is called "Immanuel," "God with us" (1:23). At the end he promises: "I am with you always" (28:20).

Five great speeches: Matthew collected Jesus' words in five great speeches: the Sermon on the Mount (Chapters 5–7), the sending speech (Chapter 10), the parables of the Kingdom of Heaven (Chapter 13), the speech about life in the community (Chapter 18) and the speech about the end times (Chapters 24–25).

The Sermon on the Mount: The Beatitudes, love for enemies, the Lord's Prayer and the Golden Rule: "Whatever you want people to do to you, you shall also do to them" (7:12).

The Kingdom of Heaven: In parables Jesus tells about God's Kingdom: like a mustard seed, like a treasure in a field, like a precious pearl (Chapter 13).

The greatest commandment: Loving God with all your heart and loving your neighbor as yourself (22:37–40).

Jesus with the little ones: He heals the sick, eats with tax collectors and sinners, blesses children and praises the faith of a foreign woman (15:28). At the final judgment he says: "Whatever you did for one of the least of these my brothers and sisters, you did for me" (25:40).

Suffering, death and resurrection: Jesus goes the way to Jerusalem. He is betrayed, condemned and crucified. But God raises him from the dead. The women are the first witnesses.

A serious note: In history some passages in the Gospel of Matthew were misused against Jews. Jesus, his mother, his disciples and Matthew himself were Jews. The conflict in the Gospel was a conflict within the Jewish people. God stays faithful to his people Israel.

For today: Matthew invites us to follow Jesus: by listening to his words and by doing them. "Not everyone who says to me, 'Lord, Lord,' will enter into the Kingdom of Heaven, but the one who does the will of my Father in heaven" (7:21).

What comes next? Next comes the Gospel of Mark. It is the shortest of the four Gospels and probably the oldest. Mark tells his story in a lively and fast way. We already know many of the stories from Matthew, but Mark often tells them with other details of his own.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 41 OF 66

MARK

16 CHAPTERS

MARK

Chapter 1

The beginning of the Good News

Before we begin: The Gospel of Mark

The Gospel of Mark is the shortest of the four Gospels. Most scholars think it is the oldest. It was probably written around AD 70, perhaps shortly before or shortly after the destruction of the temple in Jerusalem.

According to an old church tradition, it was written by John Mark. He was a companion of Peter and Paul (Acts 12:12; 1 Peter 5:13). Peter is said to have told him many things. We do not know this for certain. The book itself does not name an author.

Mark tells his story in a lively and fast way. One of his favorite words is "immediately." He reports fewer speeches than Matthew, but more of the things Jesus did. He often tells small details that the others leave out.

A big theme in Mark is the question: Who is Jesus? For a long time the disciples don't understand. Jesus often does not want people to call him the Christ yet. Only at the cross does a Roman centurion say that this man was truly the Son of God (15:39).

Many stories from Mark are also in Matthew and Luke, often with almost the same words. That is why scholars think: Matthew and Luke knew and used the Gospel of Mark.

Important note: In Mark, too, there are arguments between Jesus and other Jewish teachers. These were arguments within Judaism. Jesus and all his disciples were Jews. These texts must never be used to look down on Jews.

The Gospel has 16 chapters.

John the Baptizer VERSES 1–8

1 The beginning of the Good News of Jesus Christ, the
Son of God.
2 As it is written in the prophets,
"I send my messenger ahead of you.
He will prepare your way before you.
3 The voice of one crying in the wilderness:
'Make ready the way of the Lord!
Make his paths straight!'"
4 So John came.
He baptized in the wilderness
and preached a baptism of repentance
for the forgiveness of sins.
5 All the country of Judea
and all the people of Jerusalem went out to him.
They were baptized by him in the Jordan River
and confessed their sins.
6 John wore clothes made of camel's hair
and a leather belt around his waist.
He ate locusts and wild honey.
7 He preached,
"After me comes one who is mightier than I.
I am not worthy
to stoop down
and untie the strap of his sandals.
8 I baptized you in water.
But he will baptize you in the Holy Spirit."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mark begins without a birth story. He starts right away with Jesus as an adult. The first sentence is like a title over the whole book.

The words "the Son of God" in verse 1 are missing in some old manuscripts. The WEB has them.

Verses 2–3: The quotation combines Malachi 3:1 and Isaiah 40:3. Many old manuscripts say "Isaiah the prophet" instead of "the prophets." Here the WEB follows other manuscripts.

Repentance: turning around, changing your life and turning to God again. Baptism in the Jordan was a sign of this.

His clothing reminds us of the prophet Elijah (2 Kings 1:8). According to the Law of Moses, locusts were allowed as food (Leviticus 11:22). Locusts: large grasshoppers.

Verse 7: Taking off someone's sandals was the work of slaves. John says: I am not even worthy to serve the one who is coming in this way.

Jesus is baptized and tempted VERSES 9–13

9 In those days Jesus came from Nazareth in Galilee
and was baptized by John in the Jordan.
10 Immediately, as he came up out of the water,
he saw the heavens opening
and the Spirit coming down on him like a dove.
11 And a voice came out of the sky:
"You are my Son. I love you.
I am very pleased with you."
12 Immediately the Spirit drove him out into the
wilderness.
13 He was in the wilderness 40 days
and was tempted by Satan.
He was with the wild animals,
and the angels were serving him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nazareth was a small, unimportant village in Galilee, in the north of the country.

In Mark, Jesus himself sees the open heavens, and the voice speaks directly to him: "You are my Son. I love you." This reminds us of Psalm 2:7 and Isaiah 42:1.

The dove is a picture of the Holy Spirit, of God's power and peace.

Verses 12–13: Mark tells about the temptation very briefly (in more detail in Matthew 4:1–11). The 40 days remind us of Israel's 40 years in the wilderness and of Moses and Elijah.

"With the wild animals": Only Mark tells this. Some interpreters see it as a picture of peace with creation, as in paradise (compare Isaiah 11:6–9).

Jesus begins to preach and calls disciples VERSES 14–20

14 After John had been arrested,
Jesus came into Galilee.

He preached the Good News of God's Kingdom
15 and said,
"The time is fulfilled,
and God's Kingdom is near!
Repent, and believe in the Good News!"
16 As he was walking along the Sea of Galilee,
he saw Simon and Andrew, Simon's brother.
They were casting a net into the sea,
for they were fishermen.
17 Jesus said to them,
"Come, follow me!
I will make you into fishers for people."
18 Immediately they left their nets
and followed him.
19 When he had gone on a little farther,
he saw James the son of Zebedee
and his brother John.
They were also in the boat, mending the nets.
20 Immediately he called them.
They left their father Zebedee
in the boat with the hired workers
and followed him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15 sums up Jesus' whole message: God's Kingdom is near. God is now beginning to set up his good rule. So: Turn around and trust in it!

In Greek, "the Good News" is "euangelion." That is where the word "Gospel" comes from.

Jesus calls ordinary fishermen. They leave everything and follow him at once.

"Fishers for people": A play on words. From now on they are to win people for God's Kingdom.

Verse 20: Only Mark mentions the hired workers. So Zebedee is not left alone. His family apparently had a small fishing business.

Jesus in the synagogue of Capernaum VERSES 21–28

21 They went into Capernaum.
Immediately on the Sabbath he went into the
synagogue
and taught.
22 The people were amazed at his teaching.
For he taught them as one who has authority,
and not like the scribes.
23 Immediately there was a man in their synagogue
with an unclean spirit.
He cried out,
24 "Ha! What do we have to do with you,
Jesus, you Nazarene?
Have you come to destroy us?
I know who you are:
the Holy One of God!"
25 Jesus rebuked him and said,
"Be quiet, and come out of him!"
26 The unclean spirit shook the man violently,
cried out with a loud voice,
and came out of him.
27 They were all amazed.
They asked one another,
"What is this?
What is this new teaching?
With authority he commands even the unclean
spirits,
and they obey him!"
28 And immediately the news about him spread
through the whole region of Galilee and the area
around it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Capernaum was a town on the north shore of the Sea of Galilee. Jesus lived there for a while. Today you can see the remains of a later synagogue there. It may stand on the foundations of the synagogue from Jesus' time.

On the Sabbath people met in the synagogue to pray and to hear the Holy Scriptures. Like every devout Jew, Jesus goes there and teaches.

Verse 22: Jesus does not only teach what other teachers have said. He speaks with his own, divine authority. This is not a judgment on all scribes.

"Unclean spirit": In those days people explained some illnesses or suffering of the soul this way. Important: Mental illnesses are not a sin and not a punishment. Whoever is mentally ill needs understanding and help, for example from doctors and therapists.

Verses 24–25: The spirit recognizes Jesus. But Jesus orders it to be silent. In Mark, Jesus often does not want people to say too early who he is.

Jesus heals many people VERSES 29–39

29 Immediately, when they had come out of the
synagogue,
they went into the house of Simon and Andrew,
together with James and John.
30 Simon's mother-in-law was lying in bed with a fever.
Immediately they told Jesus about her.
31 He went to her,
took her by the hand,
and raised her up.
The fever left her immediately,
and she served them.
32 In the evening, when the sun had set,
they brought to him all who were sick
and those who were possessed by demons.
33 The whole town was gathered at the door.
34 He healed many who were sick with various diseases
and cast out many demons.
He didn't allow the demons to speak,
because they knew him.
35 Early in the morning, while it was still dark,
he got up and went out
to a deserted place.
There he prayed.
36 Simon and those who were with him
searched for him.
37 They found him and said to him,
"Everyone is looking for you!"
38 He said to them,
"Let's go somewhere else,
into the next towns,
so that I may preach there too.
For this is why I came."
39 And he went into their synagogues throughout all
Galilee,

preaching and casting out demons.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 30: Simon (Peter) was married. His mother-in-law lived in the house with them.

Verse 31: Jesus takes the sick woman by the hand. He touches her without hesitating. After that, "she served them." The Greek word for serving is the same word that is used for the service of the angels (verse 13) and for Jesus' own service (10:45). So she becomes one of the first to serve Jesus.

Verse 32: The Sabbath ends at sunset. That is why people only bring their sick in the evening. On the Sabbath they did not want to carry loads.

Verse 35: Jesus needs time alone with God. In spite of all the work, he takes time to pray.

Verse 38: Jesus does not let himself be held back, even though everyone wants him. He knows what he came for.

Important: If sick people do not get well today, it is not their fault. Illness is not a sign of too little faith.

Jesus heals a leper VERSES 40–45

40 A leper came to him.
He knelt down in front of him,
begged him, and said,
"If you want to,
you can make me clean."
41 Being moved with compassion,
he stretched out his hand,
touched him,
and said to him,
"I want to. Be made clean."
42 When he had said this,
the leprosy left him immediately,
and he was made clean.
43 Jesus strictly warned him
and sent him away at once.
44 He said to him,
"See that you say nothing to anybody.
But go,
show yourself to the priest,
and offer for your cleansing the things
that Moses commanded.
That will be a testimony to them."
45 But the man went out
and began to tell it everywhere
and to spread the news.
So Jesus could no longer openly go into a town.
He stayed outside in deserted places.
And people came to him from everywhere.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In those days "leprosy" was a name for various skin diseases. Whoever had it was considered unclean. They had to live apart from other people (Leviticus 13:45–46). That meant great loneliness.

Jesus touches the sick man. No one else did that. He not only gives him back his health, but also his place in the community.

Verse 41: Instead of "moved with compassion," some old manuscripts say that Jesus became angry. Perhaps Jesus was angry about the illness and the suffering. The WEB has compassion.

Verse 44: Jesus sends the man to the priest, as the Law of Moses requires (Leviticus 14). Jesus respects the law. The priest was to confirm that the man was healthy. Then he could return to the community.

For today: People are still excluded today because of illnesses. Jesus shows: No one should be left alone.

MARK

CHAPTER 2

New wine into fresh wineskins

Four friends and a paralyzed man VERSES 1–12

1 After some days Jesus came back to Capernaum.
People heard that he was at home.
2 Immediately many people gathered,
so that there was no more room,
not even around the door.
And he spoke the word to them.
3 Then four people came,
carrying a paralyzed man to him.
4 Because of the crowd
they could not get near him.
So they removed the roof
right above the place where he was.
They broke an opening through it
and let down the mat
that the paralyzed man was lying on.
5 When Jesus saw their faith,
he said to the paralyzed man,
"Son, your sins are forgiven you."
6 But some of the scribes were sitting there.
They were thinking in their hearts,
7 "Why does this man speak like that?
He is speaking blasphemy!
Who can forgive sins but God alone?"
8 Immediately Jesus knew in his spirit
what they were thinking.
He said to them,
"Why are you thinking these things in your hearts?
9 Which is easier:
to say to the paralyzed man,
'Your sins are forgiven,'
or to say,
'Get up, take up your mat, and walk'?
10 But I want you to know
that the Son of Man has authority
on earth to forgive sins."
And he said to the paralyzed man,
11 "I tell you,
get up, take up your mat,
and go to your house!"

12 He got up,
immediately took up the mat,
and went out in front of them all.
They were all amazed,
praised God, and said,
"We have never seen anything like this!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In those days houses had flat roofs made of wooden beams, branches and clay. You could climb up by a staircase on the outside of the house.

The four friends don't give up. They find a way, even if it is unusual. Jesus sees "their faith," the faith of the friends. The trust of other people can help someone too.

Paralyzed: unable to move parts of the body, for example the legs.

Verse 5: Jesus speaks first about forgiveness. That does not mean the paralysis was a punishment for sins. Illness and disability are not a punishment from God (compare John 9:1–3). Jesus shows: God wants to make the whole person well, body and soul.

Verse 7: The scribes are right that only God can forgive sins. That is why what Jesus does is so amazing. He acts in God's place.

Blasphemy: speaking against God or insulting God.

"Son of Man": Jesus often calls himself this. The term reminds us of Daniel 7:13–14.

Jesus calls Levi and eats with tax collectors VERSES 13–17

13 Jesus went out again by the seaside.
The whole crowd came to him,
and he taught them.
14 As he was passing by,
he saw Levi the son of Alphaeus
sitting at the tax office.
He said to him,
"Follow me!"
And he got up and followed him.
15 Jesus was reclining at the table in Levi's house.
Many tax collectors and sinners
sat down with Jesus and his disciples.
For there were many of them,
and they followed him.
16 When the scribes and the Pharisees saw
that he was eating with the sinners and tax collectors,
they said to his disciples,
"Why does he eat and drink with tax collectors and sinners?"
17 When Jesus heard it,
he said to them,
"Those who are healthy don't need a doctor,
but those who are sick do.
I didn't come to call the righteous,
but sinners to repentance."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Levi is a tax collector. In the Gospel of Matthew he is called Matthew (Matthew 9:9).

Tax collectors collected customs and taxes for the rulers. Many demanded more than they were allowed. That is why they were unpopular.

In those days eating together meant: We belong together. Jesus eats with people whom others avoid. He shows: God shuts no one out.

Verse 16: The WEB says "the scribes and the Pharisees." Many old manuscripts say the scribes of the Pharisees, meaning scribes who belonged to the Pharisees. The Pharisees wanted to keep God's commandments very carefully in everyday life, including when eating. Their question is meant seriously, not simply in a mean way.

Verse 17: The words "to repentance" are missing in many old manuscripts. They are in Luke 5:32. The WEB has them.

For today: The church should be a place for everyone, especially for those who feel shut out.

The question about fasting VERSES 18–22

18 John's disciples and the Pharisees were fasting.
People came and asked Jesus,
"Why do John's disciples
and the disciples of the Pharisees fast,
but your disciples don't fast?"
19 Jesus said to them,
"Can the groomsmen fast
while the bridegroom is with them?
As long as they have the bridegroom with them,
they can't fast.
20 But the days will come
when the bridegroom will be taken away from them.
Then, in that day, they will fast.
21 No one sews a piece of new, unshrunk cloth
on an old garment.
Otherwise the new patch shrinks,
tears away from the old cloth,
and the hole becomes worse.
22 And no one puts new wine into old wineskins.
Otherwise the wine will burst the skins.
The wine pours out,
and the skins are ruined.
Instead, new wine is put into fresh wineskins."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Fasting means: going without food for a time, in order to turn completely toward God. Devout Jews often fasted on certain days.

Jesus compares his time to a wedding. At a wedding people celebrate and don't fast. Jesus is the "bridegroom." As long as he is there, there is joy.

Groomsmen: the friends of the bridegroom at a wedding.

Verse 20: Jesus hints at his death. Then there will be times of fasting again. Many Christians still fast today, for example in the time before Easter.

Verses 21–22: Wineskins were made of animal skin. New wine is still fermenting and expands. Old skins are brittle and burst. Jesus' message is so new and alive that it needs new forms.

Important: This is not a judgment that Judaism is old and broken. Jesus himself lived as a Jew. It is about being open to the new things God is doing.

Grain on the Sabbath VERSES 23–28

23 On a Sabbath day Jesus was going through the grain fields.
As they went along, his disciples began
to pick the heads of grain.
24 The Pharisees said to him,
"Look!

Why are they doing what is not lawful on the
Sabbath?"
25 He said to them,
"Did you never read what David did
when he was in need and hungry,
he and those who were with him?
26 How he went into God's house
at the time of Abiathar the high priest,
and ate the show bread,
which only the priests are allowed to eat,
and also gave some to those who were with him?"
27 He said to them,
"The Sabbath was made for man,
not man for the Sabbath.
28 So the Son of Man is lord
even of the Sabbath."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Sabbath is the holy day of rest (Exodus 20:8–11). It was allowed to pick heads of grain at the edge of someone else's field (Deuteronomy 23:25; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 23:26). But some teachers saw picking grain on the Sabbath as harvest work. People had different opinions about this.

Verses 25–26: The story of David is in 1 Samuel 21:1–6 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 21:2–7). There, however, the priest is called Ahimelech. Abiathar was his son and later became high priest. There are different explanations for this difference. Perhaps "at the time of Abiathar" simply means the time when Abiathar lived.

Show bread: 12 holy loaves of bread that were laid out before God in the house of God.

Verse 27 is told only by Mark. A similar sentence is also found in an old Jewish explanation of the Scriptures. It says, in effect: The Sabbath is there for you, not you for the Sabbath. So Jesus says something that other Jewish teachers also believed.

The Sabbath is God's gift to people, so that they can rest and breathe again. It should not be a burden that harms people.

For today: People still need days of rest today. Sunday or another day off protects us from doing nothing but work.

MARK

CHAPTER 3

The Twelve and the new family

Healing on the Sabbath VERSES 1–6

1 Jesus went into the synagogue again.
There was a man there
whose hand was withered.
2 They watched Jesus closely
to see whether he would heal him on the Sabbath.
For they wanted to accuse him.
3 He said to the man with the withered hand,
"Stand up."
4 And he said to them,
"Is it lawful on the Sabbath
to do good or to do harm?
To save a life or to kill?"
But they were silent.
5 Then he looked around at them with anger.
He was grieved
that their hearts were so hard.
And he said to the man,
"Stretch out your hand."
He stretched it out,
and his hand was made as healthy as the other.
6 The Pharisees went out
and immediately made plans with the Herodians
about how they could destroy him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Withered: shriveled and unable to move, for example because of an illness.

Verse 3: The WEB says only "Stand up." The Greek word probably also means: Come into the middle! Jesus puts the man in the middle in front of everyone.

Jesus asks: What is right on the Sabbath, to do good or to do harm? Jewish teachers also said: To save a life you may break the Sabbath. But was this man's life in danger? People could argue about that. Jesus says: Doing good is always right.

Verse 5: Only Mark tells us that Jesus was angry and sad. Jesus had real feelings.

Verse 6: The Herodians were supporters of King Herod. The Pharisees and the Herodians were actually opponents. Here they join together against Jesus. So early in the Gospel it is already clear that Jesus' way leads to suffering.

Important: Not all Pharisees were against Jesus. Some later even became Christians (Acts 15:5). And people with disabilities are not worth less. Jesus puts the man in the middle.

Many people come to Jesus VERSES 7–12

7 Jesus withdrew to the sea with his disciples.
A great crowd from Galilee followed him.
From Judea too,
8 from Jerusalem, from Idumaea,
from beyond the Jordan,
and from the area around Tyre and Sidon,
a great crowd came to him.
They had heard about all the great things he was doing.
9 He told his disciples
to keep a little boat ready for him,
so that the crowd would not crush him.
10 For he had healed many.
So all who had diseases pushed toward him
to touch him.
11 And whenever the unclean spirits saw him,
they fell down in front of him and cried,
"You are the Son of God!"
12 He sternly warned them
not to make him known.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The people come from everywhere: from the south (Judea, Idumaea), from the east (beyond the Jordan) and from the north (Tyre and Sidon, in today's Lebanon). Non-Jews are among them too.

Verses 11–12: Again Jesus does not want the spirits to say who he is. In Mark this is called the "Messianic secret." Jesus does not want to be celebrated as a miracle worker or a political hero. Who he really is becomes clear only at the cross and at the resurrection.

Jesus chooses the 12 apostles VERSES 13–19

13 Jesus went up onto the mountain.
He called to himself those whom he wanted,
and they came to him.
14 He appointed 12.
They were to be with him,
and he would send them out to preach
15 and to have authority to heal sicknesses
and to cast out demons.
16 They were:
Simon, to whom he gave the name Peter;
17 James the son of Zebedee,
and John, the brother of James,
whom he called Boanerges,
which means "Sons of Thunder";
18 Andrew, Philip, Bartholomew, Matthew, Thomas,
James the son of Alphaeus,
Thaddaeus, Simon the Zealot,
19 and Judas Iscariot,
who later betrayed him.
Then he went into a house.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

There are 12 apostles, like the 12 tribes of Israel. Jesus gathers a renewed people of God.

Verse 14: The first thing is: "to be with him." Only after that come preaching and healing.

"Peter" means "rock." "Sons of Thunder": Perhaps James and John had a fiery temper (compare Luke 9:54).

"Simon the Zealot": The Zealots were zealous Jews, some of whom wanted to fight against the Romans. Matthew, on the other hand, was a tax collector who worked with the Romans. Jesus calls both. In his community very different people come together.

In verse 14 some old manuscripts also say that he called them apostles. The WEB does not have this.

Is Jesus out of his mind or in league with evil? VERSES 20–30

20 Again a crowd gathered,
so that they could not even eat.
21 When his friends heard about it,
they went out to take hold of him by force.
For they said,
"He is insane."
22 The scribes who had come down from Jerusalem
said,
"He has Beelzebul,"
and,
"By the prince of the demons
he casts out the demons."
23 So he called them to himself
and spoke to them in parables:
"How can Satan cast out Satan?
24 If a kingdom is divided against itself,
that kingdom cannot stand.
25 If a house is divided against itself,
that house cannot stand.
26 So if Satan has risen up against himself
and is divided,
he can't stand,
but his end has come.
27 No one can go into the house of the strong man
and steal his things
unless he first ties up the strong man.
Only then can he rob his house.
28 Most certainly I tell you,
people will be forgiven all their sins,
including all the blasphemies they speak.
29 But whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit
never has forgiveness,
but is subject to eternal condemnation."
30 He said this because they were saying,
"He has an unclean spirit."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21: The WEB says "his friends." The Greek word means "his own people," probably his family (compare verse 31). They are worried and think he is confused. Even his own family does not understand Jesus.

Important: "Insane" was an accusation. Mental illnesses are nothing to be ashamed of. People with mental illnesses deserve respect and help.

"Beelzebul" is a name for the prince of the demons, Satan.

Verses 23–27: Jesus shows how senseless the accusation is. Satan would not fight against himself! Jesus is the stronger one who defeats the "strong man" (Satan).

Verses 28–29: God's forgiveness is huge: All sins can be forgiven. "Whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit…": Here this means deliberately calling God's good work devilish, and so closing yourself off completely against God.

Condemnation: being judged guilty and punished.

Very important: Many people are afraid that they have committed this unforgivable sin. Interpreters say: Whoever worries about it and seeks God has precisely not committed it. Whoever cannot get rid of such tormenting thoughts may talk about them with a pastor or counselor. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Jesus' true family VERSES 31–35

31 Then his mother and his brothers came.
They stood outside,
sent someone to him,
and called for him.
32 Many people were sitting around him.
They said to him,
"Your mother, your brothers, and your sisters
are outside looking for you."
33 He answered them,
"Who are my mother
and my brothers?"
34 He looked around at the people
who were sitting around him

and said,
"Here are my mother and my brothers!
35 For whoever does the will of God
is my brother, my sister, and mother."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus does not reject his family. He shows: There is a new, large family of God. All who do God's will belong to it, men and women.

Verse 32: The words "and your sisters" are missing in some old manuscripts. The WEB has them.

About the "brothers" of Jesus: Protestant Christians usually understand them as his brothers and sisters by birth, Catholic and Orthodox Christians as close relatives.

Later Jesus' family belonged to the first church: Mary and Jesus' brothers were with the disciples in Jerusalem (Acts 1:14). His brother James became a leader of the church.

For today: Whoever has no family or has been hurt by their own family can find a home in the community of believers.

MARK

CHAPTER 4

Parables and a storm on the lake

The parable of the farmer who sows VERSES 1–9

1 Again Jesus began to teach by the seaside.
A very large crowd gathered around him.
So he got into a boat on the sea
and sat down.
The whole crowd was on the shore, on the land.
2 He taught them many things in parables.
In his teaching he said to them,
3 "Listen!
A farmer went out to sow.
4 As he was sowing,
some seed fell by the road.
The birds came and ate it up.
5 Other seed fell on rocky ground,
where there was little soil.
It sprang up immediately,
because the soil was not deep.
6 When the sun came up,
it was scorched.
And because it had no root,
it withered away.
7 Other seed fell among the thorns.
The thorns grew up and choked it,
and it produced no fruit.
8 Other seed fell on good ground.
It came up, grew, and produced fruit:
some 30 times as much,
some 60 times,
and some 100 times as much."
9 And he said,
"Whoever has ears to hear, let him hear!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This parable is also in Matthew 13:1–9. Mark tells it in a similar way.

In those days people sowed by throwing the seeds across the field by hand. Some seed was lost. But in the end there is still a great harvest.

In Mark the harvest grows: 30, 60, 100. God's word produces more and more fruit.

Jesus himself explains the parable in verses 14–20.

Why Jesus speaks in parables VERSES 10–12

10 When he was alone,
those who were around him,
together with the Twelve,
asked him about the parables.
11 He said to them,
"To you is given the mystery of God's Kingdom.
But to those who are outside, everything comes in parables,
12 so that
'seeing they may see and not perceive,
and hearing they may hear and not understand,
so that they won't turn back
and have their sins forgiven.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12 quotes Isaiah 6:9–10. This sentence sounds very harsh, as if Jesus did not want people to understand and turn back.

Interpreters understand it like this: Jesus describes what actually happens. Many hear his words but close themselves off. It was already like this with the prophet Isaiah. Parables open up only to those who get involved with them.

Mystery: here, a secret of God that he reveals.

Important: The whole Gospel shows that Jesus invites all people to repent (1:15). God wants to forgive. This verse is not a judgment on "the Jews." It is about everyone who does not want to listen, Christians too.

"Those who are outside" are not outside forever. Whoever comes to Jesus and asks becomes one of "those who were around him."

Jesus explains the parable VERSES 13–20

13 He said to them,
"Don't you understand this parable?
Then how will you understand all the parables?
14 The farmer sows the word.
15 The ones by the road
are those where the word is sown.
When they have heard it,
immediately Satan comes
and takes away the word
that was sown in them.
16 In the same way, the ones sown on rocky ground
are those who hear the word

and immediately receive it with joy.
17 But they have no root in themselves.
They last only a short time.
When trouble or persecution comes
because of the word,
they immediately fall away.
18 Others are the ones sown among the thorns.
These are those who have heard the word.
19 But the worries of this age,
the deceitfulness of riches,
and the desire for other things
come in and choke the word.
And it produces no fruit.
20 The ones sown on the good ground
are those who hear the word,
accept it,
and bear fruit:
some 30 times as much,
some 60 times,
and some 100 times."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The seed is God's word. The different kinds of ground are different ways in which people respond to it.

Verse 13: In Mark the disciples often don't understand. Even so, Jesus is patient with them.

The parable asks each of us: How do I listen? What is stopping good things from growing in me?

Important: Worries are part of life. Whoever has many worries is not a bad person. It is about not letting worries and greed choke everything else.

Light and measure VERSES 21–25

21 He said to them,
"Is a lamp brought in
to be put under a basket
or under a bed?
Isn't it put on a stand?
22 For nothing is hidden
except to be made known.
And nothing is secret
except to come to light.
23 If anyone has ears to hear,
let him hear!"
24 He said to them,
"Pay attention to what you hear!
With whatever measure you measure,
it will be measured to you.
And more will be given to you who hear.
25 For whoever has,
more will be given to him.
And whoever doesn't have,
even what he has will be taken away from him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In those days a lamp was a small oil lamp made of clay. People put it up high so that it lit the whole room.

God's Kingdom is still hidden now. But it will come to light. What Jesus teaches now in a small way will later reach everyone.

Verses 24–25: Whoever is open to God's word understands more and more. Whoever closes themselves off loses even the little they have. This is not a rule about money or possessions.

The seed that grows by itself VERSES 26–29

26 He said,
"God's Kingdom is like this:
A man scatters seed on the ground.
27 He sleeps and gets up,
night and day.
And the seed sprouts and grows,
though he doesn't know how.
28 The earth produces fruit by itself:
first the stalk,
then the head of grain,
then the full grain in the head.
29 But when the fruit is ripe,
immediately he puts in the sickle,
because the harvest has come."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Mark tells this parable.

The man sows. Then all he can do is wait. The growing happens by itself, without his being able to make it happen or fully understand it.

That is how it is with God's Kingdom: God makes it grow. We don't have to do everything ourselves.

For today: A comforting parable for everyone who worries about others or works a lot. You may also sleep. God keeps on working.

Sickle: a curved knife for cutting grain.

Verse 29 reminds us of Joel 3:13 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 4:13): The harvest is a picture of the end of time.

The mustard seed VERSES 30–34

30 He said,
"What shall we compare God's Kingdom to?
With what parable shall we describe it?
31 It is like a mustard seed.
When it is sown in the ground,
it is smaller than all the seeds on the earth.
32 But when it is sown,
it grows up
and becomes bigger than all the garden plants.
It puts out large branches,
so that the birds of the sky
can live in its shade."
33 With many parables like these
he spoke the word to them,
as they were able to hear it.
34 He didn't speak to them without a parable.
But when he was alone with his own disciples,
he explained everything to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The mustard seed was proverbially the smallest seed people knew in everyday life. It grows into a large bush, often over 10 feet high (compare Matthew 13:31–32).

God's Kingdom begins very small, with Jesus and a few disciples. But it becomes large, and many find shelter in it, like the birds in the shade.

Verse 33: Jesus speaks to them "as they were able to hear it." He thinks of his listeners. That is also the idea behind plain

language: God's word should be understandable for everyone.

Jesus calms the storm VERSES 35–41

35 On that day, when evening had come,
he said to them,
"Let's go over to the other side."
36 They left the crowd
and took him with them in the boat,
even as he was.
Other small boats were also with him.
37 A big windstorm came up.
The waves beat into the boat,
so that it was already filling with water.
38 He himself was in the back of the boat,
asleep on the cushion.
They woke him up and said to him,
"Teacher, don't you care
that we are dying?"
39 He woke up,
rebuked the wind,
and said to the sea,
"Peace! Be still!"
Then the wind stopped,
and there was a great calm.
40 He said to them,
"Why are you so afraid?
How is it that you have no faith?"
41 They were very afraid
and said to one another,
"Who then is this,
that even the wind and the sea obey him?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

On the Sea of Galilee strong storms can come up suddenly, because wind comes rushing down from the mountains.

Only Mark tells small details: the cushion, the other boats, Jesus "even as he was."

Jesus sleeps peacefully in the storm. He trusts God completely.

Verse 38: The disciples ask: "Teacher, don't you care?" Many people in need ask God this question too. You may ask it.

Verse 39: Jesus speaks to the storm as if to a living being. In the Old Testament it is God who calms the raging sea (Psalm 107:28–30).

Verse 40: Many old manuscripts have a slightly different question here. Then Jesus asks whether they still have no faith. The WEB has: "How is it that you have no faith?"

Verse 41: The disciples ask: Who is this? That is the big question in the Gospel of Mark.

For today: Whoever is in one of life's storms may call out to Jesus. Being afraid is not a sign of bad faith. And you may also get help from other people.

MARK

CHAPTER 5

Jesus brings healing and life

The man from the tombs VERSES 1–20

1 They came to the other side of the sea,
into the country of the Gadarenes.
2 When Jesus got out of the boat,
immediately a man came out of the tombs to meet him.
He had an unclean spirit.
3 He lived in the tombs.
Nobody could tie him up any more,
not even with chains.
4 For he had often been tied up with shackles and chains.
But he had torn the chains apart
and broken the shackles in pieces.
Nobody was strong enough to tame him.
5 Always, night and day,
he was crying out in the tombs and in the mountains
and cutting himself with stones.
6 When he saw Jesus from far away,
he ran
and bowed down in front of him.
7 He cried out with a loud voice,
"What have I to do with you,
Jesus, you Son of the Most High God?
I beg you by God,
don't torment me!"
8 For Jesus had said to him,
"Come out of the man, you unclean spirit!"
9 Jesus asked him,
"What is your name?"
He said to him,
"My name is Legion,
for we are many."
10 And he begged Jesus very much
not to send them away out of the country.
11 On the mountainside a large herd of pigs was feeding.
12 All the demons begged him,
"Send us into the pigs,
so that we may go into them!"
13 At once Jesus gave them permission.
The unclean spirits came out
and went into the pigs.
The herd, about 2,000 animals,
rushed down the steep bank into the sea
and drowned in the sea.
14 Those who took care of the pigs fled
and told it in the town and in the country.
The people came
to see what had happened.
15 They came to Jesus
and saw the man who had been possessed by demons,
the one who had had the legion.
He was sitting there, clothed,
and in his right mind.
And they were afraid.

16 Those who had seen it
told them
what had happened to the man possessed by demons,
and about the pigs.
17 Then they began to beg Jesus
to leave their region.
18 As Jesus was getting into the boat,
the man who had been possessed by demons begged
him
that he might be with him.
19 But Jesus didn't allow it.
Instead he said to him,
"Go to your house, to your friends,
and tell them
what great things the Lord has done for you
and how he had mercy on you."
20 So he went away
and began to proclaim in Decapolis
what great things Jesus had done for him.
And everyone was amazed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus is now on the east shore of the Sea of Galilee, in an area where mostly non-Jews lived. That is why there are pigs there. For Jews pigs were considered unclean (Leviticus 11:7).

Verse 1: The manuscripts name the place differently: Gerasenes, Gadarenes or Gergesenes. The WEB has "Gadarenes." Some Bibles have Gerasenes.

The man is in a terrible situation: He lives alone among the graves, is chained up, cries out day and night and hurts himself. People in those days saw this as the work of demons.

Today we would probably think of a severe mental illness. Important: People with mental illnesses are not possessed by demons. They need help from doctors and therapists, and they need people who don't shut them out.

Whoever hurts themselves or thinks about it is not alone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. Children and young people: In the US, call or text Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. In the UK, call Childline at 0800 1111. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

"Legion" was a Roman troop of about 5,000 to 6,000 soldiers. Some interpreters also see in it a hint at the Roman occupation, which tormented the land.

At the end the man sits there calmly, "clothed, and in his right mind." Jesus has given him back his life and his dignity.

The people are afraid and ask Jesus to leave. Perhaps because of the loss of the pigs, perhaps out of fear of such great power.

Verses 19–20: Jesus sends the man back to his own people. He becomes Jesus' first messenger among non-Jews. Decapolis means "Ten Cities." They were cities with Greek culture east of the Jordan.

A father asks for help VERSES 21–24

21 Jesus crossed back over in the boat to the other side.
A large crowd gathered around him,
and he was by the sea.
22 Then one of the rulers of the synagogue came,
named Jairus.
When he saw Jesus,
he fell at his feet
23 and begged him very much,
"My little daughter is dying.
Please come and lay your hands on her,
so that she may be made healthy and live!"
24 Jesus went with him.
A large crowd followed him
and pressed against him from all sides.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A ruler of the synagogue was a respected man. He took care of the worship services in the synagogue.

Jairus is a Jewish leader who trusts Jesus and asks for help. Not all leaders were against Jesus.

A father in great worry about his child: He throws all his dignity aside and falls at Jesus' feet.

The woman who touches his clothes VERSES 25–34

25 There was a woman
who had suffered from bleeding for 12 years.
26 She had suffered many things from many doctors
and had spent everything she had.
But she was no better.
Instead she had grown worse.
27 She had heard about Jesus.
She came up behind him in the crowd
and touched his clothes.
28 For she said,
"If I just touch his clothes,
I will be made well."
29 Immediately the bleeding stopped,
and she felt in her body
that she was healed of her illness.
30 Immediately Jesus noticed
that power had gone out from him.
He turned around in the crowd
and asked,
"Who touched my clothes?"
31 His disciples said to him,
"You see the crowd pressing against you,
and you ask, 'Who touched me?'"
32 He looked around
to see the woman who had done this.
33 But the woman was afraid and trembling.
She knew what had happened to her.
She came, fell down in front of him,
and told him the whole truth.
34 He said to her,
"Daughter, your faith has made you well.
Go in peace,
and be healed of your disease."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The woman had suffered from bleeding for 12 years. According to the Law of Moses a woman with bleeding was considered unclean (Leviticus 15:25–27). She was not allowed to take part in worship, and whoever touched her also became unclean. So she was not only sick, but also shut out and had become poor.

Important: Monthly bleeding and women's illnesses are nothing to be ashamed of. They are not a sign of sin.

Verse 26: In those days the doctors could not help her. That is no reason not to go to the doctor today. Doctors and medicine are a gift.

She does not dare to come to Jesus openly. Secretly she touches his clothes.

Jesus does not want her to slip away secretly. In front of everyone he calls her "Daughter." He takes her into the community and speaks peace to her. Not only her body is healed, but also her dignity.

"Your faith has made you well": The Greek word means both "saved" and "healed."

Important: Whoever does not get well is not to blame for it. Illness is not a sign of too little faith.

Jesus raises the daughter of Jairus VERSES 35–43

35 While he was still speaking,
people came from the house of the synagogue ruler
and said,
"Your daughter is dead.
Why bother the Teacher any more?"
36 When Jesus heard what was said,
he immediately said to the ruler of the synagogue,
"Don't be afraid,
only believe."
37 He allowed no one to go with him
except Peter, James,
and John the brother of James.
38 They came to the house of the synagogue ruler.
He saw the uproar,
the weeping and loud wailing.
39 He went in and said to them,
"Why are you making an uproar and weeping?
The child is not dead,
but is asleep."
40 They laughed at him.
But he put them all out.
He took the father and the mother of the child
and those who were with him
and went in where the child was lying.
41 He took the child by the hand
and said to her,
"Talitha cumi!"
That means,
"Girl, I tell you, get up!"
42 Immediately the girl got up
and walked around.
For she was 12 years old.
And they were completely amazed.
43 He strictly ordered them
that no one should know about this.
And he told them
to give her something to eat.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mark weaves two stories into each other: While Jesus is helping the woman, the girl dies. Both stories have the number 12: The woman was sick for 12 years, the girl is 12 years old.

Verse 36: "Don't be afraid, only believe." Jesus gives courage to the desperate father when everything seems lost.

Verse 38: When someone died, there was loud mourning. Often paid mourning women and flute players came too.

Verse 39: "Is asleep": For Jesus death is not the end. He can wake people from death as from sleep.

Verse 41: "Talitha cumi" is Aramaic, Jesus' native language. Here Mark keeps Jesus' own words.

Verse 43: Jesus thinks of something very practical: The girl needs something to eat. He cares for the whole person.

For today: For parents who have lost a child, this story may be hard to read. Christians hope that God also holds their children who have died in his hand. Whoever is grieving for a child can find support, for example, from The Compassionate Friends (compassionatefriends.org in the US, tcf.org.uk in the UK). In the US you can also call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123.

MARK

CHAPTER 6

Sent out, fed, and not alone in the storm

Jesus in his hometown VERSES 1–6

1 Jesus went away from there
and came into his hometown.
His disciples followed him.
2 When the Sabbath came,
he began to teach in the synagogue.
Many who heard him were amazed and said,
"Where did this man get these things?"
and,
"What is this wisdom that has been given to him?
And such mighty works happen by his hands!
3 Isn't this the carpenter,
the son of Mary,
the brother of James, Joses, Judah, and Simon?
Aren't his sisters here with us?"
And they were offended at him.
4 Jesus said to them,
"A prophet is not without honor,
except in his own hometown,
among his own relatives,
and in his own house."
5 He could do no mighty work there.
He only laid his hands on a few sick people
and healed them.
6 And he was amazed at their unbelief.
He went around the villages and taught.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus' hometown is Nazareth (1:9). The people have known him since he was a child. That is why they cannot believe that God is working through him.

Verse 3: In Mark, Jesus himself is called "the carpenter." The Greek word means a craftsman who builds with wood or stone. Some old manuscripts say instead the son of the carpenter (as in Matthew 13:55).

It is unusual that he is called "the son of Mary" and not named after his father. Perhaps Joseph was no longer alive.

About Jesus' "brothers" and "sisters": Protestant Christians usually understand them as his brothers and sisters by birth, Catholic and Orthodox Christians as close relatives.

Verse 5: "He could do no mighty work there": Jesus forces his help on no one. Where there is no trust, little happens. Even so, he heals a few sick people.

Important: This does not mean that sick people today are to blame if they don't get well.

Jesus sends out the Twelve VERSES 7–13

7 He called the Twelve to himself
and began to send them out two by two.
He gave them authority over the unclean spirits.
8 He commanded them
to take nothing for the journey
except a walking staff:
no bread, no bag,
no money in their purses.
9 They were to wear sandals,
but not put on two tunics.
10 He said to them,
"Wherever you go into a house,
stay there
until you leave that place.
11 And wherever people will not welcome you
or listen to you,
leave that place
and shake off the dust under your feet
as a testimony against them.
Most certainly I tell you,
on the day of judgment it will be more bearable for
Sodom and Gomorrah
than for that city!"
12 They went out
and preached that people should repent.
13 They cast out many demons,
anointed many sick people with oil,
and healed them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus sends the disciples two by two. No one should travel alone.

They are to take almost nothing with them. In this way they show: We trust in God and in people's hospitality.

Tunic: a long shirt that was worn under the outer clothing.

Verse 11: Shaking the dust off your feet was a sign: We have nothing more to do with you. It is not violence and not revenge.

The sentence about Sodom and Gomorrah is missing in many old manuscripts. A similar sentence is in Matthew 10:15. The WEB has it.

Verse 13: In those days anointing the sick with oil was also a remedy. In many churches there is still an anointing of the sick today (compare James 5:14).

The death of John the Baptizer VERSES 14–29

14 King Herod heard about this,
for Jesus' name had become known.
He said,
"John the Baptizer has risen from the dead.
That is why these powers are at work in him."
15 But others said,
"He is Elijah."
Still others said,
"He is a prophet,
or like one of the prophets."
16 But when Herod heard this,
he said,
"This is John,
whom I beheaded.
He has risen from the dead."
17 For Herod himself had sent men to arrest John
and had him tied up in prison.
He did this because of Herodias,
the wife of his brother Philip.
For he had married her.
18 John had said to Herod,
"It is not lawful for you
to have your brother's wife."
19 Herodias held it against him
and wanted to kill him.
But she couldn't.
20 For Herod was afraid of John.
He knew that he was a righteous and holy man,
and he kept him safe.
When he heard him,
he did many things,
and he liked to listen to him.
21 Then a convenient day came:
On his birthday Herod gave a dinner
for his nobles, the high officers,
and the leading men of Galilee.
22 The daughter of Herodias came in
and danced.
She pleased Herod and his guests.
The king said to the young lady,
"Ask me for whatever you want,
and I will give it to you."
23 He swore to her,
"Whatever you ask of me,
I will give you,
up to half of my kingdom."
24 She went out
and said to her mother,
"What shall I ask for?"
Her mother said,
"The head of John the Baptizer."
25 Immediately she hurried in to the king
and asked,
"I want you to give me right now
the head of John the Baptizer on a platter."
26 The king was very sorry.
But because of his oaths
and because of his dinner guests,
he didn't want to refuse her.
27 Immediately the king sent a soldier of his guard
and ordered him to bring John's head.
He went
and beheaded him in the prison.
28 He brought his head on a platter
and gave it to the young lady.
And the young lady gave it to her mother.

29 When John's disciples heard about it,
they came,
took his body,
and laid it in a tomb.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This Herod is Herod Antipas, a son of Herod the Great. He ruled over Galilee. He was not really a king, but a regional ruler. But people called him "King."

John had criticized Herod because he had married his brother's wife. That was forbidden by the Law of Moses (Leviticus 18:16). He was put in prison for this brave criticism of a powerful man.

Beheaded: killed by having the head cut off.

Verse 20: Only Mark tells us that Herod liked to listen to John and protected him. Herod was torn between two sides.

Verse 22: Some old manuscripts say here his daughter Herodias. The WEB has "the daughter of Herodias." The historian Josephus calls a daughter of Herodias Salome.

Herod makes a careless promise in front of his guests. So as not to look weak in front of them, he has an innocent man killed. The responsibility lies above all with him as ruler.

Important: This story is not proof that women are seductive or evil. Here powerful people used a girl for their own purposes.

Verse 29: John's disciples bury him with dignity.

Jesus feeds 5,000 people VERSES 30–44

30 The apostles gathered around Jesus again.
They told him everything
that they had done and taught.
31 He said to them,
"Come away to a deserted place
and rest a while."
For so many people were coming and going
that they didn't even have time to eat.
32 They went away in the boat
to a deserted place
to be by themselves.
33 But many people saw them leaving
and recognized him.
They ran there on foot from all the towns
and arrived ahead of them.
They gathered around him.
34 When Jesus got out of the boat,
he saw a large crowd.
He had compassion on them,
because they were like sheep without a shepherd.
And he began to teach them many things.
35 When it was already late in the day,
his disciples came to him and said,
"This place is deserted,
and it is already late.
36 Send them away,
so that they can go into the farms and villages around here
and buy themselves bread.
For they have nothing to eat."
37 But he answered them,
"You give them something to eat!"
They asked him,
"Shall we go
and buy 200 denarii worth of bread
and give them something to eat?"
38 He said to them,
"How many loaves do you have?
Go and see!"
When they had found out,
they said,
"Five, and two fish."
39 He told them
to have everyone sit down in groups
on the green grass.
40 They sat down in groups,
in groups of 100 and of 50.
41 He took the five loaves and the two fish,
looked up to heaven,
blessed,
broke the loaves,
and gave them to his disciples
to set before the people.
He also divided the two fish among them all.
42 They all ate and were filled.
43 They picked up 12 baskets full of broken pieces
and also of the fish.
44 Those who ate the loaves
were 5,000 men.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 31: Jesus takes care of his disciples. After a lot of work they should rest. Breaks and rest are good and important.

Verse 34: "Like sheep without a shepherd": A picture from the Old Testament (Numbers 27:17; Ezekiel 34:5). Jesus is the good shepherd who takes care of his people.

Verse 37: A denarius was about a day's wage for a worker. So 200 denarii were about the wages for 200 days of work. The disciples think it is impossible.

Verse 39: Only Mark mentions the "green grass." That reminds us of Psalm 23:2, where God lets us lie down in green pastures.

The words took, looked up, blessed, broke and gave remind Christians of the Lord's Supper (14:22).

Verse 44: In those days often only the men were counted. Matthew adds that women and children were there too (Matthew 14:21).

For today: What looks like little becomes enough for everyone in Jesus' hands. And Jesus still says today: "You give them something to eat!"

Jesus walks on the water VERSES 45–52

45 Immediately after that he made his disciples
get into the boat
and go ahead of him to the other side, to Bethsaida.
Meanwhile he sent the crowd away.
46 After he had said goodbye to them,
he went up the mountain to pray.
47 When evening had come,
the boat was in the middle of the sea,
and he was alone on the land.
48 He saw that they were struggling with the rowing,
for the wind was against them.
About the fourth watch of the night
he came to them,

walking on the sea.
He would have passed by them.
49 But when they saw him walking on the sea,
they thought it was a ghost
and cried out.
50 For they all saw him
and were terrified.
But he immediately spoke with them and said,
"Cheer up! It is I!
Don't be afraid!"
51 He got into the boat with them,
and the wind stopped.
They were completely amazed.
52 For they hadn't understood about the loaves,
but their hearts were hardened.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bethsaida was a town on the north shore of the lake.

The "fourth watch of the night" is between about 3 and 6 in the morning. The disciples have been fighting against the wind all night.

Verse 48: Jesus sees his disciples' distress from far away and comes to them.

"He would have passed by them": This reminds us of God, who passed by Moses and Elijah to show himself to them (Exodus 33:22; 1 Kings 19:11). It does not mean that Jesus wanted to leave them alone.

"It is I" literally means: I am. That is how God names himself in the Old Testament (Exodus 3:14).

Verse 52: The disciples do not yet understand who Jesus is. In Mark it takes them a long time. That gives courage: Even someone who doesn't understand right away may stay with Jesus.

Many sick people are healed VERSES 53–56

53 When they had crossed over,
they came to land at Gennesaret
and tied up the boat there.
54 When they got out of the boat,
the people immediately recognized him.
55 They ran around that whole region
and began to carry the sick on their mats
to wherever they heard he was.
56 And wherever he went,
into villages, into towns, or into the country,
they laid the sick in the marketplaces.
They begged him
that they might just touch the fringe of his garment.
And all who touched him
were made well.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gennesaret is a fertile plain on the west shore of the lake. Actually they wanted to go to Bethsaida (verse 45). Perhaps the wind drove them off course.

The "fringe" probably means the tassels on the garment that devout Jews wore according to God's commandment (Numbers 15:38–39).

The people carry their sick to Jesus. They help one another.

Important: Whoever is sick may pray and go to the doctor. Both belong together. Whoever does not get well is not less faithful.

MARK

CHAPTER 7

What really makes a person unclean

An argument about tradition VERSES 1–13

1 The Pharisees and some of the scribes
who had come from Jerusalem
gathered around Jesus.
2 They saw that some of his disciples
were eating bread with defiled, that is, unwashed,
hands.
They found fault with this.
3 (For the Pharisees and all the Jews
don't eat
unless they wash their hands and forearms.
In this way they hold to the tradition of the elders.
4 When they come from the marketplace,
they don't eat
unless they wash themselves.
And there are many other things
that they have received and hold to:
the washing of cups, pitchers, bronze pots, and
couches.)
5 The Pharisees and the scribes asked him,
"Why don't your disciples live according to the
tradition of the elders,
but eat their bread with unwashed hands?"
6 He answered them,
"Isaiah prophesied well about you hypocrites,
as it is written:
'This people honors me with their lips,
but their heart is far from me.
7 They worship me in vain,
teaching as doctrines
the commandments of men.'
8 For you set aside the commandment of God
and hold tightly to the tradition of men:
the washing of pitchers and cups,
and you do many other things like this."
9 He said to them,
"How cleverly you reject the commandment of God
so that you may keep your tradition!
10 For Moses said,
'Honor your father and your mother,'
and,
'He who speaks evil of father or mother,
let him be put to death.'
11 But you say,
'If a man tells his father or his mother,
"Whatever help you might have received from me
is Corban,"'"
that is, given to God,

12 "then you no longer allow him to do anything for his father
or his mother.
13 In this way you make the word of God void
by your tradition
that you have handed down.
And you do many things like this."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 3–4: Here Mark explains Jewish customs for readers who were not Jews. He writes "all the Jews." That is simplified: Not all Jews in those days kept these purity rules equally strictly. The Pharisees wanted to live out in all of everyday life the purity that was actually meant for the priests in the temple. That was a sincere wish to be close to God.

Here hand washing was a religious cleansing, not mainly a question of hygiene.

Defiled: made unclean in the religious sense.

Verses 6–7 quote Isaiah 29:13.

"Corban" is a Hebrew word for an offering to God. Someone could declare his money to be "Corban." Then supposedly it could no longer be used to help his parents. Jesus says: This undermines God's commandment to honor your parents. Many Jewish teachers also criticized such vows.

Verse 10 quotes Exodus 20:12 and 21:17. The WEB says "speaks evil of": speaking badly about, cursing. The old death penalty is not a call to violence today. Jesus only shows how seriously God takes caring for your parents.

Important: Here Jesus as a Jew argues with other Jewish teachers. It is not a criticism of Judaism as such. The danger of taking religious rules more seriously than love exists in every religion, among Christians too.

What makes a person unclean VERSES 14–23

14 He called the whole crowd to himself
and said to them,
"Listen to me, all of you, and understand!
15 There is nothing from outside a person
that can make him unclean by going into him.
But the things that come out of a person
are what make the person unclean.
16 If anyone has ears to hear,
let him hear!"
17 When he had gone into a house away from the crowd,
his disciples asked him about the parable.
18 He said to them,
"Are you also without understanding?
Don't you see
that whatever goes into a person from outside
can't make him unclean?
19 For it doesn't go into his heart,
but into his stomach,
and then out into the latrine."
In this way he was making all foods clean.
20 He said,
"What comes out of a person,
that is what makes the person unclean.
21 For from within,
out of people's hearts,
come evil thoughts,
adulteries, sexual sins,
murders, thefts,
22 greed, wickedness, deceit,
lustful desires, an evil eye,
blasphemy, pride, and foolishness.
23 All these evil things come from within
and make the person unclean."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus says: It is not food that separates a person from God, but the evil in their heart.

Verse 16 is missing in many old manuscripts. The WEB has it.

Latrine: a toilet.

Verse 19: The sentence "In this way he was making all foods clean" is an explanation by Mark for his readers. For the first Christians this was an important question: Do Christians who are not Jews have to keep the Jewish food laws? The church later decided: No (compare Acts 10 and 15).

Important: For Jews the food laws are still a precious part of their faith today. They are a gift from God to Israel. No one should look down on them.

Verses 21–22: Evil begins on the inside, in thoughts and desires. That is why the heart is so important. "An evil eye" is an old expression for envy.

The woman from Syrophoenicia VERSES 24–30

24 Jesus got up and left that place
and went into the region of Tyre and Sidon.
He went into a house
and didn't want anyone to know it.
But he could not stay hidden.
25 A woman had heard about him.
Her little daughter had an unclean spirit.
She came and fell down at his feet.
26 The woman was a Greek,
a Syrophoenician by birth.
She begged him
to cast the demon out of her daughter.
27 But Jesus said to her,
"Let the children be fed first.
For it is not right
to take the children's bread
and throw it to the dogs."
28 But she answered him,
"Yes, Lord.
But even the dogs under the table
eat the children's crumbs."
29 He said to her,
"Because of this saying,
go your way.
The demon has gone out of your daughter."
30 She went home
and found the child lying on the bed.
The demon had gone out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tyre and Sidon are cities on the Mediterranean Sea, in today's Lebanon. Mostly non-Jews lived there.

The woman is "a Greek," which means: not a Jew; she speaks Greek. "Syrophoenician" means: from Phoenicia, which belonged to the Roman province of Syria. Matthew calls her a Canaanite woman (Matthew 15:22).

Verse 27: Jesus says his task is first for Israel ("the children"). "Dogs" was an insulting word for non-Jews. The Greek word means little house dogs. This scene is hard. Interpreters understand it differently: Some think Jesus is testing the woman. Others think the woman leads Jesus to widen his path.

The woman is quick-witted and brave. She fights for her child. Jesus recognizes her clever saying and helps her.

Important: This story is no excuse for looking down on people of a different background. It is the foreign woman of all people who becomes an example.

About the "unclean spirit": Mental illnesses or seizures are not a sin and not a punishment. People affected by them need help and understanding.

Jesus heals a deaf man VERSES 31–37

31 Again Jesus left the region of Tyre and Sidon
and came to the Sea of Galilee,
through the middle of the region of Decapolis.
32 They brought to him a man
who was deaf and could hardly speak.
They begged Jesus
to lay his hand on him.
33 He took him aside from the crowd,
privately, by himself.
He put his fingers into the man's ears,
spat,
and touched his tongue.
34 Then he looked up to heaven,
sighed,
and said to him,
"Ephphatha!"
That means,
"Be opened!"
35 Immediately his ears were opened,
his tongue was set free,
and he spoke clearly.
36 Jesus commanded them
to tell no one.
But the more he commanded them,
the more widely they told it everywhere.
37 They were amazed beyond measure and said,
"He has done all things well.
He even makes the deaf hear
and the mute speak!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 31: The WEB says that Jesus left the region of Tyre and Sidon. Many old manuscripts say it differently: Jesus went from Tyre by way of Sidon. That would be a detour to the north. The translation above follows the WEB.

Jesus takes the man aside, away from the many people. He treats him gently. Because the man cannot hear, Jesus "speaks" with gestures: fingers in the ears, touching the tongue. In those days saliva was considered a remedy.

"Ephphatha" is Aramaic, Jesus' native language. Mark keeps the original word.

Jesus "sighed": He suffers along with the man.

Verse 37 reminds us of Isaiah 35:5–6, where the prophet says that the ears of the deaf will be opened and the tongue of the mute will sing for joy.

Mute: unable to speak.

Important: Deaf people are not broken or worth less. Today many deaf people see themselves as a community of their own with their own language, sign language. The story shows: Jesus turns to them with respect and tenderness.

MARK

CHAPTER 8

"You are the Christ"

Jesus feeds 4,000 people VERSES 1–10

1 In those days there was a very large crowd.
They had nothing to eat.
So Jesus called his disciples to himself
and said to them,
2 "I have compassion on the people.
They have been with me for three days now
and have nothing to eat.
3 If I send them home hungry,
they will faint on the way.
For some of them have come a long way."
4 His disciples answered him,
"From where could anyone get enough bread
to feed these people here in a deserted place?"
5 He asked them,
"How many loaves do you have?"
They said,
"Seven."
6 He told the crowd
to sit down on the ground.
He took the seven loaves,
gave thanks,
broke them,
and gave them to his disciples to serve.
And they served them to the crowd.
7 They also had a few small fish.
He blessed them
and said to serve these too.
8 They ate and were filled.
They picked up the broken pieces that were left over:
seven baskets.
9 About 4,000 people
had eaten.
Then he sent them away.
10 Immediately he got into the boat with his disciples
and came into the region of Dalmanutha.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is similar to the feeding of the 5,000 (6:30–44). Mark tells both. This one probably happens in the region of Decapolis (7:31), where many non-Jews lived. Some interpreters see in it: Jesus also cares for the nations.

Verse 3: "Some of them have come a long way": Jesus thinks of the people who have a long way home. He sees the

concrete need.

Again the disciples ask: "From where?" They have already seen Jesus feed thousands, and still they forget it.

Dalmanutha: No one knows exactly where this place was. Some manuscripts have other names.

For today: Jesus has compassion on hungry people. Many people are still hungry today. Christians should help.

The demand for a sign VERSES 11–13

11 The Pharisees came out
and began to argue with him.
They asked him for a sign from heaven,
to test him.
12 He sighed deeply in his spirit and said,
"Why does this generation look for a sign?
Most certainly I tell you,
no sign will be given to this generation."
13 He left them,
got into the boat again,
and went to the other side.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus has just fed thousands. Even so they still want proof. Jesus sighs deeply. He is sad, not angry.

Faith cannot be forced by proof. Whoever does not want to see sees nothing, even with great signs.

Important: This is not a judgment on all Pharisees or on the Jewish people.

The yeast of the Pharisees and of Herod VERSES 14–21

14 The disciples had forgotten to take bread.
They had only one loaf with them in the boat.
15 Jesus warned them and said,
"Watch out!
Beware of the yeast of the Pharisees
and the yeast of Herod!"
16 They talked with one another and said,
"He says this because we have no bread."
17 Jesus noticed it and said to them,
"Why are you talking about
having no bread?
Don't you see yet,
or understand?
Is your heart still hardened?
18 You have eyes, don't you see?
You have ears, don't you hear?
Don't you remember?
19 When I broke the five loaves for the 5,000,
how many baskets full of broken pieces did you pick up?"
They told him,
"12."
20 "And when I broke the seven loaves for the 4,000,
how many baskets full of broken pieces did you pick up?"
They told him,
"Seven."
21 He asked them,
"Don't you understand yet?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Yeast" is a picture for something that spreads without being noticed. Jesus warns against an attitude that demands signs and closes itself off from him, and against the greed for power of a ruler like Herod.

The disciples think only about their missing bread. Jesus reminds them: I have fed thousands twice! You don't need to worry.

Verse 18 reminds us of Jeremiah 5:21 and Ezekiel 12:2.

The "one loaf" in the boat: Some interpreters see in it a hint at Jesus himself. He is with them. They need nothing more.

In Mark the disciples don't understand for a long time. This is told honestly and gives courage: Even someone who is slow to understand stays with Jesus.

Jesus heals a blind man in Bethsaida VERSES 22–26

22 They came to Bethsaida.
People brought a blind man to him
and begged him to touch him.
23 He took the blind man by the hand
and led him out of the village.
He spat on his eyes,
laid his hands on him,
and asked him,
"Do you see anything?"
24 He looked up and said,
"I see people.
But I see them like trees
walking around."
25 Then Jesus laid his hands on his eyes again.
The man looked hard,
and he was healed
and saw everything clearly.
26 Jesus sent him home
and said,
"Don't go into the village,
and don't tell anyone in the village!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Mark tells about this healing. It is special: It happens in two steps. First the man sees only blurry shapes, then completely clearly.

Jesus takes the man by the hand and leads him himself. He is very close to him.

Many interpreters see this story as a picture of the disciples: They already see something, but not yet clearly. Right after this Peter recognizes who Jesus is, but he does not yet understand what that means (verses 29–33).

Verse 26: Some manuscripts have only "Don't go into the village."

Important: Blindness is not a punishment. People who stay blind are also loved by God.

Peter confesses: You are the Christ VERSES 27–30

27 Jesus went away with his disciples
into the villages near Caesarea Philippi.
On the way he asked his disciples,
"Who do people say that I am?"
28 They told him,
"Some say John the Baptizer.
Others say Elijah.
Others, one of the prophets."

29 He asked them,
"But who do you say that I am?"
Peter answered,
"You are the Christ."
30 He ordered them
to tell no one about him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the center of the Gospel of Mark. The big question was always: Who is Jesus? Now Peter says it for the first time: "You are the Christ," the Messiah, the King promised by God.

Caesarea Philippi was in the far north, near the springs of the Jordan.

Verse 30: Jesus does not want them to tell others. Many expected a Messiah who would fight with violence against the Romans. Jesus goes a different way, as he explains right away.

In Matthew this scene is told in more detail (Matthew 16:13–20).

Jesus announces his suffering VERSES 31–33

31 And he began to teach them
that the Son of Man must suffer many things.
He would be rejected by the elders, the chief priests,
and the scribes.
He would be killed
and after three days rise again.
32 He said this quite openly.
Then Peter took him aside
and began to rebuke him.
33 But Jesus turned around,
looked at his disciples,
and rebuked Peter.
He said,
"Get behind me, Satan!
For you have in mind not the things of God,
but the things of men."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

For the first time Jesus says openly: I will suffer, die and rise again. The word "must" shows: This is God's way.

The opponents whom Jesus names are certain leaders, not the Jewish people. Crucifixion was a Roman punishment. It is wrong, and it has caused much suffering, to blame "the Jews" for the death of Jesus.

Rebuke: to tell someone off sharply.

Peter cannot imagine that the Christ should suffer.

"Satan" means "opponent." Peter wants to turn Jesus away from God's way, like the tempter in the wilderness. "Get behind me" can also mean: Take your place behind me again, as my disciple. Jesus does not give up on Peter.

What it means to follow Jesus VERSES 34–38

34 He called the crowd to himself together with his disciples
and said to them,
"Whoever wants to come after me
must deny himself,
take up his cross,
and follow me.
35 For whoever wants to save his life
will lose it.
But whoever loses his life
for my sake and for the sake of the Good News
will save it.
36 For what good is it for a person
to gain the whole world
and lose his life?
37 For what can a person give
in exchange for his life?
38 For whoever is ashamed of me and of my words
in this adulterous and sinful generation,
the Son of Man will also be ashamed of him
when he comes in his Father's glory
with the holy angels."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Deny himself": no longer putting yourself at the center, but God and others. "Take up his cross": being ready to bear disadvantages for your faith too.

Very important: This does not mean that you simply have to put up with violence, abuse or injustice. Whoever experiences violence may and should get help: In the US, call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. In the UK, call the National Domestic Abuse Helpline at 0808 2000 247. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verses 35–37: The Greek word for "life" can also mean "soul." A life lived only for possessions and success is lost in the end.

Verse 38: "Adulterous" is a picture used by the prophets for being unfaithful to God. Jesus encourages: Stand by me, even when it is hard.

MARK

CHAPTER 9

"I believe. Help my unbelief!"

The transfiguration on the mountain VERSES 1–8

1 Jesus said to them,
"I tell you the truth:
Some of the people standing here
will not die
before they see
God's Kingdom come with power."
2 Six days later Jesus took Peter, James and John with him.
He led them up a high mountain.
They were alone there.
There Jesus was changed in front of them.
He looked different.
3 His clothes began to shine.
They became very white, like snow.
No one on earth who washes clothes could make them that white.

4 Elijah and Moses appeared to them.
They were talking with Jesus.
5 Peter said to Jesus,
"Rabbi, it is good for us to be here.
Let's make three tents:
one for you, one for Moses and one for Elijah."
Rabbi means: teacher.
6 Peter did not know what to say.
They were all very afraid.
7 Then a cloud came and covered them with its shadow.
A voice came out of the cloud:
"This is my Son. I love him.
Listen to him."
8 Suddenly they looked around.
They did not see anyone with them anymore,
only Jesus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Transfiguration: Jesus' appearance is changed, and his divine glory shines out.

Verse 1 is hard to understand. Many interpreters relate it to the transfiguration, which is told right after it. Others think of Easter or Pentecost.

For a moment three disciples see Jesus' divine glory. Only Mark mentions the "launderer": No human being can make anything that white. Launderer: someone who washes and bleaches clothes.

Moses stands for the Law, Elijah for the prophets. Both are among the great figures of Israel. Jesus stands in their midst.

Verse 6: Mark is honest: Peter speaks out of fear and embarrassment.

The voice says the same as at the baptism (1:11) and adds: "Listen to him" (compare Deuteronomy 18:15).

Told in more detail in Matthew 17:1–8.

The question about Elijah VERSES 9–13

9 They were coming down from the mountain.
On the way Jesus gave them an order:
They must not tell anyone what they had seen
until the Son of Man had risen from the dead.
10 They kept these words to themselves.
But they asked each other
what the "rising from the dead" meant.
11 They asked Jesus,
"Why do the scribes say
that Elijah must come first?"
12 He said to them,
"It is true: Elijah comes first.
He sets everything right again.
But what is written about the Son of Man?
It is written that he must suffer many things.
People will look down on him.
13 But I tell you:
Elijah has already come.
And people have done to him whatever they wanted,
just as it is written about him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The disciples don't understand what the "rising from the dead" is supposed to mean for Jesus.

The scribes referred to Malachi: Before the day of the LORD, Elijah will come (Malachi 4:5–6; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 3:23–24).

Jesus says: Elijah has already come. He means John the Baptizer, who was killed (6:14–29). Jesus too will suffer, as it is written, for example in Isaiah 53 and Psalm 22.

A father asks for help for his sick son VERSES 14–29

14 Jesus and the three disciples came back to the other disciples.
There they saw a large crowd around them.
Some scribes were arguing with them.
15 As soon as the people saw Jesus,
they were all very surprised.
They ran to him and greeted him.
16 Jesus asked the scribes,
"What are you arguing with them about?"
17 A man from the crowd answered,
"Teacher, I brought my son to you.
He has a spirit in him that makes him unable to speak.
18 Wherever the spirit takes hold of him,
it throws him to the ground.
Then foam comes out of his mouth.
He grinds his teeth.
And his body becomes stiff.
I asked your disciples
to drive the spirit out.
But they could not do it."
19 Jesus answered,
"You people of today do not believe!
How long do I still have to be with you?
How long do I have to put up with you?
Bring the boy to me!"
20 They brought the boy to Jesus.
When the spirit saw Jesus,
it shook the boy hard at once.
The boy fell on the ground.
He rolled around,
and foam came out of his mouth.
21 Jesus asked the father,
"How long has this been happening to him?"
The father said,
"Since he was a small child.
22 The spirit has often thrown him into the fire
and into the water.
It wants to kill him.
But if you can do anything,
please feel sorry for us and help us!"
23 Jesus said to him,
"If you can believe:
Everything is possible for the one who believes."
24 At once the father of the boy cried out in tears,
"I believe.
Help my unbelief!"
That means: Help me where I still do not believe.
25 Jesus saw that a crowd was running together.
So he spoke sharply to the unclean spirit.
He said to it,
"You spirit that makes him unable to speak and hear,
I command you:
Come out of him,
and never go into him again!"

26 The spirit screamed.
It shook the boy hard,
and it came out.
The boy lay there as if he were dead.
Most of the people said,
"He is dead."
27 But Jesus took him by the hand
and helped him up.
And the boy stood up.
28 Jesus went into the house.
When his disciples were alone with him, they asked him,
"Why could we not drive the spirit out?"
29 He said to them,
"This kind can only be driven out
by prayer and fasting."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The seizures described here (falling down, foaming at the mouth, grinding the teeth, becoming stiff) are similar to epilepsy. In those days people explained such things as the work of a spirit.

Very important: Epilepsy is an illness of the brain. It has nothing to do with demons or sin. People with epilepsy need medical help and understanding, not an exorcism. No one may use this story to keep medicine or treatment from sick people.

Verses 21–22: Jesus asks about the history of the illness. He listens to the father. The father has suffered for years and feared for his child.

Verse 24: "I believe. Help my unbelief!" That is one of the most honest sentences in the Bible. Faith and doubt are often there at the same time. Jesus accepts this small, doubting faith and helps.

Important: This does not mean that someone does not get well because they believe too little. Illness is not a sign of too little faith.

Verse 27: Jesus takes the boy by the hand and raises him up, like the daughter of Jairus (5:41).

Verse 29: The words "and fasting" are missing in important old manuscripts. The WEB has them.

Jesus announces his suffering again VERSES 30–32

30 They left that place
and traveled through Galilee.
Jesus did not want anyone to know about it.
31 He was teaching his disciples.
He said to them,
"The Son of Man is being handed over to people.
They will kill him.
But after he has been killed,
he will rise again on the third day."
32 But the disciples did not understand what he meant.
And they were afraid to ask him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the second announcement of his suffering (the first was in 8:31).

The disciples don't understand it. And they don't dare to ask. Perhaps they also did not want to accept it.

For today: You may ask questions, also about hard things in the faith.

Who is the greatest? VERSES 33–37

33 They came to Capernaum.
When Jesus was in the house,
he asked them,
"What were you arguing about on the way?"
34 But they did not say anything.
On the way they had argued with each other
about who was the greatest.
35 Jesus sat down.
He called the 12 disciples
and said to them,
"If anyone wants to be first,
he must be the last of all
and the servant of all."
36 He took a little child
and stood him in the middle of them.
He took the child in his arms
and said to them,
37 "Whoever welcomes one little child like this in my name
welcomes me.
And whoever welcomes me
does not welcome only me.
He welcomes the one who sent me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus has just spoken about his suffering. And the disciples argue about who is the most important! They are ashamed and silent.

Jesus sits down, like a teacher, and explains: With me, whoever serves others is great.

Only Mark tells us that Jesus takes the child in his arms. In those days children had no rights and counted for little. Jesus puts them in the middle.

For today: Children are important in the church. Whoever protects children and cares for them does it for Jesus and for God himself.

Whoever is not against us is for us VERSES 38–41

38 John said to Jesus,
"Teacher, we saw someone
driving out demons in your name.
He is not one of us.
We told him to stop,
because he is not one of us."
39 But Jesus said,
"Do not stop him!
No one who does a miracle in my name
can soon after that say bad things about me.
40 Whoever is not against us
is on our side.
41 I tell you the truth:
Someone may give you a cup of water to drink
in my name,
because you belong to Christ.
That person will surely not lose his reward."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The disciples want to decide who may belong to Jesus. Jesus says: Don't be so narrow! Whoever does good in my name is not an enemy.

For today: Christians of different churches should not shut each other out. God also works outside your own group.

Verse 41: Even a small kindness, a cup of water, is precious to God.

A warning against leading others astray VERSES 42–50

42 "Someone may cause one of these little ones
who believe in me
to fall away from God.
It would be better for him
to have a millstone tied around his neck
and to be thrown into the sea.
43 If your hand causes you to stumble,
cut it off.
It is better for you
to go into life with only one hand
than to have two hands and go into Gehenna,
into the fire that never goes out,
44 'where their worm does not die,
and the fire does not go out.'
45 If your foot causes you to stumble,
cut it off.
It is better for you
to go into life with only one foot
than to have two feet and be thrown into Gehenna,
into the fire that never goes out,
46 'where their worm does not die,
and the fire does not go out.'
47 If your eye causes you to stumble,
throw it away.
It is better for you
to go into God's Kingdom with one eye
than to have two eyes and be thrown into the fire of Gehenna,
48 'where their worm does not die,
and the fire does not go out.'
49 Everyone will be salted with fire,
and every sacrifice will be seasoned with salt.
50 Salt is good.
But if salt loses its salty taste,
how can you make it salty again?
Have salt in yourselves.
And live in peace with each other."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 42: Jesus clearly takes the side of the weak and of children. Whoever harms them does great wrong. Whoever has experienced abuse or knows about it can find help. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. Children and young people in the UK can call Childline at 0800 1111.

Millstone: a large, heavy stone for grinding grain.

Verses 43–47 are picture language. Jesus wants to say: Take evil very seriously. Separate yourself from everything that leads you to evil. He does not mean that anyone should really hurt themselves.

Whoever is thinking about hurting themselves, please get help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

"Gehenna" was a valley near Jerusalem. It became a picture for God's judgment.

Verses 44 and 46 are missing in the best old manuscripts. They repeat verse 48. The WEB has them. The words come from Isaiah 66:24.

Verse 49 is hard to understand. Salt cleans and preserves. Perhaps it means: Whoever follows Jesus is tested and purified by hard things. The second part ("every sacrifice will be seasoned with salt") is missing in some manuscripts. It reminds us of Leviticus 2:13.

Verse 50: At the end comes peace. The disciples who were just arguing about who is the greatest (verse 34) are to be at peace with one another.

MARK

CHAPTER 10

The way to Jerusalem

The question about divorce VERSES 1–12

1 Jesus got up and left that place.
He went into the area of Judea
and to the other side of the Jordan.
Again crowds came together around him.
And he taught them again, as he usually did.
2 Some Pharisees came to him.
They wanted to test him.
They asked him,
"Is a man allowed by the law
to divorce his wife?"
3 He answered,
"What did Moses command you?"
4 They said,
"Moses allowed a man to write a divorce paper
and send his wife away."
5 But Jesus said to them,
"Moses wrote this commandment for you
because your hearts are so hard.
6 But at the beginning, when God created the world,
he made people male and female.
7 That is why a man will leave his father and mother
and be joined to his wife.
8 And the two will become one body.
So they are no longer two,
but one body.
9 God has joined them together.
So no one should separate them."
10 In the house the disciples asked Jesus about this again.
11 He said to them,
"If a man divorces his wife
and marries another woman,
he commits adultery against her.
12 And if a woman divorces her husband
and marries another man,
she commits adultery."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Moses allowed divorce and gave rules for it (Deuteronomy 24:1–4). In those days in Israel usually only the man could get a divorce. Afterward women were often poor and without protection.

Jesus goes back to the beginning (Genesis 1:27 and 2:24): God wants marriage to last. In this way he protects above all the women against being divorced at will.

Verse 11: Adultery means: being unfaithful in marriage. "Against her": Jesus sees the woman as someone who can be wronged. That was not taken for granted in those days.

Verse 12: Under Roman law women could also get a divorce. Mark is probably also writing for readers who lived under Roman law.

Christians understand this saying in different ways. The Catholic Church holds that marriage cannot be dissolved. Protestant and Orthodox churches allow divorce and a new marriage under certain circumstances. Matthew gives an exception (Matthew 19:9).

Very important: No one has to stay in a marriage in which they are beaten, threatened or abused. In the US, call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. In the UK, call the National Domestic Abuse Helpline at 0808 2000 247. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Divorced people are not worse Christians. God loves them.

Jesus blesses the children VERSES 13–16

13 People were bringing little children to Jesus.
They wanted him to touch them.
But the disciples scolded the people who brought them.
14 Jesus saw this.
He was moved with indignation.
That means: He was angry.
He said to the disciples,
"Let the little children come to me!
Do not stop them!
God's Kingdom belongs to people like them.
15 I tell you the truth:
Whoever does not receive God's Kingdom like a little child
will never get into it."
16 Then he took the children in his arms.
He put his hands on them
and blessed them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Mark tells us that Jesus was "moved with indignation," that is, angry with his disciples. Children are important to him.

Verse 15: Children can accept gifts. They don't have to earn anything. That is how adults too should receive God's Kingdom: as a gift.

Jesus takes the children in his arms. That is tender and loving.

For today: Children should be welcome in the church. And they have a right to be protected from violence.

The rich man VERSES 17–22

17 Jesus was setting out on his way.
Then a man ran up to him.
He knelt down in front of Jesus
and asked him,
"Good Teacher,
what must I do
to receive eternal life?"
18 Jesus said to him,
"Why do you call me good?
No one is good except one: God.
19 You know the commandments:
'Do not murder.'
'Do not commit adultery.'
'Do not steal.'
'Do not tell lies about others in court.'
'Do not defraud.'
'Honor your father and mother.'"
20 The man said to him,
"Teacher, I have kept all these commandments since I was young."
21 Jesus looked at him and loved him.
He said to him,
"You are missing one thing.
Go and sell everything you have.
Give the money to the poor.
Then you will have treasure in heaven.
And come, follow me,
taking up the cross."
22 When the man heard this, his face fell.
He went away sad.
He was very rich.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus names commandments from the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:12–16). "Do not defraud" (10:19) is only in Mark. It reminds us of Deuteronomy 24:14: You must not hold back a worker's wages. Defraud: to cheat someone out of what belongs to them.

Verse 21: Only Mark tells us: "Jesus looked at him and loved him." Jesus does not challenge him out of strictness, but out of love.

The words "taking up the cross" are missing in many old manuscripts. The WEB has them.

The man is sincere and devout. But his possessions hold him tight.

Christians understand verse 21 in different ways. Some really give up all their possessions, for example monks and nuns. Most understand it like this: Nothing may be more important to us than God. Whoever has a lot should share with the poor.

Riches and God's Kingdom VERSES 23–31

23 Jesus looked around.
He said to his disciples,
"It is so hard for people
who have riches
to get into God's Kingdom!"
24 The disciples were amazed at his words.
But Jesus said to them again,
"Children, it is so hard for those
who trust in riches
to get into God's Kingdom!
25 It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle
than for a rich man to get into God's Kingdom."
26 The disciples were even more amazed.
They said to him,

"Then who can be saved?"
27 Jesus looked at them and said,
"For people it is impossible,
but not for God.
For God, everything is possible."
28 Peter began to say to him,
"Look, we have left everything
and followed you."
29 Jesus said,
"I tell you the truth:
Some have left their house
or brothers or sisters
or father or mother
or wife or children
or land
because of me and because of the Good News.
30 Each one of them will receive 100 times as much
now in this time:
houses, brothers, sisters, mothers, children and land,
together with persecutions.
And in the world to come they will receive eternal life.
31 But many who are first will be last,
and the last will be first."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 24: Jesus tenderly calls his disciples "Children." The words "who trust in riches" are missing in some old manuscripts.

Verse 25: The camel was the largest animal people knew, the eye of a needle the smallest hole. Jesus exaggerates on purpose. The explanation that there was a small city gate called the Needle's Eye has no evidence behind it.

Verse 27: A great comfort: No one can save themselves. But God can.

Verse 30: Whoever follows Jesus finds a new, large family in the church. Notice: Fathers are not named a second time here. Some interpreters say: In the new family there is only one Father, God. And: Only Mark mentions "with persecutions." Persecutions means: being treated badly because of your faith. Following Jesus is not always easy.

Important: This does not mean that you should abandon your family (compare 7:10–13).

Jesus announces his suffering for the third time
VERSES 32–34

32 They were on the road going up to Jerusalem.
Jesus was walking ahead of them.
The disciples were amazed.
And the people who followed were afraid.
Again Jesus took the Twelve aside.
He began to tell them
what was going to happen to him:
33 "Look, we are going up to Jerusalem.
There the Son of Man
will be handed over to the chief priests and the scribes.
They will sentence him to death.
They will hand him over to the Gentiles.
34 The Gentiles will make fun of him.
They will spit on him.
They will whip him
and kill him.
But on the third day he will rise again."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus walks ahead, bravely, even though he knows what is waiting for him. The disciples are afraid.

This is the third and most detailed announcement (compare 8:31 and 9:31).

"The Gentiles" here are the Romans. Gentiles: people who are not Jews. Crucifixion was a Roman punishment.

Important: Jesus names certain leaders, not the Jewish people. Blaming "the Jews" for the death of Jesus is wrong and has caused great injustice.

Whoever serves is great VERSES 35–45

35 Then James and John, the sons of Zebedee, came to Jesus.
They said,
"Teacher, we want you
to do for us
whatever we ask."
36 He said to them,
"What do you want me to do for you?"
37 They said to him,
"When you are in your glory,
let us sit next to you,
one at your right side and one at your left side."
38 But Jesus said to them,
"You do not know what you are asking.
Can you drink the cup
that I drink?
Can you be baptized with the baptism
that I am baptized with?"
39 They said to him,
"We can."
Jesus said to them,
"You will drink the cup that I drink.
And you will be baptized with the baptism
that I am baptized with.
40 But I cannot decide who sits at my right side or at my left side.
Those places are for the people
for whom they have been prepared."
41 The other 10 disciples heard about it.
They became angry with James and John.
42 Jesus called them together
and said to them,
"You know:
Those who are seen as rulers over the nations
act like lords over them.
And their great men use their power over them.
43 But it must not be like that among you!
Whoever wants to become great among you must be your servant.
44 And whoever wants to be first among you
must be the slave of all.
45 Even the Son of Man did not come
to be served.
He came to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."
A ransom is a price paid to set someone free.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Mark, James and John ask for themselves (in Matthew 20:20 it is their mother).

The "cup" and the "baptism" are pictures for the suffering that Jesus expects.

Verse 39: James was later killed because of his faith (Acts 12:2).

Verses 42–44: In the world the powerful often rule from above. With Jesus it is the other way around: Whoever leads should serve.

Verse 45 is one of the most important sentences in the Gospel of Mark. Ransom: In those days people paid money to buy prisoners or slaves free. Jesus gives his life to set people free. This reminds us of Isaiah 53:10–12.

For today: In the family, at work, in politics and in the church, no one should misuse their power.

Blind Bartimaeus VERSES 46–52

46 They came to Jericho.
Then Jesus left Jericho with his disciples and a large crowd.
A blind beggar was sitting by the road.
His name was Bartimaeus, the son of Timaeus.
47 He heard
that it was Jesus from Nazareth.
Then he began to shout,
"Jesus, son of David,
have mercy on me!"
48 Many people told him sharply
to be quiet.
But he shouted even louder,
"Son of David, have mercy on me!"
49 Jesus stopped
and said,
"Call him."
So they called the blind man.
They said to him,
"Cheer up! Get up.
He is calling you!"
50 The blind man threw off his cloak.
He jumped up
and came to Jesus.
51 Jesus asked him,
"What do you want me to do for you?"
The blind man said to him,
"Rabboni, I want to see again."
52 Jesus said to him,
"Go.
Your faith has made you well."
At once the man could see again.
And he followed Jesus on the way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jericho is in the Jordan Valley. From there the road goes up to Jerusalem.

Bartimaeus is the only healed person whom Mark names. "Bar" means "son": Bartimaeus means "son of Timaeus."

He calls Jesus "son of David," that is, the promised King. He sees more than many who can see.

The crowd wants to silence him. But he will not be stopped.

Verse 50: For a beggar, the cloak was often his only possession. He throws it away. Very different from the rich man (verse 22).

Verse 51: Jesus asks the same question as he asked the sons of Zebedee (verse 36): "What do you want me to do for you?" Bartimaeus does not ask for honor, but for help.

"Rabboni" means "my teacher." It is an especially warm way of speaking to someone.

"On the way": He follows Jesus to Jerusalem. He becomes a disciple.

Important: People with disabilities should not be silenced. Jesus asks what they themselves want. That is an attitude of respect.

MARK

CHAPTER 11

Jesus comes to Jerusalem

The entry into Jerusalem VERSES 1–11

1 They came near Jerusalem,
to Bethsphage and Bethany at the Mount of Olives.
There Jesus sent two of his disciples ahead.
2 He said to them,
"Go into the village in front of you.
As soon as you go in,
you will find a young donkey tied up there,
on which no one has sat.
Untie him and bring him here.
3 Someone may ask you,
'Why are you doing this?'
Then say,
'The Lord needs him.'
Then he will send him back here right away."
4 The two disciples went.
They found a young donkey.
It was tied at a door outside in the street.
They untied him.
5 Some of the people standing there
asked them,
"What are you doing?
Why are you untying the young donkey?"
6 The disciples answered
just as Jesus had told them.
And the people let them go.
7 They brought the young donkey to Jesus.
They put their cloaks on it.
And Jesus sat on it.
8 Many people spread their cloaks on the road.
Others cut branches from the trees
and spread them on the road.
9 The people walking in front
and the people following behind
shouted,
"Hosanna!
Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!
10 Blessed is the coming kingdom of our father David!
It comes in the name of the Lord!

Hosanna in the highest!"
11 Jesus went into Jerusalem and into the temple.
He looked around at everything.
It was already evening.
So he went out to Bethany with the 12 disciples.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bethsphage and Bethany were villages on the Mount of Olives, east of Jerusalem.

Jesus rides on a young donkey, not on a war horse. This reminds us of Zechariah 9:9: A king of peace comes, humble, riding on a donkey.

"On which no one has sat": An animal for a holy purpose was not supposed to have been used yet (compare Numbers 19:2).

Verse 3: The WEB understands the sentence like this: The owner will send the donkey here right away. The Greek can also be understood differently: Jesus will send the donkey back right away. Then Jesus would have promised to give it back.

"Hosanna" originally means "Please save us!" and became a shout of joy. The words come from Psalm 118:25–26, which pilgrims sang at the feast.

Verse 11: In Mark, Jesus only looks at everything on the first evening. Only on the next day does he act in the temple.

Christians remember this day on Palm Sunday.

The fig tree without fruit VERSES 12–14

12 The next day they left Bethany.
Jesus was hungry.
13 From far away he saw a fig tree with leaves.
He went to see
if he could find any fruit on it.
When he got there,
he found nothing but leaves.
It was not the season for figs.
14 Jesus said to the tree,
"May no one ever eat fruit from you again!"
His disciples heard it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is hard to understand, especially because Mark says: "It was not the season for figs." So why does Jesus curse the tree?

Many interpreters say: It is a symbolic action, as with the prophets. Mark uses it to "frame" the temple story (fig tree – temple – fig tree). The tree with leaves but no fruit is a picture of worship that looks beautiful on the outside but bears no fruit.

Important: This is not God's judgment on the Jewish people. Christians often interpreted the story this way in the past. That was wrong. The question about fruit is for everyone, the churches too.

Jesus in the temple VERSES 15–19

15 They came to Jerusalem.
Jesus went into the temple.
He began to throw out the people who were selling and buying there.
He turned over the tables of the money changers
and the seats of the people who sold doves.
16 He did not let anyone
carry a container through the temple.
17 He taught the people.
He said to them,
"Isn't it written:
'My house will be called a house of prayer for all the nations'?
But you have made it a den of robbers!"
A den is a hiding place.
18 The chief priests and the scribes heard this.
They looked for a way
to kill him.
They were afraid of him,
because the whole crowd was amazed at his teaching.
19 In the evening
Jesus went out of the city.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the outer court of the temple, animals for sacrifice were sold and money was changed. This was needed for the running of the temple. This court was also the only place where non-Jews were allowed to pray.

Money changers: people who exchanged foreign coins for the coins used at the temple.

Verse 16: Only Mark tells us: Jesus lets no one carry a container through the temple. Some people used the temple court as a shortcut.

Verse 17: Only Mark quotes the words "for all the nations." The verse combines Isaiah 56:7 and Jeremiah 7:11. The temple is to be a place of prayer for all people.

Like the prophets before him, Jesus criticizes that God's house has become a place of business.

Important: Jesus does not hurt anyone. This story is no excuse for violence.

Verse 18: The leaders want to get rid of Jesus. The people, on the other hand, are amazed at him. It is about certain leaders, not about the Jewish people.

Faith, prayer and forgiveness VERSES 20–26

20 In the morning they walked past the fig tree.
They saw that it had dried up,
all the way down to the roots.
21 Peter remembered what had happened.
He said to Jesus,
"Rabbi, look!
The fig tree that you cursed
has dried up."
22 Jesus answered them,
"Have faith in God.
23 I tell you the truth:
Someone may say to this mountain,
'Lift yourself up and throw yourself into the sea.'
He does not doubt in his heart.
He believes that what he says is happening.
Then he will have what he says.
24 So I tell you:
Whatever you pray and ask for,
believe that you have received it.
Then you will have it.
25 When you stand and pray,
forgive anyone you have something against.
Then your Father in heaven
will also forgive you your sins.
26 But if you do not forgive,
your Father in heaven will not forgive your sins

either."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: "Have faith in God." It is about trusting God, not about your own strength.

Moving mountains is a picture for something that seems impossible.

Important: These words do not mean that you get everything you wish for if only you believe strongly enough. And whoever stays sick or suffers is not to blame for it. In the garden of Gethsemane Jesus himself prays that not what he wants should happen, but what God wants (14:36).

Verse 25: Prayer and forgiveness belong together, as in the Lord's Prayer (Matthew 6:12).

Verse 26 is missing in many old manuscripts. A similar verse is in Matthew 6:15. The WEB has it.

Important: Forgiving does not mean approving of wrong or staying with someone who hurts you. Forgiveness often needs time.

The question about Jesus' authority VERSES 27–33

27 They came to Jerusalem again.
Jesus was walking around in the temple.
Then the chief priests, the scribes and the elders came to him.
28 They began to ask him,
"What right do you have to do these things?
Who gave you the authority
to do these things?"
29 Jesus said to them,
"I will ask you one question.
Answer me.
Then I will tell you
by what authority I do these things.
30 The baptism of John:
Did it come from heaven, or from people?
Answer me!"
31 They talked it over with each other.
They said,
"If we say, 'From heaven,'
he will say,
'Then why did you not believe John?'
32 But if we say, 'From people' ..."
They were afraid of the people.
For everyone believed that John really was a prophet.
33 So they answered Jesus,
"We do not know."
Then Jesus said to them,
"Then I will not tell you either
by what authority I do these things."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The leaders of the temple ask: Who gives you the right to act like this in the temple?

Jesus answers with a counter-question. That was a common way for Jewish teachers to discuss things.

"From heaven" means: from God. John had pointed to Jesus. Whoever accepts John as God's messenger would also have to accept Jesus.

The leaders do not want to commit themselves. Even so, the answer is clear: Jesus' authority comes from God.

MARK

CHAPTER 12

Debates in the temple and the greatest commandment

The parable of the wicked farmers VERSES 1–12

1 Jesus began to speak to them in parables.
A parable is a story that teaches something.
He said, "A man planted a vineyard.
He put a hedge around it.
He dug a pit for the winepress.
And he built a watchtower.
Then he rented the vineyard out to a farmer
and went to another country.
2 When harvest time came,
he sent a servant to the farmer.
The servant was to get the owner's share of the grapes from the farmer.
3 But the farmers grabbed the servant.
They beat him
and sent him away with nothing.
4 Then the owner sent another servant to them.
They threw stones at him
and hurt him on the head.
They treated him shamefully and sent him away.
5 The owner sent another servant.
They killed him.
It was the same with many others:
Some they beat,
and some they killed.
6 The owner still had one person left to send:
his son, whom he loved.
He sent him to them last.
He said,
'They will respect my son.'
7 But the farmers said to each other,
'This is the one who will get the vineyard someday.
Come, let's kill him.
Then the vineyard will be ours!'
8 They grabbed him and killed him.
They threw him out of the vineyard.
9 So what will the owner of the vineyard do?
He will come
and kill the farmers.
And he will give the vineyard to others.
10 Haven't you read this Scripture?
'The stone that the builders rejected
has become the head of the corner.
11 The Lord did this.
It is wonderful in our eyes.'"
12 The leaders wanted to arrest Jesus.
But they were afraid of the crowd.
They understood

that he had told the parable against them.
So they left him and went away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The parable reminds us of the "song of the vineyard" in the prophet Isaiah (Isaiah 5:1–7). There the vineyard is the people of Israel, which God planted with love.

The servants are the prophets whom God sent again and again. The "beloved son" is Jesus himself (compare 1:11 and 9:7). Jesus announces his death again.

Verses 10–11 quote Psalm 118:22–23. The rejected stone becomes the most important stone. The head of the corner (verse 10) is the cornerstone, which holds the building together. Christians see this as a picture of Jesus: rejected, killed and raised by God.

Verse 12: The leaders realize that Jesus means them. The people, on the other hand, are on his side.

Very important: For a long time Christians interpreted this parable to mean that God had rejected the Jewish people. That is wrong and helped cause much hatred of Jews. What is meant are the leaders who reject Jesus. Paul writes: God has not rejected his people (Romans 11:1–2, 29).

The violence in the parable is a warning, not permission for revenge or violence.

The question about the tax for Caesar VERSES 13–17

13 They sent some Pharisees and some Herodians to Jesus.
They wanted to trap him with his own words.
14 They came and said to him,
"Teacher, we know that you are honest.
You do not care what anyone thinks of you.
You do not treat anyone better than others.
You truly teach God's way.
Is it right to pay taxes to Caesar, or not?
15 Should we pay, or should we not pay?"
But Jesus knew that they were only pretending.
He said to them,
"Why are you trying to trap me?
Bring me a denarius.
I want to look at it."
A denarius was a silver coin.
16 They brought one.
He said to them,
"Whose picture and whose name are on this coin?"
They said to him,
"Caesar's."
17 Jesus answered them,
"Give to Caesar what belongs to Caesar.
And give to God what belongs to God."
They were very amazed at him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Caesar was the title of the Roman emperor.

The trap: If Jesus says yes, pay, he angers the people who suffer under the Romans. If he says no, he can be reported to the Romans as a rebel.

On the denarius there was the picture of the emperor. Jesus says: Give the emperor the coin with his picture. But give God what belongs to God. And human beings are created in God's image (Genesis 1:27). So the whole person belongs to God.

For today: Christians should pay taxes and respect the state. But no state stands above God. Where a state demands injustice, we must obey God rather than people (Acts 5:29).

Told in more detail in Matthew 22:15–22.

The question about the resurrection VERSES 18–27

18 Then some Sadducees came to Jesus.
They say that the dead do not rise again.
They asked him,
19 "Teacher, Moses wrote this for us:
'A man's brother may die
and leave a wife behind,
but no children.
Then the man must marry his brother's wife.
He must have children for his brother.'
20 There were seven brothers.
The first one got married.
He died without having children.
21 The second brother married her.
He also died without having children.
It was the same with the third brother.
22 All seven brothers married her.
None of them had children.
Last of all, the woman died too.
23 When the dead rise again,
whose wife will she be?
All seven brothers were married to her."
24 Jesus answered them,
"You are wrong.
You do not know the Scriptures,
and you do not know the power of God.
25 When the dead rise again,
they do not marry,
and they are not given to anyone in marriage.
They are like the angels in heaven.
26 But now about the dead rising again:
Haven't you read in the book of Moses
the story about the bush?
There God said to Moses,
'I am the God of Abraham,
the God of Isaac,
and the God of Jacob.'
27 He is not the God of the dead,
but of the living.
You are very wrong."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Sadducees were a group mostly from the leading priestly families. They did not believe in the resurrection. The Pharisees, on the other hand, believed in it, just as Jesus did.

Verse 19: The law about a brother marrying his dead brother's widow is in Deuteronomy 25:5–6. It was meant to protect widows.

The Sadducees tell an exaggerated story to make faith in the resurrection look ridiculous. In it the woman is treated almost like a possession. Jesus says: With God no one belongs to someone else.

Verse 26: The story of the burning bush is in Exodus 3:1–6. God says "I am" (not "I was") the God of Abraham. For God, Abraham, Isaac and Jacob live on.

For today: A comfort for everyone who is grieving for someone: For God, the dead are not lost.

The greatest commandment VERSES 28–34

28 One of the scribes heard them arguing.
He saw that Jesus had given them a good answer.
So he came and asked him,
"Which commandment is the most important of all?"
29 Jesus answered,
"The most important one is:
'Listen, Israel!
The Lord our God, the Lord is one.
30 Love the Lord your God
with all your heart,
with all your soul,
with all your mind
and with all your strength.'
This is the first commandment.
31 The second one is this:
'Love your neighbor as you love yourself.'
No other commandment is more important than these."
32 The scribe said to him,
"That is right, teacher!
What you said is true:
He is one,
and there is no other God but him.
33 We should love him
with all our heart,
with all our understanding,
with all our soul
and with all our strength.
And we should love our neighbor as ourselves.
That is more important than all burnt offerings and sacrifices."
34 Jesus saw
that the man had answered wisely.
He said to him,
"You are not far from God's Kingdom."
After that no one dared
to ask Jesus any more questions.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 29–30 quote Deuteronomy 6:4–5, the "Shema Yisrael" ("Hear, Israel"). Devout Jews still pray this prayer every morning and every evening. It is the most important confession of faith in Judaism. Jesus prays it too.

Verse 31 quotes Leviticus 19:18.

This scene is especially beautiful: A Jewish scribe and Jesus agree. They praise each other. Jesus says: "You are not far from God's Kingdom." Not all scribes were against Jesus.

Verse 33: Like the prophets, the scribe says: Love is more important than sacrifices (compare 1 Samuel 15:22; Hosea 6:6).

For today: This is the heart of faith for Jews and Christians: loving God and loving your neighbor.

Whose son is the Christ? VERSES 35–37

35 Jesus was teaching in the temple.
He said,
"Why do the scribes say
that the Christ is the son of David?
36 David himself said, led by the Holy Spirit:
'The Lord said to my Lord,
"Sit at my right side,
until I put your enemies
under your feet."'
37 So David himself calls him Lord.
How then can he be David's son?"
The common people heard him gladly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 36 quotes Psalm 110:1. The first "Lord" is God, the second "Lord" is the king at God's side.

Jesus asks: If David calls the Messiah "Lord," then the Messiah is more than just his descendant. Christians understand it like this: Jesus is David's son and at the same time God's Son.

Jewish interpreters usually understand the psalm differently, for example as a song about a king of Israel. Both ways of reading it should be treated with respect.

"The common people heard him gladly": The ordinary people were fond of Jesus.

A warning against false piety VERSES 38–40

38 While he was teaching, he said to them,
"Watch out for the scribes!
They like to walk around in long robes.
They like people to greet them in the marketplaces.
39 They like to have the best seats in the synagogues
and the places of honor at feasts.
40 They take away the houses of widows.
And to look good, they pray long prayers.
They will be judged more harshly."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus warns against people who want to look devout but take advantage of the weak.

"They take away the houses of widows": They take from widows everything they own.

Widows were often poor and without protection. According to the Old Testament, God is the special protector of widows and orphans (for example Exodus 22:22–24; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 22:21–23).

Important: Just before this, Jesus praised a scribe (verse 34). So he does not mean all scribes, but those who act like this. This warning applies in every religion, also to pastors, priests and church leaders today.

The offering of the poor widow VERSES 41–44

41 Jesus sat down across from the offering boxes.
He watched
how the people put money into them.
Many rich people put in a lot.
42 Then a poor widow came.
She put in two small brass coins.
Together they were worth one quadrans.
43 Jesus called his disciples to him.
He said to them,
"I tell you the truth:
This poor widow has given more
than all the others who are giving money here.
44 They all gave from what they had left over.
But she is poor, and she gave everything she had.
She gave all she had to live on."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the temple there were offering boxes for donations.
Treasury: here, the place with these offering boxes.

A quadrans was one of the smallest Roman coins. Mark explains this for his readers.

Jesus does not look at the size of the amount, but at the heart. The widow gives everything she has.

Some interpreters read the story together with verse 40: Jesus praises the woman, but he also accuses a system in which poor widows give so much while others take advantage of them.

Important: No one has to give so much that they themselves fall into need. Churches must not pressure poor people to give money.

For today: What counts is not how much someone gives, but with what kind of heart.

MARK

CHAPTER 13

Keep watch!

Jesus announces the destruction of the temple
VERSES 1–2

1 Jesus was going out of the temple.
One of his disciples said to him,
"Teacher, look at these stones!
Look at these buildings!"
2 Jesus said to him,
"Do you see these great buildings?
Not one stone here will be left on top of another.
Every stone will be thrown down."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The temple in Jerusalem was magnificent. King Herod the Great had it enlarged with enormous blocks of stone.

Jesus announces: It will be destroyed. That happened in the year AD 70 through the Romans.

For the Jewish people this was a great catastrophe. To this day Jews remember it on the day of mourning called Tisha B'Av. Jesus is not happy about the destruction.

The beginning of the birth pains VERSES 3–13

3 Later Jesus sat on the Mount of Olives,
across from the temple.
Peter, James, John, and Andrew came to him alone.
They asked him,
4 "Tell us, when will these things happen?
What sign will show
that all these things are about to come true?"
5 Jesus began to answer them.
"Be careful that no one fools you.
6 Many will come and use my name.
They will say, 'I am he!'
And they will fool many people.
7 You will hear about wars.
You will hear news of wars far away.
Don't be afraid.
These things must happen.
But that is not yet the end.
8 One nation will fight against another nation.
One kingdom will fight against another kingdom.
There will be earthquakes in many places.
There will be times of hunger and times of trouble.
These things are only the beginning of the birth pains.
9 But watch out for yourselves.
People will hand you over to the courts.
You will be beaten in the synagogues.
You will stand in front of rulers and kings because of me.
In this way you will tell them about me.
10 First the Good News must be told to all the nations.
11 People will arrest you and hand you over.
Then don't worry ahead of time about what you will say.
Don't plan it.
Just say what God gives you to say at that time.
For it is not you who will speak.
The Holy Spirit will speak.
12 A brother will hand over his brother to be killed.
A father will hand over his child.
Children will turn against their parents
and have them put to death.
13 Everyone will hate you
because you belong to me.
But whoever stays faithful to the end
will be saved."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The disciples ask: When will the temple be destroyed? Jesus answers in detail. His answer is about the destruction of the temple and about the end of time at the same time. That makes this speech hard to understand.

The first and most important message: "Be careful that no one fools you." Jesus warns against false saviors and against people who claim to know exactly when the end will come.

Verses 7–8: There have been wars, earthquakes and famines at all times. Jesus says: Don't be afraid. "Birth pains" are the pains when a baby is born. After the pain, something new comes.

Verse 9: The first Christians were mostly Jews. That is why some of them were punished in synagogues (compare 2 Corinthians 11:24). That was a conflict within Judaism. It is not a judgment on the Jewish people.

Verse 11: A comfort for everyone who stands before a court because of their faith: God's Spirit helps them.

Important for today: Again and again groups have calculated a date for the end of the world and frightened people. Jesus warns against exactly that. Whoever is in a group that puts pressure on people with fear of the end of the world may get help, for example from counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse.

The great distress VERSES 14–23

14 "You will see the 'abomination of desolation'
standing where it does not belong.
Daniel the prophet spoke about it."
(The reader should understand what this means.)

"Then the people in Judea must run away to the mountains.
15 Someone on the roof of a house must not go down.
He must not go into his house to take anything out.
16 Someone in the field must not go back to get his coat.
17 How terrible it will be in those days for women who are pregnant!
How terrible for mothers who are nursing babies!
18 Pray that you will not have to run away in the winter.
19 In those days there will be great suffering.
There has never been suffering like it,
from the time God created the world until now.
And there never will be again.
20 The Lord has made those days shorter.
If he had not done that, no one would be saved.
But he made the days shorter for the sake of his chosen people,
the ones he picked out.
21 At that time someone may say to you,
'Look, here is the Christ!'
or, 'Look, there he is!'
Don't believe it.
22 False christs and false prophets will come.
They will do signs and wonders.
They want to fool even God's chosen people, if that were possible.
23 So watch out!
I have told you everything ahead of time."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: The "abomination of desolation" is an expression from the book of Daniel (Daniel 9:27; 11:31; 12:11). There it means a desecration of the temple by a foreign king. Jesus announces: Something like this will happen again. Many interpreters think of the time around the year AD 70.

"The reader should understand what this means": A note to the readers of the Gospel.

Verses 15–18: When the time comes, people should flee at once. Jesus thinks especially of pregnant women and mothers with small children, for whom fleeing is especially hard.

Verse 20: God puts a limit on suffering. He does not forget the people in distress.

Verses 21–23: Again Jesus warns against false saviors. You should not run after anyone who says: "Look, here is the Christ!"

The coming of the Son of Man VERSES 24–27

24 "In those days, after that time of suffering,
the sun will become dark.
The moon will not give its light.
25 The stars will fall from the sky.
The powers in the heavens will be shaken.
26 Then people will see the Son of Man coming in the clouds
with great power and glory.
27 He will send out his angels.
They will gather his chosen people from all four directions,
from the ends of the earth to the ends of the sky."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 24–25 take up pictures from the prophets (Isaiah 13:10; 34:4). They describe how God steps in and everything changes. It is picture language.

Verse 26 reminds us of Daniel 7:13–14: One like a son of man comes with the clouds of the sky.

Verse 27: At the end God gathers everyone who belongs to him from all over the world.

Christians believe that Jesus will come again. That is a hope, not a threat. In the end God wins, not evil.

The parable of the fig tree VERSES 28–32

28 "Learn this lesson from the fig tree.
When its branches become soft and green
and its leaves come out,
you know that summer is near.
29 It is the same with you.
When you see these things happening,
you know that the time is near.
It is right at the door.
30 I tell you for certain:
This generation will not pass away
before all these things happen.
31 Heaven and earth will pass away.
But my words will never pass away.
32 But no one knows that day or that hour.
Not even the angels in heaven know it.
Not even the Son knows it.
Only the Father knows it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The fig tree loses its leaves in winter. When it gets new ones, everyone knows: Summer will soon be here.

Verse 30 is hard to understand. Many interpreters relate it to the destruction of Jerusalem about 40 years later. There are different interpretations.

Verse 32 is very important: No one knows the day, not even the Son, only God the Father. That is why every calculation of a date for the end of the world is wrong.

Keep watch! VERSES 33–37

33 "Watch out! Stay awake! Pray!
For you don't know when that time will come.
34 It is like a man who went on a trip to another country.
He left his house and put his servants in charge.
He gave each one his own work.
And he told the doorkeeper to keep watch.
35 So keep watch!
For you don't know when the master of the house will come.
It may be in the evening, or at midnight,
or when the rooster crows, or in the morning.
36 He may come suddenly.
Then he must not find you sleeping.
37 What I tell you, I tell everyone:
Keep watch!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 33: The words "and pray" are missing in some old manuscripts. The WEB, our English source text, has them.

Each servant has his task. In the same way, every person has received a task from God.

The four times (evening, midnight, rooster crow, morning) were the four watches of the night used by the Romans. Some interpreters notice: Jesus' passion in Mark 14–15 happens at exactly these times: the Last Supper in the evening, Gethsemane in the night, Peter's denial when the rooster crows, the handing over to Pilate in the morning. And in Gethsemane the disciples sleep.

"Keeping watch" does not mean being anxious. It means: living every day in such a way that you could meet God. Doing good, being honest, loving others.

Verse 37: This is not only for the disciples back then, but for everyone, including us today.

MARK

CHAPTER 14

The Lord's Supper, Gethsemane, and the night of the arrest

The plan against Jesus VERSES 1–2

1 It was now two days before the Passover
and the Feast of Unleavened Bread.
The chief priests and the scribes
were looking for a way
to arrest Jesus by a trick and kill him.
2 For they said,
"Not during the feast,
so that there won't be a riot among the people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Passover (Pesach) recalls how Israel was freed from Egypt (Exodus 12). For a week people eat bread without yeast (matzah).

A small group of leaders makes plans against Jesus. The people are more on his side, so the leaders are afraid of a riot.

Important: It is wrong to blame "the Jews" for the death of Jesus.

A woman anoints Jesus VERSES 3–9

3 Jesus was in Bethany,
in the house of Simon the leper.
As he was sitting at the table,
a woman came.
She had an alabaster jar
of ointment of pure nard, very costly.
She broke the jar
and poured the ointment over his head.
4 But some of the people there were angry and said to one another,
"Why has this ointment been wasted?
5 It could have been sold for more than 300 denarii,
and the money given to the poor."
And they grumbled at her.
6 But Jesus said,
"Leave her alone!
Why are you troubling her?
She has done a good thing for me.
7 For you always have the poor with you,
and whenever you want to,
you can do them good.
But you will not always have me.
8 She has done what she could.
She has anointed my body ahead of time for the burial.
9 Most certainly I tell you,
wherever this Good News is preached
throughout the whole world,
what this woman has done will also be told
in memory of her."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nard oil was made from a plant from the faraway Himalayas. It was very expensive. The 300 denarii were about the wages for a whole year of work.

The woman anoints Jesus like a king. "Christ" means "the Anointed One." She has understood what the disciples do not yet understand: Jesus will soon die.

Verse 7: Jesus is not saying that the poor are unimportant. He reminds us of Deuteronomy 15:11: Because there will always be poor people, you shall help them. "Whenever you want to, you can do them good" (14:7) is only in Mark.

Verse 9: Jesus promises that this woman will be remembered everywhere. In Mark her name is not given.

Judas wants to betray Jesus VERSES 10–11

10 Judas Iscariot, one of the Twelve,
went to the chief priests
to hand Jesus over to them.
11 When they heard it,
they were glad
and promised to give him money.
And he looked for a good opportunity
to hand him over.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mark does not say why Judas betrays Jesus.

Very important: In many languages the name "Judas" sounds like the word for "Jew." For centuries Christians used Judas as a picture for "the Jews." That was wrong and caused great injustice. All 12 disciples were Jews, and so was Jesus himself.

The Passover meal is prepared VERSES 12–16

12 On the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread,
when the Passover lamb was sacrificed,
his disciples asked him,
"Where do you want us to go
and prepare the Passover meal for you?"
13 He sent two of his disciples
and said to them,
"Go into the city.
There a man carrying a jar of water
will meet you.
Follow him.
14 And wherever he goes in,
say to the owner of the house,
'The Teacher says,

"Where is the guest room,
where I may eat the Passover with my disciples?"'
15 He himself will show you a large upper room,
furnished and ready.
Get things ready for us there."
16 The disciples went out
and came into the city.
They found everything just as he had told them,
and they prepared the Passover meal.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

On the afternoon before the feast the Passover lambs were sacrificed in the temple. In the evening people ate them with their family or with friends.

A man carrying a jar of water stood out, because usually women carried the water.

Some interpreters think Jesus had prepared this secretly, so that Judas could not betray the place ahead of time. That is a guess.

The last meal VERSES 17–21

17 When it was evening,
he came with the Twelve.
18 As they were sitting at the table and eating,
Jesus said,
"Most certainly I tell you,
one of you will betray me,
one who is eating with me."
19 They became sad
and began to ask him one after another,
"Surely not I?"
And another said,
"Surely not I?"
20 He answered them,
"It is one of the Twelve,
the one who dips into the dish with me.
21 For the Son of Man is going his way,
as it is written about him.
But how terrible it will be for that man
through whom the Son of Man is betrayed!
It would be better for that man
if he had not been born."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eating together was a sign of friendship and trust. That makes the betrayal all the more painful. This reminds us of Psalm 41:9 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 41:10). There someone complains that even his close friend, who ate his bread with him, has lifted his heel against him. That means: He has turned against me.

All the disciples ask: "Surely not I?" Each one knows that he can be weak.

Verse 19: The words "And another said" are missing in many old manuscripts. The WEB has them.

The Lord's Supper VERSES 22–26

22 As they were eating,
Jesus took bread,
blessed it,
broke it,
gave it to them, and said,
"Take, eat.
This is my body."
23 Then he took the cup,
gave thanks,
and gave it to them.
And they all drank from it.
24 He said to them,
"This is my blood of the new covenant,
which is poured out for many.
25 Most certainly I tell you,
I will no longer drink of the fruit of the vine
until that day
when I drink it new in God's Kingdom."
26 When they had sung a hymn,
they went out to the Mount of Olives.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here begins what Christians still celebrate today: the Lord's Supper, also called the Eucharist or Holy Communion.

Jesus takes bread and wine from the Passover meal and gives them a new meaning: His body and his blood are given for people.

Christians understand this in different ways. Catholic and Orthodox Christians believe that the bread and wine really become the body and blood of Christ. Lutheran Christians believe that Christ is present in, with and under the bread and wine. Reformed and many other Protestant Christians understand it more as a sign and a remembrance, in which Christ is spiritually present.

Covenant: a binding agreement, a promise of faithfulness between God and people.

Verse 24: "My blood of the new covenant" reminds us of Exodus 24:8. The word "new" is missing in some old manuscripts. The WEB has it. The new covenant reminds us of Jeremiah 31:31–34.

Important: The new covenant does not cancel God's covenant with Israel. God stays faithful to his people (Romans 11:29).

Verse 26: At the Passover meal people sing psalms, the "Hallel psalms" (Psalms 113–118).

Jesus predicts that Peter will deny him VERSES 27–31

27 Jesus said to them,
"Tonight all of you will fall away because of me.
For it is written,
'I will strike the shepherd,
and the sheep will be scattered.'
28 But after I am raised up,
I will go ahead of you into Galilee."
29 But Peter said to him,
"Even if all fall away,
I will not!"
30 Jesus said to him,
"Most certainly I tell you,
today, this very night,
before the rooster crows twice,
you will deny me three times."
31 But he said all the more strongly,
"If I must die with you,
I will not deny you."
They all said the same thing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 27 quotes Zechariah 13:7.

Jesus knows that his friends will leave him alone. But already now he promises: After the resurrection we will see each other again.

Only Mark says: "before the rooster crows twice."

Jesus prays in Gethsemane VERSES 32–42

32 They came to a place
called Gethsemane.
He said to his disciples,
"Sit here
while I pray."
33 He took Peter, James, and John with him.
And he began to be deeply troubled and distressed.
34 He said to them,
"My soul is so sad that I could die.
Stay here and keep watch."
35 He went a little farther,
fell on the ground,
and prayed
that, if it were possible,
the hour might pass away from him.
36 He said,
"Abba, Father,
all things are possible to you.
Please take this cup away from me.
But not what I want,
but what you want."
37 He came back
and found them sleeping.
He said to Peter,
"Simon, are you sleeping?
Couldn't you keep watch for one hour?
38 Watch and pray,
so that you don't fall into temptation.
The spirit indeed is willing,
but the flesh is weak."
39 Again he went away
and prayed, saying the same words.
40 When he came back,
he found them sleeping again,
for their eyes were very heavy.
And they didn't know what to answer him.
41 He came the third time
and said to them,
"Sleep on now,
and take your rest.
It is enough.
The hour has come.
The Son of Man is betrayed into the hands of sinners.
42 Get up! Let's go.
The one who betrays me is here."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gethsemane means "oil press." It was a garden with olive trees on the Mount of Olives.

Jesus is deeply shaken and very afraid. He throws himself on the ground. Here we see him as completely human.

"Abba" is Aramaic and means "Father." It is a trusting way of speaking, the way a child speaks to his father. Here only Mark keeps this word.

Jesus prays honestly: "Please take this cup away from me." But he entrusts himself to God: "Not what I want, but what you want."

For today: Jesus, too, was afraid. Fear and despair are not signs of weak faith. Whoever has great fear or dark thoughts should not stay alone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The disciples sleep. Jesus is disappointed, but he understands: "The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak."

Jesus is arrested VERSES 43–52

43 Immediately, while he was still speaking,
Judas, one of the Twelve, came.
With him came a crowd with swords and clubs,
sent by the chief priests,
the scribes, and the elders.
44 The betrayer had given them a sign:
"The one I kiss is the man.
Arrest him,
and lead him away under guard!"
45 When he came,
he went straight to Jesus and said,
"Rabbi! Rabbi!"
And he kissed him.
46 Then they laid their hands on him
and arrested him.
47 But one of those who were standing by
drew his sword,
struck the servant of the high priest,
and cut off his ear.
48 Jesus said to them,
"Have you come out with swords and clubs to arrest me,
as if I were a robber?
49 Every day I was with you in the temple teaching,
and you didn't arrest me.
But this has happened so that the Scriptures might be fulfilled."
50 They all left him and fled.
51 A young man was following him.
He was wearing only a linen cloth around his naked body.
The young men grabbed him.
52 But he left the linen cloth behind
and ran away from them naked.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In those days a kiss was a normal greeting, also from students to their teacher. Judas misuses this sign of friendship.

Verse 47: Mark does not say who drew the sword. In John 18:10 it is Peter. In Matthew, Jesus says about it: "All those who take the sword will die by the sword" (Matthew 26:52). Jesus does not want violence.

Verse 50: All the disciples flee. Jesus is completely alone.

Verses 51–52 are told only by Mark. No one knows who this young man was. Some think it was Mark himself. But that is not certain. The scene shows: Everyone abandons Jesus, so quickly that one even leaves his clothing behind.

Jesus before the Council VERSES 53–65

53 They led Jesus away to the high priest.
All the chief priests, the elders, and the scribes
came together with him.
54 Peter had followed him at a distance
right into the courtyard of the high priest.
He was sitting with the guards
and warming himself at the fire.
55 The chief priests and the whole council
were looking for witnesses against Jesus,
so that they could put him to death.
But they found none.
56 For many gave false testimony against him,
but their testimony did not agree.
57 Some stood up
and gave false testimony against him:
58 "We heard him say,
'I will destroy this temple
that is made with hands,
and in three days I will build another
made without hands.'"
59 But even so their testimony did not agree.
60 Then the high priest stood up in the middle
and asked Jesus,
"Have you no answer?
What is this that these men are saying against you?"
61 But he stayed silent
and answered nothing.
Again the high priest asked him,
"Are you the Christ,
the Son of the Blessed?"
62 Jesus said,
"I am.
And you will see the Son of Man
sitting at the right hand of Power
and coming with the clouds of the sky."
63 Then the high priest tore his clothes and said,
"Why do we need any more witnesses?
64 You have heard the blasphemy!
What do you think?"
And they all condemned him
as deserving death.
65 Some began
to spit on him,
to cover his face,
to beat him with their fists,
and to say to him,
"Prophesy!"
And the guards slapped him in the face.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Council was the highest Jewish authority in Jerusalem.

Mark tells us that the trial was not fair. The witnesses contradict each other. According to the Law of Moses, two witnesses must agree (Deuteronomy 19:15).

Verse 61: "The Blessed" is a respectful way of speaking about God. Out of reverence, devout Jews avoid saying the name of God.

Verse 62: In Mark, Jesus answers very clearly: "I am." For the first time he says in public who he is. He combines Psalm 110:1 and Daniel 7:13.

Blasphemy: speaking against God or insulting God.

Very important: Here a particular group of leaders acts on a particular night. The Jewish people as a whole were not involved. In 1965 the Catholic Church declared in the document *Nostra Aetate*: The suffering of Jesus may not be blamed on all the Jews living then, nor on the Jews of today. Protestant churches have also said this clearly.

Verse 65: Jesus is mocked and beaten. He does not fight back.

Peter denies Jesus VERSES 66–72

66 Peter was below in the courtyard.
One of the servant girls of the high priest came.
67 She saw Peter warming himself,
looked at him, and said,
"You were also with the Nazarene, Jesus!"
68 But he denied it and said,
"I neither know nor understand what you are saying."
He went out onto the porch,
and the rooster crowed.
69 The servant girl saw him
and began again to say to those who were standing
there,
"This man is one of them."
70 But he denied it again.
A little while later those standing there said to Peter
again,
"You really are one of them.
For you are a Galilean,
and your speech shows it."
71 But he began
to curse and to swear,
"I don't know this man
you are talking about!"
72 Then the rooster crowed the second time.
Peter remembered the words
that Jesus had said to him:
"Before the rooster crows twice,
you will deny me three times."
And when he thought about that, he wept.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

While inside Jesus bravely tells the truth, outside Peter says three times: I don't know him.

Verse 68: The words "and the rooster crowed" are missing in some old manuscripts. In verse 70 the words "and your speech shows it" are also missing in some manuscripts. The WEB has both.

Peter came from Galilee. People could tell that from the way he spoke, just as people recognize accents today.

Verse 72: Peter weeps. He sees his failure.

According to an old tradition, Peter was an important witness for the Gospel of Mark. If so, he did not keep quiet about this embarrassing story about himself.

For today: Even someone who has failed can make a new start. Jesus did not give up on Peter (16:7). Whoever feels very bad because of their own guilt may talk with someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Chapter 15

Jesus is crucified

Jesus before Pilate VERSES 1–15

1 Immediately, early in the morning,
the chief priests held a meeting
with the elders, the scribes,
and the whole council.
They tied Jesus up,
led him away,
and handed him over to Pilate.
2 Pilate asked him,
"Are you the King of the Jews?"
He answered,
"So you say."
3 The chief priests accused him of many things.
4 Pilate asked him again,
"Have you no answer?
See how many things they are saying against you!"
5 But Jesus made no further answer,
so that Pilate was amazed.
6 At the feast he used to release one prisoner to them,
whomever they asked for.
7 There was a man called Barabbas.
He was in prison with his fellow rebels,
men who had committed murder in the uprising.
8 The crowd, crying aloud,
began to ask him
to do as he always did for them.
9 Pilate answered them,
"Do you want me to release to you the King of the Jews?"
10 For he saw
that the chief priests had handed him over out of envy.
11 But the chief priests stirred up the crowd
to have him release Barabbas to them instead.
12 Pilate asked them again,
"Then what should I do with the one
you call the King of the Jews?"
13 They shouted again,
"Crucify him!"
14 Pilate said to them,
"Why, what evil has he done?"
But they shouted all the louder,
"Crucify him!"
15 Pilate wanted to please the crowd.
So he released Barabbas to them.
But he had Jesus flogged
and handed him over to be crucified.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Pontius Pilate was the Roman governor of Judea from about AD 26 to 36. Only he could have a death sentence carried out. Other sources from this time describe him as a harsh and cruel ruler.

For the Romans, "King of the Jews" was a political charge: Anyone who called himself king without the emperor's permission was considered a rebel.

Verse 8: The WEB says "crying aloud." Instead, many old manuscripts say that the crowd came up.

Verse 11: The crowd is stirred up by some leaders. It is a particular crowd on a particular morning.

Flogged: beaten hard with a whip.

Verse 15: Pilate knows that Jesus is innocent. Even so, he condemns him in order to please the crowd. He bears the responsibility for the sentence. The Christian creed says that Jesus suffered under Pontius Pilate.

Very important: For centuries Christians held "the Jews" responsible for the death of Jesus. That is wrong and led to persecution and murder, all the way to the Holocaust. Crucifixion was a Roman punishment. In 1965 the Catholic Church in *Nostra Aetate*, and the Protestant churches too, clearly declared: The death of Jesus may not be blamed on all the Jews of that time, nor on the Jews of today.

The soldiers mock Jesus VERSES 16–20

16 The soldiers led him away into the courtyard,
that is, the Praetorium, the governor's headquarters.
They called together the whole company of soldiers.
17 They dressed him in purple.
They twisted together a crown of thorns
and put it on him.
18 Then they began to salute him,
"Hail, King of the Jews!"
19 They hit him on the head with a reed,
spat on him,
knelt down,
and bowed before him to mock him.
20 When they had mocked him,
they took the purple cloak off him
and put his own clothes back on him.
Then they led him out
to crucify him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Purple was the color of kings. The Roman soldiers dress Jesus up as a king to make fun of him.

Jesus is humiliated, beaten and mocked. He suffers torture.

For today: Jesus stands by all people who are humiliated, tortured or abused.

The crucifixion VERSES 21–32

21 A man was passing by,
coming in from the country:
Simon of Cyrene,
the father of Alexander and Rufus.
They forced him
to go with them and carry Jesus' cross.
22 They brought Jesus to the place
called Golgotha,
which means "The place of a skull."
23 They offered him wine mixed with myrrh to drink.
But he didn't take it.
24 They crucified him
and divided his clothes among them.

They cast lots for them
to decide what each one should take.
25 It was the third hour
when they crucified him.
26 Above him was written the charge against him:
"THE KING OF THE JEWS."
27 With him they crucified two robbers,
one on his right and one on his left.
28 So the Scripture was fulfilled which says,
"He was counted with transgressors."
29 Those who passed by
insulted him.
They shook their heads and said,
"Ha! You who destroy the temple
and build it in three days,
30 save yourself,
and come down from the cross!"
31 In the same way the chief priests also mocked him
among themselves, together with the scribes, and
said,
"He saved others.
He can't save himself.
32 Let the Christ, the King of Israel,
come down from the cross now,
so that we may see and believe him."
Those who were crucified with him
also insulted him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Cyrene was a city in North Africa. Many Jews lived there. Only Mark names Simon's sons, Alexander and Rufus. The first readers probably knew them. A Rufus is also mentioned in Romans 16:13. Whether it is the same man, no one knows.

Golgotha (Aramaic) means "skull." At that time the place was outside the city wall.

Verse 23: Wine mixed with myrrh was perhaps meant to dull the pain. Jesus refuses it.

Casting lots: a way of deciding something by chance, a bit like rolling dice.

Verse 24 reminds us of Psalm 22:18 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 22:19).

Verse 25: The third hour is about 9 in the morning.

Verse 28 is missing in the best old manuscripts. It quotes Isaiah 53:12. The WEB has it. Transgressors: people who break the law, criminals.

Crucifixion was the cruelest death penalty of the Romans, mainly for slaves and rebels.

Verse 31: Again it is certain leaders who mock him, not the whole people.

Jesus dies VERSES 33–41

33 When the sixth hour had come,
there was darkness over the whole land
until the ninth hour.
34 At the ninth hour
Jesus cried out with a loud voice,
"Eloi, Eloi, lama sabachthani?"
which means,
"My God, my God,
why have you forsaken me?"
35 Some of those standing there
heard it and said,
"Look, he is calling Elijah."
36 Someone ran,
filled a sponge with vinegar,
put it on a reed,
gave it to him to drink,
and said,
"Leave him alone!
Let's see
whether Elijah comes to take him down."
37 Jesus cried out with a loud voice
and gave up the spirit.
38 The curtain of the temple was torn in two
from top to bottom.
39 The centurion was standing there opposite him.
When he saw
that he cried out like this and breathed his last,
he said,
"Truly this man was the Son of God!"
40 There were also women
watching from a distance.
Among them were Mary Magdalene,
Mary the mother of James the less and of Joses,
and Salome.
41 When he was in Galilee,
they had followed him and served him.
And there were many other women
who had come up with him to Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The sixth hour is about 12 noon, the ninth about 3 in the afternoon. Three hours of darkness in broad daylight.

Verse 34: "Eloi, Eloi ..." is Aramaic, Jesus' native language. It is the beginning of Psalm 22 (Psalm 22:1; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 22:2). This psalm begins with a lament, but ends with trust and praise of God.

Forsaken: left completely alone, abandoned.

Jesus feels the deepest pain, including the feeling of being abandoned by God. That is why we, too, may lament to God like this. Whoever feels abandoned by God is not alone. Jesus knows this feeling.

Verse 38: The curtain separated the Most Holy Place in the temple. Christians understand its tearing like this: Through Jesus' death the way to God is open for everyone.

Verse 39: A centurion is a Roman officer in charge of about 100 soldiers. This verse is the high point of the Gospel of Mark. The whole time the question was: Who is Jesus? Now a Roman officer, a non-Jew, says it at the cross: "Truly this man was the Son of God!" At the beginning these words stood in the title (1:1) and at the baptism (1:11).

Verses 40–41: The disciples have fled. But the women stay. They are faithful disciples who have followed Jesus for a long time and served him.

Jesus is buried VERSES 42–47

42 It was already evening.
It was the Preparation Day,
that is, the day before the Sabbath.
43 So Joseph of Arimathaea came.
He was a respected member of the council.
He too was waiting for God's Kingdom.

He boldly went to Pilate
and asked for Jesus' body.
44 Pilate was surprised to hear
that he was already dead.
He called the centurion
and asked him
whether he had been dead long.
45 When he found out from the centurion,
he gave the body to Joseph.
46 Joseph bought a linen cloth,
took Jesus down from the cross,
and wrapped him in the linen cloth.
He laid him in a tomb
that had been cut out of a rock.
Then he rolled a stone against the entrance of the tomb.
47 Mary Magdalene and Mary the mother of Joses
saw where he was laid.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The "Preparation Day" was Friday, when everything was prepared for the Sabbath. The Sabbath begins on Friday evening at sunset. That is why the burial had to happen quickly.

According to Jewish law, someone who had been executed was to be buried on the same day (Deuteronomy 21:22–23).

Joseph of Arimathaea was a Jewish member of the Council. He shows: Not all the leaders were against Jesus. He is brave, because it was dangerous to stand up for someone who had been crucified.

Verse 44: Pilate is surprised, because people who were crucified often died only after days. The centurion confirms: Jesus is really dead.

Verse 47: The women see where Jesus is buried. That is why on Easter morning they find the right tomb.

MARK

CHAPTER 16

He has risen!

The empty tomb VERSES 1–8

1 When the Sabbath was over,
Mary Magdalene,
Mary the mother of James,
and Salome
bought spices,
so that they could go and anoint Jesus.
2 Very early on the first day of the week
they came to the tomb,
when the sun had risen.
3 They were saying to one another,
"Who will roll away the stone from the entrance of the tomb for us?"
4 For it was very big.
When they looked up,
they saw
that the stone had already been rolled back.
5 They went into the tomb
and saw a young man
sitting on the right side.
He was dressed in a white robe.
And they were very alarmed.
6 He said to them,
"Don't be alarmed!
You are looking for Jesus, the Nazarene,
who was crucified.
He has risen!
He is not here.
See the place
where they laid him!
7 But go,
tell his disciples and Peter,
'He is going ahead of you into Galilee.
There you will see him,
as he told you.'"
8 They went out
and fled from the tomb.
For trembling and astonishment had taken hold of them.
And they said nothing to anyone,
for they were afraid.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The women who were at the cross (15:40) and had seen where Jesus was buried (15:47) now come to the tomb. With spices and oils they want to pay him their last respects.

The "first day of the week" is Sunday. That is why Christians celebrate Sunday. Easter is the most important feast of Christians.

The women are the first to hear: "He has risen!"

Verse 7: "And Peter": Only Mark mentions Peter separately here. Peter of all people, who denied Jesus three times, is to know: Jesus wants to see him again. He has not been written off.

Verse 8: The women flee, full of fear, and say nothing to anyone. That is a surprising ending.

In the oldest and most important manuscripts the Gospel of Mark ends here with verse 8. Many scholars think: This is how Mark originally ended. The open ending invites the readers: Now it is your turn to pass on the good news. Others think the original ending has been lost.

Because the ending is so sudden, later copyists added endings. There is a short ending and a long ending. The WEB has the long ending (verses 9–20). It follows here, as in the WEB.

The long ending: Jesus appears VERSES 9–14

9 When Jesus had risen early on the first day of the week,
he appeared first to Mary Magdalene.
He had cast seven demons out of her.
10 She went
and told those who had been with him,
as they were mourning and weeping.

11 When they heard
that he was alive
and that she had seen him,
they did not believe it.
12 After this he appeared in another form
to two of them
as they were walking on their way into the country.
13 They went
and told it to the others.
But they didn't believe them either.
14 Later he appeared to the Eleven themselves
as they were sitting at the table.
He rebuked them for their unbelief
and hardness of heart,
because they hadn't believed those
who had seen him after he had risen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9–20 are missing in the oldest complete manuscripts, for example the Codex Sinaiticus and the Codex Vaticanus from the 4th century. They were probably added in the 2nd century. Even so, the church accepted them as part of the Bible. Many Bibles print them in brackets or with a note.

This ending sums up appearances that are also told in other Gospels: the meeting with Mary Magdalene (John 20:11–18), the two disciples on the way (Luke 24:13–35) and the appearance to the Eleven (Luke 24:36–43).

Verse 9: Mary Magdalene is the first witness of the risen Jesus. "Seven demons" probably means a severe illness or great suffering (compare Luke 8:2). It does not mean that she was a bad woman. The old idea that Mary Magdalene was a prostitute is not in the Bible.

The disciples do not believe at first. Doubt is human. Even the first disciples had to find their way to faith.

The long ending: The commission VERSES 15–18

15 He said to them,
"Go into all the world
and preach the Good News to the whole creation.
16 Whoever believes and is baptized
will be saved.
But whoever does not believe
will be condemned.
17 These signs will go with those
who believe:
In my name they will cast out demons.
They will speak with new languages.
18 They will pick up snakes.
And if they drink anything deadly,
it will in no way hurt them.
They will lay hands on the sick,
and they will get well."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: The good news is meant for all people in the whole world.

Verse 16: A serious word. Christians understand it in different ways. Many stress: God alone judges people. God is merciful and wants all people to be saved (1 Timothy 2:4). No one should use this verse to frighten or condemn other people.

"New languages" reminds us of Pentecost (Acts 2:4). Acts 28:3–6 tells how Paul was bitten by a snake and was not harmed.

Very important: Verse 18 is not a call to test God! Some groups have handled poisonous snakes or drunk poison to prove their faith. People have died doing this. In the wilderness Jesus himself said: "Do not test the Lord your God" (Matthew 4:7). That means: You should not put God to the test. Please never do anything like this. In case of poisoning, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK) at once, or Poison Control at 1-800-222-1222 in the US. In the UK, call 999 or NHS 111.

Whoever is sick may pray and should go to the doctor. Both belong together. If someone does not get well, it is not because they believed too little.

The long ending: Jesus is taken up into heaven VERSES 19–20

19 After the Lord had spoken to them,
he was taken up into heaven
and sat down at the right hand of God.
20 They went out
and preached everywhere.
The Lord worked with them
and confirmed the word
by the signs that went with it.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: Jesus is taken up to God. "At the right hand of God" is a picture for the place of honor. It reminds us of Psalm 110:1. Christians celebrate this on Ascension Day, 40 days after Easter (compare Acts 1:9–11).

Verse 20: The disciples are not alone. The Lord works with them.

After verse 8 some manuscripts have a short ending. It reports in two sentences: The women told Peter and the others everything. After that, Jesus sent out through the disciples the message of eternal salvation into the whole world, from east to west. The WEB does not have this short ending in the text.

Looking back: What have we read in the Gospel of Mark?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Fast and lively: Mark tells his story briefly and in a lively way. His favorite word is "immediately." He does not begin with the birth, but right away with John the Baptizer and the baptism of Jesus (Chapter 1).

Who is Jesus? That is the big question of the whole book. The people are amazed, the opponents argue, the disciples do not understand for a long time. In the middle of the book Peter confesses: "You are the Christ" (8:29). And at the cross a Roman officer says: "Truly this man was the Son of God!" (15:39).

Jesus acts: Mark tells about many healings. Jesus touches lepers, raises up the sick, gives people back their dignity. He is moved by people's need, for example by the father who cries out: "I believe. Help my unbelief!" (9:24).

The way of serving: Three times Jesus announces his suffering. And he says: "Even the Son of Man did not come to be served. He came to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (10:45).

Honest disciples: The disciples often don't understand, argue about who is the greatest, sleep in Gethsemane and flee. Peter denies Jesus. Mark tells this honestly. And yet Jesus does not give up on them (16:7).

Faithful women: The women stay at the cross, see the tomb and are the first to hear the message: "He has risen!"

Important note: The debates in Mark were arguments within Judaism. Jesus and all the disciples were Jews. A Jewish scribe hears from Jesus: "You are not far from God's Kingdom" (12:34). These texts must never be used against Jews.

For today: The open ending in verse 8 asks us: Will we pass on what we have heard?

What comes next? Next comes the Gospel of Luke. It is the longest of the four Gospels. Luke tells especially about how Jesus turns to the poor, to women, to the sick and to outcasts. In Luke we find the Christmas story with the manger in Bethlehem and famous parables like the Good Samaritan and the lost son.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 42 OF 66

LUKE

24 CHAPTERS

LUKE

CHAPTER 1

Two children are announced

BEFORE WE BEGIN: THE GOSPEL OF LUKE

The Gospel of Luke is the longest of the four Gospels. It is the first part of a two-part work. The second part is the Book of Acts. Both books are addressed to a man named Theophilus.

According to old church tradition, it was written by Luke, a doctor and companion of the apostle Paul (Colossians 4:14; Philemon 24). We do not know this for sure. The book does not name its author. It was probably written between AD 80 and 90.

Luke writes carefully and in a well-ordered way. As he says himself, he did research first (1:1–4). He probably knew the Gospel of Mark and other traditions as well.

Luke especially shows: Jesus turns to the poor, the sick, women, sinners and foreigners. God's salvation is for all people.

Many famous texts are found only in Luke: the Christmas story with the manger and the shepherds, the Magnificat (the song of Mary), the parables of the Good Samaritan and the lost son, the story of Zacchaeus and the disciples on the road to Emmaus.

Important note: Luke begins and ends in the temple in Jerusalem. The story of Jesus is deeply rooted in the history and faith of Israel. Debates with other Jewish groups were arguments within Judaism. They must never be used against Jews.

The Gospel has 24 chapters.

A foreword to Theophilus VERSES 1–4

1 Many have already tried
to write an account of the events
that have been fulfilled among us.
2 They wrote it down
just as it was handed on to us
by those who from the beginning were eyewitnesses
and servants of the word.
3 So it seemed good to me also
to trace everything carefully from the start
and to write it out for you in order,
most excellent Theophilus.
4 Then you will know
the certainty of the things
you have been taught.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Luke begins like a historian of his time, with a foreword.

He says: There are already other accounts. I have done careful research and talked with eyewitnesses.

Eyewitnesses: people who saw something with their own eyes.

"Theophilus" means "friend of God." He was probably a respected man, perhaps a supporter who had the book copied and shared. The name can also be understood as a way of speaking to all readers who love God.

Luke wants faith to stand on firm ground.

The birth of John is announced VERSES 5–25

5 In the days of Herod, the king of Judea,
there was a priest named Zacharias.
He belonged to the priestly division of Abijah.
His wife was descended from Aaron,
and her name was Elizabeth.
6 They were both righteous before God.
They kept all the commandments and rules of the Lord
and lived blamelessly.
7 But they had no child,
because Elizabeth could not have children.
And they were both very old.
8 One time Zacharias was serving as priest before God,
because it was his division's turn.
9 According to the custom of the priests,
the lot fell to him
to go into the temple of the Lord
and burn incense.
10 The whole crowd of people was praying outside
at the hour of incense.
11 Then an angel of the Lord appeared to him,
standing on the right side of the altar of incense.
12 When Zacharias saw him,
he was troubled,
and fear fell on him.
13 But the angel said to him,
"Don't be afraid, Zacharias,
because your prayer has been heard.
Your wife, Elizabeth, will bear you a son,
and you are to name him John.
14 You will have joy and gladness,
and many will rejoice at his birth.
15 For he will be great in the sight of the Lord.
He will drink no wine and no strong drink.
He will be filled with the Holy Spirit,
even from his mother's womb.
16 He will turn many of the people of Israel
to the Lord their God.
17 He will go before him
in the spirit and power of Elijah,
'to turn the hearts of the fathers to the children,'
and the disobedient to the wisdom of the just.
So he will prepare a people
who are ready for the Lord."
18 Zacharias said to the angel,
"How can I be sure of this?
For I am an old man,
and my wife is very old."
19 The angel answered him,
"I am Gabriel.
I stand in the presence of God.
I was sent

to speak to you
and to bring you this good news.
20 Listen:
You will be silent
and not able to speak
until the day these things happen.
For you didn't believe my words,
which will be fulfilled at the right time."
21 The people were waiting for Zacharias
and were surprised
that he stayed so long in the temple.
22 When he came out,
he could not speak to them.
Then they realized
that he had seen a vision in the temple.
He kept making signs to them
and remained mute.
23 When the days of his service were over,
he went home.
24 After these days his wife Elizabeth became pregnant.
She kept herself hidden for five months
and said,
25 "The Lord has done this for me.
In these days he has looked at me
and taken away my disgrace
among people."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Herod" here is Herod the Great. He ruled until 4 BC.

There were 24 divisions of priests. Each division served one week in the temple twice a year (compare 1 Chronicles 24:10). A priest could usually offer incense only once in his life. For Zacharias this was a special day.

Incense: a substance that gives off a sweet-smelling smoke when it is burned. In the temple it was offered to God.

Zacharias and Elizabeth are devout, righteous Jews. Righteous means: living right before God. Luke begins the Gospel right in the middle of Israel's faith, in the temple.

Verses 7 and 25: Back then, not having children was often seen as a disgrace. Important: Being childless is not a punishment from God and not a disgrace. Elizabeth was "righteous before God" (verse 6), even without a child. People who cannot have the children they long for are loved by God just as much.

Verse 13: "John" means "God is gracious."

Verse 17 quotes Malachi 4:6 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles Malachi 3:24). John will be like the prophet Elijah.

"Gabriel" means "God is strong." He also appears in the Book of Daniel (Daniel 8:16; 9:21).

Verse 20: For a time Zacharias cannot speak. That is a sign in this special story. Important: This does not mean that people who cannot speak are being punished. Being mute or having a disability is not a punishment for doubt.

The birth of Jesus is announced VERSES 26–38

26 In the sixth month
the angel Gabriel was sent from God
to a city of Galilee
named Nazareth,
27 to a virgin.
She was engaged to a man
whose name was Joseph.
He was from the family of David.
The virgin's name was Mary.
28 The angel came in to her and said,
"Rejoice, you highly favored one!
The Lord is with you.
Blessed are you among women!"
29 When she saw him,
she was greatly troubled by what he said.
She wondered
what kind of greeting this might be.
30 The angel said to her,
"Don't be afraid, Mary,
for you have found favor with God.
31 You will become pregnant
and give birth to a son.
You are to name him 'Jesus.'
32 He will be great
and will be called the Son of the Most High.
The Lord God will give him the throne of his father
David.
33 He will reign over the house of Jacob forever.
There will be no end to his Kingdom."
34 Mary said to the angel,
"How can this be,
since I am a virgin?"
35 The angel answered her,
"The Holy Spirit will come on you,
and the power of the Most High will overshadow you.
Therefore the holy one
who is born from you
will also be called the Son of God.
36 And listen:
Elizabeth your relative
has also become pregnant with a son in her old age.
People said she could not have children.
Now she is in her sixth month.
37 For nothing spoken by God
is impossible."
38 Mary said,
"Here I am, the servant of the Lord.
Let it be done to me according to your word."
Then the angel left her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nazareth was a small, unimportant village. Mary was a simple woman, probably still very young. God does not choose the powerful, but the little ones.

Being "engaged" back then was already a firm bond, almost like being married. But the couple did not yet live together.

"Jesus" is the Greek form of the Hebrew name "Yeshua" or "Joshua." It means: "God saves."

Verses 32–33: God had promised David that his kingship would last forever (2 Samuel 7:12–16).

Verses 34–35: Christians believe that Jesus was conceived through the Holy Spirit, without a human father. This is called the "virgin birth." It is in the Christian creed. Some Christians today understand it more as a picture. For everyone it shows: Jesus comes entirely from God.

Overshadow: to cover like a shadow. Here it means that God's power will rest on Mary.

Verse 38: Mary freely says yes. God does not force her. She asks questions and then decides. For Christians, Mary is an

example of faith. In the Catholic and Orthodox churches she is especially honored. Protestant Christians honor her as the mother of Jesus and an example in faith.

Mary visits Elizabeth VERSES 39–45

39 In those days Mary set out
and hurried into the hill country,
to a city of Judah.
40 She went into the house of Zacharias
and greeted Elizabeth.
41 When Elizabeth heard Mary's greeting,
the baby leaped in her womb.
And Elizabeth was filled with the Holy Spirit.
42 She called out with a loud voice,
"Blessed are you among women,
and blessed is the fruit of your womb!
43 Why am I so favored,
that the mother of my Lord should come to me?
44 For when I heard your greeting,
the baby leaped in my womb for joy!
45 Blessed is she who believed!
For what the Lord has told her
will be fulfilled."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Two pregnant women meet: an old one and a young one. Both have experienced something unbelievable with God. They share their joy.

Even before he is born, the baby John "leaped for joy." Later John will point to Jesus.

Womb: the place in a mother's body where a baby grows.

Elizabeth calls Mary "the mother of my Lord." Words from verse 42 are part of the Catholic prayer "Hail Mary."

Verse 45: Mary is called blessed because she believed. This is different from Zacharias (verse 20).

The song of Mary – the Magnificat VERSES 46–56

46 Mary said,
"My soul magnifies the Lord.
47 My spirit has rejoiced in God my Savior,
48 for he has looked at the humble state of his servant.
From now on,
all generations will call me blessed.
49 For he who is mighty has done great things for me.
Holy is his name.
50 His mercy is for generations and generations
on those who fear him.
51 He has shown strength with his arm.
He has scattered the proud
in the plans of their hearts.
52 He has put down princes from their thrones
and has lifted up the lowly.
53 He has filled the hungry with good things.
He has sent the rich away empty.
54 He has helped Israel, his servant,
and remembered his mercy,
55 as he promised our ancestors,
Abraham and his offspring forever."
56 Mary stayed with Elizabeth about three months.
Then she returned home.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The song of Mary is named after its first word in the Latin Bible: "Magnificat" ("magnifies"). To this day it is sung every evening in many churches.

Magnifies: praises, makes great.

The song is very much like the song of Hannah (1 Samuel 2:1–10) and many psalms. Mary prays completely in the language of Israel's faith.

The song is revolutionary: God brings down the powerful and lifts up the lowly. He fills the hungry. God is on the side of the poor and oppressed. This idea runs through the whole Gospel of Luke.

Verses 54–55: God stays faithful to his people Israel, as he promised Abraham.

For today: The Magnificat encourages all who are made to feel small. God sees them.

John is born VERSES 57–66

57 The time came for Elizabeth to give birth,
and she gave birth to a son.
58 Her neighbors and relatives heard
how the Lord had shown her great mercy.
And they rejoiced with her.
59 On the eighth day they came
to circumcise the child.
They wanted to name him after his father: Zacharias.
60 But his mother said,
"Not so!
He will be called John."
61 They said to her,
"There is no one among your relatives
who is called by this name."
62 They made signs to his father
to ask what he wanted the child to be called.
63 He asked for a writing tablet
and wrote,
"His name is John."
They were all amazed.
64 Immediately his mouth was opened
and his tongue was freed,
and he spoke and praised God.
65 Fear came on all who lived around them.
All through the hill country of Judea
people talked about these things.
66 All who heard about it
kept it in their hearts and said,
"What then will this child be?"
The hand of the Lord was with him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Circumcision on the eighth day is a sign of the covenant between God and Israel (Genesis 17:12). To this day Jewish boys are circumcised on the eighth day. At that time the child receives his name.

Circumcise: to cut away the foreskin of a boy's penis. Covenant: a binding agreement.

Elizabeth stands firm. Against what the relatives expect, she gives the child the name that God has chosen.

Verse 62: People make signs to Zacharias. Perhaps he could not hear either. The Greek word in verse 22 can mean "mute" or "deaf."

As soon as Zacharias confirms the name, he can speak again. His first word is praise to God.

The song of Zacharias – the Benedictus VERSES 67–80

67 His father Zacharias was filled with the Holy Spirit
and prophesied:
68 "Blessed be the Lord, the God of Israel,
for he has visited and redeemed his people.
69 He has raised up a horn of salvation for us
in the house of his servant David,
70 as he spoke by the mouth of his holy prophets
long ago:
71 salvation from our enemies
and from the hand of all who hate us.
72 So he shows mercy to our ancestors
and remembers his holy covenant,
73 the oath which he swore to Abraham our father.
74 He grants to us
that we, rescued from the hand of our enemies,
should serve him without fear,
75 in holiness and righteousness before him
all the days of our life.
76 And you, child,
will be called a prophet of the Most High.
For you will go before the Lord
to prepare his ways,
77 to give his people knowledge of salvation
by the forgiveness of their sins.
78 This comes from the tender mercy of our God.
Through it the dawn from on high will visit us,
79 to shine on those
who sit in darkness and the shadow of death,
and to guide our feet into the way of peace."
80 The child grew and became strong in spirit.
He lived in the desert
until the day
he appeared in public to Israel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The song of Zacharias is named after its first word in the Latin Bible: "Benedictus" ("blessed"). To this day it is prayed every morning in many churches.

Redeemed: set free, rescued.

Verse 69: "A horn of salvation." In the Bible the horn is a picture of power and strength (compare Psalm 18:2; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 18:3).

Zacharias praises God, who is faithful to his people Israel and keeps his covenant with Abraham.

Verses 76–79: Zacharias speaks to his little son: You will prepare the way for the Lord. "The dawn from on high" means the Messiah.

Verse 79: "The way of peace": God's salvation leads to peace.

Verse 80: John lives in the desert until he is grown up and appears in public (Chapter 3).

LUKE

CHAPTER 2

The birth of Jesus

Jesus is born in Bethlehem VERSES 1–7

1 In those days an order went out from Caesar Augustus:
All the world should be enrolled.
2 This was the first enrollment.
It took place when Quirinius was governor of Syria.
3 Everyone went to be enrolled,
each to his own city.
4 Joseph also went up
from Galilee, out of the city of Nazareth,
into Judea, to David's city,
which is called Bethlehem.
For he was of the house and family of David.
5 He went to be enrolled
together with Mary,
who was engaged to him
and was expecting a child.
6 While they were there,
the time came for her to give birth.
7 She gave birth to her firstborn son.
She wrapped him in bands of cloth
and laid him in a feeding trough,
because there was no room for them in the inn.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"All the world" here means the whole Roman Empire.

Caesar Augustus ruled the Roman Empire from 27 BC to AD 14. An "enrollment" (a census) was mainly used to collect taxes.

Census: counting and listing all the people in a country.

Verse 2: Quirinius was governor of Syria from AD 6. Other sources tell of a census in that year. But Jesus was probably born before the death of Herod (Luke 1:5), that is, before 4 BC. These dates do not fit together exactly. Scholars explain this in different ways.

Bethlehem is the city of King David (1 Samuel 16). The prophet Micah had announced that a ruler would come from Bethlehem (Micah 5:2; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 5:1).

"Firstborn" means: the first child. This does not yet say whether Mary had more children later. Christians understand this in different ways.

Verse 7: The WEB says "inn." The Greek word can also mean "guest room." Perhaps there was no more room in the guest room of a house, and Mary had to give birth where the animals were kept.

Feeding trough: a box that holds food for animals, also called a manger.

The Son of God is not born in a palace, but in poverty, in a feeding trough.

For today: God is with the poor, the homeless and those for whom there is no room.

The shepherds and the angels VERSES 8–20

8 In the same area there were shepherds in the field.
They were keeping watch over their flock at night.

9 Suddenly an angel of the Lord stood by them,
and the glory of the Lord shone around them.
They were terrified.
10 The angel said to them,
"Don't be afraid!
For I bring you good news of great joy
which will be to all the people.
11 For today in David's city
a Savior is born to you,
who is Christ the Lord.
12 This is the sign to you:
You will find a baby
wrapped in strips of cloth,
lying in a feeding trough."
13 Suddenly there was with the angel
a great crowd of the heavenly army.
They were praising God and saying,
14 "Glory to God in the highest,
on earth peace,
good will toward men."
15 When the angels had gone away from them into the sky,
the shepherds said to one another,
"Let's go to Bethlehem now
and see this thing that has happened,
which the Lord has made known to us."
16 They hurried there
and found Mary and Joseph
and the baby
lying in the feeding trough.
17 When they saw it,
they told everyone
what they had been told about this child.
18 All who heard it
were amazed at the things
the shepherds told them.
19 But Mary kept all these sayings
and pondered them in her heart.
20 The shepherds went back.
They glorified and praised God
for all the things they had heard and seen.
It was all
just as they had been told.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then shepherds were simple, poor people. They were often looked down on. They are the very ones who hear the good news first.

Verse 11: The angel calls the child "Savior," "Christ" (Messiah) and "Lord." At that time the Roman emperor also claimed these titles for himself. Luke says: The true Savior is this poor child.

Verse 14: The WEB says: "on earth peace, good will toward men." Many old manuscripts have a different form here. Then it means: peace on earth among the people God loves.

Verse 19: Mary thinks about it. She does not yet understand everything, but she keeps it in her heart. Pondered: thought about something deeply.

This story is the heart of the Christmas celebration. Christians all over the world read it at Christmas.

Jesus is presented in the temple VERSES 21–24

21 When eight days had passed
and the child was to be circumcised,
he was given the name Jesus.
The angel had given him this name
before he was conceived in the womb.
22 When the days of their purification according to the law of Moses were over,
they brought him up to Jerusalem
to present him to the Lord.
23 For it is written in the law of the Lord,
"Every male who opens the womb
shall be called holy to the Lord."
24 And they came to offer a sacrifice,
as it says in the law of the Lord,
"A pair of turtledoves, or two young pigeons."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Like every Jewish boy, Jesus is circumcised on the eighth day (Genesis 17:12). His parents carefully keep the commandments of the law of Moses.

Verse 22: According to the law of Moses, a woman offered a sacrifice in the temple 40 days after the birth of a son (Leviticus 12:2–8). Purification: becoming clean again according to religious rules. That was a religious custom. Important: Giving birth is nothing dirty or shameful. Women are not worth less after giving birth.

Verse 23 reminds us of Exodus 13:2,12: The firstborn son belongs to God. The words about the male who opens the womb mean the first child born to a mother.

Verse 24: Two doves or pigeons were the sacrifice for poor families. Those who had more money offered a lamb (Leviticus 12:8). So Mary and Joseph were poor.

Simeon in the temple VERSES 25–35

25 There was a man in Jerusalem
whose name was Simeon.
He was righteous and devout
and was waiting for the comfort of Israel.
And the Holy Spirit was on him.
26 The Holy Spirit had shown him
that he would not die
before he had seen the Lord's Christ.
27 Led by the Spirit,
he came into the temple.
When the parents brought in the child Jesus
to do for him what the law required,
28 he took him into his arms,
praised God, and said,
29 "Master, now you are letting your servant go in peace,
according to your word.
30 For my eyes have seen your salvation,
31 which you have prepared before all peoples:
32 a light for revelation to the nations,
and the glory of your people Israel."
33 Joseph and his mother were amazed
at the things that were said about him.
34 Simeon blessed them
and said to Mary, his mother,
"This child is appointed
for the falling and the rising of many in Israel.

He will be a sign
that people speak against.
35 Yes, a sword will pierce through your own soul too.
So the thoughts of many hearts will be revealed."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Simeon is an old, devout Jew. All his life he has been waiting for the Messiah.

Verse 33: The WEB says "Joseph and his mother." Many old manuscripts say: his father and his mother.

Verses 29–32: His song is named after its Latin beginning: "Nunc dimittis" ("Now you are letting go"). To this day it is prayed in the evening in many churches.

Verse 32: Jesus is a light for all nations and the glory of Israel. Both belong together. This reminds us of Isaiah 42:6 and 49:6.

Verses 34–35: Simeon foretells: People will be divided over Jesus. And Mary will suffer great pain. Christians think of Mary standing at the cross.

Anna in the temple VERSES 36–38

36 There was also a prophetess named Anna,
the daughter of Phanuel, of the tribe of Asher.
She was very old.
After her wedding she had lived with her husband for seven years.
37 Then she had been a widow
for about 84 years.
She did not leave the temple,
but worshiped God night and day with fasting and prayer.
38 At that very hour she came up,
gave thanks to the Lord,
and spoke about the child to all
who were waiting for redemption in Jerusalem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Anna is a prophetess, a woman through whom God speaks. Luke often names women and men side by side: Simeon and Anna, Zacharias and Elizabeth.

Verse 37: The sentence can also be understood to mean that Anna was 84 years old. The WEB understands it to mean that she had been a widow for about 84 years.

Anna tells everyone about the child. She is one of the first women to spread the good news.

Redemption: being set free and saved by God.

For today: Old people are precious. Simeon and Anna are examples of faithful waiting and of a living hope in old age.

Back to Nazareth VERSES 39–40

39 When they had done everything
that the law of the Lord required,
they went back to Galilee,
to their own city, Nazareth.
40 The child grew and became strong in spirit.
He was filled with wisdom,
and the grace of God was upon him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus grows up in a devout Jewish family that keeps God's commandments.

Matthew also tells about the escape to Egypt (Matthew 2:13–23). Luke does not mention it. The Gospels tell about Jesus' childhood in different ways.

Verse 40: Jesus grows like every child, in body and spirit.

Jesus at age 12 in the temple VERSES 41–52

41 Every year his parents went to Jerusalem for the feast of the Passover.
42 When he was 12 years old,
they went up again, as was the custom for the feast.
43 When the days of the feast were over
and they were going home,
the boy Jesus stayed behind in Jerusalem.
Joseph and his mother didn't know it.
44 They thought he was with the traveling group.
They went a day's journey
and looked for him among their relatives and friends.
45 When they didn't find him,
they went back to Jerusalem
to look for him.
46 After three days they found him in the temple.
He was sitting in the middle of the teachers,
listening to them
and asking them questions.
47 All who heard him
were amazed at his understanding and his answers.
48 When his parents saw him,
they were astonished.
His mother said to him,
"Son, why have you treated us this way?
Your father and I were anxiously looking for you."
49 He said to them,
"Why were you looking for me?
Didn't you know
that I must be in my Father's house?"
50 But they didn't understand
what he meant.
51 Then he went down with them
and came to Nazareth.
He obeyed them.
And his mother kept all these sayings in her heart.
52 Jesus grew in wisdom and stature,
and in favor with God and people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Many Jews made a pilgrimage to Jerusalem for the Passover. People traveled in large groups with family and neighbors.

Pilgrimage: a journey to a holy place.

At 12 or 13, a Jewish boy took on religious responsibility. Today this is called "Bar Mitzvah."

Jesus sits with the teachers in the temple, listens and asks questions. The Jewish teachers take the boy seriously and are amazed at him.

Verse 48: Mary and Joseph were very afraid. Parents know this fear. Mary says honestly how she feels.

Verse 49: Jesus' first words in the Gospel of Luke: He calls God "my Father." He knows to whom he belongs.

Verse 51: Even so, he obeys his parents and goes home with them.

Verse 52: Jesus is fully human. He grows and learns like every child. Stature: height, size.

LUKE

CHAPTER 3

John the Baptizer and the baptism of Jesus

John the Baptizer appears VERSES 1–6

1 This happened in the fifteenth year of the rule of
Tiberius Caesar.
At that time Pontius Pilate was governor of Judea.
Herod was tetrarch of Galilee.
His brother Philip was tetrarch of the region of
Ituraea and Trachonitis.
Lysanias was tetrarch of Abilene.
2 Annas and Caiaphas were the high priests.
At that time God spoke his word to John, the son of
Zacharias.
John was in the wilderness.
3 John went through the whole area around the Jordan
River.
He told the people to turn away from their sins and be
baptized.
Then God would forgive their sins.
4 This is what is written in the book of Isaiah the prophet:
"A voice calls out in the wilderness,
'Make ready the way of the Lord.
Make his paths straight.
5 Every valley will be filled.
Every mountain and every hill will be made low.
The crooked roads will become straight.
The rough roads will become smooth.
6 All people will see how God saves.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Like a historian, Luke names the exact rulers. The fifteenth year of Emperor Tiberius was about AD 28 or 29.

"Herod" here is Herod Antipas, a son of Herod the Great. Tetrarch: a ruler over part of a country.

Annas had been high priest earlier. His son-in-law Caiaphas held the office at this time (compare John 18:13). But Annas still had great influence.

The word of God comes to John as it came to the prophets in the Old Testament.

To turn away from your sins (repentance) means: turning around, changing your life and turning back to God.

Verses 4–6 quote Isaiah 40:3–5. Only Luke also quotes: "All people will see how God saves" (3:6). Word for word it says "all flesh." That means all people. This is a favorite thought of Luke: God's salvation is for everyone.

John calls people to turn back VERSES 7–18

7 Crowds of people came out to John to be baptized.
He said to them,
"You children of poisonous snakes!
Who warned you to run away from God's coming
anger?
8 Show by the way you live that you have turned away
from your sins!
Don't start telling yourselves,
'Abraham is our father.'
I tell you, God can make children for Abraham
out of these stones!
9 The ax is already lying at the roots of the trees.
Every tree that does not grow good fruit
will be cut down and thrown into the fire."
10 The crowds asked John,
"Then what should we do?"
11 He answered them,
"If you have two coats,
give one to a person who has none.
If you have food,
do the same."
12 Tax collectors also came to be baptized.
They asked him,
"Teacher, what should we do?"
13 He said to them,
"Don't collect more money
than you are supposed to collect."
14 Soldiers also asked him,
"And what about us? What should we do?"
He said to them,
"Don't use force to take money from anyone.
Don't accuse anyone falsely.
Be happy with your pay."
15 The people were waiting and hoping.
They all wondered in their hearts about John.
Could he be the Christ?
16 John answered them all,
"I baptize you with water.
But someone is coming who is stronger than I am.
I am not even good enough
to untie the straps of his sandals.
He will baptize you in the Holy Spirit and fire.
17 He has his winnowing fork in his hand.
He will clean up his threshing floor completely.
He will gather the wheat into his barn.
But he will burn up the chaff in a fire
that never goes out."
18 John said many other things to encourage the people.
He told them the Good News.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Children of poisonous snakes" is the harsh language of the prophets. John wants to shake people awake.

Verse 8: John says: It is not enough to belong to the people of Abraham. God wants a changed life. This is not criticism of the Jewish people, but a call to turn back, like the call of Israel's prophets. John himself was a Jew.

Only Luke tells verses 10–14. John gives very practical answers: Share with the poor. Be honest at work. Don't misuse power.

Tax collectors: men who collected taxes for the Romans. Many of them took more than they should.

Striking: John does not tell the tax collectors and soldiers to give up their jobs. They are to do them fairly.

Verse 16: "Baptize you in the Holy Spirit and fire": Fire is a picture of God's cleansing power. Christians also think of Pentecost, when the Holy Spirit came like fire (Acts 2:3).

Verse 17: A winnowing fork is a kind of shovel. When winnowing, people threw the threshed grain into the wind with a shovel. The light chaff (the husks) blew away, and the heavy grain fell down. A picture of God's judgment.

For today: Verse 11 is a clear task: Whoever has more should share with those who have nothing.

John is arrested VERSES 19–20

19 John also told Herod the tetrarch that he was wrong.
He told him he was wrong to take Herodias, his brother's wife.
He told him he was wrong in all the other evil things he had done.
20 Then Herod did one more evil thing:
He locked John up in prison.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

John criticizes the powerful Herod. Herod had married his brother's wife, which was forbidden by the law of Moses (Leviticus 18:16).

Luke already tells about the arrest here, even though it happened later. In this way he finishes the story of John before the story of Jesus begins.

John is an example of courage: He tells the powerful the truth.

Jesus is baptized VERSES 21–22

21 All the people were being baptized.
Jesus was baptized too.
While he was praying,
the sky opened.
22 The Holy Spirit came down on him
in bodily form, like a dove.
And a voice came from the sky:
"You are my Son. I love you.
I am very pleased with you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus is baptized in the middle of all the people. He stands with the people.

Only Luke mentions: Jesus is praying. In Luke, Jesus often prays, especially before important events.

God's voice says: "You are my Son. I love you." This reminds us of Psalm 2:7 and Isaiah 42:1.

In verse 22 some old manuscripts have the words of Psalm 2:7: You are my son. Today I have become your father. The WEB, our English source text, follows the other reading.

The family tree of Jesus VERSES 23–38

23 Jesus was about 30 years old
when he began to teach.
People thought that he was the son of Joseph.
Joseph was the son of Heli,
24 the son of Matthat,
the son of Levi,
the son of Melchi,
the son of Jannai,
the son of Joseph,
25 the son of Mattathias,
the son of Amos,
the son of Nahum,
the son of Esli,
the son of Naggai,
26 the son of Maath,
the son of Mattathias,
the son of Semein,
the son of Joseph,
the son of Judah,
27 the son of Joanan,
the son of Rhesa,
the son of Zerubbabel,
the son of Shealtiel,
the son of Neri,
28 the son of Melchi,
the son of Addi,
the son of Cosam,
the son of Elmodam,
the son of Er,
29 the son of Jose,
the son of Eliezer,
the son of Jorim,
the son of Matthat,
the son of Levi,
30 the son of Simeon,
the son of Judah,
the son of Joseph,
the son of Jonan,
the son of Eliakim,
31 the son of Melea,
the son of Menan,
the son of Mattatha,
the son of Nathan,
the son of David,
32 the son of Jesse,
the son of Obed,
the son of Boaz,
the son of Salmon,
the son of Nahshon,
33 the son of Amminadab,
the son of Aram,
the son of Hezron,
the son of Perez,
the son of Judah,
34 the son of Jacob,
the son of Isaac,
the son of Abraham,
the son of Terah,
the son of Nahor,
35 the son of Serug,
the son of Reu,
the son of Peleg,
the son of Eber,
the son of Shelah,
36 the son of Cainan,
the son of Arphaxad,
the son of Shem,
the son of Noah,
the son of Lamech,
37 the son of Methuselah,
the son of Enoch,
the son of Jared,

the son of Mahalaleel,
the son of Cainan,
38 the son of Enos,
the son of Seth,
the son of Adam,
the son of God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At about 30 years old, Jesus begins his public work. The priests also began their service at 30 (Numbers 4:3), and David became king at 30 (2 Samuel 5:4).

"People thought that he was the son of Joseph": Luke has told us that Jesus was conceived through the Holy Spirit (1:35). By law, Jesus counted as Joseph's son.

Matthew also has a family tree (Matthew 1:1–17). It begins with Abraham and goes down to Jesus. Luke goes from Jesus back to Adam and to God. He shows: Jesus belongs to all of humanity, not only to one people.

The two family trees are very different between David and Joseph. In Matthew the line goes through Solomon, in Luke through Nathan, another son of David. There are different explanations for this. One old explanation is: Luke gives the family tree of Mary. Others think of brother-in-law marriages or adoption. No one knows for sure.

Verse 36: A "Cainan" between Arphaxad and Shelah is not in the Hebrew Bible (Genesis 11:12), but it is in the old Greek translation of the Old Testament.

Verse 38: "The son of God": Adam was created directly by God. Jesus is the new human being, like a new Adam.

The names are spelled as in the WEB. In other Bibles some names are spelled a little differently.

LUKE

CHAPTER 4

"The Spirit of the Lord is on me"

Jesus is tempted in the wilderness VERSES 1–13

1 Jesus was full of the Holy Spirit.
He came back from the Jordan River.
The Spirit led him into the wilderness.
2 There the devil tempted him for 40 days.
Tempting means: trying to get someone to do wrong.
Jesus ate nothing during those days.
When the 40 days were over, he was hungry.
3 The devil said to him,
"If you are the Son of God,
tell this stone to become bread."
4 Jesus answered him,
"It is written,
'People do not live from bread alone.
They also live from every word of God.'"
5 Then the devil led him up on a high mountain.
In one moment he showed him all the kingdoms of the world.
6 The devil said to him,
"I will give you power over all of this,
and all its glory.
For it has been given to me.
And I can give it to anyone I want.
7 So if you bow down and worship me,
all of it will be yours."
8 Jesus answered him,
"Get behind me, Satan!
For it is written,
'You must worship the Lord your God.
You must serve only him.'"
9 Then the devil led Jesus to Jerusalem.
He put him on the highest point of the temple.
He said to him,
"If you are the Son of God,
throw yourself down from here.
10 For it is written,
'He will tell his angels to take care of you
and to guard you.'
11 And it is written,
'They will catch you with their hands.
Then you will not hit your foot against a stone.'"
12 Jesus answered him,
"It has been said,
'You must not test the Lord your God.'"
13 The devil had now tried every way to tempt Jesus.
So he left him until another time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The 40 days in the wilderness remind us of the 40 years that Israel wandered through the wilderness. There Israel was often put to the test. Jesus passes the test.

Each time, Jesus answers with words from Deuteronomy: Deuteronomy 8:3; 6:13; 6:16. He lives from the Holy Scriptures of Israel.

In Luke the order is different from Matthew (Matthew 4:1–11): The last temptation is in Jerusalem, at the temple. Jerusalem is especially important for Luke.

The devil even quotes the Bible (Psalm 91:11–12). Bible words can also be misused.

Verse 4: The words "They also live from every word of God" are missing in some old manuscripts. Verse 8: "Get behind me, Satan!" is missing in the best old manuscripts. The WEB, our English source text, has both.

Verse 12: Jesus does not want to force God to prove himself. That would be putting God to the test.

Verse 13: "Until another time": The temptation comes back, especially before Jesus' suffering.

For today: Jesus was tempted too. Being tempted is not a sin. What matters is how you deal with it.

Jesus preaches in Nazareth VERSES 14–30

14 Jesus went back to Galilee
in the power of the Spirit.
News about him spread through the whole area.
15 He taught in their synagogues.
Everyone praised him.
16 Then Jesus came to Nazareth,
the town where he grew up.
On the Sabbath day he went into the synagogue,

as he always did.
He stood up to read.
17 Someone handed him the book of the prophet Isaiah.
He opened the book
and found the place where it says:
18 "The Spirit of the Lord is on me.
He has anointed me
to bring good news to poor people.
He has sent me
to heal people whose hearts are broken.
He has sent me to tell the prisoners that they will be free,
and to tell the blind that they will see again.
He has sent me to set free the people who are crushed.
19 He has sent me to announce the year
when the Lord shows his favor."
20 Then Jesus closed the book.
He gave it back to the helper and sat down.
Everyone in the synagogue was looking at him.
21 He began to speak to them.
"Today these words of Scripture have come true,
while you are listening."
22 Everyone said good things about him.
They were amazed at the kind and beautiful words he spoke.
They said,
"Isn't this Joseph's son?"
23 Jesus said to them,
"You will surely quote this saying to me:
'Doctor, heal yourself!'
You will say,
'We heard about what you did in Capernaum.
Do the same things here in your hometown!'"
24 He said,
"I tell you for certain:
People do not accept a prophet in his own hometown.
25 I tell you the truth:
There were many widows in Israel in the time of Elijah.
At that time the sky was shut
for three years and six months.
There was a great famine in the whole land.
26 But God did not send Elijah to any of those widows.
He sent him only to a widow in Zarephath,
in the land of Sidon.
27 There were also many people with leprosy in Israel
in the time of the prophet Elisha.
But not one of them was made clean.
Only Naaman, the man from Syria, was made clean."
28 When the people in the synagogue heard this,
they all became very angry.
29 They got up and threw Jesus out of the town.
Their town was built on a hill.
They led him to the edge of the hill.
They wanted to throw him off the cliff.
30 But Jesus walked right through the middle of them
and went on his way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus goes to the synagogue on the Sabbath, "as he always did." He lives as a devout Jew.

Synagogue: a Jewish house of prayer and teaching.

In the synagogue, passages from the law of Moses and from the prophets were read aloud. Afterward someone explained the text. To do this, he sat down.

Verses 18–19 quote Isaiah 61:1–2 and one line from Isaiah 58:6. This is like a program for Jesus' whole work: good news for the poor, freedom for prisoners, light for the blind, freedom for the oppressed.

Anointed: chosen by God for a task. In the past, oil was poured on a person's head for this.

"The year when the Lord shows his favor" reminds us of the "Year of Jubilee" in Leviticus 25: Every 50 years debts were to be canceled and slaves set free.

The words "to heal people whose hearts are broken" are missing in some old manuscripts.

Verse 21: "Today": Jesus says that this promise is coming true now, with him.

Verses 25–27: Jesus recalls two stories from the books of Kings. Elijah helped a foreign widow in Zarephath (1 Kings 17:8–24). Elisha healed Naaman the Syrian (2 Kings 5). Both helped people who did not belong to Israel. Jesus shows: God's goodness is also for foreigners.

Verses 28–29: The people are furious. This is the reaction of one particular place, not of the whole people. In other places Jesus is praised by many (verse 15).

Important: Violence against people who say something uncomfortable is always wrong.

For today: Jesus' program still applies today: helping the poor, visiting prisoners, setting the oppressed free.

Jesus in Capernaum VERSES 31–37

31 Then Jesus went down to Capernaum,
a town in Galilee.
On the Sabbath day he taught the people.
32 They were amazed at his teaching,
because his words had authority.
33 In the synagogue there was a man
who had the spirit of an unclean demon.
He shouted with a loud voice,
34 "Ah! What do you want with us,
Jesus of Nazareth?
Have you come to destroy us?
I know who you are.
You are the Holy One of God!"
35 Jesus spoke sharply to the demon.
"Be quiet! Come out of him!"
The demon threw the man down in front of everyone.
Then it came out of him.
It did not hurt him at all.
36 Everyone was amazed.
They said to each other,
"What kind of word is this?
He gives orders to the unclean spirits with authority and power,
and they come out!"
37 The news about Jesus spread
to every place in the whole area.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Capernaum was on the Sea of Galilee. Jesus lived there for a time.

Back then people explained some illnesses and mental suffering by demons.

Important: Mental illnesses are not a sin and not possession by demons. People with such illnesses need understanding and help, for example from doctors and therapists.
Only Luke mentions: The man was not hurt. Jesus wants to heal, not to harm.

Jesus heals many people VERSES 38–44

38 Jesus got up and left the synagogue.
He went into Simon's house.
Simon's mother-in-law was sick with a great fever.
They begged Jesus to help her.
39 He stood beside her
and ordered the fever to leave.
And the fever left her.
At once she got up
and began to serve them.
40 When the sun was going down,
people brought all their sick to Jesus.
They had many different diseases.
Jesus laid his hands on every one of them
and healed them.
41 Demons also came out of many people.
They shouted,
"You are the Christ, the Son of God!"
But Jesus spoke sharply to them.
He did not let them speak,
because they knew that he was the Christ.
42 When the day came,
Jesus went out to a place where no one lived.
The crowds looked for him.
They came to him
and tried to hold on to him.
They did not want him to leave them.
43 But he said to them,
"I must tell the good news about God's Kingdom
in the other towns too.
That is why God sent me."
44 And Jesus preached in the synagogues of Galilee.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

According to old tradition, Luke was a doctor. He writes "a great fever." Some see in this the eye of a doctor.

Verse 40: Jesus lays his hands on "every one of them." He sees each individual person.

Verse 43: Jesus does not let himself be held back. His message is to reach everyone.

Verse 44: The WEB says "Galilee." Many old manuscripts say "Judea." Luke sometimes uses "Judea" to mean the whole Jewish land.

Important: People who are sick and do not get well are not to blame for it. Illness is not a sign of too little faith.

LUKE

CHAPTER 5

People who leave everything

The great catch of fish VERSES 1–11

1 One day Jesus was standing by the lake of Gennesaret.
A crowd of people was pushing in around him.
They wanted to hear the word of God.
2 Jesus saw two boats at the shore of the lake.
The fishermen had gotten out of them.
They were washing their nets.
3 Jesus got into one of the boats.
It belonged to Simon.
Jesus asked him to go out a little way from the shore.
Then Jesus sat down in the boat
and taught the crowds.
4 When he had finished speaking,
he said to Simon,
"Go out into the deep water.
Let down your nets to catch some fish."
5 Simon answered him,
"Master, we worked hard all night
and caught nothing.
But because you say so,
I will let down the nets."
6 They did it.
And they caught so many fish
that their nets began to tear.
7 They waved to their partners in the other boat
to come and help them.
The partners came.
They filled both boats with fish,
so full that the boats began to sink.
8 When Simon Peter saw this,
he fell down at Jesus' knees.
He said,
"Go away from me, Lord!
I am a sinful man."
9 Simon was amazed at the great catch of fish.
All the men with him were amazed too.
10 James and John were amazed as well.
They were the sons of Zebedee
and Simon's partners.
Jesus said to Simon,
"Don't be afraid.
From now on you will be catching people alive."
11 They brought their boats to the shore.
They left everything
and followed Jesus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The lake of Gennesaret is another name for the Sea of Galilee.

Simon (Peter) is an experienced fisherman. Fish were usually caught at night. Fishing in deep water during the day was unusual. Even so, Simon trusts Jesus' word.

Verse 8: Simon is frightened. He senses how holy Jesus is, and how small he himself is. The prophet Isaiah felt something similar (Isaiah 6:5).

Verse 10: "Don't be afraid." Jesus does not send Simon away, but calls him. The WEB, our English source text, says

"catching people alive." The Greek word means "to catch alive": to win people for life.

Only Luke tells about this great catch of fish when the disciples are called. A similar story is in John 21:1–11, after the resurrection.

For today: Even someone who feels unworthy can be called by Jesus.

Jesus heals a man with leprosy VERSES 12–16

12 One time Jesus was in one of the towns.
There was a man there whose body was full of leprosy.
When he saw Jesus,
he bowed down with his face to the ground.
He begged him,
"Lord, if you want to,
you can make me clean."
13 Jesus reached out his hand
and touched him.
He said,
"I want to. Be clean!"
At once the leprosy left the man.
14 Jesus ordered him not to tell anyone.
He said,
"Go and show yourself to the priest.
Bring the offering for your cleansing,
as Moses commanded.
That will show them that you are healed."
15 But the news about Jesus spread even more.
Great crowds came together.
They wanted to hear him
and to be healed of their sicknesses.
16 But Jesus went away to places where no one lived
and prayed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Full of leprosy": Luke stresses how seriously ill the man was. "Leprosy" was a name for various skin diseases. Anyone who had it had to live apart from other people (Leviticus 13:45–46).

Jesus touches him. Otherwise no one did that. He gives him health and a place in the community again.

Verse 14: Jesus sends him to the priest, as the law of Moses requires (Leviticus 14). Jesus respects the law.

Verse 16: In Luke, Jesus often prays, especially when a lot is going on.

For today: No one should be shut out because of an illness.

Jesus heals a paralyzed man VERSES 17–26

17 One day Jesus was teaching.
Pharisees and teachers of the law were sitting there.
They had come from every village in Galilee and
Judea,
and from Jerusalem.
The power of the Lord was with Jesus,
so that he could heal people.
18 Some men came carrying a man on a mat.
The man was paralyzed.
That means: He could not move his body.
The men wanted to bring him in
and lay him down in front of Jesus.
19 But there were too many people.
They could not find a way to bring him in.
So they went up on the roof.
They let the man down on his mat through the tiles,
into the middle of the crowd, right in front of Jesus.
20 Jesus saw their faith.
He said to the man,
"Man, your sins are forgiven."
21 The scribes and the Pharisees began to think,
"Who is this man?
He is insulting God!
Only God can forgive sins!"
22 But Jesus knew what they were thinking.
He answered them,
"Why are you thinking these things in your hearts?
23 Which is easier to say:
'Your sins are forgiven,'
or 'Get up and walk'?
24 I want you to know
that the Son of Man has authority on earth
to forgive sins."
Then he said to the paralyzed man,
"I tell you,
get up, pick up your mat,
and go home!"
25 At once the man got up in front of them.
He picked up the mat he had been lying on.
He went home and praised God.
26 Everyone was amazed,
and they praised God.
They were filled with fear.
They said,
"We have seen amazing things today."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: Luke speaks of "tiles." He describes the houses the way his readers knew them. In Galilee houses usually had roofs made of clay (compare Mark 2:4).

The friends don't give up. Jesus sees "their faith." The trust of other people can also help someone.

Verse 20: Jesus speaks of forgiveness first. That does not mean the paralysis was a punishment. Illness and disability are not punishments from God.

The scribes think Jesus is blaspheming. Blasphemy means: words that insult God.

Verse 21: The scribes are right that only God can forgive sins. That is why what Jesus does is so astonishing. Their question is meant seriously.

Verse 25: The healed man and everyone who sees it praise God. In Luke people often praise God when he does great things.

Jesus calls Levi VERSES 27–32

27 After this Jesus went out.
He saw a tax collector named Levi.
Levi was sitting at the tax office.
Jesus said to him,
"Follow me!"
28 Levi got up.
He left everything
and followed Jesus.
29 Levi gave a great feast for Jesus in his house.
A large crowd of tax collectors and other people
were eating with them.

30 The Pharisees and their scribes
complained to the disciples of Jesus.
They said,
"Why do you eat and drink
with tax collectors and sinners?"
31 Jesus answered them,
"Healthy people do not need a doctor.
Sick people do.
32 I have not come to call righteous people.
I have come to call sinners,
so that they turn away from their sins."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tax collectors collected customs and taxes. Many of them demanded too much. That is why they were disliked and counted as sinners.

Levi leaves "everything." In Luke, letting go of possessions is very important.

Eating together meant: We belong together. Jesus eats with people whom others avoid.

Verse 30: The Pharisees wanted to keep God's commandments very carefully, including about food. Their question is meant seriously.

Verse 32: Only Luke adds that sinners are to turn away from their sins. This is called repentance. Jesus accepts sinners so that they can begin a new life.

For today: The church should be a place for everyone, especially for those who feel shut out.

The question about fasting VERSES 33–39

33 Some people said to Jesus,
"John's disciples often fast and pray.
The disciples of the Pharisees do the same.
But your disciples eat and drink."
34 Jesus said to them,
"The friends of the bridegroom are with him at the wedding.
Can you make them fast while he is with them?
35 But the time will come
when the bridegroom will be taken away from them.
In those days they will fast."
36 Jesus also told them a parable.
"No one tears a piece from new clothes
to patch old clothes.
If he does, he ruins the new clothes.
And the new piece will not match the old clothes.
37 No one pours new wine into old wineskins.
If he does, the new wine will burst the skins.
The wine will run out,
and the skins will be ruined.
38 New wine must be poured into new wineskins.
Then both are kept safe.
39 And no one who has drunk old wine
wants new wine right away.
He says,
'The old is better.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Fasting means: going without food for a time in order to focus completely on God. Devout Jews often fasted on certain days.

Jesus compares his time to a wedding. At a wedding people celebrate. Jesus is the "bridegroom."

Verse 35: Jesus hints at his death. Then there will be times of fasting again.

Wineskins: bags made of animal skin for keeping wine. Old ones are no longer stretchy and can burst.

Verses 36–38: Jesus' message is so new that it needs new forms.

Only Luke tells verse 39. With a smile he shows: Many people prefer what they are used to. New things have a hard time. That is human.

Important: The parable is not a judgment that Judaism is "old and bad." Jesus himself lived as a Jew.

Verse 39: Instead of "The old is better," some manuscripts say that the old is good. A few manuscripts leave out the whole of verse 39.

LUKE

CHAPTER 6

The Sermon on the Plain: Blessed are you who are poor

Grain on the Sabbath VERSES 1–5

1 It was the second Sabbath after the first.
Jesus was walking through the grain fields.
His disciples picked some heads of grain.
They rubbed them in their hands
and ate the grain.
2 Some of the Pharisees said to them,
"Why are you doing this?
The law does not allow it on the Sabbath day!"
3 Jesus answered them,
"Haven't you read what David did?
He and his men were hungry.
4 David went into God's house.
He took the show bread and ate it.
He also gave some to the men with him.
But the law allows only the priests to eat it."
5 Then Jesus said to them,
"The Son of Man is lord of the Sabbath."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The WEB, our English source text, says: "the second Sabbath after the first." What exactly this means is unclear. Many old manuscripts simply say: on a Sabbath.

Picking heads of grain at the edge of a field was allowed (Deuteronomy 23:25; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 23:26). But some teachers considered rubbing the grain on the Sabbath to be work. People had different opinions about this.

Verses 3–4: The story of David is in 1 Samuel 21:1–6 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 21:2–7).

Show bread: holy bread that was laid out before God in the house of God.

The Sabbath is a gift from God for rest and recovery (Exodus 20:8–11). In Judaism it is still celebrated today.

Healing on the Sabbath VERSES 6–11

6 On another Sabbath
Jesus went into the synagogue and taught.
A man was there
whose right hand was withered.
7 The scribes and the Pharisees watched Jesus closely.
Would he heal someone on the Sabbath?
They wanted to find a reason to accuse him.
8 But Jesus knew what they were thinking.
He said to the man with the withered hand,
"Get up and stand here in the middle."
The man got up and stood there.
9 Then Jesus said to them,
"I will ask you something.
What does the law allow on the Sabbath?
To do good, or to do harm?
To save a life, or to kill?"
10 Jesus looked around at all of them.
Then he said to the man,
"Stretch out your hand."
The man did it,
and his hand became healthy again,
just like the other one.
11 But the scribes and the Pharisees became very angry.
They talked with each other
about what they could do to Jesus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Luke says: It was the right hand. People worked with it. The man probably could not support himself.

Withered: dried up and shrunken, so that it could not be used.

Jesus places the man in the middle. He becomes visible and important.

Jesus asks: Is it right to do good on the Sabbath? Jewish teachers also said: To save a life, you may break the Sabbath.

Important: Not all Pharisees were against Jesus. And people with disabilities are not worth less.

Jesus chooses the 12 apostles VERSES 12–16

12 In those days Jesus went out to the mountain to pray.
He prayed to God all night long.
13 When morning came,
he called his disciples to him.
From them he chose 12.
He also called them apostles.
14 These are the 12:
Simon, whom he also named Peter,
and Andrew, his brother,
James and John,
Philip and Bartholomew,
15 Matthew and Thomas,
James the son of Alphaeus,
and Simon who was called the Zealot,
16 Judas the son of James,
and Judas Iscariot,
who later became a traitor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before an important decision, Jesus prays all night. In Luke, Jesus often prays.

"Apostle" means "one who is sent." There are 12 apostles, like the 12 tribes of Israel.

"Judas the son of James" is called "Thaddaeus" in Mark and Matthew. He probably had two names.

"Zealot" means someone who is full of zeal, eager and passionate. The Zealots were passionate Jews. Some of them wanted to fight against the Romans.

Many people come to Jesus VERSES 17–19

17 Jesus came down the mountain with them.
He stood on a flat place.
A large crowd of his disciples was there.
A great number of other people were there too.
They came from all of Judea and from Jerusalem,
and from the coast near Tyre and Sidon.
They had come to hear Jesus
and to be healed of their diseases.
18 People who were troubled by unclean spirits
were healed too.
19 The whole crowd tried to touch Jesus.
For power came out of him
and healed them all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Matthew, Jesus gives his great speech on a mountain (the "Sermon on the Mount"). In Luke he stands on a level place. That is why the speech in Luke is called the "Sermon on the Plain." It is shorter than the Sermon on the Mount, but much of it is the same.

People also come from Tyre and Sidon, where mostly non-Jews lived.

Blessings and woes VERSES 20–26

20 Jesus looked at his disciples and said,
"Blessed are you who are poor,
for God's Kingdom is yours.
21 Blessed are you who are hungry now,
for you will have plenty to eat.
Blessed are you who cry now,
for you will laugh.
22 Blessed are you when people hate you,
when they push you out and make fun of you,
and when they say your name is evil,
because of the Son of Man.
23 Be glad when that happens!
Jump for joy!
For you will have a great reward in heaven.
Their ancestors did the same things to the prophets.
24 But how terrible it will be for you who are rich!
You have already had your comfort.
25 How terrible it will be for you who are full now!
You will be hungry.
How terrible it will be for you who laugh now!
You will be sad and cry.
26 How terrible it will be for you when everyone speaks
well of you!
Their ancestors spoke well of the false prophets in the
same way."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Blessed" means: happy, blessed by God.

"How terrible it will be for you": a cry of pain and warning. The WEB, our English source text, says "woe." It means:

Things will go badly for you.

In Luke, Jesus speaks directly to the poor, the hungry and those who weep: "Blessed are you." In Matthew it says: "Blessed are those who are poor in spirit" (Matthew 5:3). Luke very directly means people who are really poor.

God is on the side of the poor. Their suffering matters to him. He promises that it will be turned around. This reminds us of the song of Mary (1:52–53).

These "woe" sayings are found only in Luke. They are a serious warning to the rich and the full. Wealth is not evil in itself. But whoever thinks only of himself and forgets the poor has already received everything he can expect.

Important: Poverty is not something God wants. Christians are to fight poverty and help the poor.

Love your enemies VERSES 27–36

27 "But I tell you who are listening:
Love your enemies!
Do good to those who hate you!
28 Bless those who curse you!
Pray for those who mistreat you!
29 If someone hits you on one cheek,
let him hit the other cheek too.
If someone takes your coat,
let him have your shirt too.
30 Give to everyone who asks you for something.
If someone takes your things,
don't ask him to give them back.
31 Treat other people
the way you want them to treat you.
32 If you love only those who love you,
why should you get any thanks for that?
Even sinners love those who love them.
33 If you do good only to those who do good to you,
why should you get any thanks for that?
Even sinners do that.
34 If you lend only to people
who you hope will pay you back,
why should you get any thanks for that?
Even sinners lend to sinners
to get back the same amount.
35 But love your enemies.
Do good to them.
Lend to them and do not expect to get anything back.
Then you will have a great reward.
And you will be children of the Most High God.
For he is kind to people who are ungrateful and evil.
36 Be merciful,
just as your Father is merciful."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Loving your enemies is one of the most important and hardest commandments of Jesus. Love here does not mean: having a good feeling. It means: doing good to the other person, praying for them and not meeting them with hatred.

Verse 29: Jesus wants to break the spiral of violence and revenge. Whoever hits back makes everything worse.

Very important: These words do not mean that you have to put up with violence, mistreatment or abuse! Whoever is beaten or mistreated may and should protect themselves and get help. That is not against Jesus' will. In the US, call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. In the UK, call the National Domestic Abuse Helpline at 0808 2000 247. Children and young people in the US can call or text Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. In the UK, call Childline at 0800 1111. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 31 is the "Golden Rule." Similar sayings exist in many religions. The Jewish teacher Hillel is said to have taught: What is hateful to you, do not do to your neighbor.

Verse 36: In Matthew it says "So you shall be perfect" (Matthew 5:48), in Luke: "Be merciful." God is merciful, and we are to be merciful too.

Do not judge VERSES 37–42

37 "Don't judge,
and you won't be judged.
Don't condemn,
and you won't be condemned.
Set others free,
and you will be set free.
38 Give,
and it will be given to you.
You will receive a good, full measure.
It will be pressed down and shaken together,
so that it runs over.
For the measure you use for others
is the measure that will be used for you."
39 Jesus also told them a parable.
"Can a blind person lead another blind person?
Won't they both fall into a hole?
40 A student is not greater than his teacher.
But every student who has learned everything
will be like his teacher.
41 Why do you see the small speck in your brother's eye,
but you don't notice the big beam in your own eye?
42 How can you say to your brother,
'Brother, let me take that speck out of your eye'?
You don't even see the beam in your own eye!
You hypocrite!
First take the beam out of your own eye.
Then you will see clearly
to take the speck out of your brother's eye."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Don't judge" means: Don't condemn others harshly and without love. Only God knows a person's heart.

That does not mean you may not call wrong by its name. Whoever experiences violence or injustice may say so and defend themselves.

Verse 38: A picture from the grain market. A generous seller presses the grain down and shakes it so that even more fits in. God is that generous.

Verse 39: "The blind" here is a picture of people who do not know the way themselves. It is not a judgment about people who are blind or visually impaired.

Verses 41–42: A funny, exaggerated picture. A beam is a large piece of wood used in building. Often we see the small faults of others, but not our own big faults.

Hypocrite: someone who pretends to be better than they are.

Tree and fruit, a house on the rock VERSES 43–49

43 "A good tree does not grow bad fruit.
And a bad tree does not grow good fruit.

44 You know each tree by its fruit.
People don't pick figs from thorn bushes.
They don't pick grapes from a bramble bush.
45 A good person has good things stored up in his heart.
He brings out good things.
An evil person has evil things stored up in his heart.
He brings out evil things.
For the mouth speaks
what the heart is full of.
46 Why do you call me 'Lord, Lord,'
but you don't do what I say?
47 Someone comes to me.
He hears my words and does what they say.
I will show you what he is like.
48 He is like a man who built a house.
He dug down deep
and laid the foundation on rock.
Then a flood came.
The water crashed against that house.
But it could not shake the house,
because it was built on rock.
49 But someone else hears my words
and does not do what they say.
He is like a man who built a house on the ground
without a foundation.
The water crashed against it,
and at once it fell down.
That house was completely destroyed."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 43–45: What a person does and says shows what is in their heart.

Verse 45: The WEB speaks of the "abundance" of the heart. Abundance means: a great amount, more than enough.

Verse 46: It is not enough to say "Lord, Lord" in a pious way. What matters is doing Jesus' words.

Verses 48–49: Whoever hears Jesus' words and lives by them has a firm foundation. When storms come in life, the house stands.

For today: A faith that is lived out in everyday life holds firm in hard times too.

LUKE

Chapter 7

Great faith and great love

Jesus heals a centurion's servant VERSES 1–10

1 Jesus finished saying all these things to the people.
Then he went into Capernaum.
2 A centurion lived there.
He had a servant whom he loved very much.
The servant was sick and about to die.
3 The centurion heard about Jesus.
So he sent some Jewish elders to him.
They were to ask Jesus to come and save his servant.
4 The elders came to Jesus.
They begged him,
"This man deserves your help.
5 He loves our people.
He even built our synagogue for us."
6 So Jesus went with them.
He was not far from the house
when the centurion sent some friends to him.
They gave him this message:
"Lord, don't trouble yourself.
I am not good enough for you to come into my house.
7 That is why I did not think I was good enough
to come to you myself.
But just say the word,
and my servant will be healed.
8 For I also have people over me.
And I have soldiers under me.
I tell one soldier, 'Go!' and he goes.
I tell another one, 'Come!' and he comes.
I tell my servant, 'Do this!' and he does it."
9 Jesus heard this
and was amazed at the man.
He turned to the crowd that was following him.
He said,
"I tell you,
I have not found such great faith,
not even in Israel."
10 The men who had been sent went back to the house.
They found the servant healthy again.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A centurion was a Roman officer. He was in charge of about 100 soldiers. He was not a Jew.

This centurion is a friend of the Jewish people. The Jewish elders speak up for him. This shows: Jews and non-Jews could be good neighbors.

The centurion is humble. Perhaps he also knows: Back then a devout Jew did not like to enter the house of a non-Jew. He does not want to make difficulties for Jesus.

Verses 7–8: The centurion knows about giving orders. He trusts: Jesus' word has power, even from far away.

In Matthew the centurion comes to Jesus himself (Matthew 8:5–13). Luke tells that he sends messengers. Both times the story is about his great trust.

In the Catholic Mass, words based on what the centurion says are prayed before Communion: Lord, I am not worthy …

For today: Faith can be found even where you don't expect it.

Jesus raises a widow's son VERSES 11–17

11 Soon after that, Jesus went to a town called Nain.
Many of his disciples went with him.
A large crowd went along too.
12 Jesus came near the town gate.
Just then some people were carrying a dead man out.
He was the only son of his mother.
She was a widow.
That means: Her husband had died.
Many people from the town were with her.

13 When the Lord saw her,
he felt very sorry for her.
He said to her,
"Don't cry."
14 He went up to the coffin and touched it.
The men who were carrying it stood still.
Jesus said,
"Young man, I tell you, get up!"
15 The dead man sat up
and began to speak.
Then Jesus gave him to his mother.
16 Everyone was filled with fear.
They praised God and said,
"A great prophet has come among us!"
And they said,
"God has visited his people!"
17 This news about Jesus spread
through the whole of Judea
and the whole area around it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nain was a small town in Galilee, not far from Nazareth. Only Luke tells this story.

A widow who loses her only son loses everything: her child, her support and often also her income. Back then women without a husband or son had hardly any protection.

Verse 13: Jesus has compassion. The Greek word means a deep feeling for someone else. You feel it right down in your gut. Jesus first sees the weeping mother.

The "coffin" was an open stretcher. The bearers are the people who carry it. The dead were buried on the same day.

Verse 15: "Jesus gave him to his mother": This reminds us of the prophet Elijah, who brought a widow's son back to life (1 Kings 17:23). That is why the people say: "A great prophet."

Verse 16: "God has visited his people!" This means: God has come to help his people. God is close to his people Israel.

For today: Jesus does not overlook those who grieve. Whoever grieves may weep. Parents who have lost a child can find help, for example, from The Compassionate Friends (compassionatefriends.org in the US, tcf.org.uk in the UK). If you are in crisis: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The question of John the Baptizer VERSES 18–23

18 John's disciples told him about all these things.
19 John called two of his disciples.
He sent them to Jesus with this question:
"Are you the one who is to come?
Or should we wait for someone else?"
20 The men came to Jesus.
They said,
"John the Baptizer has sent us to you.
He asks,
'Are you the one who is to come?
Or should we wait for someone else?'"
21 At that time Jesus healed many people
of their diseases and sicknesses,
and from evil spirits.
He gave sight to many blind people.
22 Jesus answered the men,
"Go back and tell John
what you have seen and heard:
Blind people can see.
Lame people walk.
People with leprosy are made clean.
Deaf people hear.
Dead people are raised to life.
And poor people hear the Good News.
23 Blessed is the person
who does not stumble because of me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

John is in prison (Luke 3:20). He asks: Is Jesus really the promised Savior? Perhaps he had expected a strict judge (Luke 3:17).

Even a great believer like John has questions and doubts. That is allowed.

Jesus does not answer with "yes" or "no." He points to what is happening. His words remind us of promises in the Book of Isaiah (Isaiah 35:5–6 and 61:1).

Verse 23: "Does not stumble because of me" means: does not get stuck on me, does not take offense at me, does not trip over me. Jesus is different from what many expected.

Important: These healings are signs of God's Kingdom. Whoever stays sick has not believed too little. And people with disabilities are loved by God just as much.

Jesus speaks about John VERSES 24–35

24 John's messengers left.
Then Jesus began to speak to the crowds about John.
"What did you go out into the wilderness to see?
A reed blowing in the wind?
25 What did you go out to see?
A man dressed in fine, soft clothes?
No, people who wear beautiful clothes
and live in luxury
are in the palaces of kings.
26 So what did you go out to see?
A prophet?
Yes, I tell you,
and John is much more than a prophet.
27 The Scriptures talk about him.
They say,
'Look, I am sending my messenger ahead of you.
He will prepare your way for you.'
28 I tell you:
No prophet born of a woman is greater than John the Baptizer.
But the least important person in God's Kingdom
is greater than John."
29 All the people heard this,
even the tax collectors.
They said that God is right.
For they had let John baptize them.
30 But the Pharisees and the experts in the law
said no to God's plan for them.
They had not let John baptize them.
31 "What can I compare the people of this generation to?
What are they like?
32 They are like children sitting in the marketplace.
They call out to each other,
'We played the flute for you,
but you did not dance.

We sang sad songs for you,
but you did not cry.'
33 John the Baptizer came.
He did not eat bread or drink wine.
And you say,
'He has a demon.'
34 The Son of Man came.
He eats and drinks.
And you say,
'Look at him! He is a glutton and a drunkard.
He is a friend of tax collectors and sinners!'
35 But wisdom is shown to be right
by all her children."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 24–26: John was not a swaying reed that bends with every wind. Nor was he a rich man at court. He was a brave prophet.

Verse 27 quotes Malachi 3:1. John prepares the way for Jesus.

Verse 28: John is great. But in God's Kingdom something new counts: Whoever belongs to God's Kingdom receives a gift that is even greater. This does not belittle John.

Experts in the law: people who studied and taught the law of Moses.

Verses 29–30: Luke shows two reactions. The ordinary people and the tax collectors accept John. Many Pharisees and experts in the law do not. "Said no to God's plan for them" means: They say no to what God offers them.

Important: This applies to certain people back then, not to all Pharisees and not to the Jewish people. Some Pharisees even invite Jesus to eat with them (verse 36).

Verses 31–34: The children in the marketplace want to play neither wedding nor funeral. That is how it is with some people: John is too strict for them, Jesus is too cheerful for them. No matter what God does, they always find something to complain about.

A glutton is someone who eats far too much. A drunkard is someone who drinks far too much.

Verse 35: God's wisdom is shown to be right by the people who listen to it. They are its "children."

A woman anoints Jesus' feet VERSES 36–50

36 One of the Pharisees invited Jesus to eat with him.
Jesus went into the Pharisee's house
and sat down at the table.
37 There was a woman in that town who was a sinner.
She heard that Jesus was eating in the Pharisee's house.
So she came with an alabaster jar full of ointment.
38 She stood behind Jesus at his feet and cried.
Her tears made his feet wet.
She dried his feet with her hair.
She kissed his feet
and put the ointment on them.
39 The Pharisee who had invited Jesus saw this.
He thought to himself,
"If this man were a prophet,
he would know who this woman is.
He would know what kind of woman is touching him.
She is a sinner!"
40 Jesus said to him,
"Simon, I have something to tell you."
Simon said,
"Tell me, Teacher."
41 "Two men owed money to a lender.
One owed him 500 denarii.
The other owed him 50.
42 Neither of them could pay him back.
So the lender forgave them both.
Now which of them will love him more?"
43 Simon answered,
"I think the one who was forgiven more."
Jesus said to him,
"You are right."
44 Then Jesus turned toward the woman.
He said to Simon,
"Do you see this woman?
I came into your house.
You gave me no water for my feet.
But she has made my feet wet with her tears
and dried them with her hair.
45 You did not greet me with a kiss.
But she has not stopped kissing my feet
since I came in.
46 You did not put oil on my head.
But she has put ointment on my feet.
47 So I tell you:
Her sins are many,
but they are forgiven,
because she loved much.
But whoever is forgiven little
loves little."
48 Then Jesus said to the woman,
"Your sins are forgiven."
49 The other people at the table began to say to each other,
"Who is this man?
He even forgives sins!"
50 Jesus said to the woman,
"Your faith has saved you.
Go in peace."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At feasts back then, people reclined on cushions around a low table. Their feet pointed backward. So the woman could come up behind Jesus to his feet.

Alabaster: a soft, light-colored stone used for precious jars. Ointment: a sweet-smelling oil.

Luke does not say what sins the woman had. Later people often assumed she was a prostitute. That is not in the text. She is also not Mary Magdalene. Mary Magdalene is named only in Luke 8:2, as a new person.

Similar anointings are told in Matthew 26:6–13, Mark 14:3–9 and John 12:1–8. There it happens shortly before Jesus' death in Bethany. Whether Luke means the same event or a different one is debated among interpreters.

Verse 41: A denarius was the pay for one day of work. So 500 denarii is almost two years of work.

Verses 44–46: Water for the feet, a kiss of greeting and oil for the head were signs of hospitality. Simon did not give these signs. The woman does much more.

Verse 47 is understood in different ways. Some read it: She loves much because she has already been forgiven. That fits the parable in verses 41–43. Others stress: Her love shows the way to forgiveness. Verse 50 says: Her faith has saved her.

Simon is not condemned. Jesus talks with him, kindly and honestly. The story stays open: Will Simon understand?

For today: No one is too "bad" for God's forgiveness. And no one should look down on others.

LUKE

CHAPTER 8

Whoever has ears to hear should listen

Women travel with Jesus VERSES 1–3

1 Soon after that, Jesus traveled through towns and villages.
He preached and told the good news of God's Kingdom.
The Twelve were with him.
2 Some women were also with him.
Jesus had healed them from evil spirits and sicknesses.
Mary, who was called Magdalene, was one of them.
Seven demons had gone out of her.
3 Joanna was with him too.
She was the wife of Chuzas,
who managed Herod's household.
Susanna was there,
and many other women.
These women helped Jesus and his disciples
with their own money and goods.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Luke says this so clearly: Not only 12 men traveled with Jesus, but also many women. They truly belonged to the group.

The women provided for the group with their own money. Without them Jesus could not have traveled around like this.

Mary Magdalene came from Magdala on the Sea of Galilee. She was one of the most important companions of Jesus. Later she is the first witness of the resurrection (Luke 24:10; John 20:11–18).

Important: The Bible nowhere says that Mary Magdalene was a prostitute. That is a later guess. She is also not the woman from Luke 7. "Seven demons" means: She had suffered greatly. We do not know exactly from what.

Chuzas managed Herod's household. Such a man was called a steward: a man who manages a household or property for someone.

Joanna belongs to Herod's court. This shows: People from the upper class also followed Jesus.

Verse 3: Some manuscripts say that they served him instead of them.

The parable of the farmer and the seed VERSES 4–15

4 A large crowd came together.
People came to Jesus from every town.
Then he told them a parable.
5 "A farmer went out to plant his seed.
As he scattered it,
some seed fell on the path.
People stepped on it,
and the birds ate it up.
6 Some seed fell on rock.
It began to grow.
But soon it dried up,
because it had no water.
7 Some seed fell among thorn bushes.
The thorns grew up with it
and choked the plants.
8 Some seed fell on good soil.
It grew and produced a crop,
100 times as much as was planted."
When Jesus had said this,
he called out,
"Whoever has ears to hear should listen!"
9 His disciples asked him,
"What does this parable mean?"
10 He said,
"God lets you know the secrets of his Kingdom.
But to the others I speak in parables.
So 'they look, but they do not see.
They hear, but they do not understand.'
11 This is what the parable means:
The seed is the word of God.
12 The seed on the path
is like people who hear the word.
But then the devil comes
and takes the word out of their hearts.
He does not want them to believe and be saved.
13 The seed on the rock
is like people who hear the word
and accept it with joy.
But they have no roots.
They believe for a while.
But when a time of temptation comes,
they turn away.
14 The seed that fell among the thorns
is like people who hear the word.
But as they go on,
worries, riches, and the pleasures of life choke them.
So their fruit never becomes ripe.
15 The seed on the good soil
is like people who hear the word
with an honest and good heart.
They hold on to it tightly.
They do not give up,
and they produce fruit."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then people often sowed first and plowed afterward. So seed also fell on paths, on rocky ground and among thorns.

Jesus explains the parable himself: The seed is the word of God. The different kinds of ground are different people who hear it.

Verse 10 freely quotes Isaiah 6:9. That sounds harsh. It does not mean that God shuts people out on purpose. Parables invite people in. Whoever is open and asks questions, like the disciples, understands more. Whoever closes themselves off stays outside.

Verse 13: Luke says "temptation," which can also mean a test. Hard times can put faith to the test.

Verse 14: Worries, riches and pleasures can choke the word. In Luke, how we deal with possessions is a big theme.

Verse 15: Only Luke says that they "do not give up." The WEB, our English source text, says "with perseverance." Faith grows slowly, like a plant.

For today: Everyone can ask: Which kind of ground am I right now? Ground can also change.

The light on the stand VERSES 16–18

16 "No one lights a lamp
and then covers it with a bowl
or puts it under a bed.
He puts it on a lampstand.
Then people who come in can see the light.
17 Everything that is hidden will be made known.
Everything that is secret
will be found out and come into the light.
18 So be careful how you listen!
Whoever has something will be given more.
But whoever has nothing will lose
even what he thinks he has."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The word of God is like a light. It should not be hidden, but should shine.

Verse 18: "Whoever has something will be given more" is not a rule about money here. It is about hearing: Whoever takes in God's word understands more and more. Whoever does not take it in loses even the little he thinks he has.

For today: What matters is not only whether you hear, but how.

Jesus' true family VERSES 19–21

19 The mother and brothers of Jesus came to see him.
But they could not get near him
because of the crowd.
20 Someone told Jesus,
"Your mother and your brothers are standing outside.
They want to see you."
21 But he answered them,
"My mother and my brothers
are the people who hear God's word and do it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus does not reject his family. But he says: Everyone who hears God's word and lives by it belongs to his family.

In Luke, Mary herself is an example of this: She hears God's word and says yes (Luke 1:38; 2:19).

The churches understand Jesus' "brothers" in different ways. Protestant Christians usually see them as his brothers by birth. Catholic Christians usually understand them as cousins or close relatives. Orthodox Christians often think of sons of Joseph from an earlier marriage.

Jesus calms the storm VERSES 22–25

22 One day Jesus got into a boat with his disciples.
He said to them,
"Let's go across to the other side of the lake."
So they started out.
23 While they were sailing,
Jesus fell asleep.
A strong wind came down on the lake.
Water came into the boat.
They were in great danger.
24 The disciples went to Jesus and woke him up.
They said,
"Master, Master, we are going to die!"
Jesus got up.
He gave orders to the wind and the wild waves.
They stopped,
and everything became calm.
25 Then he said to the disciples,
"Where is your faith?"
They were afraid and amazed.
They said to each other,
"Who is this man?
He gives orders even to the winds and the water,
and they obey him!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

On the Sea of Galilee strong storms can come up suddenly. The winds rush down from the mountains.

Jesus sleeps, calm and full of trust. The disciples are terrified of dying.

Verse 25: In Luke, Jesus only asks: "Where is your faith?" That is a gentle question, not an accusation.

In the Old Testament it is God who calms the sea (Psalm 107:29). That is why the disciples ask who this man is (verse 25).

For today: Being afraid is human. In times of need you may cry out, like the disciples.

Jesus heals a man in the country of the Gadarenes VERSES 26–39

26 Jesus and his disciples came to the land of the Gadarenes.
It is across the lake from Galilee.
27 Jesus got out of the boat onto the shore.
There a man from the town came to meet him.
The man had had demons for a long time.
He wore no clothes.
He did not live in a house.
He lived in the tombs, where the dead were buried.
28 When he saw Jesus,
he screamed and fell down in front of him.
He shouted with a loud voice,
"What do you want with me,
Jesus, Son of the Most High God?
I beg you, don't torture me!"
29 He said this because Jesus had ordered the unclean spirit
to come out of the man.
The unclean spirit had often taken control of him.
People had guarded him.
They had tied him up with chains and fetters.
But he broke the chains.
And the demon drove him out into the desert.
30 Jesus asked him,
"What is your name?"
He said,
"Legion."
He said this because many demons had gone into him.

31 The demons begged Jesus
not to send them into the abyss.
32 A large herd of pigs was there,
eating on the hillside.
The demons begged Jesus
to let them go into the pigs.
Jesus let them.
33 The demons came out of the man
and went into the pigs.
The herd ran down the steep bank into the lake
and drowned.
34 The men who took care of the pigs saw what had
happened.
They ran away.
They told the news in the town and in the countryside.
35 People went out to see what had happened.
They came to Jesus.
They found the man whom the demons had left.
He was sitting at the feet of Jesus,
clothed and in his right mind.
And the people were afraid.
36 Those who had seen it told the others
how the man with the demons had been healed.
37 Then all the people from the area of the Gadarenes
asked Jesus to go away from them.
For they were very afraid.
So Jesus got into the boat
and went back.
38 The man whom the demons had left
begged Jesus to let him go with him.
But Jesus sent him away and said,
39 "Go back home.
Tell people about the great things God has done for
you."
So the man went away.
He told people in the whole town
about the great things Jesus had done for him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The area was on the eastern shore of the lake. Many non-Jews lived there. That is why there were pigs there, which counted as unclean for Jews.

The WEB, our English source text, says "Gadarenes." Many old manuscripts say Gerasenes, others Gergesenes. The same area is meant.

The man is completely cast out: without clothes, without a house, chained, among the graves. Jesus gives him back his dignity. In the end he sits at Jesus' feet "clothed and in his right mind," like a student.

Fetters: chains for the feet.

"Legion" was a Roman army unit with several thousand soldiers. The name shows: The man is ruled by a huge, destructive power.

Verse 31: The "abyss" was thought of as a place where evil powers are locked up.

Verse 37: The people are afraid of so much power. And they have lost their pigs. For some people, possessions matter more than a person who has been healed.

Verse 39: The healed man becomes Jesus' first messenger among non-Jews. He tells what "God" has done, and by this he means what "Jesus" has done.

Important: Back then people often explained severe mental suffering by demons. Mental illnesses are not possession and not a sin. People with such illnesses need respect, medical help and community, not chains.

The daughter of Jairus and a sick woman VERSES 40–56

40 Jesus came back across the lake.
The crowd welcomed him,
because they had all been waiting for him.
41 A man named Jairus came.
He was a leader of the synagogue.
He fell down at the feet of Jesus.
He begged Jesus to come to his house.
42 For he had only one daughter.
She was about 12 years old,
and she was dying.
Jesus went with him.
The crowds pushed against Jesus from all sides.
43 A woman was there who had been bleeding for 12 years.
She had spent all her money on doctors.
But no one could heal her.
44 She came up behind Jesus
and touched the fringe of his cloak.
At once her bleeding stopped.
45 Jesus asked,
"Who touched me?"
Everyone said, "Not me."
Peter and those with him said,
"Master, the crowds are pushing and pressing against
you,
and you say, 'Who touched me?'"
46 But Jesus said,
"Someone did touch me.
I felt power go out of me."
47 The woman saw that she could not stay hidden.
She came, shaking with fear,
and fell down in front of Jesus.
In front of all the people she told him
why she had touched him.
And she told how she had been healed at once.
48 Jesus said to her,
"Daughter, be encouraged.
Your faith has made you well.
Go in peace."
49 Jesus was still speaking
when someone came from the house of the synagogue
leader.
He said to Jairus,
"Your daughter is dead.
Don't bother the Teacher anymore."
50 Jesus heard this.
He said to Jairus,
"Don't be afraid.
Only believe,
and she will be healed."
51 Jesus came to the house.
He did not let anyone go in with him
except Peter, John, and James,
and the girl's father and mother.
52 All the people were crying and mourning for her.
But Jesus said,
"Don't cry.

She is not dead.
She is sleeping."
53 The people laughed at him,
because they knew that she was dead.
54 But Jesus sent them all outside.
He took the girl by the hand
and called out,
"Child, get up!"
55 Her spirit came back,
and at once she got up.
Jesus told them to give her something to eat.
56 Her parents were amazed.
But Jesus ordered them
not to tell anyone what had happened.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Two stories are woven into each other. Both times it is about 12 years: The girl is 12 years old. The woman has been sick for 12 years.

Jairus is a respected man. A leader of the synagogue led the worship services. In his need he falls down before Jesus. Here Luke tells of a Jewish leader who trusts Jesus.

According to the law, the sick woman counted as unclean (Leviticus 15:25–27). For 12 years she was shut out, poor and alone. That is why she comes secretly from behind.

Verse 43: The words "She had spent all her money on doctors" are missing in some old manuscripts. In verse 45 the words "and you say, 'Who touched me?'" and the words "and those with him" are also missing in some manuscripts. The WEB has them.

Verse 44: The "fringe" was the tassels on the cloak that devout Jews wore (Numbers 15:38–39).

Verses 47–48: Jesus does not want to shame her. He wants everyone to know: She is healed and clean again. He calls her "Daughter." She belongs again.

Verse 52: "She is not dead. She is sleeping": For Jesus, death is not the last word. That is why Christians sometimes speak of death as a kind of sleep.

Verse 55: Jesus thinks of something very practical: The girl needs something to eat.

Important: Whoever stays sick, or whose child dies, has not believed too little. God is close even in suffering and grief. Parents who have lost a child can find help, for example, from The Compassionate Friends (compassionatefriends.org in the US, tcf.org.uk in the UK). If you are in crisis: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

LUKE

CHAPTER 9

Who is Jesus?

Jesus sends out the Twelve VERSES 1–6

1 Jesus called the Twelve together.
He gave them power and authority
to drive out all demons
and to heal diseases.
2 He sent them out
to tell about God's Kingdom
and to heal the sick.
3 He said to them,
"Take nothing with you for the trip.
Take no walking stick,
no bag,
no bread,
and no money.
Don't take an extra shirt.
4 When you go into a house,
stay there until you leave that town.
5 Some people will not welcome you.
When you leave their town,
shake the dust off your feet.
That will be a warning to them."
6 So the Twelve went out.
They went from village to village.
They told the Good News
and healed people everywhere.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Twelve are to do what Jesus does: preach and heal. Now they are no longer only students, but messengers.

Verse 3: They are to travel without supplies. In this way they show: We trust in God and in people's hospitality. A staff is a walking stick. The "shirt" is a tunic, a simple shirt-like garment.

Verse 5: Shaking off the dust means: We let you go. Now you are responsible yourselves. It is a sign, not revenge and not violence.

For today: Whoever tells others about God does not need much. Trust is more important than money.

Herod is puzzled VERSES 7–9

7 Herod the tetrarch heard about everything that was happening.
He did not know what to think.
Some people said that John had risen from the dead.
8 Others said that Elijah had appeared.
Still others said that one of the old prophets had come back to life.
9 Herod said,
"I had John's head cut off.
So who is this man?
I hear such things about him!"
And Herod wanted to see Jesus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This Herod is Herod Antipas. He had had John the Baptizer killed (compare Mark 6:14–29). Luke does not tell the death of John in detail.

Beheaded: killed by cutting off the head.

The question "Who is this?" runs through the whole chapter. People have different answers.

Verse 9: Herod wants to see Jesus. That will happen later, shortly before Jesus' death (Luke 23:8).

Jesus feeds 5,000 people VERSES 10–17

10 The apostles came back.
They told Jesus everything they had done.
Jesus took them with him,
and they went away by themselves.
He went with them to a deserted area of a town called
Bethsaida.
11 But the crowds found out about it
and followed him.
Jesus welcomed them.
He told them about God's Kingdom.
And he healed the people who needed healing.
12 Late in the afternoon,
the Twelve came to Jesus.
They said,
"Send the crowd away.
Then they can go to the villages and farms around
here.
They can find a place to stay and get food.
For we are in a deserted place here."
13 But Jesus said to them,
"You give them something to eat."
They said,
"We have only five loaves of bread and two fish.
Do you want us to go and buy food for all these
people?"
14 There were about 5,000 men there.
Jesus said to his disciples,
"Have them sit down in groups of about 50."
15 The disciples did this.
They had everyone sit down.
16 Jesus took the five loaves and the two fish.
He looked up to the sky
and blessed them.
He broke the bread and the fish into pieces.
He gave the pieces to the disciples
to give to the crowd.
17 Everyone ate and had enough.
The disciples picked up the pieces that were left over.
They filled 12 baskets.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the only miracle of Jesus that is told in all four Gospels (compare Matthew 14:13–21; Mark 6:30–44; John 6:1–15).

Verse 10: Here it says that Jesus went with them "to a deserted area of a town called Bethsaida." Some old manuscripts only say: to a city called Bethsaida. Bethsaida was on the north shore of the Sea of Galilee.

Verse 13: "You give them something to eat." Jesus makes the disciples responsible.

Verse 14: Back then often only the men were counted. So there were even more people there, with women and children.

Verse 16: Looking up, blessing, breaking, giving: These words remind us of the Last Supper (Luke 22:19). Christians think of Holy Communion or the Eucharist.

There are 12 baskets left over: God gives more than enough. The number 12 reminds us of the 12 tribes of Israel.

For today: A little can become a lot when it is shared.

Peter says who Jesus is VERSES 18–27

18 One day Jesus was praying alone.
His disciples were near him.
He asked them,
"Who do the crowds say that I am?"
19 They answered,
"Some say you are John the Baptizer.
Others say you are Elijah.
And others say
that one of the old prophets has come back to life."
20 Jesus said to them,
"But who do you say that I am?"
Peter answered,
"You are the Christ of God."
21 Then Jesus warned them strongly
not to tell this to anyone.
22 He said,
"The Son of Man must suffer many things.
The elders, the chief priests, and the scribes will reject
him.
He will be killed.
And on the third day he will be raised to life."
23 Then he said to everyone,
"If anyone wants to come with me,
he must say no to himself.
He must take up his cross
and follow me.
24 Whoever wants to save his life
will lose it.
But whoever loses his life because of me
will save it.
25 What good is it for a person
to win the whole world
but to lose his own self, or to throw it away?
26 Someone may be ashamed of me and of my words.
Then the Son of Man will be ashamed of him
when he comes in his glory,
in the glory of the Father
and of the holy angels.
27 I tell you the truth:
Some of the people standing here will not die
before they see God's Kingdom."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: In Luke, Jesus prays before important moments. Here too.

Verse 20: "Christ" is Greek and means "the anointed one," in Hebrew "Messiah." Peter says: You are the Savior promised by God.

Verses 21–22: Jesus does not want people to misunderstand him as a political liberator. He says: The Messiah's way leads through suffering. This is the first time in Luke that Jesus announces his suffering.

Important: Verse 22 names certain leaders in Jerusalem, not the Jewish people. According to Luke 24:20 and Acts 4:27 the Romans were involved too. The Jewish people do not bear guilt for the death of Jesus (Council declaration *Nostra Aetate*, 1965).

Verse 23: "Take up his cross" is a picture: following Jesus even when it is hard. Say no to himself: not putting himself first. Many old manuscripts say that he should take up his cross daily. The WEB, our English source text, does not have "daily."

Important: This does not mean that you simply have to put up with violence, abuse or injustice. Whoever experiences violence may and should get help.

Verse 25: "Throw it away": The WEB says "forfeit," that is, lose something as a penalty.

Verse 27: These words are understood in different ways. Many interpreters think of the transfiguration, which follows right after, or of Easter and Pentecost.

Jesus is transfigured VERSES 28–36

28 About eight days after Jesus said these things,
he took Peter, John, and James with him.
He went up on the mountain to pray.
29 While he was praying,
his face changed.
His clothes became shining white.
30 Suddenly two men were talking with him.
They were Moses and Elijah.
31 They appeared in glory.
They talked about his departure.
That means: how he would leave this world.
This was soon going to happen in Jerusalem.
32 Peter and the others with him were very sleepy.
But then they became fully awake.
They saw the glory of Jesus
and the two men standing with him.
33 The two men were about to leave Jesus.
Then Peter said to him,
"Master, it is good for us to be here.
Let's make three tents:
one for you,
one for Moses,
and one for Elijah."
Peter did not know what he was saying.
34 While he was saying this,
a cloud came and covered them.
The disciples were afraid
as they went into the cloud.
35 A voice came out of the cloud.
It said,
"This is my Son. I love him.
Listen to him!"
36 After the voice had spoken,
they saw that Jesus was alone.
The disciples kept quiet.
In those days they told no one
anything about what they had seen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story is called the "transfiguration." Transfigured means: changed in appearance, shining with glory. For a moment the disciples see Jesus' divine glory.

Moses stands for the law, Elijah for the prophets. Both belong to the Holy Scriptures of Israel. They talk with Jesus. This shows: Jesus stands within God's history with Israel.

Verse 31: Only Luke says what they talk about: his "departure." The Greek word is "exodus," that is, going out. This means Jesus' death, resurrection and ascension in Jerusalem.

Verse 33: Peter wants to hold on to the beautiful moment. But the journey goes on.

In the Bible the cloud is a sign that God is near (Exodus 40:34).

Verse 35: Many old manuscripts say "my chosen Son" instead of "my Son. I love him." "Listen to him!" reminds us of Deuteronomy 18:15.

Jesus heals a boy VERSES 37–45

37 The next day they came down from the mountain.
A large crowd came to meet Jesus.
38 A man in the crowd shouted,
"Teacher, please look at my son!
He is my only child.
39 A spirit takes hold of him.
Then he suddenly screams.
The spirit shakes him hard,
so that foam comes out of his mouth.
It hurts him badly
and hardly ever leaves him.
40 I begged your disciples
to drive it out,
but they could not do it."
41 Jesus answered,
"You people of this generation have no faith!
You have turned away from what is right!
How long must I stay with you
and put up with you?
Bring your son here."
42 The boy was still coming to Jesus
when the demon threw him to the ground.
It shook him violently.
But Jesus gave a strict order to the unclean spirit.
He healed the boy
and gave him back to his father.
43 All the people were amazed at the great power of God.
Everyone was amazed at all the things Jesus was doing.
Then Jesus said to his disciples,
44 "Listen carefully to what I am telling you.
The Son of Man will be handed over to people."
45 But the disciples did not understand what he meant.
It was hidden from them,
so that they could not understand it.
And they were afraid to ask him about it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 38: Luke stresses: He is the only child. The father is desperate.

The description reminds us of epilepsy: seizures, crying out, convulsions, foaming at the mouth. People back then explained such things by a spirit.

Convulsions: sudden, violent movements of the body that a person cannot control.

Important: Epilepsy is an illness of the brain. It has nothing to do with demons or sin. People with epilepsy need medical help and understanding, not fear.

Verse 41: Jesus' lament is aimed at the whole generation, including the disciples who could not help. It is not aimed at the desperate father. The WEB, our English source text, says "perverse": twisted, turned away from what is right.

Verse 42: Jesus "gave him back to his father": as with the widow's son in Nain (Luke 7:15).

Verses 44–45: The second time Jesus announces his suffering. The disciples do not understand it. Only after Easter will they understand (Luke 24:45).

Who is the greatest? VERSES 46–50

46 The disciples began to argue
about which of them was the greatest.
47 Jesus knew what they were thinking in their hearts.
He took a little child
and had him stand beside him.
48 Jesus said to them,
"Whoever welcomes this little child in my name
welcomes me.
And whoever welcomes me
welcomes the one who sent me.
Whoever is the least important among all of you
is the one who is great."
49 John said,
"Master, we saw someone driving out demons in your
name.
We tried to stop him,
because he does not follow you with us."
50 Jesus said to him,
"Don't stop him.
Whoever is not against us
is for us."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Right after Jesus announces his suffering, the disciples argue about who is the most important. They have not understood Jesus.

Back then children had no rights and no standing. Jesus places a child at his side, in the place of honor.

Verse 48: Whoever welcomes the little and the weak welcomes Jesus and God himself.

Important: Children are precious and must be protected. Whoever experiences violence or abuse, or knows about it, can find help. In the US, call or text Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453, or call RAINN at 1-800-656-4673. In the UK, call Childline at 0800 1111.

Verses 49–50: The disciples want to decide who belongs. Jesus is more generous. People outside your own group can also do good in his name.

For today: Christians from different churches should not fight one another.

A Samaritan village does not welcome Jesus VERSES 51–56

51 The time came near
when Jesus would be taken up.
So he set his face to go to Jerusalem.
That means: He firmly decided to go there.
52 He sent messengers ahead of him.
They went into a village of the Samaritans
to get things ready for him.
53 But the people there did not welcome Jesus,
because he was on his way to Jerusalem.
54 His disciples James and John saw this.
They said,
"Lord, do you want us to call fire down from the sky
to destroy these people,
just as Elijah did?"
55 But Jesus turned and spoke sharply to them.
He said,
"You don't know what kind of spirit you belong to.
56 The Son of Man did not come to destroy people's lives.
He came to save them."
Then they went to another village.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 51 is a turning point in the Gospel of Luke. From here on Jesus is on his way to Jerusalem, until chapter 19. "Taken up" means his death, his resurrection and his ascension.

"Set his face" means: be firmly determined.

Back then Jews and Samaritans were enemies. The Samaritans had their own holy mountain, Mount Gerizim. That is why they did not want to welcome pilgrims going to Jerusalem.

Verse 54: James and John are thinking of Elijah, who made fire fall from the sky (2 Kings 1:10–12).

Jesus clearly rejects violence and revenge. He simply goes to another village.

Verses 54–56: The words "just as Elijah did" and "You don't know what kind of spirit you belong to. The Son of Man did not come to destroy people's lives. He came to save them" are missing in many old manuscripts. The WEB has them. They fit well with Luke 19:10.

For today: Whoever is rejected should not answer with hatred and violence.

What it means to follow Jesus VERSES 57–62

57 They were walking along the road.
A man said to Jesus,
"Lord, I will follow you
wherever you go."
58 Jesus said to him,
"Foxes have holes.
Birds have nests.
But the Son of Man has no place
where he can lay down his head."
59 Jesus said to another man,
"Follow me!"
But the man said,
"Lord, let me first go and bury my father."
60 Jesus said to him,
"Let the dead bury their own dead.
But you must go and tell about God's Kingdom."
61 Another man said,
"Lord, I will follow you.
But first let me say good-bye
to my family at home."
62 Jesus said to him,
"No one who puts his hand to the plow
and then looks back
is fit for God's Kingdom."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus is on the way. Whoever goes with him has to give up security and comfort.

Verse 60 sounds very harsh. The duty to bury your parents was sacred. Some interpreters think: The father was still alive, and the son wanted to wait until he had died. What is certain: With a sharp picture Jesus says that God's Kingdom comes first now. "The dead" are probably those who are not spiritually alive.

Verses 61–62: Whoever plows and looks back plows a crooked furrow. Elijah still allowed Elisha to say good-bye (1 Kings 19:19–21). Here Jesus is even stricter.

Important: Jesus does not demand that you treat your family without love. It is about a clear decision. Groups that want to cut people off from their families sometimes appeal to verses like these. If you have questions like this, you can find advice, for example, from counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse.

LUKE

Chapter 10

Who is my neighbor?

Jesus sends out 70 disciples VERSES 1–16

1 After this the Lord chose 70 other disciples.
He sent them out two by two ahead of him.
They went to every town and place
where he was going to come.
2 He said to them,
"There is a big harvest,
but there are only a few workers.
So pray to the Lord of the harvest.
Ask him to send out workers into his harvest.
3 Go now!
I am sending you out like lambs among wolves.
4 Don't take a money bag.
Don't take a traveler's bag or sandals.
Don't stop to greet anyone on the way.
5 When you go into a house,
first say,
'Peace be with this house.'
6 If a son of peace lives there,
your peace will stay with him.
If not,
your peace will come back to you.
7 Stay in that same house.
Eat and drink what they give you.
For a worker deserves his pay.
Don't move from house to house.
8 When you go into a town
and the people welcome you,
eat what they put in front of you.
9 Heal the sick people there.
Tell them,
'God's Kingdom has come near to you.'
10 But sometimes you will go into a town
where the people do not welcome you.
Then go out into its streets and say,
11 'We wipe off even the dust of your town
that sticks to us.
We wipe it off against you.
But know this:
God's Kingdom has come near to you.'
12 I tell you,
on that day it will be easier for Sodom
than for that town.
13 How terrible it will be for you, Chorazin!
How terrible it will be for you, Bethsaida!
The great miracles that were done in you
could have been done in Tyre and Sidon.
Then the people there would have turned away from
their sins long ago.
They would have sat in sackcloth and ashes.
14 But on judgment day it will be easier for Tyre and Sidon
than for you.
15 And you, Capernaum,
you are lifted up to heaven.
But you will be brought down to Hades.
16 Whoever listens to you
listens to me.
Whoever rejects you
rejects me.
And whoever rejects me
rejects the one who sent me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Not only the Twelve, but many more people are sent out. The WEB, our English source text, says 70. Many old manuscripts say 72. Both numbers remind us of the list of nations in Genesis 10: The message is to reach all nations.

"Two by two": No one is to travel alone. Two can help each other. And two witnesses were considered trustworthy.

Verse 4: "Don't stop to greet anyone on the way": Back then greetings were long and complicated. The messengers are not to let themselves be held up. It is not unfriendliness.

Verse 6: "A son of peace": someone who is open to God's peace.

Verse 7: "A worker deserves his pay" means: Whoever works has earned his pay. This sentence is quoted again later in 1 Timothy 5:18.

Verses 12–15: In the Bible, Sodom, Tyre and Sidon were cities known as godless. Chorazin, Bethsaida and Capernaum were on the Sea of Galilee. Jesus had done a lot there. The cry "How terrible it will be for you" (in the WEB: "woe") is a serious lament, as with the prophets.

"Sackcloth and ashes": signs of mourning and being sorry. Sackcloth was rough cloth. Hades: the realm of the dead.

Important: The messengers are not to punish. Judgment is God's business. They are to move on.

The 70 return VERSES 17–20

17 The 70 came back full of joy.
They said,
"Lord, even the demons obey us
when we use your name!"
18 Jesus said to them,
"I saw Satan fall from heaven
like lightning.
19 Listen!
I have given you authority to step on snakes and
scorpions.
I have given you authority over all the power of the
enemy.
Nothing at all will hurt you.
20 But don't be glad because the spirits obey you.
Be glad because your names are written in heaven."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: Jesus sees: The power of evil is broken. With Jesus, God's Kingdom begins, and evil loses.

Verse 19: Serpents (snakes) and scorpions are pictures of everything dangerous and evil (compare Psalm 91:13).

Important: This verse is not a call to put yourself in danger on purpose. Some groups play with poisonous snakes. That is life-threatening and is not what is meant.

Verse 20: More important than success and great deeds is this: God knows you and has written down your name. You belong to him.

Jesus rejoices VERSES 21–24

21 At that time Jesus was full of joy in the Holy Spirit.
He said,
"I thank you, Father,
Lord of heaven and earth.
You have hidden these things
from people who are wise and clever.
And you have shown them to little children.
Yes, Father,
this is what pleased you."
22 Jesus turned to the disciples and said,
"My Father has given me everything.
No one knows who the Son is,
except the Father.
And no one knows who the Father is,
except the Son.
And the Son can show the Father
to anyone he chooses."
23 Then Jesus turned to the disciples.
He said to them alone,
"Blessed are the eyes
that see what you see.
24 I tell you,
many prophets and kings wanted to see what you see.
But they did not see it.
They wanted to hear what you hear.
But they did not hear it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21: Only Luke says: Jesus rejoiced "in the Holy Spirit." Here Father, Son and Holy Spirit are named together. Christians think of this when they speak of the Trinity.

"Little children" means simple people. God does not show himself first to scholars, but to those who are open like children.

Important: This is not criticism of education or of thinking. It is about pride and openness.

Verse 22: Jesus knows God the way a son knows his father. Through him people can get to know God.

Verse 24: The prophets of Israel hoped for this time. The disciples are living it.

The Good Samaritan VERSES 25–37

25 An expert in the law stood up.
He wanted to test Jesus.
He asked,
"Teacher, what must I do
to receive eternal life?"
26 Jesus said to him,
"What is written in the law?
What do you read there?"
27 The man answered,
"You shall love the Lord your God
with all your heart,
with all your soul,
with all your strength,
and with all your mind.
And you shall love your neighbor as yourself."
28 Jesus said to him,
"Your answer is right.
Do this, and you will live."
29 But the man wanted to show that he was right.
So he asked Jesus,
"Who is my neighbor?"
30 Jesus answered,
"A man was going down the road from Jerusalem to Jericho.
On the way robbers attacked him.
They took his clothes and beat him.
Then they went away
and left him lying there, almost dead.
31 It happened that a priest was going down that road.
He saw the man.
But he went past on the other side of the road.
32 Then a Levite came to that place too.
He saw the man.
But he also went past on the other side.
33 Then a Samaritan came.
He was traveling on that road.
He came to the place where the man was.
When he saw him,
he felt very sorry for him.
34 He went to the man.
He poured oil and wine on his wounds
and bandaged them.
Then he put the man on his own animal.
He brought him to an inn
and took care of him.
35 The next day the Samaritan had to leave.
He took out two denarii
and gave them to the innkeeper.
He said,
'Take care of him.
If you spend more than this,
I will pay you back when I return.'
36 Which of these three men do you think
was a neighbor to the man
whom the robbers attacked?"
37 The expert in the law said,
"The one who showed him mercy."
Jesus said to him,
"Go and do the same."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

An expert in the law was someone who studied and taught the law of Moses.

Verse 27: The expert in the law joins two commandments from the Holy Scriptures of Israel: Deuteronomy 6:5 (loving God) and Leviticus 19:18 (loving your neighbor). Jesus agrees with him. This is a shared Jewish heritage.

The road from Jerusalem to Jericho went about 3,300 feet (1,000 meters) downhill through the desert. It was dangerous and known for robbers.

Priests and Levites served in the temple. Why do they pass by? Jesus does not say. Some interpreters think of fear of robbers. Others think of the rule not to make yourself unclean by touching a dead body. But in Judaism too it was taught: Saving a human life is more important than almost all other commandments.

Important: The parable is not criticism of Judaism or of priests in general. Jesus and the expert in the law are both Jews. The point is that religion without mercy is empty. That applies to all religions, including Christians.

The surprise: Of all people, a Samaritan helps. Back then Jews and Samaritans were enemies (compare Luke 9:52–53). The foreigner becomes the example.

Back then oil and wine were used as medicine: Wine cleaned the wounds, oil soothed them.

Two denarii were the pay for two days of work. That was enough for several days at the inn.

Verse 36: Jesus turns the question around. Not: Who is my neighbor? But: To whom do I become a neighbor?

For today: Every person in need is my neighbor, no matter where they come from. In an accident or emergency: call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK) and give first aid.

Martha and Mary VERSES 38–42

38 Jesus and his disciples went on their way.
Jesus came to a village.
A woman named Martha welcomed him into her house.
39 She had a sister named Mary.
Mary sat at the feet of Jesus
and listened to what he said.
40 But Martha was busy
with all the work she had to do.
She came to Jesus and said,
"Lord, don't you care
that my sister has left me to do all the work alone?
Tell her to help me!"
41 Jesus answered her,
"Martha, Martha,
you are worried and upset
about many things.
42 But only one thing is needed.
Mary has chosen the good part.
It will not be taken away from her."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Martha and Mary also appear in the Gospel of John. There they live in Bethany, with their brother Lazarus (John 11:1).

"Sitting at someone's feet" was the position of a student with his teacher. Back then women were usually not allowed to learn from a teacher. Jesus clearly allows Mary to do so.

Jesus does not criticize Martha's hospitality. He sees her worry and lovingly calls her by name twice. Hospitality is good, as the Samaritan has just shown.

Verse 42: Some old manuscripts say here: Only a few things are needed, or really only one. The WEB follows the shorter reading.

The two stories belong together: The Samaritan shows how important doing is. Mary shows how important listening is. Both belong to faith.

For today: Sometimes it is more important to become quiet and listen than to always be busy.

LUKE

CHAPTER 11

"Lord, teach us to pray"

The Lord's Prayer VERSES 1–4

1 One time Jesus was praying in a certain place.
When he finished,
one of his disciples said to him,
"Lord, teach us to pray,
just as John taught his disciples."
2 Jesus said to them,
"When you pray, say:
'Our Father in heaven,
may your name be kept holy.
May your Kingdom come.
May your will be done
on earth as it is in heaven.
3 Give us each day
the bread we need for the day.
4 Forgive us our sins,
because we also forgive everyone
who owes us something.
Don't bring us into temptation.
But save us from the evil one.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Lord's Prayer is the most important prayer of Christians. It unites all churches. A longer form is in Matthew 6:9–13.

Jesus prays himself, and the disciples want to pray the way he does. He teaches them to call God "Father." That shows closeness and trust.

Many of the requests have roots in Jewish prayer, for example in the Kaddish, which asks that God's great name be made holy and that his kingdom come. Jesus prays as a Jew.

The oldest manuscripts of Luke have a shorter form. It begins simply with Father, and it does not have the words "Our," "in heaven," "May your will be done ..." and "But save us from the evil one." The WEB, our English source text, has the longer form.

"From the evil one": The WEB means evil as a person. It can also be understood as evil in general.

"Don't bring us into temptation": God does not want to lead anyone into evil (James 1:13). What is meant is: Keep us safe in hard tests.

For today: You don't need beautiful words to pray. You may tell God everything, as you would a good father or a good mother.

The friend at midnight VERSES 5–13

5 Then Jesus said to them,
"Imagine this:
One of you has a friend.

You go to him at midnight and say,
'Friend, lend me three loaves of bread.
6 A friend of mine has come to me from a trip.
I have nothing to give him to eat.'
7 And your friend answers from inside the house,
'Don't bother me!
The door is already locked.
My children are in bed with me.
I can't get up and give you anything.'
8 I tell you,
he may not get up and give him the bread
because he is his friend.
But he will get up because the man keeps on asking
and does not give up.
And he will give him as much as he needs.
9 So I tell you:
Keep asking, and you will receive.
Keep looking, and you will find.
Keep knocking, and the door will be opened for you.
10 For everyone who asks receives.
Everyone who looks finds.
And the door will be opened for everyone who knocks.
11 Which of you fathers would give your son a stone
when he asks for bread?
If he asks for a fish,
would you give him a snake instead?
12 If he asks for an egg,
would you give him a scorpion?
13 Even though you are evil,
you know how to give good gifts to your children.
So your Father in heaven will give even more.
He will give the Holy Spirit
to those who ask him!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then hospitality was a sacred duty. Leaving a guest without food was not possible. That is why the man goes to his neighbor in the middle of the night.

In a simple house the whole family slept in one room. Getting up would have woken everyone.

The man does not give up. He asks again and again. The WEB, our English source text, calls this "persistence."

Jesus says: If even a tired neighbor helps, how much more will God help, who loves us. You may keep on praying.

Verse 11: The words about bread and a stone are missing in some old manuscripts.

Verse 13: "Even though you are evil" means: You are not perfect. Even so, parents do good things for their children. God is much better still.

Only Luke says: God gives "the Holy Spirit." That is the best gift.

Important: Not every prayer is answered the way we wish. That does not mean someone believed too little. God still hears.

Sadly, there are parents who do not do good things for their children. Whoever experiences violence at home can get help. In the US, call or text Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. In the UK, call Childline at 0800 1111.

Jesus and Beelzebul VERSES 14–26

14 Jesus was driving out a demon
that made a man unable to speak.
When the demon had gone out,
the man spoke.
The crowds were amazed.
15 But some of them said,
"He drives out demons with the help of Beelzebul,
the ruler of the demons."
16 Others wanted to test Jesus.
They asked him for a sign from heaven.
17 But Jesus knew what they were thinking.
He said to them,
"Every kingdom that fights against itself
will be destroyed.
A family that fights against itself
will fall apart.
18 If Satan fights against himself,
how can his kingdom last?
I say this because you say
that I drive out demons with the help of Beelzebul.
19 If I drive out demons with Beelzebul's help,
then whose help do your children use to drive them
out?
So your children will be your judges.
20 But if I drive out demons by God's finger,
then God's Kingdom has come to you.
21 When a strong man with all his weapons
guards his own house,
his things are safe.
22 But someone stronger than he may attack him
and defeat him.
Then the stronger man takes away all the weapons
the strong man trusted in.
And he divides up the things he has taken.
23 Whoever is not with me
is against me.
Whoever does not gather with me
scatters.
24 An unclean spirit goes out of a person.
Then it travels through dry places
and looks for a place to rest.
But it finds none.
Then it says,
'I will go back to my house that I came out of.'
25 It comes back
and finds the house swept clean and in order.
26 Then it goes and gets seven other spirits
that are even more evil than itself.
They go in and live there.
In the end that person is worse off
than he was at first."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Beelzebul" was a name for the leader of the evil spirits. The name may come from an old idol (compare 2 Kings 1:2).

Jesus shows: The accusation makes no sense. Satan would not fight against himself.

Verse 19: "Your children" are Jewish people who at that time also cast out evil spirits. Jesus acknowledges them.

Verse 20: "God's finger" reminds us of the miracles in Egypt (Exodus 8:19; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 8:15). God himself is at work through Jesus.

Verses 21–22: The "strong man" is Satan. The one who is "stronger" is Jesus. He defeats the power of evil.

Verses 24–26: It is not enough that evil is gone. The "house" must not stay empty. It should be filled with good, with God's Spirit.

Important: Mental illnesses and disabilities such as being unable to speak are not possession. People back then explained many kinds of suffering this way. Today we know more about illnesses.

Who is truly blessed? VERSES 27–28

27 While Jesus was saying these things,
a woman in the crowd called out loudly to him,
"Blessed is the mother who gave birth to you
and who nursed you!"
28 But Jesus said,
"No, blessed are the people
who hear the word of God and obey it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Luke tells this little scene. The woman praises Jesus' mother. Back then that was great praise.

Here Jesus says "No." The WEB says "On the contrary." But the Greek word can also mean "rather" or "yes, but." Jesus does not reject the praise for his mother. He says: It is even more important to hear God's word and to live by it.

Mary herself is the best example of this (Luke 1:38,45; 2:19). She heard God's word and kept it.

The sign of Jonah VERSES 29–32

29 The crowds grew bigger and bigger.
Jesus began to say,
"The people of this generation are evil.
They want to see a sign.
But no sign will be given to them
except the sign of Jonah the prophet.
30 Jonah was a sign for the people of Nineveh.
In the same way, the Son of Man will be a sign
for this generation.
31 On judgment day the Queen of the South
will stand up with the people of this generation.
She will condemn them.
She came from the ends of the earth
to listen to the wisdom of Solomon.
And look:
Someone greater than Solomon is here!
32 On judgment day the men of Nineveh
will stand up with this generation.
They will condemn it.
For they turned away from their sins
when Jonah preached to them.
And look:
Someone greater than Jonah is here!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jonah was a prophet. He preached in Nineveh, a large city that did not belong to Israel. The people there turned back to God (Jonah 3).

The "Queen of the South" is the Queen of Sheba. She traveled far to hear King Solomon (1 Kings 10:1–13).

Both were non-Jews. They listened to God's messengers. Jesus says: Whoever hears Jesus now and does not turn back has fewer excuses than they did.

"This generation": Jesus speaks as a Jewish prophet to people of his time who did not want to accept him. This is not a judgment on the Jewish people for all time.

The light within you VERSES 33–36

33 "No one lights a lamp
and puts it in a cellar
or under a basket.
He puts it on a lampstand.
Then people who come in can see the light.
34 Your eye is the lamp of your body.
When your eye is good,
your whole body is full of light.
But when your eye is evil,
your body is full of darkness.
35 So be careful
that the light in you is not darkness.
36 Your whole body may be full of light,
with no part of it dark.
Then it will be completely full of light,
as when a lamp shines brightly on you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then people believed: The eye lets light into a person, like a window.

A "good" eye means: a clear, honest, generous way of looking. An "evil" eye means: envy, greed, a twisted way of looking.

For today: What matters is how I look at the world and at other people.

Jesus criticizes Pharisees and lawyers VERSES 37–54

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

In this section Jesus speaks very harsh words. Later they were often misused to despise and persecute Jews. That is a grave injustice.

Here Jesus speaks as a Jew to other Jews, like the prophets of Israel. He even eats with a Pharisee. His criticism is aimed at hypocrisy and injustice, which exist in every religion, including among Christians.

The Pharisees were devout people who wanted to live out God's commandments in everyday life. Later rabbinic Judaism grew out of them. Today the church teaches: The Jewish people are loved by God and not rejected (Romans 11:1–2,29; *Nostra Aetate* 1965).

37 While Jesus was speaking,
a Pharisee invited him to eat with him.
So Jesus went in
and sat down at the table.
38 The Pharisee was surprised
that Jesus did not wash first before the meal.
39 The Lord said to him,
"You Pharisees clean the outside of cups and plates.
But inside you are full of greed and evil.
40 You fools!
The one who made the outside
also made the inside, didn't he?
41 Give what is inside to the poor.
Then everything will be clean for you.
42 How terrible it will be for you Pharisees!
You give God a tenth of your mint and rue

and of every herb in your garden.
But you ignore justice and the love of God.
You should do these things,
without leaving the other things undone.
43 How terrible it will be for you Pharisees!
You love the most important seats in the synagogues.
You love it when people greet you with respect in the marketplaces.
44 How terrible it will be for you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites!
You are like graves that no one can see.
People walk over them
without knowing it."
45 One of the experts in the law said to Jesus,
"Teacher, when you say these things,
you insult us too."
46 Jesus said,
"How terrible it will be for you experts in the law too!
You put heavy loads on people
that are hard to carry.
But you yourselves will not lift one finger
to help them carry these loads.
47 How terrible it will be for you!
You build tombs for the prophets.
But it was your ancestors who killed them.
48 So you show that you agree
with what your ancestors did.
They killed the prophets,
and you build their tombs.
49 That is why the wisdom of God said,
'I will send them prophets and apostles.
They will kill some of them
and persecute others.'
50 So the people of this generation will be held responsible
for the blood of all the prophets
that has been spilled since the world was made,
51 from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zachariah.
Zachariah was killed between the altar and the temple.
Yes, I tell you,
this generation will be held responsible for it all.
52 How terrible it will be for you experts in the law!
You have taken away the key of knowledge.
You did not go in yourselves.
And you stopped others who were trying to go in."
53 Jesus said these things to them.
Then the scribes and the Pharisees became very angry with him.
They began to ask him hard questions about many things.
54 They were waiting to trap him.
They wanted to catch him saying something wrong,
so that they could accuse him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 38: Devout Jews washed their hands before eating, as a sign of purity before God. It was not a matter of hygiene, but a religious custom.

Verses 39–41: Jesus says: Outward purity is good. But the heart is more important. Whoever shares with the poor is pure inside.

Verse 42: The "tithe" was an offering for the temple and the poor: a tenth of the harvest (Deuteronomy 14:22). Mint and rue are garden herbs. Jesus does not say that tithing is wrong: "You should do these things, without leaving the other things undone" (11:42). But justice and love are more important. The prophets said this too (Micah 6:8).

Verse 44: Whoever touched a grave became unclean (Numbers 19:16). Jesus says: Whoever is a hypocrite makes others unclean without their noticing. The words "scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites" (11:44) are missing in many old manuscripts. The WEB has them.

The "experts in the law" (in the WEB: lawyers) knew the law of Moses very well. They were similar to the scribes.

Verses 47–48: Many prophets were persecuted in the history of Israel (for example Jeremiah). The Bible of Israel itself tells this honestly.

Verse 51: Abel is the first person who was murdered (Genesis 4:8). Zachariah was stoned in the temple courtyard (2 Chronicles 24:20–22). In the Hebrew Bible the Book of Chronicles comes at the end. So "from the blood of Abel to the blood of Zachariah" (11:51) means: from the beginning to the end of the Holy Scriptures.

Verses 50–51: "This generation": This is the language of the prophets. It is not a judgment on the whole Jewish people. The Bible says clearly: Each person is responsible only for their own guilt (Ezekiel 18:20).

Verse 52: The "key of knowledge" is the right understanding of the Holy Scriptures.

For today: These words are above all a warning to everyone who teaches and leads in the church: No hypocrisy, no heavy burdens for others, no obstacles on the way to God.

LUKE

CHAPTER 12

Don't be afraid, and be ready

No hypocrisy and no fear VERSES 1–12

1 In the meantime, many thousands of people had come together.
There were so many
that they were stepping on each other.
Jesus began to speak first to his disciples.
"Watch out for the yeast of the Pharisees.
Their yeast is hypocrisy.
2 Everything that is covered up will be uncovered.
Everything that is hidden will become known.
3 So what you have said in the dark
will be heard in the light.
What you have whispered in a back room
will be shouted from the rooftops.
4 I tell you, my friends,
don't be afraid of people who kill the body.
After that they cannot do anything more.
5 I will show you whom you should fear.
Fear the one who has power to throw you into Gehenna

after he has killed you.
Yes, I tell you, fear him!
6 Five sparrows are sold for two small coins, called assaria.
But God does not forget a single one of them.
7 God has even counted every hair on your head.
So don't be afraid.
You are worth more than many sparrows.
8 I tell you,
someone may say in front of people
that he belongs to me.
Then the Son of Man will also say in front of God's angels
that this person belongs to him.
9 But someone may say in front of people
that he does not know me.
Then he will be denied in front of God's angels.
10 Anyone who says something against the Son of Man will be forgiven.
But those who blaspheme against the Holy Spirit will not be forgiven.
11 People will bring you to the synagogues,
to the rulers and the authorities.
Then don't worry about how you will defend yourselves
or what you will say.
12 The Holy Spirit will teach you at that time
what you must say."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Yeast is a little bit of fermenting dough. It spreads through the whole dough. Hypocrisy can spread in the same way. Hypocrisy means: acting pious on the outside, but being different inside.

Important: Jesus warns against hypocrisy, not against Pharisees as people. Hypocrisy exists in every community, including among Christians.

Verse 5: "Gehenna" is the Valley of Hinnom near Jerusalem. In earlier times terrible sacrifices were made there (Jeremiah 7:31). Later the name became a picture of God's judgment. The one to fear is God. In the Bible, "fearing God" means: taking God seriously and having deep respect for him.

Verse 6: An assarion was a very small coin. Sparrows were the cheapest food for poor people. Even so, God forgets none of them.

Verse 7: For today: You matter to God endlessly. He knows you through and through.

Verse 10: Jesus says that "those who blaspheme against the Holy Spirit will not be forgiven." What this means is explained in different ways. Many interpreters say: What is meant is knowingly and permanently refusing God's forgiveness. Whoever is afraid of having committed this sin has probably not committed it, for that very reason. This fear shows that God matters to them.

Verses 11–12: The first Christians were put on trial. Jesus promises: You are not alone.

The rich fool VERSES 13–21

13 A man in the crowd said to Jesus,
"Teacher, tell my brother
to share our father's property with me."
14 But Jesus said to him,
"Man, who made me a judge or a referee between you two?"
15 Then he said to the people,
"Be careful!
Guard yourselves against every kind of greed.
A person's life does not depend
on how many things he owns,
even if he has more than enough."
16 Then Jesus told them a parable.
"A rich man had land
that grew a very big harvest.
17 He thought to himself,
'What shall I do?
I don't have enough room to store my crops.'
18 Then he said,
'I know what I will do.
I will tear down my barns
and build bigger ones.
There I will store all my grain
and all my other things.
19 Then I will say to myself,
"You have plenty of good things stored up for many years.
Take it easy!
Eat, drink, and enjoy yourself!"'
20 But God said to him,
'You fool!
Tonight your life will be taken from you.
Then who will get all the things you have stored up?'
21 That is how it will be
for anyone who gathers riches for himself
but is not rich toward God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–14: Back then teachers of the law often decided disputes about inheritance. Jesus does not want to be made into a judge. He sees a deeper problem: greed. A referee is someone who settles a dispute.

The rich man talks only to himself, and he talks only about what is his: I, my, my. He does not think of God, nor of other people who are hungry.

It is not wrong to put supplies aside. But possessions cannot make life secure. No one knows how long they will live.

In the Bible a "fool" means: someone who lives as if there were no God (Psalm 14:1).

Verse 21: Whoever shares and trusts God is "rich toward God."

For today: Questions to ask: What am I living for? What will I take with me when I die?

Don't worry VERSES 22–34

22 Then Jesus said to his disciples,
"So I tell you:
Don't worry about your life,
about what you will eat.
Don't worry about your body,
about what you will wear.
23 Life is more than food.
And the body is more than clothes.
24 Consider the ravens.
They don't plant seeds.

They don't harvest.
They have no storeroom or barn.
And God feeds them.
You are worth much more than birds!
25 Can any of you make yourself about 18 inches taller by
worrying?
26 You cannot do even such a small thing.
So why do you worry about the rest?
27 Look at the lilies and how they grow.
They do not work hard.
They do not make cloth.
But I tell you,
even King Solomon in all his glory
was not dressed as beautifully as one of these flowers.
28 God dresses the grass in the field like this.
Today the grass is here,
and tomorrow it is thrown into the oven.
So God will surely give you clothes too.
How little faith you have!
29 Don't keep thinking about what you will eat
or what you will drink.
Don't worry about it.
30 All the nations of the world run after these things.
But your Father knows that you need them.
31 Instead, look for God's Kingdom.
Then you will be given these things as well.
32 Don't be afraid, little flock.
Your Father is happy to give you the Kingdom.
33 Sell what you own
and give the money to the poor.
Get yourselves money bags that do not wear out.
Get yourselves a treasure in heaven that never runs
out.
No thief can come near it there.
No moth can destroy it there.
34 For where your treasure is,
there your heart will be too."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ravens counted as unclean animals (Leviticus 11:15). Even so, God takes care of them too.

Verse 25: Word for word it says: one cubit. A cubit was about 18 inches (half a meter). The Greek word can mean a person's height or the length of their life.

Verse 28: Dry grass was used as fuel for baking ovens.

Verse 30: "The nations of the world" means people who do not know God.

Verse 32: "Little flock": The disciples are few. But God gives them his Kingdom.

Important: Jesus does not say that you should not work or not plan ahead. He says: Don't let worries rule you. Trust God.

Important: People with anxiety disorders or depression are not lacking in faith. These are illnesses that can be treated. Doctors and therapists can help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

For today: Whoever relies on God can share more generously with others.

Be ready VERSES 35–48

35 "Be dressed and ready for work.
Keep your lamps burning.
36 Be like servants who are waiting for their master
to come back from a wedding feast.
When he comes and knocks,
they open the door for him at once.
37 Blessed are those servants
whom the master finds awake when he comes.
I tell you for certain:
He will get dressed to serve.
He will have them sit down at the table.
And he will come and serve them.
38 He may come in the second watch of the night,
or in the third.
Blessed are those servants
if he finds them ready.
39 But understand this:
If the owner of the house had known
at what hour the thief was coming,
he would have stayed awake.
He would not have let anyone break into his house.
40 You must be ready too.
The Son of Man will come at an hour
when you don't expect him."
41 Peter said,
"Lord, are you telling this parable only to us,
or to everyone?"
42 The Lord said,
"Who is the faithful and wise manager?
His master puts him in charge of his household.
He is to give the other servants their share of food
at the right time.
43 Blessed is that servant
if his master finds him doing his work
when he comes back.
44 I tell you the truth:
The master will put him in charge of everything he
owns.
45 But that servant may say to himself,
'My master is taking a long time to come back.'
He may begin to beat the other servants,
the men and the women.
He may eat and drink and get drunk.
46 Then the master of that servant will come
on a day when the servant does not expect him,
at an hour he does not know.
The master will cut him in two.
He will give him a place with the unfaithful.
47 A servant who knows what his master wants
but does not get ready
and does not do what his master wants
will be beaten many times.
48 But a servant who does not know what his master
wants
and does something that deserves a beating
will be beaten only a few times.
If someone has been given much,
much will be expected from him.
If someone has been trusted with much,
even more will be asked of him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 35: People tied up their long robes with a belt so that they could work or run. This means: Be ready.

Verse 37: A big surprise: The lord himself serves his servants! That is what Jesus did at the Last Supper (Luke 22:27).

Verse 38: The night was divided into watches. The second and third watches were the late hours of the night.

Verse 40: Christians believe that Jesus will come again. No one knows when.

The manager (in the WEB: steward) is someone who manages a household for its owner.

Verses 42–48: This applies especially to everyone who has responsibility, including in the church. They are to take care of others, not rule over them.

Important: The parables use pictures from the world of that time, in which slaves were beaten. That was cruel injustice. The pictures show how serious God's judgment is. They never permit violence against people. The beatings here mean blows with a whip. Whoever experiences violence can find help. In the US, call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. In the UK, call the National Domestic Abuse Helpline at 0808 2000 247.

Verses 47–48: God is just. Whoever knows more bears more responsibility.

For today: "If someone has been given much, much will be expected from him." That applies to gifts and talents, money, power and knowledge.

Jesus brings division VERSES 49–53

49 "I came to throw fire on the earth.
How I wish it were already burning!
50 But I have a baptism to go through.
How troubled I am until it is finished!
51 Do you think I came to bring peace on the earth?
No, I tell you.
I came to bring division.
52 From now on, five people in one family will be divided.
Three will be against two,
and two against three.
53 They will be divided:
A father will be against his son,
and a son against his father.
A mother will be against her daughter,
and a daughter against her mother.
A mother-in-law will be against her daughter-in-law,
and a daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 49: "Fire" is a picture of God's judgment and also of the Holy Spirit (Luke 3:16; Acts 2:3).

Verse 50: By "baptism" Jesus means his suffering and death. He will be completely "flooded" by it.

Verses 51–53: Jesus does not want strife. But the decision for or against him can divide families. The first Christians experienced this. Verse 53 reminds us of Micah 7:6.

Important: This is a description, not a command. No one should have to fight or leave their family in the name of faith. Groups that want to separate people from their families are dangerous. You can find advice, for example, from counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse.

Reading the signs of the times VERSES 54–59

54 Jesus also said to the crowds,
"You see a cloud coming up in the west.
At once you say, 'It is going to rain.'
And it does.
55 You feel the south wind blowing.
Then you say, 'It is going to be very hot.'
And it is.
56 You hypocrites!
You know how to understand the signs of the earth and the sky.
Why don't you understand the signs of this time?
57 Why don't you decide for yourselves what is right?
58 Someone may take you to court.
You are on your way to the magistrate.
Then try hard to settle the matter with him on the way.
If you don't, he may drag you to the judge.
The judge will hand you over to the officer.
And the officer will throw you into prison.
59 I tell you,
you will not get out of there
until you have paid the very last penny."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Israel the rain usually comes from the Mediterranean Sea in the west. The south wind comes from the desert and brings heat.

Jesus says: You are clever about the weather. But you do not see that God is acting through me now.

Magistrate: a judge or official of a court.

Verses 58–59: Whoever is in a dispute should make peace in time, before it is too late. That also applies before God: Now is the time to turn back.

Verse 59: The WEB, our English source text, says "penny." What is meant is the lepton, the smallest coin.

For today: Making peace is worth it. Whoever is in a dispute can also get help from a mediation or counseling service.

LUKE

CHAPTER 13

There is still time to turn back

A call to turn back VERSES 1–5

1 At that time some people were there with Jesus.
They told him about some people from Galilee.
Pilate had mixed their blood with their sacrifices.
That means: He had them killed while they were offering sacrifices.
2 Jesus answered them,
"These people from Galilee suffered such terrible things.

Do you think that this shows
they were worse sinners than all the other people in Galilee?
3 No, I tell you.
But if you do not turn away from your sins,
you will all be lost, just like them.
4 Or think about the 18 people in Siloam.
The tower fell on them and killed them.
Do you think they were more guilty
than all the other people who live in Jerusalem?
5 No, I tell you.
But if you do not turn away from your sins,
you will all be lost, just like them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Pilate had people from Galilee killed while they were sacrificing animals in the temple. We know about this event only from this passage. But it fits with what other ancient writers report about Pilate's brutality.

Verse 4: Siloam was a pool in Jerusalem. A tower had collapsed there.

Back then many people thought: Whoever suffers misfortune is being punished by God. Jesus says clearly: No! The victims of violence and accidents were not worse than others.

Important: Today too, accidents, illnesses, natural disasters or acts of violence are not a punishment from God for the victims.

To turn away from your sins (repent) means: turn around, change your life and turn back to God. To be lost (in the WEB: perish) means: to die and be lost.

Jesus turns the question around: Instead of judging others, each person should look at their own life and turn back.

The parable of the fig tree VERSES 6–9

6 Then Jesus told this parable.
"A man had a fig tree.
It was planted in his vineyard.
He came to look for fruit on it,
but he found none.
7 So he said to the man who took care of the vineyard,
'Look, for three years now I have come
to look for fruit on this fig tree.
But I have not found any.
Cut it down!
Why should it use up the soil?'
8 The man answered,
'Sir, leave it alone for one more year.
I will dig around it
and put fertilizer on it.
9 Maybe it will grow fruit next year.
That would be good.
If not, then you can cut it down.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A fig tree takes a few years before it bears fruit. After that it should bring fruit every year.

The man who takes care of the vineyard (in the WEB: the vine dresser) asks for time and does everything so that the tree can bear fruit. Many interpreters see in this a picture of Jesus, who speaks up for people before God.

God is patient. He gives time to turn back. But this time should be used.

For today: God does not give up on anyone quickly. It is never too late to start again.

Jesus heals a bent-over woman on the Sabbath VERSES 10–17

10 On a Sabbath day Jesus was teaching in one of the synagogues.
11 A woman was there.
For 18 years a spirit had made her sick.
She was bent over
and could not stand up straight at all.
12 When Jesus saw her,
he called her over.
He said to her,
"Woman, you are free from your sickness."
13 He put his hands on her.
At once she stood up straight
and began to praise God.
14 The leader of the synagogue was angry
because Jesus had healed on the Sabbath.
He said to the crowd,
"There are six days for work.
So come on those days to be healed.
Don't come on the Sabbath day!"
15 But the Lord answered him,
"You hypocrites!
On the Sabbath each of you unties his ox or his donkey from the stall.
Then you lead it out to give it water.
16 This woman is a daughter of Abraham.
Satan has kept her tied up for 18 long years.
Shouldn't she be set free from what tied her up,
even on the Sabbath day?"
17 When Jesus said this,
all who were against him were disappointed.
But the whole crowd was happy
about all the wonderful things he was doing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Luke tells this story. The woman had been bent over for 18 years. She could not look anyone in the eye.

"A spirit had made her sick": That is the language of that time for an illness. Today we might think of a disease of the spine.

Important: Illness is not a punishment and not possession. Whoever is sick is not less devout.

The Sabbath is the holy day of rest (Exodus 20:8–11). The leader of the synagogue wants to protect the commandment. That is a serious concern.

But Jesus says: The Sabbath is a very good day to set people free. The Sabbath is a reminder of the freedom from Egypt (Deuteronomy 5:15).

In Judaism too it is taught: To save a life, you may break the Sabbath. Jesus goes even further: A person who has suffered for a long time should not have to wait even one more day.

Verse 16: "A daughter of Abraham": Jesus gives her back her dignity. She belongs fully to God's people. Being tied up means: not being free.

Important: This story is not criticism of the Sabbath or of Judaism. It is about the question of how to live out God's commandment well. Jewish teachers also discussed this a great deal.

Mustard seed and yeast VERSES 18–21

18 Jesus said,
"What is God's Kingdom like?
What can I compare it to?
19 It is like a mustard seed.
A man took it
and planted it in his garden.
It grew and became a big tree.
The birds came and lived in its branches."
20 Jesus said again,
"What can I compare God's Kingdom to?
21 It is like yeast.
A woman took it
and mixed it into three measures of flour,
until all the dough had risen."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The mustard seed is very small. But the mustard plant can grow several yards (meters) tall.

The birds in the branches remind us of pictures from the Old Testament (Ezekiel 17:23; Daniel 4:12; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles Daniel 4:9): Many nations find shelter.

Three measures of flour are a very large amount, many pounds. You can bake bread from it for a great many people. A little yeast spreads through all of it. The dough rises because of the yeast.

A man and a woman are the main characters of these two parables. Luke often tells things in pairs like this.

For today: God's Kingdom begins small and unnoticed. But it grows and changes everything.

The narrow door VERSES 22–30

22 Jesus traveled through towns and villages.
He taught the people there.
He was on his way to Jerusalem.
23 Someone asked him,
"Lord, will only a few people be saved?"
Jesus said to the people,
24 "Try hard to go in through the narrow door.
I tell you, many people will try to go in,
but they will not be able to.
25 The owner of the house will get up
and lock the door.
Then you will stand outside,
knock at the door,
and say,
'Lord, Lord, open the door for us!'
But he will answer,
'I don't know you.
I don't know where you come from.'
26 Then you will say,
'We ate and drank with you.
You taught in our streets.'
27 But he will say,
'I tell you,
I don't know where you come from.
Go away from me,
all you who do evil!'
28 There will be weeping and gnashing of teeth there.
You will see Abraham, Isaac, Jacob,
and all the prophets in God's Kingdom.
But you yourselves will be thrown outside.
29 People will come from the east and the west,
from the north and the south.
They will sit down at the table in God's Kingdom.
30 Some who are last now will be first.
And some who are first now will be last."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus does not answer the question with a number. He says: Don't worry about how many there are. Make sure that you yourself go in. "Try hard" means: try with all your strength.

Verse 26: It is not enough just to know Jesus or to have been near him. What matters is how you live.

Verse 27 reminds us of Psalm 6:8 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 6:9). "You who do evil" means: people who do wrong.

"Weeping and gnashing of teeth" is a picture of despair and bitter regret. Gnashing means grinding your teeth.

Verse 29: People from all directions come to God's great feast. This reminds us of Isaiah 25:6 and Psalm 107:3. God's Kingdom is open to all nations.

Important: Abraham, Isaac, Jacob and the prophets are in God's Kingdom. The promise to Israel still stands. The warning applies to everyone who feels too sure of themselves, including Christians.

Jesus and Herod VERSES 31–35

31 At that time some Pharisees came to Jesus.
They said to him,
"Go away from here!
Herod wants to kill you."
32 Jesus said to them,
"Go and tell that fox:
'Listen! I drive out demons and heal people
today and tomorrow.
And on the third day I will finish my work.
33 But I must keep going
today and tomorrow and the next day.
For a prophet cannot die anywhere except in
Jerusalem.'
34 Jerusalem, Jerusalem!
You kill the prophets.
You throw stones at the people God sends to you.
How often I wanted to gather your children together,
like a hen gathers her chicks under her wings.
But you did not want it!
35 Look, your house is left to you empty and ruined.
I tell you,
you will not see me
until you say,
'Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 31: These Pharisees warn Jesus. They want to protect him. Not all Pharisees were against Jesus.

Herod is Herod Antipas, the ruler over Galilee. He had already had John the Baptizer killed.

"Fox" was a picture for a sly and unimportant ruler. Jesus does not let himself be frightened.

Verses 32–33: "Today and tomorrow. And on the third day …": This means a short time set by God. Christians also think of the resurrection on the third day.

Verse 33: With bitter irony Jesus says: Jerusalem is the place where prophets die. But Jerusalem is also God's holy city, which he loves.

Verse 34: Jesus laments with great love, like a mother who wants to protect her children. In the Bible God is also described with motherly pictures.

Verse 35: "Your house" probably means the temple and the city. Jesus foresees their destruction. It happened in the year AD 70 through the Romans. The words "Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord" come from Psalm 118:26.

Important: This is a prophet's lament out of love. It is not a curse on the Jewish people. The end even shows hope: Jerusalem will one day bless him.

LUKE

Chapter 14

The great feast

Jesus heals a sick man on the Sabbath VERSES 1–6

1 On a Sabbath Jesus went to eat a meal
at the house of one of the leading Pharisees.
The people there were watching him closely.
2 A man was there in front of Jesus.
He had dropsy.
3 Jesus asked the experts in the law and the Pharisees,
"Does the law allow healing on the Sabbath, or not?"
4 But they said nothing.
So Jesus took hold of the man,
healed him,
and sent him away.
5 Then Jesus said to them,
"Suppose your son or your ox falls into a well
on a Sabbath day.
Wouldn't any of you pull him out at once?"
6 They could not answer him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus eats at a Pharisee's house. He has connections with them and talks with them.

"Dropsy" is an illness in which water collects in the body. The legs and belly swell up. It can happen with heart or kidney disease.

Verse 5: Some manuscripts say donkey instead of son.

Jewish law also allowed saving a life on the Sabbath. Jewish teachers discussed how far this permission went. Jesus says: Helping a person is always right.

Important: This story is not criticism of the Sabbath. The Sabbath is a gift from God.

The right place at the feast VERSES 7–14

7 Jesus noticed how the guests chose the best seats at the table.
So he told them a parable.
8 "When someone invites you to a wedding feast,
don't sit down in the best seat.
Maybe someone more important than you has been invited too.
9 Then the man who invited both of you
will come and say to you,
'Give this man your seat.'
Then you will feel ashamed
and have to take the lowest place.
10 So when you are invited,
go and sit in the lowest place.
Then the man who invited you will come and say to you,
'Friend, move up to a better place.'
Then you will be honored
in front of all the other guests at the table.
11 For everyone who lifts himself up
will be humbled.
And whoever humbles himself
will be lifted up."
12 Jesus also said to the man who had invited him,
"When you give a lunch or a dinner,
don't invite your friends,
your brothers,
your relatives,
or your rich neighbors.
They might invite you back.
Then you would be paid back.
13 Instead, when you give a feast,
invite poor people,
crippled people,
lame people, and blind people.
14 Then you will be blessed.
They cannot pay you back.
But you will be paid back
when the people who do what is right rise from the dead."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At feasts back then the seating order was very important. It showed how much honor someone had.

Verses 8–10 remind us of Proverbs 25:6–7: "It is better that someone says to you, 'Come up here!'"

Verse 11: God does not look at rank and honor. Whoever makes himself small, God makes great. Mary already sang about this in her song (Luke 1:52). Humbled: made low.

Verses 12–14: Jesus turns the rules upside down. Normally you invite those who will invite you back. Jesus says: Invite those who cannot give anything back.

The "crippled" (the WEB, our English source text, says "maimed") were people with injuries or disabilities. Back then they were often shut out. Jesus says: They belong at the table, as honored guests.

Important: People with disabilities are not just people to feel sorry for. They have the same dignity as everyone.

For today: Whom do I invite? Who sits at our table, in the family, in the church, in society?

The parable of the great supper VERSES 15–24

15 One of the guests at the table heard this.
He said to Jesus,

"Blessed is the person who will eat at the feast in God's Kingdom!"

16 Jesus said to him,
"A man was giving a big dinner.
He invited many people.
17 When it was time for the dinner,
he sent his servant to tell the guests,
'Come! Everything is ready now.'
18 But one after another, they all began to make excuses.
The first one said,
'I have bought a field.
I must go and look at it.
Please excuse me.'
19 Another one said,
'I have bought five pairs of oxen.
I am going to try them out.
Please excuse me.'
20 Another one said,
'I have just gotten married.
So I can't come.'
21 The servant came back
and told his master about this.
Then the owner of the house became angry.
He said to his servant,
'Go out quickly into the streets and alleys of the town.
Bring in the poor, the crippled,
the blind, and the lame.'
22 Later the servant said,
'Master, I have done what you told me.
But there is still room.'
23 The master said to the servant,
'Go out to the roads and the country lanes.
Make the people come in,
so that my house will be full.
24 I tell you,
not one of the men I invited
will taste my dinner.
For many are called,
but few are chosen.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then people were invited twice: first an invitation in advance, then a message when the meal was ready. Whoever first accepted and then cancelled insulted the host.

The excuses sound polite, but they are weak. You look at a field before you buy it. You try out oxen before you buy them. The five pairs of oxen pull together, two by two. The WEB calls a pair a "yoke."

Verse 20: According to Deuteronomy 24:5, a newly married man was free from military service. But he could still have come to a feast.

The supper is a picture of God's Kingdom. God invites everyone. Whoever does not come shuts themselves out.

Verse 21: The poor, people with disabilities and people on the margins are invited. Verse 23: Then also the people far outside, in the countryside. Many interpreters think of the non-Jews here.

Important: Verse 23 ("Make the people come in"; the WEB says "compel them to come in") was terribly misused in church history. People appealed to it to force others into the faith by violence, including Jews and people who thought differently. That was grave injustice. What is meant is: Invite people so warmly that they dare to come. Faith can never be forced.

Important: The parable is also not a judgment on the Jewish people. It is a warning to everyone who does not take God's invitation seriously, including Christians.

Verse 24: The words "For many are called, but few are chosen" are not in most old manuscripts of Luke. The WEB, our English source text, has them here. They are also in Matthew 22:14.

What it costs to follow Jesus VERSES 25–35

25 Large crowds were traveling with Jesus.
He turned around and said to them,
26 "Someone may come to me.
But he must put his own father and mother in second place,
and his wife and children,
and his brothers and sisters,
yes, and even his own life.
If he does not, he cannot be my disciple.
27 Whoever does not carry his own cross
and follow me
cannot be my disciple.
28 Suppose one of you wants to build a tower.
First you sit down and figure out how much it will cost.
You check whether you have enough money to finish it.
29 If you don't do that,
you may lay the foundation
and then not be able to finish the tower.
Then everyone who sees it will laugh at you.
30 They will say,
'This man started to build,
but he could not finish.'
31 Or suppose a king is going to war against another king.
First he will sit down and think about it.
He has 10,000 soldiers.
Can he fight against the king
who is coming with 20,000?
32 If he can't,
he will send a messenger to the other king
while the other king is still far away.
He will ask for peace.
33 In the same way, any of you
who does not give up everything he has
cannot be my disciple.
34 Salt is good.
But if salt loses its taste,
how can you make it salty again?
35 It is no good for the soil
or even for the manure pile.
People throw it away.
Whoever has ears to hear should listen!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 26: The WEB says "disregard," that is: not pay attention to, put second. In the Greek there is a word that is often translated "hate." But in the language of the Bible it means: love less, put in second place (compare Genesis 29:30–31). Matthew says it this way: "Whoever loves father or mother more than me is not worthy of me" (Matthew 10:37).

Important: Jesus does not want anyone to hate their family or treat them without love. The commandment to honor your father and your mother still applies (Luke 18:20). Groups that force people to leave their families misuse these words. You can find advice, for example, from counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse.

Important: Putting your own life second also does not mean despising or harming yourself. If you are thinking about hurting yourself or ending your life, please get help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verses 28–32: Two examples: building a tower, and a king before a war. Both say: Think carefully before you decide. Following Jesus is a decision for your whole life. The king sends a messenger to ask for peace.

Verse 33: Give up everything (the WEB says "renounce"). In Luke, freedom from possessions is very important. Not all disciples had to sell everything. But nothing should be more important than God.

Verses 34–35: Back then salt was often mixed with other substances and could lose its taste. Disciples are to be like good salt: They give the world flavor.

LUKE

CHAPTER 15

Lost and found

The lost sheep VERSES 1–7

1 All the tax collectors and sinners
were coming to Jesus to listen to him.
2 The Pharisees and the scribes complained.
They said,
"This man welcomes sinners
and even eats with them."
3 So Jesus told them this parable.
4 "Suppose one of you has 100 sheep,
and one of them gets lost.
Won't he leave the 99 sheep in the wilderness?
Won't he go and look for the lost sheep
until he finds it?
5 When he finds it,
he puts it on his shoulders.
He is very happy.
6 He comes home.
He calls his friends and neighbors together.
He says to them,
'Be happy with me!
I have found my sheep that was lost!'
7 I tell you,
it is the same in heaven.
There is more joy in heaven
over one sinner who turns away from his sins
than over 99 good people
who do not need to turn away from their sins."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: The devout teachers are upset that Jesus eats with "sinners." Back then eating together meant: We belong together. Jesus answers with three parables.

The Pharisees and scribes wanted to keep God's commandments faithfully. Their concern was meant seriously. Jesus wants to win them over, not condemn them. The parables are also about them, especially the older brother.

A shepherd counted his sheep every evening. A sheep on its own was in great danger.

In the Old Testament God himself is the shepherd who looks for what is lost (Ezekiel 34:11–16; Psalm 23).

Verse 5: The shepherd does not scold. He carries the sheep home, full of joy.

Verse 7: "99 good people who do not need to turn away from their sins": This sounds almost a little ironic. Who doesn't need to turn back?

For today: No person is worth too little to God. He looks for every single one.

The lost coin VERSES 8–10

8 "Or suppose a woman has 10 silver coins called drachmas,
and she loses one of them.
Won't she light a lamp
and sweep the house?
Won't she search carefully
until she finds the coin?
9 When she finds it,
she calls her friends and neighbors together.
She says,
'Be happy with me!
I have found the coin that I lost!'
10 I tell you,
it is the same with the angels of God.
They are full of joy
over one sinner who turns away from his sins."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A drachma was a silver coin. It was worth about one day's pay. For a poor woman that was a lot of money.

The houses had hardly any windows and were dark. That is why she needs a lamp.

After the shepherd, Jesus tells about a woman. In this parable a woman stands for God, who searches. That is remarkable.

Verse 9: In the Greek, the words for friends and neighbors here are female: She calls together her women friends and neighbors.

For today: God searches with great effort. And there is a celebration in heaven when someone finds their way home.

The lost son and his brother VERSES 11–32

11 Jesus said,
"A man had two sons.
12 The younger son said to his father,
'Father, give me my share of your property.'

So the father divided his property between his two sons.
13 A few days later the younger son packed up everything he had.
He traveled to a country far away.
There he wasted his money on wild living.
14 He spent everything he had.
Then there was a terrible famine in that country.
There was not enough food.
The son began to go hungry.
15 He went to work for a man in that country.
The man sent him into his fields to feed pigs.
16 The son was so hungry
that he wanted to eat the pods the pigs were eating.
But no one gave him anything.
17 Then he came to his senses.
He said,
'My father's hired workers have more than enough food.
But here I am, dying of hunger!
18 I will get up and go back to my father.
I will say to him,
"Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you.
19 I am not good enough anymore
to be called your son.
Let me be like one of your hired workers."'
20 So the son got up
and went back to his father.
He was still a long way off
when his father saw him.
His father felt deep love and pity for him.
He ran to his son,
threw his arms around his neck,
and kissed him.
21 The son said to him,
'Father, I have sinned against heaven and against you.
I am not good enough anymore
to be called your son.'
22 But the father said to his servants,
'Bring out the best robe and put it on him.
Put a ring on his finger
and sandals on his feet.
23 Bring the calf we have been fattening.
Kill it.
Let's eat and celebrate!
24 For this son of mine was dead,
and now he is alive again.
He was lost,
and now he is found.'
And they began to celebrate.
25 The older son was out in the field.
He came back
and came near the house.
Then he heard music and dancing.
26 He called one of the servants
and asked him what was going on.
27 The servant said to him,
'Your brother has come home.
Your father has killed the fattened calf,
because your brother has come back safe and healthy.'
28 But the older brother became angry.
He did not want to go in.
So his father came out
and begged him to come in.
29 But the older son answered his father,
'Look! For so many years I have served you.
I have never disobeyed your orders.
But you never gave me even a young goat,
so that I could celebrate with my friends.
30 But this son of yours wasted your money on prostitutes.
And when he comes home,
you kill the fattened calf for him!'
31 The father said to him,
'Son, you are always with me.
Everything I have is yours.
32 But we had to celebrate and be glad.
For this brother of yours was dead,
and now he is alive again.
He was lost,
and now he is found.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This parable is one of the best known in the Bible. Only Luke tells it. It is often called the "parable of the lost son," sometimes also the parable of the loving father, because the father is the main character.

Verse 12: Asking for your inheritance while your father was still alive was a deep insult back then. It was almost like saying: I wish you were dead. Even so, the father gives in.

Verse 13: "Wild living" means: a wild, wasteful life.

Verses 15–16: For Jews, pigs counted as unclean (Leviticus 11:7). The son could hardly sink any lower. The "pods" were probably the fruit of the carob tree, which was used as animal feed.

Verse 17: "He came to his senses": He sees honestly how things stand with him. That is the beginning of turning back.

Verse 20: The father waits and keeps watch. He runs to meet his son. For an older man back then, running was almost undignified. But love is greater than dignity.

Verse 21: The father does not even let the son finish the speech he had prepared. Some old manuscripts add here: "Let me be like one of your hired workers."

Verse 22: Robe, ring and sandals are signs: You are fully my son again. Slaves went barefoot, sons wore sandals. The fattened calf was kept for a special feast.

Verses 25–32: The older brother is faithful, but bitter. He does not say "my brother," but "this son of yours." The father goes out to him too and invites him. He loves both sons.

Verse 30: Only the older brother says that the younger son lived with prostitutes. Verse 13 only says "wild living."

The parable ends openly: Will the older brother go in and celebrate too? Jesus leaves the question open for the listeners, including the Pharisees and scribes from verse 2.

Important: The older brother is not a picture of the Jews, and the younger is not a picture of Christians. Both can be found in every person: the one who runs away, and the one who does not want to join the celebration.

For today: God waits for everyone who comes back. No one is too far away. And: Be glad with others when someone else receives grace.

Chapter 16

God or money

The clever manager VERSES 1–13

1 Jesus also said to his disciples,
"There was a rich man who had a manager.
People told the rich man
that his manager was wasting his money and property.
2 So the rich man called the manager and said to him,
'What is this I hear about you?
Show me the records of your work.
You cannot be my manager any longer.'
3 The manager thought to himself,
'What shall I do now?
My master is taking my job away from me.
I am not strong enough to dig.
And I am ashamed to beg.
4 I know what I will do!
Then people will welcome me into their homes
when I lose my job.'
5 So the manager called in each person
who owed his master something.
He asked the first one,
'How much do you owe my master?'
6 The man said,
'100 batos of oil.'
The manager said to him,
'Here is your bill.
Sit down quickly and write 50.'
7 Then he asked another one,
'How much do you owe?'
The man said,
'100 cors of wheat.'
The manager said to him,
'Here is your bill.
Write 80.'
8 The master praised the dishonest manager,
because he had acted cleverly.
The children of this world
are more clever with people like themselves
than the children of the light are.
9 I tell you,
use unjust mammon to make friends for yourselves.
Then, when you fail,
your friends will welcome you into the eternal homes.
10 Whoever can be trusted with very little
can also be trusted with much.
Whoever is dishonest with very little
is also dishonest with much.
11 You may not have been faithful with unjust mammon.
Then who will trust you with the true riches?
12 You may not have been faithful with what belongs to
someone else.
Then who will give you what belongs to you?
13 No servant can serve two masters.
He will hate one and love the other.
Or he will be loyal to one and look down on the other.
You cannot serve both God and Mammon."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This parable is hard to understand. Jesus does not praise cheating. He praises the manager for thinking cleverly about his future.

Verses 6–7: The WEB, our English source text, names "batos" and "cors." These were units of measure. A batos of oil was several gallons, a cor of wheat was a large amount, many pounds. These are big quantities.

Some interpreters think: Perhaps the manager crossed out his own share, or hidden interest. Taking interest from fellow Jews was forbidden by the law (Deuteronomy 23:19; in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 23:20). But this is not certain.

Verse 8: The "children of this world" are people who think only of this world. The "children of the light" are those who belong to God. Jesus says: Worldly people are often more determined than devout people.

Verse 9: "Mammon" is an Aramaic word for money and possessions. Jesus calls it "unjust" because money is often tied up with injustice. Money should be used to do good and help others.

Verse 13: Money can become like a god that you serve. Jesus says: Decide. God should come first.

For today: Money is not evil. But it must not rule my life. Whoever has fallen into financial trouble or debt can find help from nonprofit debt counseling services.

The law and God's Kingdom VERSES 14–18

14 The Pharisees heard all these things.
They loved money.
So they made fun of Jesus.
15 Jesus said to them,
"You try to make yourselves look good in front of
people.
But God knows your hearts.
What people think is very important
is disgusting to God.
16 The law and the prophets were until John.
Since that time the Good News of God's Kingdom is
told,
and everyone is forcing his way into it.
17 But it is easier for heaven and earth to disappear
than for the smallest stroke of a pen in the law to drop
out.
18 Any man who divorces his wife
and marries another woman
commits adultery.
And a man who marries a woman
who has been divorced by her husband
commits adultery."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: Here Luke says of certain Pharisees that they loved money.

Important: This is not a judgment on all Pharisees or on the Jewish people. Many Pharisees lived simple, devout lives. The love of money is a danger for all people, including Christians and churches.

Verse 15: God does not look at the outside, but at the heart (1 Samuel 16:7). The WEB says: an "abomination" to God, something God finds disgusting.

Verse 16: With John the Baptizer a new time begins. "Everyone is forcing his way into it" is understood in different ways: Many people badly want to get into God's Kingdom. Or: You have to try with all your strength.

Verse 17: God's law stays valid. Jesus does not cancel the Torah. That is important for the relationship between Christians and Jews.

Verse 18: Back then a man could easily divorce his wife. The woman was then often left without protection or support. With these words Jesus especially protects women. Adultery means breaking the faithfulness of a marriage.

Today the churches deal with divorce in different ways. The Catholic Church holds that a marriage cannot be dissolved, but it has a process for declaring a marriage null. Protestant and Orthodox churches allow a new marriage under certain circumstances.

Important: No one has to stay in a marriage where they experience violence. In the US, call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. In the UK, call the National Domestic Abuse Helpline at 0808 2000 247. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

The rich man and poor Lazarus VERSES 19–31

19 "There was a rich man.
He wore purple clothes and fine linen.
Every day he lived in luxury.
20 A poor man named Lazarus
was laid at the rich man's gate.
Lazarus was a beggar.
His body was full of sores.
21 He wanted so much to eat
the crumbs that fell from the rich man's table.
Even the dogs came and licked his sores.
22 Then the beggar died.
The angels carried him to Abraham's side.
The rich man also died
and was buried.
23 In Hades the rich man was in great pain.
He looked up
and saw Abraham far away,
with Lazarus at his side.
24 He called out,
'Father Abraham, have mercy on me!
Send Lazarus to dip the tip of his finger in water
and cool my tongue.
I am suffering terribly in this fire!'
25 But Abraham said,
'Son, remember:
During your life you received good things.
And in the same way, Lazarus received bad things.
But now he is comforted here,
and you are suffering.
26 And besides all this,
there is a deep valley between us and you.
No one can cross it.
People who want to go from here to you cannot do it.
And no one can come over from there to us.'
27 The rich man said,
'Then I beg you, father,
send Lazarus to my father's house.
28 I have five brothers.
He should warn them,
so that they will not also come to this place of pain.'
29 But Abraham said to him,
'They have Moses and the prophets.
They should listen to them.'
30 The rich man said,
'No, father Abraham!
But if someone comes to them from the dead,
then they will turn away from their sins.'
31 Abraham said to him,
'If they don't listen to Moses and the prophets,
they will not be persuaded
even if someone rises from the dead.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Luke tells this story. The poor man has a name: Lazarus. It means "God helps." The rich man has no name.

Purple was very expensive. Only kings and very rich people wore purple.

Verse 21: Dogs counted as unclean. The poor man is so weak that he cannot defend himself against them. Sores: open wounds on the skin.

The rich man does nothing bad to Lazarus. But he overlooks him every day, right at his door. That is his guilt.

"Abraham's side" (the WEB says "Abraham's bosom") is a picture of the place of honor at God's feast, very close to Abraham.

Verse 23: "Hades" is the place of the dead. Here Jesus uses pictures that people back then knew. The parable does not want to describe exactly what it is like after death. It wants to warn: How I live now matters.

Verses 29–31: "Moses and the prophets" are the Holy Scriptures of Israel. They already say everything you need to know about justice and the poor (for example Deuteronomy 15:7–11).

Verse 31: Christians think of Jesus' resurrection here. Even that does not convince everyone.

For today: Who is lying at my door? Whom do I overlook? Poverty is not far away; it is often very close.

LUKE

CHAPTER 17

Thankfulness and watchfulness

Stumbling, forgiveness and faith VERSES 1–10

1 Jesus said to his disciples,
"Things that make people fall into sin will surely come.
But how terrible it will be for the person who causes them!

2 Suppose someone causes one of these little ones to fall into sin.
It would be better for him
to have a millstone tied around his neck
and to be thrown into the sea.
3 So be careful!
If your brother sins against you,
tell him that he did wrong.
If he is sorry and turns away from his sin,
forgive him.
4 He may sin against you seven times in one day.
And seven times he may come back to you and say,
'I am sorry.'
Then you must forgive him."
5 The apostles said to the Lord,
"Make our faith stronger!"
6 The Lord said,
"Suppose your faith were only as big as a mustard seed.
Then you could say to this sycamore tree,
'Pull yourself up by the roots
and plant yourself in the sea!'
And it would obey you.
7 Suppose one of you has a servant.
The servant has been plowing the field or taking care of the sheep.
He comes in from the field.
Would you say to him,
'Come at once and sit down at the table'?
8 No, you would say to him,
'Make my dinner.
Get dressed and serve me
while I eat and drink.
After that you can eat and drink.'
9 Do you thank the servant
because he did what he was told?
I don't think so.
10 It is the same with you.
When you have done everything you were told to do,
you should say,
'We are servants who deserve no thanks.
We have only done our duty.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: "These little ones" are children and people whose faith is still weak or who are easily hurt. Whoever leads them into evil or destroys their faith takes on heavy guilt. Jesus speaks of things that make people fall into sin. The WEB, our English source text, calls them "occasions of stumbling." A millstone was a heavy stone for grinding grain.

Important: These words show how seriously Jesus takes the protection of the weak. This applies most of all to the abuse of children, including in churches. In the US, call RAINN at 1-800-656-4673, or call or text Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. In the UK, call Childline at 0800 1111.

Verse 3: The words "against you" are not in all manuscripts.

Verses 3–4: Forgiveness should be generous, again and again. But Jesus also says: Wrong should be spoken about. Telling someone that they did wrong should be done clearly, but with love.

Important: Forgiving does not mean that you have to let yourself be hurt again. Whoever experiences violence may protect themselves and keep their distance. Forgiveness often takes a long time.

Verse 6: The sycamore tree here is a kind of fig tree with very deep roots. Even a tiny faith can do the impossible, because God is at work.

Verses 7–10: Jesus uses a picture from the working world of that time, with servants. He says: We cannot boast before God about what we achieve. The good we do is simply what we should do.

Important: The picture does not justify slavery or exploitation. And it stands in contrast to Luke 12:37: There the lord himself serves his servants. That is what God is like.

10 lepers are healed VERSES 11–19

11 Jesus was on his way to Jerusalem.
He was traveling along the border between Samaria and Galilee.
12 He was going into a village.
10 men who had leprosy came to meet him.
They stood at a distance.
13 They called out loudly,
"Jesus, Master,
have mercy on us!"
14 Jesus saw them.
He said to them,
"Go and show yourselves to the priests."
And while they were on their way,
they were made clean.
15 One of them saw that he was healed.
He came back
and praised God with a loud voice.
16 He bowed down with his face to the ground
at the feet of Jesus
and thanked him.
This man was a Samaritan.
17 Jesus asked,
"Weren't all 10 men made clean?
Where are the other nine?
18 Only this foreigner came back
to give praise to God.
Didn't anyone else come back?"
19 Then Jesus said to the man,
"Get up and go on your way.
Your faith has healed you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

People with leprosy had to keep their distance (Leviticus 13:45–46). That is why they call out from far away.

Verse 14: According to the law of Moses, a priest had to confirm that someone was well again (Leviticus 14). The 10 set out before they are healed. That is trust.

The other nine do nothing wrong. They do what Jesus told them. But only one comes back to say thank you.

The thankful one is a Samaritan, a foreigner. Back then Jews and Samaritans were enemies. In their shared need they were together.

Verse 19: All 10 became well. But only to this one does Jesus say: "Your faith has healed you." The Greek word can also mean "saved." He received more than health: an encounter with God.

For today: Saying thank you is important, to God and to people.

When does God's Kingdom come? VERSES 20–36

20 The Pharisees asked Jesus
when God's Kingdom would come.
He answered them,
"God's Kingdom does not come
in a way that people can see with their eyes.
21 People will not say,
'Look, here!'
or, 'Look, there!'
For God's Kingdom is within you."
22 Then Jesus said to his disciples,
"The time will come
when you will long to see one of the days of the Son of Man.
But you will not see it.
23 People will say to you,
'Look, here!'
or, 'Look, there!'
Don't go there.
Don't run after them.
24 Lightning flashes
and lights up the sky from one side to the other.
That is how the Son of Man will be on his day.
25 But first he must suffer many things.
The people of this generation will reject him.
26 It was like this in the days of Noah.
And it will be the same in the days of the Son of Man.
27 People were eating and drinking.
They were marrying,
and their children were being given in marriage.
This went on until the day Noah went into the ship.
Then the flood came
and destroyed them all.
28 It was the same in the days of Lot.
People were eating and drinking,
buying and selling,
planting and building.
29 But on the day Lot left Sodom,
fire and sulfur rained down from the sky
and destroyed them all.
30 It will be just like that
on the day when the Son of Man appears.
31 On that day, someone may be on the roof of his house,
and his things may be inside the house.
He must not go down to get them.
In the same way, someone in the field
must not go back home.
32 Remember Lot's wife!
33 Whoever tries to save his life will lose it.
But whoever loses his life will keep it.
34 I tell you,
on that night two people will be in one bed.
One will be taken,
and the other will be left.
35 Two will be grinding grain together.
One will be taken,
and the other will be left."
36 The disciples asked him,
"Where, Lord?"
He said to them,
"Where there is a dead body,
there the vultures will gather."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 20–21: God's Kingdom cannot be calculated or pinned down to one place. The WEB, our English source text, says "within you." The Greek word can also be translated "among you." Both are possible: God's Kingdom is already here, in Jesus, among the people.

Verse 23: Jesus warns: Don't run after people who claim to know exactly when and where the end will come. Today too there are groups that announce such dates. Beware of them.

Verse 25: Again Jesus foretells his suffering.

Verses 26–30: In the time of Noah and of Lot, people simply went on living without thinking of God (Genesis 6–7 and 19). Eating, marrying and working are not bad. But you should not forget God while doing them.

Verse 32: Lot's wife looked back and turned into a pillar of salt (Genesis 19:26). She clung to what she was supposed to leave behind.

Verses 34–35: These pictures show: God's judgment separates people who outwardly live exactly the same way. What matters is the heart. In the Greek, verse 35 speaks of two women, because grinding grain was women's work.

Important: The Bible does not give exact predictions of how the end of the world will happen. These pictures want to wake people up, not frighten them.

Verse numbering: In many other Bibles this chapter has 37 verses. There verse 36 is a sentence like Matthew 24:40, about two men in the field, one taken and the other left. This sentence is missing in the oldest manuscripts and in the WEB. That is why the last verse here is verse 36, in other Bibles verse 37.

Verse 36: "Where there is a dead body, there the vultures will gather" was probably a proverb. It means: The judgment will come as surely as vultures fly to a dead animal. No one will miss it.

LUKE

Chapter 18

Those who are small before God

The persistent widow VERSES 1–8

1 Jesus told them a parable.
He wanted to show them
that they should always pray
and never give up.
2 He said,
"In a certain town there was a judge.
He did not fear God,
and he did not respect people.
3 In that town there was also a widow.
She kept coming to the judge and saying,

'Help me get justice against the man who is against me!'
4 For a while the judge did not want to help her.
But later he said to himself,
'I don't fear God,
and I don't respect people.
5 But this widow keeps bothering me.
So I will make sure she gets justice.
Otherwise she will wear me out
by coming again and again.'"
6 The Lord said,
"Listen to what this unjust judge says!
7 God's chosen people cry out to him day and night.
Won't God see that they get justice?
And he is patient with them.
8 I tell you,
he will see that they get justice,
and he will do it quickly.
But when the Son of Man comes,
will he find faith on the earth?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then widows often had no husband and no son to stand up for them. They were easy victims of injustice. Again and again the Bible calls for widows and orphans to be protected (for example Deuteronomy 10:18).

The widow does not give up. She has no power, but she keeps on.

Jesus does not compare God to the unrighteous judge. He says: If even a bad judge helps in the end, how much more will God help, who is just and loves us.

Verses 7–8: The WEB, our English source text, says "avenge." What is meant is: God sees that people get justice. It is not about personal revenge.

Verse 8: The question at the end is aimed at us: Will we stay in faith, even if it takes a long time?

For today: You may ask God again and again. And you may stand up for your rights.

The Pharisee and the tax collector VERSES 9–14

9 Some people were sure that they themselves were good and right with God.
They looked down on everyone else.
Jesus told them this parable.
10 "Two men went up to the temple to pray.
One was a Pharisee,
and the other was a tax collector.
11 The Pharisee stood by himself and prayed,
'God, I thank you
that I am not like other people.
They steal, they do wrong,
and they are unfaithful in marriage.
I thank you that I am not like this tax collector.
12 I fast twice a week.
I give you a tenth of everything I get.'
13 But the tax collector stood far away.
He did not even look up to heaven.
He beat his chest and said,
'God, have mercy on me, a sinner!'
14 I tell you,
this tax collector went home right with God,
and the other man did not.
For everyone who lifts himself up
will be humbled.
But whoever humbles himself
will be lifted up."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The parable is aimed at people who think they themselves are righteous and look down on others (verse 9). That can be anyone, in any religion.

Important: This parable was often misused to pass judgment on the Pharisees or the Jews. Whoever does that makes exactly the mistake of the Pharisee in the parable: thanking God for not being like the others. The real Pharisees were devout people, and much of what the Pharisee does is good: praying, fasting, giving.

Verse 12: The law required fasting only on the Day of Atonement. The Pharisee does much more. His mistake is not his devout life, but that he looks down on others. He gives a tenth of what he earns to God. This is called a tithe.

Verse 13: Beating your chest was a sign of regret and sorrow. To this day the tax collector's prayer is prayed, for example in the "Jesus Prayer" of the Orthodox Church, which asks Jesus Christ, the Son of God, to have mercy.

Verse 14: "Right with God" (the WEB says "justified") means: put right with God. God accepts the one who honestly asks for grace.

For today: Before God I don't need to compare myself with others.

Jesus blesses the children VERSES 15–17

15 People were also bringing babies to Jesus.
They wanted him to touch them.
When the disciples saw this,
they told the people not to do it.
16 But Jesus called the children to him.
He said,
"Let the little children come to me.
Don't stop them!
For God's Kingdom belongs to people like them.
17 I tell you for certain:
Whoever does not accept God's Kingdom like a little child
will never get into it."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The WEB says "babies": They were very small children, even infants.

The disciples think children are unimportant. Jesus takes time for them.

"Like a little child": Children cannot achieve anything or show anything off. They can only accept gifts. That is how God's Kingdom is to be received.

Many churches appeal to these words when they baptize children. Other churches baptize only people who believe for themselves and can decide. Both want to bring children to Jesus.

Important: Children have a right to be protected. Whoever does violence to children acts against the will of Jesus. Help for children and young people: In the US, call or text Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. In the UK, call Childline at 0800 1111.

The rich ruler VERSES 18–30

18 A ruler asked Jesus,
"Good Teacher,
what must I do
to receive eternal life?"
19 Jesus asked him,
"Why do you call me good?
No one is good except God alone.
20 You know the commandments:
'Don't commit adultery.'
'Don't murder.'
'Don't steal.'
'Don't lie about others in court.'
'Honor your father and your mother.'"
21 The man said,
"I have obeyed all these commandments
since I was a boy."
22 When Jesus heard this,
he said to him,
"You still need to do one thing.
Sell everything you have
and give the money to the poor.
Then you will have treasure in heaven.
Then come and follow me."
23 When the man heard this,
he became very sad,
because he was very rich.
24 Jesus saw that he was very sad.
He said,
"How hard it is for rich people
to get into God's Kingdom!
25 It is easier for a camel to go through the eye of a needle
than for a rich person to get into God's Kingdom."
26 The people who heard this asked,
"Then who can be saved?"
27 Jesus said,
"What is impossible for people
is possible for God."
28 Peter said,
"Look, we have left everything
and followed you."
29 Jesus said to them,
"I tell you for certain:
Some people have left their house,
or wife, or brothers, or parents, or children,
for the sake of God's Kingdom.
30 Every one of them will receive many times more in this
life.
And in the world to come
they will receive eternal life."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A "ruler" was a respected man, perhaps a leader of a synagogue or a member of a council. Only Luke calls him this (compare Mark 10:17–31).

Verse 19: Jesus turns the man's attention to God. Everything good comes from God.

Verse 20: Jesus quotes commandments from the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:12–16). He confirms the law of Israel.

Verse 22: For this man his wealth was the obstacle. Jesus does not ask everyone to sell everything. But he asks everyone: What keeps you from trusting God completely?

Verse 25: The camel was the largest animal people knew, the eye of a needle the smallest opening. The picture is exaggerated on purpose: By your own strength it is impossible.

Verse 27: But God can change rich people too. Salvation is always God's gift.

Verse 29: Only Luke also mentions "wife" here. The first disciples traveled a great deal. This does not mean that you should abandon your family. What is meant is: Nothing should be more important than God.

Verse 30: "Many times more": In the church people find a new, large family.

Jesus announces his suffering a third time VERSES 31–34

31 Jesus took the 12 apostles aside.
He said to them,
"Listen! We are going up to Jerusalem.
There everything will happen
that the prophets wrote about the Son of Man.
32 He will be handed over to the Gentiles.
They will make fun of him,
treat him shamefully,
and spit on him.
33 They will whip him and kill him.
And on the third day he will rise again."
34 But the apostles did not understand any of this.
The meaning of these words was hidden from them.
They did not understand what Jesus was talking about.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the third and most exact time in Luke that Jesus announces his suffering (compare Luke 9:22 and 9:44).

"The Gentiles" here are the Romans. Gentiles means non-Jews. The Romans crucified Jesus.

Important: Jesus' death was not the guilt of "the Jews." The church stresses this explicitly (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965). Jesus goes his way freely, to save people.

Verse 34: The disciples do not understand. A suffering Messiah did not fit their expectations. Only after Easter are their eyes opened (Luke 24:25–27,45).

A blind man near Jericho is healed VERSES 35–43

35 Jesus was coming near Jericho.
A blind man was sitting by the road, begging.
36 He heard a crowd going by.
He asked what was happening.
37 The people told him,
"Jesus of Nazareth is passing by."
38 The blind man shouted,
"Jesus, son of David,
have mercy on me!"
39 The people at the front of the crowd
told him sharply to be quiet.
But he shouted even louder,
"Son of David,
have mercy on me!"
40 Jesus stopped.
He told the people to bring the man to him.
When the man came near,
Jesus asked him,

41 "What do you want me to do?"
He said,
"Lord, I want to see again."
42 Jesus said to him,
"Receive your sight!
Your faith has healed you."
43 At once the man could see.
He followed Jesus
and praised God.
When all the people saw this,
they also praised God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jericho is in the Jordan Valley, about 15 miles (25 kilometers) from Jerusalem. From there the road climbed steeply up to Jerusalem.

Mark calls the blind man Bartimaeus (Mark 10:46).

"Son of David" was a title for the Messiah. The blind man "sees" more than many who can see: He recognizes who Jesus is.

The people want to make him be quiet. But he does not let himself be stopped. Jesus stands still. For him this one person matters.

Verse 41: Jesus asks: "What do you want me to do?" He does not decide over the man's head. He respects his dignity.

Important: People who are blind or visually impaired are not worth less and do not have less faith. Whoever is not healed has not believed too little.

For today: Whoever is in need may cry out loudly. And we should not make such people be quiet.

LUKE

CHAPTER 19

Jesus comes to Jerusalem

Zacchaeus VERSES 1–10

1 Jesus came to Jericho
and was going through the town.
2 A man named Zacchaeus lived there.
He was a chief tax collector,
and he was rich.
3 He wanted to see who Jesus was.
But he could not see him because of the crowd,
for Zacchaeus was a short man.
4 So he ran on ahead
and climbed up into a sycamore tree to see Jesus.
For Jesus was going to come that way.
5 When Jesus came to the place,
he looked up and saw Zacchaeus.
He said to him,
"Zacchaeus, hurry and come down!
Today I must stay at your house."
6 Zacchaeus hurried down.
He was very happy to welcome Jesus.
7 All the people saw this
and began to complain.
They said,
"He has gone to be the guest of a sinner!"
8 But Zacchaeus stood up and said to the Lord,
"Look, Lord!
I give half of everything I own to the poor.
And if I have cheated anyone,
I pay him back four times as much."
9 Jesus said to him,
"Today salvation has come to this house.
For this man is also a son of Abraham.
10 The Son of Man came to look for the lost
and to save them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Luke tells this story. Jericho was a rich trading city. A "chief tax collector" had other tax collectors under him and earned a lot of money, often at the expense of others.

Zacchaeus is rich, but unpopular. He climbs a tree like a child. He accepts that people might laugh at him.

Sycamore tree: here a kind of fig tree with low, wide branches, easy to climb.

Verse 5: Jesus knows his name. He invites himself. "Today" is an important word in Luke (Luke 2:11; 4:21; 23:43).

Verse 8: The law required that stolen goods be given back with a fifth added (Leviticus 6:5, in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 5:24; Numbers 5:7). Zacchaeus gives much more, as in the case of serious theft (Exodus 22:1, in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 21:37). He does this freely, because Jesus has accepted him.

Verse 9: "Son of Abraham": Zacchaeus belongs to God's people, even if others had shut him out.

Verse 10 sums up the whole message of Luke.

For today: Jesus sees people whom others have written off. Whoever is accepted can change.

The parable of the entrusted coins VERSES 11–27

11 The people were listening to this.
So Jesus told them another parable.
He was near Jerusalem,
and the people thought
that God's Kingdom was going to appear right away.
12 Jesus said,
"A man from a noble family
went to a country far away.
There he was to be made king.
Then he was going to come back.
13 Before he left,
he called 10 of his servants.
He gave them 10 mina coins.
He told them,
'Do business with this money until I come back.'
14 But the people of his country hated him.
They sent messengers after him to say,
'We don't want this man to be our king.'
15 But he was made king
and came back home.
Then he called the servants
to whom he had given the money.
He wanted to know
how much each one had earned by doing business.

16 The first servant came and said,
'Master, your mina has earned 10 more minas.'
17 The king said to him,
'Well done, you good servant!
You were faithful with very little.
So you shall rule over 10 cities.'
18 The second servant came and said,
'Master, your mina has earned five minas.'
19 The king said to him,
'You shall rule over five cities.'
20 Then another servant came and said,
'Master, here is your mina.
I kept it hidden in a cloth.
21 I was afraid of you,
because you are a hard man.
You take what you did not put in.
You harvest what you did not plant.'
22 The king said to him,
'You evil servant!
I will judge you by your own words.
You knew that I am a hard man.
You knew that I take what I did not put in
and harvest what I did not plant.
23 Then why didn't you put my money in the bank?
Then when I came back,
I could have gotten it back with interest.'
24 The king said to the people standing there,
'Take the mina away from him.
Give it to the servant who has 10 minas.'
25 They said to him,
'Master, he already has 10 minas!'
26 The king answered,
'I tell you,
everyone who has something will be given more.
But whoever has nothing
will lose even what he has.
27 And bring here those enemies of mine
who did not want me to be their king.
Kill them in front of me.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A mina was a sum of money, about the wages for 100 days of work. Each servant receives the same amount.

The parable probably refers to a true story: Archelaus, a son of Herod the Great, traveled to Rome to be made king. A group of messengers from Judea traveled after him to prevent it. The historian Flavius Josephus reports this.

Verse 11: Jesus says: God's Kingdom does not come immediately. Until then the disciples are to work with what God has entrusted to them.

Verses 20–21: The third servant is afraid. He has a false picture of his lord. That is why he does nothing.

Verse 26: Whoever uses what has been entrusted receives more. Whoever buries it loses it.

Important: Verse 27 is a very harsh picture. It describes how cruel kings back then dealt with their opponents. Jesus is telling here what such a king does. It is not a command to kill opponents. Jesus himself rejects violence and even prays for his enemies (Luke 6:27–28; 23:34). No one may appeal to this verse to use violence.

Some interpreters also see in the third servant a person who refuses to be part of the exploitation of a harsh master. But most understand the parable as a call to use God's gifts.

For today: Every person has gifts from God. They should not be hidden, but used, for God and for others.

Jesus enters Jerusalem VERSES 28–40

28 After Jesus had said these things,
he went on ahead of the others.
He was going up to Jerusalem.
29 He came near the villages of Bethsphage and Bethany,
at the mountain called Olivet.
There he sent two of his disciples ahead.
30 He said to them,
"Go into the village over there.
As you go in,
you will find a colt tied up.
No one has ever ridden it.
Untie it and bring it here.
31 Someone may ask you,
'Why are you untying the colt?'
Then tell him,
'The Lord needs it.'"
32 The two disciples went.
They found everything just as Jesus had told them.
33 While they were untying the colt,
its owners asked them,
"Why are you untying the colt?"
34 The disciples said,
"The Lord needs it."
35 They brought the colt to Jesus.
They threw their coats on it
and helped Jesus get on it.
36 As Jesus rode along,
people spread their coats on the road.
37 Jesus came near the place
where the road goes down from the Mount of Olives.
Then the whole crowd of his disciples began to shout for joy.
They praised God with loud voices
for all the great miracles they had seen.
38 They said,
"Blessed is the King who comes in the name of the Lord!
Peace in heaven,
and glory in the highest!"
39 Some Pharisees in the crowd said to Jesus,
"Teacher, tell your disciples to stop!"
40 Jesus answered them,
"I tell you,
if they were quiet,
the stones would shout."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bethsphage and Bethany were villages on the Mount of Olives, east of Jerusalem. Olivet is another name for the Mount of Olives.

The WEB, our English source text, says "colt": a young animal, a foal. Matthew and John say clearly that it was a donkey. Jesus does not come on a war horse, but in peace, as the prophet Zechariah had announced (Zechariah 9:9).

An animal that no one had ever ridden was seen as especially suited for a holy purpose.

Verse 36: Laying cloaks on the road was a way to honor a king (2 Kings 9:13).

Verse 38 quotes Psalm 118:26. Pilgrims sang this psalm on the way to the temple. "Peace in heaven" is a reminder of the song of the angels at Jesus' birth (Luke 2:14).
Verse 39: The Pharisees may have been afraid that the Romans would step in if someone was celebrated as "King." Their worry was not without reason.
Verse 40: What God does cannot be kept silent.

Jesus weeps over Jerusalem VERSES 41–44

41 Jesus came closer to Jerusalem.
When he saw the city,
he cried over it.
42 He said,
"If only you, even you, had known today
what would bring you peace!
But now it is hidden from your eyes.
43 A time is coming for you
when your enemies will build a wall around you.
They will surround you
and close you in from every side.
44 They will throw you and your children to the ground.
They will not leave one stone on top of another in you.
For you did not know the time
when God came to you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Luke tells that Jesus weeps over Jerusalem. He loves this city.
In Hebrew, the name "Jerusalem" contains the word "shalom," peace. That is why Jesus speaks of "what would bring you peace."
Verses 43–44: Jesus foresees what happened in the year AD 70: The Romans besieged Jerusalem and destroyed the city and the temple.
Important: The destruction of Jerusalem was not a "punishment from God on the Jews." In church history this text was often misused in that way. Jesus weeps, he does not rejoice. It is the grief of a prophet, as with Jeremiah (Jeremiah 9:1, in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 8:23). The victims of this war were people Jesus wept for.
The WEB says "the time of your visitation": the time when God came to his people through Jesus.

Jesus in the temple VERSES 45–48

45 Jesus went into the temple.
He began to drive out the people who were buying and selling there.
46 He said to them,
"It is written,
'My house is a house of prayer.'
But you have made it a 'den of robbers'!"
47 Every day Jesus taught in the temple.
But the chief priests, the scribes,
and the leaders of the people
wanted to kill him.
48 But they could not find a way to do it.
For all the people listened eagerly to every word Jesus said.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the outer court of the temple people sold animals for sacrifice and exchanged money. That was needed for the temple service. But it disturbed prayer, especially in the court where non-Jews were also allowed to pray.
Verse 46 combines Isaiah 56:7 (there God says his house will be called a house of prayer for all peoples) and Jeremiah 7:11 ("den of robbers"). Jesus acts like the prophets of Israel, who loved the temple and criticized what was wrong.
Luke tells the cleansing of the temple very briefly. Jesus takes possession of the temple in order to teach there.
Verses 47–48: Some leaders want to kill Jesus. But "all the people" listen to him eagerly. Luke clearly distinguishes between a few powerful people and the people as a whole.
Important: The Jewish people were not against Jesus. They hung on his every word.

LUKE

CHAPTER 20

Debates in the temple

The question about Jesus' authority VERSES 1–8

1 One day Jesus was teaching the people in the temple.
He was telling them the Good News.
Then the priests and the scribes came to him,
together with the elders.
2 They said to him,
"Tell us:
What authority do you have to do these things?
Who gave you this authority?"
3 Jesus answered them,
"I will also ask you a question.
Tell me:
4 John's baptism,
did it come from heaven, or from people?"
5 They talked about this among themselves.
They said,
"If we say, 'From heaven,'
he will say,
'Then why didn't you believe John?'
6 But if we say, 'From people,'
all the people will stone us to death.
For they are sure that John was a prophet."
7 So they answered
that they did not know where it came from.
8 Jesus said to them,
"Then I will not tell you either
what authority I have to do these things."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The temple leaders were responsible for order in the temple. After the cleansing of the temple (Luke 19:45–46) they ask: Who gives you the right to do this? That is an understandable question.
"From heaven" means: from God. Jesus answers with a question of his own, as was common back then in debates among teachers.

Whoever accepts that John was sent by God will also understand where Jesus gets his authority. After all, John pointed to Jesus.

Verse 6: The people honor John as a prophet. Luke shows again and again: The people are on the side of John and Jesus.

The parable of the wicked farmers VERSES 9–19

9 Then Jesus told the people this parable.
"A man planted a vineyard.
He rented it out to some farmers.
Then he went to another country for a long time.
10 When harvest time came,
he sent a servant to the farmers.
The servant was to get the owner's share of the grapes.
But the farmers beat the servant
and sent him away with nothing.
11 So the owner sent another servant.
They beat him too.
They treated him shamefully
and sent him away with nothing.
12 Then the owner sent a third servant.
They hurt him badly too
and threw him out.
13 The owner of the vineyard said,
'What shall I do?
I will send my son, whom I love.
Maybe they will respect him.'
14 But when the farmers saw the son,
they talked it over among themselves.
They said,
'This is the one who will get the vineyard.
Come on, let's kill him!
Then the vineyard will be ours.'
15 So they threw him out of the vineyard
and killed him.
What will the owner of the vineyard do to them?
16 He will come and destroy these farmers.
And he will give the vineyard to other people."
When the people heard this,
they said,
"May that never be!"
17 But Jesus looked at them and said,
"Then what does this Scripture mean?
'The stone that the builders rejected
has become the most important cornerstone.'
18 Everyone who falls on that stone
will be broken to pieces.
And if the stone falls on someone,
it will crush him to dust."
19 The chief priests and the scribes
wanted to arrest Jesus at once.
But they were afraid of the people.
For they knew that Jesus had told this parable against them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the Bible the vineyard is a picture for Israel (Isaiah 5:1–7). The owner is God. The servants are the prophets. The beloved son is Jesus.

The farmers stand for certain leaders who had responsibility. Verse 19 says explicitly: The chief priests and scribes knew that the parable was aimed at them. The people, on the other hand, listen to Jesus.

Important: For a long time this parable was explained as if God had rejected Israel and put "the church" in its place. This explanation is wrong and has caused much suffering. The vineyard, that is Israel, is not destroyed. It is about the leadership. Paul writes clearly: God has not rejected his people (Romans 11:1–2). God's covenant with Israel still stands.

Verse 16: The people cry out in horror: "May that never be!" No one wants such an ending.

Verse 17 quotes Psalm 118:22. The rejected stone becomes the most important stone of the house. Christians see Jesus in this: He was rejected and killed, but God raised him up.

For today: Church leaders also carry responsibility. The parable is a warning to all who have power over God's people.

The question about taxes for Caesar VERSES 20–26

20 So they watched Jesus closely.
They sent spies to him.
The spies pretended to be honest people.
They wanted to catch Jesus saying something wrong.
Then they could hand him over to the power and authority of the governor.
21 The spies asked him,
"Teacher, we know that what you say and teach is right.
You do not favor anyone.
You truly teach the way of God.
22 Tell us:
Does the law allow us to pay taxes to Caesar, or not?"
23 But Jesus saw their trick.
He said to them,
"Why are you testing me?
24 Show me a denarius.
Whose picture and whose name are on it?"
They answered,
"Caesar's."
25 He said to them,
"Then give to Caesar what belongs to Caesar.
And give to God what belongs to God."
26 So they could not catch him
saying anything wrong in front of the people.
They were amazed at his answer
and said nothing more.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The question is a trap. If Jesus says "Yes," he angers the people, who suffer under the Roman taxes. If he says "No," he can be reported to the Romans as a rebel.

"The governor" at that time was Pontius Pilate.

The denarius was a Roman silver coin. On it was the image of Emperor Tiberius with an inscription that called him the son of a god. Caesar: the title of the Roman emperor.

Verse 25: Jesus says: The state may ask for taxes. But more belongs to God: the whole person. For people are created in God's image (Genesis 1:27), just as the coin bears the image of the emperor.

For today: Christians should fulfill their duties as citizens. But no state may take the place of God.

The question about the resurrection VERSES 27–40

27 Then some Sadducees came to Jesus.
The Sadducees say
that the dead will not rise again.
28 They asked him,
"Teacher, Moses wrote this law for us:
A man may die and leave a wife but no children.
Then his brother must marry the widow
and have children for his brother.
29 Now there were seven brothers.
The first one got married
and died without children.
30 The second one married the widow
and died without children.
31 Then the third one married her.
In the same way all seven brothers died
and left no children.
32 Finally the woman died too.
33 So when the dead rise again,
whose wife will she be?
For all seven brothers were married to her."
34 Jesus said to them,
"The people of this world
marry and are given in marriage.
35 But some people are found worthy
to have a part in the world to come
and in the rising from the dead.
They do not marry
and are not given in marriage.
36 They cannot die anymore.
They are like the angels.
They are children of God,
because they have been raised from the dead.
37 Even Moses showed that the dead are raised.
In the story about the burning bush,
he calls the Lord
'the God of Abraham,
the God of Isaac,
and the God of Jacob.'
38 He is not the God of the dead,
but of the living.
For to him all people are alive."
39 Some of the scribes said,
"Teacher, you have given a good answer."
40 After that, no one dared to ask him any more questions.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Sadducees were a group of rich priestly families in Jerusalem. Above all they accepted the five books of Moses. They did not believe in the resurrection of the dead. The Pharisees, on the other hand, did believe in it, just like Jesus.

Verse 28: This is the so-called "levirate marriage" (Deuteronomy 25:5–6). It was meant to provide for the widow and keep the name of the dead man alive.

The Sadducees tell an exaggerated story to make belief in the resurrection look ridiculous.

Verses 34–36: Jesus says: Life after the resurrection is completely different from this life. You cannot picture it as a continuation of life on earth.

Important: This does not mean that love ends after death. Many Christians hope to see their loved ones again with God.

Verse 37 refers to Exodus 3:6. Jesus answers with a text from the books of Moses, which the Sadducees also accept.

Verse 39: Some scribes, probably Pharisees, agree with Jesus. Here they are of one mind with Jesus.

For today: "To him all people are alive": Our loved ones who have died are not lost with God either. People who are grieving can find help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Whose son is the Christ? VERSES 41–44

41 Then Jesus said to them,
"Why do people say
that the Christ is the son of David?
42 David himself says in the book of Psalms,
'The Lord said to my Lord,
"Sit at my right side,
43 until I make your enemies
the footstool of your feet."'
44 So David calls him 'Lord.'
How then can he be David's son?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 42–43 quote Psalm 110:1. Many Jews back then understood this psalm as a word about the Messiah.

Back then the rule was: A father stands above his son. But if David calls the Messiah "Lord," then the Messiah is more than just a descendant of David.

Christians see in this a hint: Jesus is the son of David and at the same time Lord, the Son of God.

"The footstool of your feet" is a picture of complete victory.

A warning against false piety VERSES 45–47

45 All the people were listening.
Then Jesus said to his disciples,
46 "Watch out for the scribes!
They like to walk around in long robes.
They love it when people greet them with respect in the marketplaces.
They love the most important seats in the synagogues and the places of honor at feasts.
47 They take away the houses of widows.
And to make a show, they pray long prayers.
They will be punished even more."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus warns against a certain kind of scribe: those who seek honor and take advantage of the weak. Just before this, scribes had agreed with him (verse 39). It is not about all of them.

"They take away the houses of widows": Some took advantage of the trust of widows, managed their property and made themselves rich.

Important: This warning applies to all religious leaders, including those in the churches today. Whoever takes advantage of people in God's name acts seriously against God.

The next chapter goes straight on with the story of a poor widow who gives everything (Luke 21:1–4).

Chapter 21

Be watchful

The poor widow's gift VERSES 1–4

1 Jesus looked up.
He saw rich people putting their gifts
into the offering boxes in the temple.
2 He also saw a poor widow.
She put in two small brass coins.
3 Jesus said,
"I tell you the truth:
This poor widow has put in more than all the others.
4 All these people gave gifts to God
from what they had left over.
But she is poor,
and she put in everything she had to live on."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In the temple there were boxes for donations. The treasury: the place where these offering boxes stood. The two small coins were the smallest kind of coin. They were worth almost nothing.

Jesus looks closely. For God what counts is not the size of the gift, but the heart. The widow gives everything.

Just before this, Jesus warned against scribes: "They take away the houses of widows" (Luke 20:47). Some interpreters also hear a complaint in this: A system that makes poor widows give their last coins is not just.

Important: No one should pressure people to give more than they can. Groups that take advantage of people financially act against God's will.

For today: Even those who have little can give a lot. And: We should see the poor as Jesus sees them.

Jesus speaks about the destruction of the temple VERSES 5–19

5 Some people were talking about the temple.
They talked about how beautiful it was,
with its fine stones and the gifts given to God.
Then Jesus said,
6 "You see all this.
But the time will come
when not one stone will be left on top of another.
Every stone will be thrown down."
7 They asked him,
"Teacher, when will this happen?
And what will be the sign
that it is about to happen?"
8 Jesus said,
"Be careful that no one fools you.
Many will come and use my name.
They will say, 'I am he!'
And they will say, 'The time has come!'
Don't follow them.
9 You will hear about wars and riots.
Don't be afraid.
These things must happen first.
But the end will not come right away."
10 Then Jesus said to them,
"One nation will fight against another nation.
One kingdom will fight against another kingdom.
11 There will be great earthquakes.
In many places there will be famines and diseases.
Terrible things will happen,
and there will be great signs from heaven.
12 But before all this happens,
people will arrest you and persecute you.
They will hand you over to the synagogues
and put you in prison.
They will bring you before kings and governors
because of my name.
13 This will be your chance to tell them about me.
14 So make up your minds
not to worry ahead of time
about how you will defend yourselves.
15 I will give you words and wisdom.
None of your enemies will be able to stand against
them
or prove them wrong.
16 Even your parents, brothers, relatives, and friends
will hand you over.
They will have some of you killed.
17 Everyone will hate you
because of my name.
18 But not one hair on your head will be lost.
19 If you stay strong and do not give up,
you will win your lives."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The temple in Jerusalem was a huge, magnificent building. Herod the Great had it splendidly enlarged. In the year AD 70 the Romans destroyed it.

Important: For the Jewish people the destruction of the temple was a terrible disaster. To this day Jews remember it with grief, on the fast day of Tisha B'Av. Christians should respect this grief.

Verses 8–9: Jesus warns: Don't follow false saviors. And don't let wars and disasters throw you into panic. They are not a sign that the end is coming right away.

Important: Groups that bind people to themselves through fear of the end of the world misuse these words. Advice is available, for example, from counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse.

Verse 12: The first Christians were persecuted. The Book of Acts tells about this. At that time the first Christians were themselves still Jews. These were conflicts within the Jewish people and with the Roman authorities.

Important: Later, for many centuries, Christians persecuted Jews. This text must never be used to put the blame on Jews.

Verses 18–19: "Not one hair on your head will be lost": Even if disciples suffer or die, they are safe with God.

For today: Today too, Christians are persecuted in some countries, just like people of other religions. Freedom of religion is a human right for everyone.

The siege of Jerusalem VERSES 20–24

20 "You will see armies all around Jerusalem.
Then you will know
that the time has come for it to be destroyed.
21 Then the people in Judea must run away to the mountains.
The people in the city must get out.
The people in the country must not go into the city.
22 For these are the days of punishment.
Then everything that is written will come true.
23 How terrible it will be in those days for women who are pregnant!
How terrible for mothers who are nursing babies!
For there will be great trouble in the land.
There will be anger against this people.
24 They will be killed by the sword.
They will be taken away as prisoners to all the nations.
And the Gentiles will trample on Jerusalem
until the times of the Gentiles are over."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Luke describes very exactly what happened in the Jewish War: The Romans surrounded Jerusalem and conquered the city in the year AD 70. Many people died, many were made slaves.

"How terrible it will be in those days for women who are pregnant!": Jesus has compassion on those who suffer the most. It is a lament, not a curse.

Important: The words "days of punishment" and "anger against this people" (the WEB, our English source text, says "days of vengeance" and "wrath to this people") were terribly misused in church history. People said the Jews were being punished "rightly." That is wrong and has contributed to hatred and persecution. Jesus speaks as a Jewish prophet about his own people, with tears (Luke 19:41). The prophets of Israel lamented in a similar way, for example Jeremiah.

Verse 24: "Until the times of the Gentiles are over": This time has an end. God's story with Jerusalem and with Israel goes on (compare Romans 11:25–26).

"The Gentiles" here means the Romans.

The coming of the Son of Man VERSES 25–28

25 "There will be signs in the sun, the moon, and the stars.
On the earth the nations will be full of fear.
They will not know what to do
because of the roaring of the sea and the waves.
26 People will faint with fear.
They will be afraid of what is going to happen to the world.
For the powers in the heavens will be shaken.
27 Then people will see the Son of Man coming in a cloud
with power and great glory.
28 When these things begin to happen,
look up and lift up your heads!
For soon you will be set free."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus uses pictures from the books of the prophets (for example Isaiah 13:10; Joel 2:30–31, in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 3:3–4; Daniel 7:13–14). They describe God making the whole world new.

These pictures are not exact predictions. They want to show: In the end God comes, and evil does not have the last word.

Verse 28: While others are afraid, the disciples are to look up. For them the coming of Jesus is not a threat, but freedom. The WEB calls this "redemption": being set free.

For today: Whoever is afraid of the future may lift up their head. God holds the world in his hand.

The parable of the fig tree VERSES 29–33

29 Then Jesus told them a parable.
"Look at the fig tree and all the other trees.
30 When they begin to grow new leaves,
you see it.
And you know by yourselves
that summer is near.
31 It is the same with you.
When you see these things happening,
you know that God's Kingdom is near.
32 I tell you for certain:
This generation will not pass away
before all these things happen.
33 Heaven and earth will pass away.
But my words will never pass away."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Israel many trees lose their leaves in winter. When they get new leaves, you know: Summer is coming soon.

Verse 32 is hard to understand. Some interpreters connect "this generation" with the destruction of Jerusalem, which happened while many of the listeners were still alive. Others understand it as "humanity" or "this kind of people." What is certain: Jesus wants us to be ready at all times.

Verse 33: Jesus' words remain valid, even when everything else passes away.

Be watchful! VERSES 34–38

34 "Be careful!
Don't let your hearts be loaded down
with wild partying and getting drunk,
and with the worries of this life.
Otherwise that day may come on you suddenly,
35 like a trap.
For it will come on everyone
who lives on the whole earth.
36 So be watchful all the time and pray.
Pray that God will find you worthy
to escape all these things that are going to happen.
And pray that you will be able to stand before the Son of Man."
37 Every day Jesus taught in the temple.
Every night he went out
and stayed on the mountain called Olivet.
38 Early every morning all the people came to the temple
to listen to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 34: Not only partying and alcohol, but also everyday worries can make the heart "loaded down." Then you forget what really matters.

Important: Whoever struggles with alcohol or other addictions is not a bad person. Addiction is an illness. Help is available from addiction counseling services and self-

help groups. In the US, call the SAMHSA National Helpline at 1-800-662-4357. In the UK, call Frank at 0300 123 6600.

Verse 36: "Be watchful all the time and pray": That is the attitude Jesus expects from his disciples.

Verses 37–38: Luke shows once more: All the people come early in the morning to hear Jesus. The Jewish people love Jesus and listen to him.

LUKE

Chapter 22

The last meal and the long night

Judas betrays Jesus VERSES 1–6

1 The Feast of Unleavened Bread was coming near.
It is also called the Passover.
2 The chief priests and the scribes
were looking for a way to kill Jesus.
But they were afraid of the people.
3 Then Satan entered into Judas,
who was called Iscariot.
Judas was one of the Twelve.
4 He went to the chief priests
and the captains of the temple guard.
He talked with them
about how he could hand Jesus over to them.
5 They were glad
and agreed to give him money.
6 Judas agreed.
He began to look for a good time
to hand Jesus over to them
when there was no crowd around.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Passover (in Hebrew Pesach) is the great Jewish feast. It remembers how Israel was set free from slavery in Egypt (Exodus 12). The Feast of Unleavened Bread belongs to it. For a week people eat only bread without yeast. Many pilgrims came to Jerusalem.

Verse 2: The temple leaders are afraid of the people. The people are on Jesus' side.

Important: Jesus' death was not the guilt of "the Jews." Jesus, Judas, Peter and all the disciples were Jews themselves. A few powerful people acted together with the Romans. The church teaches clearly: The death of Jesus may not be blamed on all the Jews of that time, nor on the Jews of today (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965).

Important: For centuries the name Judas was used to insult Jews as "traitors." That is hatred of Jews and a grave injustice.

Verse 3: "Satan entered into Judas": Luke shows that an evil power is at work here. Even so, Judas remains responsible for his decision.

The Passover meal is prepared VERSES 7–13

7 Then the day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread came.
On this day the Passover lamb had to be killed.
8 Jesus sent Peter and John.
He said,
"Go and get the Passover meal ready for us,
so that we can eat it."
9 They asked him,
"Where do you want us to get it ready?"
10 He said to them,
"Listen! When you go into the city,
a man carrying a jar of water will meet you.
Follow him into the house he goes into.
11 Say to the owner of the house,
'The Teacher asks you:
"Where is the guest room
where I can eat the Passover meal with my disciples?"'
12 He will show you a large room upstairs.
It is already set up.
Get everything ready there."
13 Peter and John went.
They found everything just as Jesus had told them.
And they got the Passover meal ready.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Passover lambs were sacrificed in the temple and then eaten in the families, with bread without yeast, bitter herbs and wine.

Verse 10: Back then carrying water was usually women's work. A man with a jar of water stood out. He was a good sign to recognize.

Jesus has prepared everything. He goes his way knowingly.

The Last Supper VERSES 14–23

14 When the time came,
Jesus sat down at the table with the 12 apostles.
15 He said to them,
"I have wanted very much
to eat this Passover meal with you
before I suffer.
16 For I tell you,
I will not eat it again
until it comes true in God's Kingdom."
17 Then Jesus took a cup
and thanked God for it.
He said,
"Take this and share it among yourselves.
18 For I tell you,
from now on I will not drink wine again
until God's Kingdom comes."
19 Then Jesus took bread
and thanked God for it.
He broke it and gave it to them.
He said,
"This is my body,
which is given for you.
Do this in memory of me."
20 In the same way, he took the cup after the meal.
He said,
"This cup is the new covenant in my blood,
which is poured out for you.

21 But look!
The man who is going to hand me over
is here with me at the table.
22 The Son of Man will go the way
that has been decided for him.
But how terrible it will be for the man
who hands him over!"
23 Then the apostles began to ask each other
which of them would do this.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Luke there are two cups: one before the bread (verse 17) and one after the meal (verse 20). At the Jewish Passover meal people drink several cups of wine.

Verses 19–20: These words are the origin of the Lord's Supper, also called the Eucharist or Holy Communion. To this day Christians celebrate it "in memory of" Jesus. The words are similar to those in Paul (1 Corinthians 11:23–25).

The churches understand the Lord's Supper in different ways. Catholic and Orthodox Christians believe that bread and wine truly become the body and blood of Christ. Lutheran Christians believe that Christ is truly present in, with and under the bread and wine. Reformed and other Protestant Christians stress Christ's spiritual presence and the remembering. What unites them all: Jesus gives himself.

"New covenant" is a reminder of Jeremiah 31:31–34. This does not mean that God's covenant with Israel has been canceled (Romans 11:29). Covenant: a binding agreement.

In verses 19b–20, the words about the body given for you and the blood poured out for you are missing in a single old Greek manuscript and in some old translations. Almost all manuscripts have them.

Verse 21: Judas is at the meal too. Jesus does not shut him out.

Who is the greatest? VERSES 24–30

24 The apostles also began to argue.
They argued about which of them was the most
important.
25 Jesus said to them,
"The kings of the nations rule over their people with
force.
And those who have power over the people
are called 'benefactors.'
26 But you must not be like that.
The most important one among you
should be like the youngest.
And the leader should be like a servant.
27 Who is more important:
the person who sits at the table,
or the person who serves him?
Isn't it the one who sits at the table?
But I am among you
like one who serves.
28 You have stayed with me
in my hard times.
29 So I give you a kingdom,
just as my Father gave a kingdom to me.
30 You will eat and drink at my table
in my Kingdom.
And you will sit on thrones,
judging the 12 tribes of Israel."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Of all times, at the last meal the disciples argue about who is the most important.

Verse 25: "Benefactors" (people who do good) was a title of honor that rulers liked to give themselves, even when they misused their power.

Verses 26–27: With Jesus everything is turned around. Whoever leads should serve. Jesus himself is like a servant. In the Gospel of John he washes his disciples' feet (John 13).

Important: This applies to everyone who has responsibility in the church. Power in the church must never be misused.

Verse 30: "Judging the 12 tribes of Israel" here probably means: leading, ruling, like the judges in the Old Testament. The 12 tribes stand for the whole people of Israel, whom God wants to gather.

Jesus announces that Peter will deny him VERSES 31–34

31 The Lord said,
"Simon, Simon, listen!
Satan has asked to have all of you.
He wants to shake you like wheat in a sieve.
32 But I have prayed for you
that your faith will not fail.
And when you have turned back,
make your brothers strong."
33 Peter said to Jesus,
"Lord, I am ready to go to prison with you.
I am even ready to die with you!"
34 Jesus said,
"I tell you, Peter,
before the rooster crows today,
you will say three times
that you don't know me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 31: When grain is sifted, it is shaken back and forth. In the same way the disciples will be hard tested in the coming night. "All of you" means all the disciples.

Verse 32: Jesus prays for Peter. He knows that Peter will fail. But he does not give up on him. He even gives him a task for the time afterward.

For today: Even someone who has failed can make a new start and be there for others.

Two swords VERSES 35–38

35 Then Jesus said to the apostles,
"I sent you out without a money bag,
without a traveler's bag, and without sandals.
Did you need anything?"
They said,
"No, nothing."
36 Jesus said to them,
"But now, if you have a money bag, take it.
Take a traveler's bag too.
And if you have no sword,
sell your coat and buy one.
37 For I tell you,
this Scripture must come true about me:
'He was counted among the criminals.'
Yes, what is written about me is coming true."
38 The apostles said,
"Lord, look! Here are two swords."

Jesus said to them,
"That is enough."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This passage is hard to understand. Jesus says: Now a hard time begins. The disciples will no longer be welcomed everywhere.

Verse 37 quotes Isaiah 53:12. Jesus will be treated like a criminal. The WEB, our English source text, says "transgressors": people who break the law.

Verse 38: "That is enough" probably means: Enough of this! Once again the disciples take Jesus literally. Two swords would have been ridiculously few against an armed troop anyway.

Important: Jesus is not calling for violence. A few hours later he forbids the use of the sword and heals the man who was wounded (verses 49–51). No one may appeal to this passage to justify violence in the name of faith.

Jesus prays on the Mount of Olives VERSES 39–46

39 Jesus left the city
and went to the Mount of Olives, as he often did.
His disciples followed him.
40 When he came to the place,
he said to them,
"Pray that you will not give in to temptation."
41 Then he went a short distance away from them,
about as far as a person can throw a stone.
He knelt down and prayed,
42 "Father, if you are willing,
take this cup away from me.
But let your will be done, not mine."
43 Then an angel from heaven came to him
and gave him strength.
44 Jesus was in great fear and pain.
He prayed even harder.
His sweat was like large drops of blood
falling to the ground.
45 When he got up from praying,
he went back to the disciples.
He found them sleeping.
They were worn out because they were so sad.
46 He said to them,
"Why are you sleeping?
Get up and pray
that you will not give in to temptation."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Matthew and Mark the garden on the Mount of Olives is called "Gethsemane." Luke only names the Mount of Olives.

Verse 42: The "cup" is a picture for the suffering that awaits Jesus. Jesus is afraid, like every human being. But he entrusts himself to God.

Verses 43–44: These two verses are missing in many very old manuscripts. The WEB, our English source text, has them. They show how great Jesus' distress was.

Verse 44: Luke says "like" drops of blood. It is a comparison: The sweat fell in large, heavy drops. The WEB says he was "in agony": in very great fear and pain.

Verse 45: Only Luke says: The disciples were sleeping "because they were so sad." He excuses them a little. Grief can make you tired.

For today: Jesus was afraid too. Whoever is afraid may pray and may tell God everything. Whoever is in great distress can find help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Jesus is arrested VERSES 47–53

47 Jesus was still speaking
when a crowd came.
The man called Judas,
one of the Twelve,
was leading them.
He came close to Jesus to kiss him.
48 But Jesus said to him,
"Judas, are you handing over the Son of Man with a kiss?"
49 The people around Jesus saw what was going to happen.
They said,
"Lord, should we fight with our swords?"
50 And one of them struck the servant of the high priest
and cut off his right ear.
51 But Jesus said,
"Let me at least do this."
He touched the man's ear
and healed him.
52 Then Jesus spoke to the chief priests,
the captains of the temple guard,
and the elders who had come to arrest him.
"Have you come out with swords and clubs,
as if I were a robber?
53 Every day I was with you in the temple.
But you did not lay a hand on me.
But this is your hour.
Now the power of darkness rules."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then a kiss was a common greeting between a student and his teacher. Judas misuses this sign of friendship.

Verse 51: The WEB translates: "Let me at least do this." Others translate it as an order to stop, enough of this. What is clear: Jesus stops the violence. Only Luke tells that Jesus heals the ear. Even in this hour he heals an opponent.

John names the servant Malchus and the man with the sword Peter (John 18:10).

Verse 53: They come at night, in secret, because they fear the people. "The power of darkness": For a short time evil seems to win.

For today: Jesus does not answer violence with violence, but with healing.

Peter denies Jesus VERSES 54–62

54 They arrested Jesus and led him away.
They took him into the house of the high priest.
Peter followed far behind.
55 People had made a fire in the middle of the courtyard.
They were sitting around it.
Peter sat down with them.
56 A servant girl saw Peter sitting in the light of the fire.
She looked closely at him and said,
"This man was with Jesus too."
57 But Peter said it was not true.
He said,

"Woman, I don't know him."
58 A little later someone else saw Peter.
He said,
"You are one of them too!"
But Peter said,
"Man, I am not!"
59 About an hour later another man said firmly,
"This man was with Jesus too, for sure!
He is from Galilee!"
60 But Peter said,
"Man, I don't know what you are talking about!"
At that moment, while Peter was still speaking,
a rooster crowed.
61 The Lord turned and looked at Peter.
Then Peter remembered what the Lord had said to him:
"Before the rooster crows,
you will say three times that you don't know me."
62 Peter went outside
and cried bitterly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Peter had promised to go to death with Jesus (verse 33). Now he is afraid and says three times that he does not know Jesus.

Verse 59: People from Galilee could be recognized by the way they spoke (compare Matthew 26:73).

Verse 61: Only Luke tells: Jesus turns and looks at Peter. It is not a look of anger, but a look that brings Peter to his senses.

Verse 62: Peter weeps. His regret is real. After the resurrection Jesus will forgive him (compare Luke 24:34; John 21:15–19).

For today: Anyone can fail, even the strongest. But failure is not the end.

Jesus is mocked and questioned VERSES 63–71

63 The men who were guarding Jesus
made fun of him and beat him.
64 They covered his eyes.
They hit him in the face and said,
"Prophesy!
Tell us who hit you!"
65 They said many other bad things to him
and insulted him.
66 When morning came,
the elders of the people met together.
The chief priests and the scribes were there too.
They brought Jesus to their council.
They said,
67 "If you are the Christ, tell us!"
Jesus said to them,
"If I tell you,
you will not believe me.
68 And if I ask you a question,
you will not answer me
or let me go.
69 But from now on,
the Son of Man will sit at the right side of the mighty God."
70 They all asked,
"So are you the Son of God?"
He said to them,
"You say it, because I am."
71 They said,
"Why do we need any more witnesses?
We ourselves have heard it from his own mouth!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 63–65: Jesus is tormented and mocked. He does not fight back.

Important: Torturing and humiliating prisoners is always wrong, no matter who it is done to.

Verse 66: The council (in Greek "Sanhedrin") was the highest Jewish authority in Jerusalem. Under the Romans it had only limited power. Probably only the Romans were allowed to carry out a death sentence (compare John 18:31).

Verse 69: Jesus is speaking of Psalm 110:1 and Daniel 7:13. He says: God will honor me and raise me up to himself.

Verse 70: "You say it, because I am": Jesus openly confesses who he is.

Important: Here individual members of the leadership of that time were acting. Not all council members agreed: Joseph of Arimathea had not consented (Luke 23:50–51). The Jewish people as a whole bear no guilt for Jesus' death.

LUKE

CHAPTER 23

"Father, forgive them"

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

In the history of the church the story of Jesus' suffering was often misused to insult Jews as "Christ killers." This led to terrible persecution and violence. That is grave guilt.

In 1965 the Catholic Church declared: What happened in Jesus' suffering may not be blamed on all the Jews living at that time, nor on the Jews of today (*Nostra Aetate*). The Protestant churches have also clearly taken a stand against hostility toward Jews.

Jesus was crucified by the Romans. Crucifixion was a Roman punishment. Those involved were a few powerful people from the temple leadership together with the Roman governor Pilate. Jesus, his mother, the disciples and the women who wept for him were Jews.

Christians believe: Jesus died for the sins of all people. No group of people may be made the guilty ones.

Jesus before Pilate VERSES 1–7

1 Then the whole group of them got up.
They brought Jesus to Pilate.
2 They began to accuse him.
They said, "We found this man leading our nation the wrong way.
He tells people not to pay taxes to Caesar.
And he says that he himself is Christ, a king."

3 Pilate asked him, "Are you the King of the Jews?"
Jesus answered him, "So you say."
4 Pilate said to the chief priests and the crowds,
"I find no reason to charge this man with a crime."
5 But they kept on.
They said, "He stirs up the people.
He teaches all over Judea.
He started in Galilee, and now he has come all the way here."
6 Pilate heard them mention Galilee.
So he asked if the man was from Galilee.
7 He found out that Jesus was from the area that Herod ruled.
So he sent him to Herod.
Herod was also in Jerusalem during those days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Pontius Pilate was the Roman governor of Judea from about AD 26 to 36. Other ancient sources describe him as harsh and cruel.

Verse 2: The charges are political: rebellion, refusing to pay taxes, claiming the title of king. The Romans dealt harshly with such things. The charge about the taxes is false (compare Luke 20:25).

Verse 4: For the first time Pilate says that Jesus is innocent. Luke has him say this three times (verses 4, 14, 22).

Verse 7: Herod Antipas ruled over Galilee. He was in Jerusalem for the Passover feast.

Jesus before Herod VERSES 8–12

8 Herod was very glad when he saw Jesus.
He had wanted to see him for a long time.
He had heard many things about him.
He hoped to see Jesus do a miracle.
9 He asked Jesus many questions.
But Jesus gave him no answers.
10 The chief priests and the scribes stood there.
They accused him with great anger.
11 Herod and his soldiers treated Jesus with contempt and made fun of him.
They dressed him in fancy clothes.
Then they sent him back to Pilate.
12 On that same day, Herod and Pilate became friends.
Before that, they had been enemies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Luke tells that Jesus stood before Herod.

Herod had had John the Baptizer killed. He is only curious. He wants to see a show. That is why Jesus is silent.

Verse 11: The fancy clothes are mockery: They dress him up as a king.

Verse 12: The powerful become friends, at the cost of an innocent man.

Pilate condemns Jesus VERSES 13–25

13 Pilate called together the chief priests, the rulers, and the people.
14 He said to them,
"You brought this man to me.
You said that he leads the people the wrong way.
Look, I have questioned him in front of you.
I found no reason to charge this man with the things you accuse him of.
15 Herod didn't find any reason either.
I sent you to him.
And see, this man has done nothing that deserves death.
16 So I will have him whipped, and then I will let him go."
17 At the feast, Pilate had to set one prisoner free for them.
18 But they all shouted together,
"Away with this man!
Set Barabbas free for us!"
19 Barabbas had been thrown into prison.
He had taken part in a revolt in the city, and he had committed murder.
20 Pilate wanted to let Jesus go.
So he spoke to them again.
21 But they shouted, "Crucify! Crucify him!"
22 Pilate spoke to them a third time.
He said, "Why? What evil has this man done?
I have found nothing in him that deserves the death penalty.
So I will have him whipped, and then I will let him go."
23 But they kept pushing.
They shouted loudly that he must be crucified.
Their voices and the voices of the chief priests won.
24 Pilate decided to give them what they asked for.
25 He set free the man they asked for.
That man had been thrown into prison for revolt and murder.
But Pilate handed Jesus over to them, to do with him what they wanted.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: We do not know exactly who stood there and shouted. It was a crowd in Jerusalem, led by the temple leaders. Shortly before, "all the people" hung on Jesus' every word (Luke 19:48; 21:38). And right afterward many people from the crowds mourn for Jesus (verses 27 and 48).

Important: A crowd in one city on one morning is not "the Jewish people." No one may conclude from this that all Jews are guilty.

Verse 17: Many old manuscripts do not have this verse. The WEB has it. We know of such a custom, releasing a prisoner at the feast, only from the Gospels.

Pilate thinks Jesus is innocent and has him crucified anyway. He had the power and bears the responsibility. A governor who condemns an innocent man to keep the peace acts in a cowardly and unjust way.

Barabbas was a rebel against the Romans. The crowd chooses a violent man instead of Jesus, who brings peace.

For today: Today too, innocent people are condemned because the powerful seek their own advantage. Christians should stand up for justice.

The way to the cross VERSES 26–32

26 They led Jesus away.
On the way they grabbed a man named Simon from Cyrene.
He was coming in from the country.
They put the cross on him.
He had to carry it behind Jesus.

27 A large crowd of people followed Jesus.
Among them were women who were mourning and crying for him.
28 Jesus turned to them and said,
"Daughters of Jerusalem, don't cry for me.
Cry for yourselves and for your children.
29 Look, the days are coming when people will say,
'Blessed are the barren women.
Blessed are the wombs that never gave birth.
Blessed are the breasts that never fed a baby.'
30 Then people will begin to say to the mountains, 'Fall on us!'
And they will say to the hills, 'Cover us.'
31 If they do these things when the tree is green,
what will happen when it is dry?"
32 Two other men were led away with Jesus to be put to death.
They were criminals.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Cyrene was a city in North Africa, in what is now Libya. Many Jews lived there. Simon is forced to carry the cross. He becomes a picture of everyone who follows Jesus (compare Luke 9:23).

Verse 27: Many people from the crowds and many women weep for Jesus. Only Luke tells this. The Jewish people mourn for Jesus.

Verses 28–31: Even on the way to his death Jesus thinks of others. He foresees the suffering that will come over Jerusalem in the war with the Romans. He speaks with compassion. Barren: unable to have children.

Verse 30 is a reminder of Hosea 10:8.

Verse 31: A proverb. It probably means: If even the innocent one has to suffer like this, how bad will it be in the hard time to come?

Jesus is crucified VERSES 33–43

33 They came to the place called "The Skull."
There they crucified Jesus.
They also crucified the criminals there, one on his right and the other on his left.
34 Jesus said, "Father, forgive them. They don't know what they are doing."
They divided his clothes among themselves.
They threw lots for them.
35 The people stood watching.
The rulers also made fun of him.
They said, "He saved others.
Let him save himself, if he is the Christ of God, his chosen one!"
36 The soldiers also made fun of him.
They came to him and offered him sour wine.
37 They said, "If you are the King of the Jews, save yourself!"
38 There was also a sign above him.
It was written in Greek, Latin, and Hebrew letters:
"THIS IS THE KING OF THE JEWS."
39 One of the criminals hanging there insulted Jesus.
He said, "If you are the Christ, save yourself and us!"
40 But the other criminal told him to stop.
He said, "Don't you even fear God?
You are under the same sentence.
41 We deserve our punishment.
We are getting what our deeds have earned.
But this man has done nothing wrong."
42 Then he said to Jesus,
"Lord, remember me when you come into your Kingdom."
43 Jesus said to him,
"I tell you the truth: Today you will be with me in Paradise."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The Skull" (in Latin "Calvary," in Aramaic "Golgotha") was a place of execution outside the city walls of Jerusalem.

Crucifixion was one of the cruelest punishments of the Romans. It was meant for slaves and rebels.

Verse 34: "Father, forgive them": Jesus prays for those who are killing him. These words are missing in some old manuscripts. But they fit Jesus completely (Luke 6:27–28) and also Stephen (Acts 7:60).

Important: If Jesus himself asks forgiveness for his executioners, then no Christian has the right to blame anyone for his death.

Verse 34: The dividing of the clothes is a reminder of Psalm 22:18 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 22:19). Casting lots: a way of deciding by chance, like throwing dice.

Verse 35: "The people stood watching." Luke separates the people from the mockers.

Verse 38: The words about the letters of Greek, Latin, and Hebrew are missing in many old manuscripts. The WEB has them.

Verses 39–43: Only Luke tells about the criminal who asks for mercy. He can no longer make anything right. But he trusts Jesus. And Jesus promises him: "today you will be with me in Paradise."

"Paradise" is a word for God's garden, the place of fellowship with God.

For today: It is never too late to turn to Jesus.

Jesus dies VERSES 44–49

44 It was now about the sixth hour.
Darkness came over the whole land until the ninth hour.
45 The sun stopped shining.
The curtain in the temple was torn in two.
46 Jesus called out with a loud voice,
"Father, into your hands I commit my spirit!"
After he said this, he breathed his last breath.
47 The centurion saw what had happened.
He praised God and said,
"This man really was righteous."
48 All the crowds had come together to watch this.
They saw what had happened.
Then they went back home, beating their chests.
49 All the people who knew Jesus stood far away and watched these things.
The women who had followed him from Galilee were with them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The sixth hour is about 12 noon, the ninth hour about 3 in the afternoon.

Verse 45: The curtain in the temple separated the Most Holy Place from the rest of the temple. Christians often understand its tearing like this: Through Jesus' death the way to God is open for everyone.

Verse 46: Jesus prays with words from Psalm 31:5 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 31:6). Devout Jews also prayed this prayer in the evening before going to sleep. Jesus dies trusting his Father.

Verse 47: A Roman officer recognizes: Jesus was innocent and righteous. Centurion: a Roman officer in charge of about 100 soldiers.

Verse 48: The people from the crowds beat their chests, a sign of grief and regret. Once again Luke shows: The people mourn for Jesus.

Verse 49: The women stay, even when it is dangerous. They will be the first witnesses of the resurrection.

For today: Whoever is dying or has to say goodbye may pray like Jesus, with the words "into your hands I commit my spirit."

Jesus is buried VERSES 50–56

50 There was a man named Joseph.
He was a member of the council.
He was a good and righteous man.
51 He had not agreed with the council's plan and with what they did.
He was from Arimathaea, a town of the Jews.
He was waiting for God's Kingdom.
52 This man went to Pilate and asked for Jesus' body.
53 He took the body down and wrapped it in a linen cloth.
He laid him in a tomb that was cut into the rock.
No one had ever been laid there before.
54 It was the day of the Preparation.
The Sabbath was about to begin.
55 The women who had come with Jesus from Galilee followed Joseph.
They saw the tomb.
They saw how his body was laid there.
56 Then they went back home.
They prepared spices and fragrant oils.
On the Sabbath they rested, as the commandment says.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 50–51: Joseph of Arimathaea is a Jewish member of the council. He did not agree with what happened. He honors Jesus with a dignified burial. This shows: The council was not united.

People who were crucified were often not buried. Joseph stands up for Jesus, even though that was dangerous.

Verse 54: "The day of the Preparation" is the Friday on which everything is made ready for the Sabbath. The Sabbath begins on Friday evening at sunset.

Verse 56: The women keep the Sabbath, as God's law says (Exodus 20:8–11). They live as devout Jewish women. The fragrant oils were for the body of the dead.

For today: Burying a person with dignity and mourning for them is a work of love. People who are grieving can find help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

LUKE

CHAPTER 24

He is alive!

The empty tomb VERSES 1–12

1 On the first day of the week, very early in the morning,
the women came to the tomb.
Some others came with them.
They brought the spices they had prepared.
2 They found that the stone had been rolled away from the tomb.
3 They went in.
But they didn't find the body of the Lord Jesus.
4 They did not know what to think.
Suddenly two men stood next to them.
Their clothes were shining brightly.
5 The women were terrified.
They bowed down with their faces to the ground.
The men said to them,
"Why are you looking for the living among the dead?
6 He isn't here.
He has risen!
Remember what he told you while he was still in Galilee.
7 He said that the Son of Man must be handed over to sinful people.
He said that they would crucify him, and that he would rise again on the third day."
8 Then the women remembered his words.
9 They went back from the tomb.
They told all these things to the Eleven and to all the others.
10 The women were Mary Magdalene, Joanna, and Mary the mother of James.
The other women with them also told these things to the apostles.
11 But the apostles thought these words were nonsense.
They didn't believe the women.
12 But Peter got up and ran to the tomb.
He bent down and looked in.
He saw only the strips of linen lying there by themselves.
Then he went home.
He wondered what had happened.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The first day of the week" is Sunday. That is why Christians hold their worship services on Sunday: It is the day of the resurrection. Easter is the most important feast of Christians.

The women want to anoint the dead Jesus. They are not expecting a resurrection. But the tomb is empty.

Verse 5: "Why are you looking for the living among the dead?" That is the Easter message.

The women are the first witnesses of the resurrection. Back then the testimony of women often counted for little in court. Even so, all the Gospels tell that women were the first at the empty tomb. That suggests that this is how it was handed down.

Verse 11: The apostles do not believe the women. They think it is nonsense. That is told honestly.

Verse 12 is missing in one old manuscript. Almost all others have it.

For today: Whoever has doubts is in good company. Even the apostles could not believe it at first.

The disciples on the road to Emmaus VERSES 13–35

13 On that same day, two of them were walking to a village
named Emmaus.
It was 60 stadia from Jerusalem, about 7 miles.
14 They were talking with each other about all the things
that had happened.
15 While they were talking and asking each other
questions, Jesus himself came near.
He walked along with them.
16 But something kept their eyes from recognizing him.
17 He said to them,
"What are you talking about as you walk along?
Why are you sad?"
18 One of them was named Cleopas.
He answered him,
"Are you the only visitor in Jerusalem who doesn't
know what has happened there in these days?"
19 Jesus asked them, "What things?"
They said to him,
"The things about Jesus the Nazarene.
He was a prophet.
His deeds and his words were powerful before God and
before all the people.
20 The chief priests and our rulers handed him over.
They had him sentenced to death, and they crucified
him.
21 But we were hoping that he was the one who would set
Israel free.
And there is more:
It is now the third day since these things happened.
22 Also, some women from our group amazed us.
They went to the tomb early this morning.
23 They didn't find his body.
They came back and said that they had also seen angels
in a vision.
The angels said that he is alive.
24 Some of us went to the tomb.
They found it just as the women had said.
But they didn't see him."
25 Jesus said to them,
"You foolish people!
Your hearts are so slow to believe everything the
prophets have said!
26 Didn't the Christ have to suffer these things and then
enter into his glory?"
27 Then he explained to them what all the Scriptures say
about him.
He began with Moses and with all the prophets.
28 They came near the village they were going to.
Jesus acted as if he was going on farther.
29 But they begged him,
"Stay with us.
It is almost evening.
The day is almost over."
So he went in to stay with them.
30 He sat down at the table with them.
He took the bread and gave thanks.
He broke it and gave it to them.
31 Then their eyes were opened, and they recognized him.
And he disappeared from their sight.
32 They said to each other,
"Weren't our hearts burning inside us while he talked
with us on the road?
Weren't they burning while he explained the
Scriptures to us?"
33 They got up that same hour and went back to
Jerusalem.
There they found the Eleven and the others with
them.
They were all gathered together.
34 They were saying,
"The Lord really has risen!
He has appeared to Simon!"
35 Then the two told what had happened on the road.
They told how they had recognized Jesus when he
broke the bread.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Only Luke tells this story. It is one of the most beautiful in the Bible.

Verse 13: 60 stadia are about 7 miles (11 kilometers). Some manuscripts have 160 stadia. Where exactly Emmaus was is not certain.

Verse 16: The two are so sad and disappointed that they do not recognize Jesus.

Verse 18: Cleopas is one of the two. Luke does not give the name of the other. Some interpreters think it was his wife.

Verse 20: The two disciples are Jews themselves. They speak of "our rulers." What is meant is certain leaders, not the people. Important: No guilt of the Jews may be drawn from this.

Verse 21: "We were hoping": Their hope seems to have died. Many people know this feeling.

Verse 27: Jesus explains the Holy Scriptures of Israel to them, the Old Testament. Without them you cannot understand Jesus.

Verses 30–31: They recognize him when he breaks the bread, as at the Last Supper (Luke 22:19). To this day Christians experience this: In worship, in hearing the Scriptures and in the Lord's Supper, Jesus is near.

Verse 34: Jesus appeared to Simon Peter. Paul also speaks of this (1 Corinthians 15:5). Peter, who had denied him, is one of the first he meets.

For today: Jesus walks with us, even when we do not recognize him. The request of the two, to stay with them because it is almost evening, is to this day a well-loved prayer and the theme of many hymns.

Jesus appears to the disciples VERSES 36–49

36 While they were still talking about this, Jesus himself
stood among them.
He said to them, "Peace be to you."
37 But they were terrified and full of fear.
They thought they were seeing a spirit.
38 He said to them,
"Why are you so upset?
Why do doubts come up in your hearts?
39 Look at my hands and my feet.
It really is me.
Touch me and see.
A spirit doesn't have flesh and bones.
But you see that I have them."
40 After he said this, he showed them his hands and his
feet.
41 They were so full of joy that they still couldn't believe
it.
They were amazed.
Then he said to them, "Do you have anything here to
eat?"
42 They gave him a piece of cooked fish and some
honeycomb.
43 He took it and ate it in front of them.
44 He said to them,
"This is what I told you while I was still with you:
Everything that is written about me must come true.
It is written in the law of Moses, in the prophets, and
in the psalms."
45 Then he opened their minds, so that they could
understand the Scriptures.
46 He said to them,
"This is what is written:
The Christ had to suffer.
He had to rise from the dead on the third day.
47 And in his name, people must preach to all nations:
Turn back to God, and your sins will be forgiven.
They must begin in Jerusalem.
48 You are witnesses of these things.
49 Look, I am sending on you what my Father promised.
But wait in the city of Jerusalem until you are clothed
with power from on high."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 36: "Peace be to you" is the Jewish greeting "shalom." It is still spoken in worship services today.

Verses 39–43: Luke stresses: The risen Jesus is not a ghost. He has a body, he can be touched, he eats. And yet he is different: He appears and disappears. The resurrection is a mystery that goes beyond our understanding.

Verse 40 is missing in one old manuscript. Verse 42: The words about the honeycomb are missing in most old manuscripts. The WEB has them.

Verse 44: The law of Moses, the prophets and the psalms: These are the three parts of the Holy Scriptures of Israel. Jesus reads the whole Bible of Israel as a witness to himself.

Verse 47: The message is to go to all nations, but to begin in Jerusalem. The Book of Acts, the second part of Luke's work, tells about this.

Verse 49: "Clothed with power from on high" means: filled with God's strength. What the Father promised is the Holy Spirit. He comes at Pentecost (Acts 2).

Jesus is taken up into heaven VERSES 50–53

50 Jesus led them out as far as Bethany.
He lifted up his hands and blessed them.
51 While he was blessing them, he left them.
He was carried up into heaven.
52 They worshiped him.
Then they went back to Jerusalem with great joy.
53 They were always in the temple.
There they praised God and blessed him.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This is the Ascension of Jesus. Christians celebrate it 40 days after Easter (compare Acts 1:3–11).

Verses 50–51: The last thing the disciples see of Jesus: He blesses them. With this blessing they go into the future.

Verses 51–52: The words about being carried up into heaven and about worshiping him are missing in some old manuscripts. The WEB has them.

"Heaven" is not a place above the clouds. It means: Jesus is with God, in God's reality. From there he is near to all people.

Verse 52: The disciples are not sad, but full of joy.

Verse 53: The Gospel ends where it began: in the temple in Jerusalem (Luke 1:8–9). The disciples keep praying in the temple as devout Jews.

"Amen" means: So it is, or: So be it. It is missing in many old manuscripts.

Looking back: What have we read in the Gospel of Luke?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A careful report: Luke wanted "to trace everything carefully from the start" (1:3). He names emperors and rulers and places Jesus' story within world history. He writes for Theophilus and for everyone who loves God.

Christmas: In Luke we find the story of Mary's yes, the birth in Bethlehem, the manger, the shepherds and the angels: "a Savior is born to you" (2:11). Also the songs of Mary, Zechariah and Simeon, which are still sung today.

Good news for the poor: In Nazareth Jesus reads from Isaiah that God has anointed him "to bring good news to poor people" (4:18). Luke shows Jesus on the side of the poor, the sick, tax collectors, sinners, Samaritans and foreigners.

Women: In Luke women play a big role: Mary and Elizabeth, the prophetess Anna, the women who travel with Jesus and support him, Martha and Mary, the widows. Women are the first witnesses of the resurrection.

Famous parables: Only Luke tells of the Good Samaritan, the lost son, the rich farmer, the rich man and poor Lazarus, the Pharisee and the tax collector.

Prayer and the Holy Spirit: In Luke Jesus prays before all the important moments. And he promises the Holy Spirit.

Mercy and forgiveness: Zacchaeus, the woman who anoints Jesus' feet, the criminal on the cross. And on the cross Jesus prays: "Father, forgive them" (23:34). The Son of Man came "to look for the lost and to save them" (19:10).

Important note: Luke begins and ends in the temple in Jerusalem. Jesus, Mary, the disciples and the first Christians lived as Jews. Again and again Luke shows how "all the people" listen to Jesus and mourn for him. No text of this Gospel may be used against Jews.

For today: Like the disciples on the road to Emmaus, we too can meet Jesus: when we hear the Holy Scriptures and share the bread.

What comes next? Next comes the Gospel of John. It is different from the other three Gospels. It begins with the Word that was there in the beginning. John tells of great signs of Jesus and of long speeches in which Jesus says who he is: the bread of life, the light of the world, the good shepherd.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 43 OF 66

JOHN

21 CHAPTERS

JOHN

Chapter 1

The Word became human

Before we begin: The Gospel of John

The Gospel of John is the fourth Gospel. It is different from the other three (Matthew, Mark, Luke). It tells fewer parables, but has long conversations and speeches. Here Jesus often says who he is: the bread of life, the light of the world, the good shepherd, the resurrection and the life.

According to old church tradition, it was written by the apostle John, a son of Zebedee. The book itself names as its witness the disciple whom Jesus loved (21:20–24). Who exactly that was is debated among scholars. The Gospel was probably written around AD 90 to 100.

John tells of seven great "signs," for example the wedding at Cana and the raising of Lazarus. He says himself why he writes: so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life (20:31).

A very important note: John often speaks of "the Jews," even where he means opponents of Jesus. This language was terribly misused in history and has contributed to hatred and persecution. You need to know: Jesus, his mother, all the disciples and the author himself were Jews. In many places John uses "the Jews" to mean certain leaders in Jerusalem, not the whole people. The Gospel itself says that salvation comes from the Jews (4:22). We translate exactly what the text says. In the boxes we explain who is meant each time. No word of this book may be used against Jews.

The Gospel has 21 chapters.

In the beginning was the Word VERSES 1–18

1 In the beginning was the Word.
The Word was with God.
And the Word was God.
2 He was with God in the beginning.
3 Everything was made through him.
Nothing that has been made was made without him.
4 In him was life.
And this life was the light of people.
5 The light shines in the darkness.
And the darkness hasn't overcome it.
6 God sent a man.
His name was John.
7 He came as a witness.
He came to tell about the light,
so that everyone might believe through him.
8 John was not the light himself.
He was sent to tell about the light.
9 The true light was coming into the world.
This light gives light to every person.
10 He was in the world.
The world was made through him.
But the world didn't recognize him.
11 He came to his own.
But his own people didn't welcome him.
12 But some did welcome him.
He gave all of them the right to become God's children.
These are the people who believe in his name.
13 They were not born from human blood.
They were not born because a human body wanted it,
or because a man wanted it.
They were born from God.
14 The Word became flesh and lived among us.
That means: He became a human being.
We saw his glory.
It was the glory of the only born Son of the Father.
He was full of grace and truth.
15 John told about him.
He called out,
"This is the one I was talking about.
I said, 'The one who comes after me is greater than I am,
because he was there before me.'"
16 From his fullness we have all received grace upon grace.
17 The law was given through Moses.
Grace and truth came through Jesus Christ.
18 No one has ever seen God.
But the only born Son is very close to the Father's heart.
He has made God known.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These verses are called the "prologue," the foreword. They are among the best-known texts of the Bible.

"In the beginning" is a reminder of the first sentence of the Bible, where God creates the heavens and the earth (Genesis 1:1). God created the world through his word: God said, and it happened.

"The Word" (in Greek "Logos") is Jesus. John says: Jesus was already with God before creation. He is God. Everything came into being through him. That is why Christians believe: Jesus is true God and true man.

Verses 6–8: John here is John the Baptizer, not the author of the Gospel.

Verse 11: Some interpreters understand "his own" as the people of the world he created, others as his people Israel. Important: This is not a judgment on the Jewish people. Many Jews received Jesus, first of all his disciples. Verse 12 speaks right away of those who received him.

Verse 14: "The Word became flesh" means: God became a human being, with a body, feelings and limits. Christians celebrate this at Christmas. "Lived among us" literally means "pitched his tent among us." That is a reminder of the holy tent in which God lived among Israel in the wilderness (Exodus 40:34).

Verse 17: The law through Moses is also a gift from God. John does not present it as bad. He says: In Jesus God's grace comes once again, new and very close.

Verse 18: The WEB says "The only born Son." The oldest manuscripts have "the only God" or "the only born God." The WEB says the Son is "in the bosom of the Father": very close to him.

For today: God is not far away. In Jesus he became human and knows our life from the inside.

John the Baptizer gives an answer VERSES 19–28

19 The Jews sent priests and Levites from Jerusalem to John.
They were to ask him, "Who are you?"
This is what John said to them.

20 He told them openly.
He didn't deny it.
He said clearly, "I am not the Christ."

21 They asked him, "Then who are you? Are you Elijah?"
He said, "I am not."
"Are you the prophet?"
He answered, "No."

22 So they said to him,
"Who are you?
We must give an answer to the people who sent us.
What do you say about yourself?"

23 John said,
"I am the voice of someone calling out in the wilderness,
'Make the way straight for the Lord.'
That is what Isaiah the prophet said."

24 The messengers were from the Pharisees.

25 They asked him,
"If you are not the Christ, or Elijah, or the prophet, then why do you baptize?"

26 John answered them,
"I baptize in water.
But someone is standing among you whom you don't know.

27 He is the one who comes after me.
He is greater than I am.
I am not even good enough to untie the strap of his sandal."

28 These things happened in Bethany on the other side of the Jordan.
John was baptizing there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: "The Jews" here means the religious leaders in Jerusalem. They send a group of messengers. The question of who John is was a serious and fair question for them.

Priests and Levites served in the temple.

Verse 21: Many expected the prophet Elijah to come back before the Messiah (Malachi 4:5, in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 3:23). "The prophet" means the prophet like Moses whom God had promised (Deuteronomy 18:15).

John says clearly who he is not. He does not want to be important. He points to someone else.

Verse 23 quotes Isaiah 40:3.

Verse 27: Loosening sandals was the work of a slave. John says: I am not even worthy to do him this service.

Verse 28: This Bethany is by the Jordan, not the village near Jerusalem. Some manuscripts have "Bethabara."

The Lamb of God VERSES 29–34

29 The next day, John saw Jesus coming toward him.
He said, "Look, there is the Lamb of God!
He takes away the sin of the world!

30 He is the one I was talking about.
I said, 'A man is coming after me who is greater than I am,
because he was there before me.'

31 I didn't know him myself.
But I came baptizing in water for this reason:
so that he would be shown to Israel."

32 John told them,
"I saw the Spirit coming down from heaven like a dove.
And the Spirit stayed on him.

33 I didn't know who he was.
But the one who sent me to baptize in water said to me,
'You will see the Spirit come down on someone and stay on him.
He is the one who baptizes in the Holy Spirit.'

34 I have seen it.
And I tell you: This is the Son of God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Lamb of God" is a reminder of the Passover lamb, which recalls the freeing from Egypt (Exodus 12). It is also a reminder of the suffering servant of God, who was led like a lamb (Isaiah 53:7).

"He takes away the sin of the world": Christians believe that through his death Jesus carries the guilt of all people. In many worship services people still sing: *Lamb of God, you take away the sins of the world.*

John does not tell the baptism of Jesus directly. John the Baptizer only reports what he saw.

Verse 34: Instead of Son of God, some old manuscripts have the Chosen One of God.

The first disciples VERSES 35–42

35 The next day, John was standing there again with two of his disciples.

36 He looked at Jesus walking by.
He said, "Look, there is the Lamb of God!"

37 The two disciples heard him say this.
So they followed Jesus.

38 Jesus turned around.
He saw them following him.
He asked them, "What are you looking for?"
They said to him, "Rabbi, where are you staying?"
Rabbi means: Teacher.

39 He said to them, "Come and see."
So they came and saw where he was staying.
They stayed with him that day.
It was about the tenth hour.

40 One of the two men was Andrew, the brother of Simon Peter.
He had heard what John said, and he had followed Jesus.

41 First Andrew found his own brother, Simon.
He said to him, "We have found the Messiah!"
Messiah means: Christ.

42 Andrew brought Simon to Jesus.
Jesus looked at him and said,
"You are Simon, the son of Jonah.
You will be called Cephas."
Cephas means: Peter.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 38: "What are you looking for?" are the first words of Jesus in the Gospel of John. This question is for all people.

Verse 39: "Come and see." Jesus invites. People are to get to know him for themselves. The tenth hour is about 4 in the afternoon.

The second disciple is not named. Some interpreters think it was the disciple whom Jesus loved.

"Messiah" (Hebrew) and "Christ" (Greek) both mean "the Anointed One."

Verse 42: "Cephas" (Aramaic) and "Peter" (Greek) both mean "rock" or "stone." Instead of "son of Jonah" many old manuscripts have "son of John."

For today: Whoever has found Jesus tells others, like Andrew told his brother.

Philip and Nathanael VERSES 43–51

43 The next day, Jesus decided to go to Galilee.
He found Philip and said to him, "Follow me."
44 Philip was from Bethsaida.
Andrew and Peter were from that town too.
45 Philip found Nathanael.
He said to him,
"We have found the one Moses wrote about in the law.
The prophets also wrote about him.
He is Jesus of Nazareth, the son of Joseph."
46 Nathanael said to him,
"Nazareth? Can anything good come from there?"
Philip said to him, "Come and see."
47 Jesus saw Nathanael coming toward him.
He said about him,
"Look, here is a true Israelite.
There is nothing false in him!"
48 Nathanael asked him, "How do you know me?"
Jesus answered him,
"I saw you before Philip called you.
You were under the fig tree."
49 Nathanael answered him,
"Rabbi, you are the Son of God!
You are King of Israel!"
50 Jesus answered him,
"Do you believe because I told you that I saw you under the fig tree?
You will see greater things than that!"
51 Then he said to him,
"I tell all of you the truth:
From now on you will see heaven open.
You will see God's angels going up and coming down on the Son of Man."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nathanael appears only in the Gospel of John. Some interpreters think he is the same person as Bartholomew in the other Gospels. That is not certain.

Verse 46: Nazareth was a small, unimportant village. Nathanael is doubtful. Philip does not argue, but invites: "Come and see."

Verse 47: Jesus praises Nathanael as "a true Israelite," honest and without anything false. That is great praise for a devout Jew.

Verse 48: People liked to sit under the fig tree to read the Holy Scriptures and to pray.

Verse 51 is a reminder of Jacob's dream of the ladder to heaven (Genesis 28:12). Jesus is the connection between heaven and earth. The words "from now on" are missing in the oldest manuscripts.

For today: Doubts and questions are allowed. Jesus takes doubters seriously too.

JOHN

CHAPTER 2

Water becomes wine

The wedding at Cana VERSES 1–12

1 On the third day, there was a wedding in Cana in Galilee.
Jesus' mother was there.
2 Jesus and his disciples were also invited to the wedding.
3 The wine ran out.
Then Jesus' mother said to him, "They have no wine."
4 Jesus said to her,
"Woman, what does that have to do with you and me?
My hour has not come yet."
5 His mother said to the servants,
"Do whatever he tells you."
6 Six stone water jars were standing there.
The Jews used them for washing, to make themselves clean before God.
Each jar held about 20 to 30 gallons.
7 Jesus said to the servants, "Fill the jars with water."
So they filled them up to the top.
8 Then he said to them,
"Now take some out.
Bring it to the man in charge of the feast."
So they brought it to him.
9 The man in charge of the feast tasted the water.
It had now become wine.
He didn't know where it came from.
But the servants who had taken out the water knew.
So the man in charge of the feast called the bridegroom.
10 He said to him,
"Everyone serves the good wine first.
Then, when the guests have had plenty to drink, they serve the cheaper wine.
But you have kept the good wine until now!"
11 This was the first of Jesus' signs.
He did it in Cana in Galilee.

In this way, he showed his glory.
And his disciples believed in him.

12 After this, Jesus went down to Capernaum.
His mother, his brothers, and his disciples went with him.
They stayed there for a few days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then a wedding often lasted a whole week. If the wine ran out, it was a great shame for the bridegroom's family.

Verse 4: "Woman" was not an impolite way to speak back then. Jesus also says it lovingly to his mother at the cross (John 19:26). In John, "my hour" means the hour of his death and his glorification.

Verse 5: Mary trusts Jesus, even without knowing what he will do. "Do whatever he tells you" is good advice for all Christians.

Verse 6: A metretes was about 10 gallons (39 liters). So each jar held about 20 to 30 gallons (80 to 120 liters). Together that is over 120 gallons (500 liters), a huge amount of wine.

The jars were meant for ritual washing, a good devout custom. Jesus fills them with new content. This shows: With Jesus comes God's abundance and joy.

Verse 11: John calls Jesus' miracles "signs." They show who Jesus is.

Important: In the Bible wine belongs to a celebration. Whoever has problems with alcohol is not worse than others. Help is available from addiction counseling services and self-help groups. In the US, call the SAMHSA National Helpline at 1-800-662-4357.

Verse 12: About Jesus' "brothers," see the boxes at Luke 8:19–21: The churches understand this in different ways.

For today: Jesus celebrates with people. He gives joy in abundance.

Jesus in the temple VERSES 13–25

13 It was almost time for the Passover of the Jews.
So Jesus went up to Jerusalem.

14 In the temple he found people selling cattle, sheep, and doves.
The money changers were also sitting there.

15 Jesus made a whip out of ropes.
He drove them all out of the temple, with the sheep and the cattle.
He poured out the money changers' coins.
He turned over their tables.

16 He said to the people who sold doves,
"Get these things out of here!
Don't turn my Father's house into a market!"

17 His disciples remembered that the Scriptures say,
"Zeal for your house will eat me up."

18 Then the Jews asked him,
"You are doing these things.
So what sign will you show us?"

19 Jesus answered them,
"Destroy this temple, and I will raise it up again in three days."

20 Then the Jews said,
"It took 46 years to build this temple!
And you will raise it up in three days?"

21 But the temple Jesus was talking about was his body.

22 Later he was raised from the dead.
Then his disciples remembered that he had said this.
And they believed the Scriptures and the words Jesus had said.

23 Jesus was in Jerusalem for the Passover feast.
During the feast, many people saw the signs he did.
So they believed in his name.

24 But Jesus didn't trust himself to them.
He knew all people.

25 No one needed to tell him anything about people.
He himself knew what was inside a person.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

John tells the cleansing of the temple at the beginning of Jesus' work. The other Gospels tell it at the end, shortly before his death. John arranges the events more by their meaning.

In the outer court animals were sold for the sacrifices. Pilgrims had to exchange their money for temple money. That was needed for the temple service.

Jesus acts like a prophet: He wants the temple to remain a house of prayer. He calls it "my Father's house." He loves the temple.

Important: Jesus uses the whip to drive out the animals. John does not tell that he hit people. This passage does not justify violence.

Verse 17 quotes Psalm 69:9 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 69:10). Zeal: burning love and eagerness.

Verses 18 and 20: "The Jews" here means those in charge of the temple. Their question is fair: Who gives you the right? Important: This does not mean the Jewish people.

Verse 20: King Herod the Great had the temple splendidly enlarged. Building work had been going on for 46 years.

Verse 21: Jesus means his own body. He predicts his death and his resurrection. God lives in him.

For today: Christians also say: Our body is a temple of God (1 Corinthians 6:19). That is why we should treat it with respect.

JOHN

CHAPTER 3

God so loved the world

Jesus and Nicodemus VERSES 1–21

1 There was a man named Nicodemus.
He was one of the Pharisees and a leader of the Jews.

2 He came to Jesus at night.
He said to him,
"Rabbi, we know that you are a teacher who has come from God.
No one can do the signs you do unless God is with him."

3 Jesus answered him,
"I tell you the truth:
No one can see God's Kingdom unless he is born again."

4 Nicodemus said to him,
"How can a man be born when he is old?
He can't go into his mother's womb a second time and be born, can he?"
5 Jesus answered,
"I tell you the truth:
No one can enter God's Kingdom unless he is born of water and Spirit.
6 What is born of the flesh is flesh.
What is born of the Spirit is spirit.
7 Don't be surprised that I told you,
'You must all be born again.'
8 The wind blows wherever it wants to.
You hear the sound it makes.
But you don't know where it comes from or where it is going.
It is the same with everyone who is born of the Spirit."
9 Nicodemus answered him,
"How can this happen?"
10 Jesus answered him,
"You are the teacher of Israel, and you don't understand these things?
11 I tell you the truth:
We speak about what we know.
We tell about what we have seen.
But you people don't accept what we tell you.
12 I have told you about things on earth, and you don't believe.
So how will you believe if I tell you about things in heaven?
13 No one has gone up into heaven except the one who came down from heaven:
the Son of Man, who is in heaven.
14 Moses lifted up the snake in the wilderness.
In the same way, the Son of Man must be lifted up.
15 Then everyone who believes in him will not be lost.
They will have eternal life.
16 God loved the world very much.
So he gave his only born Son.
Everyone who believes in him will not be lost.
They will have eternal life.
17 God didn't send his Son into the world to judge the world.
He sent him so that the world would be saved through him.
18 Whoever believes in him is not judged.
Whoever doesn't believe is judged already.
That person has not believed in the name of God's only born Son.
19 This is the judgment:
The light has come into the world.
But people loved the darkness more than the light, because the things they did were evil.
20 Everyone who does evil hates the light.
He doesn't come to the light,
because he doesn't want his deeds to be seen.
21 But whoever does what is true comes to the light.
Then everyone can see that his deeds were done in God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Nicodemus is a respected Pharisee and a member of the council. He is open and honestly interested in Jesus. Later he stands up for Jesus (John 7:50–51) and helps with his burial (John 19:39). He is an example that many Jewish leaders treated Jesus with respect.

Verse 2: He comes at night. Perhaps because he wants to talk in peace. In John, night also stands for not understanding.

Verse 3: "Born again." The Greek word can also mean "born from above." Nicodemus first understands it literally.

Verse 5: "Of water and Spirit": Many Christians think of baptism here. What is meant is: God himself gives a new life.

Verse 8: In Greek, "wind" and "spirit" are the same word (pneuma). God's Spirit is like the wind: You cannot hold on to it, but you feel what it does.

Verse 13: The words "who is in heaven" are missing in the oldest manuscripts. The WEB has them.

Verse 14: In the wilderness Moses made a snake out of bronze. Whoever had been bitten and looked at it was saved (Numbers 21:8–9). In John, "lifted up" means: lifted up on the cross and raised up to God.

Verse 16 is one of the best-known verses of the Bible. It sums up the whole good news: God loves the world, all people.

Verse 17: God wants to save, not to condemn.

Important: The churches answer the question of what happens to people who do not believe in Jesus in different ways. Many stress: God's love and mercy are greater than we think. Judgment belongs to God alone, not to people.

For today: No one is too old for a new start with God.

John the Baptizer and Jesus VERSES 22–36

22 After this, Jesus went with his disciples into the land of Judea.
He stayed there with them and baptized.
23 John was also baptizing.
He was in Enon near Salim, because there was a lot of water there.
People came to him and were baptized.
24 John had not yet been thrown into prison.
25 Some of John's disciples started to argue with some Jews.
They argued about washing to become clean before God.
26 They came to John and said to him,
"Rabbi, do you remember the man who was with you on the other side of the Jordan?
You told people about him.
Look, he is baptizing, and everyone is going to him."
27 John answered,
"A person can receive only what is given to him from heaven.
28 You yourselves are witnesses that I said, 'I am not the Christ.'
I said, 'I have been sent ahead of him.'
29 The bride belongs to the bridegroom.
But the friend of the bridegroom stands there and listens for him.
He is full of joy when he hears the bridegroom's voice.
That is why my joy is now complete.
30 He must become greater.
I must become less.

31 "The one who comes from above is above everyone.
The one who is from the earth belongs to the earth.
He speaks about the earth.
The one who comes from heaven is above everyone.
32 He tells about what he has seen and heard.
But no one accepts what he says.
33 Whoever accepts what he says has confirmed that God is true.
34 God sent him, and he speaks God's words.
God gives the Spirit without limit.
35 The Father loves the Son.
He has put everything into his hands.
36 Whoever believes in the Son has eternal life.
But whoever does not obey the Son will not see life.
God's anger stays on him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Enon near Salim was probably in the Jordan Valley. The name Enon means "springs."

Verse 25: "Some Jews": Some manuscripts have "a Jew." It is about a question of religious purification. Such discussions were common among devout Jews.

Verse 26: John's disciples are a little jealous. But John is not.

Verse 29: John compares himself to the friend of the bridegroom, who prepares the wedding. He is glad when the bridegroom comes. The bridegroom is Jesus.

Verse 30: "He must become greater. I must become less." John is an example of humility.

Verses 31–36: We do not know exactly whether John the Baptizer is still speaking here, or whether the author of the Gospel is explaining.

Verse 36: "God's anger" means: God does not simply let evil stand. Whoever deliberately turns away from God's life remains without this life.

Important: These verses are no license to condemn other people or to threaten them with God's anger. Judgment belongs to God alone. And God wants all to be saved (verse 17).

JOHN

CHAPTER 4

Living water

Jesus and the woman of Samaria VERSES 1–26

1 The Pharisees had heard that Jesus was making and baptizing more disciples than John.
The Lord knew that they had heard this.
2 But Jesus himself didn't baptize.
His disciples did.
3 So Jesus left Judea and went back to Galilee.
4 He had to go through Samaria.
5 So he came to a town in Samaria called Sychar.
It was near the field that Jacob had given to his son Joseph.
6 Jacob's well was there.
Jesus was tired from the long walk.
So he sat down by the well.
It was about the sixth hour.
7 A woman from Samaria came to get water.
Jesus said to her, "Give me a drink."
8 His disciples had gone into the town to buy food.
9 The Samaritan woman said to him,
"You are a Jew, and I am a Samaritan woman.
How can you ask me for a drink?"
Jews have nothing to do with Samaritans.
10 Jesus answered her,
"You don't know the gift of God.
And you don't know who is asking you, 'Give me a drink.'
If you knew, you would have asked him.
And he would have given you living water."
11 The woman said to him,
"Sir, you have nothing to get water with, and the well is deep.
So where do you get that living water?
12 Are you greater than our father Jacob?
He gave us this well.
He drank from it himself.
His children and his animals drank from it too."
13 Jesus answered her,
"Everyone who drinks this water will get thirsty again.
14 But whoever drinks the water I give him will never be thirsty again.
The water I give him will become a spring of water inside him.
It will keep flowing up to eternal life."
15 The woman said to him,
"Sir, give me this water!
Then I won't get thirsty.
And I won't have to keep coming all the way here to get water."
16 Jesus said to her,
"Go, call your husband, and come back here."
17 The woman answered, "I have no husband."
Jesus said to her,
"You are right when you say, 'I have no husband.'
18 You have had five husbands.
And the man you have now is not your husband.
What you said is true."
19 The woman said to him,
"Sir, I can see that you are a prophet.
20 Our ancestors worshiped on this mountain.
But you Jews say that people must worship in Jerusalem."
21 Jesus said to her,
"Woman, believe me:
The hour is coming when you will worship the Father neither on this mountain nor in Jerusalem.
22 You worship what you don't know.
We worship what we know.
For salvation is from the Jews.

23 But the hour is coming, and it is already here:
The true worshipers will worship the Father in spirit and truth.
The Father is looking for people like that to worship him.
24 God is spirit.
The people who worship him must worship in spirit and truth."
25 The woman said to him,
"I know that the Messiah is coming.
He is called Christ.
When he comes, he will tell us everything."
26 Jesus said to her,
"I am he, the one who is speaking to you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jews and Samaritans had been in conflict for centuries. The Samaritans had their own holy mountain, Mount Gerizim, and accepted only the five books of Moses. Many Jews avoided Samaria.

Verse 6: The sixth hour is about 12 noon. That was the hottest time of the day. Usually women fetched water in the morning or evening. Perhaps the woman comes alone because she wants to keep away from the others.

Verse 7: Jesus speaks to a woman he does not know and asks her for help. Back then a Jewish man did not simply talk with a strange woman, and certainly not with a Samaritan woman. Jesus crosses these boundaries.

"Living water" was the word for fresh, flowing spring water. Jesus means a life from God's Spirit that never dries up.

Verses 16–18: Jesus knows her life. But he does not condemn her. We do not know why she had five husbands. Back then women could hardly divorce on their own. Perhaps she had been widowed several times or sent away by men. The Bible does not say that she was a sinner.

Verse 22: "Salvation is from the Jews." Jesus says clearly: God's rescue comes from the Jewish people. He himself is a Jew. This sentence is very important against all hostility toward Jews.

Verses 23–24: God is not bound to one place. You can worship him anywhere, honestly and from the heart.

Verse 26: "I am he." To a woman from Samaria, as one of the very first, Jesus says quite openly that he is the Messiah.

For today: Jesus goes to people whom others avoid. He sees every person with dignity.

The harvest is ready VERSES 27–42

27 Just then, his disciples came back.
They were surprised that he was talking with a woman.
But no one said, "What are you looking for?"
And no one said, "Why are you talking with her?"
28 Then the woman left her water jar.
She went back into the town and said to the people,
29 "Come and see a man who told me everything I have ever done!
Could he be the Christ?"
30 So the people left the town and started coming to Jesus.
31 Meanwhile, the disciples kept asking him,
"Rabbi, eat something."
32 But he said to them,
"I have food to eat that you don't know about."
33 So the disciples said to each other,
"Has someone brought him something to eat?"
34 Jesus said to them,
"My food is to do the will of the one who sent me.
My food is to finish his work.
35 Don't you say, 'It is still four months until the harvest'?
Look, I tell you: Look up and see the fields.
They are already white for harvest.
36 The one who harvests is already getting paid.
He is gathering a crop for eternal life.
So the one who plants and the one who harvests can be glad together.
37 Here the saying is true:
'One person plants, and another person harvests.'
38 I sent you to harvest a crop you didn't work for.
Others did the hard work.
And you have come in to enjoy the results of their work."
39 Many of the Samaritans from that town believed in Jesus.
They believed because of what the woman told them.
She said, "He told me everything I have ever done."
40 So the Samaritans came to Jesus.
They begged him to stay with them.
And he stayed there two days.
41 Many more people believed because of what he said.
42 They said to the woman,
"Now we believe, but not because of what you told us.
We have heard him ourselves.
And we know that he really is the Christ, the Savior of the world."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 28: The woman leaves her jar behind. She has found something more important.

The woman becomes Jesus' first messenger in Samaria. Through her testimony many people come to faith. A woman who perhaps lived on the edge becomes a preacher.

Verse 34: Jesus lives by doing God's will. That gives him strength like food.

Verse 35: The fields that are "white for harvest" are the people from Samaria who are just coming out of the city. They are ready for God's message.

Verse 42: "The Savior of the world": Jesus did not come for only one people, but for all people.

For today: Anyone can tell about Jesus, even those who think they are not good enough.

Jesus heals the son of a royal official VERSES 43–54

43 After the two days, Jesus left that place and went on to Galilee.
44 Jesus himself had said that a prophet is not honored in his own country.
45 He came to Galilee, and the people of Galilee welcomed him.
They had seen everything he did in Jerusalem at the feast.
They had also gone to the feast.
46 So Jesus came again to Cana in Galilee.
That was where he had turned the water into wine.
There was a royal official in Capernaum.
His son was sick.

47 The official heard that Jesus had come from Judea to Galilee.
So he went to Jesus.
He begged him to come down and heal his son,
because his son was about to die.
48 Jesus said to him,
"Unless you people see signs and wonders, you will never believe."
49 The royal official said to him,
"Sir, come down before my child dies."
50 Jesus said to him,
"Go home. Your son lives."
The man believed what Jesus said to him, and he went on his way.
51 While he was still on his way down, his servants met him.
They told him, "Your child lives!"
52 So he asked them at what time the boy had started to get better.
They said to him,
"Yesterday at the seventh hour, the fever left him."
53 Then the father knew:
That was the very hour when Jesus had said to him,
"Your son lives."
So he believed, and so did everyone in his house.
54 This was the second sign that Jesus did after he came from Judea to Galilee.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A "royal official" probably served at the court of Herod Antipas. He was a powerful man. But as a father he is helpless.

Cana lies in the hills, Capernaum down by the Sea of Galilee. The way was about 15 to 20 miles (25 to 30 kilometers) long.

Verse 48: Jesus wants faith that does not depend only on miracles.

Verse 50: The man believes Jesus' word without seeing anything. He sets off with only the promise in his heart.

Verse 52: The seventh hour is about 1 in the afternoon.

Verse 54: John counts the signs: The first was the wedding at Cana, now the second.

Important: Not every sick child gets well. That has nothing to do with the parents having too little faith. Bereaved parents can find help, for example from The Compassionate Friends (compassionatefriends.org in the US, tcf.org.uk in the UK). In a crisis: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123.

JOHN

CHAPTER 5

The Father and the Son

The healing at the pool of Bethesda VERSES 1–18

1 After this, there was a feast of the Jews.
Jesus went up to Jerusalem.
2 In Jerusalem, near the Sheep Gate, there is a pool.
In Hebrew it is called "Bethesda."
It has five covered porches.
3 Many sick people were lying in these porches.
Some were blind. Some could not walk. Some were paralyzed.
They were waiting for the water to move.
4 At certain times an angel went down into the pool and stirred up the water.
After the water was stirred up, the first one to step in was healed of any disease he had.
5 A man was there who had been sick for 38 years.
6 Jesus saw him lying there.
He knew that the man had been sick for a long time.
He asked him, "Do you want to be made well?"
7 The sick man answered him,
"Sir, I have no one to put me into the pool when the water is stirred up.
While I am trying to get there, someone else steps down ahead of me."
8 Jesus said to him,
"Get up, pick up your mat, and walk."
9 At once the man was well.
He picked up his mat and walked.
That day was a Sabbath.
10 So the Jews said to the man who had been healed,
"It is the Sabbath.
The law does not allow you to carry your mat."
11 He answered them,
"The man who made me well told me, 'Pick up your mat and walk.'"
12 They asked him,
"Who is the man who told you, 'Pick up your mat and walk'?"
13 But the man who had been healed didn't know who it was.
There was a crowd in that place, and Jesus had slipped away.
14 Later Jesus found him in the temple.
He said to him,
"Look, you have been made well.
Don't sin anymore, so that nothing worse happens to you."
15 The man went away.
He told the Jews that it was Jesus who had made him well.
16 Jesus was doing these things on the Sabbath.
That is why the Jews persecuted Jesus and tried to kill him.
17 But Jesus answered them,
"My Father is still working.
So I am working too."
18 So the Jews tried even harder to kill him.
He was not only breaking the Sabbath.
He was also calling God his own Father.
In this way, he was making himself equal with God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The pool of Bethesda was in the north of Jerusalem, near the temple. Archaeologists have found the remains of a large pool complex there. Instead of "Bethesda" some manuscripts have "Bethzatha" or "Bethsaida."

Verses 3–4: The words about waiting for the moving of the water and the whole of verse 4 with the angel are missing in the oldest manuscripts. The WEB has them. They explain what people believed back then.

Verse 6: "Do you want to be made well?" Jesus asks the man. He respects his will.

Verse 7: "I have no one." The man is not only sick, but also lonely. No one helps him. To this day that is the need of many sick and old people.

Verse 10: On the Sabbath one was not to carry loads (Jeremiah 17:21). The question is meant seriously. Devout Jews wanted to keep the commandment faithfully.

Verse 14: "Don't sin anymore" does not mean that the illness was a punishment for sin. In John 9:3 Jesus says explicitly that illness is not a punishment. Here Jesus is calling the man to a new life.

Important: Illness and disability are not a punishment from God.

Verses 10–18: "The Jews" here means certain leaders in Jerusalem, not the Jewish people. The healed man, Jesus and his disciples are Jews too. These verses must never be used to accuse Jews. The church teaches clearly: The Jewish people bear no guilt for Jesus' death (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965).

Verse 17: Jesus says: God never stops doing good, not even on the Sabbath. That is why Jesus also heals on the Sabbath.

The Son does what the Father does VERSES 19–30

19 So Jesus answered them,
"I tell you the truth:
The Son can do nothing by himself.
He can only do what he sees the Father doing.
Whatever the Father does, the Son does too.
20 The Father loves the Son.
He shows him everything he himself does.
And he will show him even greater works than these.
Then you will be amazed.
21 The Father raises the dead and gives them life.
In the same way, the Son gives life to anyone he wants to.
22 The Father judges no one.
He has given all judging to the Son.
23 Then everyone will honor the Son, just as they honor the Father.
Whoever doesn't honor the Son doesn't honor the Father who sent him.
24 "I tell you the truth:
Whoever hears my word and believes the one who sent me has eternal life.
He will not be judged.
He has already passed from death into life.
25 I tell you the truth:
The hour is coming, and it is already here,
when the dead will hear the voice of the Son of God.
And those who hear it will live.
26 The Father has life in himself.
In the same way, he has let the Son have life in himself too.
27 He has also given him the power to judge, because he is a son of man.
28 Don't be surprised at this.
The hour is coming when all who are in the tombs will hear his voice.
29 They will come out.
Those who have done good will rise to life.
Those who have done evil will rise to be judged.
30 I can do nothing by myself.
I judge as I hear.
And my judging is fair,
because I don't look for what I want.
I look for what my Father wants, who sent me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus explains his close bond with God the Father. The Son does nothing alone, but always together with the Father, like a son who learns from his father.

Christians believe: Jesus is God's Son and one with the Father. That is the reason for the dispute in this chapter.

Verse 24: Whoever trusts Jesus already shares in eternal life now. It does not begin only after death.

Verse 27: "Son of man": Because Jesus himself became human, he knows people. That is why he may judge. Judgment is in the hands of someone who understands us.

Verse 29: At the end there will be a resurrection of all the dead. Many Jews back then also believed this, for example the Pharisees (compare Daniel 12:2).

Important: No person may presume to judge the eternal destiny of others. Judgment belongs to God alone.

Witnesses for Jesus VERSES 31–47

31 "If I speak for myself, what I say is not valid.
32 But there is someone else who speaks for me.
And I know that what he says about me is true.
33 You sent messengers to John.
And he told the truth.
34 But I don't accept the word of a human being about me.
I am saying these things so that you can be saved.
35 John was a lamp that burned and gave light.
For a while you were happy to enjoy his light.
36 But I have a witness that is greater than John.
The Father gave me works to finish.
These works that I am doing speak for me.
They show that the Father has sent me.
37 And the Father who sent me has spoken for me himself.
You have never heard his voice.
You have never seen what he looks like.
38 And his word does not live in you,
because you don't believe the one he sent.
39 "You study the Scriptures,
because you think that they give you eternal life.
And the Scriptures are the very ones that speak about me.
40 But you don't want to come to me to have life.
41 I don't accept honor from people.
42 But I know you.
I know that you don't have God's love in you.
43 I have come in my Father's name, and you don't accept me.

If someone else comes in his own name, you will
accept him.
44 You accept honor from each other.
But you don't look for the honor that comes from the
only God.
So how can you believe?
45 "Don't think that I will accuse you in front of the
Father.
Someone else accuses you: Moses.
And you have put your hope in him.
46 If you believed Moses, you would believe me,
because he wrote about me.
47 But if you don't believe what he wrote,
how will you believe what I say?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

According to the law of Moses, at least two witnesses were needed (Deuteronomy 19:15). Jesus names several: John the Baptizer, his own works, the Father himself and the Holy Scriptures.

Verse 39: Studying the Holy Scriptures was and is very important in Judaism. Jesus does not say that this is wrong. He says: The Scriptures point to me.

Verse 42: The WEB says "God's love." This probably means: love for God. It can also be understood as God's own love.

Verses 45–46: For Jesus, Moses is a witness, not an opponent. Jesus stands fully in the tradition of the Holy Scriptures of Israel.

Important: These harsh words are aimed at certain opponents in a debate. They are not a judgment on the Jewish people or on Jewish people today.

For today: Whoever reads the Bible should not only gather knowledge, but meet God.

JOHN

CHAPTER 6

The bread of life

Jesus feeds 5,000 people VERSES 1–15

1 After this, Jesus went away to the other side of the Sea
of Galilee.
It is also called the Sea of Tiberias.
2 A large crowd followed him.
They had seen the signs he did by healing sick people.
3 Jesus went up on the mountain.
He sat down there with his disciples.
4 It was almost time for the Passover, the feast of the
Jews.
5 Jesus looked up.
He saw a large crowd coming toward him.
He said to Philip,
"Where can we buy bread, so that these people can
eat?"
6 He said this to test Philip.
He himself already knew what he was going to do.
7 Philip answered him,
"Bread for 200 denarii would not be enough for them.
Each one would not even get a little."
8 One of his disciples spoke to him.
It was Andrew, the brother of Simon Peter.
9 He said,
"There is a boy here who has five barley loaves and two
fish.
But what is that for so many people?"
10 Jesus said, "Have the people sit down."
There was a lot of grass in that place.
So the people sat down.
There were about 5,000 men.
11 Jesus took the loaves and gave thanks.
He gave the bread to the disciples.
And the disciples gave it to the people who were sitting
there.
He did the same with the fish.
Everyone got as much as they wanted.
12 When they were full, he said to his disciples,
"Gather up the pieces that are left over, so that nothing
is lost."
13 So they gathered them up.
They filled 12 baskets with the pieces of the five barley
loaves.
These pieces were left over by the people who had
eaten.
14 The people saw the sign that Jesus had done.
They said, "He really is the prophet who is to come into
the world."
15 Jesus knew that they were about to come and take him
by force to make him king.
So he went back up on the mountain by himself.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Sea of Galilee was also named after the city of Tiberias, which Herod Antipas had built there.

Verse 4: Once again Passover is coming soon. The feeding is a reminder of the manna with which God fed Israel in the wilderness (Exodus 16).

Verse 7: 200 denarii were the wages for more than half a year of work.

Verse 9: Barley bread was the bread of poor people. A boy gives the little he has. Out of it Jesus makes enough for everyone.

Verse 11: The words about handing the bread to the disciples, and the disciples to the people, are missing in the oldest manuscripts. There Jesus hands it out himself.

Verse 12: "So that nothing is lost": God takes care with his gifts.

Verse 14: "The prophet" is the prophet like Moses whom God had promised (Deuteronomy 18:15).

Verse 15: Jesus does not want to be a king put in place by force. His kingdom is different.

For today: Whoever shares finds that there is enough for everyone.

Jesus walks on the water VERSES 16–21

16 When evening came, his disciples went down to the lake.
17 They got into the boat.
They started across the lake to Capernaum.
It was already dark, and Jesus had not yet come to them.
18 A strong wind was blowing.
The water became rough.
19 They had rowed about 3 or 3½ miles.
Then they saw Jesus walking on the water.
He was coming near the boat.
They were afraid.
20 But he said to them,
"It is I. Don't be afraid."
21 Then they were glad to take him into the boat.
And right away the boat reached the shore where they were going.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

25 or 30 stadia are about 3 to 3½ miles (5 to 6 kilometers). The disciples were in the middle of the lake.

Verse 20: "It is I" is in Greek simply "I am." That is how God names himself in the Bible (Exodus 3:14). John is hinting: In Jesus we meet God.

In the Bible only God rules over the sea (Psalm 77:19, in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 77:20).

For today: Even in darkness and storm Jesus says: "Don't be afraid."

Jesus is the bread of life VERSES 22–59

22 The next day, the crowd was still on the other side of the lake.
They saw that only one boat had been there.
They knew that Jesus had not gotten into that boat with his disciples.
His disciples had left alone.
23 But some boats from Tiberias came near the place where they had eaten the bread after the Lord gave thanks.
24 The crowd saw that Jesus was not there.
His disciples were not there either.
So the people got into the boats themselves.
They went to Capernaum to look for Jesus.
25 They found him on the other side of the lake.
They asked him, "Rabbi, when did you get here?"
26 Jesus answered them,
"I tell you the truth:
You are looking for me, but not because you saw signs.
You are looking for me because you ate the bread and got full.
27 Don't work for food that spoils.
Work for the food that lasts for eternal life.
The Son of Man will give you this food.
God the Father has put his seal on him."
That means: God has shown that the Son comes from him.
28 Then they asked him,
"What must we do to do the works of God?"
29 Jesus answered them,
"This is the work of God:
that you believe in the one he has sent."
30 So they said to him,
"Then what sign will you do, so that we can see it and believe you?
What will you do?
31 Our ancestors ate the manna in the wilderness.
The Scriptures say, 'He gave them bread from heaven to eat.'"
32 Jesus said to them,
"I tell you the truth:
It was not Moses who gave you the bread from heaven.
My Father is giving you the true bread from heaven.
33 The bread of God is the one who comes down from heaven.
He gives life to the world."
34 Then they said to him,
"Lord, give us this bread always."
35 Jesus said to them,
"I am the bread of life.
Whoever comes to me will not be hungry.
Whoever believes in me will never be thirsty.
36 But I told you: You have seen me, and still you don't believe.
37 Everyone the Father gives me will come to me.
And I will never send away anyone who comes to me.
38 I have come down from heaven.
I did not come to do what I want.
I came to do what the one who sent me wants.
39 This is what my Father, who sent me, wants:
I should not lose anyone he has given me.
I should raise them up on the last day.
40 This is what the one who sent me wants:
Everyone who sees the Son and believes in him should have eternal life.
And I will raise him up on the last day."
41 Then the Jews grumbled about Jesus,
because he said, "I am the bread that came down from heaven."
42 They said,
"Isn't this Jesus, the son of Joseph?
We know his father and mother.
So how can he say, 'I have come down from heaven'?"
43 Jesus answered them,
"Stop grumbling among yourselves.
44 No one can come to me unless the Father who sent me draws him to me.
And I will raise him up on the last day.
45 The prophets wrote, 'They will all be taught by God.'
Everyone who listens to the Father and learns from him comes to me.
46 That doesn't mean that anyone has seen the Father.
Only the one who is from God has seen the Father.
47 I tell you the truth:
Whoever believes in me has eternal life.
48 I am the bread of life.
49 Your ancestors ate the manna in the wilderness, and they died.
50 But here is the bread that comes down from heaven.
Anyone can eat it and not die.

51 I am the living bread that came down from heaven.
Whoever eats this bread will live forever.
The bread I will give is my flesh.
I will give it for the life of the world."
52 Then the Jews argued with each other.
They said, "How can this man give us his flesh to eat?"
53 Jesus said to them,
"I tell you the truth:
You must eat the flesh of the Son of Man and drink his blood.
If you don't, you have no life in you.
54 Whoever eats my flesh and drinks my blood has eternal life.
And I will raise him up on the last day.
55 My flesh is real food.
My blood is real drink.
56 Whoever eats my flesh and drinks my blood lives in me, and I live in him.
57 The living Father sent me, and I live because of the Father.
In the same way, whoever feeds on me will live because of me.
58 This is the bread that came down from heaven.
It is not like the manna our ancestors ate.
They died.
But whoever eats this bread will live forever."
59 Jesus said these things while he was teaching in the synagogue in Capernaum.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 26–27: The people are looking for Jesus because they got full. Jesus wants to give them more: food for the soul.

Verse 29: The most important "work" is to trust God.

Verse 31 quotes Psalm 78:24. The manna was a gift from God in the wilderness.

Verse 35: "I am the bread of life" is the first of the seven great "I am" sayings in John. As bread feeds the body, so Jesus feeds the whole of life.

Verse 37: "I will never send away anyone who comes to me." A great comfort: No one is turned away.

Verses 41 and 52: "The Jews" here means listeners in the synagogue of Capernaum who are discussing with Jesus. Their questions are understandable. The word "grumble" is a reminder of Israel in the wilderness (Exodus 16:2).
Important: This is not a judgment on the Jewish people. Jesus and all the disciples were Jews too.

Verse 45 quotes Isaiah 54:13.

Verse 47: The words "in me" are missing in the oldest manuscripts. There it simply says that whoever believes has eternal life.

Verses 51–58: These words are hard to understand. Many Christians relate them to the Lord's Supper (Eucharist). Catholic, Orthodox and Lutheran Christians see in them a sign that Christ is truly present in the bread and wine. Other Protestant Christians understand it more spiritually: taking Jesus fully into yourself in faith.

Important: The picture of "drinking blood" was offensive to Jewish listeners, because eating blood was forbidden (Leviticus 17:10–14). That is why an argument arises.

Many go away, Peter stays VERSES 60–71

60 Many of his disciples heard this.
They said, "This teaching is hard! Who can listen to it?"
61 Jesus knew that his disciples were grumbling about this.
He said to them,
"Does this make you stumble?
62 Then what if you saw the Son of Man going up to where he was before?
63 The Spirit is the one who gives life.
The flesh is of no use.
The words I have spoken to you are spirit, and they are life.
64 But some of you don't believe."
From the beginning, Jesus knew which of them didn't believe.
He also knew who would betray him.
65 He said,
"That is why I told you that no one can come to me unless my Father gives it to him."
66 After this, many of his disciples turned back.
They didn't go along with him anymore.
67 So Jesus said to the Twelve,
"You don't want to go away too, do you?"
68 Simon Peter answered him,
"Lord, to whom would we go?
You have the words of eternal life.
69 We have come to believe and to know that you are the Christ, the Son of the living God."
70 Jesus answered them,
"Didn't I choose you, the Twelve?
And yet one of you is a devil."
71 He meant Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot.
Judas was one of the Twelve, and he would betray Jesus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 60: Many disciples, too, find Jesus' words too hard. Believing is not always easy.

Verse 63: Jesus says: His words should not be understood only in a literal, bodily way. God's Spirit gives life.

Verse 66: Many go away. Jesus lets them go. He forces no one.

Verses 68–69: Peter answers for the Twelve. His words are a confession of trust, even if he does not understand everything. Instead of the Christ, the Son of the living God, many old manuscripts have in verse 69: the Holy One of God.

Verses 70–71: "A devil" here means: someone who will work against Jesus. Judas is meant. Jesus chose him anyway and kept him with him.

Important: For centuries the name Judas was misused to insult Jews. That is wrong.

For today: Whoever has doubts may ask with Peter: "Lord, to whom would we go?"

JOHN

CHAPTER 7

Rivers of living water

Jesus and his brothers VERSES 1–13

1 After this, Jesus traveled around in Galilee.
He did not want to travel in Judea,
because the Jews there were trying to kill him.
2 It was almost time for the feast of the Jews called the
Feast of Booths.
3 So his brothers said to him,
"Leave this place and go to Judea.
Then your disciples there can also see the works you
are doing.
4 No one does things in secret if he wants to be known in
public.
If you do these things, show yourself to the world."
5 Even his brothers didn't believe in him.
6 So Jesus said to them,
"My time has not come yet.
But for you, any time is right.
7 The world can't hate you.
But it hates me,
because I say openly that the things it does are evil.
8 You go up to the feast.
I am not yet going up to this feast,
because my time has not fully come yet."
9 After he said this to them, he stayed in Galilee.
10 But after his brothers had gone up to the feast, Jesus
went up too.
He did not go openly.
He went almost in secret.
11 At the feast the Jews were looking for him.
They asked, "Where is he?"
12 Many people in the crowds were whispering about him.
Some said, "He is a good man."
Others said, "No, he leads the people the wrong way."
13 But no one spoke openly about him for fear of the Jews.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Feast of Booths (in Hebrew "Sukkot") is a great Jewish autumn feast. For a week people live in huts made of branches. This recalls Israel's journey through the wilderness (Leviticus 23:33–43). It is also a harvest thanksgiving feast. Many pilgrims came to Jerusalem.

Verse 5: At first even Jesus' brothers did not believe in him. Later they belonged to the church (Acts 1:14).

Verse 8: The text above says "I am not yet going up." Many old manuscripts have only "not" instead of "not yet."

Verses 1, 11 and 13: Important: Here it becomes especially clear that "the Jews" in John does not mean the Jewish people. The people in the crowd are Jews themselves. And yet they speak "for fear of the Jews." Certain powerful leaders in Jerusalem are meant. No one may use these verses against Jews.

Verse 12: Opinions about Jesus are divided. It is the same to this day.

Jesus teaches in the temple VERSES 14–36

14 When the feast was half over, Jesus went up to the
temple and began to teach.
15 The Jews were amazed.
They said, "How does this man know so much?
He has never studied."
16 So Jesus answered them,
"My teaching is not my own.
It comes from the one who sent me.
17 Anyone who wants to do God's will
will know whether my teaching comes from God,
or whether I am speaking on my own.
18 Whoever speaks on his own is looking for honor for
himself.
But someone may look for honor for the one who sent
him.
That person is true.
There is nothing wrong in him.
19 Didn't Moses give you the law?
Yet none of you keeps the law.
Why are you trying to kill me?"
20 The crowd answered,
"You have a demon!
Who is trying to kill you?"
21 Jesus answered them,
"I did one work, and you are all amazed by it.
22 Moses gave you circumcision.
It did not really start with Moses, but with your
ancestors before him.
And you circumcise a boy even on the Sabbath.
23 A boy is circumcised on the Sabbath, so that the law of
Moses is not broken.
So why are you angry with me
because I made a man completely well on the Sabbath?
24 Stop judging by what you see on the outside.
Judge in a fair and right way."
25 Then some of the people from Jerusalem said,
"Isn't this the man they are trying to kill?
26 Look, he is speaking openly, and they say nothing to
him.
Could the rulers really know that he is the Christ?
27 But we know where this man comes from.
When the Christ comes, no one will know where he
comes from."
28 So Jesus called out while he was teaching in the temple.
He said,
"You know me, and you know where I come from.
I have not come on my own.
The one who sent me is true.
But you don't know him.
29 I know him,
because I come from him.
And he sent me."
30 Then they tried to arrest him.
But no one laid a hand on him,
because his hour had not come yet.
31 But many people in the crowd believed in him.
They said,
"When the Christ comes, he won't do more signs than
this man has done, will he?"
32 The Pharisees heard the crowd whispering these things
about him.
So the chief priests and the Pharisees sent temple
guards to arrest him.
33 Then Jesus said,
"I will be with you only a little while longer.

Then I will go to the one who sent me.
34 You will look for me, but you won't find me.
You can't come where I am."
35 So the Jews said to each other,
"Where is this man going that we won't find him?
Will he go to our people who live scattered among the Greeks?
Will he teach the Greeks?
36 What does he mean when he says,
'You will look for me, but you won't find me,'
and 'You can't come where I am'?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: Jesus had not studied with a famous teacher. Even so, he knows the Holy Scriptures very well.

Verses 22–23: Circumcision on the eighth day after birth was so important that it was carried out even on the Sabbath (Leviticus 12:3). Jesus argues like a Jewish teacher: If that is allowed, then all the more so to heal a whole person. He is referring to the healing in chapter 5.

Verse 27: Some people back then believed that no one would know where the Messiah came from until he suddenly appeared.

Verse 31: Many of the people believe in Jesus.

Verse 35: The people "scattered among the Greeks" are called the Dispersion (in Greek "Diaspora"). It means the Jews who lived outside the land of Israel. John is hinting: The message will in fact go out into the whole world.

Important: The conversations in this chapter are debates among Jews about the question of who Jesus is. There is agreement and rejection. This is not a judgment on the Jewish people.

"If anyone is thirsty, let him come to me" VERSES 37–44

37 On the last and most important day of the feast, Jesus stood up.
He called out loudly,
"If anyone is thirsty, let him come to me and drink!
38 The Scriptures say this about whoever believes in me:
Rivers of living water will flow from inside him."
39 By this he meant the Spirit.
The people who believed in Jesus would receive the Spirit later.
The Holy Spirit had not yet been given,
because Jesus had not yet been glorified.
40 Many people in the crowd heard these words.
They said, "This man really is the prophet."
41 Others said, "He is the Christ."
But some said,
"What? The Christ doesn't come from Galilee, does he?
42 The Scriptures say that the Christ comes from David's family.
They say that he comes from Bethlehem, the village where David lived."
43 So the crowd was divided because of him.
44 Some of them wanted to arrest him.
But no one laid a hand on him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the Feast of Booths, every day water was brought from the pool of Siloam in a solemn procession and poured out at the altar. People prayed for rain and remembered the promises of the prophets (for example Zechariah 14:8; Ezekiel 47). At exactly this moment Jesus cries out: "If anyone is thirsty, let him come to me and drink!" (7:37).

Verse 38: Which Scripture passage Jesus means is not certain. It is a reminder of Isaiah 58:11 and other passages.

Verse 39: John explains: The Holy Spirit is meant. He is given after Jesus' death and resurrection.

Verses 41–42: The people do not know that Jesus was born in Bethlehem (Matthew 2; Luke 2). John tells this with a quiet smile: The readers know more.

Verse 42 refers to Micah 5:2 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 5:1).

For today: Jesus quenches the deepest thirst of human beings: the longing for life, meaning and love.

Nicodemus stands up for Jesus VERSES 45–53

45 Then the temple guards went back to the chief priests and Pharisees.
These asked them, "Why didn't you bring him?"
46 The guards answered,
"No one has ever spoken like this man!"
47 The Pharisees answered them,
"You haven't been fooled too, have you?
48 Have any of the rulers or any of the Pharisees believed in him?
49 But this crowd doesn't know the law.
They are under a curse."
50 Nicodemus was one of them.
He was the one who had come to Jesus at night.
He said to them,
51 "Our law does not judge a man without first hearing him.
It wants to know what he has done, doesn't it?"
52 They answered him,
"Are you from Galilee too?
Search, and you will see:
No prophet has ever come from Galilee."
53 Then everyone went home.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 46: Even the temple guards are impressed by Jesus.

Verse 49: Some leaders look down on the ordinary people. That is a harsh, arrogant statement. Jesus, on the other hand, turns especially to ordinary people.

Verses 50–51: Nicodemus, a Pharisee and leader, stands up for a fair process. He appeals to the law of Moses (Deuteronomy 1:16–17). This shows: Among the Pharisees and leaders there were different opinions.

Verse 52: That is not quite true: The prophet Jonah came from Galilee (2 Kings 14:25). The opponents are speaking in anger.

Verse 53: With this verse begins the story of the woman caught in adultery (John 7:53–8:11). It is missing in the oldest and in many other old manuscripts. In some manuscripts it stands in a different place. The WEB has it here. More about this in the next chapter.

For today: Before you judge someone, you should listen to them yourself.

Chapter 8

The light of the world

Jesus and the woman caught in adultery VERSES 1–11

1 But Jesus went to the Mount of Olives.
2 Very early the next morning, he came back to the temple.
All the people came to him.
He sat down and taught them.
3 Then the scribes and the Pharisees brought a woman to him.
She had been caught in adultery.
They made her stand in the middle of everyone.
4 They said to Jesus,
"Teacher, we caught this woman while she was committing adultery.
5 In our law, Moses told us to stone women like her.
So what do you say about her?"
6 They said this to test him.
They wanted a reason to accuse him.
But Jesus bent down.
He wrote on the ground with his finger.
7 They kept on asking him.
So he looked up and said to them,
"Whoever among you has never sinned
may throw the first stone at her."
8 Then he bent down again.
He wrote on the ground with his finger.
9 They heard what he said.
Their conscience told them that they were guilty too.
So they left, one by one.
The oldest ones left first, and then all the rest.
Only Jesus was left, with the woman still standing in the middle.
10 Jesus stood up and looked at her.
He said to her,
"Woman, where are the people who accused you?
Didn't anyone condemn you?"
11 She said, "No one, Lord."
Jesus said,
"I don't condemn you either.
You may go.
From now on, stop sinning."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This story (7:53–8:11) is missing in the oldest manuscripts of the Gospel of John. In some manuscripts it stands in another place, for example after Luke 21:38. Many scholars think: It is an old, genuine tradition about Jesus that was only later put here. The churches read it as part of the Bible.

According to the law of Moses, in a case of adultery both were to die, the man and the woman (Leviticus 20:10; Deuteronomy 22:22). Here only the woman is brought. Where is the man? That shows the injustice.

The question is a trap: If Jesus says to stone her, he goes against his own mercy, and only the Romans were allowed to carry out death sentences. If he says to let her go, he can be accused of disregarding the law.

We do not know what Jesus wrote on the ground.

Verse 7: "Whoever among you has never sinned may throw the first stone at her." No one is without sin. That is why no one has the right to judge others like this.

Verse 11: Jesus does not condemn the woman. He does not pretend there was no wrong, but he gives her a new start.

Important: This story is a strong word against violence toward women and against people taking justice into their own hands. In later Judaism, too, the death penalty was very strongly restricted.

For today: Whoever points a finger at others should first look at themselves. Whoever experiences violence can find help. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

"I am the light of the world" VERSES 12–20

12 Jesus spoke to the people again.
He said,
"I am the light of the world.
Whoever follows me will not walk in the dark.
He will have the light that gives life."
13 So the Pharisees said to him,
"You are speaking as a witness for yourself.
So what you say does not count."
14 Jesus answered them,
"Even if I speak as a witness for myself, what I say is true.
I know where I came from, and I know where I am going.
But you don't know where I came from or where I am going.
15 You judge the way humans judge.
I don't judge anyone.
16 But even if I do judge, my judging is true.
I am not alone.
The Father who sent me is with me.
17 Your own law says that when two people say the same thing, it counts as true.
18 I am one witness for myself.
And the Father who sent me is a witness for me too."
19 Then they asked him, "Where is your Father?"
Jesus answered,
"You don't know me, and you don't know my Father.
If you knew me, you would know my Father too."
20 Jesus said these words while he was teaching in the temple, in the area where the offering boxes were.
But no one arrested him,
because his hour had not come yet.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At the Feast of Booths, large lamps were lit in the temple that lit up all of Jerusalem. Here Jesus says: "I am the light of the world." That is the second of the "I am" sayings.

In the Bible "light" is a picture for God and for life (Psalm 27:1). Whoever follows Jesus finds the way even in the dark.

Verse 17: The law requires two witnesses (Deuteronomy 19:15). "Your law" sounds distant, but Jesus himself lived

by this law. John is writing here from the point of view of a later time.

Verse 20: The area with the offering boxes (the WEB calls it "the treasury") was in the Court of the Women.

"Where I go, you can't come" VERSES 21–30

21 Jesus spoke to them again.
He said,
"I am going away.
You will look for me.
But you will die in your sins.
You can't come to the place where I am going."
22 So the Jews said,
"He says, 'You can't come to the place where I am going.'
Is he going to kill himself?"
23 Jesus said to them,
"You come from below.
I come from above.
You belong to this world.
I don't belong to this world.
24 That is why I told you that you will die in your sins.
If you don't believe that I am he, you will die in your sins."
25 So they asked him, "Who are you?"
Jesus said to them,
"I am the one I have been telling you about from the start.
26 I have many things to say about you and to judge.
But the one who sent me is true.
And I tell the world what I have heard from him."
27 They didn't understand that he was talking to them about the Father.
28 So Jesus said to them,
"You will lift up the Son of Man.
Then you will know that I am he.
You will know that I do nothing on my own.
I say only what my Father taught me.
29 The one who sent me is with me.
The Father has not left me alone,
because I always do what pleases him."
30 While Jesus was saying these things, many believed in him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 24 and 28: "That I am he" literally means "that I am." It is a reminder of God's name (Exodus 3:14).

Verse 28: "Lift up" means the crucifixion. On the cross it becomes visible who Jesus is.

Verse 22: In Judaism, taking one's own life was seen as a grave sin. The question shows that the listeners do not understand.

Important: Whoever is thinking about suicide is not alone. Help is available day and night: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 30: Many believe in Jesus. The conversation continues with people who at first believed him.

IMPORTANT NOTE BEFORE THE NEXT SECTION

The following verses (8:31–59) contain some of the harshest words in the whole New Testament, especially verse 44: "Your father is the devil, and you belong to him." For centuries this sentence was misused to slander Jews as children of the devil. That led to hatred, persecution and murder, all the way to the Holocaust. That is grave guilt on the part of Christians.

You need to know: Here Jews are arguing with Jews. Jesus is a Jew. He is speaking to a certain group in a certain, very heated argument. He is not speaking about the Jewish people. In the same Gospel Jesus says that "salvation is from the Jews" (4:22).

Sharp words were common in debates back then, also among Jewish groups themselves. They describe behavior (lying and wanting to kill), not descent.

Today the churches teach clearly: The Jewish people are loved by God. God has never canceled his covenant with Israel (Romans 11:1–2,29). Hostility toward Jews is sin.

The truth will make you free VERSES 31–47

31 Some of the Jews had started to believe him.
Jesus said to them,
"If you keep holding on to what I say, then you really are my disciples.
32 You will know the truth.
And the truth will make you free."
33 They answered him,
"We are Abraham's descendants.
We have never been anyone's slaves.
So how can you say, 'You will be made free'?"
34 Jesus answered them,
"I tell you the truth:
Everyone who sins is a slave of sin.
35 A slave does not stay in the family's house forever.
A son stays forever.
36 So if the Son makes you free, you will really be free.
37 I know that you are Abraham's descendants.
But you are trying to kill me,
because there is no room in you for what I say.
38 I tell you what I have seen with my Father.
And you do what you have seen with your father."
39 They answered him, "Abraham is our father."
Jesus said to them,
"If you were Abraham's children, you would do what Abraham did.
40 But now you are trying to kill me.
I am a man who has told you the truth that I heard from God.
Abraham did not do things like that.
41 You are doing what your own father does."
They said to him,
"We were not born from sexual sin.
We have one Father: God."
42 Jesus said to them,
"If God were your Father, you would love me.
I came from God, and now I am here.
I did not come on my own.
He sent me.
43 Why don't you understand what I am saying?
It is because you are not able to listen to my words.

44 Your father is the devil, and you belong to him.
You want to do what your father wants.
He was a murderer from the beginning.
He does not hold on to the truth,
because there is no truth in him.
When he lies, he is doing what comes naturally to him.
He is a liar, and lies come from him.
He is the father of lies.
45 But I tell the truth.
That is why you don't believe me.
46 Can any of you prove that I have sinned?
If I tell the truth, why don't you believe me?
47 Whoever belongs to God listens to God's words.
You don't listen,
because you don't belong to God."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 31–32: "The truth will make you free" is one of the best-known sentences of the Bible. What is meant is: Whoever trusts Jesus becomes free from the power of sin.

Verse 33: Israel had often been oppressed (in Egypt, in Babylon, now under Rome). But the listeners mean inner freedom: As children of Abraham they are God's free people.

Verses 39–41: It is about the question: Who is a true child of Abraham and of God? Jesus says: That shows in how you act, not only in your descent. The prophets of Israel said this too.

Verse 41: "Not born from sexual sin" is perhaps a hint at rumors about Jesus' birth.

Verse 44: Please read the note before this section. Here Jesus describes the behavior of people who want to kill him: Killing and lying come from evil. That applies to every person who acts like that, whatever their background. No people and no religion is "of the devil."

For today: Truth sets free. Lies and hatred make people unfree, Christians too.

Before Abraham was, I AM VERSES 48–59

48 Then the Jews answered him,
"Aren't we right when we say that you are a Samaritan and have a demon?"
49 Jesus answered,
"I don't have a demon.
I honor my Father.
But you dishonor me.
50 I am not looking for honor for myself.
But there is someone who is looking for it.
He is the judge.
51 I tell you the truth:
Whoever holds on to my word will never see death."
52 Then the Jews said to him,
"Now we know that you have a demon!
Abraham died.
The prophets died too.
And you say, 'Whoever holds on to my word will never taste death.'
53 Are you greater than our father Abraham?
He died.
The prophets died.
Who do you think you are?"
54 Jesus answered,
"If I give myself honor, my honor means nothing.
My Father is the one who gives me honor.
You say that he is your God.
55 But you have not known him.
I know him.
If I said, 'I don't know him,' I would be a liar like you.
But I do know him, and I hold on to his word.
56 Your father Abraham was full of joy at the thought of seeing my day.
He saw it and was glad."
57 So the Jews said to him,
"You are not even 50 years old!
And you have seen Abraham?"
58 Jesus said to them,
"I tell you the truth:
Before Abraham was born, I AM."
59 Then they picked up stones to throw at him.
But Jesus hid himself.
He went out of the temple.
He walked right through the middle of them and went on his way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 48: Back then "Samaritan" was an insult for someone who strays from the true faith. Jesus is insulted here too. The argument is carried on with harsh words from both sides.

Verse 56: Abraham believed God's promise. Jesus says: Abraham looked forward with joy to what God would do through Jesus.

Verse 58: "I AM" is God's name from Exodus 3:14. Jesus says: I was there before Abraham, I belong to God. To the listeners that sounded like blasphemy. That is why they pick up stones (compare Leviticus 24:16). Blasphemy means: speaking against God.

Verse 59: The words about going through the middle of them are missing in the oldest manuscripts. The WEB has them.

Important: The opponents here are a certain group in the temple, not "the Jews" as a whole. Just a few verses earlier it says: "many believed in him" (verse 30). No Christian may use these verses against Jewish people.

JOHN

CHAPTER 9

"I was blind, but now I can see"

Jesus heals a man who was born blind VERSES 1–12

1 As Jesus walked along, he saw a man who had been blind since he was born.
2 His disciples asked him,
"Rabbi, why was this man born blind?
Who sinned, this man or his parents?"

3 Jesus answered,
"This man didn't sin, and his parents didn't sin either.
It happened so that God's works could be seen in him.
4 While it is day, I must do the works of the one who sent me.
Night is coming.
Then no one can work.
5 While I am in the world, I am the light of the world."
6 After he said this, he spit on the ground.
He made mud with the spit.
He spread the mud on the blind man's eyes.
7 He said to him,
"Go and wash in the pool of Siloam."
Siloam means: Sent.
So the man went and washed.
When he came back, he could see.
8 His neighbors had seen him before, when he was blind.
They said,
"Isn't this the man who used to sit and beg?"
9 Some said, "It is him."
Others said, "He looks like him."
The man himself said, "I am he."
10 So they asked him,
"How were your eyes opened?"
11 He answered,
"A man called Jesus made mud.
He spread it on my eyes.
He told me, 'Go to the pool of Siloam and wash.'
So I went and washed, and now I can see."
12 They asked him, "Where is he?"
He said, "I don't know."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: Back then many people thought: Whoever is sick or disabled is being punished for a sin, perhaps even for the sin of the parents.

Verse 3: Jesus says very clearly: No! Neither the man nor his parents are to blame. Illness and disability are not a punishment from God. This is one of the most important sentences in the Bible on this subject.

Important: People with disabilities are loved by God and have full dignity, whether they are healed or not.

Verse 4: Instead of "I must," many old manuscripts have "We must."

Verse 6: Back then saliva was thought to have healing power. Jesus touches the man and uses simple things.

Verse 7: The pool of Siloam was in the south of Jerusalem. Archaeologists have found the remains of a large pool there. John explains the name: "Sent." Jesus is the one sent by God.

Verse 9: "I am he": The man stands by who he is and by what has happened to him.

The Pharisees question the man who was healed

VERSES 13–34

13 They brought the man who had been blind to the Pharisees.
14 Jesus had made the mud and opened the man's eyes on a Sabbath day.
15 So the Pharisees also asked him how he had become able to see.
He told them,
"He put mud on my eyes.
I washed, and now I can see."
16 Some of the Pharisees said,
"This man is not from God,
because he doesn't keep the Sabbath."
Others said,
"How can a sinner do signs like these?"
So they did not agree with each other.
17 Then they asked the blind man again,
"He opened your eyes.
What do you say about him?"
The man said, "He is a prophet."
18 The Jews did not believe that the man had been blind and could now see.
So they called his parents.
19 They asked them,
"Is this your son?
You say that he was born blind.
So how is it that he can see now?"
20 His parents answered them,
"We know that this is our son.
And we know that he was born blind.
21 But we don't know how he can see now.
And we don't know who opened his eyes.
He is old enough.
Ask him.
He can speak for himself."
22 His parents said this because they were afraid of the Jews.
The Jews had already decided something:
Anyone who said that Jesus is the Christ would be put out of the synagogue.
23 That is why his parents said,
"He is old enough. Ask him."
24 So for the second time they called the man who had been blind.
They said to him,
"Give honor to God.
We know that this man is a sinner."
25 He answered,
"I don't know if he is a sinner.
I know one thing:
I was blind,
but now I can see."
26 They asked him again,
"What did he do to you?
How did he open your eyes?"
27 He answered them,
"I already told you, and you didn't listen.
Why do you want to hear it again?
You don't want to become his disciples too, do you?"
28 Then they insulted him.
They said,
"You are his disciple.
But we are disciples of Moses.
29 We know that God spoke to Moses.
But we don't know where this man comes from."
30 The man answered them,
"That is amazing!
You don't know where he comes from.
And yet he opened my eyes.

31 We know that God doesn't listen to sinners.
But God listens to anyone who worships him and does what he wants.
32 Since the world began, no one has ever heard of anyone who opened the eyes of a person born blind.
33 If this man were not from God, he could do nothing."
34 They answered him,
"You were born completely in sins.
And you want to teach us?"
Then they threw him out.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: On the Sabbath, kneading dough or making mud counted as work. That is why an argument arises.

Verse 16: The Pharisees do not agree with each other. Some are open to Jesus. Luke and John show again and again: There was no such thing as "the" Pharisees.

Verse 22: "Put out of the synagogue": Many scholars think that John is also reflecting here the experience of his own church at the end of the first century. At that time Jewish and Christian communities painfully separated from one another. That is where the harsh language about "the Jews" in this Gospel comes from.

Important: "The Jews" here means certain leaders. The healed man, his parents, Jesus and the disciples are Jews themselves. These verses must not be used against Jewish people.

Verse 25: "I was blind, but now I can see." The man stands by what he has experienced. He grows braver and braver.

Verse 34: The opponents say he was "born in sins." That is exactly what Jesus rejected in verse 3.

For today: Whoever has experienced something with God may tell about it, even if others do not want to believe it.

Who is really blind? VERSES 35–41

35 Jesus heard that they had thrown the man out.
He found him and asked him,
"Do you believe in the Son of God?"
36 The man answered,
"Lord, who is he?
Tell me, so that I can believe in him."
37 Jesus said to him,
"You have seen him.
He is the one who is talking with you now."
38 The man said, "Lord, I believe!"
And he worshiped Jesus.
39 Jesus said,
"I came into this world to judge.
I came so that people who can't see will see,
and so that people who can see will become blind."
40 Some Pharisees who were with him heard this.
They asked him,
"Are we blind too?"
41 Jesus said to them,
"If you were blind, you would not be guilty of sin.
But now you say, 'We can see.'
So your sin stays.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 35: Jesus looks for the man when he has been thrown out. He does not leave him alone. Instead of Son of God, many old manuscripts have Son of Man.

Verse 38: Now the man sees not only with his eyes, but also with his heart.

Verses 39–41: "Blind" and "seeing" are pictures here for knowing God. Whoever thinks they already know everything is blind to anything new.

Important: The word "blind" is a picture here. It does not look down on people who cannot see. Blind people have the same dignity and can believe and know God just as well.

For today: Whoever can admit that they do not see everything is open to God.

JOHN

CHAPTER 10

The good shepherd

The shepherd and the door VERSES 1–10

1 "I tell you the truth:
Someone may not go into the sheep pen through the door.
He may climb in some other way.
That person is a thief and a robber.
2 But the one who goes in through the door is the shepherd of the sheep.
3 The gatekeeper opens the gate for him.
The sheep listen to his voice.
He calls his own sheep by name and leads them out.
4 When he has brought all his own sheep out, he walks ahead of them.
The sheep follow him, because they know his voice.
5 They will never follow a stranger.
They will run away from him,
because they don't know the voice of strangers."
6 Jesus told them this picture story.
But they didn't understand what he was telling them.
7 So Jesus spoke to them again.
He said,
"I tell you the truth:
I am the door for the sheep.
8 All who came before me are thieves and robbers.
But the sheep didn't listen to them.
9 I am the door.
Anyone who comes in through me will be saved.
He will go in and out and find pasture.
10 The thief comes only to steal, to kill, and to destroy.
I came so that they can have life, and have it in abundance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The chapter follows on from the healing of the blind man (chapter 9). Jesus takes care of him like a good shepherd when others throw him out.

Sheep knew the voice of their shepherd. Several flocks often spent the night together in one pen. In the morning each shepherd called his own sheep out.

Verse 3: "He calls his own sheep by name." God knows every person personally.

Verses 7 and 9: "I am the door" is the third "I am" saying. Through Jesus people find the way to God.

Verse 8: "All who came before me" does not mean Moses and the prophets. What is meant is false leaders who took advantage of people.

Verse 10: "Have it in abundance": God wants people to have a full life.

For today: Today too there are "thieves" who take advantage of people, also in the name of religion. You can recognize a good shepherd by the fact that he serves life.

"I am the good shepherd" VERSES 11–21

11 "I am the good shepherd.
The good shepherd gives his life for the sheep.
12 A hired worker is not the shepherd.
The sheep don't belong to him.
So when he sees the wolf coming, he leaves the sheep and runs away.
The wolf grabs the sheep and scatters the flock.
13 The hired worker runs away because he is only paid to do the work.
He doesn't care about the sheep.
14 I am the good shepherd.
I know my sheep, and my sheep know me,
15 just as the Father knows me and I know the Father.
I give my life for the sheep.
16 I have other sheep too.
They are not from this sheep pen.
I must bring them too.
They will listen to my voice.
Then there will be one flock and one shepherd.
17 This is why the Father loves me:
I give my life, so that I can take it back again.
18 No one takes my life from me.
I give it of my own free will.
I have the power to give it.
And I have the power to take it back again.
My Father gave me this command."
19 These words caused the Jews to be divided again.
20 Many of them said,
"He has a demon.
He is out of his mind!
Why do you listen to him?"
21 Others said,
"Someone who has a demon doesn't talk like this.
A demon can't open the eyes of blind people, can it?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"I am the good shepherd" is the fourth "I am" saying. In the Old Testament God himself is the shepherd of his people (Psalm 23; Ezekiel 34). Kings and leaders were also called shepherds.

Verses 11 and 15: Jesus gives his life for his own. This happens on the cross.

Verse 16: "Other sheep" probably means the people from other nations who will come to Jesus. Important: This does not mean that the Jewish people are replaced. It is about belonging together, not about shutting people out.

For today: The churches are different, but Jesus wants all who belong to him to be one. That is a call to unity among Christians.

Verse 18: Jesus goes his way freely. No one can take his life from him unless he gives it himself.

Verses 19–21: "The Jews" here are listeners who do not agree with each other. Many are open to Jesus.

Important: Mental illnesses are not possession. "Out of his mind" was used here as an insult. People with mental illnesses deserve respect and help.

"I and the Father are one" VERSES 22–42

22 Then came the Feast of the Dedication in Jerusalem.
23 It was winter.
Jesus was walking in the temple area, in Solomon's porch.
24 The Jews gathered around him.
They said to him,
"How long will you keep us guessing?
If you are the Christ, tell us clearly."
25 Jesus answered them,
"I told you, and you don't believe.
I do works in my Father's name.
These works speak for me.
26 But you don't believe,
because you are not my sheep.
I already told you that.
27 My sheep listen to my voice.
I know them, and they follow me.
28 I give them eternal life.
They will never be lost.
No one will tear them out of my hand.
29 My Father has given them to me.
He is greater than all.
No one can tear them out of my Father's hand.
30 I and the Father are one."
31 Then the Jews picked up stones again to stone him.
32 Jesus answered them,
"I have shown you many good works from my Father.
For which of these works are you stoning me?"
33 The Jews answered him,
"We are not stoning you for a good work.
We are stoning you because you speak against God.
You are a human being, but you make yourself God."
34 Jesus answered them,
"Your law says, 'I said, you are gods.'
Isn't that so?
35 God called those people gods, the people to whom his word came.
And the Scriptures can't be broken.
36 The Father set me apart as holy and sent me into the world.
So why do you say to me, 'You are speaking against God,'
because I said, 'I am the Son of God'?
37 If I don't do the works of my Father, then don't believe me.
38 But if I do them, believe the works, even if you don't believe me.
Then you will know and understand that the Father is

in me,
and that I am in the Father."
39 Again they tried to grab him.
But he slipped out of their hands.
40 Jesus went away again to the other side of the Jordan.
He went to the place where John had first baptized people.
He stayed there.
41 Many people came to him.
They said,
"John did not do any sign.
But everything John said about this man is true."
42 Many believed in him there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: The Feast of the Dedication is called "Hanukkah" in Hebrew. It remembers how the temple was dedicated again in 164 BC after it had been made unholy. To this day Jews celebrate it in winter by lighting lights.

Verse 23: Solomon's porch was a covered row of columns at the edge of the temple square.

Verses 28–29: A great comfort: No one can tear those who belong to Jesus out of God's hand.

Verse 30: "I and the Father are one." Christians see in this a reason for their faith in the triune God: Father, Son and Holy Spirit are one God.

Verses 31–33: To the opponents this sounds like blasphemy, that is, speaking against God.

According to the law, blasphemy was severely punished (Leviticus 24:16). Their concern for God's honor was serious.

Verse 34 quotes Psalm 82:6. There judges are called "gods," because they judge on God's behalf. Jesus argues like a Jewish teacher.

Verse 35: "The Scriptures can't be broken": Jesus holds the Holy Scriptures of Israel to be valid.

Important: "The Jews" here means opponents in an argument in the temple. It is not a judgment on the Jewish people. At the end of the chapter "many believed in him" (verse 42).

JOHN

CHAPTER 11

"I am the resurrection and the life"

Lazarus is sick VERSES 1–16

1 A man named Lazarus was sick.
He was from Bethany, the village where Mary and her sister Martha lived.
2 This Mary had poured fragrant oil on the Lord and dried his feet with her hair.
Her brother Lazarus was the one who was sick.
3 So the sisters sent a message to Jesus.
They said,
"Lord, look, your dear friend is sick."
4 When Jesus heard this, he said,
"This sickness will not end in death.
It is for God's glory.
Through it, God's Son will be honored."
5 Jesus loved Martha, her sister, and Lazarus.
6 He heard that Lazarus was sick.
But he stayed two more days in the place where he was.
7 After that, he said to the disciples,
"Let's go back to Judea."
8 The disciples said to him,
"Rabbi, the Jews there were trying to stone you just a short time ago.
And you want to go back there?"
9 Jesus answered,
"Doesn't the day have 12 hours of light?
Whoever walks during the day doesn't trip,
because he sees the light of this world.
10 But whoever walks at night trips,
because the light is not in him."
11 He said this.
Then he told them,
"Our friend Lazarus has fallen asleep.
But I am going there to wake him up."
12 The disciples said,
"Lord, if he is sleeping, he will get better."
13 But Jesus had been talking about his death.
They thought he meant normal sleep.
14 So Jesus told them plainly,
"Lazarus is dead.
15 For your sake, I am glad that I was not there.
This will help you to believe.
But let's go to him."
16 Thomas, who was also called Didymus, said to the other disciples,
"Let's go too, so that we can die with Jesus."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bethany was near Jerusalem. The sisters Martha and Mary and their brother Lazarus lived there. They were friends of Jesus.

Verse 2: John already mentions the anointing here, which he only tells in chapter 12.

Verse 3: "Your dear friend": The sisters know how close Jesus and Lazarus are.

Verse 6: Jesus waits two days. That is hard to understand. John shows: Jesus acts according to God's time, not according to what people expect.

Important: If God seems not to help right away, that does not mean that he does not love us. Verse 5 says explicitly: Jesus loved them.

Verse 8: "The Jews" here means the opponents in Jerusalem (compare 10:31). The disciples and Lazarus are Jews themselves.

Verse 11: Christians sometimes speak of death as a sleep from which God wakes people up.

Verse 16: Thomas ("Didymus" is Greek for "twin") is brave. He wants to go with Jesus, even into danger.

Jesus and Martha VERSES 17–27

17 When Jesus arrived, he learned that Lazarus had
already been in the tomb for four days.
18 Bethany was near Jerusalem.
It was about 15 stadia away, almost 2 miles.
19 Many Jews had come to Martha and Mary.
They wanted to comfort them because their brother
had died.
20 Martha heard that Jesus was coming.
She went out to meet him.
But Mary stayed at home.
21 Martha said to Jesus,
"Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not
have died.
22 But even now I know that God will give you whatever
you ask him for."
23 Jesus said to her,
"Your brother will rise again."
24 Martha said to him,
"I know that he will rise again on the last day, when the
dead rise."
25 Jesus said to her,
"I am the resurrection and the life.
Whoever believes in me will live, even if he dies.
26 And everyone who lives and believes in me will never
die.
Do you believe this?"
27 She said to him,
"Yes, Lord.
I believe that you are the Christ, God's Son.
You are the one who was to come into the world."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Four days in the tomb: According to a Jewish idea that was written down later, the soul stays near the dead person for three days. After four days it was completely certain for everyone that Lazarus was dead.

Verse 18: A distance of 15 stadia is almost 2 miles (about 3 kilometers).

Verse 19: Many Jews come to comfort the sisters. Visiting people who are grieving was (and is) an important good deed in Judaism. Here "the Jews" is meant in a completely friendly way: They are friends and neighbors.

Verse 21: Martha says honestly what she thinks, including her disappointment. You may tell God everything, even your complaints.

Verse 24: Martha believes in the resurrection at the end of time. The Pharisees also believed this.

Verse 25: "I am the resurrection and the life" is the fifth "I am" saying. These words are often read at funerals.

Verse 27: Martha's confession is one of the strongest in the whole Gospel. A woman speaks it.

Jesus weeps VERSES 28–37

28 After Martha said this, she went back.
She called her sister Mary and said to her quietly,
"The Teacher is here.
He is asking for you."
29 When Mary heard this, she got up quickly and went to
Jesus.
30 Jesus had not yet come into the village.
He was still at the place where Martha had met him.
31 The Jews who were in the house with Mary were
comforting her.
They saw her get up quickly and go out.
So they followed her.
They thought, "She is going to the tomb to cry there."
32 Mary came to the place where Jesus was.
When she saw him, she fell down at his feet.
She said to him,
"Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not
have died."
33 Jesus saw her crying.
He also saw the Jews who had come with her crying.
He was deeply moved in his spirit and very upset.
34 He asked, "Where have you put him?"
They said to him, "Lord, come and see."
35 Jesus cried.
36 So the Jews said,
"See how much he loved him!"
37 But some of them said,
"This man opened the eyes of the blind man.
Couldn't he also have kept Lazarus from dying?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 33: Jesus "was deeply moved in his spirit and very upset." The Greek word describes deep inner agitation, perhaps also anger at the power of death.

Verse 35: "Jesus cried." In many Bibles this is the shortest verse of the Bible. Jesus weeps with those who are grieving, even though he knows that he will raise Lazarus. He takes their pain seriously.

Verse 36: The Jews who are mourning with Mary see Jesus' love. Here too "the Jews" is meant in a completely positive way.

For today: Grief is not a weakness and not a lack of faith. Jesus wept too. Whoever is grieving may weep. Help is available from grief groups in churches and hospices. In a crisis: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Jesus raises Lazarus VERSES 38–44

38 Again Jesus was deeply moved inside.
He came to the tomb.
It was a cave, and a stone was lying in front of it.
39 Jesus said, "Take the stone away."
Martha, the sister of the dead man, said to him,
"Lord, by now there will be a bad smell.
He has been dead for four days."
40 Jesus said to her,
"Didn't I tell you that you would see God's glory if you
believed?"
41 So they took the stone away from the place where the
dead man was lying.
Jesus looked up and said,
"Father, thank you for listening to me.
42 I know that you always listen to me.
But I said this because of the crowd standing here.
I want them to believe that you sent me."
43 After he said this, he called out with a loud voice,
"Lazarus, come out!"
44 The dead man came out.
His hands and feet were tied up with strips of cloth.

A cloth was wrapped around his face.
Jesus said to them,
"Free him, and let him go."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Back then tombs were often caves in the rock, with a large stone in front.

Verses 41–42: Jesus prays out loud so that people will understand: The power comes from God the Father.

Verse 43: Jesus calls Lazarus by name, like the good shepherd calls his sheep (10:3).

Verse 44: Lazarus comes back to life, but he will die again later. It is a sign of the resurrection that Jesus himself will experience and wants to give to everyone.

"Free him": The people are to help free Lazarus from the grave clothes.

Many interpreters count this as the seventh and greatest sign in the Gospel of John.

The decision to kill Jesus VERSES 45–57

45 Many of the Jews who had come to visit Mary saw what Jesus did.
And they believed in him.
46 But some of them went to the Pharisees.
They told them what Jesus had done.
47 So the chief priests and the Pharisees called a meeting of the council.
They said,
"What are we going to do?
This man is doing many signs.
48 If we let him go on like this, everyone will believe in him.
Then the Romans will come.
They will take away our place and our nation."
49 One of them was Caiaphas.
He was high priest that year.
He said to them,
"You don't know anything at all.
50 You don't understand that it is better for us if one man dies for the people.
Then the whole nation will not be destroyed."
51 He did not say this on his own.
He was high priest that year.
So he spoke as a prophet:
Jesus would die for the nation.
52 And he would not die only for the nation.
He would also gather God's children who are scattered everywhere and make them one.
53 So from that day on, they made plans to kill Jesus.
54 That is why Jesus no longer moved around openly among the Jews.
He left and went to the countryside near the wilderness, to a town called Ephraim.
He stayed there with his disciples.
55 It was almost time for the Passover of the Jews.
Many people went up from the countryside to Jerusalem before the Passover.
They went there to make themselves clean for the feast.
56 They were looking for Jesus.
As they stood in the temple, they said to each other,
"What do you think?
Isn't he coming to the feast at all?"
57 The chief priests and the Pharisees had given an order:
Anyone who knew where Jesus was had to report it, so that they could arrest him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 45: Many Jews believe in Jesus. John shows this again and again.

Verse 48: "Our place" probably means the temple. The leaders are afraid: If a movement forms around Jesus, the Romans could step in and destroy everything. This fear was not without reason. In AD 70

the Romans really did destroy the temple.

Verses 49–50: Caiaphas was high priest from about AD 18 to 36. He thinks politically: Better for one to die than many.

Verses 51–52: John sees in this an unintended prophecy: Jesus really dies "for" everyone, for Israel and for the whole world.

Important: This decision was made by a small group of powerful people in a politically dangerous situation, under Roman occupation. The Jewish people were not involved. And at the same time many people in the temple are looking for Jesus (verse 56). The church teaches clearly: The death of Jesus may not be blamed on the Jews (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965).

Verse 55: Before the Passover feast people had to purify themselves ritually.

JOHN

CHAPTER 12

The grain of wheat

Mary anoints Jesus in Bethany VERSES 1–11

1 Six days before the Passover, Jesus came to Bethany.
Lazarus lived there.
He had been dead, and Jesus had raised him from the dead.
2 There they made a dinner for Jesus.
Martha served the food.
Lazarus was one of the people sitting at the table with him.
3 Then Mary took about 12 ounces of very expensive perfume.
It was pure nard.
She poured it on Jesus' feet and dried his feet with her hair.
The whole house was filled with the sweet smell of the perfume.
4 One of Jesus' disciples was Judas Iscariot, the son of Simon.
He was the one who would later betray Jesus.
He said,

5 "Why wasn't this perfume sold for 300 denarii?
The money could have been given to poor people."
6 He did not say this because he cared about poor people.
He said it because he was a thief.
He kept the money box, and he used to steal from it.
7 But Jesus said,
"Leave her alone.
She has kept this for the day of my burial.
8 You will always have poor people with you.
But you will not always have me."
9 A large crowd of Jews found out that Jesus was there.
So they came.
They did not come only because of Jesus.
They also wanted to see Lazarus, whom Jesus had raised from the dead.
10 So the chief priests made plans to kill Lazarus too.
11 Because of him, many Jews were going away and believing in Jesus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: Mary took a "pound" (in Greek "litra"). That was about 12 ounces (a third of a kilogram). Nard is a very expensive fragrant oil made from a plant that grows in the Himalayas.

A sum of 300 denarii was about the wages for a whole year of work.

Mary gives lavishly out of love. She honors Jesus before his death. The dead were anointed with oil. Mary does it in advance.

Verse 6: John says Judas was a thief. Important: Later the name Judas was misused to insult all Jews as greedy and as traitors. That is a nasty anti-Jewish prejudice. All the disciples, and Mary, Martha and Lazarus too, were Jews.

Verse 8: "You will always have poor people with you" is a reminder of Deuteronomy 15:11. There it goes on to say that you shall open your hand wide to your brother, to the needy and to the poor in your land. So Jesus is not saying that we may forget the poor. He is saying: Now is a special hour.

Verses 9 and 11: Many Jews come to believe in Jesus.

For today: Love may also be generous and lavish.

Jesus enters Jerusalem VERSES 12–19

12 The next day, a large crowd had come to the feast.
They heard that Jesus was coming to Jerusalem.
13 So they took palm branches and went out to meet him.
They shouted,
"Hosanna!
Blessed is the one who comes in the name of the Lord,
the King of Israel!"
14 Jesus found a young donkey and sat on it.
This is what the Scriptures say:
15 "Don't be afraid, daughter of Zion.
Look, your King is coming.
He is sitting on a donkey's colt."
16 At first his disciples did not understand these things.
But later, when Jesus had been glorified, they remembered:
These things had been written about him.
And people had done these things for him.
17 Many people had been with Jesus when he called Lazarus out of the tomb and raised him from the dead.
They kept telling others about it.
18 That is why the crowd went out to meet him.
They had heard that he had done this sign.
19 So the Pharisees said to each other,
"You see, you are getting nowhere.
Look, the whole world is running after him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Palm Sunday, one week before Easter, remembers this event.

Palm branches were a sign of victory and joy.

Verse 13: "Hosanna" is Hebrew and means "Please help!" or "Please save!" It became a shout of joy. The shout comes from Psalm 118:25–26.

Verse 15 quotes Zechariah 9:9. Jesus comes as a peaceful king on a donkey, not on a war horse.

Verse 19: "The whole world is running after him": The Jewish people cheer Jesus.

The grain of wheat must die VERSES 20–36

20 Some Greeks were among the people who went up to worship at the feast.
21 They came to Philip, who was from Bethsaida in Galilee.
They asked him,
"Sir, we would like to see Jesus."
22 Philip went and told Andrew.
Then Andrew and Philip went and told Jesus.
23 Jesus answered them,
"The hour has come for the Son of Man to be glorified.
24 I tell you the truth:
A grain of wheat must fall into the ground and die.
If it doesn't, it stays just one single grain.
But if it dies, it produces a big harvest.
25 Whoever loves his life will lose it.
Whoever hates his life in this world will keep it for eternal life.
26 Whoever wants to serve me must follow me.
Where I am, my servant will be there too.
My Father will honor anyone who serves me.
27 "Now my soul is deeply upset.
What should I say?
Should I say, 'Father, save me from this hour'?
But this is the very reason I came to this hour.
28 Father, glorify your name!"
Then a voice came from the sky.
It said,
"I have glorified it, and I will glorify it again."
29 The crowd standing there heard it.
Some said that it had thundered.
Others said, "An angel has spoken to him."
30 Jesus answered,
"This voice did not come for my sake.
It came for your sake.
31 Now is the time for this world to be judged.
Now the ruler of this world will be thrown out.
32 And if I am lifted up from the earth, I will draw all people to myself."
33 He said this to show what kind of death he would die.
34 The crowd answered him,
"We have heard from the law that the Christ will stay forever.

So how can you say, 'The Son of Man must be lifted up'?
Who is this Son of Man?"
35 Jesus said to them,
"The light will be with you for only a little while longer.
Walk while you have the light,
so that darkness doesn't catch you.
Whoever walks in the dark doesn't know where he is going.
36 While you have the light, believe in the light.
Then you will become children of light."
After Jesus said these things, he went away and hid from them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 20–21: "Greeks" are people from other nations who worshiped the God of Israel. They want to see Jesus. For Jesus that is a sign: Now the hour has come.

Verse 24: A grain of wheat has to go into the earth so that a new plant can grow. That is how Jesus explains his death: From it comes new life for many.

Verse 25: "Hating your life" is a strong picture. What is meant is: not clinging to yourself. Important: It does not mean that you should despise yourself or harm yourself. Whoever is thinking about self-harm or suicide can find help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 27: Jesus is afraid of what is coming. Here John tells what the other Gospels tell in the garden on the Mount of Olives.

Verse 31: "The ruler of this world" is the power of evil. Through Jesus' death it is defeated.

Verse 32: "Lifted up" means the cross and at the same time being raised to God. Jesus wants to draw "all people" to himself.

Verse 34: The crowd knows Bible passages that say the Messiah remains forever (for example Psalm 89:36, in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 89:37). That is why they do not understand why he should die. That is an honest question.

Why many do not believe VERSES 37–43

37 Jesus had done so many signs in front of them.
But still they didn't believe in him.
38 This happened so that the words of the prophet Isaiah would come true.
Isaiah said:
"Lord, who has believed our message?
To whom has the Lord shown his power?"
39 That is why they could not believe.
Isaiah also said:
40 "He has made their eyes blind.
He has made their hearts hard.
So they cannot see with their eyes.
They cannot understand with their hearts.
They cannot turn back to me, so that I could heal them."
41 Isaiah said these things when he saw his glory.
He spoke about him.
42 Yet even many of the leaders believed in Jesus.
But they did not say so openly because of the Pharisees.
They did not want to be put out of the synagogue.
43 They loved praise from people more than praise from God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 38 quotes Isaiah 53:1. Verse 40 quotes Isaiah 6:10 freely.

John asks: Why do not all believe in Jesus? He answers with words of the prophet Isaiah. Isaiah too experienced that many did not want to listen.

Important: These verses were misused to claim that God had hardened the Jews forever. That is wrong. Paul writes: The hardening is only partial and only for a time. In the end all Israel will be saved (Romans 11:25–26). God has not rejected his people.

Verse 42: Many leaders believe in Jesus. John shows once again: The Jewish people and their leaders were not all united against Jesus.

Verse 43: Fear of what people think can paralyze faith. That applies to all people.

Jesus' last public words VERSES 44–50

44 Jesus called out loudly,
"Whoever believes in me does not believe in me.
He believes in the one who sent me.
45 Whoever sees me sees the one who sent me.
46 I have come into the world as a light.
So whoever believes in me will not stay in the dark.
47 If anyone hears my words but doesn't believe, I don't judge him.
I did not come to judge the world.
I came to save the world.
48 There is a judge for whoever rejects me and doesn't accept my words.
The word I have spoken will judge him on the last day.
49 I have not spoken on my own.
The Father who sent me gave me a command.
He told me what to say and what to speak.
50 I know that his command is eternal life.
So whatever I say, I say just as the Father told me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These are Jesus' last public words in the Gospel of John. After this he speaks only with his disciples.

Verses 44–45: Whoever meets Jesus meets God himself.

Verse 47: Jesus came to save, not to condemn.

Important: Judgment on people belongs to God alone. No person may presume to condemn others.

JOHN

CHAPTER 13

Love one another

Jesus washes his disciples' feet VERSES 1–20

1 It was just before the Passover feast.
Jesus knew that his hour had come.
It was time for him to leave this world and go to the Father.
He had loved his own people who were in the world.
He loved them to the end.
2 They were eating supper.
The devil had already put the idea into the heart of Judas Iscariot, Simon's son, to betray Jesus.
3 Jesus knew that the Father had put everything into his hands.
He knew that he had come from God and was going back to God.
4 So he got up from the table.
He took off his outer clothes.
He took a towel and tied it around his waist.
5 Then he poured water into a bowl.
He began to wash the disciples' feet.
He dried them with the towel that was tied around him.
6 Then he came to Simon Peter.
Peter said to him,
"Lord, are you going to wash my feet?"
7 Jesus answered him,
"You don't understand now what I am doing.
But later you will understand."
8 Peter said to him,
"You will never wash my feet!"
Jesus answered him,
"If I don't wash you, you have no part with me."
9 Simon Peter said to him,
"Lord, then don't wash only my feet.
Wash my hands and my head too!"
10 Jesus said to him,
"Someone who has had a bath only needs to wash his feet.
The rest of him is completely clean.
You are clean, but not all of you."
11 Jesus knew who was going to betray him.
That is why he said, "Not all of you are clean."
12 Jesus finished washing their feet.
He put his outer clothes back on and sat down again.
Then he said to them,
"Do you understand what I have done for you?
13 You call me 'Teacher' and 'Lord.'
You are right, because that is what I am.
14 I am your Lord and Teacher, and I have washed your feet.
So you also should wash each other's feet.
15 I have given you an example.
You should do what I have done for you.
16 I tell you the truth:
A servant is not greater than his master.
And a messenger is not greater than the one who sent him.
17 Now you know these things.
You will be blessed if you do them.
18 I am not talking about all of you.
I know the ones I have chosen.
But the Scriptures must come true:
'The one who eats bread with me has lifted up his heel against me.'
19 I am telling you this now, before it happens.
Then, when it happens, you will believe that I am he.
20 I tell you the truth:
Whoever welcomes someone I send welcomes me.
And whoever welcomes me welcomes the one who sent me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

John tells the Last Supper differently from the other Gospels. He does not report about bread and wine, but about the washing of feet.

Washing feet was work for slaves. The roads were dusty, and people walked in sandals. Jesus, the Lord and Teacher, makes himself a servant.

Verse 1: "He loved them to the end": to the utmost, all the way to his death.

Verse 8: Peter does not want to allow this. But Jesus says: Whoever does not let me serve him cannot belong to me.

Verse 10: The words about only needing to have the feet washed are missing in some old manuscripts.

Verses 14–15: Jesus gives an example: Christians are to serve one another, especially those who have responsibility. On Maundy Thursday many churches repeat the washing of feet.

Important: Serving does not mean letting yourself be used or abused. Jesus serves out of freedom and love.

Verse 18 quotes Psalm 41:9 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 41:10). "Lifted up his heel against me" means: betraying or kicking someone.

Jesus announces that he will be betrayed VERSES 21–30

21 After Jesus said this, he was deeply upset in his spirit.
He said openly,
"I tell you the truth:
One of you will betray me."
22 The disciples looked at each other.
They had no idea which one of them he meant.
23 One of his disciples was at the table, leaning against Jesus' chest.
Jesus loved this disciple.
24 Simon Peter waved to him to get his attention.
He said to him,
"Ask him who he is talking about."
25 So that disciple leaned back against Jesus' chest.
He asked him, "Lord, who is it?"
26 Jesus answered,
"It is the one I will give this piece of bread to, after I dip it in the dish."
Then he dipped the piece of bread.
He gave it to Judas, the son of Simon Iscariot.
27 After Judas took the bread, Satan went into him.
Then Jesus said to him,
"What you are going to do, do it quickly."
28 No one at the table knew why Jesus said this to him.
29 Judas kept the money box.
So some of them thought that Jesus was telling him,
"Buy what we need for the feast."
Or they thought that Jesus wanted him to give something to poor people.

30 Judas took the piece of bread and went out right away.
It was night.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23: The disciple whom "Jesus loved": This disciple is mentioned here for the first time. According to old tradition it is John. That is not certain.

At festive meals people lay on cushions. So the disciple could lean his head against Jesus.

Verse 26: Handing someone a piece of bread was a sign of friendship and honor. Jesus offers Judas his friendship to the very end.

Verse 30: "It was night": Night is a picture of the darkness into which Judas goes out.

Important: In this text Judas stands for every person who betrays Jesus. He does not stand for "the Jews." All 12 disciples were Jews. Misusing the name Judas against Jews is wrong.

The new commandment VERSES 31–38

31 After Judas had gone out, Jesus said,
"Now the Son of Man has been glorified.
And God has been glorified in him.
32 God has been glorified in him.
So God will also glorify the Son in himself.
And he will do it right away.
33 Little children, I will be with you only a little while longer.
You will look for me.
I told the Jews, 'You can't come where I am going.'
Now I am telling you the same thing.
34 Here is a new commandment for you:
Love each other.
Love each other in the same way that I have loved you.
35 If you love each other, then everyone will know that you are my disciples."
36 Simon Peter said to him,
"Lord, where are you going?"
Jesus answered,
"You can't follow me now to the place where I am going.
But you will follow me later."
37 Peter said to him,
"Lord, why can't I follow you now?
I will give my life for you."
38 Jesus answered him,
"Will you really give your life for me?
I tell you the truth:
Before the rooster crows, you will say three times that you don't know me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 31–32: Jesus' suffering and death is at the same time his glorification. On the cross God's love shows most clearly.

Verse 33: "Little children": Jesus speaks to his disciples tenderly.

Verse 34: The commandment to love your neighbor is already in the Old Testament (Leviticus 19:18). What is "new" is the measure: to love as Jesus has loved.

Verse 35: Christians are to be recognizable by their love for one another. That is a task for all churches, also toward unity.

Verses 37–38: Peter means it seriously, but he overestimates himself. Jesus knows him and loves him anyway.

For today: Love does not show itself in big words, but in serving.

JOHN

CHAPTER 14

The way, the truth, and the life

"I am the way" VERSES 1–14

1 "Don't let your heart be upset.
Believe in God.
Believe in me too.
2 In my Father's house there are many places to live.
If that were not true, I would have told you.
I am going there to get a place ready for you.
3 I will go and get a place ready for you.
Then I will come back and take you to be with me.
I want you to be where I am.
4 You know where I am going.
And you know the way."
5 Thomas said to him,
"Lord, we don't know where you are going.
So how can we know the way?"
6 Jesus said to him,
"I am the way, the truth, and the life.
No one comes to the Father except through me.
7 If you had really known me, you would have known my Father too.
From now on, you know him.
And you have seen him."
8 Philip said to him,
"Lord, show us the Father.
That will be enough for us."
9 Jesus said to him,
"Philip, I have been with you all for such a long time.
And you still don't know me?
Whoever has seen me has seen the Father.
So how can you say, 'Show us the Father'?
10 Don't you believe that I am in the Father and the Father is in me?
The words I say to you are not my own words.
The Father lives in me.
He is the one doing his works.
11 Believe me when I say that I am in the Father and the Father is in me.
Or else believe because of the works themselves.
12 I tell you the truth:
Whoever believes in me will do the works that I do.
He will do even greater works than these,
because I am going to my Father.

13 I will do whatever you ask in my name.
Then the Father will be glorified in the Son.
14 If you ask for anything in my name, I will do it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

John 14–17 are called the "farewell speeches." Jesus is speaking with his disciples at the last meal. He is preparing them for his death and his return to the Father.

Verses 1–3: These words are often read at funerals. With God there is room for all who belong to Jesus.

Verse 6: "I am the way, the truth, and the life" is the sixth "I am" saying. For Christians Jesus is the way to God.

Important: Christians understand this sentence differently when it comes to other religions. The Catholic Church teaches: The church rejects nothing that is true and holy in other religions (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965). Many Protestant Christians stress something similar: God's grace is greater than our understanding. Judaism has its own covenant given by God (Romans 11:29). This verse must never be used to look down on people of other religions or to put pressure on them.

Verse 9: "Whoever has seen me has seen the Father." In Jesus we see what God is like.

Verses 13–14: Asking "in my name" means: asking in a way that fits Jesus. It is not a magic formula to get everything you want.

The promise of the Holy Spirit VERSES 15–31

15 If you love me, do what I command.
16 I will ask the Father.
And he will give you another Counselor, who will be with you forever.
17 He is the Spirit of truth.
The world can't accept him,
because the world doesn't see him and doesn't know him.
But you know him,
because he lives with you, and he will be in you.
18 I will not leave you alone like orphans.
I will come to you.
19 In a little while, the world will not see me anymore.
But you will see me.
Because I live, you will live too.
20 On that day you will know that I am in my Father.
You will know that you are in me, and I am in you.
21 Whoever knows my commands and does them is the one who loves me.
My Father will love the one who loves me.
I will love him too, and I will show myself to him."
22 Then Judas spoke to him.
This was not Judas Iscariot.
He said,
"Lord, why will you show yourself to us, but not to the world?"
23 Jesus answered him,
"Anyone who loves me will hold on to my word.
My Father will love him.
We will come to him and live with him.
24 Whoever doesn't love me doesn't hold on to my words.
The word you hear is not mine.
It comes from the Father who sent me.
25 "I have told you these things while I am still with you.
26 But the Father will send the Counselor in my name.
The Counselor is the Holy Spirit.
He will teach you everything.
He will help you remember everything I have told you.
27 I leave peace with you.
I give you my peace.
I don't give it to you the way the world gives.
Don't let your heart be upset or afraid.
28 You heard me tell you, 'I am going away, and I will come back to you.'
If you loved me, you would be glad that I said, 'I am going to my Father.'
The Father is greater than I.
29 I have told you this now, before it happens.
Then, when it happens, you will believe.
30 I will not talk with you much longer.
The ruler of this world is coming.
He has no power over me.
31 But the world must know that I love the Father.
So I do just what the Father has commanded me.
Get up, let's go from here.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: "Counselor" (in Greek "Paraclete") means: someone who stands by your side, comforts, advises and defends. The Holy Spirit is meant.

Verse 18: "I will not leave you alone like orphans." Jesus does not abandon his disciples.

Verse 22: This Judas is a different disciple, not Judas Iscariot. Luke calls him Judas the son of James (Luke 6:16).

Verse 23: God wants to live with the people who love him.

Verse 26: The Holy Spirit helps the disciples to remember Jesus' words and to understand them. The Gospels also rest on this.

Verse 27: "Peace" is "shalom" in Hebrew. That was (and is) the Jewish farewell greeting. Jesus' peace is more than quiet: It is God's wholeness and well-being.

Verse 28: "The Father is greater than I": Christians have thought a lot about this. Many understand it this way: As a human being Jesus places himself under the Father, and yet he is one with the Father (10:30).

Verse 31: "Let's go from here": Even so, more speeches follow in chapters 15–17.

For today: Whoever is afraid may hold on to Jesus' words: "Don't let your heart be upset."

JOHN

CHAPTER 15

The vine and the branches

"I am the true vine" VERSES 1–8

1 "I am the true vine.
My Father is the farmer.

2 He cuts off every branch in me that doesn't bear fruit.
He prunes every branch that does bear fruit,
so that it will bear even more fruit.
3 You are already pruned and clean because of the word I
have spoken to you.
4 Remain in me, and I will remain in you.
A branch can't bear fruit by itself.
It has to remain in the vine.
In the same way, you can't bear fruit unless you
remain in me.
5 I am the vine.
You are the branches.
If you remain in me and I remain in you, you will bear
much fruit.
Without me you can do nothing.
6 Anyone who doesn't remain in me is thrown away like a
branch.
He dries up.
People gather such branches.
They throw them into the fire, and the branches are
burned.
7 If you remain in me and my words remain in you,
you may ask for whatever you want.
And it will be done for you.
8 "My Father is glorified when you bear much fruit.
In this way, you will be my disciples.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Prune means: cut back a plant so that it grows better.

"I am the true vine" is the seventh and last "I am" saying in John.

In the Old Testament the vineyard or the vine is a picture for Israel (Isaiah 5:1–7; Psalm 80:8–16, in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 80:9–17). Jesus takes up this picture.

Important: "The true vine" does not mean that Israel is a "false" vine. Jesus himself is a Jew and belongs to Israel. He says: Whoever is connected with me has life.

Verse 2: A farmer cuts back the branches so that they bear more grapes. That sometimes hurts, but it helps growth.

Verse 5: "Without me you can do nothing": As a branch gets its sap from the vine, so Christians get their strength from Jesus.

Verse 6: This is a picture from growing grapes: Branches that had been cut off and dried out were burned.

Important: In church history this verse was also used to justify burning "heretics." That was a terrible injustice. The verse speaks in a picture about what happens without a connection to Jesus. It gives no one the right to do violence to people.

For today: "Remain in me": Faith is a living connection, not an achievement.

"You are my friends" VERSES 9–17

9 I have loved you just as the Father has loved me.
Remain in my love.
10 If you do what I command, you will remain in my love.
In the same way, I have done what my Father
commands, and I remain in his love.
11 I have told you these things so that my joy will be in
you,
and so that your joy will be complete.
12 "This is my command:
Love each other in the same way that I have loved you.
13 No one has a greater love than the one who gives his life
for his friends.
14 You are my friends if you do what I command you.
15 I don't call you servants anymore.
A servant doesn't know what his master is doing.
But I have called you friends.
I have told you everything I heard from my Father.
16 You did not choose me.
I chose you.
I gave you the task to go and bear fruit, fruit that lasts.
Then the Father will give you whatever you ask him
for in my name.
17 "This is what I command you:
Love each other.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Jesus wants his disciples to have joy, a joy that remains.

Verse 13: "No one has a greater love": Jesus is speaking about his own death. He gives his life for those whom he loves.

Important: This verse does not mean that you should throw your life away. It describes how great Jesus' love is. If you are thinking about ending your life, please get help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 15: Jesus calls his disciples "friends," not servants. That is a great honor. Abraham was called God's friend (Isaiah 41:8).

Verse 16: God looks for people first. Faith begins with God's call.

The hatred of the world VERSES 18–27

18 If the world hates you, remember that it hated me first.
19 If you belonged to the world, the world would love you
as its own.
But you don't belong to the world.
I chose you out of the world.
That is why the world hates you.
20 Remember what I told you:
'A servant is not greater than his master.'
If people persecuted me, they will persecute you too.
If they held on to my word, they will hold on to yours
too.
21 But they will do all these things to you because of my
name.
They don't know the one who sent me.
22 If I had not come and spoken to them, they would not
be guilty of sin.
But now they have no excuse for their sin.
23 Whoever hates me also hates my Father.
24 I have done works among them that no one else has
ever done.
If I had not done them, they would not be guilty of sin.
But now they have seen these works.
And they have hated both me and my Father.
25 But this happened so that the words written in their
law would come true:

'They hated me for no reason.'
26 "I will send you the Counselor from the Father.
He is the Spirit of truth, who comes from the Father.
When he comes, he will tell about me.
27 And you will also tell about me,
because you have been with me from the beginning."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Persecute means: hunt down and treat cruelly because of their faith.

In John, "the world" often means: everything that sets itself against God. It does not mean a certain group of people.

Verses 18–21: The first Christians experienced rejection and persecution. Jesus prepares his disciples for it.

Important: These verses do not give Christians the right to feel superior or to label others as "the world." God loves the world (3:16).

Verse 25 quotes Psalm 35:19 or Psalm 69:4 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 69:5). "Law" here means the whole Holy Scripture of Israel.

Verse 26: The Holy Spirit is the Spirit "who comes from the Father." The Creed says: He *proceeds* from the Father. The churches argued for a long time about where exactly the Spirit comes from: The Western churches confess in the Creed that the Spirit proceeds *from the Father and the Son*. The Orthodox churches only say *from the Father*. Today the churches talk about this in dialogue.

For today: Christians are to tell about Jesus, kindly and honestly, even if they are rejected for it.

JOHN

CHAPTER 16

Sorrow turns into joy

Persecution will come VERSES 1–4

1 "I have told you these things so that you won't stumble.
2 People will put you out of the synagogues.
Yes, the time is coming when people will kill you.
And they will think that they are serving God by doing it.
3 They will do these things because they have not known the Father or me.
4 But I have told you these things now.
So when the time comes, you will remember that I told you about them.
I didn't tell you these things at the beginning, because I was with you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Stumble means: here: lose your faith.

Verse 2: Here John probably reflects the experience of his church: Christians who were themselves of Jewish background were put out of synagogues. There were also persecutions.

Important: In later history it was the other way around: For many centuries Christians persecuted and killed Jews, often believing that they were offering a service to God. This is exactly what this verse warns against. Whoever kills in God's name does not know God (verse 3). That is true for all people and all religions.

For today: Violence in God's name is always wrong.

The work of the Holy Spirit VERSES 5–15

5 But now I am going to the one who sent me.
Yet none of you asks me, 'Where are you going?'
6 Instead, your hearts are full of sadness because I have told you these things.
7 But I am telling you the truth:
It is better for you that I go away.
If I don't go away, the Counselor will not come to you.
But if I go, I will send him to you.
8 When he comes, he will convict the world.
He will show the world the truth about sin, about what is right, and about judgment.
9 About sin: because people don't believe in me.
10 About what is right: because I am going to my Father, and you won't see me anymore.
11 About judgment: because the ruler of this world has been judged.
12 "I still have many things to tell you.
But right now it would be too much for you.
13 But the Spirit of truth will come.
He will lead you into all the truth.
He will not speak on his own.
He will speak only what he hears.
He will tell you about the things that are going to happen.
14 He will bring me glory.
He will take what is mine and tell it to you.
15 Everything the Father has is mine.
That is why I said that the Spirit will take what is mine and tell it to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Convict means: show clearly who is guilty and what is true.

Verse 7: Jesus says: My going away is good for you. For then the Holy Spirit will come. He is everywhere and with everyone at the same time.

Verse 8: "Convict" means: to show, to uncover, to make clear what is true.

Verse 11: "The ruler of this world" is the power of evil. Through Jesus' death and resurrection it is already defeated.

Verses 12–13: The Holy Spirit helps Christians to understand Jesus more and more deeply, also in new times and with new questions.

For today: If you can't understand something yet, you don't need to despair. God's Spirit leads step by step.

Sorrow turns into joy VERSES 16–24

16 "In a little while, you will not see me anymore.
Then, after a little while, you will see me again."
17 So some of his disciples said to each other,
"What does he mean?

He tells us, 'In a little while, you won't see me, and
then after a little while, you will see me.'
And he says, 'Because I am going to the Father.'"
18 They kept asking,
"What does he mean by 'a little while'?
We don't understand what he is saying."
19 Jesus saw that they wanted to ask him about it.
So he said to them,
"Are you asking each other what I meant?
I said, 'In a little while, you won't see me, and then
after a little while, you will see me.'
20 I tell you the truth:
You will cry and lament, but the world will be glad.
You will be sad, but your sadness will turn into joy.
21 When a woman is giving birth, she is in pain, because
her hour has come.
But after the baby is born, she forgets the pain.
She is so happy that a new person has been born into
the world.
22 It is the same with you.
You are sad now.
But I will see you again.
Then your hearts will be full of joy.
No one will take your joy away from you.
23 "On that day you will not ask me any questions.
I tell you the truth:
The Father will give you whatever you ask him for in
my name.
24 Until now you have not asked for anything in my
name.
Ask, and you will receive.
Then your joy will be complete.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Lament means: cry out loudly in grief.

Verse 16: "A little while": Jesus is speaking about his death and about Easter. After three days the disciples will see him again.

Verse 21: Jesus compares sorrow with the pain of giving birth. After the pain comes new life. This is a picture from the experience of many women.

Important: Not every birth goes well. Whoever has lost a child may grieve as long as needed. Help is offered, for example, by The Compassionate Friends (compassionatefriends.org in the US, tcf.org.uk in the UK). In a crisis: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 22: "No one will take your joy away from you": No one can destroy the joy of Easter.

"I have overcome the world" VERSES 25–33

25 "I have told you these things using figures of speech.
But the time is coming when I will not use figures of
speech anymore.
Then I will tell you plainly about the Father.
26 On that day you will ask in my name.
I am not saying that I will ask the Father for you.
27 The Father himself loves you,
because you have loved me.
And you have believed that I came from God.
28 I came from the Father into the world.
Now I am leaving the world and going back to the
Father."
29 His disciples said to him,
"Look, now you are speaking plainly.
You are not using figures of speech.
30 Now we know that you know everything.
No one needs to ask you questions.
This is why we believe that you came from God."
31 Jesus answered them,
"So now you believe?
32 Look, the time is coming, and it is already here,
when you will be scattered.
Each of you will go to his own home.
And you will leave me alone.
But I am not alone,
because the Father is with me.
33 I have told you these things so that you will have peace
in me.
In the world you have trouble.
But cheer up!
I have overcome the world."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Figures of speech means: pictures and comparisons.

Verse 27: "The Father himself loves you." God doesn't need a go-between in order to love us. He already loves us.

Verse 32: The disciples will leave Jesus alone when he is arrested. But Jesus is never completely alone: The Father is with him.

Verse 33: "Trouble" means: distress, need, fear. Jesus does not promise a life without difficulties. But he promises: Trouble does not have the last word; God does.

For today: "Cheer up! I have overcome the world." A word of comfort for hard times.

JOHN

Chapter 17

Jesus prays for his own

Jesus prays for himself VERSES 1–5

1 After Jesus had said these things, he looked up to
heaven.
He said,
"Father, the time has come.
Glorify your Son,
so that your Son can glorify you.
2 You gave him power over all flesh.
So he will give eternal life to everyone you have given
him.
3 And this is eternal life:
to know you, the only true God,

and to know Jesus Christ, whom you sent.
4 I have glorified you on earth.
I have finished the work you gave me to do.
5 So now, Father, glorify me with you.
Give me the glory that I had with you before the world began.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

John 17 is the longest prayer of Jesus in the Bible. It is often called the "High Priestly Prayer": Jesus stands up for his own before God, like a priest.

Verse 1: "The time" is the hour of his death and his glorification.

Verse 2: "All flesh" is a biblical expression for all people.

Verse 3: In John, "eternal life" is not only a life after death. It already begins now: knowing God and being connected with him.

"The only true God": Jesus confesses the one God of Israel. This connects Jews and Christians (Deuteronomy 6:4).

Jesus prays for his disciples VERSES 6–19

6 "I have shown your name to the people you gave me out of the world.
They belonged to you, and you gave them to me.
They have held on to your word.
7 Now they know that everything you have given me comes from you.
8 I have given them the words you gave me.
They accepted them.
They know for sure that I came from you.
They have believed that you sent me.
9 I am praying for them.
I don't pray for the world.
I pray for the people you have given me,
because they belong to you.
10 Everything that is mine is yours.
And everything that is yours is mine.
And I am glorified in them.
11 I will not be in the world anymore.
But they are still in the world, and I am coming to you.
Holy Father, protect them through your name, the name you have given me.
Then they will be one, just as we are one.
12 While I was with them in the world, I kept them safe in your name.
I protected the ones you gave me.
Not one of them is lost except the son of destruction.
This happened so that the Scriptures would come true.
13 But now I am coming to you.
I am saying these things while I am still in the world,
so that my joy will fill them completely.
14 I have given them your word.
The world has hated them,
because they don't belong to the world,
just as I don't belong to the world.
15 I am not asking you to take them out of the world.
I am asking you to protect them from the evil one.
16 They don't belong to the world,
just as I don't belong to the world.
17 Sanctify them in your truth.
Your word is truth.
18 You sent me into the world.
In the same way, I have sent them into the world.
19 I sanctify myself for them,
so that they also will be sanctified in truth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sanctify means: make holy, set apart for God.

Verse 9: "I don't pray for the world": Here Jesus prays especially for his disciples. That does not mean that he doesn't care about the world. God loves the world (3:16), and the disciples are sent into the world (verse 18).

Verse 11: "Then they will be one": Jesus prays for the unity of his disciples.

Verse 12: "The son of destruction" means Judas.

Verse 15: Christians are not to flee from the world, but to live in the world, protected from evil.

Verse 17: "Sanctify" means: to be set apart for God, to belong to God.

For today: Jesus prays for his friends. We may also pray for one another.

Jesus prays for all who will believe VERSES 20–26

20 "I am not praying only for these disciples.
I am also praying for the people who will believe in me because of their word.
21 I pray that they will all be one.
Father, you are in me, and I am in you.
In the same way, may they also be one in us.
Then the world will believe that you sent me.
22 I have given them the glory you gave me,
so that they will be one, just as we are one.
23 I am in them, and you are in me.
So they will become completely one.
Then the world will know that you sent me.
It will know that you have loved them just as you have loved me.
24 Father, you have given them to me.
I want them to be with me where I am.
I want them to see my glory, the glory you have given me.
You loved me before the world was made.
25 Righteous Father, the world has not known you.
But I have known you.
And these people know that you sent me.
26 I have made your name known to them, and I will keep making it known.
Then the love you have for me will be in them,
and I will be in them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: Jesus also prays for all later Christians, up to today.

Verse 21: "That they will all be one" is the guiding verse of the ecumenical movement, the movement for the unity of Christians. The division of the churches into Catholic, Orthodox, Protestant and many others goes against this prayer. Today many churches work together and pray with one another.

Unity does not mean that everyone has to be the same. It is about being connected in love.

Verse 23: The world is to recognize from the unity and love of Christians that God loves it.

Verse 26: The whole prayer ends with love: God's love is to live in people.

For today: Christians of different churches can pray together and do good together.

JOHN

Chapter 18

"My Kingdom is not of this world"

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

In chapters 18 and 19 John tells about Jesus' arrest, his sentencing and his death. In doing so he often writes "the Jews." Here he almost always means the temple leaders in Jerusalem and their servants, not the Jewish people.

For centuries these texts were misused to insult Jews as "Christ killers" and to persecute them. That is a grave guilt of Christians.

Jesus, Peter, John and all the disciples were Jews. Crucifixion was a Roman punishment. Today the churches teach clearly: The death of Jesus must not be blamed on all the Jews of that time nor on the Jews of today (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965).

Jesus is arrested VERSES 1–11

1 Jesus finished speaking these words.
Then he went out with his disciples and crossed the brook Kidron.
There was a garden there.
He and his disciples went into it.
2 Judas, the one who betrayed him, also knew the place.
Jesus often met there with his disciples.
3 So Judas came there.
He brought a detachment of soldiers with him.
He also brought temple guards from the chief priests and the Pharisees.
They had lanterns, torches, and weapons.
4 Jesus knew everything that was going to happen to him.
So he went out to them and asked, "Who are you looking for?"
5 They answered, "Jesus of Nazareth."
Jesus said to them, "I am he."
Judas, the one who betrayed him, was standing with them.
6 When Jesus said to them, "I am he,"
they stepped back and fell to the ground.
7 So he asked them again, "Who are you looking for?"
They said, "Jesus of Nazareth."
8 Jesus answered, "I told you that I am he.
So if you are looking for me, let these men go."
9 This happened so that his own word would come true.
He had said, "I have lost none of those you have given me."
10 Simon Peter had a sword.
He pulled it out and struck the high priest's servant.
He cut off the servant's right ear.
The servant's name was Malchus.
11 Then Jesus said to Peter, "Put the sword back into its sheath.
The Father has given me this cup.
Shall I not drink it?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Detachment means: a group of soldiers.

Sheath means: the cover for a sword.

The brook Kidron lies between Jerusalem and the Mount of Olives. In Matthew and Mark the garden is called Gethsemane.

Verse 3: A "detachment of soldiers" were probably Roman soldiers. Temple guards came along too. The Romans and the temple leaders acted together.

Verses 5–6: "I am he" is literally "I am," like the name of God. The soldiers fall back. John shows: Jesus is not helpless. He gives himself up freely.

Verse 8: Jesus protects his disciples.

Verses 10–11: Only John names Peter and Malchus. Jesus stops the violence. He does not want to be defended with the sword.

For today: Jesus' way is the way of nonviolence.

Jesus before Annas, and Peter denies him VERSES 12–27

12 So the detachment, its commanding officer, and the officers of the Jews arrested Jesus.
They tied him up.
13 First they took him to Annas.
Annas was the father-in-law of Caiaphas.
Caiaphas was high priest that year.
14 Caiaphas was the one who had given the Jews this advice:
It is better for one man to die for the people.
15 Simon Peter followed Jesus.
Another disciple followed him too.
The high priest knew that disciple.
So he went with Jesus into the courtyard of the high priest.
16 But Peter stood outside at the door.
So the other disciple, the one the high priest knew, went out again.
He spoke to the woman who kept the door.
Then he brought Peter in.
17 The servant girl at the door said to Peter, "Are you one of this man's disciples too?"
He said, "I am not."
18 The servants and the officers were standing there.
They had made a charcoal fire, because it was cold.
They were warming themselves.
Peter was standing with them and warming himself too.
19 The high priest asked Jesus about his disciples and about his teaching.
20 Jesus answered him, "I spoke openly to the world.
I always taught in synagogues and in the temple.
The Jews always meet there.
I said nothing in secret.

21 Why do you ask me?
Ask the people who heard me.
Ask them what I said to them.
They know what I said."
22 When Jesus said this, one of the officers standing nearby slapped him.
He said, "Is that how you answer the high priest?"
23 Jesus answered him, "If I said something wrong, then show what was wrong.
But if I spoke rightly, why do you hit me?"
24 Then Annas sent him, still tied up, to Caiaphas, the high priest.
25 Simon Peter was still standing there and warming himself.
So they said to him, "You aren't one of his disciples too, are you?"
He denied it and said, "I am not."
26 One of the high priest's servants spoke up.
He was a relative of the man whose ear Peter had cut off.
He said, "Didn't I see you in the garden with him?"
27 Peter denied it again.
At that moment the rooster crowed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Annas had been high priest earlier and still had great influence. Caiaphas was his son-in-law.

Verse 15: "The other disciple" is not named. Many think of "the disciple whom Jesus loved."

Verses 17 and 25: Peter says "I am not." Jesus had said "I am he" (verse 5). John sets the two side by side.

Verse 20: Jesus taught openly, in synagogue and temple, like a Jewish teacher.

Verses 22–23: Jesus is beaten. He does not defend himself with violence, but he demands justice. That is dignity.

Important: Violence against prisoners is always wrong.

Jesus before Pilate VERSES 28–40

28 Then they took Jesus from Caiaphas to the Praetorium.
It was early in the morning.
They themselves didn't go into the Praetorium.
They did not want to become unclean.
They wanted to be able to eat the Passover meal.
29 So Pilate came out to them.
He asked, "What charge do you bring against this man?"
30 They answered him, "If this man weren't a criminal, we wouldn't have handed him over to you."
31 Pilate said to them, "Take him yourselves.
Judge him by your own law."
The Jews said to him, "We are not allowed to put anyone to death."
32 This happened so that the word of Jesus would come true.
With that word he had shown what kind of death he would die.
33 Pilate went back into the Praetorium.
He called Jesus and asked him, "Are you the King of the Jews?"
34 Jesus answered him, "Are you saying this on your own?
Or did others tell you about me?"
35 Pilate answered, "I'm not a Jew, am I?
Your own nation and the chief priests handed you over to me.
What have you done?"
36 Jesus answered, "My Kingdom is not of this world.
If my Kingdom were of this world, my servants would fight.
They would fight so that I would not be handed over to the Jews.
But my Kingdom is not from here."
37 So Pilate said to him, "So you are a king?"
Jesus answered, "You say that I am a king.
This is why I was born.
This is why I came into the world: to be a witness to the truth.
Everyone who belongs to the truth listens to my voice."
38 Pilate said to him, "What is truth?"
After he said this, he went out to the Jews again.
He said to them, "I find no reason to charge him with anything.
39 But you have a custom.
At the Passover I release one prisoner to you.
So do you want me to release the King of the Jews to you?"
40 Then they all shouted again, "Not this man, but Barabbas!"
Barabbas was a robber.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Praetorium was the official residence of the Roman governor in Jerusalem.

Verse 28: Whoever entered the house of a non-Jew was considered unclean and could not take part in the Passover meal. In John, Jesus dies on the day when the Passover lambs were slaughtered.

Verse 31: Under Roman rule the Jewish authorities were probably not allowed to carry out the death penalty. The death sentence was given by the Roman governor.

Verse 35: "Your own nation": This is how Pilate speaks. The temple leaders and their people are meant. Pilate wants to push the responsibility away from himself.

Verse 36: "My Kingdom is not of this world": Jesus is not a political rebel. His Kingdom does not come through violence. That is why his servants do not fight.

Verse 38: "What is truth?" Pilate asks, but he doesn't wait for an answer. The truth is standing in front of him.

Verse 40: Barabbas is called a "robber." The word could also mean a rebel against Rome.

Important: Pilate had the power. He finds no guilt and still doesn't set Jesus free. He bears responsibility. No people bears a collective guilt.

JOHN

CHAPTER 19

"It is *finished*"

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

In this chapter too John often writes "the Jews." He mainly means the chief priests and their servants (verses 6 and 15). The Jewish people are not meant. Jewish women and a Jewish disciple stand under the cross. Two Jewish council members, Joseph and Nicodemus, bury Jesus.

Crucifixion was a Roman punishment, ordered by the Roman governor Pilate. No one may use these texts to accuse or hate Jews (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965).

"Look, here is the man!" VERSES 1–16

1 Then Pilate took Jesus and had him flogged.
2 The soldiers twisted thorns into a crown.
They put it on his head.
They dressed him in a purple robe.
3 Again and again they said, "Hail, King of the Jews!"
And again and again they slapped him.
4 Then Pilate went out again.
He said to them, "Look, I am bringing him out to you.
I want you to know that I find no reason to charge him with anything."
5 So Jesus came out.
He was wearing the crown of thorns and the purple robe.
Pilate said to them, "Look, here is the man!"
6 The chief priests and the temple guards saw him.
They shouted, "Crucify! Crucify!"
Pilate said to them, "Take him yourselves and crucify him.
I find no reason to charge him with anything."
7 The Jews answered him, "We have a law.
By our law he must die, because he made himself the Son of God."
8 When Pilate heard this, he was even more afraid.
9 He went back into the Praetorium.
He asked Jesus, "Where are you from?"
But Jesus gave him no answer.
10 So Pilate said to him, "Aren't you going to speak to me?
Don't you know that I have the power to set you free?
And I have the power to crucify you."
11 Jesus answered, "You would have no power over me at all if it had not been given to you from above.
So the one who handed me over to you has the greater sin."
12 After this, Pilate tried to set him free.
But the Jews shouted, "If you set this man free, you are not Caesar's friend!
Everyone who makes himself a king speaks against Caesar!"
13 Pilate heard these words.
Then he brought Jesus out.
He sat down on the judge's seat.
The place was called "The Pavement."
In Hebrew it is called "Gabbatha."
14 It was the Day of Preparation for the Passover.
It was about the sixth hour.
Pilate said to the Jews, "Look, here is your King!"
15 They shouted, "Away with him! Away with him!
Crucify him!"
Pilate said to them, "Shall I crucify your King?"
The chief priests answered, "We have no king but Caesar!"
16 So Pilate handed him over to them to be crucified.
They took Jesus and led him away.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Flog means: beat hard with a whip.

Caesar means: the Roman emperor.

The sixth hour means: about noon.

Flogging was a cruel Roman punishment. The crown of thorns and the purple garment are mockery: They dress Jesus up as a king.

Verse 5: "Look, here is the man!" (in Latin *Ecce homo*). Pilate shows a tortured, humiliated human being. Christians see in this: In Jesus God is very close to a suffering human being.

Verse 6: Here John says exactly who is shouting: the chief priests and the temple guards. That is not the Jewish people.

Verse 7: The accusers appeal to the law against blasphemy, that is, speaking against God (Leviticus 24:16).

Verse 11: Pilate's power is only borrowed. He remains responsible. Jesus doesn't say who is meant by "the one who handed me over." Some think of Caiaphas, others of Judas.

Verse 12: "Caesar's friend" was a title of honor for loyal officials. Pilate is afraid for his position.

Verse 14: In John, Jesus is sentenced at the same time as the Passover lambs are being slaughtered in the temple. He is "the Lamb of God" (1:29).

Important: Torture is a crime against human dignity. Jesus is close to all who are tortured.

Jesus is crucified VERSES 17–27

17 Jesus went out, carrying his cross himself.
He went to the place called "The Place of a Skull."
In Hebrew it is called "Golgotha."
18 There they crucified him.
They crucified two other men with him, one on each side.
Jesus was in the middle.
19 Pilate also wrote a title.
He had it put on the cross.
It said: "JESUS OF NAZARETH, THE KING OF THE JEWS."
20 Many of the Jews read this title.
The place where Jesus was crucified was near the city.
And the title was written in Hebrew, in Latin, and in Greek.
21 So the chief priests of the Jews said to Pilate, "Don't write, 'The King of the Jews.'
Write, 'He said, "I am King of the Jews."'"
22 Pilate answered, "What I have written, I have written."
23 The soldiers crucified Jesus.
Then they took his clothes and made four parts, one part for each soldier.
They also took his tunic.
The tunic had no seam.
It was woven in one piece from top to bottom.
24 So they said to one another, "Let's not tear it.
Let's cast lots for it to decide who gets it."

This happened so that the Scripture would come true.
It says, "They divided my clothes among them.
They cast lots for my clothing."
So that is what the soldiers did.

25 Some women were standing by Jesus' cross.
They were his mother, his mother's sister, Mary the wife of Clopas, and Mary Magdalene.

26 Jesus saw his mother there.
He also saw the disciple he loved standing there.
He said to his mother, "Woman, here is your son!"

27 Then he said to the disciple, "Here is your mother!"
From that hour on, the disciple took her into his own home.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Title means: here: a sign with writing on it.

Tunic means: a long shirt worn under the outer clothes.

Cast lots means: decide something by chance, like throwing dice.

Golgotha was a place of execution outside the gates of Jerusalem.

Verses 19–20: The title gave the reason for the sentence. Everyone could read it in the three most important languages. Without wanting to, Pilate proclaims: Jesus is King.

Verses 23–24: This quotes Psalm 22:18 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 22:19). The soldiers even take Jesus' clothes from him.

Verse 25: Women stand by the cross when most of the disciples have fled. It is not completely clear whether there are three or four women.

Verses 26–27: Even while dying, Jesus takes care of his mother. He entrusts her to the beloved disciple. Many Christians see in this: Mary becomes the mother of all believers. The churches honor Mary in different ways, but all respect her as the mother of Jesus.

Jesus dies VERSES 28–37

28 After this, Jesus knew that everything was now finished.
So that the Scripture would come true, he said, "I am thirsty!"

29 A jar full of vinegar was standing there.
So they put a sponge full of the vinegar on a hyssop stalk.
They held it up to his mouth.

30 Jesus took the vinegar.
Then he said, "It is finished!"
He bowed his head and gave up his spirit.

31 It was the Day of Preparation.
The Jews did not want the bodies to stay on the crosses on the Sabbath.
That Sabbath was a special one.
So they asked Pilate to have the men's legs broken and the bodies taken away.

32 So the soldiers came.
They broke the legs of the first man.
Then they broke the legs of the other man who was crucified with Jesus.

33 But when they came to Jesus, they saw that he was already dead.
So they didn't break his legs.

34 But one of the soldiers stabbed his side with a spear.
At once blood and water came out.

35 The man who saw this has told about it, and what he says is true.
He knows that he is telling the truth.
He tells it so that you also may believe.

36 These things happened so that the Scripture would come true:
"Not one of his bones will be broken."

37 And another Scripture says, "They will look at the one they pierced."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Vinegar means: here: sour wine.

Hyssop means: a plant with small, bushy branches.

Verse 28: "I am thirsty" reminds us of Psalm 69:21 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 69:22) and Psalm 22:15 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 22:16). Jesus really suffers, as a human being.

Verse 29: At the first Passover, hyssop was used to put the blood of the lambs on the doors (Exodus 12:22).

Verse 30: "It is finished!" Jesus' work is complete. This is not a cry of despair, but of completion.

Verse 31: According to the law, an executed man was not to hang overnight (Deuteronomy 21:22–23). When their legs were broken, crucified people died more quickly.

Verse 34: Blood and water show: Jesus has really died. Many Christians also think of baptism (water) and the Lord's Supper (blood).

Verse 36 reminds us of the Passover lamb, whose bones were not to be broken (Exodus 12:46). Verse 37 quotes Zechariah 12:10.

For today: Whoever suffers is not abandoned by God. Jesus carried suffering to the very end.

Jesus is buried VERSES 38–42

38 After this, Joseph of Arimathaea asked Pilate if he could take away Jesus' body.
Joseph was a disciple of Jesus.
But he kept it secret, because he was afraid of the Jews.
Pilate allowed it.
So Joseph came and took Jesus' body away.

39 Nicodemus came too.
He was the one who had first come to Jesus at night.
He brought a mixture of myrrh and aloes.
It weighed about 100 Roman pounds (about 75 pounds).

40 So they took Jesus' body.
They wrapped it in strips of linen cloth with the spices.
That is how the Jews bury their dead.

41 There was a garden at the place where Jesus was crucified.
In the garden was a new tomb.
No one had ever been laid in it.

42 It was the Jews' Day of Preparation, and the tomb was close by.
So they laid Jesus there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Myrrh and aloes means: sweet-smelling spices used for burial.

Verses 38–39: Two respected Jewish men bury Jesus: Joseph of Arimathaea and Nicodemus, a Pharisee. They

show courage and love.

"Afraid of the Jews": This means afraid of the powerful leaders. Joseph was a Jew himself.

Verse 39: A Roman pound was a little less than our pound. So 100 Roman pounds are about 75 pounds (33 kilograms). That is a burial fit for a king.

Verse 40: Jesus is buried according to Jewish custom, with love and dignity.

Verse 41: As creation began in a garden, so Jesus' tomb also lies in a garden. There Easter will begin.

For today: Burying a person with dignity is a work of love. If you are grieving for someone, you can find help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. Many churches and hospices also offer grief groups.

JOHN

CHAPTER 20

Jesus is alive!

The empty tomb VERSES 1–10

1 It was the first day of the week.
Early in the morning, while it was still dark, Mary Magdalene went to the tomb.
She saw that the stone had been taken away from the tomb.
2 So she ran to Simon Peter and to the other disciple, the one Jesus loved.
She said to them, "They have taken the Lord out of the tomb!
And we don't know where they have laid him!"
3 So Peter and the other disciple set out for the tomb.
4 The two of them ran together.
But the other disciple ran faster than Peter.
He came to the tomb first.
5 He bent down and looked in.
He saw the strips of linen cloth lying there.
But he didn't go in.
6 Then Simon Peter came after him.
He went into the tomb.
He saw the strips of linen lying there.
7 He also saw the cloth that had been on Jesus' head.
It was not lying with the strips of linen.
It was rolled up in a place by itself.
8 Then the other disciple went in too.
He was the one who had come to the tomb first.
He saw, and he believed.
9 Until then they had not understood the Scripture.
It says that he must rise from the dead.
10 Then the disciples went back to their homes.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The first day of the week" is Sunday. That is why Christians hold their worship services on Sunday: It is the day of the resurrection.

Mary Magdalene is the first at the tomb. She was a faithful disciple of Jesus (Luke 8:2). She was not a sinful woman or a prostitute, as people often claimed later. That is not written anywhere in the Bible.

Verse 2: "We don't know": Perhaps other women were there too, as the other Gospels tell.

Verses 5–7: The cloths are lying there neatly. That doesn't look like grave robbery.

Verse 8: The beloved disciple sees the empty tomb and believes.

For today: Easter begins in the dark (verse 1). Even when it is dark in our lives, God can begin something new.

Jesus meets Mary Magdalene VERSES 11–18

11 But Mary stood outside at the tomb and cried.
As she cried, she bent down and looked into the tomb.
12 She saw two angels in white.
They were sitting where the body of Jesus had been lying.
One sat at the head, and one sat at the feet.
13 They asked her, "Woman, why are you crying?"
She said to them, "They have taken away my Lord.
And I don't know where they have laid him."
14 After she said this, she turned around.
She saw Jesus standing there.
But she didn't know that it was Jesus.
15 Jesus said to her, "Woman, why are you crying?
Who are you looking for?"
She thought he was the gardener.
So she said to him, "Sir, if you have carried him away, tell me where you have laid him.
Then I will take him away."
16 Jesus said to her, "Mary."
She turned and said to him, "Rabboni!"
That means "Teacher!"
17 Jesus said to her, "Don't hold on to me.
I have not yet ascended to my Father.
But go to my brothers and tell them:
'I am ascending to my Father and your Father, to my God and your God.'"
18 Mary Magdalene went to the disciples.
She told them that she had seen the Lord.
And she told them what he had said to her.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ascend means: go up.

Verses 14–15: At first Mary doesn't recognize Jesus. The risen Jesus is the same and yet changed.

Verse 16: When Jesus calls her by name, she recognizes him. This reminds us of the good shepherd, who calls his own sheep by name (10:3).

"Rabboni" is Aramaic and means "my teacher."

Verse 17: "Don't hold on to me": Mary is not to hold on to Jesus as before. Now a new kind of connection begins.

"My brothers": For the first time Jesus calls his disciples this. Through him God is their Father too.

Verse 18: Mary Magdalene is the first witness of the resurrection. That is why the church calls her the apostle to the apostles. Women were the first messengers of Easter.

Jesus comes to the disciples VERSES 19–23

19 It was the evening of that same day, the first day of the week.
The disciples had gathered.
They had locked the doors, because they were afraid of the Jews.
Then Jesus came and stood among them.
He said to them, "Peace be to you."
20 After he said this, he showed them his hands and his side.
The disciples were glad when they saw the Lord.
21 Jesus said to them again, "Peace be to you.
The Father has sent me.
In the same way I am sending you."
22 After he said this, he breathed on them.
He said to them, "Receive the Holy Spirit!
23 If you forgive anyone's sins, they are forgiven.
If you retain anyone's sins, they are retained."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Retain means: here: not forgive.

Verse 19: "Afraid of the Jews": The disciples were Jews themselves. They were afraid of the leaders who had handed Jesus over.

"Peace be to you" (in Hebrew "shalom") is the greeting of the risen Jesus. He doesn't blame the disciples, even though they had run away.

Verse 20: The wounds show: The risen Jesus is really the one who was crucified.

Verse 22: Jesus breathes on the disciples. This reminds us of creation: God breathed the breath of life into the human being (Genesis 2:7).

Verse 23: The churches understand this verse in different ways. In the Catholic and Orthodox churches it is one basis for confession. Protestant churches stress: All Christians may speak forgiveness to one another.

For today: Forgiveness sets people free.

Jesus and Thomas VERSES 24–29

24 Thomas, one of the Twelve, was not with them when Jesus came.
He was also called Didymus.
25 So the other disciples told him, "We have seen the Lord!"
But he said to them, "First I must see the marks of the nails in his hands.
I must put my finger into the marks of the nails.
I must put my hand into his side.
If I don't, I will not believe."
26 Eight days later the disciples were inside again.
This time Thomas was with them.
The doors were locked.
Jesus came and stood among them.
He said, "Peace be to you."
27 Then he said to Thomas, "Put your finger here, and look at my hands.
Reach out your hand, and put it into my side.
Don't be an unbeliever. Be a believer."
28 Thomas answered him, "My Lord and my God!"
29 Jesus said to him, "You have believed because you have seen me.
Blessed are those who have not seen and still have believed."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Didymus" is Greek and means "twin."

Verse 25: Thomas is often called doubting Thomas. But he only wants to experience for himself what the others have experienced. Doubt is allowed.

Verse 27: Jesus doesn't turn Thomas away. He comes to meet him. John doesn't tell whether Thomas really touched Jesus.

Verse 28: "My Lord and my God!" is the strongest confession in the Gospel of John. It links back to the beginning: "The Word was God" (1:1).

Verse 29: This is true for all later Christians. They have not seen Jesus and can still believe.

For today: Whoever doubts still belongs.

Why this book was written VERSES 30–31

30 Jesus did many other signs in front of his disciples.
They are not written in this book.
31 But these are written so that you may believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God.
And if you believe, you may have life in his name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here John says why he wrote his Gospel: The readers are to believe in Jesus and find life.

He didn't write down everything, but made a selection.

Many scholars think: The Gospel originally ended here. Chapter 21 was probably added later, perhaps by students of John. But in all old manuscripts chapter 21 belongs to it.

JOHN

CHAPTER 21

"Do you love me?"

The great catch of fish VERSES 1–14

1 After this, Jesus showed himself to the disciples again.
It was at the Sea of Tiberias.
This is how it happened.
2 Some of his disciples were together:
Simon Peter, Thomas (also called Didymus), Nathanael from Cana in Galilee, the sons of Zebedee, and two other disciples.
3 Simon Peter said to them, "I'm going fishing."
They said to him, "We are coming with you."
So they went out and got into the boat right away.
But that night they caught nothing.
4 Early in the morning Jesus stood on the shore.
But the disciples didn't know that it was Jesus.
5 Jesus called to them, "Children, do you have anything to eat?"
They answered him, "No."

6 He said to them, "Throw the net out on the right side of the boat.
Then you will find some fish."
So they threw the net out.
Now they could not pull it in, because there were so many fish.
7 The disciple Jesus loved said to Peter, "It's the Lord!"
Simon Peter heard that it was the Lord.
He was naked, so he wrapped his coat around himself.
Then he jumped into the sea.
8 The other disciples came in the little boat.
They dragged the net full of fish behind them.
They were not far from land, only about 200 cubits away (about 100 yards).
9 They got out onto the land.
There they saw a charcoal fire.
Fish and bread were lying on it.
10 Jesus said to them, "Bring some of the fish you have just caught."
11 Simon Peter went up and pulled the net to land.
It was full of big fish, 153 of them.
There were so many, but the net still didn't tear.
12 Jesus said to them, "Come and eat breakfast!"
None of the disciples dared to ask him, "Who are you?"
They knew that it was the Lord.
13 Then Jesus came.
He took the bread and gave it to them.
He did the same with the fish.
14 This was now the third time that Jesus showed himself to his disciples after he had risen from the dead.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Cubit means: an old measure of length, about 18 inches (45 centimeters).

The Sea of Tiberias is the Sea of Galilee. The disciples are back at home and working as fishermen.

Verse 3: Without Jesus they catch nothing. This reminds us of Luke 5:1–11.

Verse 7: While working, Peter was probably wearing very little. Out of respect he puts on his coat before he goes to Jesus.

Verse 8: A distance of 200 cubits is about 100 yards (90 meters).

Verse 9: Again a fire of coals. At a fire of coals Peter had denied Jesus (18:18).

Verse 11: It is not certain what the number 153 means. Some scholars think: That is how many kinds of fish people knew at that time. Then it would be a picture for all peoples. The net doesn't tear: The church has room for everyone.

Verse 13: Jesus shares bread and fish, as at the feeding of the 5,000 (6:11).

For today: Jesus meets people in the middle of everyday life, at work and at meals.

Jesus and Peter VERSES 15–19

15 When they had finished breakfast, Jesus said to Simon Peter, "Simon, son of Jonah, do you love me more than these?"
Peter said to him, "Yes, Lord. You know that I have affection for you."
Jesus said to him, "Feed my lambs."
16 Jesus asked him a second time, "Simon, son of Jonah, do you love me?"
Peter said to him, "Yes, Lord. You know that I have affection for you."
Jesus said to him, "Tend my sheep."
17 Jesus asked him the third time, "Simon, son of Jonah, do you have affection for me?"
Peter was sad because Jesus asked him the third time, "Do you have affection for me?"
He said to him, "Lord, you know everything.
You know that I have affection for you."
Jesus said to him, "Feed my sheep.
18 I tell you the truth:
When you were young, you dressed yourself.
You went wherever you wanted to go.
But when you are old, you will stretch out your hands.
Someone else will dress you.
He will carry you where you do not want to go."
19 Jesus said this to show by what kind of death Peter would bring glory to God.
After he said this, he said to Peter, "Follow me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tend means: take care of.

Peter had denied Jesus three times (18:17, 25–27). Now Jesus asks him three times whether he loves him. Three times Peter may say his love. In this way he is set back on his feet.

In Greek there are two different words for "love" here. The WEB tells them apart: "love" and "have affection." The third time, Jesus takes up Peter's word. Some scholars see an important difference in this; others think the words mean almost the same.

"Feed my sheep": Peter is to take care of the church like a shepherd. The Catholic Church sees here a basis for the office of the pope. Other churches understand it as a task given to Peter and to all who have responsibility in the church.

Verses 18–19: Jesus hints at Peter's death. According to old tradition Peter died in Rome as a martyr, probably under the emperor Nero.

For today: After failure a new beginning is possible. Jesus gives up on no one.

Jesus and the beloved disciple VERSES 20–25

20 Peter turned around.
He saw the disciple Jesus loved following them.
At the supper this disciple had leaned against Jesus' chest.
He had asked, "Lord, who is going to betray you?"
21 When Peter saw him, he said to Jesus, "Lord, what about this man?"
22 Jesus said to him, "What if I want him to stay until I come?
What is that to you?
You follow me."
23 So a rumor spread among the brothers: This disciple will not die.
But Jesus did not say to him that he would not die.
He only said, "What if I want him to stay until I come?
What is that to you?"
24 This is the disciple who tells about these things.
He is the one who wrote these things down.
We know that what he says is true.

25 Jesus also did many other things.
Suppose they were all written down, one by one.
Then I think even the whole world would not have
room for all the books that would be written.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 21–22: Peter asks about the other disciple's path. Jesus says: Everyone has his own path. Don't compare yourself. Follow me.

Verse 23: John corrects a misunderstanding. Jesus had not promised that the disciple would not die.

Verse 24: "We know": Here others are probably speaking, perhaps students of the beloved disciple. They testify that his report is true.

Verse 25: A beautiful closing word: Jesus is greater than all the books in the world.

Looking back: What have we read in the Gospel of John?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A different Gospel: John tells his story differently from Matthew, Mark and Luke. He doesn't begin with the birth, but with eternity: "In the beginning was the Word." And: "The Word was God" (1:1). "The Word became flesh" (1:14). That means: The Word became a human being.

The signs: John tells of great deeds of Jesus and calls them "signs": water becomes wine in Cana, healings, the feeding of the 5,000, Jesus walks on the water, the man born blind sees, Lazarus is raised. Many scholars count seven such signs. The signs show who Jesus is.

The "I am" sayings: "I am the bread of life," "I am the light of the world," "I am the door," "I am the good shepherd," "I am the resurrection and the life," "I am the way, the truth, and the life," "I am the true vine."

God's love: "God loved the world very much" (3:16). Jesus washes his disciples' feet and gives the new commandment: to love one another as he has loved us (13:34).

The Holy Spirit: Jesus promises the Counselor, the Spirit of truth. He remains with the disciples.

Cross and Easter: On the cross Jesus says: "It is finished!" Mary Magdalene is the first to meet the risen Jesus. Thomas confesses: "My Lord and my God!"

Important note: John often writes "the Jews." By this he mostly means the leaders in Jerusalem who rejected Jesus. Jesus, his mother, all the disciples and the first Christians were Jews. "Salvation is from the Jews" (4:22). These texts were often misused to hate Jews. That was a grave guilt. No text of this Gospel may be used against Jews.

For today: John wrote this "so that you may believe" and so that believing you may have life (20:31). Whoever doubts like Thomas or fails like Peter is invited too.

What comes next? Next comes the Acts of the Apostles. It was written by Luke and continues his Gospel. It tells how the Holy Spirit comes at Pentecost, and how the good news is carried from Jerusalem all the way to Rome, by Peter, Paul and many others.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 44 OF 66

ACTS

28 CHAPTERS

ACTS

Chapter 1

Jesus goes to the Father

Before we begin: The Acts of the Apostles

The Acts of the Apostles continues the Gospel of Luke. Both books are written to a man named Theophilus. According to old church tradition, Luke wrote both books. He was a companion of the apostle Paul. Acts was probably written between AD 70 and 90. No one knows exactly.

The book tells how the first Christian church came into being: Jesus goes to the Father, and at Pentecost the Holy Spirit comes. Then the good news spreads: from Jerusalem to Judea and Samaria and all the way to Rome, the capital of the world at that time. In the first part Peter is mostly at the center, in the second part Paul.

An important theme is: The good news is for all people, for Jews and for people from all other nations.

Important note: The first Christians were Jews. They prayed in the temple and kept the Jewish feasts. In Acts, too, there are conflicts between the apostles and Jewish leaders. Sometimes the text says "the Jews." Then certain groups are meant, never the whole Jewish people. No text of this book may be used against Jews.

The Acts of the Apostles has 28 chapters.

Jesus promises the Holy Spirit VERSES 1–8

1 In the first book, Theophilus,
I wrote about all
that Jesus began both to do and to teach,
2 until the day
on which he was taken up.
Before that, he had given commands
through the Holy Spirit
to the apostles
whom he had chosen.
3 After he suffered,
he showed himself alive to them
by many proofs.
He appeared to them over a period of 40 days
and spoke about God's Kingdom.
4 While he was together with them,
he commanded them,
"Don't leave Jerusalem,
but wait for the promise of the Father,
which you heard from me.
5 For John baptized in water,
but you will be baptized in the Holy Spirit
not many days from now."
6 When they had come together,
they asked him,
"Lord, are you now restoring the kingdom to Israel?"
7 He said to them,
"It isn't for you to know times or seasons
which the Father has set
by his own authority.
8 But you will receive power
when the Holy Spirit has come upon you.
And you will be witnesses to me
in Jerusalem,
in all Judea and Samaria,
and to the farthest parts of the earth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "The first book" is the Gospel of Luke. There too Luke speaks to Theophilus (Luke 1:3). The name means friend of God.

Verse 3: The number 40 is special in the Bible: Israel was in the wilderness for 40 years, Jesus fasted for 40 days. That is why Christians celebrate Ascension Day 40 days after Easter.

Verse 5: John here is John the Baptizer.

Verse 6: The disciples are still hoping for a political kingdom for Israel. Jesus does not reject the question, but he says: God decides the time.

Verse 8 is like a table of contents for Acts: Jerusalem (chapters 1–7), Judea and Samaria (chapters 8–12), to the farthest parts of the earth (chapters 13–28).

For today: No one needs to know when the world will end. Whoever wants to calculate it exactly is mistaken. What matters is to be a witness for Jesus now.

Jesus is taken up into heaven VERSES 9–14

9 When he had said these things,
he was taken up
while they were watching.
A cloud took him out of their sight.
10 They were looking steadily into the sky
as he went.
Suddenly two men in white clothing stood by them.
11 They said,
"You men of Galilee,
why do you stand
looking into the sky?
This Jesus,
who was taken up from you into the sky,
will come back in the same way
as you saw him going into the sky."
12 Then they returned to Jerusalem
from the mountain called Olivet.
It is near Jerusalem,
a Sabbath day's journey away.
13 When they had come into the city,
they went up into the upper room
where they were staying:
Peter, John, James, and Andrew,
Philip and Thomas,
Bartholomew and Matthew,
James the son of Alphaeus,
Simon the Zealot,
and Judas the son of James.
14 All these were of one mind
and kept on praying steadily,
together with the women,

and with Mary the mother of Jesus,
and with his brothers.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Olivet means: the Mount of Olives.

Verse 9: In the Bible the cloud is a sign of God's presence (for example Exodus 13:21). Jesus goes into God's world. "Heaven" does not mean a place above the clouds, but being near God.

Verse 11: The two men in white are probably angels. They say: Don't just stand around! Jesus will come back.

Verse 12: A Sabbath day's journey was the distance a person was allowed to walk on the Sabbath. That was about half a mile (1 kilometer).

Verse 13: This is the list of the 11 apostles. A Zealot was someone who stood up very eagerly for God and the law. Some Zealots fought against the Romans.

Verse 14: Women naturally belong to the first church. Mary, the mother of Jesus, is named here for the last time in the Bible. The brothers of Jesus are also there. The churches understand differently who exactly they were: brothers, half brothers or relatives.

For today: Praying together makes a community stronger.

Matthias becomes an apostle VERSES 15–26

15 In these days,
Peter stood up in the middle of the disciples.
About 120 people were together.
He said,
16 "Brothers,
this Scripture had to be fulfilled,
which the Holy Spirit spoke before by the mouth of David
about Judas.
Judas was the guide for those
who arrested Jesus.
17 For he was counted with us
and received his share in this ministry.
18 This man bought a field
with the reward for his wickedness.
He fell headlong,
his body burst open,
and all his intestines gushed out.
19 This became known to everyone
who lived in Jerusalem.
So in their language that field was called
'Akeldama,'
that is,
'The field of blood.'
20 For it is written in the book of Psalms,
'Let his home be made desolate.
Let no one live in it.'
And,
'Let another take his office.'
21 So one of the men
who have been with us all the time
that the Lord Jesus went in and out among us,
22 beginning from the baptism of John
to the day
that he was taken up from us,
one of these must become a witness with us of his resurrection."
23 They put forward two men:
Joseph called Barsabbas,
who was also called Justus,
and Matthias.
24 They prayed and said,
"You, Lord, know the hearts of all people.
Show us
which one of these two you have chosen
25 to take the place in this ministry
and apostleship.
Judas turned away from it
to go to his own place."
26 They drew lots for them.
The lot fell on Matthias.
And he was counted with the 11 apostles.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Desolate means: empty and ruined.

Draw lots means: decide something by chance, like throwing dice.

Verse 15: 120 people: The first church was still small.

Verses 16–20: Peter speaks about the terrible end of Judas. Matthew 27:3–10 tells it a little differently. Both reports agree: Judas died, and with the money a field was bought that is called the field of blood.

Verse 19: The WEB writes Akeldama. Some Bibles have Hakeldamach. The word is Aramaic, the language people spoke in Jerusalem at that time.

Verse 20 quotes Psalm 69:25 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 69:26) and Psalm 109:8.

Important: If, like Judas, you feel heavy guilt and see no way out, please get help: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verses 21–22: An apostle had to be a witness of Jesus' whole way and of his resurrection.

Verse 26: In Israel drawing lots was a way to ask for God's will (for example Leviticus 16:8). They prayed first. After this, the New Testament never tells of drawing lots again.

The Twelve are complete again. The number 12 reminds us of the 12 tribes of Israel.

ACTS

CHAPTER 2

Pentecost: The Holy Spirit comes

The Holy Spirit comes VERSES 1–13

1 The day of Pentecost came.
They were all together in one place, and they were all of one mind.
2 Suddenly a sound came from the sky.
It sounded like a strong wind rushing by.
It filled the whole house where they were sitting.

3 Then they saw tongues like fire.
The tongues spread out, and one came to rest on each of them.
4 They were all filled with the Holy Spirit.
They began to speak in other languages.
The Spirit gave them the ability to speak.
5 At that time devout Jews were living in Jerusalem.
They came from every nation under the sky.
6 When people heard this sound, a crowd came together.
They were confused.
Each one heard them speaking in his own language.
7 They were all amazed and full of wonder.
They said to one another, "Look, aren't all these people who are speaking from Galilee?
8 So how can each of us hear them in our own native language?
9 We are Parthians, Medes, and Elamites.
We are people from Mesopotamia, Judea, Cappadocia, Pontus, and Asia,
10 from Phrygia, Pamphylia, and Egypt, and from the parts of Libya around Cyrene.
We are visitors from Rome, both Jews and proselytes,
11 and we are Cretans and Arabians.
And we hear them speaking in our own languages about the mighty works of God!"
12 They were all amazed and did not know what to think.
They said to one another, "What does this mean?"
13 But others made fun of them.
They said, "They are full of new wine."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Devout means: deeply faithful to God.

Proselytes means: people who had become Jews.

Pentecost (Greek for "the fiftieth day") was a Jewish feast, 50 days after Passover. It is the Feast of Weeks, in Hebrew "Shavuot." People gave thanks for the harvest. Later this feast also remembered the giving of the Torah at Mount Sinai. Many pilgrims came to Jerusalem for it.

Verses 2–3: In the Bible storm and fire are signs of God's nearness, for example at Mount Sinai (Exodus 19:18).

Verses 4–11: People from many countries understand the message in their own language. Many scholars see this as the opposite of the tower of Babel (Genesis 11): There the languages were confused, here people understand one another again.

Verses 5 and 10: The listeners are Jews from all over the world and people who had become Jews. The countries reach from Persia to Rome.

Verse 13: "New wine" is fresh, sweet wine. The mockers mean: They are drunk.

Christians celebrate Pentecost as the birthday of the church.

Peter's sermon at Pentecost VERSES 14–36

14 Then Peter stood up with the Eleven.
He spoke to the crowd in a loud voice:
"You men of Judea, and all of you who live in Jerusalem!
I want you to know this.
Listen to my words.
15 These people aren't drunk, as you think.
It is only the third hour of the day.
16 No, this is what God spoke through the prophet Joel:
17 'God says: In the last days I will pour out my Spirit on all flesh.
Your sons and your daughters will prophesy.
Your young men will see visions.
Your old men will dream dreams.
18 In those days I will pour out my Spirit even on my servants, men and women.
And they will prophesy.
19 I will show wonders in the sky above.
I will show signs on the earth below:
blood, fire, and clouds of smoke.
20 The sun will become dark.
The moon will become like blood.
That will happen before the great and glorious day of the Lord comes.
21 Then everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved.'
22 Men of Israel, listen to these words!
Jesus of Nazareth was a man whom God approved of in front of you.
God did mighty works, wonders, and signs through him among you.
You know this yourselves.
23 God had planned it and knew it ahead of time:
This Jesus was handed over.
And you used lawless men to crucify him and kill him.
24 But God raised him up.
God set him free from the pain of death.
It was not possible for death to hold him.
25 David says about him:
'I always saw the Lord before me.
He is at my right hand, so that nothing can shake me.
26 That is why my heart was glad, and my tongue was full of joy.
My body also will live in hope.
27 For you will not leave my soul in Hades.
You will not let your Holy One see decay.
28 You showed me the ways of life.
You will fill me with joy in your presence.'
29 Brothers, I can tell you plainly about our forefather David:
He died and was buried.
His tomb is still here with us today.
30 But David was a prophet.
He knew that God had promised him with an oath:
God would raise up one of his own descendants, the Christ.
The Christ would sit on David's throne.
31 David saw this ahead of time.
So he spoke about the resurrection of the Christ.
He said that the Christ was not left in Hades, and that his body did not see decay.
32 God raised up this Jesus.
We are all witnesses of this.
33 God has lifted him up to his right hand.
Jesus has received from the Father the Holy Spirit, as God promised.
And he has poured out what you now see and hear.
34 David himself did not go up into the heavens.
But he says:
'The Lord said to my Lord, "Sit at my right hand

35 until I make your enemies a footstool for your feet."'
36 So the whole house of Israel should know this for certain:
God has made this Jesus both Lord and Christ.
He is the Jesus whom you crucified."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Prophesy means: speak a message from God.

Verse 15: The third hour is about nine in the morning. People are not drunk that early.

Verses 17–21 quote Joel 2:28–32 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles Joel 3:1–5). Important: The Spirit comes on everyone, on sons and daughters, young and old, male and female servants. Women and men prophesy.

"All flesh" means: all people.

Verses 25–28 quote Psalm 16:8–11. Verse 30 recalls Psalm 132:11. Verses 34–35 quote Psalm 110:1.

"Hades" is the realm of the dead.

Verses 23 and 36: "You crucified" him: Peter is speaking here to people in Jerusalem who had seen Jesus a short time before. He is a Jew himself and speaks to his own people, the way the prophets called for a change of heart. Right after this he says: God forgives (verse 38).

Important: These verses give no one the right to insult Jews as "Christ killers." The church teaches: The death of Jesus must not be blamed on all the Jews of that time nor on the Jews of today (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965). The crucifixion was carried out by the Romans, the "lawless men" of verse 23.

The first people are baptized VERSES 37–41

37 When the people heard this, it cut them to the heart.
They said to Peter and the other apostles, "Brothers, what should we do?"
38 Peter said to them, "Repent!
Every one of you should be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ, so that your sins are forgiven.
And you will receive the Holy Spirit as a gift.
39 For the promise is for you and for your children.
It is also for all who are far off.
It is for everyone the Lord our God will call to himself."
40 Peter said many more words to them.
He gave witness and urged them, "Save yourselves from this crooked generation!"
41 Those who gladly accepted his message were baptized.
About 3,000 people were added to them that day.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Repent means: turn your life around toward God.

Verse 37: The listeners are deeply moved. They ask: What shall we do?

Verse 38: "Repent" means: to turn your life toward God in a new way. Baptism is the sign of this. God forgives and gives his Spirit.

Verse 39: "For all who are far off": The good news is for all people and all times.

Verse 41: About 3,000 people, all of them Jews and people who had become Jews. The first church was a Jewish community.

The churches baptize in different ways: Some baptize small children, others only people who believe themselves and decide for it. All of them appeal to the Bible.

How the first church lived VERSES 42–47

42 They kept on faithfully with the apostles' teaching and with the fellowship.
They kept on with the breaking of bread and with prayer.
43 Fear came on everyone.
The apostles did many wonders and signs.
44 All the believers were together.
They shared everything they had.
45 They sold their land and their belongings.
They gave the money to everyone who had need.
46 Every day they kept meeting in the temple, all of one mind.
They broke bread in their homes.
They ate their meals with joy and with sincere hearts.
47 They praised God, and they had favor with all the people.
Every day the Lord added to the church those who were being saved.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Fellowship means: community, sharing life together.

Verse 43: "Fear" here means awe before God, not being afraid.

Verse 42 describes four marks of the church: the apostles' teaching, the fellowship, the breaking of bread (the Lord's Supper or Eucharist) and prayer. Up to today they belong to worship.

Verses 44–45: The first Christians shared their possessions so that no one would be in need. This was voluntary (compare 5:4).

Verse 46: They kept on praying in the temple, like all devout Jews. Christians and Jews were not yet separated.

Verse 47: "Favor with all the people": The Jewish people in Jerusalem looked kindly on the church.

For today: A church lives by sharing, praying and celebrating. No one should be alone in need. If you have debts or money worries, a free debt advice or nonprofit credit counseling service can help.

ACTS

CHAPTER 3

"What I have, I give you"

A lame man is healed VERSES 1–10

1 One day Peter and John were going up to the temple.
It was the hour of prayer, the ninth hour.
2 Some people were carrying a man there.
He had been lame from birth.
Every day they put him down at the temple gate called Beautiful.

There he begged for gifts from the people going into the temple.
3 He saw Peter and John about to go into the temple.
So he asked them for a gift.
4 Peter looked straight at him, and so did John.
Peter said, "Look at us."
5 The man paid attention to them.
He expected to get something from them.
6 But Peter said, "I have no silver or gold.
But what I have, I give you.
In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, get up and walk!"
7 Peter took him by the right hand and helped him up.
At once the man's feet and ankles became strong.
8 He jumped up and stood on his feet.
He began to walk.
He went with them into the temple.
He walked and jumped and praised God.
9 All the people saw him walking and praising God.
10 They recognized him.
He was the man who used to sit and beg at the Beautiful Gate of the temple.
They were filled with wonder and amazement at what had happened to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Lame means: not able to walk.

Verse 1: Peter and John keep praying in the temple, like devout Jews. The ninth hour is about three in the afternoon, the time of the afternoon prayer.

Verse 2: At that time people with disabilities often had to live from gifts. They sat at the gates because many people passed by there.

Verses 4–6: Peter looks at the man. He sees him as a person. He has no money, but he gives him something greater.

Verse 6: "In the name of Jesus": Peter doesn't heal by his own power. Jesus heals.

Verse 8: The man leaps for joy. This reminds us of Isaiah 35:6: There the prophet says that the lame will leap like a deer.

Important: A disability is not a punishment and not a sign of missing faith. People with disabilities have the same dignity and fully belong.

Peter speaks to the people VERSES 11–26

11 The healed man held on to Peter and John.
All the people were amazed.
They ran together to them in the place called Solomon's porch.
12 When Peter saw this, he said to the people:
"You men of Israel, why are you amazed at this?
Why do you stare at us?
Do you think we made him walk by our own power or by our own goodness?
13 The God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, the God of our ancestors, has given glory to his Servant Jesus.
You handed Jesus over.
You rejected him in front of Pilate, even though Pilate had decided to set him free.
14 You rejected the Holy and Righteous One.
You asked for a murderer to be set free for you instead.
15 You killed the Prince of life.
But God raised him from the dead.
We are witnesses of this.
16 You see this man, and you know him.
Faith in the name of Jesus has made him strong.
Yes, the faith that comes through Jesus has made him completely well.
You all have seen it.
17 Now, brothers, I know that you did this in ignorance.
Your rulers did too.
18 But this is how God made his word come true.
Through all his prophets he had told ahead of time that the Christ would suffer.
19 So repent and turn back to God.
Then your sins will be blotted out.
Then times of refreshing will come from the Lord.
20 And he will send Christ Jesus, whom he chose for you long ago.
21 Jesus must stay in heaven until the time when God makes all things new again.
God spoke about this long ago through his holy prophets.
22 Moses said to our ancestors:
'The Lord God will raise up a prophet for you from among your brothers.
He will be like me.
You must listen to everything he tells you.
23 Everyone who does not listen to that prophet will be completely destroyed from among the people.'
24 All the prophets who have spoken also told about these days.
That is true of Samuel and of all the prophets after him.
25 You are the children of the prophets, and of the covenant.
God made this covenant with our ancestors.
He said to Abraham, 'All the families of the earth will be blessed through your offspring.'
26 God raised up his servant Jesus.
He sent him to you first, to bless you.
He blesses you by turning each of you away from your evil ways."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ignorance means: not knowing.

Blot out means: wipe away completely.

Verse 11: Solomon's porch was a large hall with columns at the edge of the temple square.

Verse 12: Peter says: We didn't do this. He takes no honor for himself.

Verse 13: "The God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob": Peter is speaking of the God of Israel. It is the same God in whom Jews and Christians believe.

Verses 13–15: Peter speaks harshly. But he is a Jew himself and speaks to his own people, like the prophets.

Verse 17 is very important. Peter says: "I know that you did this in ignorance." Peter doesn't accuse in order to condemn, but to invite people to turn around. As Jesus prayed on the cross: "Father, forgive them" (Luke 23:34).

Important: These verses must never be used against Jews (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965).

Verses 22–23 quote Deuteronomy 18:15, 19. Verse 25 quotes Genesis 22:18.

Verse 25: "You are the children of the prophets, and of the covenant": God's covenant with Israel still stands. Later Paul says: God does not take back his gifts and his calling (Romans 11:29).

Verse 26: God sends Jesus to Israel "first," to bless.

ACTS

Chapter 4

"We can't help telling"

Peter and John are arrested VERSES 1–4

1 Peter and John were still speaking to the people.
Then the priests, the captain of the temple, and the
Sadducees came up to them.
2 They were angry because the apostles were teaching the
people.
The apostles were telling them that in Jesus the dead
rise again.
3 So they arrested them.
It was already evening.
So they put them in custody until the next day.
4 But many of those who had heard the message believed.
The number of men grew to about 5,000.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Custody means: prison, being held by guards.

The Sadducees were a group among the temple leaders. They didn't believe in the resurrection of the dead (compare Luke 20:27). That is why it especially angers them that the apostles speak about the resurrection.

The captain of the temple was responsible for order in the temple.

Verse 4: The church grows in spite of the arrest. Only the men are counted, as was usual then. Women and children came in addition.

Peter before the council VERSES 5–22

5 The next morning the rulers, the elders, and the scribes
met together in Jerusalem.
6 Annas the high priest was there.
Caiaphas, John, and Alexander were there too, and all
the relatives of the high priest.
7 They had Peter and John stand in front of them.
They asked, "By what power did you do this?
Or in whose name did you do it?"
8 Then Peter was filled with the Holy Spirit.
He said to them, "You rulers of the people and elders of
Israel!
9 Today we are being questioned about a good deed.
We helped a man who was crippled.
You want to know how this man was healed.
10 So all of you, and all the people of Israel, should know
this:
This man stands in front of you healthy and whole.
That happened in the name of Jesus Christ of
Nazareth.
You crucified him, but God raised him from the dead.
Through Jesus this man is healthy.
11 Jesus is 'the stone that you builders thought was
worthless.
But it has become the head of the corner.'
12 There is salvation in no one else.
There is no other name under heaven given to people
by which we must be saved!"
13 The leaders saw how bold Peter and John were.
They noticed that these men were unlearned and
ordinary people.
They were amazed.
They realized that these men had been with Jesus.
14 They also saw the healed man standing there with
them.
So they could say nothing against it.
15 They ordered them to leave the council room.
Then they talked it over among themselves.
16 They said, "What should we do with these men?
They have clearly done an amazing miracle.
Everyone who lives in Jerusalem can see it.
We can't deny it.
17 But we must stop this from spreading any further
among the people.
So let's threaten them.
From now on they must not speak to anyone in this
name."
18 They called them back in.
They ordered them not to speak or teach in the name
of Jesus at all.
19 But Peter and John answered them, "You decide for
yourselves:
Is it right in God's eyes to listen to you rather than to
God?
20 We can't help telling what we have seen and heard."
21 The leaders threatened them even more.
Then they let them go.
They found no way to punish them, because of the
people.
Everyone was praising God for what had happened.
22 The man who had been healed by this miracle was more
than 40 years old.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The head of the corner means: the most important stone in a building.

Unlearned means: without schooling in the Scriptures.

The council (in Greek "Sanhedrin") was the highest Jewish authority in Jerusalem. We already know Annas and Caiaphas from the trial of Jesus (John 18).

Verse 10: "Whom you crucified": Here Peter is speaking to the leaders who had handed Jesus over to Pilate. He is not speaking to the Jewish people as a whole. The people praise God for the healing (verse 21).

Verse 11 quotes Psalm 118:22.

Verse 12: "There is salvation in no one else": For Christians Jesus is the Savior. Christians think differently about how

God deals with people of other religions. Many churches say today: God's love is greater than our understanding. Christians are to respect other religions.

Verse 13: "Unlearned" means: They had not studied with scribes. They were fishermen. But they speak boldly.

Verses 19–20: In chapter 5 the apostles say something similar again: One must obey God more than people (5:29). Later this sentence gave many people courage to stand up against injustice, also in dictatorships.

Verse 22: The man had been lame for over 40 years. That is why the miracle was so clear to everyone.

The church prays VERSES 23–31

23 After they were set free, Peter and John went back to
their own people.
They told them everything the chief priests and the
elders had said to them.
24 When the believers heard it, they all prayed to God
together.
They said, "Lord, you are God.
You made the sky, the earth, the sea, and everything in
them.
25 You spoke through your servant David.
He said: 'Why are the nations so angry?
Why do the peoples make vain plans?
26 The kings of the earth get ready to fight.
The rulers make plans together against the Lord and
against his Christ.'
27 And that is truly what happened.
Herod and Pontius Pilate came together with the
Gentiles and the people of Israel.
They came together against your holy servant Jesus,
whom you anointed.
28 They did what your power and your plan had decided
long before.
29 And now, Lord, look at their threats.
Help your servants to speak your word with great
boldness.
30 Stretch out your hand to heal.
Let signs and wonders happen through the name of
your holy Servant Jesus."
31 When they had prayed, the place where they had
gathered shook.
They were all filled with the Holy Spirit.
And they spoke the word of God boldly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Vain means: useless, in vain.

Gentiles means: people who are not Jews.

Verse 24: The church prays to the Creator. This reminds us of Psalm 146:6.

Verses 25–26 quote Psalm 2:1–2.

Verse 27: Some Bibles also have the words in this city here. These words are in some old manuscripts; the WEB doesn't have them.

The church names everyone who stood against Jesus: Herod, Pilate, the Romans and people from Israel. No single group alone carries the guilt.

Verse 29: The church doesn't ask for revenge on its opponents. It asks for courage.

For today: In fear and danger we may pray together and ask for courage.

The believers share everything VERSES 32–37

32 All the many believers were of one heart and soul.
No one said that anything he owned was his own.
They shared everything they had.
33 The apostles told about the resurrection of the Lord
Jesus with great power.
And great grace was on all of them.
34 No one among them was in need.
Those who owned land or houses sold them.
They brought the money from the sale
35 and put it at the apostles' feet.
Then it was given out to each person as he had need.
36 There was a man named Joses.
The apostles also called him Barnabas.
That name means "Son of Encouragement."
He was a Levite, born in Cyprus.
37 He owned a field.
He sold it, brought the money, and put it at the
apostles' feet.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 32: "One heart and soul": Many languages have taken this saying from this verse.

Verse 34: This reminds us of Deuteronomy 15:4: There God promises that there will be no poor among his people.

The sharing was voluntary. It was not forced, but an expression of love.

Verse 36: Joses is a form of Joseph; some Bibles call him that. "Son of Encouragement" can also be translated son of comfort. Barnabas later becomes an important companion of Paul.

A Levite belonged to the tribe of Levi. Levites helped with the service in the temple.

For today: A church in which no one suffers need is a strong sign. If you are in money trouble, you can find help from a free debt advice service or from the social services of churches, such as Catholic Charities or the Salvation Army.

ACTS

CHAPTER 5

"We must obey God rather than men"

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

The story of Ananias and Sapphira (verses 1–11) is hard to read. Two people die. The Bible doesn't say that Peter killed them or cursed them. It says that God takes lying in the church seriously.

This story gives no one the right to threaten others with punishment or death, not even in a church. If you are being put under pressure in a religious group, you can find

advice at counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse.

Ananias and Sapphira VERSES 1–11

1 There was a man named Ananias.
He and his wife Sapphira sold a piece of property.
2 He kept back part of the money for himself.
His wife knew about it.
He brought only part of the money and put it at the apostles' feet.
3 But Peter said, "Ananias, why has Satan filled your heart?
You lied to the Holy Spirit.
You kept back part of the money for the land.
4 Before you sold it, the land belonged to you, didn't it?
And after you sold it, you could do what you wanted with the money.
So why did you plan this in your heart?
You haven't lied to people, but to God."
5 When Ananias heard these words, he fell down and died.
Everyone who heard about it was filled with great fear.
6 The young men got up and wrapped up his body.
They carried him out and buried him.
7 About three hours later his wife came in.
She didn't know what had happened.
8 Peter asked her, "Tell me: Did you sell the land for this much?"
She said, "Yes, for that much."
9 But Peter said to her, "Why did the two of you agree to test the Spirit of the Lord?
Listen!
The men who buried your husband are at the door.
They will carry you out too."
10 At once she fell down at his feet and died.
The young men came in and found her dead.
They carried her out and buried her next to her husband.
11 Great fear came on the whole church.
And great fear came on everyone who heard about these things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4 is important: Ananias didn't have to give anything. The land and the money belonged to him. Sharing in the church was voluntary. His mistake was not that he kept something, but that he lied. He wanted to pretend that he had given everything.

Verse 3: "Why has Satan filled your heart": This reminds us of Judas (Luke 22:3).

Verses 5 and 10: The text doesn't say exactly why the two die. It doesn't say that Peter kills them. Many scholars see in this a warning to the young church: Honesty before God is important.

Verse 11: Here the word "church" (in Greek "ekklesia") appears for the first time in Acts. The Greek word means "assembly." In many languages the word for church comes from it.

For today: God doesn't need a show. Honesty is more important than looking good.

Many are healed VERSES 12–16

12 The apostles did many signs and wonders among the people.
The believers all met together, of one mind, in Solomon's porch.
13 None of the rest dared to join them.
But the people thought highly of them.
14 More and more people believed in the Lord and were added to them.
Crowds of men and women came.
15 People even carried the sick out into the streets.
They laid them on cots and mats.
They hoped that at least Peter's shadow would fall on some of them when he came by.
16 Crowds also came from the towns around Jerusalem.
They brought sick people and people who were tormented by unclean spirits.
And all of them were healed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: "The rest" were probably people who hesitated or were afraid. Even so, the church grows (verse 14).

Verse 14: Men and women are named explicitly.

Verse 15: People hope so much for healing that they even trust in Peter's shadow. But healing comes from God, not from Peter.

Verse 16: "Unclean spirits": At that time many illnesses were seen as the work of evil spirits. Important: Mental illnesses are not possession. They are illnesses that can be treated. Help is available from doctors and therapists. In a crisis: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The apostles are set free VERSES 17–26

17 But the high priest and all who were with him took action.
They belonged to the party of the Sadducees.
They were filled with jealousy.
18 They arrested the apostles and put them in the public prison.
19 But during the night an angel of the Lord opened the prison doors.
He led them out and said,
20 "Go and stand in the temple.
Tell the people all the words of this life."
21 When they heard this, they went into the temple at daybreak and began to teach.
The high priest and those with him came.
They called together the council and all the elders of the people of Israel.
Then they sent men to the prison to bring the apostles.
22 But the officers went to the prison, and the apostles were not there.
So they came back and reported:
23 "We found the prison shut and locked.
The guards were standing at the doors.
But when we opened them, we found no one inside!"
24 The high priest, the captain of the temple, and the chief priests heard this.
They were very confused.
They wondered what would come of this.

25 Then someone came and told them, "Look!
The men you put in prison are standing in the temple.
They are teaching the people!"
26 Then the captain went with the officers and brought the apostles back.
But they did not use force.
They were afraid that the people might stone them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Again it is the party of the Sadducees, a small group of powerful people. The people are on the side of the apostles (verse 26).

Verse 19: God can't be locked up. Neither can his messengers.

Verse 20: "All the words of this life": The good news of Jesus brings life.

"We must obey God" VERSES 27–42

27 They brought the apostles in and made them stand in front of the council.
The high priest questioned them.
28 He said, "We gave you strict orders not to teach in this name, didn't we?
But look, you have filled Jerusalem with your teaching.
And you want to bring this man's blood on us."
29 But Peter and the apostles answered, "We must obey God rather than men.
30 The God of our ancestors raised Jesus from the dead.
You killed him by hanging him on a tree.
31 God lifted him up to his right hand.
God made him Prince and Savior.
Through him God gives Israel the chance to repent and have their sins forgiven.
32 We are witnesses of these things.
The Holy Spirit is a witness too.
God has given the Holy Spirit to those who obey him."
33 When the council heard this, it cut them to the heart.
They decided to kill the apostles.
34 But a Pharisee named Gamaliel stood up in the council.
He was a teacher of the law.
All the people respected him.
He ordered that the apostles be taken outside for a little while.
35 Then he said to the council, "Men of Israel, be careful what you do to these men.
36 Some time ago Theudas rose up.
He claimed to be somebody important.
About 400 men joined him.
He was killed.
All his followers were scattered, and it came to nothing.
37 After him, Judas of Galilee rose up.
That was at the time of the census.
He got some people to follow him.
He also died, and all his followers were scattered.
38 So now I tell you: Stay away from these men!
Leave them alone!
If this plan or this work comes from people, it will fail.
39 But if it comes from God, you will not be able to stop it.
You might even find yourselves fighting against God!"
40 The council agreed with him.
They called the apostles in and had them beaten.
They ordered them not to speak in the name of Jesus.
Then they let them go.
41 The apostles left the council full of joy.
They were glad that they had been counted worthy to suffer shame for the name of Jesus.
42 Every day, in the temple and at home, they kept on teaching.
They never stopped telling the good news of Jesus, the Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Census means: counting of the people.

Verse 28: "Bring this man's blood on us" means: You want to blame us for his death. The leaders are defending themselves against this accusation.

Verse 29: "We must obey God rather than men." Later this sentence gave many people courage to resist injustice and dictatorships.

Verse 30: "Hanging him on a tree" means the cross (compare Deuteronomy 21:22–23). Here Peter is speaking to the council, not to the Jewish people.

Verse 31: God wants to give Israel repentance and forgiveness. This is an offer, not a condemnation.

Verses 34–39: Gamaliel was a famous Jewish teacher. Later Paul was his student (22:3). Gamaliel is wise and protects the apostles. This shows: Many Pharisees were open and fair.

Verses 36–37: Theudas and Judas of Galilee were men who led uprisings. Scholars disagree about exactly when Theudas appeared.

Verse 40: The apostles are beaten. Violence against people because of their faith is always wrong.

For today: Freedom of religion is a human right. No one may be persecuted because of their faith.

ACTS

CHAPTER 6

Seven helpers for the church

Seven men are chosen VERSES 1–7

1 In those days,
the number of the disciples kept growing.
Then the Hellenists complained
against the Hebrews,
because their widows were overlooked
in the daily serving of food.
2 The Twelve called the whole crowd of the disciples
together
and said,
"It is not right

for us to neglect the word of God
and serve at tables.
3 So, brothers,
choose from among you seven men
who have a good reputation,
full of the Holy Spirit and of wisdom.
We will appoint them over this task.
4 But we will keep on faithfully with prayer
and with serving the word."
5 These words pleased the whole crowd.
They chose Stephen,
a man full of faith and of the Holy Spirit,
and Philip,
Prochorus,
Nicanor,
Timon,
Parmenas,
and Nicolaus,
a man from Antioch
who had become a Jew.
6 They set these men before the apostles.
The apostles prayed
and laid their hands on them.
7 The word of God spread.
The number of the disciples in Jerusalem grew very large.
A great number of the priests also
became obedient to the faith.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "Hellenists" and "Hebrews": Both groups were Jews who believed in Jesus. The Hellenists came from other countries and spoke Greek. The Hebrews probably came from the land of Israel and spoke Aramaic.

At that time widows often had no one to take care of them. The church gave them food every day.

Verses 2–4: The apostles settle the conflict wisely: They divide up the tasks. All seven men who are chosen have Greek names. So the group that had been treated unfairly gets its own representatives.

Verse 6: Laying on hands is a sign of blessing and of giving someone a task. Many churches see here the beginning of the office of deacons, that is, helpers for the poor and needy.

Verse 7: Even many priests from the temple come to faith.

For today: If someone in the church is overlooked, it must be taken seriously and a fair solution must be found.

Stephen is arrested VERSES 8–15

8 Stephen was full of faith and power.
He did great wonders and signs among the people.
9 But some people stood up
from the synagogue called "The Libertines,"
and people from Cyrene and Alexandria,
and from Cilicia and Asia.
They argued with Stephen.
10 But they weren't able to stand against the wisdom and the Spirit
with which he spoke.
11 Then they secretly got men
to say,
"We have heard him speak blasphemous words
against Moses and God."
12 They stirred up the people,
the elders,
and the scribes.
They came at Stephen,
seized him,
and brought him to the council.
13 There they set up false witnesses
who said,
"This man never stops speaking blasphemous words
against this holy place
and the law.
14 For we have heard him say
that this Jesus of Nazareth will destroy this place
and will change the customs
which Moses handed down to us."
15 All who sat in the council
looked at him intently.
They saw his face
like the face of an angel.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Blasphemous means: insulting God.

Verse 9: "The Libertines" (that is, the freed people) were probably Jews who themselves or whose parents had been taken to Rome as slaves and later set free. These people had their own synagogue in Jerusalem.

Verses 11–13: False witnesses are used against Stephen, as with Jesus (Mark 14:56–58). The Bible itself says: The accusation is false.

Verse 14: The temple ("this holy place") and the law of Moses were very important to the Jews. That is why the accusation was serious.

Verse 15: Stephen's face shines like that of an angel. This reminds us of Moses, whose face shone when he came from God (Exodus 34:29–30).

Important: False accusations destroy people. If you are falsely accused, you may get help, for example from a lawyer or a counseling center.

ACTS

CHAPTER 7

Stephen's speech and death

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

Stephen tells the history of Israel, his own people. At the end he speaks very harshly to the members of the council (verses 51–53). He speaks like the prophets of Israel, who also often warned their people harshly. Stephen is a Jew himself.

These words are addressed to certain people in a certain situation. They must never be used against the Jewish people (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965). And Stephen himself prays for his opponents as he dies (verse 60).

Abraham, Joseph and the ancestors VERSES 1–16

1 The high priest asked, "Is this true?"
2 Stephen said, "Brothers and fathers, listen to me.
The God of glory appeared to our father Abraham.
Abraham was in Mesopotamia then, before he lived in Haran.
3 God said to him, 'Leave your land and your relatives.
Go to the land that I will show you.'
4 So Abraham left the land of the Chaldaeans and lived in Haran.
After his father died, God moved him from there to this land, where you live now.
5 God gave him no part of it as his own.
He did not even give him enough land to set his foot on.
But God promised to give it to him and to his offspring after him.
They would own it.
God promised this when Abraham still had no child.
6 God said this to him:
His offspring would live as foreigners in a strange land.
There they would be slaves.
They would be treated badly for 400 years.
7 God said, 'But I will judge the nation that makes them slaves.
After that they will come out and serve me in this place.'
8 God gave Abraham the covenant of circumcision.
Abraham became the father of Isaac.
He circumcised Isaac on the eighth day.
Isaac became the father of Jacob.
And Jacob became the father of the 12 patriarchs.
9 The patriarchs were jealous of Joseph.
They sold him as a slave into Egypt.
But God was with him.
10 God rescued him from all his troubles.
God gave him favor and wisdom with Pharaoh, the king of Egypt.
Pharaoh made him governor over Egypt and over his whole household.
11 Then a famine came over the whole land of Egypt and Canaan.
There was great suffering.
Our ancestors could not find any food.
12 Jacob heard that there was grain in Egypt.
So he sent our ancestors there.
That was their first trip.
13 On their second trip, Joseph told his brothers who he was.
And Pharaoh learned about Joseph's family.
14 Joseph sent for his father Jacob and all his relatives.
There were 75 people.
15 So Jacob went down to Egypt.
There he died, and our ancestors died too.
16 Their bodies were brought back to Shechem.
They were laid in the tomb there.
Abraham had bought that tomb with silver from the sons of Hamor of Shechem.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Stephen had been accused of speaking against Moses, the law and the temple (6:11–14). He answers by telling the history of Israel. He shows: I honor the ancestors and Moses.

Verses 2–8 recall Genesis 11–21. Verse 3 quotes Genesis 12:1. Verses 6–7 recall Genesis 15:13–14 and Exodus 3:12.

Verse 8: The "patriarchs" are the forefathers of the people of Israel.

Important: God appears to Abraham outside the land of Israel, in Mesopotamia. God is not tied to one place.

Verses 9–16 briefly tell the story of Joseph (Genesis 37–50). Joseph too was in a foreign land, and God was with him.

Verse 14: "75": That is what the Greek translation of the Old Testament says. In the Hebrew text it is 70 (Genesis 46:27).

Verse 16: Here Stephen brings different traditions together. In the Old Testament Abraham buys a tomb in Hebron (Genesis 23), and Jacob buys a piece of land in Shechem (Genesis 33:19). The WEB translates exactly what the Greek text says.

Moses VERSES 17–43

17 "The time came near for God to keep his promise to Abraham.
God had promised it with an oath.
The people grew and became very many in Egypt.
18 Then a different king came to power in Egypt.
He did not know about Joseph.
19 This king took advantage of our people.
He treated our ancestors badly.
He forced them to leave their babies outside, so that they would die.
20 At that time Moses was born.
He was very beautiful in God's eyes.
For three months he was cared for in his father's house.
21 Then he was put outside.
Pharaoh's daughter took him in.
She raised him as her own son.
22 Moses was taught all the wisdom of the Egyptians.
He was powerful in what he said and in what he did.
23 When Moses was 40 years old, he decided to visit his brothers, the people of Israel.
24 He saw an Egyptian treating one of them unfairly.
So he defended the man.
He took revenge for him and struck down the Egyptian.
25 Moses thought his brothers would understand that God was using him to rescue them.
But they didn't understand.
26 The next day he saw two of them fighting.
He tried to make peace between them.
He said, 'Men, you are brothers.
Why are you hurting each other?'
27 But the man who was hurting his neighbor pushed Moses away.
He said, 'Who made you a ruler and a judge over us?
28 Do you want to kill me, like you killed the Egyptian yesterday?'
29 When Moses heard this, he fled.
He lived as a foreigner in the land of Midian.
There he had two sons.

30 After 40 years had passed,
an angel of the Lord appeared to Moses in the
wilderness near Mount Sinai.
The angel was in the flame of a burning bush.
31 Moses saw it and was amazed at the sight.
He went closer to look.
Then he heard the voice of the Lord:
32 'I am the God of your ancestors:
the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac, and the God of
Jacob.'
Moses trembled.
He did not dare to look.
33 The Lord said to him, 'Take off your sandals.
The place where you are standing is holy ground.
34 I have seen how my people in Egypt are suffering.
I have heard them groaning.
I have come down to rescue them.
Now come, I will send you to Egypt.'
35 The people had rejected this Moses.
They had said, 'Who made you a ruler and a judge?'
But God sent him to be their ruler and their deliverer.
God did it through the angel who had appeared to
Moses in the bush.
36 Moses led them out.
He did wonders and signs in Egypt and at the Red Sea.
He did them in the wilderness for 40 years.
37 This is the same Moses who said to the people of Israel:
'The Lord our God will raise up a prophet for you from
among your brothers.
He will be like me.'
38 Moses was with the assembly in the wilderness.
He was with the angel who spoke to him on Mount
Sinai.
And he was with our ancestors.
He received living words from God to give to us.
39 But our ancestors did not want to obey him.
They rejected him.
In their hearts they wanted to go back to Egypt.
40 They said to Aaron, 'Make us gods who will lead us!
This Moses led us out of the land of Egypt.
But we don't know what has happened to him.'
41 At that time they made an idol in the shape of a calf.
They brought sacrifices to it.
They celebrated what their own hands had made.
42 But God turned away from them.
He let them serve the army of the sky.
That is what is written in the book of the prophets:
'House of Israel, did you bring me slaughtered animals
and sacrifices for 40 years in the wilderness?
43 You carried the tabernacle of Moloch.
You carried the star of your god Rephan.
These were the images you made so that you could
worship them.
So I will send you away beyond Babylon.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 17–36 tell the story of Moses (Exodus 1–14). Stephen speaks about Moses with great respect. In this way he shows: The accusation that he insults Moses is false.

Verse 19: Pharaoh had the baby boys of the Israelites killed (Exodus 1:22). That was a terrible crime.

Verse 20: "Very beautiful in God's eyes" means: God was pleased with this child.

Verse 24: Moses kills an Egyptian. The Bible tells this honestly. Afterwards Moses had to flee. Violence doesn't solve problems.

Verses 30–34 recall Exodus 3: God sees the suffering of his people and wants to rescue them.

Verse 35: A deliverer is a rescuer. Stephen shows a pattern: At first Moses was rejected, but God sent him as a deliverer. For Stephen this points to Jesus.

Verse 37 quotes Deuteronomy 18:15.

Verses 40–41 recall the golden calf (Exodus 32).

Verse 42: "The army of the sky" means the stars, which people worshiped as gods. Verses 42–43 quote Amos 5:25–27 in the Greek translation. Moloch and Rephan were names of foreign gods. A tabernacle is a tent used as a holy place.

Important: The prophets of Israel themselves called their people to turn back to God. Stephen speaks in this tradition, as part of the people.

The tent of meeting and the temple VERSES 44–53

44 "Our ancestors had the tabernacle of the testimony
with them in the wilderness.
God had spoken to Moses and told him how to make it.
Moses made it like the pattern he had seen.
45 Later our ancestors received it.
They brought it with them when they came into the
land with Joshua.
They took the land from the nations.
God drove these nations out in front of our ancestors.
The tabernacle was there until the days of David.
46 David found favor with God.
He asked to find a home for the God of Jacob.
47 But it was Solomon who built a house for God.
48 Yet the Most High does not live in temples that people
have made.
As the prophet says:
49 'The Lord says: Heaven is my throne.
The earth is a footstool for my feet.
What kind of house will you build for me?
Where is the place where I can rest?
50 Didn't my hand make all these things?'
51 You stiff-necked people!
You are uncircumcised in heart and ears!
You always resist the Holy Spirit!
You are just like your ancestors.
52 Was there any prophet your ancestors did not
persecute?
They killed the people who told ahead of time that the
Righteous One would come.
And now you have betrayed and murdered him.
53 You received the law through angels.
But you did not keep it!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 44: "The tabernacle of the testimony" is the holy tent, Israel's portable sanctuary in the wilderness (Exodus 25–27).

Verses 47–50: Stephen doesn't say that the temple is bad. He says: God is greater than any house. Solomon himself already said this when the temple was dedicated (1 Kings 8:27). Verses 49–50 quote Isaiah 66:1–2.

Verse 51: "Stiff-necked" means: stubborn, not willing to listen. "Uncircumcised in heart" is a picture from Israel's Bible: The heart is closed to God (Deuteronomy 10:16; Jeremiah 4:4). Moses and the prophets already called their own people this (Exodus 32:9).

Verse 52: "The Righteous One" is Jesus. Righteous means: living right before God.

Important: Here Stephen is speaking to the council. It is a prophetic warning within the Jewish people. It must not be read as a judgment on all Jews. Christians have often misused such verses. That was wrong.

Stephen is stoned VERSES 54–60

54 When the council heard this, it cut them to the heart.
They ground their teeth at Stephen in anger.
55 But Stephen was full of the Holy Spirit.
He looked steadily up into heaven.
He saw the glory of God.
He saw Jesus standing at the right hand of God.
56 He said, "Look!
I see the heavens open.
I see the Son of Man standing at the right hand of God!"
57 Then they shouted loudly and covered their ears.
All together they rushed at him.
58 They threw him out of the city and stoned him.
The witnesses laid their coats at the feet of a young man named Saul.
59 While they were stoning Stephen, he called out, "Lord Jesus, receive my spirit!"
60 He knelt down and cried out loudly, "Lord, don't hold this sin against them!"
After he said this, he fell asleep.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 55–56: Jesus is "standing" at the right hand of God. Usually it says that he "sits." Many scholars say: Jesus stands up to welcome Stephen.

Verse 58: Here Saul is named for the first time. Later he becomes the apostle Paul. He is present at the killing and agrees with it (8:1).

Verses 59–60: Stephen dies like Jesus: He gives his spirit to God (compare Luke 23:46) and prays for his murderers (compare Luke 23:34).

Stephen is the first martyr of the church. A martyr is a person who is killed for his or her faith. Many churches remember him on December 26.

"He fell asleep" is a picture for death. Christians hope that the dead will be raised as if from sleep.

Important: The stoning was wrong. Violence because of faith is always wrong. Stephen doesn't answer with hatred, but with forgiveness.

ACTS

CHAPTER 8

The good news comes to Samaria and Africa

The church is persecuted VERSES 1–3

1 Saul agreed to his death.
On that day a great persecution began against the church in Jerusalem.
They were all scattered throughout the regions of Judea and Samaria,
except for the apostles.
2 Devout men buried Stephen
and mourned greatly over him.
3 But Saul was destroying the church.
He went into every house,
dragged both men and women off,
and put them in prison.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: After Stephen's death many Christians have to flee from Jerusalem. The apostles stay.

Verse 2: The "devout men" were probably faithful Jews. They mourn for Stephen and bury him with dignity. Not everyone was against him.

Verse 3: Saul, who later becomes Paul, persecutes the Christians. Later he himself will say that he regrets it (1 Corinthians 15:9).

For today: People can change. Saul the persecutor becomes Paul the apostle.

Philip in Samaria VERSES 4–25

4 So those who were scattered
went around
preaching the word.
5 Philip went down to the city of Samaria
and proclaimed the Christ to them.
6 The crowds all listened
to the things that Philip said.
They heard him
and saw the signs
which he did.
7 For unclean spirits came out of many who had them,
crying with a loud voice.
Many who had been paralyzed or lame were healed.
8 And there was great joy in that city.
9 But in the city there was a man named Simon.
For a long time he had practiced sorcery
and amazed the people of Samaria.
He made himself out to be some great one.
10 They all listened to him,
from the least to the greatest.
They said,
"This man is that great power of God."
11 They listened to him
because for a long time
he had amazed them with his sorceries.
12 But then they believed Philip.
He preached the good news about God's Kingdom
and the name of Jesus Christ.
So both men and women were baptized.

13 Simon himself also believed.
He was baptized
and stayed with Philip.
When he saw the signs and great miracles
that were happening,
he was amazed.
14 The apostles in Jerusalem heard
that Samaria had received the word of God.
So they sent Peter and John to them.
15 The two came down
and prayed for them,
that they might receive the Holy Spirit.
16 For as yet he had not come on any of them.
They had only been baptized in the name of Christ
Jesus.
17 Then they laid their hands on them,
and they received the Holy Spirit.
18 Simon saw
that the Holy Spirit was given
through the laying on of the apostles' hands.
So he offered them money
19 and said,
"Give me also this power,
so that whomever I lay my hands on
may receive the Holy Spirit."
20 But Peter said to him,
"May your silver perish with you,
because you thought
you could get the gift of God with money!
21 You have no part or share in this matter,
for your heart isn't right before God.
22 So repent of this wickedness of yours,
and ask God
whether perhaps the thought of your heart
may be forgiven you.
23 For I see
that you are full of bitter poison
and bound by wrongdoing."
24 Simon answered,
"Pray for me to the Lord,
so that none of the things
which you have spoken
happen to me."
25 When Peter and John had testified
and spoken the word of the Lord,
they returned to Jerusalem.
On the way they preached the Good News
in many villages of the Samaritans.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sorcery means: magic.

Verse 5: The Samaritans were related to the Jews, but there had been hostility between them for a long time (compare John 4:9). Now the good news comes to them too. In this way what Jesus said comes true (1:8).

This Philip is one of the seven helpers from chapter 6, not the apostle Philip.

Verse 7: "Unclean spirits": At that time many illnesses were understood this way. Important: Mental illnesses are not possession. They can be treated.

Verses 9–11: Simon was a magician who made himself great. In later tradition he is called *Simon Magus*.

Verses 14–17: The apostles come from Jerusalem so that the new church is connected with the whole church. The churches understand differently how baptism and receiving the Spirit belong together. Catholic and Orthodox churches see here a link to confirmation.

Verses 18–20: Simon wants to buy God's gift. From his name comes the word simony: buying or selling church offices. God's gifts can't be bought.

Verse 22: Simon too gets a chance to turn back.

Philip and the man from Ethiopia VERSES 26–39

26 An angel of the Lord said to Philip,
"Get up,
and go toward the south
to the road
that goes down from Jerusalem to Gaza.
This is a desert."
27 Philip got up
and went.
There was a man from Ethiopia,
a eunuch.
He was a powerful official under Candace,
queen of the Ethiopians.
He was in charge of all her treasure.
He had come to Jerusalem
to worship.
28 Now he was on his way home.
He was sitting in his chariot
and reading the prophet Isaiah.
29 The Spirit said to Philip,
"Go near,
and join this chariot."
30 Philip ran to him.
He heard him
reading Isaiah the prophet out loud.
He asked,
"Do you understand
what you are reading?"
31 The man said,
"How can I,
unless someone explains it to me?"
And he begged Philip
to come up and sit with him.
32 Now the passage of the Scripture
which he was reading
was this:
"He was led as a sheep to the slaughter.
As a lamb before his shearer is silent,
so he doesn't open his mouth.
33 In his humiliation,
his judgment was taken away.
Who will tell about his generation?
For his life is taken from the earth."
34 The eunuch asked Philip,
"Who is the prophet talking about?
About himself,
or about someone else?"
35 Then Philip began to speak.
Beginning from this Scripture,
he preached to him about Jesus.
36 As they went on the way,
they came to some water.

The eunuch said,
"Here is water.
What is keeping me from being baptized?"
37 He commanded the chariot to stop.
They both went down into the water,
both Philip and the eunuch,
and Philip baptized him.
38 When they came up out of the water,
the Spirit of the Lord took Philip away.
The eunuch didn't see him any more,
for he went on his way rejoicing.
39 But Philip was found at Azotus.
He passed through the land
and preached the Good News to all the cities,
until he came to Caesarea.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eunuch means: a man who had been castrated; such men often served at royal courts.

Chariot means: a carriage pulled by horses.

Important about the numbering: The WEB has 39 verses in this chapter. Some Bibles have 40. There is an additional verse 37: Philip asks about the man's faith, and the man confesses Jesus Christ as the Son of God. This verse is missing in the oldest manuscripts. That is why the WEB leaves it out. Our verses 37–39 are verses 38–40 in those Bibles.

Verse 27: At that time Ethiopia meant the kingdom south of Egypt, in today's Sudan. Candace was a title of the queens there. Eunuchs often served at royal courts. According to Deuteronomy 23:1 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 23:2), they were not allowed to enter the assembly of the Lord. But the prophet Isaiah had promised: God will accept them too (Isaiah 56:3–5).

Verses 32–33 quote Isaiah 53:7–8 in the Greek translation. Christians understand this passage about the suffering servant of God as pointing to Jesus. In Judaism it is often related to the people of Israel.

Verse 36: "What is keeping me from being baptized?" The answer is: nothing. A man from Africa, a foreigner, a eunuch, is baptized without hesitation. No one is excluded.

Verse 39: Azotus is the old city of Ashdod. It was on the coast. Caesarea was a port city and the seat of the Roman governor.

For today: If you don't understand the Bible, you may ask. And whoever understands it should help others to understand it.

ACTS

CHAPTER 9

Saul becomes a disciple

Jesus meets Saul VERSES 1–9

1 But Saul was still breathing threats and murder
against the disciples of the Lord.
He went to the high priest
2 and asked him for letters to the synagogues of
Damascus.
If he found any there
who belonged to the Way,
whether men or women,
he wanted to bring them tied up to Jerusalem.
3 As he traveled,
he came close to Damascus.
Suddenly a light from the sky shone around him.
4 He fell to the ground
and heard a voice
saying to him,
"Saul, Saul,
why do you persecute me?"
5 He said,
"Who are you, Lord?"
The Lord said,
"I am Jesus,
whom you are persecuting.
6 But get up
and go into the city.
There you will be told
what you must do."
7 The men
who traveled with him
stood speechless.
They heard the sound,
but saw no one.
8 Saul got up from the ground.
When his eyes were opened,
he saw nothing.
They led him by the hand
and brought him into Damascus.
9 For three days he couldn't see.
He neither ate
nor drank.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: Damascus was a large city in Syria with many Jewish communities. "The Way" was one of the first names for the Christians. They followed the way of Jesus.

Verse 4: "Why do you persecute me?" Saul is persecuting the Christians. But Jesus says: You are persecuting me. Jesus is united with the people who suffer.

Verses 5–6: Some Bibles, such as the King James Version, have more words here. They are not in the oldest manuscripts. The WEB doesn't have them.

Verse 9: Three days of darkness, without food or drink. Saul has to learn to see everything in a new way.

People often speak of Paul's "conversion." But he doesn't change his religion. He remains a Jew. He recognizes Jesus as the Christ and receives a new task. That is why many people today prefer to speak of his calling.

For today: No one is too far away from God. God can change any life.

Ananias visits Saul VERSES 10–19

10 There was a disciple in Damascus named Ananias.
The Lord said to him in a vision,
"Ananias!"
He said,
"Here I am, Lord."

11 The Lord said to him,
"Get up and go to the street
which is called Straight.
In the house of Judah, ask
for a man from Tarsus
named Saul.
For he is praying.
12 And in a vision he has seen
a man named Ananias
coming in
and laying his hands on him,
so that he might see again."
13 But Ananias answered,
"Lord, I have heard from many about this man,
how much evil he did to your saints in Jerusalem.
14 And here he has authority from the chief priests
to arrest all
who call on your name."
15 But the Lord said to him,
"Go your way!
For he is my chosen instrument
to carry my name
to the nations and kings,
and the people of Israel.
16 For I will show him
how many things he must suffer for my name's sake."
17 So Ananias went
and entered the house.
He laid his hands on him
and said,
"Brother Saul,
the Lord has sent me.
He appeared to you on the road
by which you came.
He sent me so that you may see again
and be filled with the Holy Spirit."
18 Immediately something like scales fell from his eyes,
and he could see again.
He got up
and was baptized.
19 He took food
and became strong again.
Saul stayed several days with the disciples in Damascus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Instrument means: here: a tool, someone God uses.

Verse 11: The street called Straight still exists in Damascus today. Tarsus was Saul's hometown, in the south of today's Turkey.

Verses 13–14: Ananias is afraid. That is understandable. Saul was dangerous. But he obeys God anyway.

Verse 17: "Brother Saul": Ananias calls his former persecutor "brother." That is forgiveness.

Verse 18: The saying that the scales fell from someone's eyes comes from this verse.

For today: Sometimes God sends people to someone they are afraid of. Reconciliation takes courage.

Saul preaches Jesus VERSES 20–31

20 Immediately he proclaimed the Christ in the
synagogues.
He proclaimed that he is the Son of God.
21 All who heard him
were amazed and said,
"Isn't this the man
who in Jerusalem attacked those
who called on this name?
And didn't he come here
to bring them tied up to the chief priests?"
22 But Saul grew stronger and stronger.
He confused the Jews
who lived in Damascus.
For he proved to them
that this is the Christ.
23 When many days had passed,
the Jews plotted together
to kill him.
24 But Saul learned of their plot.
They watched the gates day and night
in order to kill him.
25 But his disciples took him by night
and let him down through the wall,
lowering him in a basket.
26 When Saul came to Jerusalem,
he tried
to join the disciples.
But they were all afraid of him.
They didn't believe
that he was a disciple.
27 But Barnabas took him
and brought him to the apostles.
He told them
how Saul had seen the Lord on the way,
and that the Lord had spoken to him.
And he told
how Saul had preached boldly in the name of Jesus in
Damascus.
28 From then on, Saul went in and out with them
in Jerusalem.
29 He preached boldly in the name of the Lord Jesus.
He spoke and argued with the Hellenists.
But they were trying to kill him.
30 When the brothers found out,
they brought him down to Caesarea
and sent him off to Tarsus.
31 So the churches throughout all Judea, Galilee, and
Samaria
had peace.
They were built up
and lived in the fear of the Lord.
Through the comfort of the Holy Spirit,
they kept growing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: Saul preaches in the synagogues. He speaks as a Jew to Jews.

Verses 22–23: "The Jews" here means certain opponents in Damascus, not all Jews. Saul himself is a Jew, and the disciples in Damascus were Jews too.

Verses 23–25: Paul himself tells about his escape in the basket (2 Corinthians 11:32–33).

Verses 26–27: The disciples are afraid of Saul. Barnabas, the "Son of Encouragement" (4:36), gives him a chance. He builds a bridge.

Verse 29: The Hellenists here are Greek-speaking Jews in Jerusalem.

Verse 31: Here the WEB, our English source text, has the plural "assemblies," that is, churches. Some Bibles have the singular, the church, following other manuscripts. All the churches in these regions are meant.

For today: Whoever makes a new beginning needs people like Barnabas who trust him.

Peter heals Aeneas and raises Tabitha VERSES 32–43

32 Peter went throughout all those regions.
He also came down to the saints
who lived at Lydda.
33 There he found a man named Aeneas.
He had been in bed for eight years,
because he was paralyzed.
34 Peter said to him,
"Aeneas,
Jesus Christ heals you.
Get up
and make your bed!"
Immediately he got up.
35 All who lived at Lydda and in Sharon
saw him,
and they turned to the Lord.
36 Now in Joppa there was a disciple named Tabitha,
which when translated means Dorcas.
She was full of good works
and acts of mercy.
37 In those days, she became sick
and died.
When they had washed her,
they laid her in an upper room.
38 Lydda was near Joppa.
The disciples heard
that Peter was there.
So they sent two men to him.
They begged him
to come to them without delay.
39 Peter got up
and went with them.
When he arrived,
they brought him into the upper room.
All the widows stood by him weeping.
They showed him the tunics and other garments
which Dorcas had made
while she was with them.
40 Peter sent them all out.
He knelt down
and prayed.
Then he turned to the body
and said,
"Tabitha, get up!"
She opened her eyes.
When she saw Peter,
she sat up.
41 He gave her his hand
and raised her up.
Then he called the saints and the widows
and showed them
that she was alive.
42 This became known throughout all Joppa.
And many believed in the Lord.
43 Peter stayed many days in Joppa
with a tanner named Simon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tanner means: someone who makes leather from animal skins.

Verse 32: "The saints" is a name for all Christians. Holy means: belonging to God.

Verse 34: "Jesus Christ heals you": Peter makes clear who heals.

Verse 36: Tabitha is one of the few women in the New Testament who are explicitly called a disciple. Tabitha is Aramaic, Dorcas is Greek. Both mean gazelle.

Verse 39: The widows show the clothes that Tabitha sewed for them. Her love can be seen.

Verse 40: This reminds us of Jesus and the daughter of Jairus (Mark 5:40–41).

Verse 43: A tanner worked with animal skins. According to the purity rules this was an unclean job. That Peter stays with him already prepares for chapter 10.

For today: Tabitha shows: Even simple help like sewing clothes is a service to God.

ACTS

CHAPTER 10

God shows no favoritism

Cornelius sees an angel VERSES 1–8

1 In Caesarea there was a man named Cornelius.
He was a centurion of what was called the Italian
Regiment.
2 He was a devout man
and feared God
with all his household.
He gave gifts generously to the needy among the
people
and always prayed to God.
3 At about the ninth hour of the day,
he clearly saw in a vision an angel of God.
The angel came to him
and said to him,
"Cornelius!"
4 Cornelius looked at him
and was frightened.
He said,
"What is it, Lord?"
The angel said to him,
"Your prayers and your gifts to the needy
have gone up for a memorial before God.
5 Now send men to Joppa,
and get Simon,
who is also called Peter.

6 He is staying with a tanner named Simon,
whose house is by the seaside."
7 When the angel
who spoke to him
had left,
Cornelius called two of his household servants
and a devout soldier
from among those who served him personally.
8 He explained everything to them
and sent them to Joppa.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Centurion means: a Roman officer in charge of about 100 soldiers.

Memorial means: something that keeps a person in memory.

Verse 1: Cornelius was a Roman officer, a centurion. He led about 100 soldiers. He was not a Jew.

Verse 2: Cornelius honored the God of Israel, prayed and helped the poor. Such people were called God-fearers. They often went to the synagogue, but had not become Jews.

Verse 3: The ninth hour is about three in the afternoon, the time of the Jewish afternoon prayer. Cornelius prays at the same time as devout Jews.

Verse 4: The prayers and gifts have gone up "for a memorial" before God. God has seen them and won't forget them.

Peter has a vision VERSES 9–23

9 On the next day, the men were on their journey
and came close to the city.
At about noon, Peter went up on the housetop
to pray.
10 He became hungry
and wanted to eat.
While the food was being prepared,
he fell into a trance.
11 He saw heaven opened.
Something came down to him
like a great sheet,
let down by four corners to the earth.
12 In it were all kinds of four-footed animals of the earth,
wild animals,
reptiles,
and birds of the sky.
13 A voice came to him,
"Get up, Peter,
kill and eat!"
14 But Peter said,
"Not so, Lord!
For I have never eaten anything
that is common or unclean."
15 A voice came to him again the second time,
"What God has cleansed,
you must not call unclean."
16 This happened three times.
Then immediately the sheet was taken up into heaven.
17 Peter was very puzzled
about what the vision might mean.
Just then the men
who had been sent by Cornelius
had asked their way to Simon's house.
They were standing at the gate.
18 They called out
and asked
whether Simon,
who was also called Peter,
was staying there.
19 While Peter was still thinking about the vision,
the Spirit said to him,
"Three men are looking for you.
20 Get up,
go down,
and go with them,
without doubting.
For I have sent them."
21 Peter went down to the men
and said,
"I am the one
you are looking for.
Why have you come?"
22 They said,
"Cornelius, a centurion,
a righteous man
who fears God
and is well spoken of by all the nation of the Jews,
was told by a holy angel
to invite you to his house
and to listen
to what you say."
23 So Peter invited them in
and gave them a place to stay.
On the next day Peter got up
and went with them.
Some of the brothers from Joppa went along with
him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Trance means: a state like a dream while awake.

Common means: here: not holy, not allowed by the food laws.

Verse 9: At that time flat roofs were often used as a quiet place to pray.

Verses 12–14: According to the food laws of the Torah (Leviticus 11), Jews were not allowed to eat certain animals. Peter keeps these laws, like a devout Jew.

Verse 15: "What God has cleansed, you must not call unclean." Peter soon understands: It is not only about food, but about people (verse 28).

Verse 16: Three times, as with the question "Do you love me?" (John 21).

Important: For Jews, the food laws are a valuable part of their faith up to today. This vision is not a judgment on them. It shows Peter that God is opening the door to the non-Jewish nations.

Verse 22: Cornelius is respected by the Jewish people. Jews and Romans could live well together.

Peter in the house of Cornelius VERSES 24–33

24 On the day after that, they came into Caesarea.
Cornelius was waiting for them.
He had called together his relatives
and his close friends.
25 When Peter came in,
Cornelius met him.

He fell down at his feet
and worshiped him.
26 But Peter raised him up
and said,
"Stand up!
I myself am also a man."
27 As he talked with him,
he went in.
He found many people gathered together.
28 He said to them,
"You yourselves know
that it is against the law for a Jewish man
to associate with someone of another nation
or to visit him.
But God has shown me
that I shouldn't call any man unholy or unclean.
29 That is why I came without complaint
when I was sent for.
So I ask:
Why did you send for me?"
30 Cornelius said,
"Four days ago,
I was fasting until this hour.
At the ninth hour, I was praying in my house.
Suddenly a man in bright clothing stood before me
31 and said,
'Cornelius,
your prayer is heard,
and your gifts to the needy are remembered in the
sight of God.
32 So send to Joppa
and call Simon,
who is also called Peter.
He is staying in the house of a tanner named Simon,
by the seaside.
When he comes,
he will speak to you.'
33 So I sent for you at once.
It was good of you
to come.
Now we are all here in the sight of God
to hear all things
that God has commanded you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 25–26: Peter refuses to be worshiped. No human being should be honored like God.

Verse 28: At that time many devout Jews avoided close contact with non-Jews, especially eating together, because of the purity rules. Now Peter says: No human being is unclean.

For today: "I shouldn't call any man unholy or unclean." This stands against every form of racism and exclusion.

Peter preaches VERSES 34–43

34 Then Peter began to speak
and said,
"Truly I understand now
that God doesn't show favoritism.
35 But in every nation,
he who fears him
and does what is right
is acceptable to him.
36 He sent the word to the people of Israel.
He preached the good news of peace
through Jesus Christ.
He is Lord of all.
37 You yourselves know
what happened throughout all Judea,
beginning from Galilee,
after the baptism
which John preached:
38 how God anointed Jesus of Nazareth
with the Holy Spirit and with power.
He went about doing good
and healing all
who were oppressed by the devil,
for God was with him.
39 We are witnesses of everything
he did both in the country of the Jews
and in Jerusalem.
They killed him
by hanging him on a tree.
40 God raised him up on the third day
and caused him to be seen,
41 not by all the people,
but by witnesses
who were chosen before by God:
us.
We ate and drank with him
after he rose from the dead.
42 He commanded us
to preach to the people
and to testify
that he is the one
whom God has appointed as Judge of the living and the
dead.
43 All the prophets testify about him
that through his name everyone
who believes in him
will receive forgiveness of sins."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Favoritism means: treating some people better than others.

Verses 34–35 contain one of the most important sentences in Acts: God doesn't show favoritism. Origin, nation and skin color make no difference to God.

Verse 36: "He is Lord of all": Jesus doesn't belong to only one people.

Verse 38: A short summary of Jesus' life: He did good and healed.

Verse 39: "They" are those who had Jesus executed. Here Peter is not speaking to Jews, but to Romans.

Verse 42: The words *the living and the dead* are also found in the creeds of the churches.

The Holy Spirit comes on non-Jews VERSES 44–48

44 While Peter was still speaking these words,
the Holy Spirit fell on all
who heard the word.
45 The believers of the circumcision
who had come with Peter
were amazed,

because the gift of the Holy Spirit was also poured out
on the Gentiles.
46 For they heard them
speaking in other languages
and praising God.
Then Peter said,
47 "Can anyone forbid these people
from being baptized with water?
They have received the Holy Spirit
just like us."
48 He commanded
that they be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ.
Then they asked him
to stay some days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 45: "The believers of the circumcision" are Jewish Christians. "Gentiles" here simply means people from the other nations who are not Jewish. The word is not an insult.

Verses 44–46: This is like a second Pentecost. God gives his Spirit also to people who are not Jews. God himself opens the door, even before they are baptized.

Verse 47: Peter asks: "Can anyone forbid these people from being baptized with water?" No one may exclude people whom God has accepted.

For today: The church is there for all people, from all nations and cultures.

ACTS

Chapter 11

For the first time they are called "Christians"

Peter explains himself in Jerusalem VERSES 1–18

1 The apostles and the brothers in Judea heard
that the Gentiles had also received the word of God.
2 When Peter came up to Jerusalem,
those who were of the circumcision argued with him.
3 They said,
"You went in to uncircumcised men
and ate with them!"
4 But Peter began
and explained everything to them in order.
He said,
5 "I was in the city of Joppa
praying.
In a trance I saw a vision:
Something came down
like a great sheet,
let down from heaven by four corners.
It came right down to me.
6 I looked at it closely
and studied it.
I saw the four-footed animals of the earth,
wild animals,
creeping things,
and birds of the sky.
7 I also heard a voice
saying to me,
'Get up, Peter,
kill and eat!'
8 But I said,
'Not so, Lord,
for nothing unholy or unclean
has ever entered into my mouth.'
9 But a voice answered me the second time out of heaven,
'What God has cleansed,
don't you call unclean.'
10 This happened three times.
Then everything was drawn up again into heaven.
11 Immediately three men stood in front of the house
where I was.
They had been sent to me from Caesarea.
12 The Spirit told me
to go with them
without discriminating.
These six brothers also came with me,
and we went into the man's house.
13 He told us
how he had seen the angel standing in his house.
The angel said to him,
'Send to Joppa
and get Simon,
who is called Peter.
14 He will speak words to you
by which you will be saved,
you and all your household.'
15 As I began to speak,
the Holy Spirit fell on them,
just as on us at the beginning.
16 I remembered the word of the Lord,
how he said,
'John baptized in water,
but you will be baptized in the Holy Spirit.'
17 So if God gave them the same gift as us,
when we believed in the Lord Jesus Christ,
who was I
that I could stand in God's way?"
18 When they heard these things,
they became quiet.
They praised God
and said,
"Then God has also granted to the Gentiles
repentance to life!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: "Those who were of the circumcision" are Jewish Christians for whom the Torah was very important.

Verse 3: The accusation is: Peter ate with non-Jews. For devout Jews this was a big problem because of the purity rules.

Verse 4: Peter doesn't get angry. He calmly explains what happened. That is a good way to settle a conflict.

Verse 12: "Without discriminating" means: without making a difference between people.

Verse 16 recalls 1:5.

Verse 18: The church in Jerusalem listens, changes its mind and praises God. That is a beautiful example: People can learn something new together.

"Gentiles" means people from the non-Jewish nations. The word is not an insult here.

The church in Antioch VERSES 19–26

19 Those who were scattered
by the persecution that arose after Stephen's death
traveled as far as Phoenicia,
Cyprus, and Antioch.
But they spoke the word to no one except Jews.
20 But some of them were men from Cyprus and Cyrene.
When they came to Antioch,
they also spoke to the Hellenists
and preached the good news about the Lord Jesus.
21 The hand of the Lord was with them.
A great number believed
and turned to the Lord.
22 The news about them came to the ears of the church in Jerusalem.
So they sent Barnabas to Antioch.
23 When he arrived
and saw the grace of God,
he was glad.
He encouraged them all
to remain close to the Lord with a firm heart.
24 For he was a good man,
full of the Holy Spirit and of faith.
And many people were added to the Lord.
25 Barnabas went to Tarsus
to look for Saul.
26 When he had found him,
he brought him to Antioch.
For a whole year they met with the church
and taught many people.
The disciples were first called Christians in Antioch.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: Phoenicia is today's Lebanon. Antioch was a large city in Syria, today Antakya in Turkey. At that time it was one of the largest cities in the Roman Empire.

Verse 20: The Hellenists here are Greek-speaking people. Non-Jews are probably meant here too. Some Bibles have Greeks, following other manuscripts.

Verses 23–24: Barnabas sees God's grace and is glad. He encourages people. He is "a good man."

Verses 25–26: Barnabas brings Saul to Antioch. Antioch becomes the starting point of Paul's great journeys.

Verse 26: "Christians" means: people who belong to Christ. Perhaps at first it was a nickname given by others.

For today: A church in which people of different backgrounds live together is a gift.

Help for the Christians in Judea VERSES 27–30

27 In those days,
prophets came down from Jerusalem to Antioch.
28 One of them was named Agabus.
He stood up
and showed through the Spirit
that there would be a great famine all over the world.
It came in the days of Claudius.
29 So the disciples decided
that each of them,
as much as he was able,
should send relief to the brothers who lived in Judea.
30 They did this.
They sent the help to the elders
by the hands of Barnabas and Saul.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Relief means: help for people in need.

Verse 28: Claudius was Roman emperor from AD 41 to 54. In his time there were several severe famines in different regions. "All over the world" here means the Roman Empire.

Verse 29: The young church in Antioch helps the church in Jerusalem. Each gives as much as he can.

Verse 30: "The elders" were the leaders of the church in Jerusalem.

For today: Christians help one another across borders. Church relief agencies all over the world still work this way today.

ACTS

CHAPTER 12

Peter is set free from prison

James is killed, Peter is arrested VERSES 1–5

1 About that time King Herod began to attack some
people of the church.
He wanted to harm them.
2 He had James, the brother of John, killed with the
sword.
3 He saw that this pleased the Jews.
So he arrested Peter too.
This happened during the Feast of Unleavened Bread.
4 After Herod arrested Peter, he put him in prison.
He had four squads of soldiers guard him.
Each squad had four soldiers.
Herod planned to bring Peter out to the people after
the Passover.
5 So Peter was kept in prison.
But the church kept praying hard to God for him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Unleavened bread means: bread made without yeast, eaten at Passover.

Verse 1: This Herod is Herod Agrippa I, a grandson of Herod the Great. He was king over Judea from AD 41 to 44. He worked closely with the Romans.

Verse 2: James is one of the Twelve, a son of Zebedee. He is the first apostle to be killed for his faith.

Verse 3: "The Jews" here means people in Jerusalem who were against the Christians, probably mainly influential circles. Not all Jews. After all, the Christians in Jerusalem were Jews themselves.

Verses 3–4: The Feast of Unleavened Bread belongs to the feast of Passover. This reminds us of the arrest of Jesus, which also happened at Passover.

Verse 5: The church can't free Peter. But it prays.

Important: Killing people because of their faith is a crime.

An angel sets Peter free VERSES 6–19

6 It was the night before Herod planned to bring him out.
Peter was sleeping between two soldiers.
He was tied with two chains.
Guards stood at the door and watched the prison.
7 Suddenly an angel of the Lord stood next to Peter.
A light shone in the cell.
The angel hit Peter on the side and woke him up.
He said, "Get up quickly!"
The chains fell off Peter's hands.
8 The angel said to him, "Get dressed and put on your sandals."
Peter did it.
The angel said to him, "Put on your coat and follow me."
9 Peter went out and followed him.
He didn't know that what the angel was doing was really happening.
He thought he was seeing a vision.
10 They walked past the first guard and the second guard.
Then they came to the iron gate that leads into the city.
It opened for them by itself.
They went out and walked along one street.
Suddenly the angel left him.
11 Then Peter came to his senses.
He said, "Now I really know it:
The Lord has sent his angel.
He has rescued me from Herod's power.
And he has rescued me from everything the Jewish people were expecting."
12 When Peter understood this, he went to the house of Mary.
She was the mother of John, who was also called Mark.
Many people had gathered there and were praying.
13 Peter knocked at the door of the gate.
A servant girl named Rhoda came to answer.
14 She recognized Peter's voice.
She was so happy that she didn't open the gate.
Instead she ran inside.
She told them that Peter was standing at the gate.
15 They said to her, "You are crazy!"
But she kept saying that it was true.
They said, "It is his angel."
16 But Peter kept on knocking.
When they opened the gate, they saw him.
They were amazed.
17 He waved his hand to tell them to be quiet.
He told them how the Lord had led him out of the prison.
He said, "Tell James and the brothers about this."
Then he left and went to another place.
18 In the morning there was a great stir among the soldiers.
What had happened to Peter?
19 Herod searched for Peter, but he could not find him.
He questioned the guards.
Then he ordered them to be put to death.
After that Herod went down from Judea to Caesarea and stayed there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: Peter sleeps peacefully, even though he is to be executed the next day. He trusts God.

Verse 11: "Everything the Jewish people were expecting": This means the people who supported Herod and were waiting for the execution. It is not a judgment on all Jews.

Verse 12: Mary is the mother of John Mark. Her house is a meeting place of the church. Women played an important role in the first church. Many think that John Mark is the author of the Gospel of Mark.

Verses 13–16: An almost funny scene: The church prays for Peter, but when he is standing at the door, no one believes the servant girl Rhoda. She was right.

Verse 15: "It is his angel": At that time some people believed that every person has a guardian angel (compare Matthew 18:10).

Verse 17: James here is a different James: the brother of Jesus. He becomes a leader of the church in Jerusalem.

Verse 19: The guards are executed. That was cruel Roman law: Guards answered with their lives for their prisoners.

The death of Herod VERSES 20–25

20 Herod was very angry with the people of Tyre and Sidon.
They came to him together.
First they made Blastus their friend.
Blastus was the king's personal helper.
Then they asked for peace,
because their country got its food from the king's country.
21 On a set day, Herod put on his royal clothes.
He sat on his throne and gave a speech to them.
22 The people shouted, "This is the voice of a god, not of a man!"
23 At once an angel of the Lord struck Herod down,
because he did not give the glory to God.
Worms ate him, and he died.
24 But the word of God kept growing and spreading.
25 Barnabas and Saul finished their service and returned to Jerusalem.
They took John with them, who was also called Mark.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: Tyre and Sidon were trading cities by the sea, in today's Lebanon. They needed grain from Herod's land.

Verses 22–23: Herod lets himself be celebrated like a god. He doesn't object. This is very different from Peter, who said: "I myself am also a man" (10:26).

Verse 23: The Jewish historian Josephus also reports that in AD 44, after a celebration, Herod Agrippa suddenly became very ill and died.

Verse 24: The persecutor dies, but the word of God keeps on growing.

Verse 25: Many old manuscripts say that they returned from Jerusalem, not to Jerusalem. The WEB has "to Jerusalem." Barnabas and Saul had brought the help to Jerusalem (11:30).

For today: No human being is God. Whoever has power should stay humble.

ACTS

Chapter 13

The first great journey of Paul and Barnabas

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

In this chapter it sometimes says that "the Jews" opposed Paul (verses 45 and 50). Certain people in a certain city are meant. At the same time the text tells: Many Jews came to faith (verse 43). Paul and Barnabas were Jews themselves and preached first in synagogues.

No verse of this chapter may be used against the Jewish people. God has not rejected his people Israel (Romans 11:1–2).

Barnabas and Saul are sent out VERSES 1–3

1 In the church at Antioch there were some prophets and teachers.
They were Barnabas, Simeon (who was called Niger), and Lucius from Cyrene.
There was also Manaen, who had grown up with Herod the tetrarch, and there was Saul.
2 They were serving the Lord and fasting.
Then the Holy Spirit said, "Set apart Barnabas and Saul for me.
I have called them to do a work."
3 So they fasted and prayed.
They laid their hands on Barnabas and Saul and sent them on their way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tetrarch means: a ruler over part of a country.

Verse 1: The leadership of the church in Antioch is very mixed. Niger is Latin and means "black." Simeon perhaps came from Africa, like Lucius from Cyrene in today's Libya. Manaen came from the circle of the royal court.

"Herod the tetrarch" is Herod Antipas, who had John the Baptizer killed.

Verses 2–3: The church prays and fasts. Then it sends the two out. Here Paul's first great journey begins.

On the island of Cyprus VERSES 4–12

4 The Holy Spirit had sent the two men out.
They went down to Seleucia.
From there they sailed to Cyprus.
5 When they arrived in Salamis, they proclaimed God's word in the synagogues of the Jews.
John was with them as their helper.
6 They traveled across the whole island to Paphos.
There they met a sorcerer.
He was a Jew and a false prophet.
His name was Bar Jesus.
7 He was with the proconsul, Sergius Paulus.
Sergius Paulus was a man of understanding.
He sent for Barnabas and Saul.
He wanted to hear the word of God.
8 But Elymas the sorcerer worked against them.
(That is what his name means.)
He tried to turn the proconsul away from the faith.
9 Then Saul, who is also called Paul, was filled with the Holy Spirit.
He looked straight at Elymas
10 and said, "You son of the devil!
You are full of every kind of lie and trick.
You are an enemy of everything that is right.
Will you never stop twisting the straight ways of the Lord?
11 Now the hand of the Lord is against you.
You will be blind.
For a season you will not see the sun!"
At once a mist and darkness came over him.
He went around looking for someone to lead him by the hand.
12 The proconsul saw what had happened.
Then he believed.
He was amazed at the teaching about the Lord.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Proconsul means: a Roman governor of a province.

Verse 4: Cyprus was Barnabas' home (4:36).

Verse 5: "John" is John Mark (12:25).

Verse 7: Sergius Paulus was the Roman governor of Cyprus, a proconsul.

Verse 9: From here on Saul is mostly called Paul. He probably always had two names: Saul (Hebrew) and Paul (Latin). That was common at the time.

Verses 10–11: Paul speaks very sharply. But the blindness is only "for a season." It reminds us of Paul himself, who was blind for three days after he met Jesus (9:8–9).

Important: That Bar Jesus was a Jew is only a piece of information here. His fault was his deception, not his origin.

Paul preaches in Antioch of Pisidia VERSES 13–41

13 Paul and the men with him set sail from Paphos.
They came to Perga in Pamphylia.
There John left them and went back to Jerusalem.
14 They traveled on from Perga and came to Antioch in Pisidia.
On the Sabbath day they went into the synagogue and sat down.
15 First the law and the prophets were read aloud.
Then the leaders of the synagogue sent them a message:
"Brothers, if you have a word of encouragement for the people, please speak."
16 Paul stood up and motioned with his hand.
He said, "Men of Israel, and you others who fear God,

listen!
17 The God of this people chose our ancestors.
He made the people great while they lived as foreigners in the land of Egypt.
With his raised arm he led them out of Egypt.
18 For about 40 years he put up with them in the wilderness.
19 He destroyed seven nations in the land of Canaan.
He gave their land to our people as their own for about 450 years.
20 After that he gave them judges until the time of Samuel the prophet.
21 Then the people asked for a king.
So God gave them Saul, the son of Kish.
Saul was from the tribe of Benjamin.
He was king for 40 years.
22 Then God removed Saul.
He made David their king.
God said about David:
'I have found David, the son of Jesse.
He is a man after my heart.
He will do everything I want.'
23 God brought salvation to Israel from David's offspring, as he had promised.
24 Before he came, John preached to the people of Israel.
He told them to repent and be baptized.
25 When John was coming to the end of his work, he said:
'Who do you think I am?
I am not the one.
But look, someone is coming after me.
I am not even good enough to untie his sandals.'
26 Brothers, you descendants of Abraham's family, and you others who fear God!
God has sent this message of salvation to you.
27 Those who live in Jerusalem, and their rulers, didn't recognize Jesus.
They also didn't understand the words of the prophets.
Those words are read aloud every Sabbath.
But when they condemned Jesus, they made those words come true.
28 They found no reason to sentence him to death.
But they still asked Pilate to have him killed.
29 They did everything that was written about him.
Then they took him down from the tree and laid him in a tomb.
30 But God raised him from the dead.
31 For many days he appeared to those who had come up with him from Galilee to Jerusalem.
They are now his witnesses to the people.
32 We are bringing you good news.
God made a promise to our ancestors.
33 Now he has kept this promise for us, their children.
He did it by raising up Jesus.
That is also what is written in the second psalm:
'You are my Son.
Today I have become your father.'
34 God raised him from the dead.
He will never go back to decay.
God said about this:
'I will give you the holy and sure blessings of David.'
35 That is why he also says in another psalm:
'You will not allow your Holy One to see decay.'
36 David served God's plan in his own time.
Then he fell asleep.
He was buried with his ancestors, and his body saw decay.
37 But the one whom God raised up saw no decay.
38 So, brothers, you should know this:
We tell you that through this man your sins can be forgiven.
39 Through him everyone who believes is justified from all things.
The law of Moses could not justify you from these things.
40 So be careful!
Do not let happen to you what the prophets said:
41 'Look, you scoffers!
Wonder, and then die!
I am doing a work in your days.
You would never believe it, even if someone told you about it.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Justified means: made right with God, set free from guilt.

Scoffers means: people who mock.

Verse 13: The text doesn't say why John Mark goes back. Later there is a dispute about it (15:36–38).

Verse 14: This Antioch is in Pisidia, in today's Turkey. It is not the Antioch in Syria.

Verse 15: This is how a service in the synagogue went: a reading from the Torah and the Prophets, then an explanation. Guests were allowed to speak. It is still like this in many synagogues today.

Verse 16: Paul is speaking to Jews and to God-fearers, that is, non-Jews who honor the God of Israel.

Verses 17–22 briefly tell the history of Israel. Paul speaks lovingly of "our ancestors."

Verse 19: In the WEB, the figure "about 450 years" stands in this verse. Other Bibles put the number in verse 20 and relate it to the time of the judges.

Verse 23: Some Bibles name Jesus explicitly here as the Savior. The WEB only says: God has brought salvation to Israel. Jesus is meant.

Verse 22 combines 1 Samuel 13:14 and Psalm 89:20 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 89:21).

Verses 27–28: Paul names "those who live in Jerusalem, and their rulers." He also says: They didn't recognize him. It is not an accusation against all Jews.

Verse 33 quotes Psalm 2:7. Verse 34 quotes Isaiah 55:3. Verse 35 quotes Psalm 16:10. Verse 41 quotes Habakkuk 1:5.

Verse 39: "Justified" means: accepted by God, free from guilt. This becomes a big theme in Paul's letters.

The message goes to all nations VERSES 42–52

42 The Jews went out of the synagogue.
Then the Gentiles begged Paul and Barnabas to speak about these things to them on the next Sabbath.
43 When the meeting in the synagogue was over, many Jews followed Paul and Barnabas.
Many devout proselytes did too.
Paul and Barnabas talked with them.
They urged them to keep living in the grace of God.

44 On the next Sabbath almost the whole city came
together to hear the word of God.
45 But when the Jews saw the crowds, they became very
jealous.
They spoke against what Paul said, and they insulted
him.
46 Paul and Barnabas spoke out boldly.
They said, "We had to tell God's word to you first.
But you push it away.
You show that you do not think you are worthy of
eternal life.
So now we are turning to the Gentiles.
47 This is what the Lord has commanded us:
'I have made you a light for the Gentiles.
You will bring salvation to the farthest parts of the
earth.'"
48 When the Gentiles heard this, they were glad.
They praised the word of God.
And as many as were appointed to eternal life believed.
49 The Lord's word spread through the whole region.
50 But the Jews stirred up the devout women of high
standing and the leading men of the city.
They started to persecute Paul and Barnabas.
They threw them out of their region.
51 So Paul and Barnabas shook the dust off their feet as a
sign against them.
They went on to Iconium.
52 And the disciples were filled with joy and with the Holy
Spirit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 42: "Gentiles" means people from the non-Jewish nations. The word is not an insult here.

Verse 43: Many Jews come to faith. This is important: It is not "the Jews" who reject the message. Some of them accept it, others don't.

Verse 45: The jealousy probably has to do with the large crowds of non-Jews. Certain people in this city are meant.

Verse 46: To the Jews "first": For Paul Israel remains God's first people. Later too, in every city he will go to the synagogue first.

Verse 47 quotes Isaiah 49:6.

Verse 48: "As many as were appointed to eternal life": Christians have thought a lot about this sentence. It stresses: Faith is a gift of God. The churches understand it in different ways.

Verse 51: Shaking the dust off one's feet was a sign: We let you go. Jesus had told his disciples to do this (Luke 9:5).

Important: In history Christians often used such verses against Jews. That was wrong. God has not rejected his people (Romans 11:1–2, 29).

ACTS

CHAPTER 14

"We also are men"

In Iconium VERSES 1–7

1 In Iconium, they went together
into the synagogue of the Jews.
They spoke in such a way
that a great crowd of both Jews and Greeks
believed.
2 But the Jews
who did not believe
stirred up the Gentiles against the brothers
and made them angry.
3 So they stayed there a long time.
They spoke boldly, trusting in the Lord.
He confirmed the word of his grace
by letting signs and wonders be done by their hands.
4 But the people of the city were divided.
Some sided with the Jews,
and some with the apostles.
5 Some of both the Gentiles and the Jews,
with their rulers,
made a violent attempt
to mistreat and stone them.
6 The apostles became aware of it
and fled to the cities of Lycaonia,
Lystra and Derbe,
and the surrounding region.
7 There they preached the Good News.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Iconium is today's Konya in Turkey.

Verse 1: Many Jews and Greeks come to faith.

Verse 2: The text speaks of the Jews "who did not believe." It is about some of the Jews in Iconium, not all of them.

Verse 3: "So": Precisely because there was opposition, they stayed and encouraged the new believers.

Verse 4: Paul and Barnabas are called "apostles" here. The word means "messengers." Here it is used more widely than only for the Twelve.

Verse 5: Gentiles and Jews stand together against the apostles. It is not a conflict of Jews against Christians.

In Lystra VERSES 8–20

8 At Lystra a man was sitting
who couldn't use his feet.
He had been lame from birth
and had never walked.
9 He was listening to Paul speaking.
Paul looked straight at him.
He saw
that the man had faith
to be made well.
10 So Paul said with a loud voice,
"Stand upright on your feet!"
The man leaped up
and walked.
11 When the crowd saw
what Paul had done,

they shouted in the language of Lycaonia,
"The gods have come down to us
in the likeness of men!"
12 They called Barnabas "Jupiter,"
and Paul "Mercury,"
because he was the chief speaker.
13 The priest of Jupiter,
whose temple was in front of their city,
brought oxen and garlands to the gates.
Together with the crowds,
he wanted to make a sacrifice.
14 But when the apostles Barnabas and Paul heard of it,
they tore their clothes.
They rushed into the crowd,
crying out,
15 "Men, why are you doing these things?
We also are men of the same nature as you.
We bring you good news:
You should turn from these useless things
to the living God.
He made the sky, the earth, the sea,
and all that is in them.
16 In the generations gone by,
he allowed all the nations
to walk in their own ways.
17 Yet he didn't leave himself without witness.
He did good.
He gave you rains from the sky
and fruitful seasons.
He filled our hearts with food and gladness."
18 Even though they said these things,
they could hardly stop the crowds
from making a sacrifice to them.
19 But then some Jews came there
from Antioch and Iconium.
They persuaded the crowds.
They stoned Paul
and dragged him out of the city.
They thought
that he was dead.
20 But as the disciples stood around him,
he got up
and went into the city.
On the next day he went with Barnabas to Derbe.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Garlands means: wreaths of flowers.

Verses 8–10: The healing reminds us of the healing of the lame man by Peter (3:1–10).

Verse 12: The WEB uses the Roman names Jupiter and Mercury. In Greek they are called Zeus and Hermes. Hermes was considered the messenger of the gods; that is why they took Paul, the speaker, for him.

Verse 14: Tearing one's clothes was a sign of horror.

Verses 15–17: Here Paul speaks to people who don't know the Bible. He doesn't speak about Moses, but about creation: Rain, harvest, food and joy show that there is a good God.

Verse 15: "We also are men": No preacher and no leader should let himself be worshiped like a god.

Verse 19: Paul is stoned. Later he tells about it himself (2 Corinthians 11:25). "Some Jews" means a certain group, not the Jewish people.

Important: How quickly a crowd can turn from admiration to violence! Violence against people is always wrong.

Back to Antioch VERSES 21–28

21 They preached the Good News to that city too
and made many disciples.
Then they returned to Lystra, Iconium, and Antioch.
22 They strengthened the disciples
and encouraged them
to continue in the faith.
They said
that through many hardships
we must enter into God's Kingdom.
23 They appointed elders for them in every church.
They prayed with fasting
and entrusted them to the Lord
in whom they had believed.
24 They passed through Pisidia
and came to Pamphylia.
25 When they had spoken the word in Perga,
they went down to Attalia.
26 From there they sailed to Antioch.
There they had been entrusted to the grace of God
for the work
which they had now completed.
27 When they had arrived,
they gathered the church together.
They reported all the things
that God had done with them.
And they told
that he had opened a door of faith to the nations.
28 They stayed there with the disciples for a long time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21: Paul and Barnabas courageously return to the cities where they had been persecuted. They don't leave the young churches alone.

Verse 22: Being a Christian doesn't protect you from difficulties. But God is there in hard times too.

Verse 23: "Elders" were the leaders of the churches. Later the church offices developed from them.

Verse 26: This ends Paul's first great journey. It probably lasted one to two years.

Verse 27: Paul and Barnabas tell that God "had opened a door of faith to the nations." That is the heart of this journey.

For today: A church rejoices together about what God does.

ACTS

CHAPTER 15

The meeting of the apostles in Jerusalem

A dispute about circumcision VERSES 1–5

1 Some men came down from Judea.
They taught the brothers, "You must be circumcised,

as Moses taught.
If you are not, you can't be saved."
2 Paul and Barnabas disagreed strongly with them.
They argued a lot with them.
So the brothers chose Paul, Barnabas, and some others of them.
They were to go up to Jerusalem to the apostles and elders and talk about this question.
3 The church sent them on their way.
They traveled through Phoenicia and Samaria.
There they told how the Gentiles had turned to God.
This made all the brothers very happy.
4 When they arrived in Jerusalem, the church welcomed them.
So did the apostles and the elders.
Paul and Barnabas told them everything God had done through them.
5 But some believers stood up.
They belonged to the party of the Pharisees.
They said, "The Gentiles must be circumcised.
They must be told to keep the law of Moses."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The question was: Do people from other nations first have to become Jews, that is, be circumcised and keep the whole Torah, in order to be Christians?

Circumcision is the sign of God's covenant with Abraham (Genesis 17). It is still very important for Jews today.

Verse 5: Pharisees also belonged to the church. Their concern was sincere: They wanted to stay faithful to God's law.

For today: There are conflicts in the church too. What matters is how they are settled: People come together, listen to one another and seek God's will together.

Peter and James speak VERSES 6–21

6 The apostles and the elders met together to look into this matter.
7 They talked about it for a long time.
Then Peter stood up and said to them, "Brothers, you know that some time ago God made a choice among you.
He chose me to tell the nations the word of the Good News, so that they would believe.
8 God knows every heart.
He gave witness about them.
He gave them the Holy Spirit, just as he gave it to us.
9 He made no difference between us and them.
He made their hearts clean through faith.
10 So why are you testing God now?
Why do you want to put a yoke on the neck of the disciples?
Neither our ancestors nor we were able to carry it.
11 No, we believe that we are saved through the grace of the Lord Jesus, just as they are."
12 The whole crowd became quiet.
They listened to Barnabas and Paul.
The two told them about the signs and wonders God had done through them among the nations.
13 When they had finished speaking, James answered, "Brothers, listen to me.
14 Simeon has told us how God first came to the nations.
God wanted to choose a people from them for his name.
15 This agrees with the words of the prophets.
It is written:
16 'After this I will return.
I will build up again the tabernacle of David, which has fallen down.
I will build up again its ruins.
I will set it up again,
17 so that the rest of the people may seek the Lord.
All the Gentiles who are called by my name will seek him.
That is what the Lord says, who does all these things.'
18 God has known all his works from eternity.
19 So this is my judgment:
We should not make it hard for the Gentiles who turn to God.
20 Instead we should write to them.
They should stay away from what is made unclean by idols.
They should stay away from sexual immorality.
They should not eat what is strangled, and they should not eat blood.
21 For a very long time, in every city there have been people who preach Moses.
His books are read aloud in the synagogues every Sabbath."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Yoke means: a wooden bar put on the necks of animals that pull a load.

Strangled means: here: meat from animals killed without letting the blood drain out.

Verses 7–9: Peter recalls Cornelius (chapter 10). God gave non-Jews the Spirit, without circumcision.

Verse 10: A "yoke" is a piece of wood with which animals pull a cart. Peter means: You are putting a burden on the new Christians.

Important: For devout Jews the Torah is not a burden, but a gift and a joy (Psalm 119). Here Peter does not say that the law is bad. He says: Salvation comes by grace, for Jews and non-Jews alike (verse 11).

Verse 13: James is the brother of Jesus and a leader of the church in Jerusalem.

Verse 14: "Simeon" is Simon Peter, with his Hebrew name.

Verses 16–17 quote Amos 9:11–12 in the Greek translation.

Verse 20: These four rules recall rules for foreigners who lived among Israel (Leviticus 17–18). In this way Jewish and non-Jewish Christians could eat and live together.

Verse 21: James respects the Torah and the synagogue.

The letter to the churches VERSES 22–33

22 Then the apostles and the elders and the whole church decided to choose some men from among them.
They would send them to Antioch with Paul and Barnabas.
They chose Judas, who was called Barsabbas, and Silas.
Both were leaders among the brothers.
23 They gave them a letter.
It said:
"From the apostles, the elders, and the brothers.

To the brothers from the Gentiles in Antioch, Syria,
and Cilicia: Greetings!
24 We have heard that some people from our group came
to you.
They upset you with what they said.
They troubled your souls.
They said, 'You must be circumcised and keep the law.'
But we did not give them any such orders.
25 So we came together and all agreed.
We decided to choose some men and send them to you.
They come with our dear friends Barnabas and Paul.
26 Barnabas and Paul have risked their lives for the name
of our Lord Jesus Christ.
27 So we are sending Judas and Silas.
They will tell you the same things in person.
28 It seemed good to the Holy Spirit, and to us, not to put
any heavier burden on you.
You only need to do these necessary things:
29 Stay away from food sacrificed to idols.
Do not eat blood.
Do not eat things strangled.
And stay away from sexual immorality.
If you keep away from these things, you will do well.
Farewell."
30 So the men were sent off and went to Antioch.
There they gathered all the people together and gave
them the letter.
31 The people read it.
They were glad because it encouraged them.
32 Judas and Silas were prophets too.
They said many things to encourage the brothers and
make them strong.
33 They stayed there for some time.
Then the brothers sent them back in peace to the
apostles.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: The whole church takes part in the decision. They consult together.

Verse 28: "It seemed good to the Holy Spirit, and to us": The church trusts that God guided it in its decision.

Verse 29: "Things strangled" and "blood" mean meat from animals whose blood has not been drained out. According to the Bible, blood, the sign of life, belongs to God (Leviticus 17:11).

Verse 31: The letter brings joy. The new Christians don't have to become Jews in order to belong to Jesus.

This meeting is often called the Council of Jerusalem. It probably took place around AD 48 or 49.

Important: For Christians of Jewish background the Torah remained important. The Council of Jerusalem does not declare Judaism outdated. It opens the door for the nations.

Paul and Barnabas separate VERSES 34–40

34 But Paul and Barnabas stayed in Antioch.
They taught and preached the word of the Lord.
Many others did this with them.
35 After some days Paul said to Barnabas, "Let's go back
and visit our brothers.
Let's go to every city where we preached the word of
the Lord.
Let's see how they are doing."
36 Barnabas wanted to take John along too, who was
called Mark.
37 But Paul didn't think it was a good idea to take him
along.
Mark had left them in Pamphylia.
He had not gone on with them to do the work.
38 Paul and Barnabas had such a sharp argument that they
separated.
Barnabas took Mark with him and sailed to Cyprus.
39 But Paul chose Silas and set out.
The brothers put him into the care of God's grace.
40 Paul traveled through Syria and Cilicia.
He made the churches strong.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Important about the numbering: The WEB has 40 verses in this chapter. Some Bibles have 41. There is an additional verse 34: Silas decides to stay in Antioch. This verse is missing in the oldest manuscripts. That is why our verses 34–40 are verses 35–41 in those Bibles.

Verse 37: Mark had left the two on the first journey (13:13).

Verse 38: Apostles argue too. Paul and Barnabas separate. The Bible doesn't hide this.

Later Paul is reconciled with Mark. In a letter he writes that Mark is useful to him for the ministry (2 Timothy 4:11).

For today: Good people can also argue. Reconciliation is possible, sometimes only after a long time.

ACTS

CHAPTER 16

The good news comes to Europe

Timothy joins them VERSES 1–5

1 Paul came to Derbe and Lystra.
A disciple was there,
named Timothy.
His mother was a Jewish woman who believed,
but his father was a Greek.
2 The brothers at Lystra and Iconium
spoke well of him.
3 Paul wanted him to come along with him.
He took him
and circumcised him
because of the Jews
who lived in those parts.
For they all knew
that his father was a Greek.
4 As they went on their way through the cities,
they passed on to the churches the decisions
which the apostles and elders in Jerusalem had made.
The churches were to keep them.

5 So the churches were strengthened in the faith
and grew in number daily.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Timothy had a Jewish mother and a Greek father. He becomes a close co-worker of Paul. Two letters in the Bible are addressed to him.

Verse 3: Why does Paul circumcise Timothy, even though the Council of Jerusalem said that non-Jews don't have to be circumcised? Because Timothy had a Jewish mother, many Jews considered him a Jew. Paul didn't want that to become an obstacle. He respects the Jewish tradition.

Verse 4: The "decisions" are the rules from the letter in chapter 15.

Paul sees a man from Macedonia VERSES 6–10

6 They went through the region of Phrygia and Galatia.
The Holy Spirit kept them
from speaking the word in Asia.
7 When they came near Mysia,
they tried
to go into Bithynia.
But the Spirit didn't allow them.
8 They passed by Mysia
and came down to Troas.
9 In the night Paul had a vision:
A man of Macedonia was standing there,
begging him
and saying,
"Come over into Macedonia
and help us."
10 When he had seen the vision,
we immediately tried to set out for Macedonia.
For we were sure
that the Lord had called us
to preach the Good News to them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–7: Twice a way is blocked. Sometimes God also leads by closing a door.

Verse 9: Macedonia is in the north of today's Greece. With this journey the good news comes to Europe for the first time.

Verse 10: From here on the narrator writes "we." Many think: Luke, the author, was now there himself.

Lydia in Philippi VERSES 11–15

11 So we set sail from Troas
and sailed straight to Samothrace,
and the next day to Neapolis,
12 and from there to Philippi.
It is the leading city of that district of Macedonia,
a Roman colony.
We stayed some days in this city.
13 On the Sabbath day we went outside the city
by a riverside.
We thought
that there was a place of prayer there.
We sat down
and spoke to the women
who had come together.
14 A woman named Lydia was listening.
She was a seller of purple cloth
from the city of Thyatira.
She worshiped God.
The Lord opened her heart
to pay attention to the things
which Paul said.
15 She was baptized,
together with her household.
Then she begged us,
"If you have judged me to be faithful to the Lord,
come into my house
and stay."
And she persuaded us.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Colony means: here: a city where many Roman citizens lived, with Roman rights.

Verse 12: Philippi was a Roman colony. Many former Roman soldiers lived there. Later Paul wrote a letter to the church there, the letter to the Philippians.

Verse 13: There was probably no synagogue there. Jewish and God-fearing women met by the river to pray.

Verse 14: Lydia is the first person in Europe of whom the Bible tells that she believed in Jesus. She was an independent businesswoman. Purple was an expensive dye for cloth.

Verse 15: Lydia's house becomes the first meeting place of the church in Philippi. She is hospitable.

The slave girl with a spirit of fortune telling VERSES 16–24

16 As we were going to the place of prayer,
a young slave girl met us.
She had a spirit of fortune telling.
By her fortune telling she brought her masters much money.
17 She followed Paul and us
and cried out,
"These men are servants of the Most High God!
They proclaim to us a way of salvation!"
18 She did this for many days.
But Paul became greatly annoyed.
He turned
and said to the spirit,
"I command you in the name of Jesus Christ:
come out of her!"
And it came out that very hour.
19 When her masters saw
that their hope of making money was gone,
they seized Paul and Silas.
They dragged them into the marketplace
before the rulers.
20 They brought them to the magistrates
and said,
"These men, being Jews,
are stirring up our city.
21 They promote customs
which it is not lawful for us to accept or to practice,
being Romans."
22 The crowd rose up together against them.
The magistrates tore their clothes off them
and commanded
that they be beaten with rods.

23 When they had given them many blows,
they threw them into prison.
They ordered the jailer
to keep them safely.
24 Having received such a command,
he threw them into the inner prison
and fastened their feet in the stocks.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Magistrates means: the city judges.

Stocks means: a wooden frame that holds a prisoner's feet tight.

Verse 16: The young woman was a slave. Other people made money from her. That is exploitation.

Verse 18: Paul sets her free. After that she is "worthless" to her masters. Her masters only care about their money, not about the person.

Verses 20–21: Here hostility toward Jews among the Romans shows itself: "Being Jews" is used as an accusation. The Bible tells this as an injustice.

Verses 22–24: Paul and Silas are beaten and locked up without a trial.

Important: Human trafficking and exploitation still exist today. If you are affected or notice something, you can call the police (911 in the US, 999 in the UK) or a hotline against human trafficking: in the US, the National Human Trafficking Hotline at 1-888-373-7888; in the UK, the Modern Slavery Helpline at 08000 121 700.

An earthquake in the prison VERSES 25–40

25 About midnight Paul and Silas were praying
and singing hymns to God.
The other prisoners were listening to them.
26 Suddenly there was a great earthquake,
so that the foundations of the prison were shaken.
Immediately all the doors were opened,
and everyone's chains came loose.
27 The jailer woke up.
He saw the prison doors open.
He drew his sword
and was about to kill himself,
because he thought
that the prisoners had escaped.
28 But Paul cried with a loud voice,
"Don't harm yourself,
for we are all here!"
29 The jailer called for lights
and rushed in.
Trembling, he fell down before Paul and Silas.
30 He brought them out
and said,
"Sirs,
what must I do
to be saved?"
31 They said,
"Believe in the Lord Jesus Christ,
and you will be saved,
you and your household."
32 They spoke the word of the Lord to him,
and to all
who were in his house.
33 He took them that same hour of the night
and washed their wounds.
Immediately he was baptized,
he and all his household.
34 He brought them up into his house
and set food before them.
He rejoiced greatly with all his household,
because he had come to believe in God.
35 When it was day,
the magistrates sent the officers,
saying,
"Let those men go."
36 The jailer reported these words to Paul,
saying,
"The magistrates have sent word to let you go.
So come out now
and go in peace."
37 But Paul said to them,
"They have beaten us publicly
without a trial,
men who are Romans,
and have thrown us into prison!
And now they want to release us secretly?
No, most certainly not!
Let them come themselves
and bring us out!"
38 The officers reported these words to the magistrates.
They were afraid
when they heard
that they were Romans.
39 They came
and begged them.
They brought them out
and asked them
to leave the city.
40 They went out of the prison
and went into Lydia's house.
When they had seen the brothers,
they encouraged them
and then left.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25: In the middle of pain and imprisonment Paul and Silas pray and sing. Their faith gives them strength.

Verses 27–28: The jailer wants to kill himself because he thinks he will be punished harshly for the escape. Paul saves him: "Don't harm yourself!"

Important: If you are thinking about ending your life, you are not alone. Help is available around the clock: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verses 30–34: The jailer who locked them up now washes their wounds. Enemies become brothers.

Verse 37: Roman citizens were not allowed to be beaten without a trial. Paul insists on his rights. In this way he also protects the young church in Philippi.

For today: Christians may also stand up for their rights. Human rights apply to everyone.

Chapter 17

Paul in Athens: "To an unknown god"

In Thessalonica VERSES 1–9

1 They passed through Amphipolis and Apollonia
and came to Thessalonica.
There was a Jewish synagogue there.
2 Paul went in to them,
as was his custom.
For three Sabbath days he reasoned with them
from the Scriptures.
3 He explained
and showed them
that the Christ had to suffer
and rise again from the dead.
He said,
"This Jesus,
whom I proclaim to you,
is the Christ."
4 Some of them were persuaded
and joined Paul and Silas,
and also a great crowd of the devout Greeks,
and not a few of the leading women.
5 But the Jews
who were not persuaded
took along some wicked men from the marketplace.
They gathered a crowd
and set the city in an uproar.
They attacked the house of Jason.
They tried to bring Paul and Silas
out to the people.
6 When they didn't find them,
they dragged Jason and some brothers
before the rulers of the city.
They shouted,
"These who have turned the world upside down
have come here also!
7 Jason has welcomed them.
These all act against the decrees of Caesar.
They say
that there is another king:
Jesus!"
8 The crowd and the rulers of the city
were troubled
when they heard these things.
9 They took security from Jason and the rest
and then let them go.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Security means: here: money paid as a guarantee.

Thessalonica is today's Thessaloniki in Greece. Later Paul wrote two letters to the church there.

Verse 2: Paul goes to the synagogue first, "as was his custom." He remains connected with Judaism.

Verse 4: Some Jews, many devout Greeks and leading women come to faith.

Verse 5: "The Jews who were not persuaded": This is about a certain group in Thessalonica, not about all Jews.

Verse 7: The accusation is political: They are supposed to be against the emperor. That was dangerous.

Verse 9: Jason had to pay a kind of bail.

In Beroea VERSES 10–15

10 The brothers immediately sent Paul and Silas away
by night to Beroea.
When they arrived,
they went into the Jewish synagogue.
11 These people were more noble-minded
than those in Thessalonica.
They received the word with great eagerness.
Every day they examined the Scriptures
to see whether these things were so.
12 So many of them believed,
and also many of the prominent Greek women,
and not a few men.
13 But when the Jews of Thessalonica learned
that Paul was proclaiming the word of God in Beroea
also,
they came there too
and stirred up the crowds.
14 Then the brothers immediately sent Paul away
to go as far as the sea.
But Silas and Timothy stayed there.
15 The men
who escorted Paul
brought him as far as Athens.
They received a command
that Silas and Timothy should come to him
as quickly as possible.
Then they left.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: The Jews in Beroea are praised: Every day they examine the Holy Scriptures themselves to see whether what Paul says is true. That is a good example for all who believe: read it yourself and check it.

Verse 12: Many Jews in Beroea come to faith.

Verse 13: Again it is about a certain group from Thessalonica.

Paul on the Areopagus in Athens VERSES 16–34

16 While Paul waited for them in Athens,
his spirit was stirred up within him,
because he saw
that the city was full of idols.
17 So he reasoned in the synagogue
with the Jews and the devout people.
And every day he spoke in the marketplace
with those he met there.
18 Some of the Epicurean and Stoic philosophers
also talked with him.
Some said,
"What does this babbler want to say?"
Others said,
"He seems to be promoting foreign gods."

For he preached Jesus
and the resurrection.
19 They took hold of him
and brought him to the Areopagus.
They said,
"May we know
what this new teaching is
which you are speaking about?
20 For you bring some strange things to our ears.
So we want to know
what these things mean."
21 Now all the Athenians
and the foreigners
living there
spent their time on nothing else
but telling or hearing some new thing.
22 Paul stood in the middle of the Areopagus
and said,
"You men of Athens,
I see
that you are very religious in all things.
23 For as I walked around
and looked at the objects of your worship,
I also found an altar
with this inscription:
'TO AN UNKNOWN GOD.'
So what you worship
without knowing it,
I announce to you.
24 God made the world
and all things in it.
He is Lord of heaven and earth.
He doesn't live in temples
made with hands.
25 He isn't served by human hands,
as though he needed anything.
For he himself gives to all
life and breath and all things.
26 He made from one blood
every nation of people
to live on the whole surface of the earth.
He set appointed times for them
and the boundaries of the places where they live.
27 They were to seek the Lord,
if perhaps they might reach out for him and find him.
For he is not far from each one of us.
28 'For in him we live,
move,
and have our being.'
As some of your own poets have said,
'For we are also his offspring.'
29 So since we are the offspring of God,
we ought not to think
that the divine nature is like gold, or silver, or stone,
shaped by the art and design of human beings.
30 God overlooked the times of ignorance.
But now he commands all people everywhere
to repent.
31 For he has appointed a day
on which he will judge the world in righteousness
through the man
whom he has chosen for this.
He has given proof of this to all people
by raising him from the dead."
32 When they heard of the resurrection of the dead,
some mocked.
But others said,
"We want to hear you again about this."
33 So Paul went out from among them.
34 But some men joined him
and believed,
among them Dionysius,
a member of the Areopagus,
and a woman named Damaris,
and others with them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Babbler means: someone who talks a lot of nonsense.

Offspring means: children, descendants.

Verse 16: Athens was the most famous city of philosophy. Statues of gods stood everywhere.

Verse 18: Epicureans and Stoics were two well-known schools of philosophy. The Epicureans sought a calm, happy life. The Stoics taught that a divine reason fills everything.

Verse 18: "Jesus and the resurrection": Some probably thought these were two new gods.

Verse 19: The Areopagus was a hill in Athens and also the name of the council that met there.

Verses 22–31: Paul speaks kindly and wisely. He builds on what the Athenians know: their altar and their poets. He doesn't insult them.

Verse 26: "From one blood every nation": All people are one family. This stands against every kind of racism.

Verse 28: Here Paul quotes Greek poets. The sentence "For we are also his offspring" is found in the poet Aratus.

Verses 30–31: Paul speaks about the judgment and the resurrection of Jesus without naming him.

Verse 34: Damaris is a woman who comes to faith in the middle of philosophers.

For today: You can speak respectfully with people of other worldviews and still say clearly what you believe.

ACTS

CHAPTER 18

Paul in Corinth, Priscilla and Aquila

Paul in Corinth VERSES 1–11

1 After these things Paul left Athens
and came to Corinth.
2 There he found a Jew named Aquila.
He came from Pontus
and had recently come from Italy
with his wife Priscilla,

because Claudius had commanded
all the Jews to leave Rome.
Paul went to them.
3 Because he had the same trade,
he lived with them
and worked with them.
By trade they were tent makers.
4 Every Sabbath he reasoned in the synagogue
and persuaded Jews and Greeks.
5 When Silas and Timothy came down from Macedonia,
Paul was pressed by the Spirit.
He testified to the Jews
that Jesus was the Christ.
6 When they opposed him
and blasphemed,
he shook out his clothing
and said to them,
"Your blood be on your own heads!
I am clean.
From now on, I will go to the Gentiles!"
7 He left there
and went into the house of a man named Justus.
Justus worshiped God.
His house was next door to the synagogue.
8 Crispus,
the ruler of the synagogue,
believed in the Lord with all his household.
And many of the Corinthians
who heard
believed
and were baptized.
9 In the night the Lord said to Paul in a vision,
"Don't be afraid,
but speak
and don't be silent.
10 For I am with you.
No one will attack you
to harm you.
For I have many people in this city."
11 Paul lived there a year and six months,
teaching the word of God among them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Corinth was a large port city in Greece. Later Paul wrote two long letters to the church there.

Verse 2: Around AD 49 the emperor Claudius drove Jews out of Rome. That too was hostility toward Jews.

Priscilla and Aquila are a married couple. They become important co-workers of Paul. Priscilla is often named first. This probably shows how important she was in the church.

Verse 3: Paul earned his own money with his trade. He didn't want to be a burden to anyone.

Verse 6: "Your blood be on your own heads" means: You are responsible yourselves. I have done my duty. Shaking out his clothes is a sign of this. It is meant for certain people in Corinth, not for all Jews. Paul keeps going to synagogues later (verse 19).

Verse 8: Even the ruler of the synagogue, Crispus, comes to faith.

Verses 9–10: Paul was probably afraid. God encourages him: "Don't be afraid." And: "For I am with you."

Paul before Gallio VERSES 12–17

12 When Gallio was proconsul of Achaia,
the Jews rose up together against Paul.
They brought him before the judgment seat
13 and said,
"This man persuades people
to worship God
against the law."
14 Paul was about to speak.
But Gallio said to the Jews,
"You Jews,
if it were a matter of wrongdoing
or of a wicked crime,
it would be reasonable for me to listen to you.
15 But if these are questions
about words and names
and your own law,
see to it yourselves.
I don't want to be a judge of these matters."
16 So he drove them away from the judgment seat.
17 Then all the Greeks seized Sosthenes,
the ruler of the synagogue,
and beat him in front of the judgment seat.
But Gallio didn't care about any of these things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Gallio was the brother of the famous philosopher Seneca. An inscription shows that he was governor in Corinth around AD 51/52. This helps to date Paul's journeys.

Verses 14–15: For Gallio this is a dispute within Judaism. He doesn't want to get involved.

Verse 17: A Jewish man, Sosthenes, is beaten up by the crowd, and the governor looks away. That too is injustice and hostility toward Jews. Whoever looks away from violence shares the guilt.

Perhaps this Sosthenes is the same one who is later called a brother in 1 Corinthians (1 Corinthians 1:1). But that is not certain.

Paul travels back to Antioch VERSES 18–23

18 After this Paul stayed there many more days.
Then he said goodbye to the brothers
and sailed from there for Syria,
together with Priscilla and Aquila.
In Cenchreae he had his head shaved,
for he had taken a vow.
19 He came to Ephesus
and left the two of them there.
But he himself went into the synagogue
and reasoned with the Jews.
20 They asked him
to stay with them longer.
But he declined.
21 He said goodbye to them
and said,
"I must by all means keep this coming feast in Jerusalem.
But I will return to you again
if God wills."
Then he set sail from Ephesus.
22 When he had landed at Caesarea,
he went up

and greeted the church.
Then he went down to Antioch.
23 He spent some time there.
Then he left
and went through the region of Galatia and Phrygia,
place by place.
He strengthened all the disciples.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Vow means: a solemn promise made to God.

Verse 18: Paul takes a vow, as devout Jews did (compare Numbers 6). He continues to live as a devout Jew.

Verses 19–20: The Jews in Ephesus ask Paul to stay longer. They are open to his message.

Verse 21: Paul wants to go to Jerusalem for the feast. Some Bibles don't have the sentence about the feast. It is missing in some old manuscripts. The WEB has it.

Verse 22: The second great journey ends with the return to Antioch. The third begins with verse 23.

Apollos VERSES 24–28

24 A Jew named Apollos,
who came from Alexandria,
came to Ephesus.
He was an eloquent man
and knew the Scriptures well.
25 He had been taught the way of the Lord.
He was on fire in spirit
and spoke and taught accurately about Jesus.
But he knew only the baptism of John.
26 He began
to speak boldly in the synagogue.
When Priscilla and Aquila heard him,
they took him aside
and explained the way of God to him more accurately.
27 Apollos wanted to travel to Achaia.
The brothers encouraged him
and wrote to the disciples there
to welcome him.
When he arrived,
he greatly helped those
who had believed through grace.
28 For he powerfully refuted the Jews
in public.
He showed from the Scriptures
that Jesus was the Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Eloquent means: good at speaking.

Refute means: prove that something is wrong.

Verse 24: Alexandria in Egypt was a city of great learning with a large Jewish community.

Verse 25: Apollos knew a lot about Jesus, but not yet everything.

Verse 26: Priscilla and Aquila teach the educated Apollos kindly and in private, not in public. Again Priscilla is named first. A woman teaches a learned man.

Verse 27: Achaia is the province in the south of Greece that included Corinth. Later Apollos becomes important in Corinth (1 Corinthians 3:6).

Verse 28: This is about a debate among Jews about Scripture. Apollos is a Jew himself.

For today: Whoever knows something better should help others kindly, without embarrassing them.

ACTS

CHAPTER 19

Paul in Ephesus

Disciples of John the Baptizer VERSES 1–7

1 While Apollos was in Corinth,
Paul passed through the upper country
and came to Ephesus.
There he found some disciples.
2 He said to them,
"Did you receive the Holy Spirit
when you believed?"
They said to him,
"No,
we haven't even heard
that there is a Holy Spirit."
3 He said,
"Into what then were you baptized?"
They said,
"Into John's baptism."
4 Paul said,
"John baptized with the baptism of repentance.
He told the people
that they should believe in the one
who would come after him,
that is, in Christ Jesus."
5 When they heard this,
they were baptized in the name of the Lord Jesus.
6 Paul laid his hands on them.
Then the Holy Spirit came on them.
They spoke in other languages
and prophesied.
7 They were about 12 men in all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ephesus was one of the largest cities in the Roman Empire, on the west coast of today's Turkey. Paul stayed there for more than two years.

Verses 2–4: These disciples only knew the baptism of John the Baptizer. Paul explains to them: John pointed to Jesus.

Verse 6: The Holy Spirit comes, as at Pentecost.

Paul teaches in Ephesus VERSES 8–20

8 Paul went into the synagogue
and spoke boldly there for three months.
He reasoned with the people
and tried to persuade them about God's Kingdom.
9 But some were hardened
and disobedient.
Before the crowd they spoke evil of the Way.

So Paul left them
and took the disciples with him.
Every day he reasoned in the school of Tyrannus.
10 This continued for two years.
So all those who lived in Asia
heard the word of the Lord Jesus,
both Jews and Greeks.
11 God did special miracles
through the hands of Paul.
12 People even carried handkerchiefs or aprons
that had touched his body
to the sick.
Then the diseases left them,
and the evil spirits went out.
13 But some Jewish exorcists
who traveled from place to place
also tried
to call the name of the Lord Jesus
over those who had evil spirits.
They said,
"We command you by Jesus
whom Paul preaches!"
14 Seven sons of a man named Sceva,
a Jewish chief priest,
did this.
15 But the evil spirit answered,
"Jesus I know,
and Paul I know,
but who are you?"
16 The man
in whom the evil spirit was
leaped on them,
overpowered them
and was stronger than they were.
They fled out of that house naked and wounded.
17 This became known to all,
both Jews and Greeks,
who lived at Ephesus.
Fear fell on them all.
And the name of the Lord Jesus was highly honored.
18 Many
of those who had believed
came
and openly confessed
what they had done.
19 Many
of those who had practiced magic
brought their books together
and burned them in the sight of all.
They counted the price of the books:
50,000 pieces of silver.
20 So the word of the Lord grew
and became mighty.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Exorcist means: someone who tries to drive out evil spirits.

Verse 9: "The Way" is an early name for the Christian faith. Some reject the message, not all.

Verse 10: Jews and Greeks in the province of Asia hear the good news. Perhaps the churches in Colossae and Laodicea also began at this time.

Verse 12: People hope for healing, even through cloths from Paul. But the healing comes from God (verse 11).

Verses 13–16: You can't use the name of Jesus like a magic formula. What matters is real faith.

Verse 14: A chief priest named Sceva is not known from anywhere else. Perhaps he only called himself that.

Verse 19: Ephesus was known for books of magic. The people burn their own books freely. This is a sign that they turn away from magic completely.

Important: This story gives no one the right to burn other people's books. Burning books against the will of others, as in Germany in 1933, is wrong.

Mental illnesses are not possession by evil spirits. They can be treated. Help is available from doctors. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The riot of the silversmiths VERSES 21–41

21 After these things had ended,
Paul decided in the Spirit
to pass through Macedonia and Achaia
and then go to Jerusalem.
He said,
"After I have been there,
I must also see Rome."
22 He sent two of his helpers,
Timothy and Erastus,
into Macedonia.
He himself stayed in Asia for a while.
23 About that time there was a great disturbance
about the Way.
24 A silversmith named Demetrius
made silver shrines of Artemis.
In this way he brought a lot of business
to the craftsmen.
25 He gathered them together
with the workers of similar trades.
He said,
"Sirs,
you know
that we have our wealth from this business.
26 You see and hear
that not only at Ephesus,
but almost throughout all Asia,
this Paul has persuaded and turned away many people.
He says
that gods
that are made with hands
are no gods.
27 There is not only the danger
that this trade of ours will get a bad name.
But also the temple of the great goddess Artemis
will be counted as nothing.
And her majesty will be destroyed,
though all Asia and the world worship her."
28 When they heard this,
they were filled with anger
and cried out,
"Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!"
29 The whole city was filled with confusion.
They all rushed together into the theater.
They seized Gaius and Aristarchus,

men from Macedonia,
Paul's travel companions.
30 Paul wanted to go in to the people,
but the disciples didn't allow him.
31 Some of the Asiarchs,
who were his friends,
also sent to him
and begged him
not to go into the theater.
32 Some cried one thing,
and some another.
For the assembly was in confusion.
Most of them didn't even know
why they had come together.
33 They brought Alexander out of the crowd.
The Jews pushed him forward.
Alexander motioned with his hand
and wanted to make a defense before the people.
34 But when they realized
that he was a Jew,
all of them cried out with one voice
for about two hours,
"Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!"
35 The town clerk quieted the crowd
and said,
"You men of Ephesus,
who doesn't know
that the city of the Ephesians is temple keeper
of the great goddess Artemis,
and of the image
which fell down from Zeus?
36 Since these things can't be denied,
you ought to be quiet
and do nothing rash.
37 For you have brought these men here,
who are neither robbers of temples
nor blasphemers of your goddess.
38 If Demetrius and the craftsmen
who are with him
have a complaint against anyone,
the courts are open
and there are proconsuls.
Let them bring charges against one another there.
39 But if you want anything else,
it will be settled in the regular assembly.
40 For we are in danger
of being accused because of today's riot.
There is no reason for it.
We wouldn't be able to give an account of this
commotion."
41 When he had said this,
he dismissed the assembly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Shrine means: here: a small model of a temple.

Asiarchs means: respected leading men of the province of Asia.

Verse 21: Paul plans to go to Rome. This becomes the goal of the whole book.

Verse 24: The temple of Artemis in Ephesus was one of the seven wonders of the ancient world. Demetrius sold small souvenirs of the temple.

Verses 25–27: Demetrius is worried most of all about his money. For him religion is also a business.

Verse 29: The theater of Ephesus had room for about 25,000 people. You can still visit it today.

Verse 31: Some of these respected men were friends of Paul.

Verses 33–34: The Jews in Ephesus probably wanted to show that they had nothing to do with Paul. But when the crowd realizes that Alexander is a Jew, they don't let him speak. Here too hostility toward Jews shows itself.

Verses 35–40: The town clerk acts wisely. He says: There are courts. Problems should be solved by law, not by violence.

For today: When a crowd gets angry, calm and lawful action is important.

ACTS

CHAPTER 20

Farewell to Ephesus

Journey through Macedonia and Greece VERSES 1–6

1 After the uproar had ended,
Paul sent for the disciples.
He said goodbye to them
and left to go into Macedonia.
2 He went through those regions
and encouraged the people with many words.
Then he came into Greece.
3 He stayed there three months.
He was about to set sail for Syria.
Then a plot was made against him by Jews.
So he decided
to return through Macedonia.
4 These went with him as far as Asia:
Sopater of Beroea,
Aristarchus and Secundus of Thessalonica,
Gaius of Derbe,
Timothy,
and Tychicus and Trophimus of Asia.
5 These had gone ahead
and were waiting for us at Troas.
6 After the days of Unleavened Bread
we sailed away from Philippi.
In five days we came to them at Troas.
There we stayed seven days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: "By Jews" here means certain opponents, not the Jewish people.

Verse 4: Paul travels with a group from many churches. They were probably bringing a collection of money for the poor Christians in Jerusalem (compare Romans 15:25–26).

Verse 5: Here the report in the "we" form begins again.

Verse 6: Paul continues to live by the Jewish feasts.

Eutychus falls from the window VERSES 7–12

7 On the first day of the week
the disciples gathered together
to break bread.
Paul talked with them.
He wanted to leave the next day.
So he kept on speaking until midnight.
8 There were many lamps
in the upper room
where we were gathered.
9 A young man named Eutychus
sat in the window.
He became very sleepy.
Paul kept speaking even longer.
Then sleep overcame him,
and he fell down from the third floor.
He was picked up dead.
10 Paul went down,
threw himself on him,
put his arms around him
and said,
"Don't be troubled,
for his life is in him."
11 Then Paul went up again,
broke bread
and ate.
He talked with them a long while,
until daybreak.
Then he left.
12 They brought the boy in alive
and were greatly comforted.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: "On the first day of the week": That is Sunday, the day of the resurrection. Already the first Christians met on this day to break bread, that is, for the Lord's Supper or Eucharist.

Verse 9: A very human, even somewhat funny scene: A sermon lasts so long that a young man falls asleep. But then it becomes serious.

Verse 10: Paul embraces the boy, as the prophets Elijah and Elisha did (1 Kings 17:21; 2 Kings 4:34).

For today: God gives life, even when everything seems lost.

From Troas to Miletus VERSES 13–16

13 But we went ahead to the ship
and sailed for Assos.
There we wanted to take Paul on board.
He had arranged it this way,
for he himself wanted to go by land.
14 When he met us at Assos,
we took him on board
and came to Mitylene.
15 We sailed on from there
and the next day came opposite Chios.
The day after, we touched at Samos
and stayed at Trogyllium.
The following day we came to Miletus.
16 For Paul had decided
to sail past Ephesus,
so that he would not have to spend time in Asia.
For he was hurrying
to be in Jerusalem on the day of Pentecost,
if possible.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–15: Luke describes the journey exactly, port by port. He was probably there himself.

Verse 15: "And stayed at Trogyllium": These words are missing in some old manuscripts. The WEB has them.

Verse 16: Paul wants to be in Jerusalem for Pentecost, a Jewish feast.

Paul says goodbye VERSES 17–38

17 From Miletus Paul sent to Ephesus
and called the elders of the church to himself.
18 When they had come to him,
he said to them,
"You yourselves know
how I was with you all the time,
from the first day
that I set foot in Asia.
19 I served the Lord
with all humility,
with many tears,
and with trials
that came to me through the plots of the Jews.
20 You know
that I didn't hold back from telling you anything
that was useful to you.
I taught you publicly
and from house to house.
21 I testified to both Jews and Greeks:
Turn to God in repentance
and have faith in our Lord Jesus.
22 And now
I am going to Jerusalem,
bound by the Spirit.
I don't know
what will happen to me there.
23 I only know
that the Holy Spirit testifies to me in every city:
Chains and troubles are waiting for me.
24 But these things don't count.
I don't hold my life dear to myself.
What matters
is that I finish my race with joy,
and the ministry
which I received from the Lord Jesus:
to testify to the Good News of the grace of God.
25 And now
I know
that you all,
among whom I went about
preaching God's Kingdom,
will see my face no more.
26 So I testify to you today
that I am clean from the blood of all people.
27 For I didn't hold back.
I declared to you the whole plan of God.
28 So take care of yourselves
and of all the flock.
The Holy Spirit has made you overseers in it.

You are to shepherd the church of the Lord and God
which he bought with his own blood.
29 For I know
that after I have left,
vicious wolves will come in among you.
They will not spare the flock.
30 Men will also rise up
from among your own selves.
They will speak twisted things
to draw the disciples away after them.
31 So be watchful!
Remember
that for three years
I didn't stop
warning everyone night and day
with tears.
32 And now, brothers,
I entrust you to God
and to the word of his grace.
It is able
to build you up
and to give you the inheritance
among all those who are made holy.
33 I wanted no one's silver,
gold,
or clothing.
34 You yourselves know
that these hands
earned what I needed
and what those who were with me needed.
35 In all things I gave you an example:
By working like this
you ought to help the weak.
And remember the words of the Lord Jesus.
He himself said,
'It is more blessed to give than to receive.'"
36 When he had said these things,
he knelt down
and prayed with them all.
37 They all wept very much.
They hugged Paul
and kissed him.
38 They were sad most of all because of the word
that they would see his face no more.
Then they went with him to the ship.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Overseer means: someone who watches over and cares for others.

Flock means: a group of sheep; here: the church.

This is the only speech of Paul in Acts that he gives to Christians. It is a farewell speech.

Verse 19: "The plots of the Jews" means certain opponents. Paul himself is a Jew.

Verses 22–24: Paul knows that danger is waiting for him. Still he goes. He trusts God.

Verse 26: "I am clean from the blood of all people" means: I have done my task. No one can say that I kept something from them.

Verse 28: "Overseer" in Greek is *episkopos*. The word "bishop" comes from it. The church leaders are to care for the church like shepherds.

Verse 28: Here we follow the WEB, our English source text: "the church of the Lord and God." The old manuscripts have different forms here: *the church of God* or *the church of the Lord*.

Verses 29–30: Paul warns against false teachers who want to tie people to themselves. Anyone who is put under pressure in a group can find advice at counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse.

Verse 35: "It is more blessed to give than to receive": This saying of Jesus is not in the Gospels. Paul knew it from what was passed on by word of mouth.

Verses 37–38: A tearful farewell. The church loves Paul. Christians may show their feelings.

ACTS

CHAPTER 21

Paul is arrested in Jerusalem

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

In this chapter and the next ones the text often says "the Jews." This means certain people who oppose Paul, for example "the Jews from Asia" (verse 27). At the same time the text tells of "many thousands" of Jews who believe in Jesus and faithfully keep the law (verse 20). Paul himself says: "I am a Jew" (verse 39).

These texts must never be used against the Jewish people (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965).

Journey to Caesarea VERSES 1–14

1 We parted from them
and set sail.
We came on a straight course to Cos,
the next day to Rhodes,
and from there to Patara.
2 There we found a ship
crossing over to Phoenicia.
We went on board
and set sail.
3 We came in sight of Cyprus
and left it on our left.
We sailed to Syria
and landed at Tyre.
For the ship was to unload its cargo there.
4 We found disciples
and stayed there seven days.
Through the Spirit they told Paul
that he should not go up to Jerusalem.
5 When those days were over,
we left and went on our journey.
They all, with wives and children,
went with us

until we were out of the city.
We knelt down on the beach
and prayed.
6 We said goodbye to each other.
Then we went on board the ship,
and they returned home.
7 When we had finished the voyage from Tyre,
we arrived at Ptolemais.
We greeted the brothers
and stayed with them one day.
8 The next day we,
Paul's companions,
left
and came to Caesarea.
We went into the house of Philip
the evangelist.
He was one of the seven.
We stayed with him.
9 He had four daughters
who were virgins
and prophesied.
10 We stayed there some days.
Then a prophet named Agabus came down from
Judea.
11 He came to us,
took Paul's belt,
tied his own feet and hands with it
and said,
"The Holy Spirit says:
'So the Jews at Jerusalem will bind the man
who owns this belt,
and will hand him over to the Gentiles.'"
12 When we heard these things,
both we and the people of that place
begged Paul
not to go up to Jerusalem.
13 Then Paul answered,
"What are you doing?
Why are you weeping
and breaking my heart?
For I am ready
not only to be bound,
but also to die at Jerusalem
for the name of the Lord Jesus."
14 He would not be persuaded.
So we stopped and said,
"The Lord's will be done."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Evangelist means: someone who spreads the Good News.

Verse 4: Through the Spirit the disciples sense that danger is waiting for Paul. They want to protect him. Paul goes anyway, because he knows that God has called him (20:22).

Verse 5: Whole families, with wives and children, pray on the beach. A beautiful picture of fellowship.

Verse 8: Philip is one of the seven helpers from chapter 6. He had baptized the man from Ethiopia (chapter 8).

Verse 9: Philip's four daughters were prophets. In the first church, women spoke in God's name.

Verse 11: Agabus does a symbolic action, like the prophets of Israel.

Verses 13–14: Paul is ready to suffer for Jesus. His friends let him go: "The Lord's will be done."

Paul with James in Jerusalem VERSES 15–26

15 After these days we packed our baggage
and went up to Jerusalem.
16 Some of the disciples from Caesarea went with us.
They brought a man with them:
Mnason of Cyprus,
an early disciple.
We were to stay with him.
17 When we came to Jerusalem,
the brothers welcomed us gladly.
18 The next day Paul went with us to James.
All the elders were there.
19 Paul greeted them
and told them one by one
the things God had done among the Gentiles
through his ministry.
20 When they heard it,
they praised God.
They said to him,
"You see, brother,
how many thousands there are among the Jews
who have believed.
And they are all zealous for the law.
21 They have been told about you
that you teach all the Jews
who live among the Gentiles
to turn away from Moses.
They say you tell them
not to circumcise their children
and not to live by the customs.
22 What then?
The church will certainly meet,
for they will hear
that you have come.
23 So do what we tell you.
We have four men
who have taken a vow.
24 Take them
and purify yourself with them.
Pay their expenses,
so that they can shave their heads.
Then all will know
that there is no truth in the things
they have been told about you.
They will see
that you yourself also live by keeping the law.
25 But about the Gentiles who believe,
we have written our decision:
They don't need to keep any of this.
They should only keep themselves
from food offered to idols,
from blood,
from strangled things,
and from sexual immorality."
26 Then Paul took the men.
The next day he purified himself with them
and went into the temple.
There he announced

when the days of purification would be completed
and the offering would be made for each one of them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Purify means: make clean according to the rules of the law.

Verse 18: James is the brother of Jesus and the leader of the church in Jerusalem.

Verse 20: "Many thousands" of Jews believe in Jesus and faithfully keep the law. For them both belong together. Zealous means: full of eager devotion.

Verse 21: This is a false rumor. Paul didn't tell Jews to leave Moses. He even circumcised Timothy (16:3).

Verses 23–26: Paul goes into the temple and keeps the Jewish rules of purification (compare Numbers 6). He shows: I am a Jew who respects the law.

Verse 25 recalls the decision from chapter 15.

Paul is seized in the temple VERSES 27–40

27 The seven days were almost completed.
Then the Jews from Asia
saw Paul in the temple.
They stirred up the whole crowd
and seized him.
28 They shouted,
"Men of Israel, help!
This is the man
who teaches everyone everywhere
against the people,
against the law,
and against this place!
And he has even brought Greeks into the temple
and has made this holy place unclean!"
29 For they had seen Trophimus from Ephesus
with him in the city.
They thought
that Paul had brought him into the temple.
30 The whole city was stirred up.
The people ran together.
They seized Paul
and dragged him out of the temple.
Immediately the doors were shut.
31 They were trying to kill him.
Then news came to the commanding officer of the Roman troops
that all Jerusalem was in an uproar.
32 Immediately he took soldiers and centurions
and ran down to them.
When they saw the commanding officer and the soldiers,
they stopped beating Paul.
33 Then the commanding officer came near
and arrested Paul.
He ordered him to be bound with two chains
and asked
who he was
and what he had done.
34 In the crowd some shouted one thing,
and some another.
Because of the noise he couldn't find out the truth.
So he ordered
Paul to be brought into the barracks.
35 When Paul came to the stairs,
the soldiers had to carry him,
because the crowd was so violent.
36 For the crowd of people followed
and shouted,
"Away with him!"
37 As Paul was about to be brought into the barracks,
he said to the commanding officer,
"May I speak to you?"
He answered,
"Do you know Greek?
38 Aren't you then the Egyptian
who some time ago started a revolt
and led the 4,000 men of the Assassins
out into the wilderness?"
39 But Paul said,
"I am a Jew from Tarsus in Cilicia,
a citizen of no unimportant city.
I beg you,
allow me
to speak to the people."
40 The commanding officer allowed it.
Paul stood on the stairs
and motioned with his hand to the people.
There was a great silence.
Then he spoke to them in the Hebrew language,
saying:

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Barracks means: a building where soldiers live.

Verse 27: "The Jews from Asia": These are people who knew Paul from Ephesus. Not all Jews in Jerusalem.

Verses 28–29: Non-Jews were not allowed into the inner area of the temple. Warning signs at the temple threatened death. But the charge against Paul was false. It was a misunderstanding (verse 29).

Verses 31–33: The Roman commanding officer saves Paul from the angry crowd. His name is Claudius Lysias (23:26).

Verse 36: "Away with him!" The crowd had shouted something similar about Jesus too (Luke 23:18).

Verse 38: The historian Josephus tells of an "Egyptian" who led a revolt. The "Assassins" (in Greek *sicarii*) were men who killed opponents with short daggers.

Verse 40: "In the Hebrew language" probably means Aramaic, the language of the people in Jerusalem at that time. With the colon the speech continues in the next chapter.

Important: Mob violence is always wrong, no matter against whom.

ACTS

CHAPTER 22

Paul tells his story

"I am a Jew" VERSES 1–5

1 "Brothers and fathers,
listen to the defense
which I now make to you."
2 When they heard
that he spoke to them in the Hebrew language,
they became even more quiet.
He said,
3 "I am a Jew.
I was born in Tarsus of Cilicia,
but brought up in this city.
At the feet of Gamaliel
I was taught exactly in the law of our ancestors.
I was zealous for God,
just as you all are today.
4 I persecuted this Way to the death.
I bound both men and women
and put them in prison.
5 The high priest
and all the council of the elders can testify to this.
From them I even received letters to the brothers in Damascus.
I traveled there
to bring those who were there to Jerusalem in chains,
to be punished.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: Paul speaks in the people's mother tongue. That is why they listen to him. "The Hebrew language" probably means Aramaic.

Verse 3: Paul stresses: I am a Jew, I learned from the famous teacher Gamaliel (5:34). I understand your zeal for God, because I had it too. Zealous means: full of eager devotion.

"At the feet of" means: as a student.

Verses 4–5: Paul speaks honestly about his guilt.

The encounter near Damascus VERSES 6–16

6 "As I was on my way
and came close to Damascus,
about noon
a great light from the sky suddenly shone around me.
7 I fell to the ground
and heard a voice
saying to me,
'Saul, Saul,
why are you persecuting me?'
8 I answered,
'Who are you, Lord?'
He said to me,
'I am Jesus of Nazareth,
whom you persecute.'
9 Those
who were with me
saw the light
and were afraid.
But they didn't understand the voice
of him who spoke to me.
10 I said,
'What shall I do, Lord?'
The Lord said to me,
'Get up
and go into Damascus.
There you will be told everything
that you are meant to do.'
11 I couldn't see,
because that light had been so bright.
Those who were with me led me by the hand,
and so I came into Damascus.
12 There was a man named Ananias.
He was devout and lived by the law.
All the Jews
who lived in Damascus
spoke well of him.
13 He came to me,
stood by me
and said,
'Brother Saul,
receive your sight!'
In that very hour I looked up at him.
14 He said,
'The God of our ancestors has chosen you
to know his will,
to see the Righteous One,
and to hear a voice from his mouth.
15 For you will be a witness for him
to all people
of what you have seen and heard.
16 Now why do you wait?
Get up,
be baptized,
and wash away your sins,
calling on the name of the Lord.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here Paul tells the story from chapter 9 again in his own words. Some details are told a little differently. This is how people tell things when they report the same experience several times.

Verse 9: In 9:7 it says that his companions heard the sound of a voice. Here it says: They didn't understand the voice. So they heard something, but didn't understand the words.

Verse 12: Paul stresses that Ananias was a devout Jew who lived by the law.

Verse 14: "The God of our ancestors": It is the God of Israel who calls Paul.

Verse 16: Baptism is a sign of the forgiveness of sins.

God sends Paul to the nations VERSES 17–21

17 "After that I returned to Jerusalem.
While I was praying in the temple,
I fell into a trance.
18 I saw him,
and he said to me,
'Hurry
and get out of Jerusalem quickly!
For they will not accept your testimony about me.'
19 I said,
'Lord,
they themselves know
that in every synagogue I imprisoned and beat
those
who believed in you.

20 And when the blood of Stephen,
your witness,
was shed,
I also was standing by.
I agreed with his death
and guarded the cloaks of those
who killed him.'
21 He said to me,
'Go!
For I will send you far away to the Gentiles.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Trance means: a state like a dream, in which someone sees or hears things from God.

Verse 17: Paul prays in the temple, like a devout Jew. There Jesus calls him.

Verse 18: The WEB only says "him." This means Jesus, the Lord.

Verse 20: Paul remembers the death of Stephen (7:58). He doesn't hide his guilt.

Verse 21: God sends Paul to the nations. That is the task of his life.

Paul is a Roman citizen VERSES 22–30

22 They listened to him until he said that.
But then they raised their voices
and shouted,
"Rid the earth of this fellow,
for he isn't fit to live!"
23 They shouted,
threw off their cloaks
and threw dust into the air.
24 Then the commanding officer ordered
Paul to be brought into the barracks.
He ordered
him to be questioned under whipping.
In this way he wanted to find out
why they were shouting against him like that.
25 When they had tied him up with straps,
Paul said to the centurion
who stood there,
"Is it lawful for you to whip a man
who is a Roman citizen
and has not been found guilty?"
26 When the centurion heard it,
he went to the commanding officer,
told him
and said,
"Watch what you are about to do!
This man is a Roman!"
27 The commanding officer came
and asked him,
"Tell me,
are you a Roman?"
Paul said,
"Yes."
28 The commanding officer answered,
"I bought my citizenship for a great price."
Paul said,
"But I was born a Roman."
29 Immediately those who were about to question him
left him alone.
The commanding officer also was afraid
when he realized
that Paul was a Roman,
because he had bound him.
30 The next day he wanted to know the truth
about why Paul was accused by the Jews.
He freed him from the chains
and ordered
the chief priests and all the council to come together.
Then he brought Paul down
and set him before them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Citizenship means: the rights of a citizen.

Verse 22: When Paul says that God is sending him to the Gentiles, the crowd becomes angry. They were probably afraid that Paul was removing the boundaries of God's people.

Verse 24: Questioning under whipping was a form of torture. Torture is always a crime against human dignity.

Verse 25: Paul claims his rights. Roman citizens could not be whipped without a verdict.

Verse 28: The commanding officer had bought his citizenship. Paul was born with it, perhaps because his father was already a citizen.

Verse 30: "Accused by the Jews": This means the opponents in Jerusalem who accused Paul. Paul himself is a Jew.

For today: Human rights protect all people from torture and arbitrary power.

ACTS

CHAPTER 23

Paul before the council and the murder plot

Paul before the council VERSES 1–11

1 Paul looked straight at the council.
He said, "Brothers, I have lived my life before God with a completely clear conscience until this day."
2 Then the high priest Ananias gave an order to the men standing next to Paul.
They were to hit him on the mouth.
3 Then Paul said to him, "God will strike you, you whitewashed wall!
You sit there to judge me by the law.
But you break the law yourself when you order them to hit me!"
4 The men standing there said, "How dare you insult God's high priest!"
5 Paul said, "Brothers, I didn't know that he was the high priest.
For it is written: 'You must not speak evil of a ruler of your people.'"

6 Paul knew that some of the council were Sadducees and the others were Pharisees.
So he called out in the council, "Brothers, I am a Pharisee, the son of Pharisees.
I am on trial because I hope that the dead will rise again!"
7 When he said this, the Pharisees and the Sadducees began to argue.
The group was divided.
8 The Sadducees say that there is no resurrection.
They say that there are no angels and no spirits.
But the Pharisees believe in all of these.
9 There was a lot of shouting.
Some of the scribes who belonged to the Pharisees stood up.
They argued hard.
They said, "We find nothing wrong with this man.
Maybe a spirit or an angel has spoken to him.
Then let's not fight against God!"
10 The argument became more and more violent.
The commanding officer was afraid that they would tear Paul to pieces.
So he ordered the soldiers to go down and take Paul away from them by force.
They were to bring him into the barracks.
11 The next night the Lord stood next to Paul.
He said, "Cheer up, Paul!
You have been my witness in Jerusalem.
You must also be my witness in Rome."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Whitewashed means: painted white on the outside.

Verse 3: "Whitewashed wall" means: beautiful on the outside, bad on the inside. Paul accuses the high priest of acting against the law. For an accused person was not to be struck without a verdict.

Verse 5: Paul quotes Exodus 22:28 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 22:27). He apologizes and respects the law.

Verse 6: "I am a Pharisee": Paul says this in the present tense. He still sees himself as a Pharisee.

Verse 9: The Pharisees defend Paul. This shows: Many Pharisees were open and fair.

Verse 11: Jesus encourages Paul: You will come to Rome. That is the goal of the book.

The murder plot VERSES 12–22

12 When it was day, some of the Jews got together and made a plan.
They swore an oath and put themselves under a curse.
They would not eat or drink anything until they had killed Paul.
13 More than 40 men were part of this plot.
14 They went to the chief priests and the elders.
They said, "We have put ourselves under a strong curse.
We will not eat anything until we have killed Paul.
15 So now you and the council must send a message to the commanding officer.
Ask him to bring Paul down to you tomorrow.
Act as if you want to look at his case more closely.
We are ready to kill him before he gets there."
16 But the son of Paul's sister heard about the ambush.
He went into the barracks and told Paul.
17 Paul called one of the centurions.
He said, "Take this young man to the commanding officer.
He has something to tell him."
18 So the centurion took him to the commanding officer.
He said, "Paul, the prisoner, called me.
He asked me to bring this young man to you.
He has something to tell you."
19 The commanding officer took the young man by the hand.
He went off to the side with him.
He asked him privately, "What do you have to tell me?"
20 The young man said, "The Jews have agreed to ask you to bring Paul down to the council tomorrow.
They will act as if they want to question him more closely.
21 But don't do what they ask!
More than 40 men are hiding and waiting for him.
They have put themselves under a curse.
They will not eat or drink until they have killed him.
They are ready now.
They are only waiting for you to say yes."
22 The commanding officer let the young man go.
He told him, "Don't tell anyone that you told me this."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ambush means: a hidden attack.

Verse 12: "Some of the Jews": This is about a group of about 40 men. Not about the Jewish people. Their plan was a crime.

Verses 14–15: Some leaders know about the murder plot and help with it. That is a serious injustice.

Verse 16: Here we learn: Paul had a sister in Jerusalem. Her son saves his life. A brave young person.

For today: Anyone who learns about a planned crime should report it. Call the police: 911 in the US, 999 in the UK.

Paul is brought to Caesarea VERSES 23–35

23 Then the commanding officer called two of the centurions.
He said, "Get 200 soldiers ready to go to Caesarea.
Also get 70 horsemen and 200 men with spears.
Leave at the third hour of the night.
24 Get some animals for Paul to ride on.
Bring him safely to Felix the governor."
25 He wrote a letter.
This is what it said:
26 "From Claudius Lysias to the most excellent governor Felix: Greetings!
27 The Jews had taken hold of this man.
They were about to kill him.
But I came with my soldiers and rescued him.
I had learned that he was a Roman.
28 I wanted to know why they were accusing him.
So I brought him to their council.
29 I found out that they were accusing him about questions of their own law.
But he has done nothing that deserves death or prison.

30 Then I was told that the Jews were lying in wait for him.
So I sent him to you at once.
I have also ordered his accusers to bring their charges against him to you.
Farewell."
31 So the soldiers did what they were ordered.
They took Paul and brought him to Antipatris during the night.
32 The next day the horsemen went on with Paul.
The other soldiers went back to the barracks.
33 The horsemen came to Caesarea.
They gave the letter to the governor.
They also brought Paul to him.
34 The governor read the letter.
He asked Paul what province he was from.
He learned that Paul was from Cilicia.
35 Then he said, "I will hear your case when your accusers arrive too."
He ordered that Paul be kept under guard in Herod's palace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Third hour of the night means: about 9 o'clock in the evening.

Verse 23: Almost 500 soldiers protect one prisoner. That is how seriously the Roman takes the danger.

Verse 26: Now we learn the name of the commanding officer: Claudius Lysias. Felix was the Roman governor of Judea, from about AD 52 to 60.

Verse 27: In the letter Lysias presents himself a little better than things really were: He only learned later that Paul was a Roman (22:25–29).

Verse 29: The Roman also finds: Paul is innocent.

Verse 35: Herod's palace was the official residence of the governor in Caesarea.

ACTS

CHAPTER 24

Paul before the governor Felix

The accusation VERSES 1–8

1 After five days the high priest Ananias came down with some elders
and a speaker named Tertullus.
They brought charges against Paul before the governor.
2 Paul was called.
Then Tertullus began to accuse him, saying,
"Through you we enjoy much peace.
And through your foresight
things are getting better and better for this nation.
3 We accept this in all ways and in all places,
most excellent Felix,
with all thankfulness.
4 But I don't want to delay you for long.
I ask you
kindly to hear a few words from us.
5 For we have found
this man to be a plague.
He stirs up riots among all the Jews throughout the world.
He is a ringleader of the sect of the Nazarenes.
6 He even tried
to profane the temple.
So we arrested him.
7 By questioning him yourself
you can find out all these things
of which we accuse him."
8 The Jews also joined in the attack
and claimed
that these things were so.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sect means: a group with its own teaching.

Profane means: make something holy unclean.

About the numbering: In the WEB this chapter has 26 verses. Some Bibles have 27. There, verses 6–8 have a few more words: The accusers say they wanted to judge Paul by their law, but Lysias took him away from them. These words are missing in the oldest manuscripts. That is why the WEB leaves them out. Our verses 7–26 are verses 8–27 in some Bibles.

Verses 2–4: Tertullus flatters the governor. In reality Felix was known for his harshness.

Verse 5: "Nazarenes" was a name for the Christians, after Jesus of Nazareth.

Verse 8: "The Jews" here means the accusers from Jerusalem: the high priest and some elders.

Paul defends himself VERSES 9–20

9 The governor signaled to Paul
that he could speak.
Then Paul answered,
"I know
that you have been a judge of this nation for many years.
So I gladly make my defense.
10 You can check:
It is not more than 12 days
since I went up to Jerusalem
to worship.
11 They didn't find me in the temple
arguing with anyone
or stirring up a crowd,
either in the synagogues
or in the city.
12 Nor can they prove to you
the things of which they now accuse me.
13 But this I confess to you:
I serve the God of our ancestors
according to the Way,
which they call a sect.

I believe all things
which are according to the law
and which are written in the prophets.
14 I have hope in God,
which these men themselves also have:
that there will be a resurrection of the dead,
both of the just and the unjust.
15 So I also always try
to have a clear conscience
before God and people.
16 After some years I came
to bring gifts for the needy to my nation
and to offer sacrifices.
17 While I was doing this,
some Jews from Asia found me in the temple.
I had been purified.
I was not with a crowd
and made no noise.
18 They should have been here before you
to accuse me,
if they had anything against me.
19 Or else let these men themselves say
what wrong they found in me
when I stood before the council.
20 Unless it is about this one thing
that I cried out
as I stood among them:
'Concerning the resurrection of the dead
I am being judged before you today!'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: Paul says: I serve the God of our ancestors. I believe everything that is written in the law and in the prophets. He does not see his faith in Jesus as falling away from Judaism, but as part of it.

Verse 14: Paul shares the hope of the resurrection with many Jews, especially with the Pharisees.

Verse 16: Paul brought a collection of money for the poor in Jerusalem. He wanted to help his people.

Verse 17: "Some Jews from Asia": This is about a few particular people. They didn't even come as witnesses.

Felix hesitates VERSES 21–26

21 But Felix knew the Way well.
He put off the case and said,
"When Lysias, the commanding officer, comes down,
I will decide your case."
22 He ordered the centurion
to keep Paul in custody,
but to give him some freedoms.
None of his friends should be stopped
from serving him
or visiting him.
23 After some days Felix came
with his wife Drusilla,
who was Jewish.
He sent for Paul
and listened to him
speak about faith in Christ Jesus.
24 Paul spoke about righteousness,
self-control,
and the judgment to come.
Then Felix was terrified
and answered,
"Go away for now.
When it is convenient for me,
I will send for you again."
25 At the same time he hoped
that Paul would give him money,
so that he would release him.
So he sent for him often
and talked with him.
26 When two years had passed,
Felix was followed in office by Porcius Festus.
Felix wanted to do the Jews a favor
and left Paul in chains.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Custody means: being held as a prisoner.

Verse 22: Paul is allowed to have visitors. Friends take care of him. Prisoners depend on help from outside.

Verse 23: Drusilla was a daughter of King Herod Agrippa I (chapter 12).

Verse 24: Paul speaks about righteousness and self-control. This hits Felix, who was known for injustice.

Verse 25: Felix is waiting for a bribe. That is corruption and injustice.

Verse 26: Paul remains a prisoner for two years, although he is innocent, only for political reasons. "The Jews" here means the influential accusers in Jerusalem.

For today: Anyone who is in prison while innocent needs people who visit them and stand up for them. Human rights organizations still work for political prisoners today.

ACTS

CHAPTER 25

"I appeal to Caesar!"

Paul before Festus VERSES 1–12

1 Festus came into the province.
After three days he went up from Caesarea to
Jerusalem.
2 Then the high priest
and the leading men of the Jews
brought charges against Paul before him.
They begged him
3 for a favor against Paul:
He should have him brought to Jerusalem.
For they were planning
to kill him on the way.
4 But Festus answered
that Paul should be kept in custody at Caesarea.
And he himself was going back there soon.

5 He said,
"Those among you
who are in power
should go down with me.
If there is anything wrong in the man,
let them accuse him."
6 Festus stayed among them more than 10 days.
Then he went down to Caesarea.
The next day he sat on the judgment seat
and commanded
Paul to be brought in.
7 When Paul came,
the Jews
who had come down from Jerusalem
stood around him.
They brought many serious charges against him.
But they could not prove them.
8 Paul defended himself
and said,
"I have not sinned at all,
neither against the law of the Jews,
nor against the temple,
nor against Caesar."
9 But Festus wanted to do the Jews a favor.
He answered Paul,
"Are you willing to go up to Jerusalem
and be judged by me there about these things?"
10 But Paul said,
"I am standing before Caesar's judgment seat.
This is where I ought to be tried.
I have done no wrong to the Jews,
as you also know very well.
11 If I have done wrong
and have done anything
that deserves death,
I don't refuse to die.
But if none of the things is true
that they accuse me of,
no one can hand me over to them.
I appeal to Caesar!"
12 Then Festus talked with the council
and answered,
"You have appealed to Caesar.
To Caesar you shall go."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Appeal means: ask a higher court to decide.

Festus was the Roman governor of Judea from about AD 59/60.

Verses 2–3: Some leading men in Jerusalem are again planning a murder. "The Jews" here means this small group of powerful men, not the people.

Verse 8: Paul says: I have done nothing against the Jewish law or the temple. He remains a faithful Jew.

Verse 11: Every Roman citizen could demand that the emperor in Rome decide his case. Paul uses this right. In this way he comes to Rome, as Jesus had promised (23:11).

Verse 12: "The council" here is the governor's group of advisers, not the Jewish council.

Festus tells King Agrippa about Paul VERSES 13–22

13 After some days King Agrippa and Bernice
arrived at Caesarea
and greeted Festus.
14 They stayed there many days.
Then Festus told the king about Paul's case
and said,
"There is a man here
whom Felix left as a prisoner.
15 When I was at Jerusalem,
the chief priests and the elders of the Jews
brought charges against him.
They asked for a sentence against him.
16 I answered them:
It is not the custom of the Romans
to hand anyone over to be put to death
before the accused has met the accusers face to face
and has had the opportunity
to defend himself against the charge.
17 So when they had come together here,
I didn't delay.
The next day I sat on the judgment seat
and commanded
the man to be brought in.
18 When the accusers stood up,
they brought no charges about the crimes
I had expected.
19 Instead they had some arguments with him
about their own religion
and about a certain Jesus,
who was dead.
But Paul claimed
that he is alive.
20 I didn't know
how to look into these questions.
So I asked him
whether he was willing to go to Jerusalem
and be judged there about these matters.
21 But Paul asked
that his case be kept for the decision of the emperor.
So I commanded
him to be kept in custody
until I could send him to Caesar."
22 Agrippa said to Festus,
"I also would like to hear the man myself."
Festus said,
"Tomorrow you shall hear him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: King Agrippa II was a son of Herod Agrippa I (chapter 12). Bernice was his sister. Agrippa knew the Jewish customs well.

Verse 16: An important principle of law: Every accused person has the right to defend themselves. That still holds today.

Verse 19: For the Roman Festus all this is hard to understand: a Jesus who was dead, and Paul says he is alive. That is exactly the point: the resurrection.

Paul before Agrippa VERSES 23–27

23 The next day Agrippa and Bernice came
with great pomp.

They went into the hall of hearing,
together with the commanding officers
and the leading men of the city.
At the command of Festus, Paul was brought in.
24 Festus said,
"King Agrippa,
and all of you who are here with us!
You see this man.
All the multitude of the Jews have come to me about him,
both at Jerusalem and here.
They cried
that he ought not to live any longer.
25 But I found
that he had done nothing
that deserves death.
And because he himself appealed to the emperor,
I decided
to send him.
26 But I have nothing certain about him
to write to my lord.
So I have brought him out before you,
and especially before you, King Agrippa.
After this hearing
I may have something
to write.
27 For it seems unreasonable to me
to send a prisoner
without stating the charges against him."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Pomp means: a grand show of wealth and power.

Verse 24: "All the multitude of the Jews": Festus is exaggerating. He means the accusers and their followers.

Verse 25: Again a Roman official says: Paul is innocent.

Verse 26: "My lord" is the emperor in Rome, at that time Nero.

ACTS

CHAPTER 26

Paul speaks before King Agrippa

The hope of Israel VERSES 1–8

1 Agrippa said to Paul, "You may speak for yourself."
Then Paul raised his hand and began his defense:
2 "King Agrippa, I am glad that I can defend myself in front of you today.
The Jews accuse me of many things.
3 And you know all the customs and questions of the Jews very well.
So please listen to me patiently.
4 All the Jews know how I have lived since I was young.
From the beginning I lived among my own people and in Jerusalem.
5 They have known me for a long time.
If they are willing, they can say it:
I lived as a Pharisee.
The Pharisees are the strictest group in our religion.
6 And now I stand here on trial because of my hope.
I hope for what God promised our ancestors.
7 Our 12 tribes hope to see this promise come true.
That is why they serve God with all their hearts, night and day.
And because of this hope I am accused by the Jews,
King Agrippa!
8 Why do you all think it is impossible to believe that God raises the dead?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 4–5: Paul stresses his Jewish background. He was a Pharisee, so he kept the law very carefully.

Verses 6–7: The hope for which Paul is accused is the hope of Israel: that God keeps his promise. "Our 12 tribes" means the whole people of Israel.

Verse 7: "I am accused by the Jews": Paul means his accusers. In the same sentence he says: I share the hope of my people.

Verse 8: The resurrection of the dead is the heart of this hope.

Paul tells how he was called VERSES 9–23

9 "I myself was sure that I had to do many things against the name of Jesus of Nazareth.
10 And that is what I did in Jerusalem.
The chief priests gave me the power to put many of the saints in prison.
And when they were put to death, I voted against them.
11 Many times I punished them in all the synagogues.
I tried to force them to speak against God.
I was so angry with them that I even went to cities in other countries to persecute them.
12 So I went to Damascus.
The chief priests had given me the power and the orders to do this.
13 At noon, O king, I was on the road.
I saw a light from the sky.
It was brighter than the sun.
It shone around me and the men traveling with me.
14 We all fell to the ground.
Then I heard a voice speaking to me in the Hebrew language:
'Saul, Saul, why are you persecuting me?
It is hard for you to kick against the goads.'
15 I asked, 'Who are you, Lord?'
He said, 'I am Jesus, the one you are persecuting.
16 But get up and stand on your feet!
I have appeared to you for this reason:
I am choosing you to be my servant and my witness.
You will tell what you have seen.
And you will tell what I will still show you.
17 I will rescue you from your own people and from the Gentiles.

I am sending you to them
18 to open their eyes.
Then they will turn from darkness to light.
They will turn from the power of Satan to God.
Their sins will be forgiven.
They will receive a share among those who are made holy by faith in me.'
19 So, King Agrippa, I obeyed the vision from heaven.
20 First I preached to the people in Damascus.
Then I preached in Jerusalem and in the whole country of Judea.
I also preached to the Gentiles.
I told them that they should repent and turn to God.
And they should do things that show they have repented.
21 That is why the Jews took hold of me in the temple and tried to kill me.
22 But God has helped me until this day.
So I stand here and tell this to everyone, to the small and to the great.
I say nothing except what the prophets and Moses said would happen:
23 The Christ would suffer.
By rising from the dead, he would be the first to bring the message of light to these people and to the Gentiles."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Goad means: a pointed stick used to drive oxen.

Verses 10–11: Paul tells honestly and with shame how much he persecuted the Christians.

Verse 14: The voice says: "It is hard for you to kick against the goads." That was a saying. An ox that kicks against the pointed stick only hurts itself. It means: There is no point in fighting against God.

Verses 17–18: Paul is to "open their eyes." He himself was blind and was given his sight again (chapter 9).

Verse 21: "The Jews" means the people who seized him in the temple (21:27). Not the whole people.

Verses 22–23: Paul says: What I proclaim is already in Moses and the prophets. He sees himself fully within the tradition of Israel.

Do you want to make me a Christian? VERSES 24–32

24 Paul was still defending himself in this way when Festus shouted, "Paul, you are crazy!
All your learning is driving you insane!"
25 But Paul said, "I am not crazy, most excellent Festus.
What I am saying is true and makes good sense.
I say it boldly.
26 The king knows about these things.
So I can speak freely to him.
I am sure that none of these things is hidden from him.
This has not been done in a corner.
27 King Agrippa, do you believe the prophets?
I know that you believe them."
28 Agrippa said to Paul, "With so little persuasion, are you trying to make me a Christian?"
29 Paul said, "Whether with little or with much, I pray to God for this:
Not only you, but everyone who is listening to me today should become like me.
But I do not wish these chains on anyone."
30 Then the king stood up.
The governor and Bernice and everyone who sat with them stood up too.
31 They went out and talked with one another.
They said, "This man is doing nothing that deserves death or chains."
32 Agrippa said to Festus, "This man could have been set free if he had not appealed to Caesar."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 24: To Festus the resurrection sounds crazy. But Paul stays polite and calm.

Verse 26: "This has not been done in a corner": The life, death and resurrection of Jesus were publicly known.

Verse 28: Agrippa avoids the question. Perhaps his answer is meant mockingly, perhaps thoughtfully. That is not certain.

Verse 29: Paul wishes everyone faith, but no one his chains. He forces no one.

Verses 31–32: Again everyone says: Paul is innocent. Still he goes to Rome as a prisoner.

For today: You can't force faith on anyone. You can only invite, like Paul.

ACTS

CHAPTER 27

Storm and shipwreck

The journey begins VERSES 1–12

1 It was decided
that we should sail for Italy.
So they handed Paul and some other prisoners over to a centurion named Julius,
of the emperor's regiment.
2 We went on board a ship of Adramyttium,
which was about to sail to places on the coast of Asia,
and put to sea.
Aristarchus,
a Macedonian of Thessalonica,
was with us.
3 The next day we landed at Sidon.
Julius treated Paul kindly.
He allowed him
to go to his friends
and let them take care of him.
4 We put to sea from there.
Because the winds were against us,
we sailed in the shelter of Cyprus.

5 We sailed across the sea off Cilicia and Pamphylia
and came to Myra, a city of Lycia.
6 There the centurion found a ship of Alexandria
sailing for Italy.
He put us on board.
7 For many days we sailed slowly.
With difficulty we came near Cnidus.
The wind didn't let us go further.
So we sailed in the shelter of Crete,
past Salmone.
8 With difficulty we sailed along the coast
and came to a place called Fair Havens,
near the city of Lasea.
9 Much time had passed.
Sailing was now dangerous,
because the Fast had already gone by.
So Paul warned them
10 and said to them,
"Sirs,
I see
that this voyage will bring damage and much loss,
not only of the cargo and the ship,
but also of our lives."
11 But the centurion listened more to the captain
and to the owner of the ship
than to the things
Paul said.
12 The harbor was not suitable to spend the winter in.
So most of them advised
going to sea from there.
They wanted to try
to reach Phoenix
and spend the winter there.
That is a port of Crete,
facing southwest and northwest.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Shelter here means: the side of an island protected from the wind.

Verse 1: From here on Luke again tells the story in the "we" form. He was probably on the ship.

Verse 3: The Roman centurion Julius is kind to Paul. People who believe differently can also act kindly.

Verse 9: "The Fast" is the Jewish Day of Atonement, Yom Kippur, in the fall. After that, sailing on the Mediterranean was dangerous because of the storms.

Verse 11: The experts want to sail on. Paul warns them. Sadly, no one listens to him.

The storm VERSES 13–26

13 When a gentle south wind blew,
they thought
they had what they wanted.
They pulled up the anchor
and sailed along Crete, close to shore.
14 But soon after,
a stormy wind rushed down from the land.
It is called Euroclydon.
15 The ship was caught
and couldn't face the wind.
We gave up
and let ourselves be driven along.
16 We ran in the shelter of a small island called Clauda.
There, with difficulty, we were able to secure the
lifeboat.
17 They pulled it on board
and used ropes to tie the ship together
to make it stronger.
They were afraid
of running aground on the sandbars of Syrtis.
So they lowered the sea anchor
and so were driven along.
18 The storm battered us badly.
The next day they began
to throw cargo overboard.
19 On the third day they threw out the ship's equipment
with their own hands.
20 For many days
neither sun nor stars shone on us.
And the storm kept raging hard.
Then all hope
that we would be saved
was taken away.
21 They had been without food for a long time.
Then Paul stood up in the middle of them
and said,
"Sirs,
you should have listened to me
and not set sail from Crete.
Then you would have been spared this damage and
loss.
22 But now I urge you:
Cheer up!
For there will be no loss of life among you.
Only the ship will be lost.
23 For this night an angel stood by me.
He comes from the God
to whom I belong
and whom I serve.
24 He said,
'Don't be afraid, Paul!
You must stand before Caesar.
And God has granted you all those
who sail with you.'
25 So, sirs,
cheer up!
For I believe God
that it will be just
as it has been told to me.
26 But we must run aground on an island."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sea anchor means: a device dragged behind a ship to slow it down.

Verse 14: "Euroclydon" was a dangerous northeast wind.

Verse 17: The Syrtis are dangerous sandbars off the coast of North Africa, in today's Libya.

Verse 20: Without sun and stars, the sailors couldn't know where they were. Everyone loses hope.

Verses 21–26: In the middle of despair Paul gives them courage. He trusts God. And God saves not only him, but everyone on the ship.

For today: Even in great distress you may hope in God. If you are in despair, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988.

In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123.
Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The shipwreck VERSES 27–44

27 It was the fourteenth night.
We were driven back and forth in the Adriatic Sea.
About midnight the sailors suspected
that they were coming near to land.
28 They measured the depth
and found 20 fathoms (about 120 feet).
After a little while they measured again
and found 15 fathoms (about 90 feet).
29 They were afraid
of running onto rocks.
So they let down four anchors from the back of the ship
and wished for daylight.
30 The sailors tried
to flee from the ship.
They lowered the lifeboat into the sea
and pretended
that they wanted to put out anchors from the front of the ship.
31 Then Paul said to the centurion and to the soldiers,
"Unless these stay in the ship,
you can't be saved."
32 Then the soldiers cut the ropes of the lifeboat
and let it fall off.
33 As day was coming,
Paul begged them all
to take some food.
He said,
"Today is the fourteenth day
that you have been waiting
and fasting
and have eaten nothing.
34 So I beg you
to take some food.
This is for your safety.
For not a hair will perish from any of your heads."
35 When he had said this,
he took bread,
gave thanks to God in front of everyone,
broke it
and began to eat.
36 Then they all cheered up
and also took food.
37 In all, we were
276 people on the ship.
38 When they had eaten enough,
they made the ship lighter
by throwing the wheat into the sea.
39 When it was day,
they didn't recognize the land.
But they noticed a bay with a beach.
They decided to try
to run the ship onto it.
40 They cut off the anchors
and left them in the sea.
At the same time they untied the ropes of the rudders.
They raised the front sail to the wind
and headed for the beach.
41 But they came to a place
where two seas met.
There the ship ran aground.
The front stuck fast
and could not be moved.
But the back began to break up
from the force of the waves.
42 The soldiers planned to kill the prisoners,
so that none of them would swim away and escape.
43 But the centurion wanted to save Paul
and stopped them.
He commanded
that those who could swim
should jump overboard first
and go to land.
44 The rest should follow,
some on planks
and some on other pieces of the ship.
So they all got safely to land.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Fathom means: a measure of depth, about 6 feet (1.8 meters).

Verse 27: At that time the "Adriatic Sea" meant the whole sea between Greece, Italy and Africa.

Verse 28: 20 fathoms are about 120 feet (36 meters).

Verse 35: Paul takes bread, gives thanks to God and breaks it, as Jesus did. In the middle of the storm a meal becomes a sign of hope.

Verse 37: The ship was large: 276 people were on board.

Verses 42–43: The soldiers want to kill the prisoners, because they themselves would be punished harshly for every prisoner who escaped. The centurion prevents this.

Verse 44: As Paul had said: Everyone is saved. No one dies.

For today: In an emergency you help everyone, not only your own people.

ACTS

CHAPTER 28

Paul comes to Rome

On the island of Malta VERSES 1–10

1 When we had escaped,
we learned
that the island was called Malta.
2 The local people showed us unusual kindness.
They lit a fire
and welcomed us all,
because it was raining
and it was cold.

3 Paul gathered a bundle of sticks
and laid them on the fire.
Then a viper came out because of the heat
and fastened itself on his hand.
4 When the local people saw the creature hanging from his hand,
they said to one another,
"No doubt this man is a murderer.
Though he has escaped from the sea,
Justice has not allowed him to live."
5 But Paul shook off the creature into the fire.
He wasn't harmed.
6 They expected
that he would swell up
or suddenly fall down dead.
They watched for a long time.
But when they saw
that nothing bad happened to him,
they changed their minds
and said
that he was a god.
7 Near that place
the chief man of the island had lands.
His name was Publius.
He welcomed us
and kindly took care of us for three days.
8 The father of Publius lay sick in bed
with fever and dysentery.
Paul went in to him,
prayed,
laid his hands on him
and healed him.
9 After this the other sick people on the island
also came
and were cured.
10 They honored us with many honors.
And when we sailed,
they put on board the things
we needed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Viper means: a poisonous snake.

Dysentery means: a serious illness of the bowels.

Verse 2: The people of Malta help strangers who have been shipwrecked. Hospitality toward people in need is a sign of humanity.

Verse 4: "Justice" (in Greek *Dike*) was a goddess for the people there. They thought: Whoever goes through something terrible must be guilty. That is not true. Misfortune is not a punishment.

Verse 6: First they think Paul is a murderer, then a god. Both are wrong. He is a human being who trusts God.

Verse 8: Paul prays and lays his hands on him. The healing comes from God.

For today: Whoever takes in people in need does something good, no matter where they come from.

From Malta to Rome VERSES 11–16

11 After three months we set sail in a ship of Alexandria.
It had spent the winter at the island.
Its figurehead was "The Twin Brothers."
12 We landed at Syracuse
and stayed there three days.
13 From there we sailed around
and arrived at Rhegium.
After one day a south wind came up.
On the second day we came to Puteoli.
14 There we found brothers.
They begged us
to stay with them for seven days.
And so we came to Rome.
15 The brothers there had heard about us.
They came to meet us as far as The Market of Appius
and The Three Taverns.
When Paul saw them,
he thanked God
and took courage.
16 When we came into Rome,
the centurion handed the prisoners over to the captain of the guard.
But Paul was allowed to live by himself,
with the soldier
who guarded him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Figurehead means: a carved figure on the front of a ship.

Verse 11: "The Twin Brothers" were Castor and Pollux, two gods who, as sailors believed, protected ships.

Verse 14: There are already Christians in Italy. Paul is not the first to bring the good news to Italy.

Verse 15: The Christians from Rome walk a long way to meet Paul. The Market of Appius was about 40 miles (65 kilometers) from Rome. Paul takes courage: He is not alone.

Verse 16: Paul is a prisoner, but he may live in his own lodging, guarded by a soldier.

Paul speaks with the Jews in Rome VERSES 17–29

17 After three days
Paul called together the leaders of the Jews.
When they had come together,
he said to them,
"Brothers,
I have done nothing against our people
or the customs of our ancestors.
Still I was handed over as a prisoner from Jerusalem
into the hands of the Romans.
18 They questioned me
and wanted to set me free,
because I had done nothing
that deserves death.
19 But the Jews spoke against it.
So I was forced
to appeal to Caesar.
But I have nothing to accuse my nation of.
20 For this reason I asked
to see you
and to speak with you.
For because of the hope of Israel
I am bound with this chain."
21 They said to him,
"We have received no letters about you from Judea.
And none of the brothers has come here
and reported or said anything bad about you.

22 But we want to hear from you
what you think.
For about this sect we know
that everywhere people speak against it."
23 They set a day with him.
Then many people came to him at his lodging.
He explained everything to them
and testified about God's Kingdom.
From morning until evening
he tried
to persuade them about Jesus,
from the law of Moses
and from the prophets.
24 Some believed
the things
that were spoken.
Others did not believe.
25 They didn't agree among themselves
and left.
Before that, Paul spoke one more message:
"The Holy Spirit spoke rightly
through Isaiah the prophet to our ancestors.
26 He said,
'Go to this people and say:
You will hear and hear,
but will in no way understand.
You will see and see,
but will in no way really see.
27 For this people's heart has grown hard.
Their ears hear with difficulty.
They have closed their eyes.
Otherwise they would see with their eyes,
hear with their ears,
understand with their heart,
and turn again,
and I would heal them.'
28 So know this:
The salvation of God is sent to the nations,
and they will listen."
29 When he had said these words,
the Jews left
and argued strongly among themselves.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Lodging means: a place where someone lives for a while.

Verses 17–20: Paul calls the Jews in Rome "Brothers." He says: I have nothing against my people. He is bound with this chain "because of the hope of Israel." Paul stays connected with his people to the very end.

Verse 24: Some Jews come to faith, others don't. The people are not against Paul; they are divided.

Verses 26–27 quote Isaiah 6:9–10. The prophet Isaiah said these words to his own people. They are a lament from within Israel, not a judgment from outside.

Verse 28: This does not mean that God has rejected his people Israel. In his letter to the Romans, Paul himself writes that God has not rejected his people (Romans 11:1–2). God's gifts and his calling cannot be taken back (Romans 11:29).

Important: In history Christians often used these verses to claim that God had rejected the Jews. That was wrong and caused much suffering. Today the churches teach: God's covenant with Israel remains valid (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965).

Verse 29: This verse is missing in some old manuscripts. The WEB has it.

Paul preaches in Rome VERSES 30–31

30 Paul stayed two whole years
in his own rented house.
He welcomed all
who came to him.
31 He preached God's Kingdom
and taught about the Lord Jesus Christ
with all boldness,
without hindrance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The book ends open. We don't learn how Paul's trial ended. According to old tradition, Paul later died in Rome as a martyr, probably under the emperor Nero.

Verse 31: The last word of the book in Greek means "without hindrance." Paul is a prisoner, but the word of God is not a prisoner.

At the beginning Jesus had said that the apostles would be his witnesses to the ends of the earth (1:8). Now the good news has arrived in Rome, at the center of the world of that time.

Looking back: What have we read in the Acts of the Apostles?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The continuation of Luke's Gospel: Luke tells what happens after Easter. Jesus goes to the Father, but he sends the Holy Spirit.

Pentecost: The Holy Spirit comes. People from many countries hear the good news in their own language. The church begins.

The first church: The first Christians share, pray, break bread together and care for the poor. They live as Jews and pray in the temple.

From Jerusalem to Rome: The good news goes to Samaria, to the man from Ethiopia, to the Roman centurion Cornelius, and finally into the whole world.

God shows no favoritism: At the meeting of the apostles in Jerusalem (chapter 15) it is decided: People from all nations belong, without first having to become Jews.

Peter and Paul: Peter leads the church at the beginning. Paul, the former persecutor, becomes the great missionary to the nations. He travels through Asia Minor and Greece, and in the end he comes to Rome as a prisoner.

Women in the church: Tabitha, Lydia, Priscilla, the daughters of Philip and many others play an important role.

Important note: In Acts there is conflict between the apostles and some Jewish groups. But the apostles were Jews themselves. Many thousands of Jews came to faith. To the very end Paul calls the Jews "Brothers." No text of this book may be used against the Jewish people.

For today: The Holy Spirit makes people brave. The good news is there for all people. "Without hindrance": God's word cannot be stopped.

What comes next? Next comes Paul's letter to the Romans. It is Paul's longest and perhaps most important letter. He wrote it to the church in Rome before he came there himself. In it he explains how God makes people righteous: through faith, by grace.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 45 OF 66

ROMANS

16 CHAPTERS

ROMANS

Chapter 1

The Good News is the power of God

Before we begin: The letter to the Romans

The letter to the Romans is a letter from the apostle Paul to the Christians in Rome. Paul probably wrote it around AD 56 or 57, probably in Corinth. He had never been to Rome, but he wanted to go there soon (compare Acts 19:21 and 28).

The church in Rome was made up of Christians of Jewish background and Christians who came from other nations. Paul explains to them in detail what the Good News of Jesus means: God accepts all people, Jews and non-Jews, not because of what they achieve, but by grace, through faith.

The letter to the Romans is one of the most important texts of Christianity. It deeply shaped people like Augustine and Martin Luther. The churches argued for a long time about some passages. Today they agree on many things, for example in the *Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification* of 1999.

Important note: In chapters 9 to 11 Paul writes in detail about Israel. He says: God has not rejected his people. His gifts and his calling cannot be taken back. Today these chapters are the basis for the churches recognizing God's lasting covenant with the Jewish people.

Paul sometimes writes difficult and long sentences. We divide them into short sentences, but we leave nothing out.

The letter to the Romans has 16 chapters.

Greeting to the church in Rome VERSES 1–7

1 Paul,
a servant of Jesus Christ,
called to be an apostle,
set apart for the Good News of God.
2 God promised this Good News beforehand
through his prophets in the holy Scriptures.
3 It is about his Son.
He was born of the offspring of David according to the flesh.
4 Through the Spirit of holiness
he was declared to be the Son of God with power,
by the resurrection from the dead:
Jesus Christ our Lord.
5 Through him we received grace and apostleship,
to bring about the obedience of faith
among all the nations
for the sake of his name.
6 You are also among them.
You too are called
to belong to Jesus Christ.
7 To all who are in Rome,
who are loved by God
and called
to be saints:
Grace to you and peace
from God our Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Apostle means: someone sent out by Jesus with his message.

Saints here means: all who belong to God.

In those days a letter began with the name of the sender and a greeting. Paul turns this into a small confession of faith.

Verse 1: "Servant" means: Paul belongs completely to Jesus and serves him.

Verse 2: The Good News is not something completely new. God already promised it in the Bible of Israel.

Verse 3: The WEB, our English source text, says "according to the flesh." That means: as a human being. Jesus was a descendant of King David, so he was a Jew.

Verse 7: "Saints" are all Christians. Holy means: belonging to God.

"Grace" and "peace": Grace recalls the Greek greeting, peace (shalom) the Hebrew one. Paul joins the two.

Paul wants to come to Rome VERSES 8–15

8 First, I thank my God
through Jesus Christ for all of you.
For your faith is spoken of throughout the whole world.
9 God is my witness.
I serve him in my spirit
in the Good News of his Son.
He knows
how I always remember you in my prayers
without ceasing.
10 I ask
that now at last I may succeed
in coming to you by the will of God.
11 For I long
to see you.
I want to share some spiritual gift with you,
so that you may be made strong.
12 That is,
I want to be encouraged together with you,
each of us by the other's faith,
both yours and mine.
13 Brothers,
I want you to know:
I often planned
to come to you.
But so far I have been prevented.
I wanted to have some fruit among you also,
as among the rest of the Gentiles.
14 I am in debt
both to Greeks and to foreigners,
both to the wise and to the foolish.
15 So as much as I can,
I am eager
to preach the Good News to you also who are in Rome.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Paul doesn't only want to give, but also to receive. They strengthen each other's faith.

Verse 14: "To Greeks and to foreigners": This means all people, educated or not, from all cultures. Paul feels he owes something to all of them.

The power of the Good News VERSES 16–17

16 For I am not ashamed of the Good News of Christ.
For it is the power of God
for salvation
for everyone who believes,
for the Jew first,
and also for the Greek.
17 For in it God's righteousness is revealed,
from faith to faith.
As it is written,
"But the righteous shall live by faith."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Righteousness means: being right with God.

Verses 16–17 are like a heading over the whole letter.

"For the Jew first": For Paul, Israel has a special place. The Good News comes from Israel and is meant first for Israel.

Verse 17 quotes Habakkuk 2:4. "God's righteousness" means: God makes people righteous. He gives them a good relationship with himself. This happens through faith, that is, through trusting God.

This verse was especially important for Martin Luther. It became the heart of the Reformation.

All people need God VERSES 18–32

18 For the anger of God is revealed from heaven
against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of people
who hold down the truth by unrighteousness.
19 For what can be known about God
is plain to them.
God has shown it to them.
20 For since the creation of the world
his invisible qualities
are clearly seen in the things he has made:
his everlasting power and divinity.
So they are without excuse.
21 For they knew God,
but they didn't glorify him as God
and didn't give thanks.
Instead their thinking became empty,
and their senseless heart was darkened.
22 They claimed
to be wise,
and became fools.
23 They traded the glory of the God who never decays
for images
that look like human beings who decay,
and like birds,
four-footed animals,
and creeping things.
24 So God gave them up
to the lusts of their hearts,
to uncleanness,
so that their bodies were dishonored among
themselves.
25 They exchanged the truth of God for a lie.
They worshiped and served the creature
rather than the Creator.
He is blessed forever.
Amen.
26 For this reason God gave them up
to shameful passions.
For their women changed the natural function
into that which is against nature.
27 Likewise the men also
left the natural function of the woman
and burned in their lust toward one another.
Men did with men
what is inappropriate.
And they received in themselves
the penalty
their error deserved.
28 Because they refused
to have God in their knowledge,
God gave them up to a corrupt mind,
so that they do
what is not fitting.
29 They are filled with all unrighteousness,
sexual immorality,
wickedness,
greed
and malice.
They are full of envy,
murder,
strife,
deceit
and evil habits.
They are secret slanderers,
30 backbiters,
hateful to God,
insolent,
arrogant,
boastful,
inventors of evil things,
disobedient to parents,
31 without understanding,
unfaithful to promises,
without natural affection,
unforgiving
and unmerciful.
32 They know what God has ruled:
Those who do such things
are worthy of death.
Yet they not only do the same themselves,
but also approve of others
who do them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Slanderer means: someone who tells lies about others.

Verses 18–32: Paul describes what the world looks like when people don't honor God: They make their own gods, and much injustice follows from that. "The anger of God" means: God takes evil seriously. He lets people feel the results of what they do ("God gave them up").

Verse 20: You can recognize God in creation, in nature and its greatness.

Verses 29–31: The long list shows: It is about many kinds of wrong, including very everyday ones like envy, strife,

gossip and arrogance. No one can leave themselves out.

Important: Right at the beginning of the next chapter Paul says that whoever judges others has no excuse, whoever they are (2:1). Whoever points at others is also meant. Paul wants to show: All people need God's grace.

Verses 26–27: These verses speak about same-sex sexuality. Today the churches understand them in different ways. Some churches see them as a lasting command against same-sex relationships. Other churches say: Paul had mainly the practices of his time in mind, for example exploitation and cult practices, not loving, faithful partnerships as we know them today. Many churches are seriously wrestling with this question.

Very important: These verses give no one the right to despise, insult or persecute people or to use violence against them. Every person has the same dignity. If you experience exclusion or violence because of your sexual orientation, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988; young LGBTQ people can also contact The Trevor Project. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 32: "Worthy of death" describes God's judgment on sin. It is not a call for people to kill or punish others.

ROMANS

CHAPTER 2

God judges all people fairly

Whoever judges others VERSES 1–11

1 So you have no excuse,
you human being who judges,
whoever you are.
For in the things you judge another,
you condemn yourself.
For you
who judge
do the same things.
2 We know
that the judgment of God
against those who do such things
is according to truth.
3 You human being,
you judge those
who do such things,
and you do the same yourself.
Do you think
that you will escape the judgment of God?
4 Or do you despise the riches of his goodness,
his patience
and his forbearance?
Don't you know
that the goodness of God leads you to repentance?
5 But you have a hard heart
that doesn't want to repent.
So you are storing up anger for yourself
for the day of anger,
when the righteous judgment of God will be revealed.
6 He "will pay back to everyone according to their
works":
7 To those
who patiently keep doing good
and seek glory, honor and what never decays,
he gives eternal life.
8 But to those
who are self-seeking
and don't obey the truth,
but obey unrighteousness,
there will be anger and fury,
9 oppression and anguish
on every human being
who does evil,
to the Jew first,
and also to the Greek.
10 But glory, honor and peace go to everyone
who does good,
to the Jew first,
and also to the Greek.
11 For there is no partiality with God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Forbearance means: holding back punishment, patience.

Partiality means: treating some people better than others.

Verse 1: Paul turns around. He has just described the sins of the world. Now he says: Whoever points a finger at others is also meant.

No one is better than the others.

Verse 4: A beautiful sentence: The goodness of God leads to repentance. God doesn't threaten first; he invites.

Verse 6 quotes Psalm 62:12 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 62:13) and Proverbs 24:12.

Verses 9–10: "To the Jew first, and also to the Greek": Israel has a special place with God. But God measures everyone with the same measure.

Verse 11: "No partiality": God does not favor anyone because of their background, wealth or reputation.

The law in the heart VERSES 12–16

12 All
who have sinned without the law
will also perish without the law.
And all
who have sinned under the law
will be judged by the law.
13 For it isn't those
who hear the law
who are righteous before God.
But those
who do the law
will be declared righteous.
14 For when Gentiles
who don't have the law
do by nature

the things the law requires,
they are a law to themselves,
even though they don't have the law.
15 In this way they show:
The work of the law
is written in their hearts.
Their conscience testifies to it,
and their thoughts accuse them
or else excuse them.
16 This will be seen on the day
when God will judge the secrets of people
through Jesus Christ,
as my Good News says.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Conscience means: the inner voice that tells us what is right and wrong.

Verse 12: "The law" is the Torah, which God gave to Israel. The other nations didn't know it.

Verses 14–15: People who don't know the Bible also have a conscience. They often know what is good and evil. God has written it in their hearts.

For today: The conscience is a gift from God. Many people of other religions or of no religion do good.

What makes someone a Jew VERSES 17–29

17 But you call yourself a Jew.
You rely on the law
and boast in God.
18 You know his will
and can tell
what is excellent,
because you have been taught by the law.
19 You are sure
that you are a guide of the blind,
a light to those
who are in darkness,
20 a corrector of the foolish,
a teacher of babies.
For in the law you have the form of knowledge and of the truth.
21 So you teach others.
Don't you teach yourself?
You preach
that people shouldn't steal.
Do you steal?
22 You say
that people shouldn't commit adultery.
Do you commit adultery?
You hate idols.
Do you rob temples?
23 You boast in the law.
Do you dishonor God
by disobeying the law?
24 For "the name of God is blasphemed among the Gentiles because of you,"
just as it is written.
25 Circumcision is indeed useful
if you do the law.
But if you break the law,
your circumcision has become uncircumcision.
26 So if the uncircumcised
keep the commands of the law,
won't their uncircumcision
be counted as circumcision?
27 And won't those
who are physically uncircumcised
but fulfill the law
judge you?
For you have the letter of the law and circumcision,
and yet you break the law.
28 For he is not a Jew
who is one only outwardly.
And circumcision is not only what is outward in the flesh.
29 But he is a Jew
who is one inwardly.
And circumcision is that of the heart,
in the spirit,
not in the letter.
His praise does not come from people,
but from God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Circumcision means: cutting away the foreskin; the sign of God's covenant with Israel.

Important: Paul is a Jew himself. Here he writes like a prophet who warns his own people. He speaks to an imagined partner in a conversation, as teachers did at that time. This is not about the Jews as a whole.

Verses 17–20: Paul lists the real gifts of Israel: the law, the knowledge of God's will, the task of being a light for the nations. These are great gifts from God.

Verses 21–23: Paul warns against hypocrisy: teaching others but acting differently yourself. This warning is for all people, and especially for Christians.

Verse 24 quotes Isaiah 52:5.

Verse 29: "Circumcision is that of the heart": This is a picture from the Bible of Israel itself (Deuteronomy 10:16; Jeremiah 4:4). God wants the heart, not only outward signs.

Important: These verses were later misused to claim that Jews were no longer *real* Jews. Paul did not mean that. In chapter 3 he says right away that the advantage of the Jews is great (3:1–2). And in chapter 11: God has not rejected his people.

ROMANS

CHAPTER 3

Made right by grace, through faith

God remains faithful VERSES 1–8

1 So what advantage does the Jew have?
What good is circumcision?

2 It is good in many ways!
First of all, God trusted the Jews with his words.
3 What if some of them were not faithful?
Does that mean that God is not faithful?
4 Of course not!
God is always true, even if every person is a liar.
As it is written:
"So you are shown to be right in what you say.
You win when you are judged."
5 But maybe our wrongdoing shows even more clearly
that God is right.
What can we say then?
Is God unfair when he punishes us in his anger?
(I am speaking the way people talk.)
6 Of course not!
If that were so, how could God judge the world?
7 Maybe my lie makes God's truth shine even more.
Maybe it brings him more glory.
Then why am I still judged as a sinner?
8 Then why not say, "Let's do evil, so that good may come
of it"?
Some people slander us.
They claim that we say this.
They deserve to be condemned.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: Paul says clearly: The advantage of the Jews is great. God entrusted his word, the Holy Scriptures, to them.

Verses 3–4: Even when people are unfaithful, God remains faithful. God's faithfulness to Israel does not end. This is very important for the relationship between Christians and Jews.

Verse 4 quotes Psalm 51:4 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 51:6).

Verses 5–8: Paul goes through objections, as in a debate. He rejects the idea that you may do evil so that God appears all the more gracious.

All people need God's grace VERSES 9–20

9 So what does this mean?
Are we better than they are?
No, not at all!
We have already warned both Jews and Greeks
that they are all under the power of sin.
10 As it is written:
"There is no one righteous; no, not one.
11 There is no one who understands.
There is no one who looks for God.
12 They have all turned away.
All of them together have become useless.
There is no one who does good, no, not even one."
13 "Their throat is an open grave.
They use their tongues to lie."
"The poison of snakes is under their lips."
14 "Their mouth is full of cursing and bitterness."
15 "Their feet run quickly to shed blood.
16 Wherever they go, they leave ruin and misery.
17 They have never known the way of peace."
18 "They have no fear of God at all."
19 We know that the law speaks to those who live under
the law.
So every mouth must be closed.
The whole world must stand before God's judgment.
20 For no one will be justified before God by the works of
the law.
The law only shows us what sin is.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Justified means: declared righteous by God.

Verse 9: "We" here probably means the Jews, to whom Paul himself belongs. He says: We are not better, but not worse either. All people, Jews and non-Jews, need God's grace.

Verses 10–18 are a collection of quotations from the Bible of Israel: Psalm 14:1–3 (and Psalm 53), Psalm 5:9 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 5:10), Psalm 140:3 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 140:4), Psalm 10:7, Isaiah 59:7–8 and Psalm 36:1 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 36:2).

"The works of the law" (verse 20) means: doing what the law requires. Paul says: No one can make themselves righteous before God by their own achievement. Verse 20 recalls Psalm 143:2.

Verse 20: The law is good. It shows what is right and wrong. But it cannot set people free from sin.

Made right by grace VERSES 21–31

21 But now God has shown his righteousness.
He has shown it apart from the law.
The law and the prophets also speak about it.
22 God makes people righteous through faith in Jesus
Christ.
He does this for all who believe.
There is no difference between people.
23 For all have sinned, and fall short of the glory of God.
24 But God makes them righteous as a free gift, by his
grace.
He does this through the redemption that is in Christ
Jesus.
That means: Christ Jesus sets them free.
25 God gave Jesus as an atoning sacrifice, through his
blood.
People receive this through faith.
In this way God wanted to show that he is righteous.
For God was patient.
He did not punish the sins people had done before.
26 Now, at this time, God shows his righteousness:
He himself is righteous.
And he makes righteous everyone who has faith in
Jesus.
27 So can anyone boast?
No, there is no room for boasting.
Why not?
Because of the law of works?
No, because of the law of faith.
28 So we say: A person is justified by faith, apart from the
works of the law.
29 Or is God only the God of the Jews?
Isn't he also the God of the Gentiles?
Yes, he is the God of the Gentiles too.
30 For there is only one God.
He will justify the circumcised by faith.
And he will justify the uncircumcised through faith.

31 So does faith mean that the law no longer counts?
Of course not!
No, faith makes the law stand firm.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Redemption means: being set free, being bought free.

Atoning sacrifice means: an offering that makes peace between God and people.

Verses 21–26 are the heart of the letter to the Romans. The message is: God makes people righteous. Not because they deserve it, but as a gift, by grace, through Jesus Christ.

Verse 23: "All have sinned": No one is without guilt. But no one is shut out from God's grace either.

Verse 25: "Atoning sacrifice": This recalls the Day of Atonement in the temple (Leviticus 16). Christians believe: Through the death of Jesus God gives reconciliation. How exactly to understand this is something the churches still think about today.

Verse 28: In his German translation, Martin Luther added the word *alone* here. This word is not in the Greek text and not in the WEB either. There was a long argument about it. In the *Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification* (1999), the Catholic Church and the Lutheran World Federation stated together: We are made righteous by grace alone, in faith, not because of our merits.

Verses 29–30: God is the one God of all people, of the Jews and of the other nations.

Verse 31: Paul says clearly: Faith does not cancel the law, but establishes it. God's law remains good and holy.

ROMANS

Chapter 4

Abraham, the father of all who believe

Abraham believed God VERSES 1–12

1 What then will we say?
What has Abraham,
our forefather according to the flesh,
found?
2 For if Abraham was justified by works,
he would have something
to boast about,
but not before God.
3 For what does the Scripture say?
"Abraham believed God,
and it was accounted to him for righteousness."
4 To someone who works,
the wage is not counted as a gift,
but as something
that is owed.
5 But to someone who doesn't work,
but believes in him
who justifies the ungodly,
his faith is accounted for righteousness.
6 So David also calls the person blessed
to whom God counts righteousness
apart from works:
7 "Blessed are they
whose iniquities are forgiven,
whose sins are covered.
8 Blessed is the man
whom the Lord will by no means charge with sin."
9 Is this blessing then only for the circumcised,
or for the uncircumcised also?
For we say
that faith was accounted to Abraham for
righteousness.
10 When was it counted?
When he was already circumcised,
or when he was still uncircumcised?
Not when he was circumcised,
but when he was still uncircumcised.
11 He received the sign of circumcision
as a seal of the righteousness of the faith
which he already had
while he was uncircumcised.
So he was to be the father of all
who believe,
even if they are uncircumcised,
so that righteousness might also be counted to them.
12 And he is also the father of the circumcised
who are not only circumcised,
but also walk in the steps of the faith
that our father Abraham had
while he was still uncircumcised.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Accounted means: counted, credited.

Iniquities means: wrong deeds.

Seal means: a mark that confirms something.

Abraham is the forefather of Israel. Paul uses him to show: At the very beginning there was faith, trust in God.

Verse 3 quotes Genesis 15:6. Paul quotes this verse several times.

Verse 5: "Him who justifies the ungodly": God accepts people before they are good. That is grace.

Verses 7–8 quote Psalm 32:1–2.

Verses 10–11: Abraham believed God (Genesis 15) before he was circumcised (Genesis 17). So he can be the father of all who believe, from Israel and from all nations.

Important: Abraham is the common father of Jews and Christians. Islam also refers to Abraham. Abraham connects people; he doesn't divide them.

The promise is for all VERSES 13–17

13 For the promise to Abraham and to his offspring,
that he would be heir of the world,
did not come through the law,
but through the righteousness of faith.
14 For if those
who are of the law
are the heirs,

then faith is made empty
and the promise is made of no effect.
15 For the law brings anger.
For where there is no law,
there is no disobedience either.
16 For this reason it is of faith,
so that it may be by grace.
So the promise is to be sure for all the offspring:
not only for those
who are of the law,
but also for those
who are of the faith of Abraham.
He is the father of us all.
17 As it is written,
"I have made you a father of many nations."
He is this in the presence of God,
in whom he believed:
the God
who gives life to the dead
and calls the things
that are not,
as though they were.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Heir means: someone who receives an inheritance.

Verse 13: "Heir of the world": God had promised Abraham that all nations would be blessed through him (Genesis 12:3).

Verse 15: The law shows what is wrong. That is why it makes disobedience visible.

Verse 16: "The father of us all": Abraham is the father of the Jews and of those who believe from all nations. Both belong to his offspring.

Verse 17 quotes Genesis 17:5. God calls into being what does not yet exist. He can create something new out of nothing.

Abraham trusted against all hope VERSES 18–25

18 Against hope,
Abraham in hope believed
that he would become a father of many nations,
as it had been told to him:
"So will your offspring be."
19 He was not weakened in faith.
He didn't look at his own body,
which was already worn out,
for he was about 100 years old.
And he didn't look at the fact
that Sarah's womb was as good as dead.
20 He looked to the promise of God.
He didn't waver through unbelief,
but grew strong through faith.
He gave glory to God
21 and was fully sure:
What God has promised,
he is also able to do.
22 So it also was
"credited to him for righteousness."
23 But it was not written only for his sake
that it was counted to him,
24 but for our sake also.
It will be counted to us too,
when we believe in him
who raised Jesus our Lord
from the dead.
25 He was handed over for our trespasses
and was raised
for our justification.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Trespasses means: wrongs, sins.

Verse 18: "Against hope, Abraham in hope believed": He trusts God, although it seems humanly impossible.

Verse 18 quotes Genesis 15:5. God had shown Abraham the stars in the sky: You will have that many descendants.

Verse 19: Abraham was almost 100,

and Sarah was old. Still they had a son, Isaac (Genesis 21).

Verses 24–25: What was true for Abraham is also true for us: God accepts us when we trust him. The center of faith is Jesus, who died for us and was raised.

For today: Even when a situation seems hopeless, you may trust God. If you can't see any hope, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

ROMANS

CHAPTER 5

Peace with God

Peace and hope VERSES 1–11

1 God has made us righteous through faith.
So now we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ.
2 Through Jesus we can come into God's grace by faith.
We now stand in this grace.
And we rejoice because we hope to share in the glory of God.
3 But that is not all.
We also rejoice in our sufferings.
For we know that suffering produces perseverance.
4 Perseverance produces proven character.
And proven character produces hope.
5 And this hope will not let us down.
For God has poured his love into our hearts.
He did this through the Holy Spirit, whom he has given to us.
6 We were still weak.
But at the right time Christ died for the ungodly.
7 It is rare for anyone to die even for a righteous person.
Maybe someone would dare to die for a good person.
8 But God shows how much he loves us:
Christ died for us while we were still sinners.

9 Now we have been made righteous by his blood.
So we can be even more sure that he will save us from God's anger.
10 We were God's enemies.
But we were made friends with God again through the death of his Son.
Now we are his friends again.
So we can be even more sure that the life of his Son will save us.
11 But that is not all.
We also rejoice in God through our Lord Jesus Christ.
Through him we have now been reconciled with God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Perseverance means: keeping going in hard times.

Reconciled means: made friends again after being apart.

Verse 1: "Peace with God": The relationship with God is whole again. We no longer need to be afraid of God.

Verses 3–5: Suffering is not good. But Paul says: Even in hard times something can grow: perseverance, proven character, hope. This doesn't mean that you should look for suffering. Whoever suffers may lament and get help.

Verse 5: God's love is like water that flows into our hearts.

Verse 8 is one of the most beautiful sentences in the Bible: God doesn't love us only once we are good. He loved us already while we were still sinners.

Verse 10: "Enemies": People stood against God. But God has given reconciliation.

For today: If you are going through deep suffering, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Adam and Christ VERSES 12–21

12 Sin came into the world through one man.
And through sin came death.
So death came to all people, because all have sinned.
13 Even before the law was given, sin was in the world.
But where there is no law, sin is not counted.
14 Still, death ruled from the time of Adam to the time of Moses.
It even ruled over people whose sins were not like Adam's disobedience.
Adam is a foreshadowing of the one who was to come.
15 But the free gift is not like Adam's sin.
Through the sin of one man, many people died.
But God's grace is much greater.
The gift of grace came through one man, Jesus Christ.
And this gift has overflowed to many people.
16 The gift is not like what came through the one man who sinned.
The judgment followed one sin, and it brought condemnation.
But the free gift followed many sins, and it made people righteous.
17 Through the sin of one man, death ruled because of that one man.
But think of those who receive God's overflowing grace and the gift of righteousness.
They will rule in life through the one man, Jesus Christ.
That is so much greater!
18 So one sin brought condemnation to all people.
In the same way one righteous act makes all people righteous and gives them life.
19 Through the disobedience of one man, many people became sinners.
In the same way, through the obedience of one man, many people will be made righteous.
20 The law came in, so that sin would grow.
But where sin grew, grace grew even more.
21 Sin ruled and brought death.
In the same way grace now rules through righteousness.
It brings eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Foreshadowing means: a picture or sign of something that comes later.

Condemnation means: being judged guilty.

Verse 12: Paul recalls Adam, the first human being (Genesis 3). With him sin entered the world. From this verse Christians later developed the teaching of *original sin*. The churches understand it in different ways. It means: All people are born into a world in which there is guilt and harm.

Verse 14: Adam is a "foreshadowing" of Christ: As Adam stands for all people, so does Christ. But Christ brings life instead of death.

Verses 15–19: Paul compares again and again: what came through Adam, and what comes through Christ. Grace is always greater.

Verse 20: "Where sin grew, grace grew even more." A word of comfort: No guilt is so great that God's grace cannot be greater.

Important: The law is not bad. It makes sin visible.

ROMANS

CHAPTER 6

A new life with Christ

Died and alive with Christ VERSES 1–14

1 What shall we say then?
Shall we continue in sin,
so that grace may increase?
2 Of course not!
We died to sin.
How could we live in it any longer?
3 Or don't you know:
All of us
who were baptized into Christ Jesus
were baptized into his death.
4 So we were buried with him
through baptism into death.

Christ was raised from the dead
through the glory of the Father.
In the same way we too can now live a new life.
5 For if we have become united with him
in the likeness of his death,
we will also be part of his resurrection.
6 We know this:
Our old self was crucified with him,
so that the body of sin might be done away with,
and we would no longer be slaves to sin.
7 For whoever has died
has been freed from sin.
8 But if we died with Christ,
we believe
that we will also live with him.
9 For we know:
Christ has been raised from the dead
and dies no more.
Death no longer has dominion over him!
10 For the death that he died,
he died to sin one time.
But the life that he lives,
he lives to God.
11 So consider yourselves also:
You are dead to sin,
but alive to God
in Christ Jesus our Lord.
12 So don't let sin reign
in your mortal body,
so that you obey its lusts.
13 Don't offer the parts of your body to sin
as tools of unrighteousness.
But offer yourselves to God
as people
who are alive from the dead,
and the parts of your body to God as tools of
righteousness.
14 For sin will not have dominion over you.
For you are not under law,
but under grace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Dominion means: power, rule.

Mortal means: able to die.

Verse 1: A possible objection: If God's grace is so great, can we simply go on sinning? Paul says: Of course not!

Verses 3–4: Baptism is like dying and rising again with Christ. In the early days people were completely immersed: under the water (as if buried) and out again (as if risen). After that a new life begins.

Verse 6: "Our old self" means the old life that was ruled by sin.

Verse 9: "Death no longer has dominion over him": That is the Easter message.

Verse 13: "The parts of your body" means the whole body: hands, feet, mouth. With everything we are, we can do good.

Verse 14: "Not under law, but under grace": Christians don't live out of fear of punishment, but out of God's gift.

Free for God VERSES 15–23

15 What then?
Shall we sin
because we are not under law
but under grace?
Of course not!
16 Don't you know:
When you offer yourselves as servants to someone
and obey them,
you are the servants of the one you obey.
Either of sin,
which leads to death,
or of obedience,
which leads to righteousness.
17 But thanks be to God!
You were slaves of sin.
But you became obedient from the heart
to the form of teaching
to which you were handed over.
18 You were set free from sin
and became slaves of righteousness.
19 I speak in human terms
because of the weakness of your flesh:
In the past you offered the parts of your body as
servants
to uncleanness and to wickedness,
so that there was more and more wickedness.
So now offer the parts of your body as servants
to righteousness,
so that you become holy.
20 For when you were servants of sin,
you were free from righteousness.
21 What fruit did you have at that time?
Today you are ashamed of these things.
For their end is death.
22 But now you have been set free from sin
and have become servants of God.
Your fruit is
that you become holy.
And the result is eternal life.
23 For the wages of sin is death,
but the free gift of God is eternal life
in Christ Jesus our Lord.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Wages means: pay for work.

Verses 16–18: Paul uses a picture from his time: Slaves belonged to their master. He says: Every person serves something. The only question is: what? Whoever serves God becomes free.

Important: With the picture of slavery, Paul is not describing a good order. Slavery is a grave injustice. The picture only shows how strong the power of sin is.

Verse 19: "I speak in human terms": Paul himself says that he uses a human picture so that people understand him.

Verse 23 is one of the best-known verses in the Bible: Sin pays with death. God gives life. Life is not a wage, but a gift.

Chapter 7

The inner struggle

Free from the law for Christ VERSES 1–6

1 Or don't you know, brothers,
for I speak to people
who know the law,
that the law has power over a person
for as long as he lives?
2 A married woman is bound by law
to her husband
while he lives.
But if the husband dies,
she is released from the law
that binds her to the husband.
3 So if,
while her husband lives,
she is joined to another man,
she would be called an adulteress.
But if the husband dies,
she is free from the law.
Then she is no adulteress,
though she is joined to another man.
4 So you also, my brothers,
were made dead to the law
through the body of Christ.
So you can be joined to another,
to him
who was raised from the dead,
so that we might bear fruit for God.
5 For when we were in the flesh,
the sinful passions,
which were stirred up through the law,
worked in the parts of our body.
They brought fruit for death.
6 But now we have been released from the law.
We have died to that
in which we were held.
So we serve in the new way of the spirit,
and not in the old way of the letter.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Adulteress means: a married woman who is unfaithful to her husband.

Verses 1–3: Paul uses a picture from the marriage law of his time: When one spouse dies, the other is free. Here he is not giving a teaching about marriage and divorce, but a picture.

Verse 4: In the same way, the Christians have become free through the death of Christ, to belong to Christ.

Verse 5: "In the flesh" means: in the old life, ruled by human weakness.

Verse 6: "The new way of the spirit": Christians live from the Holy Spirit, not only by written rules.

Is the law bad? VERSES 7–13

7 What shall we say then?
Is the law sin?
Of course not!
But I wouldn't have known sin
except through the law.
For I wouldn't have known coveting
unless the law had said,
"You shall not covet."
8 But sin used the commandment as an opportunity
and produced in me all kinds of coveting.
For apart from the law, sin is dead.
9 I was once alive apart from the law.
But when the commandment came,
sin came to life,
and I died.
10 The commandment
that was meant for life
brought me death.
11 For sin used the commandment as an opportunity,
deceived me,
and through it killed me.
12 So the law indeed is holy,
and the commandment holy, righteous, and good.
13 Did then that which is good become death to me?
Of course not!
But sin produced death in me
through that which is good,
so that it might be shown to be sin.
So through the commandment sin was to become
extremely sinful.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Covet means: want something that belongs to someone else.

Verse 7 quotes the tenth commandment (Exodus 20:17; Deuteronomy 5:21).

Verses 7–11: When people hear that something is forbidden, they sometimes want it even more. In this way sin even misuses the good commandment.

Verse 12 is very important: "The law indeed is holy, and the commandment holy, righteous, and good." Paul doesn't speak badly about the Torah. The problem is not the law, but the power of sin.

Important: Christians have often claimed that the Jewish law is a burden or bad. That contradicts Paul. For Jews, the Torah is still a gift from God today.

The good I want, I don't do VERSES 14–25

14 For we know:
The law is spiritual.
But I am fleshly,
sold under sin.
15 For I don't understand
what I am doing.
For I don't do
what I want to do.
But what I hate,
that I do.
16 But if I do
what I don't want,
I agree with the law
that it is good.

17 So now it is no more I that do it,
but sin
which lives in me.
18 For I know:
In me,
that is, in my flesh,
lives no good thing.
The wanting is there,
but I don't find
how to do what is good.
19 For the good
which I want,
I don't do.
But the evil
which I don't want,
that I do.
20 But if I do
what I don't want,
it is no more I that do it,
but sin
which lives in me.
21 So I find this law in me:
When I want to do good,
evil is there.
22 For in my inner self
I delight in God's law.
23 But I see a different law in the parts of my body.
It wars against the law of my mind
and makes me a prisoner
under the law of sin
which is in the parts of my body.
24 What a wretched man I am!
Who will rescue me
out of the body of this death?
25 I thank God
through Jesus Christ, our Lord!
So then with the mind I myself serve God's law,
but with the flesh, sin's law.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Wretched means: very unhappy, miserable.

Verses 15–19: Many people know this: You want to do something good and don't manage it. You want to stop doing something bad and do it anyway. Paul describes this inner conflict very honestly.

Scholars think differently about who is speaking as "I" here: Paul himself as a Christian, Paul before his encounter with Jesus, or human beings in general. All three readings are found in the churches.

Verse 22: Paul delights in God's law. The law is good.

Verses 24–25: The way out doesn't come from our own strength, but from God, through Jesus Christ.

For today: If you are struggling with an addiction or a compulsion, you are not alone. It is no shame to look for help. Help is available from addiction counseling services and doctors. In the US, call or text 988. US: SAMHSA 1-800-662-4357.

In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

ROMANS

Chapter 8

Nothing can separate us from God's love

Life in the Spirit VERSES 1–11

1 So now there is no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.
They are the people who don't walk according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit.
2 The Spirit gives life in Christ Jesus.
And the law of the Spirit has set me free from the law of sin and death.
3 The law could not do it, because the flesh made the law weak.
But God did it.
He sent his own Son as a human being, in a body like our sinful bodies.
He sent him to deal with sin.
So God condemned sin in the flesh.
4 He did this so that what the law requires would be fulfilled in us.
We don't walk according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit.
5 Some people live according to the flesh.
They think about what the flesh wants.
Others live according to the Spirit.
They think about what the Spirit wants.
6 A mind set on the flesh leads to death.
But a mind set on the Spirit leads to life and peace.
7 A mind set on the flesh is against God.
It does not obey God's law.
And it cannot obey it.
8 Those who live in the flesh can't please God.
9 But you do not live in the flesh.
You live in the Spirit, if the Spirit of God really lives in you.
If anyone doesn't have the Spirit of Christ, he doesn't belong to Christ.
10 If Christ is in you, your body is dead because of sin.
But your spirit is alive because God has made you righteous.
11 God raised Jesus from the dead.
His Spirit lives in you.
So God, who raised Christ Jesus from the dead, will also give life to your bodies that must die.
He will do it through his Spirit, who lives in you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "No condemnation": Whoever belongs to Christ need not fear condemnation before God. A great comfort.

Verse 1: The words "who don't walk according to the flesh, but according to the Spirit" are missing from verse 1 in

many old manuscripts. The WEB has them. In verse 4 they are in all manuscripts.

"Flesh" and "Spirit": "Flesh" doesn't mean the body as something bad. It means a person who looks only at themselves and lives without God. "Spirit" means a life that is guided by the Holy Spirit.

Verse 3: God sent his Son as a real human being. In this way he broke the power of sin.

Verse 11: The Spirit who raised Jesus will also raise us. That is the Christian hope beyond death.

Children of God VERSES 12–17

12 So, brothers, we owe nothing to the flesh.
We don't have to live the way the flesh wants.
13 If you live by the flesh, you will die.
But if by the Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body, you will live.
14 All who are led by the Spirit of God are children of God.
15 You did not receive a spirit that makes you slaves again, so that you would be afraid.
No, you received the Spirit of adoption.
Through him we call out, "Abba! Father!"
16 The Spirit himself tells our spirit that we are children of God.
17 And if we are children, then we will also inherit.
We will inherit from God, and we will inherit together with Christ.
This is true if we suffer with him, so that we will also share in his glory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Adoption means: taking someone as your own child.

Verse 13: "If by the Spirit you put to death the deeds of the body, you will live." This is a picture. It means: not letting evil rule within you. It does not mean that you should harm your body. If you are thinking about hurting yourself, please get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 15: "Abba" is Aramaic and means *father*, the loving way a child speaks to a father. Jesus himself prayed to God like this (Mark 14:36).

Verse 15: "Spirit of adoption": God takes us as his children.

Verse 17: Children are heirs. We receive a share in everything that belongs to God.

For today: We don't need to be afraid of God. We may call him Father.

All creation is waiting VERSES 18–30

18 I am sure of this:
What we suffer now is nothing compared with the glory that will be shown to us.
19 The creation is waiting and longing for the children of God to be shown.
20 The creation was made subject to emptiness.
It was not its own choice.
It happened because of the one who made it subject.
But there is hope:
21 The creation itself will also be set free.
It will be set free from being a slave to decay.
It will share in the freedom and glory of the children of God.
22 We know that the whole creation groans until now.
It suffers, as in the pains of childbirth.
23 And not only the creation.
We ourselves groan inside too.
We already have the Spirit as the first fruits.
But we are waiting for God to adopt us fully as his children.
We are waiting for our bodies to be set free.
24 We were saved in this hope.
But hope that is seen is not hope.
Who hopes for something he already sees?
25 But we hope for what we don't see.
So we wait for it patiently.
26 In the same way, the Spirit helps us in our weakness.
We don't know how we should pray.
But the Spirit himself prays for us.
He prays with groans that words cannot express.
27 God searches our hearts.
He knows what the Spirit is thinking.
For the Spirit prays for the saints the way God wants.
28 We know that all things work together for good for those who love God.
They are the people he has called according to his purpose.
29 God knew them beforehand.
And he chose beforehand that they would become like his Son.
So his Son would be the firstborn among many brothers.
30 Those he chose beforehand, he also called.
Those he called, he also made righteous.
Those he made righteous, he also gave glory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

First fruits means: the first part of a harvest; a first gift that promises more to come.

Verses 19–22: Not only people, but the whole creation, animals, plants and the earth, are waiting for redemption. Many Christians see this as a task to care for creation.

Verse 22: "The pains of childbirth": The suffering of the world is like pain during a birth. After it comes something new.

Verse 26: When we don't know what to pray, the Spirit prays for us. Even a quiet sigh is a prayer.

Verse 28: "All things work together for good for those who love God." This doesn't mean that everything terrible is good. It means: God can let something good grow even out of hard things. Whoever grieves or suffers may still lament.

Verses 29–30: "Chose beforehand": Christians have thought a lot about these verses. The churches understand them differently. Here Paul mainly wants to comfort: God has a plan and does not let go of his own.

God's love holds on VERSES 31–39

31 So what can we say about all this?
If God is for us, who can be against us?
32 God did not spare his own Son.
He gave him up for all of us.
So he will surely give us everything else with him, as a gift.

33 Who could bring a charge against God's chosen ones?
It is God who justifies.
34 Who can condemn them?
It is Christ who died.
More than that, he was raised from the dead.
He is at the right hand of God.
And he speaks up for us.
35 Who can separate us from the love of Christ?
Can trouble or distress?
Can persecution or hunger?
Can having no clothes, or danger, or the sword?
36 As it is written:
"For your sake we are killed all day long.
We are treated like sheep to be slaughtered."
37 No, in all these things we are more than conquerors
through him who loved us.
38 I am sure of this:
Neither death nor life, neither angels nor rulers,
nothing now and nothing in the future, no powers,
39 nothing high and nothing deep, and nothing else in all creation
will be able to separate us from God's love which is in Christ Jesus our Lord.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 31: "If God is for us, who can be against us?" A strong word of comfort.

Verse 35: Paul knew distress, persecution and danger from his own experience.

Verse 36 quotes Psalm 44:22 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 44:23).

Verses 38–39 are among the best-known texts in the Bible. They are often read at funerals. Nothing, not even death, can separate us from God's love.

For today: If you feel abandoned, you may know: God's love holds on to you. In hard times you can also get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

ROMANS

CHAPTER 9

God's faithfulness to Israel

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

In chapters 9 to 11 Paul writes about his own people Israel. He writes with great pain and great love (9:1–3). His question is: Has God abandoned his people because many Jews do not believe in Jesus as the Christ? His answer at the end is: No! God's gifts and his calling cannot be taken back (11:29). And: In this way all Israel will be saved (11:26).

These three chapters must always be read together. Individual verses from chapter 9 or 10 have often been torn out of context in history and used against Jews. That was a grave injustice.

Today the churches teach: God's covenant with the Jewish people has never been revoked (*Nostra Aetate*, 1965; many Protestant synods since 1980).

Paul's grief for his people VERSES 1–5

1 I am telling the truth in Christ.
I am not lying.
My conscience agrees with me, and it is guided by the Holy Spirit:
2 I am very sad.
The pain in my heart never stops.
3 I could even wish that I myself were cursed and cut off from Christ.
I would accept that for the sake of my brothers, the people of my own race.
4 They are Israelites.
Theirs is the adoption as God's children.
Theirs is the glory, and theirs are the covenants.
Theirs is the giving of the law, the worship, and the promises.
5 Theirs are the ancestors.
And Christ, as a human being, comes from them.
He is over all, God, blessed forever.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Covenant means: a solemn agreement between God and people.

Verses 1–3: Paul loves his people so much that he would even wish to be lost himself if that would help them. Moses had prayed for Israel like this too (Exodus 32:32).

Verses 4–5: Paul lists what God has given Israel: God has taken Israel as his children. Israel has the glory of God, the covenants, the Torah, the worship, the promises, the ancestors Abraham, Isaac and Jacob. And Jesus himself is a Jew. Paul writes "Theirs is," in the present tense. These gifts still hold today.

Verse 5: The end of the sentence can also be understood differently: as praise of God the Father. The WEB understands it as a statement about Christ: "He is over all, God, blessed forever." In Greek there were no punctuation marks.

God chooses freely VERSES 6–13

6 But it is not as though the word of God has come to nothing.
For not everyone who comes from Israel is truly Israel.
7 And not everyone who comes from Abraham is truly his child.
No, the Scripture says: "Your offspring will be counted through Isaac."
8 That means: The children born in the normal human way are not God's children.
The children of the promise are counted as heirs.
9 For this is what God promised:
"At the set time I will come, and Sarah will have a son."
10 And that is not all.
Rebekah also became pregnant by one man, our father

Isaac.
11 Her twins were not born yet.
They had not done anything good or bad.
But God's plan of choosing had to stand.
It does not depend on what people do.
It depends on God, who calls.
12 So God said to Rebekah: "The older will serve the younger."
13 As it is written: "Jacob I loved, but Esau I hated."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: "It is not as though the word of God has come to nothing": God's promise to Israel still holds.

Verse 7 quotes Genesis 21:12. Verse 9 quotes Genesis 18:10 and 18:14. Verse 12 quotes Genesis 25:23. Verse 13 quotes Malachi 1:2–3.

Verse 13: "Loved" and "hated" is a Hebrew way of speaking. It means: God chose the one and not the other. It is about the path of the promise, not about feelings of hatred. Esau is also blessed in the Bible (Genesis 27:39–40; 33).

Paul shows: God chooses freely, already in the story of the ancestors. Not human achievement but God's call decides.

Is God unfair? VERSES 14–29

14 So what can we say?
Is God unfair?
Of course not!
15 For God said to Moses:
"I will have mercy on whom I have mercy.
And I will have compassion on whom I have compassion."
16 So it does not depend on what people want or on how hard they try.
It depends on God, who has mercy.
17 For the Scripture says to Pharaoh:
"I raised you up for this very reason:
I wanted to show my power through you.
I wanted my name to be made known in all the earth."
18 So God has mercy on whom he wants to.
And he makes stubborn whom he wants to.
19 Then you will say to me:
"So why does God still blame us?
Who can resist what he wants?"
20 But who are you, a human being, to talk back to God?
Can a pot say to the one who made it, "Why did you make me like this?"
21 The potter has the right to do what he wants with the clay, doesn't he?
From the same lump of clay he can make one vessel for honor and another for dishonor.
22 God wanted to show his anger and make his power known.
But he was very patient with the vessels of his anger.
They were ready to be destroyed.
23 He did this to show the riches of his glory to the vessels of his mercy.
He prepared them ahead of time for glory.
24 We are these vessels.
God has called us.
He called us not only from the Jews, but also from the Gentiles.
25 As God also says in the book of Hosea:
"I will call them 'my people,' who were not my people.
I will call her 'beloved,' who was not beloved."
26 "In the place where people said to them, 'You are not my people,'
there they will be called 'children of the living God.'"
27 Isaiah calls out about Israel:
"The people of Israel may be as many as the sand of the sea.
But only the remnant will be saved.
28 For the Lord will finish his work on earth.
He will do it quickly and in righteousness."
29 Isaiah said before:
"If the Lord of Armies had not left us some descendants,
we would have become like Sodom.
We would have been like Gomorrah."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Vessel means: a pot or jar.

Remnant means: the part that is left over.

Verse 15 quotes Exodus 33:19. Verse 17 quotes Exodus 9:16.

Verses 20–21: The picture of the potter comes from the Bible of Israel (Isaiah 29:16; 45:9; Jeremiah 18:1–6). Paul says: People cannot call God to account. God is free.

Verses 14–23 are among the most difficult passages in the Bible. Christians have argued about them a lot. Important: In chapter 11 Paul ends with the thought that God has shut up all people in disobedience so that he may have mercy on all (11:32). God's last word is mercy.

Verse 25 quotes Hosea 2:23 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 2:25). Verse 26 quotes Hosea 1:10 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 2:1).

Verses 27–28 quote Isaiah 10:22–23. Verse 29 quotes Isaiah 1:9.

"The remnant": God always keeps a part of his people. That is a sign of his faithfulness, not of turning away.

The stumbling stone VERSES 30–33

30 So what can we say?
The Gentiles did not try to become righteous.
But they became righteous, through faith.
31 Israel tried to become righteous by keeping a law.
But they did not reach that law of righteousness.
32 Why not?
Because they did not try to reach it through faith.
They tried to reach it through works of the law.
They stumbled over the stumbling stone.
33 As it is written:
"Look, I am putting a stumbling stone in Zion, a rock that makes people fall.
But no one who believes in him will be disappointed."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 33 combines Isaiah 28:16 and Isaiah 8:14.

"The stumbling stone": For Paul, this is Jesus. For many he is a cause of stumbling, but whoever trusts him will not be disappointed.

Verses 31–32: Paul describes why many of his people did not accept Jesus as the Christ. He does not judge from above. He speaks as someone who belongs himself and is sad (verse 2).

Important: This is not yet the last word. In chapter 11 Paul says that Israel did not stumble so as to fall for good (11:11).

Christians must not consider themselves better than Jews (11:18).

ROMANS

Chapter 10

The word is near you

Paul prays for Israel VERSES 1–4

1 Brothers,
with all my heart I wish that the people of Israel may be saved.
That is my prayer to God for them.
2 I can tell you this about them:
They are eager for God.
But they do not really understand.
3 They do not know God's righteousness.
Instead, they try to set up their own righteousness.
So they did not put themselves under God's righteousness.
Righteousness means: being right with God.
4 Christ is the fulfillment of the law.
Through him, everyone who believes is made right with God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Paul prays for his people. He loves Israel.

Verse 2: Paul praises how eager his people are for God. He knows this eagerness from his own experience.

Verse 4: The WEB, our English source text, says "fulfillment." The Greek word *telos* can mean *goal*, *fulfillment* or *end*. Many scholars today say: Paul means that the law finds its goal in Christ. It does not mean that the law is worthless (compare 3:31 and 7:12).

The word of faith VERSES 5–13

5 Moses writes about the righteousness that comes from the law.
He says,
"The one who does these things will live by them."
6 But the righteousness that comes from faith says this:
"Do not say in your heart,
'Who will go up into heaven?' "
That means: to bring Christ down.
7 "Or do not say,
'Who will go down into the abyss?' "
That means: to bring Christ up from the dead.
The abyss is a very deep place. Here it means the place of the dead.
8 So what does it say?
"The word is near you.
It is in your mouth and in your heart."
This is the word about faith.
We preach this word:
9 Say with your mouth that Jesus is Lord.
Believe in your heart that God raised him from the dead.
If you do that, you will be saved.
10 With the heart a person believes.
This makes them right with God.
With the mouth a person says openly what they believe.
This leads to salvation.
Salvation means: being rescued by God.
11 The Scripture says,
"Whoever believes in him will not be disappointed."
12 There is no difference between Jew and Greek.
The same Lord is Lord of all.
He gives richly to all who call on him.
13 For,
"Whoever will call on the name of the Lord will be saved."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5 quotes Leviticus 18:5.

Verses 6–8 take up words from Deuteronomy 30:12–14. There Moses says: God's command is not far away, but very near, in your mouth and in your heart. Paul applies this to the word about Jesus.

Verse 9: This is one of the oldest Christian confessions of faith: Jesus is Lord.

Verse 11 quotes Isaiah 28:16. Verse 13 quotes Joel 2:32 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 3:5).

Verse 12: God is the Lord of all people. With him there is no difference.

How will they believe if they don't hear? VERSES 14–21

14 But how can people call on someone they have not believed in?
How can they believe in someone they have not heard about?
How can they hear without someone who preaches?
15 And how can people preach unless someone sends them?
It is written:
"How beautiful are the feet of those who bring the Good News of peace!
They bring the happy news of good things."
16 But not all of them listened to the happy news.
Isaiah says,
"Lord, who has believed what we told them?"
17 So faith comes from hearing.
And hearing comes through the word of God.
18 But I ask:
Did they not hear?
Yes, they certainly did.
"Their sound went out into all the earth.
Their words went to the ends of the world."
19 But I ask:
Did Israel not understand?
First, Moses says,
"I will make you jealous of a people that is not a nation.

I will make you angry with a nation that has no
understanding."
20 Isaiah is very bold.
He says,
"People who did not look for me found me.
I showed myself to people who did not ask for me."
21 But about Israel he says,
"All day long I stretched out my hands
to a people who do not obey and who argue against
me."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15 quotes Isaiah 52:7. Verse 16 quotes Isaiah 53:1.

Verse 17: "So faith comes from hearing": That is why it is important that people tell others about God.

Verse 18 quotes Psalm 19:4 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 19:5). Verse 19 quotes Deuteronomy 32:21. Verses 20–21 quote Isaiah 65:1–2.

Verse 21: God stretches out his hands to Israel "all day long." This is not a picture of rejection, but of love: God does not give up on his people. He waits with open arms.

Important: These hard words of the prophets come from the Bible of Israel itself. The prophets spoke like this to their own people. They give Christians no right to look down on Jews. In the next chapter Paul says clearly: God has not rejected his people (11:1–2).

ROMANS

CHAPTER 11

God has not rejected his people

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

This chapter is the high point of chapters 9 to 11. Here Paul says very clearly: God has not rejected his people Israel (verses 1–2). He does not take back his gifts and his calling (verse 29). Christians are like branches that were grafted into an olive tree that was not their own. They must not boast over the original branches (verse 18).

This chapter is very important for the relationship between Christians and Jews today. The churches refer to it when they say: God's covenant with Israel still holds.

A remnant remains VERSES 1–10

1 So I ask:
Did God reject his people?
Of course not!
I myself am an Israelite.
I am a descendant of Abraham, from the tribe of
Benjamin.
2 God did not reject his people.
He knew them from the beginning.
Do you not know what the Scripture says about Elijah?
Elijah complains to God against Israel.
He says,
3 "Lord, they have killed your prophets.
They have torn down your altars.
I am the only one left,
and they are trying to kill me."
4 But how does God answer him?
"I have kept 7,000 men for myself.
They have not bowed down to Baal."
5 It is the same today.
There is a remnant, that is, a small group that is left.
God chose them because of his grace.
Grace means: God's kindness that we do not earn.
6 If it is by grace, then it is no longer because of what
people do.
Otherwise grace would no longer be grace.
But if it is because of what people do, it is no longer
grace.
Otherwise work would no longer be work.
7 What does this mean?
Israel did not get what it was looking for.
But the chosen ones got it.
The rest were hardened.
That means: their hearts became hard.
8 It is written,
"God gave them a spirit of deep sleep.
He gave them eyes that do not see
and ears that do not hear,
to this very day."
9 David says,
"Let their table become a snare,
a trap,
something to stumble over,
and a punishment for them.
10 Let their eyes be darkened, so that they cannot see.
Keep their backs bent forever."
A snare is a trap.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Paul himself is a Jew. For that reason alone God cannot have rejected his people.

Verse 3 quotes 1 Kings 19:10 and 19:14. Verse 4 quotes 1 Kings 19:18. Elijah thought he was all alone. But God had kept many people faithful.

Verse 5: "A remnant": Even in Paul's time there were many Jews who believed in Jesus. The first Christians were all Jews.

Verse 8 combines Deuteronomy 29:4 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 29:3) and Isaiah 29:10. Verses 9–10 quote Psalm 69:22–23 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 69:23–24).

Verses 7–10: "Hardened" is a hard word. But Paul says right after: This hardening is only partial and only for a time (verses 11 and 25). It is not a final verdict.

Important: In the past these verses were often used against Jews. That was wrong. Here Paul speaks as a Jew about his own people, and his goal is the salvation of all Israel (verse 26).

Stumbled, but not fallen VERSES 11–16

11 So I ask:
Did they stumble so that they would fall for good?
Of course not!
But because they fell, salvation has come to the
Gentiles.

Gentiles are people who are not Jews.
This happened to make Israel jealous.
12 Their fall has made the world rich.
Their loss has made the Gentiles rich.
So how much more will their fullness bring!
13 Now I am speaking to you who are Gentiles.
I am an apostle to the Gentiles.
So I honor my work.
14 Perhaps I can make my own people jealous in this way,
and save some of them.
15 Their rejection means that the world is made friends
with God again.
So what will their acceptance be?
It will be life from the dead!
16 If the first fruit is holy, then the whole lump of dough
is holy too.
If the root is holy, then the branches are holy too.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Israel did not fall in order to stay down. God has a good plan.

Verses 12 and 15: Paul expects something great for Israel: "fullness" and "life from the dead." His hope for his people is huge.

Verse 15: "Rejection" here means a time in which many do not believe in Jesus. It is not God's last word. Right after, Paul speaks of their "acceptance."

Verse 16: "The first fruit": In the law of Israel, the first piece of the bread dough was given to God (Numbers 15:17–21). "The root" probably means the ancestors Abraham, Isaac and Jacob.

Because they are holy, the whole people is dedicated to God.

The olive tree VERSES 17–24

17 Some of the branches were broken off.
You were a wild olive branch.
But you were grafted in among the other branches.
To graft means: to join a branch from one tree onto another tree, so that it grows there.
Now you share with them in the root and in the rich sap of the olive tree.
18 So do not boast that you are better than the branches.
If you do boast, remember this:
It is not you who support the root, but the root supports you.
19 Then you will say,
"Branches were broken off, so that I could be grafted in."
20 That is true.
They were broken off because they did not believe.
And you stand because you believe.
Do not be proud.
Be afraid instead.
21 God did not spare the natural branches.
So he will not spare you either.
22 So look at God's goodness and his strictness.
He is strict with those who fell.
But he is good to you,
if you stay in his goodness.
If you do not, you will be cut off too.
23 And they will be grafted in again,
if they do not stay in their unbelief.
God is able to graft them in again.
24 You were cut out of an olive tree that is wild by nature.
And against nature you were grafted into a good olive tree.
So how much more will these natural branches be grafted into their own olive tree!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The olive tree is a picture of God's people. The root and the tree belong to Israel. The Christians from the other nations are like wild branches that were grafted in. They live from the sap of this root.

Verse 18: "It is not you who support the root, but the root supports you." The Christian faith is rooted in Judaism. Christians owe their faith in the one God, the Holy Scriptures and Jesus himself to Israel.

Verses 18–21: Paul expressly warns the Christians from the nations against arrogance toward Jews. This warning was forgotten far too often in church history. Contempt, hatred and violence against Jews came from this. That was a grave guilt.

Verses 23–24: God can and will graft the "natural branches" in again. The tree is "their own olive tree."

All Israel will be saved VERSES 25–32

25 Brothers, I want you to know this mystery.
A mystery is something hidden that God now makes known.
I tell you this so that you do not think you are wise.
Part of Israel has become hard.
This will last until the full number of Gentiles has come in.
26 And so all Israel will be saved.
It is written,
"The Deliverer will come out of Zion.
He will turn Jacob away from ungodliness.
27 This is my covenant with them,
when I take away their sins."
A covenant is a binding agreement.
28 When it comes to the Good News, they are enemies for your sake.
But when it comes to God's choosing, they are loved, because of their ancestors.
29 God's gifts and his calling can never be taken back.
30 In the past, you did not obey God.
But now you have received mercy, because they did not obey.
31 In the same way, they have now not obeyed.
So through the mercy shown to you, they may also receive mercy.
32 God has shut up all people in disobedience,
so that he can have mercy on all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25: The hardening affects only part of Israel, and it lasts only "until" a certain time. It is not forever.

Verse 26: "And so all Israel will be saved." Paul does not say exactly how this happens. Scholars understand it differently. What is clear: God keeps his promise to Israel.

Verses 26–27 combine Isaiah 59:20–21 and Isaiah 27:9.

Verse 28: "Enemies" here means: opponents of the Christian message. But in the same sentence Paul says: They are "loved" by God. God's love has the last word.

Verse 29 is one of the most important verses for the relationship between Christians and Jews: "God's gifts and his calling can never be taken back." God never takes back his choosing of Israel. The Catholic Church also refers to this in the declaration *Nostra Aetate* (1965). Many Protestant churches have confessed this too.

Verse 32: All people, Jews and Gentiles, depend on God's mercy. And God wants to have mercy on all.

Praise of God's wisdom VERSES 33–36

33 Oh, how deep are the riches of God's wisdom and knowledge!
No one can search out his judgments.
No one can trace his ways.
34 "Who has known the mind of the Lord?
Or who has given him advice?"
35 "Or who has first given something to him,
so that God must pay it back?"
36 Everything comes from him.
Everything exists through him.
Everything is for him.
To him be the glory forever!
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the hard questions in chapters 9 to 11, Paul doesn't end with a teaching but with a song of praise. He is amazed at God. God's ways are greater than people can understand.

Verse 34 quotes Isaiah 40:13. Verse 35 takes up Job 41:11 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 41:3).

Verse 36: Everything comes from God, everything exists through him, and everything is heading toward him.

For today: Where we don't understand God's ways, we may still trust and praise God.

ROMANS

Chapter 12

The new life in everyday life

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

With chapter 12 a new part of the letter to the Romans begins. In chapters 1 to 11 Paul explained what God has done for people. Now he shows how Christians can respond: in everyday life, in the church, and in how they treat all people.

A living sacrifice VERSES 1–2

1 So I urge you, brothers,
by the mercies of God:
Present your bodies to God
as a living sacrifice,
holy, acceptable to God.
This is your spiritual service.
2 Don't be conformed to this world,
but be transformed
by the renewing of your mind.
Then you can test
what the will of God is:
what is good,
well-pleasing,
and perfect.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Conformed means: made the same as everyone else.

Verse 1: In the past people brought animals to God as sacrifices. Paul says: Give yourselves to God, with your whole life. "Living" means: not dying, but living in a way that pleases God. It is not about harming yourself.

Verse 1: "Bodies" here means the whole person, with everything they do in everyday life.

Verse 1: "Spiritual service": The Greek word can also mean *reasonable* or *fitting*. It means: A life for God is the true worship.

Verse 2: Christians should not simply go along with everything that everyone does. They should think for themselves and test what is good.

One body, many gifts VERSES 3–8

3 For through the grace
that was given to me,
I say to each one of you:
Don't think of yourself more highly
than you ought to think.
But think reasonably about yourself,
as God has given each person a measure of faith.
4 For as we have many members in one body,
and all the members don't have the same function,
5 so we,
who are many,
are one body in Christ.
And each one is a member of the others.
6 We have different gifts,
according to the grace God has given us.
If someone has the gift of prophecy,
let them prophesy
according to the measure of their faith.
7 If someone has the gift of service,
let them give themselves to serving.
Whoever teaches,
let them give themselves to teaching.
8 Whoever encourages,
let them give themselves to encouraging.
Whoever gives,
let them do it with generosity.
Whoever leads,
let them do it with diligence.
Whoever shows mercy,
let them do it with cheerfulness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Members here means: parts of the body.

Diligence means: careful, eager effort.

Verses 4–5: Paul compares the church to a body. Every part is important, even if it has a different task. A similar picture

is found in 1 Corinthians 12.

Verses 6–8: Every person has gifts from God. No one is unimportant. The gifts are different, but all serve the community.

Verse 6: "Prophecy" here doesn't mean fortune-telling, but: encouraging, warning and comforting on God's behalf.

For today: People with disabilities, old people and children also have their gifts. A church needs everyone.

This is what real love looks like VERSES 9–21

9 Let love be without hypocrisy.
Hate what is evil.
Cling to what is good.
10 Love one another warmly
like brothers and sisters.
Be the first
to show honor
to one another.
11 Don't lag behind in eagerness.
Be on fire in spirit.
Serve the Lord.
12 Rejoice in hope.
Endure in troubles.
Keep on praying faithfully.
13 Help the saints
when they are in need.
Be eager to welcome guests.
14 Bless those
who persecute you.
Bless them,
and don't curse them.
15 Rejoice with those
who rejoice.
Weep with those
who weep.
16 Be of one mind with each other.
Don't set your mind on high things,
but associate with the humble.
Don't be wise in your own eyes.
17 Repay no one evil for evil.
Respect what is honorable
in the sight of all people.
18 If it is possible,
as much as it is up to you,
be at peace with all people.
19 Don't seek revenge yourselves,
beloved,
but leave room for God's anger.
For it is written,
"Vengeance belongs to me;
I will repay,
says the Lord."
20 Therefore
"If your enemy is hungry,
feed him.
If he is thirsty,
give him a drink;
for in doing so,
you will heap coals of fire on his head."
21 Don't be overcome by evil,
but overcome evil with good.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hypocrisy means: pretending to be better than you are.

Hospitality means: welcoming guests kindly.

Verse 9: "Without hypocrisy" means: real, not just acted.

Verse 13: "The saints" are the Christians, for example poor churches. Hospitality was very important for the first Christians.

Verse 14: Christians should wish good even for their persecutors. Jesus also taught this (Matthew 5:44).

Verse 15: Feeling with others is a form of love: rejoicing with them and grieving with them.

Verse 18: "As much as it is up to you": You can't always force peace. But you should do what you can.

Verse 19 quotes Deuteronomy 32:35. Revenge is not our business. But we may bring injustice before God in lament and report it to the police or to a court. That is not revenge.

Verse 20: "Coals of fire on his head" is an old picture. Many scholars understand it like this: Kindness makes the enemy ashamed and can lead him to change his mind. The verse quotes Proverbs 25:21–22.

Verse 21: Violence and hatred are not overcome with more violence and hatred, but with good.

Important: These verses don't mean that you simply have to put up with violence. Whoever experiences violence may protect themselves and get help. US: 1-800-799-7233. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

ROMANS

CHAPTER 13

The state, love and the new day

Christians and the state VERSES 1–7

1 Let every person be subject to the governing
authorities.
For there is no authority
except from God.
And the authorities
that exist
are appointed by God.
2 So whoever resists the authority
resists what God has ordained.
And those who resist
will receive judgment.
3 For rulers are not a terror
to good work,
but to evil.
Do you want to have no fear of the authority?
Then do what is good,
and you will have praise from it.

4 For it is a servant of God
to you for good.
But if you do what is evil,
be afraid.
For it doesn't bear the sword in vain.
It is a servant of God,
who punishes in anger
the one who does evil.
5 So you need to be subject,
not only because of the anger,
but also for conscience' sake.
6 For this reason you also pay taxes.
For the officials are servants of God,
who continually do this very thing.
7 So give everyone
what you owe:
taxes
to whom taxes are owed,
customs
to whom customs are owed,
respect
to whom respect is owed,
honor
to whom honor is owed.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Authorities means: people who govern, such as rulers and officials.

Customs means: taxes on goods.

These verses are among the most misused passages in the Bible. Rulers and also churches have often used them to demand that people obey every government, even an unjust one. During the time of National Socialism in Germany, many Christians behaved this way. That was a grave mistake.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Paul writes to Christians in Rome, under the emperor. He wants to say: Christians are not troublemakers. Order, laws and taxes are good for living together.

Verses 3–4: Paul describes what a state is for: It should protect the good and punish evil. A state is "a servant of God to you for good." Every state must be measured by this.

When a state itself does grave injustice, another word of the Bible applies too. The apostles said before the council: "We must obey God rather than men" (Acts 5:29). In Revelation 13 a state that sets itself up as God is described as a monster.

The *Barmen Theological Declaration* of 1934 says: The state has the task of providing for justice and peace. But it must not try to control the whole of people's lives.

For today: In a democracy it is also part of our responsibility to vote, to take part in public life, and to stand up peacefully against injustice.

Love is the fulfillment of the law VERSES 8–10

8 Owe no one anything,
except to love one another.
For whoever loves his neighbor
has fulfilled the law.
9 For the commandments,
"You shall not commit adultery,"
"You shall not murder,"
"You shall not steal,"
"You shall not covet,"
and whatever other commandments there are,
are all summed up in this one saying:
"You shall love your neighbor as yourself."
10 Love doesn't harm a neighbor.
So love is the fulfillment of the law.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Love is a debt you never fully pay off. You always owe it to one another.

Verse 9 quotes commandments from the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:13–17; Deuteronomy 5:17–21) and the command to love your neighbor from Leviticus 19:18. Jesus also called this command one of the most important (Mark 12:31).

Verse 10: Whoever really loves harms no one. In this way they fulfill what God wants in the law.

The day is near VERSES 11–14

11 Do this,
because you know
what time it is:
It is already time
to wake up out of sleep.
For salvation is now nearer to us
than when we first believed.
12 The night is far gone,
and the day is near.
So let's throw off the deeds of darkness
and put on the armor of light.
13 Let's live properly,
as in the day:
not in wild partying and drunkenness,
not in sexual promiscuity and lustful acts,
and not in strife and jealousy.
14 But put on the Lord Jesus Christ.
And make no provision for the flesh,
to satisfy its lusts.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Provision means: making plans for something.

Verses 11–12: Paul compares the time to the early morning. The night is coming to an end; God's day is coming. That is why Christians should be awake and live with care.

Verse 12: "The armor of light" is a picture. It means good deeds, truth and love, not real weapons.

Verse 14: "Put on the Lord Jesus Christ" is also a picture: to live so closely connected with Christ that you become like him, as you put on new clothes.

Verses 13–14: In the year 386 these verses moved the church father Augustine so much that he changed his life.

For today: If you have problems with alcohol, you can get help from addiction counseling services and support groups such as Alcoholics Anonymous. US: SAMHSA 1-800-662-4357. In a crisis: In the US, call or text 988.

In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Chapter 14

The strong and the weak

Don't judge one another VERSES 1–12

1 Accept the one
who is weak in faith,
but not to argue about opinions.
2 One person has faith
to eat all things.
But the one who is weak eats only vegetables.
3 Don't let the one who eats everything
despise the one
who doesn't.
And don't let the one who doesn't eat everything
judge the one
who does.
For God has accepted him.
4 Who are you
to judge another person's servant?
Whether he stands or falls
is up to his own master.
Yes, he will be made to stand.
For God has the power
to make him stand.
5 One person considers one day more important than
others.
Another considers every day alike.
Let each person be fully sure in his own mind.
6 Whoever observes the day
observes it for the Lord.
And whoever doesn't observe the day
doesn't observe it for the Lord.
Whoever eats
eats for the Lord,
for he gives God thanks.
And whoever doesn't eat
doesn't eat for the Lord,
and he too gives God thanks.
7 For none of us lives to himself,
and none dies to himself.
8 For if we live,
we live to the Lord.
Or if we die,
we die to the Lord.
If therefore we live or die,
we are the Lord's.
9 For this is why Christ died,
rose, and lived again:
so that he might be Lord of both the dead and the
living.
10 But you,
why do you judge your brother?
Or you,
why do you despise your brother?
For we will all stand before the judgment seat of
Christ.
11 For it is written,
" 'As I live,'
says the Lord,
'to me every knee will bow.
Every tongue will confess to God.' "
12 So then each one of us
will give account of himself to God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Despise means: look down on someone.

There was conflict in the church in Rome. Some Christians didn't eat meat, for example because they worried it might have been offered to idols or not prepared according to the Jewish food laws. Others ate everything. Some kept certain feast days, others didn't.

"Weak" and "strong": Paul calls the careful ones "weak in faith." This is not an insult. He asks all sides to respect one another.

Verse 3: "God has accepted him." Whoever God accepts, we should accept too.

Verses 7–8: "If therefore we live or die, we are the Lord's." These words are often read at funerals. They comfort.

Verse 11 takes up Isaiah 45:23 and combines it with words from Isaiah 49:18.

For today: Christians have different opinions on many questions, for example about food, about Sunday or about customs. That is no reason to look down on each other.

Be considerate of one another VERSES 13–23

13 So let's not judge one another any more.
Rather, decide this:
No one should put a stumbling block in his brother's
way,
or something that makes him fall.
14 I know
and am persuaded in the Lord Jesus
that nothing is unclean of itself.
But to anyone
who considers something to be unclean,
to him it is unclean.
15 Yet if your brother is hurt because of your food,
you are no longer walking in love.
Don't destroy with your food
the one for whom Christ died.
16 So don't let what is good for you
be spoken of as evil.
17 For God's Kingdom is not eating and drinking,
but righteousness,
peace,
and joy in the Holy Spirit.
18 Whoever serves Christ in these things
is acceptable to God
and approved by people.
19 So then, let's follow after things
which make for peace,
and things by which we may build one another up.
20 Don't tear down God's work
for the sake of food.
All things indeed are clean.

But it is wrong for a person
to make others stumble by what he eats.
21 It is good
not to eat meat,
not to drink wine,
and not to do anything
by which your brother stumbles,
is hurt or is made weak.
22 Do you have faith?
Keep it to yourself before God.
Happy is the one
who doesn't judge himself
in what he approves.
23 But whoever doubts and still eats
is condemned,
because it isn't done in faith.
And whatever
is not done in faith
is sin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Stumbling block means: something that makes someone trip and fall.

Verse 14: "Nothing is unclean of itself": For Christians from the nations, the Jewish food laws are not an obligation. But Paul respects those who keep them. For Jews, the food laws are still an important part of their life with God today.

Verses 15 and 21: Love is more important than your own rights. Whoever is free should be considerate of others.

Verse 17: God's Kingdom is not about food rules, but about righteousness, peace and joy.

Verse 23: You should not act against your own conscience.

For today: For example, if you have a guest who struggles with alcohol, out of love you go without alcohol. That is what is meant.

Praise of God VERSES 24–26

24 Now to him
who is able to make you strong,
according to my Good News
and the preaching of Jesus Christ,
according to the revelation of the mystery
which has been kept secret through long ages,
25 but now is revealed.
Through the Scriptures of the prophets,
by the command of the eternal God,
it has been made known to all the nations,
so that they may believe and obey.
26 To the only wise God,
through Jesus Christ,
be the glory forever!
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

About the numbering: In the WEB this chapter has 26 verses. Many other Bibles end this chapter with verse 23.

Verses 24–26: This praise of God appears in different places in the old manuscripts: in some after chapter 14, in others at the end of the letter after chapter 16 or after chapter 15. The WEB puts it here, as verses 24–26 of chapter 14. Many other Bibles have it as Romans 16:25–27.

Its content: God's plan was hidden for a long time. Now it has been revealed: Through Jesus Christ all nations are to come to faith.

ROMANS

CHAPTER 15

Accept one another

Carrying one another VERSES 1–13

1 Now we
who are strong
ought to bear the weaknesses of the weak,
and not to please ourselves.
2 Let each one of us please his neighbor
for what is good,
to build him up.
3 For even Christ didn't please himself.
But it is
as it is written:
"The reproaches of those
who reproached you
fell on me."
4 For whatever things
were written before
were written
for our learning.
So we can have hope
through perseverance
and through the encouragement of the Scriptures.
5 Now may the God of perseverance and of
encouragement
grant you
to be of the same mind with one another
according to Christ Jesus,
6 so that together
and with one voice
you may glorify the God and Father of our Lord Jesus
Christ.
7 So accept one another,
even as Christ also accepted you,
to the glory of God.
8 For I say:
Christ has become a servant of the circumcised
for the sake of the truth of God.
He was to confirm the promises
given to the ancestors.
9 And the Gentiles were to glorify God
for his mercy.
As it is written,
"Therefore I will give praise to you among the Gentiles
and sing to your name."

10 Again he says,
"Rejoice, you Gentiles,
with his people."
11 Again,
"Praise the Lord, all you Gentiles!
Let all the peoples praise him."
12 Again, Isaiah says,
"There will be the root of Jesse,
he who arises
to rule over the Gentiles;
in him the Gentiles will hope."
13 Now may the God of hope
fill you with all joy and peace
in believing,
so that you may overflow with hope
in the power of the Holy Spirit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Reproaches means: insults, blame.

Verse 1: Whoever is strong should be considerate of the weaker. This continues chapter 14.

Verse 3 quotes Psalm 69:9 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 69:10).

Verse 4: The Scriptures of Israel, the Old Testament, are written for Christians too. They give comfort and hope.

Verse 7: "Accept one another, even as Christ also accepted you." A guiding word for every church.

Verse 8: Jesus was a Jew and came first to his people. In this way God confirmed his promises to Israel.

Verses 9–12: With four quotations Paul shows: The Bible of Israel already announces that the other nations will also praise God, together with Israel. Verse 9 quotes Psalm 18:49 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 18:50). Verse 10 quotes Deuteronomy 32:43. Verse 11 quotes Psalm 117:1. Verse 12 quotes Isaiah 11:10. Jesse is the father of King David.

Verse 13 is a beautiful blessing: May God, who gives hope, fill us with joy and peace.

Paul and his task VERSES 14–21

14 I myself am convinced about you,
my brothers:
You yourselves are full of goodness,
filled with all knowledge,
and able
to warn one another.
15 But in some places I have written to you
quite boldly,
to remind you.
I do this because of the grace
that God has given me:
16 I am to be a servant of Christ Jesus
to the Gentiles.
Like a priest I serve the Good News of God,
so that the Gentiles may become an offering acceptable
to God,
made holy by the Holy Spirit.
17 So I can boast in Christ Jesus
in things that concern God.
18 For I will not dare
to speak of anything
except what Christ has worked through me
to bring the Gentiles to obedience,
by word and deed,
19 in the power of signs and wonders,
in the power of God's Spirit.
So from Jerusalem
and around as far as Illyricum
I have fully preached the Good News of Christ.
20 In this my aim has been
to preach the Good News
where Christ was not yet named.
For I didn't want to build on a foundation
that someone else had laid.
21 But it is
as it is written:
"They will see,
to whom no news of him came.
They who haven't heard
will understand."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 14–15: Paul praises the Christians in Rome. He doesn't want to lecture them, but to remind them.

Verse 16: Paul describes his service with pictures from the temple. The people from the nations who come to faith are like a gift to God.

Verse 19: Illyricum is a region on the coast of the Adriatic Sea, in today's Croatia, Bosnia and Albania. So Paul had already traveled far.

Verse 21 quotes Isaiah 52:15.

Travel plans: Jerusalem, Rome, Spain VERSES 22–33

22 That is also why I was often prevented
from coming to you.
23 But now I no longer have any place in these regions.
And for many years I have longed
to come to you.
24 When I travel to Spain,
I will come to you.
For I hope
to see you on my journey
and to be helped by you on my way there,
after I have first enjoyed your company for a while.
25 But now I am going to Jerusalem,
to serve the saints.
26 For the churches in Macedonia and Achaia
have been glad to make a collection
for the poor among the saints in Jerusalem.
27 Yes, they were glad to do it,
and they also owe it to them.
For the Gentiles have received a share
in their spiritual things.
So they also owe it to them
to serve them with material things.
28 When I have done this
and have safely handed this fruit over to them,
I will go on by way of you to Spain.
29 I know
that when I come to you,
I will come in the fullness of the blessing
of the Good News of Christ.
30 Now I beg you, brothers,
by our Lord Jesus Christ

and by the love of the Spirit:
Strive together with me
in your prayers to God for me,
31 that I may be rescued from those
who are disobedient in Judea,
and that my service for Jerusalem
may be welcome to the saints,
32 so that I may come to you with joy,
if God wills,
and find rest together with you.
33 Now the God of peace be with you all.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 24 and 28: Paul wanted to travel as far as Spain, at that time the western end of the known world. We don't know for sure whether he ever got there.

Verses 25–27: The collection for the poor Christians in Jerusalem was very important to Paul. The Christians from the nations owe their faith to the church in Jerusalem and to Israel. That is why they are glad to help.

Verse 31: By "those who are disobedient in Judea," Paul means certain opponents who were hostile to him. It doesn't mean the Jews in general. What happened later in Jerusalem is told in Acts (chapters 21 to 26). Paul was arrested there and finally came to Rome as a prisoner (Acts 28).

For today: Christians help one another across borders. And they pray for one another.

ROMANS

Chapter 16

Greetings to many friends

Phoebe VERSES 1–2

1 I want to recommend our sister Phoebe to you.
She is a servant of the church in Cenchreae.
2 Welcome her as someone who belongs to the Lord.
Welcome her in the way God's holy people should.
Help her with anything she may need from you.
She herself has been a helper of many people,
and of me too.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Cenchreae was the port of the city of Corinth. Paul probably wrote this letter from there.

Phoebe probably carried the letter to Rome.

Verse 1: The WEB, our English source text, says "servant." The Greek word is *diakonos*. It can simply mean *servant*, or it can name an office: *deacon*. Many Bibles and scholars today translate *deacon*.

Verse 2: The word for "helper" can also mean *protector* or *patron*. Phoebe was probably a respected woman who supported Paul and others.

Greetings to the church in Rome VERSES 3–16

3 Greet Prisca and Aquila.
They work together with me for Christ Jesus.
4 They risked their own lives to save my life.
I thank them.
And all the churches of the Gentiles thank them too.
5 Also greet the church that meets in their house.
Greet my dear friend Epaenetus.
He was the first person in Achaia to come to Christ.
6 Greet Mary.
She worked very hard for us.
7 Greet Andronicus and Junia.
They are my relatives.
They were in prison with me.
They are notable among the apostles.
And they belonged to Christ before I did.
8 Greet Amplias.
I love him dearly in the Lord.
9 Greet Urbanus.
He works together with us for Christ.
And greet my dear friend Stachys.
10 Greet Apelles.
He has been tested and has proved true in Christ.
Greet the people of Aristobulus's household.
11 Greet my relative Herodion.
Greet the people of Narcissus's household who belong
to the Lord.
12 Greet Tryphaena and Tryphosa.
They work for the Lord.
Greet dear Persis.
She has worked very hard for the Lord.
13 Greet Rufus.
The Lord chose him.
Greet his mother too.
She has also been a mother to me.
14 Greet Asyncritus,
Phlegon,
Hermes,
Patrobas,
Hermas,
and the brothers who are with them.
15 Greet Philologus and Julia,
Nereus and his sister,
and Olympas,
and all of God's holy people who are with them.
16 Greet one another with a holy kiss.
All the churches of Christ send you greetings.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: We know Prisca (also called Priscilla) and her husband Aquila from Acts (chapter 18). Prisca is often named first. She was probably especially important in the church.

Verse 5: At that time there were no church buildings. Christians met in people's homes.

Verse 5: The WEB says "Achaia" here, a region in Greece. Many old manuscripts have *Asia* instead, a province in today's Turkey. This edition follows the WEB.

Verse 7: Junia is a woman's name. Paul says that she and Andronicus are "notable among the apostles." Many scholars understand this to mean: Junia was an apostle herself. Others understand: The apostles thought highly of them. In some later Bibles Junia was turned into a man (*Junias*). Today most experts agree that Junia was a woman.

Verse 13: Rufus is perhaps the son of Simon of Cyrene, who carried the cross of Jesus (Mark 15:21).

Paul greets many women and men, slaves and free people, Jews and non-Jews. Many of the names were typical names of slaves or freed slaves. In the church they all belonged together.

Verse 16: The "holy kiss" was a sign of fellowship. Today many Christians give each other a sign of peace in worship, for example a handshake.

A last warning VERSES 17–20

17 Brothers, I urge you:
Watch out for people who cause divisions.
They make others stumble.
They go against the teaching you learned.
Stay away from them.

18 Such people do not serve our Lord Jesus Christ.
They serve their own stomachs.
They use smooth words and flattery.
That is how they fool people who do not suspect anything.

19 Everyone has heard that you obey God.
So I am happy about you.
But I want you to be wise about what is good,
and innocent about what is evil.

20 The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet.
May the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 17–18: Paul warns against people who sow conflict and only look for their own advantage. Whoever uses beautiful words to exploit others is not serving Christ.

For today: Today too there are groups that use beautiful words to make people dependent. If you feel pressured in a group, you can find help at counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse. In a crisis: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 20 recalls Genesis 3:15: In the end evil will be defeated. God is a God of peace.

Greetings from his co-workers VERSES 21–24

21 Timothy works together with me.
He sends you greetings.
So do my relatives Lucius, Jason and Sosipater.

22 I am Tertius.
I am writing down this letter.
I greet you in the Lord.

23 Gaius sends you greetings.
He is my host.
He is also the host of the whole church.
Erastus, the city treasurer, sends you greetings.
A treasurer is the official who takes care of a city's money.
Our brother Quartus sends greetings too.

24 May the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with you all!
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: Paul didn't write the letter himself, but dictated it. Tertius was the writer. Here he sends his own greeting.

Verse 23: Erastus was an important official in Corinth. An old inscription with the name Erastus has been found in Corinth. Whether it is the same man is not certain.

Verse 24 is missing in many old manuscripts. The WEB has it.

About the numbering: Many Bibles have verses 25–27 here, a praise of God. The WEB placed these verses at the end of chapter 14 (Romans 14:24–26). You will find them there in this edition.

Looking back: What have we read in the letter to the Romans?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A letter to Rome: Paul writes to a church that he doesn't know yet. He introduces himself and his message.

Everyone needs God's grace: Jews and people from the nations, all have sinned. No one can make themselves righteous (chapters 1 to 3).

Made right through faith: God makes people righteous, by grace, through faith in Jesus Christ. Abraham is the great example of faith (chapters 3 to 5).

A new life: Through baptism Christians belong to Christ. Sin is no longer to rule. The Holy Spirit makes people children of God. Nothing can separate us from God's love (chapters 6 to 8).

God remains faithful to Israel: God has not rejected his people. His gifts and his calling cannot be taken back.

Christians are like branches grafted into the olive tree of Israel. They must not consider themselves better than Jews (chapters 9 to 11).

Living from love: Christians are to accept one another, be considerate, overcome evil with good and live at peace with all people (chapters 12 to 15).

A colorful church: At the end Paul greets many women and men, among them Phoebe, Prisca and Junia (chapter 16).

In history: The letter to the Romans has strongly shaped the church, for example Augustine, Martin Luther and Karl Barth. In 1999 Catholic and Lutheran Christians declared together: At heart we understand justification by grace in the same way.

For today: God's love is for all people. We don't have to earn it.

What comes next? Next comes Paul's first letter to the church in Corinth. There were many problems there: conflict, divisions and questions about worship. This letter also contains the famous chapter about love (chapter 13).

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 46 OF 66

1 CORINTHIANS

16 CHAPTERS

1 CORINTHIANS

Chapter 1

The message of the cross

Before we begin: The first letter to the Corinthians

Corinth was a large, rich port city in Greece. People from many countries lived there. There was a lot of trade, there were many religions, and there were big differences between rich and poor.

Paul had founded the church in Corinth himself. He lived there for about a year and a half (Acts 18). Later he wrote several letters to the church. He probably wrote this letter around AD 54 or 55 in Ephesus.

The church had many problems: quarrels and groups, questions about marriage and sexuality, about food, about worship, about the gifts of the Spirit and about the resurrection. Paul answers all these questions.

The first letter to the Corinthians contains some of the best-known texts of the Bible: the "Song of Love" (chapter 13), the words about the Lord's Supper (chapter 11) and the great chapter about the resurrection (chapter 15).

Important note: Some passages in this letter are about women in worship and about other questions that were much debated at that time. We translate everything exactly. In the boxes we explain how Christians understand these passages differently today.

The first letter to the Corinthians has 16 chapters.

Greeting VERSES 1–3

1 Paul,
called to be an apostle of Jesus Christ
through the will of God,
and our brother Sosthenes,
2 write to the church of God
which is at Corinth:
to those who are sanctified in Christ Jesus,
called saints,
with all who call on the name of our Lord Jesus Christ
in every place,
both theirs and ours.
3 Grace to you and peace
from God our Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sanctified means: made holy, belonging to God.

Verse 1: Sosthenes was perhaps the leader of the synagogue in Corinth that Acts 18:17 tells about. That is not certain.

Verse 2: "Saints" are not especially pious people, but all Christians. They belong to God.

Verse 2: Paul writes not only to Corinth, but to all Christians in every place. The letter is meant for us too.

Paul thanks God VERSES 4–9

4 I always thank my God for you,
for the grace of God
which was given you in Christ Jesus.
5 For in him you were made rich in everything,
in all speech and all knowledge.
6 So the testimony of Christ
was made firm in you.
7 So you lack no gift,
while you wait
for the revelation of our Lord Jesus Christ.
8 He will also make you firm until the end,
so that you are blameless
in the day of our Lord Jesus Christ.
9 God is faithful.
Through him you were called
into the fellowship of his Son,
Jesus Christ our Lord.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Even though there were many problems in Corinth, Paul first gives thanks for the good. He sees the gifts that God has given the church.

Verses 7–8: The first Christians were waiting for Jesus to come again.

Verse 9: "God is faithful." That is the reason why Christians can hope, even when they themselves are weak.

For today: Even in a quarrel, it is worth seeing the good in the other person first.

Quarrels in the church VERSES 10–17

10 Now I beg you, brothers,
through the name of our Lord Jesus Christ:
All of you, speak the same thing.
There should be no divisions among you.
Be joined together
in the same mind
and in the same judgment.
11 For it has been reported to me about you,
my brothers,
by those from Chloe's household,
that there are quarrels among you.
12 I mean this:
Each one of you says,
"I follow Paul,"
"I follow Apollos,"
"I follow Cephas,"
and, "I follow Christ."
13 Is Christ divided?
Was Paul crucified for you?
Or were you baptized into the name of Paul?
14 I thank God
that I baptized none of you
except Crispus and Gaius,
15 so that no one can say
that I baptized you into my own name.
16 (I also baptized the household of Stephanas.
Besides them, I don't know

whether I baptized anyone else.)
17 For Christ didn't send me
to baptize,
but to preach the Good News,
and not with clever words,
so that the cross of Christ doesn't lose its power.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Chloe was probably a woman who ran a household with workers or slaves. Her people told Paul about the quarrels.

Verse 12: In Corinth, groups formed around well-known teachers. Apollos was a gifted preacher (Acts 18:24–28). "Cephas" is the Aramaic name of Peter.

Verse 13: Paul asks: "Is Christ divided?" All Christians belong to the one Christ, not to a human teacher.

Verse 14: Crispus was the leader of the synagogue in Corinth (Acts 18:8).

Verse 17: Paul doesn't say that baptism is unimportant. But his special task was preaching.

For today: Today too there are many churches and groups. This text reminds us: We all belong to Christ. That is why ecumenism, the churches living and working together, is important.

God's wisdom and human wisdom VERSES 18–31

18 For the message of the cross
is foolishness
to those who are dying.
But to us
who are being saved
it is the power of God.
19 For it is written:
"I will destroy the wisdom of the wise.
I will bring the discernment of the discerning to
nothing."
20 Where is the wise?
Where is the scribe?
Where is the debater of this age?
Hasn't God made foolish
the wisdom of this world?
21 For in the wisdom of God
the world through its wisdom
didn't know God.
So it pleased God
through the foolishness of the preaching
to save those
who believe.
22 For Jews ask for signs,
and Greeks seek after wisdom.
23 But we preach Christ crucified.
To Jews this is a stumbling block,
and to Greeks it is foolishness.
24 But to those who are called,
both Jews and Greeks,
Christ is the power of God and the wisdom of God.
25 For the foolishness of God
is wiser than people.
And the weakness of God
is stronger than people.
26 Look at your calling, brothers:
Not many of you are wise by human standards,
not many are mighty,
and not many are noble.
27 But God chose the foolish things of the world
to put to shame those who are wise.
God chose the weak things of the world
to put to shame the things that are strong.
28 God chose the lowly things of the world,
and the things that are despised,
and the things that don't exist,
to bring to nothing
the things that exist,
29 so that no one can boast before God.
30 Because of him, you are in Christ Jesus.
He was made to us wisdom from God,
and righteousness,
and holiness,
and redemption.
31 So it is
as it is written:
"He who boasts,
let him boast in the Lord."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Scribe means: a teacher of the Scriptures.

Righteousness means: living right before God.

Redemption means: being set free.

Verse 18: A crucified savior sounded like nonsense to many people at that time. Crucifixion was the worst and most shameful death penalty. Paul says: It is precisely in the cross that God's power shows itself.

Verse 19 quotes Isaiah 29:14. Verse 31 takes up Jeremiah 9:24 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 9:23).

Verse 21: "In the wisdom of God": God in his wisdom arranged it this way. People cannot find God by their own reason alone. God shows himself, in the message about Jesus.

Verses 22–24: Paul describes why the message of the cross was hard to accept for many people of his time, for Jews as well as for Greeks. He himself is a Jew. He is speaking about a question of faith, not speaking badly about a people. And he says clearly: Many Jews also belong to those who are called (verse 24).

Verses 26–28: The church in Corinth was made up mainly of ordinary people, of the poor and of slaves. God chooses precisely the weak and the despised.

For today: With God, education, money and reputation don't count. Every person is valuable.

1 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 2

The wisdom that comes from the Spirit

Paul preaches Christ crucified VERSES 1–5

1 Brothers, when I came to you,
I told you the testimony of God.
That means: what God has shown and said.
But I did not come with fine speeches or with great wisdom.
2 I made up my mind not to know anything while I was with you,
except Jesus Christ, and him crucified.
3 I was with you in weakness, in fear, and in much trembling.
4 My speaking and my preaching did not use clever words of human wisdom.
Instead, they showed the Spirit and God's power.
5 So your faith would not rest on human wisdom.
It would rest on the power of God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–3: Paul was not a brilliant speaker. He came to Corinth "in weakness, in fear, and in much trembling." He says this honestly.

Verse 2: At the center of his preaching was Jesus, who died on the cross.

Verse 5: Faith should not rest on an impressive preacher, but on God.

For today: If you are afraid of speaking in front of others, you can know: Paul felt the same way. God doesn't need perfect people.

God's hidden wisdom VERSES 6–16

6 But we do speak wisdom among those who are full grown.
But it is not the wisdom of this world.
It is not the wisdom of the rulers of this world.
They are coming to nothing.
7 We speak God's wisdom.
It is a mystery.
This wisdom was hidden.
Before the worlds began, God planned it for our glory.
8 None of the rulers of this world has known it.
If they had known it,
they would not have crucified the Lord of glory.
9 But it is as it is written:
"No eye has seen these things.
No ear has heard them.
No human heart has thought of them.
These things God has prepared for those who love him."
10 But God has shown them to us through the Spirit.
The Spirit searches everything,
even the deep things of God.
11 Who knows what is inside a person?
Only the person's own spirit inside them knows.
In the same way, no one knows the things of God,
except God's Spirit.
12 We did not receive the spirit of the world.
We received the Spirit who comes from God.
So we can know the things that God has freely given us.
13 We also speak about these things.
We do not use words that human wisdom teaches.
We use words that the Holy Spirit teaches.
So we compare spiritual things with spiritual things.
14 The natural man does not accept the things of God's Spirit.
They seem foolish to him.
He cannot understand them,
because they can only be judged with the help of the Spirit.
15 But a spiritual person can judge all things.
And no one can judge him.
16 "Who has known the mind of the Lord,
so that he could teach him?"
But we have the mind of Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: "Full grown" means: grown up. It means people who have grown in faith.

Verse 8: "None of the rulers of this world has known it." The rulers probably means the powerful people who had Jesus crucified, above all the Roman power. Some interpreters also think of invisible powers.

Verse 9 recalls Isaiah 64:4 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 64:3) and Isaiah 65:17. Paul quotes freely here. These words are often read at funerals: God has prepared more for those who love him than we can imagine.

Verses 10–12: God's Spirit helps us to understand God. By our own strength we cannot fully grasp God.

Verse 14: "The natural man" means a person who judges only with his own reason, without God's Spirit.

Verse 16 quotes Isaiah 40:13.

Verses 15–16 don't mean that Christians are better than others or are above everything. In the next chapter Paul scolds the Corinthians precisely because they think they are especially spiritual.

1 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 3

God makes things grow

Like babies VERSES 1–4

1 Brothers,
I could not speak to you as to spiritual people.
I had to speak to you as to fleshly people,
as to babies in Christ.
2 I gave you milk to drink.
I did not give you solid food.
You were not ready for it yet.
And you are still not ready now,
3 because you are still fleshly.
There is jealousy among you.
You quarrel and split into groups that are against each

other.
So are you not fleshly?
Are you not living like ordinary people?
4 One of you says,
"I follow Paul."
Another says,
"I follow Apollos."
So are you not fleshly?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Fleshly" here means: thinking and acting as if there were no God. It doesn't mean the body.

Verses 1–2: Paul compares the Corinthians with babies who still need milk. They think they are very wise, but their quarrels show: They are not yet grown up in faith.

God makes things grow VERSES 5–9

5 Who is Apollos?
And who is Paul?
We are only servants.
Through us you came to believe.
Each of us did what the Lord gave him to do.
6 I planted.
Apollos watered.
But God made it grow.
7 So the one who plants is nothing.
The one who waters is nothing.
Only God matters,
because he makes things grow.
8 The one who plants and the one who waters are the same.
But each one will get his own reward
for his own work.
9 We work together with God.
You are God's field.
You are God's building.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: A picture from farming. People can plant and water. But whether something grows is not in their hands. God gives that.

Verse 9: The church doesn't belong to Paul or Apollos, but to God.

For today: No one in the church has to do everything alone. And no one should think they are more important than the others.

The foundation is Jesus Christ VERSES 10–17

10 God gave me his grace.
With it I laid a foundation, like a wise master builder.
Now someone else is building on it.
But each one must be careful how he builds on it.
11 No one can lay any other foundation than the one that has been laid.
That foundation is Jesus Christ.
12 Someone may build on this foundation with gold,
silver,
costly stones,
wood,
hay
or straw.
13 But each person's work will be shown for what it is.
The Day will make it clear,
because it will be revealed with fire.
The fire will test what kind of work each person has done.
14 If the building that someone built on the foundation lasts,
he will receive a reward.
15 If someone's work burns up, he will lose it.
But he himself will be saved,
like someone who escapes through a fire.
16 Don't you know that you are God's temple?
Don't you know that God's Spirit lives in you?
17 If anyone destroys God's temple,
God will destroy him.
God's temple is holy, and you are that temple.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: The foundation of the church is Jesus Christ. Everything else builds on him.

Verses 12–15: "The Day" means the day when God judges everything. What is built well remains. What is built badly burns. But the person himself is saved. God's grace is greater than our mistakes.

Verse 15: The Catholic Church sees in this verse a hint of "purgatory," a cleansing after death. Protestant and Orthodox Christians usually understand the verse differently. What is certain: Here Paul is speaking about the testing of work in the church.

Verses 16–17: "God's temple is holy, and you are that temple": This means the whole church. Whoever destroys the church through quarrels acts against God.

Everything is yours VERSES 18–23

18 Do not fool yourselves.
Some of you may think that you are wise in this world.
If so, you should become a fool,
so that you can become truly wise.
19 The wisdom of this world is foolishness to God.
It is written,
"He has caught the wise in their own tricks."
20 And it is also written,
"The Lord knows the thoughts of the wise.
He knows that they are worthless."
21 So no one should boast about people.
Everything belongs to you:
22 Paul,
Apollos,
Cephas,
the world,
life,
death,
the present,
and the future.
Everything belongs to you.
23 And you belong to Christ.
And Christ belongs to God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19 quotes Job 5:13. Verse 20 quotes Psalm 94:11.

Verse 18: "Become a fool" means: not thinking you are wiser than God.

Verses 21–23: The Corinthians say: "I follow Paul" or "I follow Apollos." Paul turns this around: You don't belong to

the teachers, but the teachers belong to you. And you belong
to Christ.

1 CORINTHIANS

Chapter 4

Servants of Christ

God alone judges VERSES 1–5

1 So people should think of us
as Christ's servants
and stewards of God's mysteries.
2 Above all, stewards are required
to be faithful.
3 But to me it is a very small thing
whether I am judged by you
or by a human court.
Yes, I don't even judge myself.
4 For I know nothing against myself.
Yet that doesn't make me righteous.
He who judges me
is the Lord.
5 So judge nothing before the time,
until the Lord comes.
He will bring to light
the things hidden in darkness,
and he will reveal
the intentions of the hearts.
Then each one will get his praise from God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Steward means: a manager who takes care of someone else's house or property.

Verses 1–2: In those days a steward managed someone else's house or property. He had to be faithful. In the same way, the leaders in the church should faithfully pass on God's gifts.

Verses 3–4: Paul doesn't depend on what others think of him. He doesn't even judge himself. Only God can truly judge a person.

Verse 5: "Judge nothing before the time": We don't know another person's heart. So we shouldn't judge others too quickly.

For today: If you constantly worry about what others think of you, you can know: God's judgment is what counts. And God wants to praise us (verse 5).

What do you have that you didn't receive? VERSES 6–13

6 Brothers,
I have applied these things
to myself and Apollos as an example,
for your sake.
From us you should learn:
"Not beyond what is written."
Then none of you will be puffed up
against one another.
7 For who makes you different?
What do you have
that you didn't receive?
But if you did receive it,
why do you boast
as if you had not received it?
8 You are already full.
You have already become rich.
You have come to reign like kings
without us.
Yes, I wish
that you really did reign,
so that we also might reign with you!
9 For I think
God has put us apostles last of all,
like men
sentenced to death.
For we have become a spectacle
to the world,
both to angels and to people.
10 We are fools for Christ's sake,
but you are wise in Christ.
We are weak,
but you are strong.
You have honor,
but we are despised.
11 Even to this present hour
we are hungry and thirsty,
we don't have enough clothes,
we are beaten,
and we have no settled home.
12 We work hard
with our own hands.
When people curse us,
we bless.
When we are persecuted,
we endure.
13 When people speak badly of us,
we answer kindly.
We have become like the filth of the world,
like the dirt
wiped off by everyone,
even until now.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: "Not beyond what is written" was probably a well-known saying. It means: Stay with what Holy Scripture says, and don't make yourselves more important.

Verse 7 is an important question: "What do you have that you didn't receive?" Everything we have and can do is a gift.

Verses 8–10: Here Paul speaks with irony. The Corinthians think they are rich, wise and strong. Paul shows: The apostles live very differently, poor and despised.

Verse 9: "A spectacle": In the arena, people sentenced to death were brought out at the end. That is how the apostles feel.

Verse 12: Paul earned his own money as a tentmaker (Acts 18:3).

Verses 12–13: The apostles answer evil with good, as Jesus taught.

Paul as father of the church VERSES 14–21

14 I don't write these things
to shame you,
but to warn you
as my beloved children.
15 For even if you have 10,000 tutors in Christ,
you don't have many fathers.
For in Christ Jesus
I became your father through the Good News.
16 So I beg you:
Follow my example.
17 That is why I have sent Timothy to you.
He is my beloved and faithful child in the Lord.
He will remind you of my ways in Christ,
as I teach everywhere in every church.
18 But some of you are puffed up,
as though I were not coming to you.
19 But I will come to you soon,
if the Lord is willing.
Then I will pay attention not to the words of those who
are puffed up,
but to their power.
20 For God's Kingdom is not in words,
but in power.
21 What do you want?
Shall I come to you with a rod,
or in love and a spirit of gentleness?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Tutor here means: a guardian who looked after children.

Verse 15: In those days a "tutor" was often a slave who took the children to school and watched over them. Paul says: You have many teachers, but I founded the church. So I am like a father to you.

Verse 16: "Follow my example": Paul means his life of simplicity, patience and love (verses 11–13).

Verse 17: Timothy was a close co-worker of Paul (Acts 16:1–3).

Verse 21: "With a rod" is a picture for a strict warning. But Paul wishes to come with love and gentleness.

Important: This picture from the way children were raised back then is no permission to hit children. Children have a right to grow up without violence. Help for parents and children: In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

1 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 5

A serious case in the church

A man lives with his father's wife VERSES 1–5

1 It is actually reported
that there is sexual immorality among you,
and such sexual immorality
as is not even found among the Gentiles:
one has his father's wife.
2 And you are arrogant!
You should rather have mourned,
so that he
who had done this deed
might be removed from among you.
3 For I am absent in body,
but present in spirit.
And I have already judged him
who has done this thing,
as though I were present.
4 In the name of our Lord Jesus Christ,
when you are gathered together
and my spirit is with you,
with the power of our Lord Jesus Christ,
5 you are to hand such a one over to Satan
for the destruction of the flesh,
so that the spirit may be saved
in the day of the Lord Jesus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gentiles means: people who are not Jews.

Verse 1: "One has his father's wife." This probably means his stepmother. Such a relationship was forbidden in the law of Israel (Leviticus 18:8) and also under Roman law.

Verse 2: Paul scolds not only the man, but above all the church. It was proud of its "freedom" and looked away.

Verse 5: "Hand such a one over to Satan" is a difficult phrase. It probably means: The man is to be excluded from the fellowship of the church. Outside, he should notice what he has lost. The goal is not his destruction, but his rescue: "so that the spirit may be saved."

Important: This verse is no permission to use violence against people, to curse them or to harm them. The goal is turning back and rescue.

A little yeast VERSES 6–8

6 Your boasting is not good.
Don't you know
that a little yeast
makes the whole lump of dough rise?
7 Clean out the old yeast,
so that you may be a new lump,
as you really are without yeast.
For Christ, our Passover lamb,
has been sacrificed in our place.
8 So let's keep the feast,
not with old yeast,
nor with the yeast of malice and wickedness,
but with the bread without yeast
of sincerity and truth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Before the Passover feast, Jewish families still remove all yeast from the house today. Then they eat bread without

yeast (Exodus 12:15–20).

Paul uses this picture: Just as a little yeast goes through the whole dough, a bad example can change the whole church.

Verse 7: Paul compares Jesus with the Passover lamb. Jesus died at the time of the Passover feast.

Verse 7: The WEB, our English source text, says "in our place." These words are missing in many old manuscripts.

Who belongs to the church? VERSES 9–13

9 I wrote to you in my letter
that you should have no company
with people who live in sexual immorality.
10 But I didn't mean
the sexually immoral people of this world in general,
or the greedy and those who rob others,
or those who worship idols.
For then you would have to leave the world.
11 But I wrote to you:
Don't associate with anyone
who is called a brother
and lives in sexual immorality,
or is greedy,
or worships idols,
or slanders others,
or is a drunkard,
or robs others.
Don't even eat with such a person.
12 For what do I have to do
with judging those who are outside?
Don't you judge those
who are inside?
13 But those who are outside, God judges.
"Put away the wicked man from among yourselves."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Idol means: a statue or image that people worship as a god.

Slander means: to tell lies about others.

Verse 9: Paul had already written an earlier letter to the Corinthians. This letter has not survived.

Verses 10–12: Christians should not cut themselves off from the world. They should not judge people outside the church. But inside the church they should look out for one another.

Verse 13 takes up a saying that comes often in Deuteronomy (for example Deuteronomy 17:7 and 22:24).

Important: How churches deal with serious wrong is a serious question today too. Sadly, churches have often protected offenders and left victims alone, for example in cases of sexual abuse. This text shows: Looking away is wrong. If you have experienced abuse, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673.

In the second letter to the Corinthians, Paul writes that a person who is sorry should be forgiven and comforted again (2 Corinthians 2:5–11). Some interpreters think it is about the same case there.

1 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 6

Your body belongs to God

Christians quarrel in court VERSES 1–8

1 Suppose one of you has a complaint against his neighbor.
How can he dare to take it to court before unrighteous people?
Why does he not take it before God's holy people?
2 Don't you know that the saints will judge the world?
The saints are God's holy people.
You will judge the world.
So are you not good enough to decide the smallest matters?
3 Don't you know that we will judge angels?
Then we can surely judge the things of everyday life!
4 So if you have to decide matters of everyday life,
why do you ask people to judge who count for nothing in the church?
5 I say this to make you ashamed.
Is there not even one wise person among you?
Is there no one who can settle a quarrel between his brothers?
6 Instead, one brother takes another brother to court.
And he does it in front of unbelievers!
7 The fact that you take each other to court
already shows that you have failed completely.
Why not rather let others wrong you?
Why not rather let others cheat you?
8 But no, you yourselves do wrong and cheat others.
And you even do it to your own brothers.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The Christians in Corinth took small quarrels, for example about money, to the Roman courts. Paul thinks: Christians should settle their quarrels among themselves peacefully.

Verses 2–3: Paul writes "that the saints will judge the world." He means the future, when God's Kingdom comes.

Verse 7: Paul says: It is better to suffer wrong than to do wrong.

Important: This text is about small quarrels. It does not mean that crimes like violence or abuse should be handled inside the church. Such acts belong before the police and a court of the state. That protects the victims. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

For today: Many churches offer conflict resolution and mediation.

You were washed VERSES 9–11

9 Don't you know that the unrighteous will not inherit God's Kingdom?

Do not be fooled!
None of these people will inherit God's Kingdom:
the sexually immoral,
people who worship idols,
adulterers,
male prostitutes,
homosexuals,
10 thieves,
greedy people,
drunkards,
people who speak evil of others,
or people who take things from others by force.
An adulterer is someone who is unfaithful in marriage.
11 Some of you were like that.
But you were washed.
You were made holy.
You were made righteous
in the name of the Lord Jesus
and in the Spirit of our God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9–10: Paul lists ways of behaving that don't fit with God's Kingdom. Many of them are about how we treat other people: cheating, greed, slander, robbery.

Verse 9: Two Greek words in this verse are hard to translate. The WEB, our English source text, translates them as "male prostitutes" and "homosexuals." The first word (*malakoi*) literally means *the soft ones*. The second word (*arsenokoitai*) means something like *men who sleep with men*. It does not appear in any known text before Paul. The word "homosexual" has only existed since the 19th century. That is why other Bibles translate these words very differently.

The churches understand this passage differently today. Some see it as a lasting command against same-sex sexuality. Others say: Paul meant exploitation, prostitution and the abuse of boys as it existed in his time, not loving, faithful partnerships as we know them today. Many churches are seriously wrestling with this question.

Very important: This text gives no one the right to despise, insult or use violence against people. Every person has the same dignity before God. If you experience exclusion or violence because of your sexual orientation, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988; young LGBTQ people can also contact The Trevor Project. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 11 is the heart: "But you were washed. You were made holy. You were made righteous." God changes people. No one is shut out from his grace.

Your body is a temple VERSES 12–20

12 "I am allowed to do anything,"
but not everything is good for me.
"I am allowed to do anything,"
but I will not let anything control me.
13 "Food is for the stomach, and the stomach is for food,"
but God will bring both of them to an end.
But the body is not for sexual immorality.
The body is for the Lord,
and the Lord is for the body.
14 God raised the Lord from the dead.
And by his power he will also raise us up.
15 Don't you know that your bodies are parts of Christ's body?
So should I take parts of Christ's body
and make them parts of a prostitute's body?
Of course not!
16 Don't you know that a man who joins himself to a prostitute
becomes one body with her?
For he says,
"The two will become one flesh."
17 But someone who joins himself to the Lord
becomes one spirit with him.
18 Run away from sexual immorality!
"Every sin that a person does is outside the body."
But someone who commits sexual immorality sins against his own body.
19 Don't you know that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit?
The Holy Spirit is in you.
You have received him from God.
You do not belong to yourselves.
20 You were bought with a price.
So honor God with your body and with your spirit.
They belong to God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 12–13 and 18: The sentences in quotation marks were probably sayings that people used in Corinth. Some thought: The body is unimportant, you can do anything with it. Paul disagrees.

Verses 13–14: The body is not worthless. God will raise us up with our bodies too.

Verses 15–16: There was a lot of prostitution in Corinth. Verse 16 quotes Genesis 2:24. Sexuality joins people deeply together. It is not something minor.

Verse 19: Paul writes "that your body is a temple of the Holy Spirit." Every person may value their body and take good care of it.

Verse 20: "Bought with a price": In those days slaves were bought free. Jesus bought us free with his life.

Important: Many people in prostitution are exploited or are victims of human trafficking. They deserve protection and help, not contempt. In the US, call the National Human Trafficking Hotline at 1-888-373-7888. In the UK, call the Modern Slavery Helpline at 08000 121 700.

1 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 7

Marriage and staying single

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

In this chapter Paul answers questions that the church in Corinth asked him in a letter. We don't know these

questions exactly. Paul writes at a time when he believes that Jesus will come again very soon (verses 26 and 29). This shapes his advice.
Paul himself makes a difference: Some things are a command of the Lord (verse 10), some things are his own advice (verses 6, 12, 25 and 40).

Marriage goes both ways VERSES 1–9

1 Now I will answer the things you wrote to me about:
"It is good for a man not to touch a woman."
2 But there is a lot of sexual immorality.
So each man should have his own wife.
And each woman should have her own husband.
3 The husband should give his wife the affection he owes her.
And the wife should do the same for her husband.
4 The wife does not have authority over her own body.
Her husband does.
In the same way, the husband does not have authority over his own body.
His wife does.
5 Do not refuse each other.
You may stop for a while, but only by consent for a season.
That means: if you both agree, for a certain time.
Then you can give yourselves to fasting and prayer.
After that, come together again.
Otherwise Satan may tempt you, because you lack self-control.
6 I say this to allow it.
It is not a command.
7 I wish that all people were like me.
But each person has his own gift from God.
One has this gift, and another has that gift.
8 To the unmarried and to widows I say:
It is good for them to stay single, as I am.
9 But if they cannot control themselves, they should marry.
It is better to marry than to burn with passion.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "It is good for a man not to touch a woman" was probably a sentence from the Corinthians' letter. Some in Corinth thought that Christians should give up sexuality completely, even in marriage. Paul disagrees.

Verses 3–4: For that time this was very new: Paul speaks about husband and wife in exactly the same way. Both have the same rights and duties.

Very important: These verses give no one the right to force sex. Sexuality in marriage always needs the agreement of both (verse 5: "by consent for a season"). Violence and rape are a serious wrong in marriage too, and they are a crime. Help: US: 1-800-799-7233; RAINN 1-800-656-4673. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 7: Paul himself was not married. He sees both marriage and staying single as a "gift from God."

Divorce and mixed marriages VERSES 10–16

10 To those who are married I give this command.
It is not from me, but from the Lord:
A wife should not leave her husband.
11 (But if she does leave him,
she should stay unmarried,
or else make peace with her husband again.)
And a husband should not leave his wife.
12 To the others I say this.
It is from me, not from the Lord:
A brother may have a wife who does not believe.
If she is happy to live with him,
he should not leave her.
13 A woman may have a husband who does not believe.
If he is happy to live with her,
she should not leave her husband.
14 The husband who does not believe is made holy through his wife.
And the wife who does not believe is made holy through her husband.
Otherwise your children would be unclean.
But now they are holy.
15 But if the one who does not believe leaves,
then let them separate.
In such cases, the brother or the sister is not bound.
God has called us to peace.
16 Wife, how do you know whether you will save your husband?
Husband, how do you know whether you will save your wife?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–11: Here Paul refers to a word of Jesus (compare Mark 10:9–12). Marriage should last a lifetime.

Churches today deal with divorce and remarriage in different ways. The Catholic Church holds firmly that marriage cannot be dissolved. Protestant and Orthodox churches allow a new marriage under certain circumstances.

Very important: No one has to stay in a marriage in which they experience violence. Safety comes first. Paul himself says: "God has called us to peace" (verse 15). US: 1-800-799-7233. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. Women's shelters also offer protection. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verses 12–14: If one partner is a Christian and the other is not, they should still stay together. The Christian partner makes the family "holy." The children belong to God.

Stay as God called you VERSES 17–24

17 But each person should live the life
that the Lord has given him,
the life to which God has called him.
I give this command in all the churches.
18 Was a man already circumcised when God called him?
He should not try to undo his circumcision.
Was a man uncircumcised when God called him?
He should not be circumcised.
Circumcision was a sign of the covenant with God for Jewish boys and men.
19 Being circumcised is nothing.
Not being circumcised is nothing.
What matters is keeping God's commandments.
20 Each person should stay in the situation he was in when God called him.

21 Were you a slave when God called you?
Don't let that bother you.
But if you get an opportunity to become free, use it.
22 Someone who was a slave when the Lord called him
is the Lord's free man.
In the same way, someone who was free when he was called
is Christ's slave.
23 You were bought with a price.
Don't become slaves of people.
24 Brothers, each person should stay with God
in the situation he was in when he was called.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: At that time some Jewish men tried to hide their circumcision so as not to stand out in Greek sports. Paul says: Jews should stay Jews; non-Jews should not have to become Jews.

Verse 21: The Greek text is not clear here. The WEB, our English source text, understands

it like this: "But if you get an opportunity to become free, use it." Others understand it as: *Rather stay as you are*.

Important: Slavery is a grave injustice. Paul could not abolish it in his time. But verse 23 says: "Don't become slaves of people." Later Christians used these words against slavery. Today there is still human trafficking and forced labor. Christians should stand up against it.

Advice for the unmarried VERSES 25–35

25 Now about virgins.
Here "virgins" means young women who are not married.
I have no command from the Lord about them.
But I give my opinion.
The Lord has shown me mercy,
so that I can be trusted.
26 So this is what I think:
Because of the distress that is on us now,
it is good for a person to stay as he is.
27 Are you married to a wife?
Then do not try to get free.
Are you not married?
Then do not look for a wife.
28 But if you do marry, you have not sinned.
And if a virgin marries, she has not sinned.
But people who marry will have trouble in this life.
I want to spare you that.
29 Brothers, I tell you this:
The time is short.
From now on, those who have wives should live as if they had none.
30 Those who cry should live as if they were not crying.
Those who are happy should live as if they were not happy.
Those who buy things should live as if they did not own anything.
31 Those who use the things of the world
should not use them to the full.
For this world in its present form is passing away.
32 I want you to be free from worries.
A man who is not married cares about the things of the Lord.
He wants to please the Lord.
33 But a man who is married cares about the things of the world.
He wants to please his wife.
34 There is also a difference between a married woman and a virgin.
The unmarried woman cares about the things of the Lord.
She wants to be holy in body and in spirit.
But the married woman cares about the things of the world.
She wants to please her husband.
35 I say this to help you.
I do not want to trap you.
I want you to live in a fitting way.
I want you to serve the Lord without distraction.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25: "Virgins" here means young, unmarried women.

Verse 26: "Because of the distress that is on us now": Paul expects hard times before the end of the world. That is why he advises against marrying now. This is advice for his time, not a command.

Verse 28: Whoever marries does nothing wrong. Paul says this clearly.

Verses 29–31: "The time is short": Christians should not tie themselves completely to the things of this world. Everything earthly passes away.

Verses 32–34: Paul sees in staying single a freedom to give oneself completely to God. Many members of religious orders and Catholic priests still live this way today. But married people can also serve God with all their heart.

To marry or not? VERSES 36–40

36 A man may think that he is not treating his virgin rightly.
Perhaps she is getting older,
and he feels that it has to be so.
Then he should do what he wants.
He is not sinning.
They should marry.
37 But another man may stand firm in his heart.
No one is pressuring him.
He has control over his own will.
He has decided in his heart to keep his virgin as she is.
That man does well.
38 So the man who lets his virgin marry does well.
And the man who does not let her marry does better.
39 A wife is bound by law as long as her husband lives.
But if her husband dies,
she is free to marry anyone she wants.
But he must belong to the Lord.
40 But in my opinion, she is happier if she stays as she is.
And I think that I also have God's Spirit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 36–38: These verses are hard to understand. The WEB understands them like this: A man (probably the father) decides whether his daughter marries. Other interpreters think: It is about an engaged couple who are thinking about

whether to marry. In those days fathers often decided about their daughters' marriages.

Important: Today the rule is: No one may be forced into a marriage. Forced marriage is against the law. If you are being threatened, you can get help. US: 1-800-799-7233. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 39: A widow may freely choose whom she marries. For that time this was a large piece of freedom.

Verse 40: Paul stresses once more: This is his opinion.

1 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 8

Knowledge and love

Knowledge puffs up, love builds up VERSES 1–6

1 Now about things sacrificed to idols:
We know
that we all have knowledge.
Knowledge puffs up,
but love builds up.
2 If anyone thinks
that he knows anything,
he doesn't yet know
as he ought to know.
3 But anyone who loves God
is known by him.
4 So about eating things sacrificed to idols,
we know:
No idol in the world
is anything.
And there is no other God
but one.
5 For even though there are things
that are called "gods,"
whether in the heavens or on earth,
as there are many "gods" and many "lords,"
6 yet for us there is one God,
the Father.
All things come from him,
and we live for him.
And there is one Lord,
Jesus Christ.
Through him are all things,
and we live through him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sacrificed means: offered as a gift to a god.

In Corinth there were many temples for Greek and Roman gods. Animals were sacrificed there. Afterwards the meat was eaten or sold at the market. The Christians asked: May we eat such meat?

Verse 1: That "we all have knowledge" was probably a saying from Corinth. Some Christians were proud of their knowledge. Paul answers: Knowledge alone makes people proud, but love builds up.

Verse 3: More important than our knowledge about God is that God knows and loves us.

Verses 4–6: There is only one God. Here Paul takes up the basic Jewish confession of faith, the *Shema*: *Hear, Israel* (Deuteronomy 6:4). He joins it with the confession of Jesus Christ as the one Lord.

Caring for the weak VERSES 7–13

7 But not everyone has this knowledge.
Some are still used to idols until now.
So they eat the meat
as something
sacrificed to an idol.
And their conscience,
being weak,
is made unclean.
8 Food will not bring us closer to God.
If we don't eat,
we are not worse off.
And if we eat,
we are not better off.
9 But be careful
that this freedom of yours
doesn't become a stumbling block to the weak.
10 For if someone sees you,
who have knowledge,
sitting at a meal in an idol's temple,
won't his conscience,
if he is weak,
be encouraged
to eat things sacrificed to idols?
11 And through your knowledge
the weak one is ruined,
the brother
for whom Christ died.
12 When you sin against the brothers in this way
and wound their weak conscience,
you sin against Christ.
13 So,
if food causes my brother to stumble,
I will never eat meat again,
so that I don't cause my brother to stumble.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Conscience means: the inner voice that tells us what is right and wrong.

Stumbling block means: something that makes someone fall, here: fall away from faith.

Verse 7: Some Christians had worshiped idols themselves before. When they ate sacrificed meat, they felt pulled back into their old life. Their conscience troubled them.

Verses 9–12: Paul says: Even if you know that idols are nothing, you should care for others. Your freedom must not harm others.

Verse 13: Paul is ready to give up something that he is allowed to do, for the sake of others. Love is more important than your own rights.

For today: If you know, for example, that a friend is struggling with alcohol or gambling, out of love you give it up when you are with them.

1 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 9

Becoming all things to all people

The rights of an apostle VERSES 1–14

1 Am I not free?
Am I not an apostle?
Haven't I seen Jesus Christ,
our Lord?
Aren't you my work in the Lord?
2 If I am not an apostle to others,
at least I am one to you.
For you are the seal
that I really am an apostle in the Lord.
3 To those
who want to examine me,
I answer like this:
4 Don't we have the right
to eat and to drink?
5 Don't we have the right
to take along a wife who is a believer,
as the rest of the apostles do,
and the brothers of the Lord,
and Cephas?
6 Or are Barnabas and I the only ones
who have no right
to stop working for a living?
7 What soldier ever serves at his own expense?
Who plants a vineyard
and doesn't eat of its fruit?
Or who tends a flock
and doesn't drink from the flock's milk?
8 Do I say these things only in a human way?
Or doesn't the law also say the same thing?
9 For it is written in the law of Moses:
"You shall not muzzle an ox
while it treads out the grain."
Is it for the oxen that God cares?
10 Or doesn't he surely say it for our sake?
Yes, it was written for our sake.
For he who plows
should plow in hope.
And he who threshes
should thresh in the hope
of getting his share.
11 If we sowed spiritual things among you,
is it too much
if we reap material things from you?
12 If others have this right over you,
don't we have it even more?
But we didn't use this right.
Instead we put up with everything,
so that we cause no hindrance
to the Good News of Christ.
13 Don't you know
that those
who serve in the temple
eat from the things
of the temple?
And that those
who serve at the altar
get their share from the altar?
14 In the same way the Lord commanded
that those
who proclaim the Good News
should live from the Good News.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Seal means: a stamp that proves something is real.

Muzzle means: to tie an animal's mouth shut.

Verse 1: Some in Corinth doubted whether Paul was a real apostle. Paul says: I have seen the risen Jesus (Acts 9).

Verse 5: The other apostles, the brothers of Jesus and Peter ("Cephas") were married. Their wives traveled with them.

Verse 5: "The brothers of the Lord": Christians understand this in different ways: as Jesus' own brothers, as half-brothers or as close relatives.

Verse 9 quotes Deuteronomy 25:4. An ox that works may also eat. Paul applies this to people.

Verse 14 recalls a word of Jesus (Luke 10:7).

Verse 12: Paul had the right to be supported by the church. But he gave it up. No one should think that he preached only for money.

Paul gives up his rights freely VERSES 15–23

15 But I have used none of these things.
And I don't write this
so that it will be done for me now.
For I would rather die
than let anyone take away my reason to boast.
16 For if I preach the Good News,
I have nothing
to boast about.
For I must do it.
How terrible it will be for me
if I don't preach the Good News!
17 For if I do this of my own will,
I have a reward.
But if not of my own will,
I have a task as a steward entrusted to me.
18 What then is my reward?
That I present the Good News of Christ
without charge,
so that I don't misuse my right
in the Good News.
19 For though I was free from all,
I made myself a slave to all,
so that I might win as many as possible.
20 To the Jews I became as a Jew,
so that I might win Jews.

To those
who are under the law,
I became as one under the law,
so that I might win those
who are under the law.
21 To those
who are without law,
I became as one without law,
though I am not without law toward God,
but under the law of Christ,
so that I might win those
who are without law.
22 To the weak I became as weak,
so that I might win the weak.
I have become all things to all people,
so that by all means I may save some.
23 I do all this for the sake of the Good News,
so that I may have a share in it myself.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: Paul feels sent by God. He simply can't help telling about Jesus.

Verse 18: Paul worked as a tentmaker and preached without charge.

Verse 20: Paul was a Jew himself. He means: When he was with Jews, he lived according to the Torah and its customs. When he was with non-Jews, he respected their way of life.

Verse 22: "All things to all people" doesn't mean giving up your convictions. It means: putting yourself in other people's shoes, going toward them and speaking their language.

For today: If you want to tell others about God, first listen and try to understand them.

Like a runner in the stadium VERSES 24–27

24 Don't you know
that in a race all the runners run,
but only one receives the prize?
Run like that,
so that you may win.
25 Everyone
who competes in the games
exercises self-control in all things.
They do it
to receive a crown that withers,
but we to receive one that never withers.
26 So I don't run aimlessly.
I fight like a boxer
who doesn't beat the air.
27 But I beat my body
and bring it under control,
so that after I have preached to others,
I myself won't be disqualified.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The famous Isthmian Games took place near Corinth, similar to the Olympic Games. The winners received a crown made of plants, which soon withered.

Verses 24–25: Paul compares life as a Christian with a race. It takes effort and endurance. But unlike in sports, everyone can reach the goal.

Verse 27: "I beat my body" is a picture from boxing. It means self-discipline. It does not mean that you should hurt yourself. If you are thinking about hurting yourself, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

1 CORINTHIANS

Chapter 10

Learning from history

An example from the wilderness VERSES 1–13

1 Brothers, I want you to know this:
Our ancestors were all under the cloud,
and all passed through the sea.
2 All were baptized into Moses
in the cloud and in the sea.
3 All ate the same spiritual food,
4 and all drank the same spiritual drink.
For they drank from a spiritual rock
that followed them.
And the rock was Christ.
5 But with most of them
God was not pleased.
For they died in the wilderness.
6 These things became examples for us,
so that we don't long for evil things
as they longed for them.
7 Don't be idolaters,
as some of them were.
As it is written:
"The people sat down
to eat and drink,
and rose up
to play."
8 Let's not commit sexual immorality,
as some of them did,
and in one day 23,000 fell.
9 Let's not test Christ,
as some of them tested him
and died by the snakes.
10 Don't grumble,
as some of them grumbled
and died by the destroyer.
11 All these things happened to them
as an example.
They were written down
to warn us.
The end of the ages has come to us.
12 So whoever thinks
that he stands firm
should be careful
that he doesn't fall.

13 No temptation has come to you
except what is common to all people.
God is faithful.
He will not allow
you to be tempted beyond what you are able.
But with the temptation he will also make the way of escape,
so that you may be able to endure it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Idolater means: someone who worships idols.

Temptation means: something that pulls you toward doing wrong.

Verses 1–4: Paul recalls Israel's exodus from Egypt (Exodus 13–17). The cloud led the people. They passed through the sea. God gave them manna to eat and water from the rock. Paul sees in this pictures of baptism and the Lord's Supper.

Verse 4: "The rock was Christ": Paul says: Christ was already with his people back then. Jewish interpreters told a story that the rock went along with the people.

Verse 7 quotes Exodus 32:6 (the golden calf). Verse 8 recalls Numbers 25:1–9. There 24,000 dead are mentioned. Paul says 23,000. Verse 9 recalls Numbers 21:4–9. Verse 10 recalls Numbers 14 and 16.

Important: Paul doesn't tell these stories to judge Israel. He speaks of "our ancestors" and says: This is a warning for us, for Christians.

Verse 13 is a great comfort: God is faithful. He makes a way of escape. No one has to go through hard times alone.

For today: If you feel overwhelmed, you may look for help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The Lord's Supper and idol sacrifices VERSES 14–22

14 So, my beloved,
flee from idolatry.
15 I speak to you as to sensible people.
Judge for yourselves
what I say.
16 The cup of blessing
which we bless,
isn't it a sharing in the blood of Christ?
The bread
which we break,
isn't it a sharing in the body of Christ?
17 Because there is one loaf of bread,
we,
who are many,
are one body.
For we all share in the one loaf of bread.
18 Look at the people of Israel:
Don't those
who eat the sacrifices
share in the altar?
19 What am I saying then?
That a thing sacrificed to idols is anything?
Or that an idol is anything?
20 But I say:
What the Gentiles sacrifice,
they sacrifice to demons
and not to God.
And I don't want
you to have fellowship with demons.
21 You can't drink the cup of the Lord
and the cup of demons at the same time.
You can't share in the table of the Lord
and in the table of demons at the same time.
22 Or do we want to make the Lord jealous?
Are we stronger than he is?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 16–17: This is one of the oldest texts about the Lord's Supper. At the Lord's Supper, Christians share in Christ and with one another. One loaf of bread, one body: All belong together.

The churches understand the Lord's Supper (the Eucharist) in different ways: Catholic and Orthodox Christians believe that bread and wine become the body and blood of Christ. Lutheran Christians believe that Christ is truly present in, with and under bread and wine. Reformed Christians stress the spiritual presence of Christ. All churches say: Christ himself invites.

Verses 20–21: Whoever belongs to Christ should not at the same time take part in pagan sacrifice feasts.

Important: This text is not a judgment on people of other religions today. Paul is speaking about the sacrifice cults of his time in Corinth.

Everything for the glory of God VERSES 23–33

23 "All things are lawful for me,"
but not all things are helpful.
"All things are lawful for me,"
but not all things build up.
24 No one should seek only his own good,
but each one his neighbor's good.
25 Whatever is sold in the meat market,
eat it,
without asking questions for the sake of conscience.
26 For "the earth is the Lord's,
and its fullness."
27 If one of those who don't believe
invites you to a meal,
and you want to go,
eat whatever is set before you,
without asking questions for the sake of conscience.
28 But if anyone says to you,
"This was offered to idols,"
don't eat it,
for the sake of the one
who told you,
and for the sake of conscience.
For "the earth is the Lord's,
with all its fullness."
29 I mean not your own conscience,
but the other person's conscience.
For why should my freedom
be judged by someone else's conscience?
30 If I eat with thankfulness,
why am I blamed
for something
I give thanks for?
31 So whether you eat or drink,
or whatever you do:
Do all to the glory of God.

32 Give no cause for stumbling,
whether to Jews,
or to Greeks,
or to the church of God,
33 just as I also try to please everyone in all things.
I don't seek my own advantage,
but the advantage of the many,
so that they may be saved.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 25–27: Christians may freely eat what is sold at the market or what hosts offer them. Everything comes from God.

Verses 26 and 28 quote Psalm 24:1. The words at the end of verse 28 are missing in many old manuscripts. The WEB has them.

Verses 28–29: But if someone points it out on purpose, you should give it up out of respect for that person's conscience.

Verse 31: "Do all to the glory of God": Everyday life too, eating and drinking, can be a way of worshiping God.

Verse 32: Christians should not make anyone stumble, neither Jews nor people of other backgrounds nor their own church.

1 CORINTHIANS

Chapter 11

Worship and the Lord's Supper

Head coverings in worship VERSES 1–16

1 Follow my example,
just as I follow the example of Christ.
2 Brothers, I praise you,
because you remember me in everything.
And you hold on to the traditions that I passed on to you.
3 But I want you to know this:
Christ is the head of every man.
The man is the head of the woman.
And God is the head of Christ.
4 Any man who prays or prophesies with his head covered
dishonors his head.
To prophesy means: to speak a message from God.
5 But any woman who prays or prophesies with her head uncovered
dishonors her head.
It is the same as if her head were shaved.
6 If a woman does not cover her head,
she should also cut her hair off.
But it is shameful for a woman to cut her hair off or to shave her head.
So she should cover her head.
7 A man should not cover his head,
because he is the image and glory of God.
But the woman is the glory of the man.
8 Man did not come from woman.
Woman came from man.
9 And man was not created for the woman.
Woman was created for the man.
10 That is why the woman should have authority over her own head,
because of the angels.
11 But in the Lord, the woman does not exist without the man,
and the man does not exist without the woman.
12 Woman came from man.
In the same way, a man is born from a woman.
But everything comes from God.
13 Judge for yourselves:
Is it fitting for a woman to pray to God without a veil?
14 Doesn't nature itself teach you
that long hair is a dishonor for a man?
15 But if a woman has long hair, it is a glory to her.
Her hair is given to her as a covering.
16 But someone may want to argue about this.
Then I say: We have no such custom,
and neither do God's churches.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: First of all, it is important: Women in Corinth prayed and prophesied out loud in worship. Paul takes this for granted and finds it right.

Verses 3–15: In those days respectable women in public often wore a head covering or pinned up their hair. Paul wants the church not to give offense. He gives reasons from the creation story (Genesis 2) and from the customs of his time.

Verse 3: "Head" can mean ruler over someone, but also origin or source. Interpreters understand it differently.

Verse 10: "Because of the angels": What Paul means by this is unclear. The WEB says: The woman ought to have "authority over her own head."

Verses 11–12: Paul stresses: In the Lord, man and woman depend on each other. Both come from God.

Today: Most churches see the head covering as a custom of that time. Some Christian women still wear one in worship today. Other churches stress the equal dignity of man and woman (Galatians 3:28). What is important: Man and woman have the same dignity before God.

Wrongs at the Lord's Supper VERSES 17–22

17 Now I give you this instruction.
And here I do not praise you.
When you meet, it does more harm than good.
18 First of all, I hear that there are divisions among you
when you come together as a church.
And I partly believe it.
19 There must be groups among you,
so that it becomes clear which of you God approves.
20 So when you meet,
it is not the Lord's Supper that you eat.
21 When you eat, each person eats his own supper first.
One person stays hungry,
and another gets drunk.

22 Don't you have houses where you can eat and drink?
Or do you despise God's church?
Do you want to shame the people who do not have enough?
What should I say to you?
Should I praise you?
No, in this I do not praise you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In those days Christians celebrated the Lord's Supper as a shared meal in a home. The rich came earlier because they didn't have to work. They were already eating before the poor and the slaves came after their work. So nothing was left for the poor.

Paul says: That is not the Lord's Supper. Whoever shames the poor despises God's church.

For today: With God there are no first-class and second-class people. A church should make sure that everyone belongs, including the poor.

The Lord's Supper VERSES 23–34

23 I received from the Lord what I also passed on to you:
On the night Jesus was betrayed,
the Lord Jesus took bread.
24 He gave thanks.
Then he broke it and said,
"Take, eat.
This is my body,
which is broken for you.
Do this in memory of me."
25 In the same way, he also took the cup after supper and said,
"This cup is the new covenant in my blood.
Do this, as often as you drink, in memory of me."
A covenant is a binding promise between God and people.
26 Every time you eat this bread and drink this cup,
you proclaim the Lord's death until he comes.
That means: you tell everyone about it.
27 So anyone who eats this bread or drinks the Lord's cup in a way unworthy of the Lord
will be guilty of the body and the blood of the Lord.
28 Each person should test himself first.
Then he may eat the bread and drink from the cup.
29 Someone may eat and drink in an unworthy way,
if he doesn't discern the Lord's body.
To discern means: to recognize.
Then he eats and drinks judgment on himself.
30 That is why many of you are weak and sick,
and quite a few have died.
31 If we tested ourselves,
we would not be judged.
32 But when the Lord judges us,
he corrects us.
So we will not be condemned with the world.
33 So, my brothers,
when you come together to eat,
wait for one another.
34 If anyone is hungry,
he should eat at home.
Then your meeting will not bring judgment on you.
I will put the other things in order when I come.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 23–25: This is the oldest written report about the Lord's Supper, even older than the Gospels. These words are still spoken at every Lord's Supper today, in all churches. (Compare Mark 14:22–25; Matthew 26:26–29; Luke 22:19–20.)

Verse 24: The WEB says "broken for you." Some old manuscripts only say *for you*.

Verse 26: At the Lord's Supper, Christians remember the death of Jesus and wait for him to come again.

Verses 27–29: "In an unworthy way" here mainly means: the way it was happening in Corinth, without care for the poor. To "discern the Lord's body" probably also means: to respect the church as the body of Christ (compare 10:17).

Important: No one has to be perfect to come to the Lord's Supper. Especially people who know their weakness are invited.

Verse 30: Paul sees illnesses in Corinth as a result of these wrongs. That doesn't mean that illness in general is a punishment from God. Jesus himself rejected that idea (John 9:2–3).

1 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 12

Many gifts, one body

One Spirit, many gifts VERSES 1–11

1 Brothers, now I will write about spiritual gifts.
I want you to understand them.
2 You know that you were once heathen.
Heathen are people who worship many gods.
Back then, you were led away to idols that cannot speak.
You let yourselves be led in any direction.
3 So I want you to know this:
No one who speaks by God's Spirit says, "Jesus is cursed."
And no one can say, "Jesus is Lord,"
unless the Holy Spirit helps him.
4 There are different kinds of gifts,
but there is one and the same Spirit.
5 There are different kinds of service,
and there is one and the same Lord.
6 There are different ways in which God works,
but it is the same God who does all things in all people.
7 Each person is given a way to show the Spirit,
for the good of all.
8 Through the Spirit, one person is given words of wisdom.
The same Spirit gives another person words of knowledge.
9 The same Spirit gives another person faith.
The same Spirit gives another person gifts of healing.

10 Another person can work miracles.
Another can prophesy.
Another can tell which spirits are from God and which are not.
Another can speak different kinds of languages.
Another can explain what those languages mean.
11 The one and the same Spirit does all these things.
He gives gifts to each person,
just as he wants.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: The Holy Spirit leads people to confess Jesus as Lord. Whoever does that has the Spirit, even without special miraculous gifts.

Verses 4–6: Here Spirit, Lord (Jesus) and God are named together. Christians see in this an early hint of the triune God.

Verse 7: Every person in the church has a gift. The gifts are not there for yourself, but "for the good of all."

Verse 10: "Different kinds of languages": This means *speaking in tongues*, praying in sounds that others don't understand. This gift was very popular in Corinth. Paul writes about it in detail in chapter 14.

Verse 9: "Gifts of healing": God can heal. But whoever stays ill is not less faithful. Medical help is also a gift from God.

One body, many parts VERSES 12–31

12 The body is one,
but it has many parts.
All the parts of the body are many,
but together they are one body.
It is the same with Christ.
13 We were all baptized by one Spirit into one body,
whether we are Jews or Greeks,
whether we are slaves or free.
And we were all given the one Spirit to drink.
14 The body is not made of one part,
but of many parts.
15 The foot might say,
"I am not a hand, so I am not part of the body."
But it is still part of the body.
16 The ear might say,
"I am not an eye, so I am not part of the body."
But it is still part of the body.
17 If the whole body were an eye,
how could it hear?
If the whole body were an ear,
how could it smell?
18 But God has put each part in the body,
just as he wanted.
19 If all were only one part,
where would the body be?
20 But there are many parts,
and only one body.
21 The eye cannot say to the hand,
"I have no need for you."
And the head cannot say to the feet,
"I have no need for you."
22 No, it is just the other way around.
The parts of the body that seem weaker are necessary.
23 We give more honor to the parts of the body
that we think are less honorable.
And we cover the parts that we do not show
with special care.
24 The parts that we show do not need this.
But God put the body together.
He gave more honor to the parts that lacked it.
25 So there should be no division in the body.
All the parts should care for one another in the same way.
26 When one member suffers, all the members suffer with it.
When one member is honored, all the members rejoice with it.
A member here means: a part of the body.
27 You are the body of Christ.
And each one of you is a part of it.
28 God has put some people in the church:
first apostles,
second prophets,
third teachers,
then people who work miracles,
then gifts of healing,
helping others,
leading,
and different kinds of languages.
29 Are all apostles?
Are all prophets?
Are all teachers?
Do all work miracles?
30 Do all have gifts of healing?
Do all speak in different languages?
Do all explain what they mean?
31 But eagerly desire the best gifts.
And now I will show you a most excellent way.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 12–27: The picture of the body was well known at that time. Paul uses it like this: The church is like a body. Every part is important, and all need one another.

Verse 13: In the church, differences of background and social position no longer count: Jews and Greeks, slaves and free people belong to the one body.

Verses 15–16: No one should think that they are not important.

Verses 21–22: And no one should say to another: "I have no need for you." Especially those who seem weak are needed.

For today: People with disabilities, old, sick and poor people belong as a matter of course. A church in which they are missing is not complete.

Verse 26: "When one member suffers, all the members suffer with it." Compassion is part of what the church is.

Verse 31: The "most excellent way" is love. The next chapter is about that.

1 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 13

The Song of Love

Without love everything is nothing VERSES 1–3

1 I may speak in the languages of people and of angels.
But if I don't have love,
I am only a noisy piece of brass
or a clanging cymbal.
Brass is a metal instrument that makes a loud sound.
A cymbal is a round metal plate that is struck to make a loud sound.
2 I may have the gift of prophecy.
I may know all mysteries and have all knowledge.
I may have so much faith that I can move mountains.
But if I don't have love,
I am nothing.
3 I may give away everything I own to feed the poor.
I may even give my body to be burned.
But if I don't have love,
it does me no good at all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In chapter 12 Paul wrote about the gifts of the Spirit. Now he says: The greatest gifts are worthless without love.

Verse 1: "Brass" and "cymbal" were loud instruments that were also used at pagan festivals. A lot of noise, but nothing behind it.

Verse 3: The WEB says "to be burned." Some old manuscripts say instead: *so that I may boast*.

What love is VERSES 4–7

4 Love is patient.
Love is kind.
Love is not jealous.
Love does not brag.
It is not proud.
5 It is not rude.
It does not insist on its own way.
It does not get angry easily.
It does not keep a record of wrongs.
6 It is not happy about what is wrong.
It is happy with the truth.
7 It bears all things.
It believes all things.
It hopes all things.
It endures all things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Paul doesn't describe love as a feeling, but by what it does and what it doesn't do.

Many Christians read these verses and think of Jesus: That is how he lived.

This text is read very often at weddings. But Paul first wrote it for a church that was full of quarrels.

Verse 6: Love is not happy about what is wrong. It stands on the side of the truth.

Important about verse 7: "It endures all things" doesn't mean that you have to put up with violence, abuse or humiliation. Love protects and stands up against wrong (verse 6). If you experience violence, you may protect yourself and get help. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Love remains VERSES 8–13

8 Love never fails.
But prophecies will come to an end.
The different languages will stop.
Knowledge will come to an end.
9 We know only in part.
And we prophesy only in part.
10 But when what is complete comes,
what is partial will come to an end.
11 When I was a child,
I spoke like a child.
I felt like a child.
I thought like a child.
Now that I have become a man,
I have put childish things away.
12 Now we see only a dim picture in a mirror.
But then we will see face to face.
Now I know only in part.
But then I will know fully,
even as I was also fully known.
13 So now these three remain:
faith, hope and love.
The greatest of these is love.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 8–10: All the gifts are only for this time. When God's Kingdom is complete, they will no longer be needed. But love remains forever.

Verse 12: Mirrors at that time were made of polished metal. You could only see yourself in them unclearly. That is how our knowledge of God is now: incomplete. One day we will see God fully.

Verse 12: "Even as I was also fully known": God already knows us completely now, and he loves us.

Verse 13: Faith, hope and love belong together. But love is the greatest. For God himself is love (1 John 4:8).

For today: No knowledge, no achievement and no piety can replace love.

1 CORINTHIANS

Chapter 14

Speaking clearly in worship

Prophecy and other languages VERSES 1–5

1 Strive for love!
Eagerly desire spiritual gifts,
but most of all
that you may prophesy.

2 For he who speaks in another language
speaks not to people,
but to God.
For no one understands him.
In the Spirit he speaks mysteries.
3 But he who prophesies
speaks to people.
He builds them up,
encourages them
and comforts them.
4 He who speaks in another language
builds up himself.
But he who prophesies
builds up the church.
5 I would like
all of you to speak in other languages,
but even more
that you would prophesy.
For he who prophesies
is greater than he
who speaks in other languages,
unless he also interprets,
so that the church may be built up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Speaking in another language" (often called *speaking in tongues*) was very popular in Corinth. People prayed in sounds that others didn't understand.

"Prophesy" here means: speaking clearly on God's behalf, so that others are built up, encouraged and comforted (verse 3).

Paul doesn't forbid speaking in tongues. But in worship it is more important to him that everyone understands what is said.

What you don't understand doesn't help VERSES 6–19

6 Brothers,
if I came to you
speaking in other languages,
what good would I do you
unless I also spoke to you
with a revelation,
or with knowledge,
or with prophecy,
or with teaching?
7 Even lifeless things
that make a sound,
like a flute or a harp:
If they don't give clear notes,
how would anyone know
what is played on the flute or harp?
8 And if the trumpet gives an uncertain sound,
who will prepare himself for battle?
9 It is the same with you:
Unless you speak words with your tongue that are easy
to understand,
how will anyone know
what is said?
You would be speaking into the air.
10 There may be very many languages in the world,
and none of them is without meaning.
11 But if I don't know the meaning of a language,
I will be a foreigner
to the one
who speaks it.
And the one who speaks it
will be a foreigner to me.
12 It is the same with you.
Since you are so eager for spiritual gifts,
seek to be rich
in what builds up the church.
13 So let him
who speaks in another language
pray
that he may interpret.
14 For if I pray in another language,
my spirit prays,
but my understanding bears no fruit.
15 What should I do then?
I will pray with the spirit,
and I will pray with the understanding also.
I will sing with the spirit,
and I will sing with the understanding also.
16 Otherwise, if you only praise with the spirit,
how can someone
who doesn't understand
say the "Amen" to your giving of thanks?
He doesn't know
what you are saying.
17 You certainly give thanks well,
but the other person is not built up.
18 I thank my God:
I speak in other languages more than all of you.
19 But in the church I would rather speak five words
with my understanding,
so that I teach others too,
than 10,000 words in another language.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Interpret means: to explain what something means.

Verses 7–11: Paul uses pictures: An instrument that doesn't give clear notes is no use. A trumpet must sound clearly, or no one knows what to do.

Verse 15: Faith needs heart and mind.

Verse 16: "Amen" means *So it is* or *So be it*. You can only say Amen if you understand what was prayed.

For today: Worship should be understandable for everyone, including guests and people who can't read or hear well. That is why plain language is important too.

A sign for outsiders VERSES 20–25

20 Brothers,
don't be children in your thinking.
Be like babies
when it comes to evil.
But in your thinking be mature.
21 In the law it is written:
"By people of strange languages
and by the lips of strangers
I will speak to this people.
They won't even listen to me that way,
says the Lord."
22 So other languages are a sign,
not for those
who believe,

but for unbelievers.
But prophecy is a sign,
not for unbelievers,
but for those
who believe.
23 So if the whole church comes together
and all speak in other languages,
and outsiders or unbelievers come in,
won't they say
that you are crazy?
24 But if all prophesy,
and an unbeliever or outsider comes in,
he is convinced of his sin by all
and examined by all.
25 The secrets of his heart
are revealed.
Then he will fall down on his face,
worship God
and declare:
"God is truly among you!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21 takes up Isaiah 28:11–12. "The law" here means the whole Holy Scripture of Israel.

Verses 23–25: Paul is thinking of guests in worship. If everyone talks at once in sounds that can't be understood, it seems strange to outsiders. But if they hear words they can understand, God can touch their heart.

Order in worship VERSES 26–40

26 What does this mean then, brothers?
When you come together,
each one has something to give:
a psalm,
a teaching,
a revelation,
another language
or an interpretation.
Let everything be done
to build each other up.
27 If anyone speaks in another language,
let there be two,
or at the most three,
one after the other.
And let one interpret.
28 But if there is no interpreter,
let him keep silent in the church.
Let him speak to himself and to God.
29 Let two or three of the prophets speak,
and let the others weigh what is said.
30 But if a revelation comes to another
who is sitting there,
let the first one keep silent.
31 For you can all prophesy one by one,
so that all may learn
and all may be encouraged.
32 The spirits of the prophets
are under the control of the prophets.
33 For God is not a God of confusion
but of peace,
as in all the churches of the saints.
34 Let the wives be quiet in the churches.
For they are not permitted to talk,
except in submission,
as the law also says,
35 if they want to learn anything.
"Let them ask their own husbands at home,
for it is shameful for a wife
to be talking in the church."
36 What!?
Was it from you that the word of God went out?
Or did it come only to you?
37 If anyone thinks
he is a prophet or spiritual,
let him recognize
that the things
I write to you
are a command of the Lord.
38 But if anyone doesn't recognize this,
let him not recognize it.
39 So, brothers:
Eagerly desire
to prophesy,
and don't forbid
speaking in other languages.
40 Let all things be done decently and in order.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 26: In worship back then, everyone could contribute something. The goal was always: building one another up.

Verse 33: "God is not a God of confusion but of peace." That is why worship should be orderly.

Verses 34–35 are among the most debated verses of the Bible. It is important to know:

In chapter 11:5 Paul takes it for granted that women pray and prophesy in worship. That doesn't fit with a complete command to be silent.

The WEB puts part of verse 35 in quotation marks. Some interpreters think: Paul is quoting an opinion from Corinth here and disagrees with it in verse 36 ("What!?").

In some old manuscripts, verses 34–35 are found in another place, after verse 40. That is why some scholars think they were added later.

Other interpreters think: Paul only wanted to prevent disturbances in worship, such as loud questions in between.

Some churches still understand these verses as a rule that women should not preach or hold an office. Many other churches have women pastors and preachers.

Important: These verses give no one the right to look down on women or to deny them their dignity. Man and woman are of equal worth before God.

Verses 39–40: Paul ends in a reconciling way: Prophecy is welcome, speaking in tongues is not forbidden, but everything should be done in order.

1 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 15

Christ is risen

The Good News of the resurrection VERSES 1–11

1 Brothers,
I remind you of the Good News
which I preached to you.
You received it,
and you stand firm in it.
2 Through it you are also saved,
if you hold firmly to the word
which I preached to you.
Otherwise you believed in vain.
3 For first of all I passed on to you
what I also received:
Christ died for our sins
according to the Scriptures.
4 He was buried.
He was raised on the third day
according to the Scriptures.
5 He appeared to Cephas,
then to the Twelve.
6 Then he appeared to over 500 brothers at once.
Most of them are still alive,
but some have fallen asleep.
7 Then he appeared to James,
then to all the apostles.
8 Last of all
he appeared to me also,
as to one born at the wrong time.
9 For I am the least of the apostles.
I am not worthy
to be called an apostle,
because I persecuted the church of God.
10 But by the grace of God I am
what I am.
And his grace,
which was given to me,
was not in vain.
I worked harder than all of them,
yet not I,
but the grace of God
which was with me.
11 Whether it is I or they:
This is what we preach,
and this is what you believed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Resurrection means: rising from the dead to new life.

Verses 3–5 are one of the oldest confessions of faith of the Christians. Paul himself had received it, probably only a few years after Jesus' death.

The core sentences are: Christ died, he was buried, he was raised, he appeared.

Verse 5: "Cephas" is Peter.

Verse 6: Paul says: Many witnesses are still alive. You can ask them.

Verse 7: James was a brother of Jesus and later a leader of the church in Jerusalem.

Verse 8: "As to one born at the wrong time": Paul feels like someone who became an apostle late and unexpectedly.

Verse 10: "By the grace of God I am what I am." Paul once persecuted Christians. God called him anyway.

If Christ had not been raised VERSES 12–19

12 But if it is preached
that Christ has been raised from the dead,
how can some of you say:
"There is no resurrection of the dead"?
13 If there is no resurrection of the dead,
then Christ has not been raised either.
14 But if Christ has not been raised,
then our preaching is empty,
and your faith is empty too.
15 Then we are even found to be false witnesses of God.
For we testified about God
that he raised Christ.
But he did not raise him
if it is true
that the dead are not raised.
16 For if the dead are not raised,
then Christ has not been raised either.
17 But if Christ has not been raised,
then your faith is useless.
Then you are still in your sins.
18 Then those also are lost
who have fallen asleep in Christ.
19 If we have hoped in Christ only for this life,
then we are the most pitiable of all people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In Corinth there were Christians who said: "There is no resurrection of the dead." Perhaps they thought that only the soul lives on, or that they had already received everything now.

Paul answers very clearly: The resurrection of Jesus is the center of the Christian faith. Without it, faith would be empty.

Verse 18: "Fallen asleep" is a word for having died. It sounds like hope: Whoever sleeps will wake up again.

Christ is the first VERSES 20–28

20 But now Christ has been raised from the dead.
He became the first fruit of those
who are asleep.
21 For since death came through a man,
the resurrection of the dead also came through a man.
22 For as in Adam all die,
so also in Christ all will be made alive.
23 But each in his own order:
Christ the first fruits,
then, at his coming, those
who belong to Christ.
24 Then the end comes,
when he hands over the Kingdom to God the Father,
when he has done away with all rule
and all authority and power.
25 For he must reign
until he has put all his enemies under his feet.

26 The last enemy
that will be done away with
is death.
27 For: "He put all things in subjection under his feet."
But when it says,
"All things are put in subjection,"
it is clear
that he is excepted
who put all things in subjection to him.
28 When all things have been put in subjection to him,
then the Son himself will also be subject to him
who put all things in subjection to him,
so that God may be all in all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

First fruit means: the first part of the harvest.

Verse 20: The WEB says "first fruit," the first fruit of the harvest. The first fruit is the sign that the whole harvest is coming. In the same way, the resurrection of Jesus is the sign that we will also rise.

Verses 21–22: Adam stands for the human being who dies. Christ stands for the new human being who lives.

Verse 26: "The last enemy that will be done away with is death." In the end God will defeat death too.

Verse 25 recalls Psalm 110:1. Verse 27 quotes Psalm 8:6 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 8:7).

Verse 28: "So that God may be all in all": In the end God will fill everything completely.

Why we keep going anyway VERSES 29–34

29 Otherwise, what will they do
who are baptized for the dead?
If the dead aren't raised at all,
why then are they baptized for them?
30 And why are we in danger every hour?
31 I assure you,
as surely as I can boast about you in Christ Jesus
our Lord:
I die daily.
32 If I fought with wild animals at Ephesus
only for human reasons,
what does it profit me?
If the dead are not raised,
then:
"Let's eat and drink,
for tomorrow we die."
33 Don't be deceived!
"Bad company corrupts good morals."
34 Wake up and live rightly, and don't sin.
For some have no knowledge of God.
I say this
to make you ashamed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 29: "Baptized for the dead": What this means is no longer known for certain today. There are more than 40 different explanations. Paul only mentions the custom, without praising it or blaming it.

Verse 31: "I die daily": Paul is constantly in danger of his life.

Verse 32: "Fought with wild animals" is perhaps a picture for fierce enemies in Ephesus. The quotation comes from Isaiah 22:13.

Verse 33 is a well-known saying of a Greek poet (Menander).

How will the dead be raised? VERSES 35–49

35 But someone will ask:
"How are the dead raised?
And with what kind of body do they come?"
36 You foolish one!
What you sow
is not made alive
unless it dies first.
37 And what you sow
is not the body
that will grow later,
but a bare grain,
maybe of wheat or of some other kind.
38 But God gives it a body
as he wants,
and to each seed a body of its own.
39 Not all flesh is the same.
There is one flesh of people,
another flesh of animals,
another of fish,
and another of birds.
40 There are heavenly bodies and earthly bodies.
But the glory of the heavenly is different
from that of the earthly.
41 The sun has its own glory,
the moon has another glory,
and the stars have yet another glory.
For one star differs from another star in glory.
42 So also is the resurrection of the dead.
What is sown
is perishable.
What is raised
is imperishable.
43 What is sown
is without honor.
What is raised
is full of glory.
What is sown
is weak.
What is raised
is full of power.
44 A natural body is sown.
A spiritual body is raised.
If there is a natural body,
there is also a spiritual body.
45 So also it is written:
"The first man Adam
became a living soul."
The last Adam became a spirit
who gives life.
46 But the spiritual is not first,
but the natural,
then the spiritual.
47 The first man is of the earth,
made of dust.
The second man is the Lord from heaven.
48 As the one made of dust is,
so are those
who are made of dust.

And as the heavenly one is,
so are those who are heavenly.
49 As we have carried the image of the one
made of dust,
so let's also bear the image of the heavenly one.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Perishable means: something that decays and comes to an end.

Imperishable means: something that never decays.

Verses 36–38: Paul compares the resurrection with a seed. You put a small grain into the ground. A completely new plant grows from it. In the same way our body will be changed.

Verses 42–44: The new body is imperishable, full of power and glory. We cannot know exactly what it will look like.

Verse 45 quotes Genesis 2:7. The WEB says "living soul" there, a living being. "The last Adam" means Christ.

Verse 49: The WEB says "let's also bear." Many old manuscripts say: *we will also bear*.

For today: People with illness or disability may hope too: God will make everything new.

Death is defeated VERSES 50–58

50 But I say this, brothers:
Flesh and blood can't inherit God's Kingdom.
And the perishable doesn't inherit the imperishable.
51 Listen,
I tell you a mystery:
We will not all sleep,
but we will all be changed,
52 suddenly,
in the twinkling of an eye,
at the last trumpet.
For the trumpet will sound,
and the dead will be raised imperishable,
and we will be changed.
53 For this perishable body
must become imperishable,
and this mortal body
must put on immortality.
54 But when this perishable body
has become imperishable,
and this mortal body
has put on immortality,
then what is written will happen:
"Death is swallowed up in victory."
55 "Death, where is your sting?
Hades, where is your victory?"
56 The sting of death is sin.
And the power of sin is the law.
57 But thanks be to God,
who gives us the victory
through our Lord Jesus Christ.
58 So, my beloved brothers:
Be steadfast and don't let anything move you.
Always do more and more in the Lord's work.
For you know:
Your work is not in vain in the Lord.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Mortal means: something that must die.

Immortality means: never dying.

Verses 51–52: Paul expects that Jesus will come again soon. Then the dead will rise, and the living will be changed.

Verse 54 takes up Isaiah 25:8. Verse 55 takes up Hosea 13:14.

Verse 55: The WEB says "Hades." That is the Greek word for the realm of the dead.

Verse 56: Sin gives death its power. Paul explains this in more detail in the letter to the Romans (Romans 7).

Verses 55–57: These verses are often read at funerals. They say: Death does not have the last word. Through Jesus it has been defeated.

Verse 58: Nothing we do in faith and love is in vain.

For today: If you are grieving for someone, you may hope. Help in grief is available from grief support groups and pastors. In a crisis: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

1 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 16

Plans and greetings

The collection for Jerusalem VERSES 1–4

1 Now about the collection for God's holy people.
A collection is money that is gathered for a good purpose.
Do what I told the churches in Galatia to do.
2 On the first day of every week,
each of you should put some money aside,
as much as he is able.
Then no collections will have to be made when I come.
3 When I arrive, I will send the people you choose.
I will give them letters.
They will take your gift to Jerusalem.
4 If it seems right for me to go too,
they will go with me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The church in Jerusalem was poor. Paul collected money for it in many churches (compare Romans 15:25–27).

Verse 2: "On the first day of every week": This means Sunday, the day of Jesus' resurrection. Even then Christians met on this day.

Everyone should give "as much as he is able." No one should be overburdened.

Verse 3: Paul is honest with money. Representatives of the church are to bring it to Jerusalem themselves.

Travel plans VERSES 5–12

5 I will come to you after I have traveled through Macedonia.
I am going to travel through Macedonia.

6 Perhaps I will stay with you for a while,
or even spend the winter with you.
Then you can help me on my journey,
wherever I go next.
7 This time I do not want to see you only in passing.
I hope to stay with you for a while,
if the Lord allows it.
8 But I will stay in Ephesus until Pentecost.
9 A great and effective door has opened to me.
And there are many people against me.
10 Timothy may come to you.
If he does, make sure that he has nothing to fear while he is with you.
He is doing the Lord's work, just as I am.
11 So no one should look down on him.
Help him on his way in peace,
so that he can come back to me.
I am waiting for him and the brothers.
12 Now about our brother Apollos:
I strongly urged him to visit you with the brothers.
But he did not want to come now at all.
He will come when he has the chance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Paul writes this letter in Ephesus, a large city in what is now Turkey. At that time "Pentecost" was the Jewish Feast of Weeks, 50 days after Passover.

Verse 9: "A great and effective door has opened to me." That means: There is a good opportunity to proclaim the Good News.

Verses 10–11: Timothy was still young. Paul asks the church to welcome him kindly.

Verse 12: Apollos was very popular in Corinth (1 Corinthians 1:12). Paul and Apollos were not opponents, but co-workers.

Last words of advice VERSES 13–18

13 Stay alert!
Stand firm in the faith!
Be brave!
Be strong!
14 Let all that you do be done in love.
15 Brothers, I ask you something.
You know the family of Stephanas.
They were the first people in Achaia to believe.
And they have given themselves to serving God's holy people.
16 Follow the lead of such people,
and of everyone who works and labors hard with them.
17 I am happy that Stephanas, Fortunatus and Achaicus have come.
They have made up for what I was missing from you.
18 They have refreshed my spirit and yours.
So value people like that.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: "Let all that you do be done in love." This sums up the whole letter.

Verses 15–16: Whoever serves faithfully in the church deserves respect.

Verse 17: Stephanas, Fortunatus and Achaicus probably brought Paul the Corinthians' letter (compare 7:1).

Greetings and blessing VERSES 19–24

19 The churches of Asia send you greetings.
Aquila and Priscilla and the church that meets in their house
send you warm greetings in the Lord.
20 All the brothers send you greetings.
Greet one another with a holy kiss.
21 I, Paul, write this greeting with my own hand.
22 If anyone does not love the Lord Jesus Christ,
let him be cursed.
Come, Lord!
23 May the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ be with you.
24 My love to all of you in Christ Jesus.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: Aquila and Priscilla knew the Corinthians well. They had lived there with Paul (Acts 18:2–3).

Verse 21: Paul dictated the letter. He writes the last greeting himself, as a sign that the letter is genuine.

Verse 22: "Come, Lord!" is *Maranatha* in Aramaic. It was a prayer of the first Christians: They asked Jesus to come again soon.

Verse 22: "Let him be cursed" is a fixed formula. It leaves the judgment to God. It is no permission to curse people, shut them out or harm them.

Verse 24: After all the serious words, Paul ends with love.

Looking back: What have we read in the first letter to the Corinthians?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A church with many problems: In Corinth there were quarrels, groups, pride and questions about the right way to live as a Christian.

The message of the cross: God shows his power especially in weakness, in the crucified Christ (chapters 1 to 4).

Living with the body: The body is a temple of the Holy Spirit. Paul speaks about sexuality, marriage and staying single (chapters 5 to 7).

Freedom and care for others: Christians are free. But they should not use their freedom against those who are weaker (chapters 8 to 10).

Worship and the Lord's Supper: At the Lord's Supper everyone should belong, especially the poor (chapter 11).

Many gifts, one body: Everyone in the church is important (chapter 12). Love is greater than all gifts (chapter 13). Worship should be understandable (chapter 14).

The resurrection: Christ is risen. Death is defeated (chapter 15).

For today: "Let all that you do be done in love" (16:14).

What comes next? Next comes Paul's second letter to the Corinthians. In it Paul shares many personal things: about suffering and comfort, about weakness and God's power. A famous word from it says, in short: God's power shows itself especially in weakness (2 Corinthians 12:9).

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 47 OF 66

2 CORINTHIANS

13 CHAPTERS

2 CORINTHIANS

Chapter 1

The God of all comfort

Before we begin: The second letter to the Corinthians

Paul writes once more to the church in Corinth. After the first letter there had been new difficulties there. Some people in the church were against Paul. They doubted whether he was really an apostle.

Paul probably visited the church in between. This visit was painful. Afterwards he wrote a letter *with many tears* (2:4). Meanwhile he has received good news: The church has been reconciled again (chapter 7).

The letter was probably written around AD 55 or 56 in Macedonia. Some scholars think that several letters of Paul were put together here.

In this letter Paul shares many personal things: about fear and suffering, about comfort and hope. He shows: God's power shows itself especially in human weakness.

The second letter to the Corinthians has 13 chapters.

Greeting VERSES 1–2

1 Paul,
an apostle of Christ Jesus through the will of God,
and Timothy our brother,
write to the church of God which is at Corinth,
with all the saints in the whole of Achaia.

2 Grace to you and peace
from God our Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Achaia was the Roman province in the south of Greece. Corinth was its capital.

Timothy was a close co-worker of Paul.

God comforts us VERSES 3–11

3 Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ,
the Father of mercies
and God of all comfort.

4 He comforts us in all our trouble,
so that we may be able to comfort those
who are in any trouble,
with the comfort
with which we ourselves are comforted by God.

5 For as the sufferings of Christ
overflow to us,
so our comfort also overflows through Christ.

6 But if we are in trouble,
it is for your comfort and salvation.
If we are comforted,
it is for your comfort.
This comfort helps you
to endure patiently the same sufferings
which we also suffer.

7 Our hope for you is firm.
For we know:
As you share in the sufferings,
so you also share in the comfort.

8 For we don't want you to be uninformed, brothers,
about the trouble
which happened to us in the province of Asia.
We were weighed down beyond measure,
far beyond our strength.
We even despaired of life.

9 Yes,
we had the sentence of death within ourselves.
That was so that we should not trust in ourselves,
but in God
who raises the dead.

10 He rescued us from so great a danger of death,
and he does rescue us.
We have set our hope on him
that he will also rescue us again.

11 You also help with this
by praying for us.
So many people will give thanks for us,
for the gift
given to us through the prayers of many.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 3–4: God is the "God of all comfort." Whoever has experienced comfort can comfort others.

Verses 8–9: Paul tells quite openly: He despaired and thought he would die. We don't know exactly what happened in the province of Asia (in what is now Turkey).

For today: People with strong faith can despair too. That is no shame. If you don't know how to go on, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 11: Praying for one another connects people.

Paul explains his travel plans VERSES 12–24

12 For this is what we boast about:
the testimony of our conscience.
We have lived in the world,
and especially toward you,
in holiness and sincerity
that come from God,
not in human wisdom,
but in the grace of God.

13 For we write nothing else to you
than what you read
and also understand.
And I hope
you will understand fully to the end,

14 as you have already understood us in part:
that we are your reason to boast,
as you also are ours,
in the day of our Lord Jesus.

15 In this confidence I wanted to come to you first,
so that you might have a second blessing.
16 I wanted to pass through your city into Macedonia
and come back to you from Macedonia.
Then you would send me on my journey to Judea.
17 When I planned this,
was I fickle?
Or do I plan in a human way,
so that with me it is "Yes, yes"
and at the same time "No, no"?
18 But as God is faithful:
Our word to you was not "Yes and no."
19 For the Son of God,
Jesus Christ,
whom we preached among you,
I, Silvanus and Timothy,
was not "Yes and no."
But in him is "Yes."
20 For however many promises of God there are,
in him is the "Yes."
That is why through him we also say the "Amen,"
to the glory of God through us.
21 It is God
who makes us firm in Christ together with you.
And he has anointed us.
22 He also sealed us
and gave us the Spirit as a down payment in our hearts.
23 But I call on God as my witness,
on my life:
It was to spare you
that I didn't come to Corinth.
24 We don't want to rule over your faith,
but we are fellow workers with you for your joy.
For you stand firm in faith.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Fickle means: changing your mind all the time, unreliable.

Anointed means: chosen by God and given a task.

Verses 15–17: Paul had changed his travel plans. Some in Corinth accused him of being unreliable. Paul explains: I wanted to spare you (verse 23).

Verse 20: The "Yes" means Jesus. All of God's promises are fulfilled in Jesus. That is why Christians say "Amen." It means: So it is.

Verse 22: The WEB says "down payment." The Holy Spirit is like a first installment. He guarantees that God will keep his whole promise.

Verse 24: "We don't want to rule over your faith." Leaders in the church should not control people, but serve their joy.

2 CORINTHIANS

Chapter 2

Forgiveness and the aroma of Christ

A letter written with tears VERSES 1–4

1 But I decided for myself
that I would not come to you again in sorrow.
2 For if I make you sad,
then who will make me glad
except the one
whom I have made sad?
3 And I wrote this very thing to you for that reason.
For when I came,
I didn't want to be made sad by those
who should make me rejoice.
I am confident about all of you
that my joy is the joy of all of you.
4 For out of much trouble
and anguish of heart
I wrote to you with many tears.
I didn't want to make you sad,
but I wanted you to know
how great my love for you is.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Anguish means: great pain and worry.

Paul had visited the church once, and it was a sad visit. Afterwards he wrote a letter "with many tears." This letter has probably not survived. Some scholars think that parts of it are found in 2 Corinthians 10 to 13.

Verse 4: Paul writes strictly, but out of love. He doesn't want to destroy the relationship, but to heal it.

Forgive him VERSES 5–11

5 But if anyone has caused sorrow,
he has not caused sorrow to me,
but in part to all of you.
I don't want to say it too strongly.
6 For such a person the punishment
which the majority of you gave him
is enough.
7 So now you should rather forgive him
and comfort him,
so that he isn't swallowed up by too much sorrow.
8 So I beg you:
Show him your love.
9 For this is also why I wrote:
I wanted to test you,
whether you are obedient in all things.
10 Whomever you forgive anything,
I forgive too.
For if I have forgiven anything,
I have forgiven it for your sake,
in the presence of Christ,
11 so that Satan doesn't take advantage of us.
For we know his schemes well.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–8: Someone in Corinth had hurt Paul badly. The church punished him. Now Paul says: That is enough. Forgive him, comfort him and show him your love.

Verse 7: Paul doesn't want the person to break under his sorrow. Punishment should never lead to despair.

Verse 11: Satan wants quarrels and an unwillingness to make peace. Forgiveness spoils his plans.

For today: Forgiveness is important. But forgiveness doesn't mean that victims of violence have to live with the offender again. Safety comes first.

The aroma of Christ VERSES 12–17

12 When I came to Troas
to preach the Good News of Christ,
and a door was opened to me in the Lord,
13 I still had no rest in my spirit,
because I didn't find my brother Titus.
So I said goodbye to them
and went on to Macedonia.
14 But thanks be to God!
In Christ he always leads us in a victory parade
and through us makes known in every place
the sweet aroma of his knowledge.
15 For we are a sweet aroma of Christ to God
among those
who are being saved
and among those
who are perishing.
16 To the one we are a stench from death to death,
to the other a sweet aroma from life to life.
Who is fit for these things?
17 For we are not like so many
who sell the word of God for profit.
But we speak in Christ
with sincerity,
as from God
and in the sight of God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Aroma means: a pleasant smell.

Verses 12–13: Troas was a port city in what is now Turkey. Paul waited there for Titus, who was to bring news from Corinth. Because Titus didn't come, Paul was very restless. The story continues in chapter 7:5–7.

Verse 14: A "victory parade" was a Roman triumphal procession. Incense was often burned during it. Paul uses this picture: God leads him along, and everywhere a pleasant smell spreads: the message of Jesus.

Verse 16: The Good News has different effects: Some accept it, others reject it.

Verse 17: Paul doesn't preach for money. In those days there were traveling preachers who did business with religion.

2 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 3

Serving the new covenant

You are our letter of recommendation VERSES 1–6

1 Are we beginning again
to recommend ourselves?
Or do we need,
as some do,
letters of recommendation to you or from you?
2 You yourselves are our letter,
written in our hearts.
All people know it and read it.
3 It is clear:
You are a letter of Christ,
delivered by us.
It is written not with ink,
but with the Spirit of the living God.
It is written not on tablets of stone,
but on tablets
that are hearts of flesh.
4 We have such confidence through Christ toward God.
5 Not
that we are able by ourselves
to claim anything as coming from us.
But our ability comes from God.
6 He also made us able
to be servants of a new covenant,
not of the letter
but of the Spirit.
For the letter kills,
but the Spirit gives life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Letter of recommendation means: a letter that says someone can be trusted.

Verse 1: Other preachers came to Corinth with letters of recommendation. Paul says: I don't need any. The church itself is my letter of recommendation.

Verse 3: Here Paul takes up words of the prophets. In Jeremiah 31:31–33 God promises a new covenant in which he writes his law on people's hearts. In Ezekiel 36:26 God promises a heart of flesh instead of a heart of stone. These promises were first given to Israel.

Verse 6: "The letter kills, but the Spirit gives life": Paul doesn't mean that God's commandments are bad (compare Romans 7:12). He means: Written rules alone cannot change a person. Only God's Spirit can do that.

Important: This verse has often been wrongly used against Judaism, as if Jews only clung to a *dead letter*. That is unjust. In Judaism too, faith lives from God's Spirit and from love for God's teaching.

Greater glory VERSES 7–11

7 The service of death,
engraved in letters on stones,
already came with glory.
The people of Israel could not look at Moses' face,
because of the glory of his face,
which was passing away.
8 Won't the service of the Spirit
have much more glory?
9 For if the service of condemnation has glory,
then the service of righteousness
is even richer in glory.
Righteousness means: living right before God.

10 For what was made glorious
has in this respect no glory at all,
compared with the glory
that surpasses everything.
11 For if what passes away
came with glory,
then what remains
is much more glorious.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Condemnation means: being judged guilty.

Verse 7: Paul recalls Exodus 34:29–35. When Moses came down from Mount Sinai, his face shone because he had talked with God.

Verses 7–11: Paul compares: The gift of the Torah at Sinai was already full of glory. Paul says this clearly. But in Christ he sees an even greater glory.

"The service of death" and "the service of condemnation" are hard words. Paul means: The commandment shows people their guilt, but it alone cannot save them. He does not say that the Torah is worthless.

The veil is taken away VERSES 12–18

12 Because we have such a hope,
we speak with great boldness.
13 We are not like Moses,
who put a veil over his face,
so that the people of Israel wouldn't look at the end
of what was passing away.
14 But their minds were hardened.
For until this very day the same veil remains
when the old covenant is read.
For only in Christ is it taken away.
15 Yes, to this day a veil lies on their heart
when Moses is read.
16 But whenever someone turns to the Lord,
the veil is taken away.
17 Now the Lord is the Spirit.
And where the Spirit of the Lord is,
there is freedom.
18 But we all, with unveiled face,
see the glory of the Lord as in a mirror.
And we are changed into the same image,
from glory to glory,
as it comes from the Lord,
the Spirit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Veil means: a cloth that covers the face.

Verse 13: Paul interprets the story from Exodus 34:33–35 in his own way.

Verses 14–15: Paul describes why many of his own people do not recognize Jesus as the Christ. He speaks as a Jew about his own people, with pain, not with contempt.

Very important: In church history these verses were often used against Jews. In the Middle Ages, the "Synagogue" was shown as a woman with her eyes blindfolded. Such pictures encouraged contempt and hatred. That was wrong. Paul himself says in the letter to the Romans: God has not rejected his people (Romans 11:1–2), and his gifts and his calling can never be taken back (Romans 11:29).

Verse 17: "Where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is freedom." God's Spirit sets people free.

Verse 18: Whoever looks at Jesus becomes more like him step by step.

2 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 4

A treasure in clay jars

The light of the Good News VERSES 1–6

1 So we have this ministry
because God has shown us mercy.
And we don't lose heart.
2 We have turned away from everything
that people hide out of shame.
We don't act with trickery,
and we don't twist the word of God.
Instead we make the truth plain.
In this way we recommend ourselves to every person's
conscience
in the sight of God.
3 Even if our Good News is veiled,
it is veiled among those
who are dying.
4 Among them the god of this world
has blinded the minds of the unbelieving.
So the light of the Good News
of the glory of Christ,
who is the image of God,
cannot dawn on them.
5 For we don't preach ourselves,
but Christ Jesus as Lord.
And we present ourselves as your servants
for Jesus' sake.
6 For God said:
"Light will shine out of darkness."
He has also shone in our hearts,
so that the knowledge of the glory of God
shines out in the face of Jesus Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ministry means: service for God.

Verse 2: Paul works openly and honestly. He has nothing to hide.

Verse 4: "The god of this world" means Satan, the power of evil. Paul says: When people don't understand the Good News, it is not God's fault.

Verse 5: Paul doesn't want to make himself great. He is a servant.

Verse 6 recalls the beginning of the Bible: *Let there be light* (Genesis 1:3). Just as God created light back then, he creates light in people's hearts.

Strong in weakness VERSES 7–15

7 But we have this treasure in clay jars.
So it becomes clear
that the surpassing power comes from God
and not from us.
8 We are pressed on every side,
yet not crushed.
We are puzzled,
yet not in despair.
9 We are hunted,
yet not abandoned.
We are struck down,
yet not destroyed.
10 We always carry in our body the dying of Jesus,
so that the life of Jesus
may also be seen in our body.
11 For we who live
are always handed over to death for Jesus' sake,
so that the life of Jesus
may also be seen in our mortal body.
12 So death works in us,
but life in you.
13 But we have the same spirit of faith,
as it is written:
"I believed,
and therefore I spoke."
We also believe,
and therefore we also speak.
14 For we know:
He who raised the Lord Jesus
will also raise us through Jesus
and present us together with you.
15 For all things are for your sake.
So grace will spread through more and more people
and cause even more thanks to the glory of God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: "Clay jars" were simple, cheap pots that break easily. Paul says: We human beings are weak and fragile. But in us is a precious treasure: the Good News of Jesus.

Verses 8–9: Paul describes honestly how hard his life is. But each time he says: "yet not." God doesn't let him fall.

Verse 13 quotes Psalm 116:10 (in the Greek Bible 115:1).

For today: No one has to be strong to be used by God. Especially in our weakness God's power can be seen.

What cannot be seen is eternal VERSES 16–18

16 So we don't lose heart.
Even though our outer person is wasting away,
our inner person
is renewed day by day.
17 For our light trouble,
which lasts only for a moment,
is producing for us an eternal weight of glory
that far surpasses everything.
18 For we don't look at the things
which are seen,
but at the things
which are not seen.
For the things which are seen
are temporary.
But the things which are not seen
are eternal.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: "Our outer person" is the body, which gets older and weaker. "Our inner person" is life with God, which becomes new every day.

Verse 17: Paul calls his trouble "light." That doesn't mean that suffering isn't bad. Paul suffered greatly (chapter 11). But compared with what God will give, it seems small to him.

Important: No one has to play down their suffering. Whoever suffers may lament and look for help.

Verse 18: The most important things in life often cannot be seen: love, hope, God himself.

2 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 5

Made new and reconciled

A house in heaven VERSES 1–10

1 For we know:
If our earthly house, this tent, is taken down,
we have a building from God,
a house
not made with hands,
eternal, in the heavens.
2 For in this tent we groan
and long
to be clothed with our home from heaven.
3 When we are clothed with it,
we will not be found naked.
4 For we
who are in this tent
groan and are burdened.
We don't want to be unclothed,
but to be clothed,
so that what is mortal may be swallowed up by life.
5 God has prepared us for this very thing.
He has also given us the Spirit as a down payment.
6 So we are always confident.
We know:
While we are at home in the body,
we are away from the Lord.
7 For we walk by faith,
not by sight.
8 We are confident
and would rather be away from the body
and at home with the Lord.
9 So we also make it our aim
to please him,

whether we are at home or away.
10 For we must all be revealed before the judgment seat of Christ.
Then each one will receive
what he has done in the body,
whether good or bad.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Groan means: to sigh deeply because something is hard.

Verse 1: Paul compares our body with a tent: It is only for a time. Paul was a tentmaker himself. After death God gives a solid house, a new life with him.

Verses 2–4: "To be clothed": Paul doesn't hope simply to get rid of the body, but that God will give us a new life that overcomes death.

Verse 7: "We walk by faith, not by sight." We don't see God now. But we trust him.

Verse 8: Paul longs to be with Jesus. That does not mean that anyone should end their life. At the same time Paul wants to go on living and to serve others (compare Philippians 1:21–25). If you are thinking about suicide, get help right away. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 10: Every person is responsible to God for their life.

The love of Christ drives us VERSES 11–15

11 Because we know
what the fear of the Lord means,
we try
to persuade people.
But we are known to God.
And I hope
that we are also known in your consciences.
12 We are not recommending ourselves to you again.
Instead we are giving you a reason
to be proud of us.
Then you can answer those
who boast about outward appearance
and not about
what is in the heart.
13 For if we are out of our minds,
it is for God.
And if we are of sober mind,
it is for you.
14 For the love of Christ drives us.
For we have come to this conclusion:
One died for all,
so all died.
15 He died for all,
so that those
who live
should no longer live for themselves,
but for him
who died and rose again for them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Paul's opponents boasted about outward things, for example great speeches and letters of recommendation. Paul says: What counts is the heart.

Verse 13: "Out of our minds" perhaps means special spiritual experiences. Paul says: They are a matter between me and God. For the church what counts is that I speak clearly and understandably.

Verse 14: "The love of Christ drives us": That is the driving force behind everything Paul does.

Verse 15: Whoever belongs to Christ no longer lives only for themselves.

A new creation VERSES 16–21

16 So from now on we know no one
according to the flesh.
Even though we once knew Christ according to the flesh,
we don't know him that way any more.
17 So:
If anyone is in Christ,
he is a new creation.
The old things have passed away.
Look,
all things have become new.
18 But all things are from God.
He reconciled us to himself through Jesus Christ.
And he gave us the ministry of reconciliation.
19 That is:
God was in Christ
reconciling the world to himself.
He doesn't count people's wrongs against them.
And he has entrusted us with the word of reconciliation.
20 So we are ambassadors on behalf of Christ.
God himself is pleading through us.
We beg you on behalf of Christ:
Be reconciled to God!
21 God made him
who knew no sin
to be sin for us,
so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Reconcile means: to make peace again after a quarrel.

Ambassador means: someone who speaks for a king or a country.

Verse 16: The WEB says "according to the flesh." That means: by human standards. Paul once judged Jesus only from the outside, as a crucified man. Now he sees him with the eyes of faith.

Verse 17: "A new creation": Through Christ a person can start completely new. The past no longer has to decide who they are.

Verses 18–20: Reconciliation is a key word in this chapter. It is not God who has to be reconciled. God himself takes the first step and reconciles the world to himself.

Verse 20: Christians are "ambassadors" of reconciliation. They are to make peace, with God and among people.

Verse 21: Jesus was without sin. He took our guilt on himself, so that we can be righteous before God. Later Martin Luther called this a *joyful exchange*.

For today: Reconciliation is also possible between people and between nations. Christians are called to work for it.

Chapter 6

Now is the time of grace

Now is the day of salvation VERSES 1–10

1 As God's fellow workers we also beg you:
Don't receive the grace of God in vain.
2 For he says:
"At an acceptable time I listened to you.
In a day of salvation I helped you."
Look,
now is the acceptable time.
Look,
now is the day of salvation.
3 We give no cause for stumbling in anything,
so that our service may not be blamed.
4 But in everything we show ourselves to be servants of God:
in great endurance,
in troubles,
in hardships,
in distress,
5 in beatings,
in prisons,
in riots,
in hard work,
in sleepless nights,
in fasting,
6 in purity,
in knowledge,
in patience,
in kindness,
in the Holy Spirit,
in sincere love,
7 in the word of truth,
in the power of God,
with the armor of righteousness
on the right hand and on the left,
8 in honor and dishonor,
in bad reputation and good reputation,
regarded as deceivers and yet true,
9 as unknown and yet well known,
as dying,
and look:
we live,
as punished and yet not killed,
10 as sorrowful
yet always rejoicing,
as poor
yet making many rich,
as having nothing
and yet possessing all things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Salvation means: being saved, rescued by God.

Verse 2 quotes Isaiah 49:8. Paul says: The time the prophet spoke about has come now. Now is the time to accept God's grace.

Verses 4–10: Paul describes his life as an apostle: full of hardship, but carried by God. He shows opposites: What looks like defeat from the outside is in truth riches.

Verse 7: "The armor of righteousness" is a picture. It means truth and righteousness, not real weapons.

Verse 10: "As sorrowful yet always rejoicing": Christians may be sad. But beneath the sadness there is a deep joy that comes from God.

Open your hearts VERSES 11–13

11 Our mouth has spoken openly to you, Corinthians.
Our heart has opened wide.
12 There is no lack of room for you in us.
But there is a lack of room in your own hearts.
13 I speak to you as to my children:
In return, open your hearts wide too.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Paul is asking for the church's love. He has opened his heart to them. He asks: Open your hearts to me too.

You are a temple of God VERSES 14–18

14 Don't be unequally yoked with unbelievers.
For what do righteousness and lawlessness have in common?
Or what does light have in common with darkness?
15 What agreement does Christ have with Belial?
Or what share does a believer have with an unbeliever?
16 What agreement does a temple of God have with idols?
For you are a temple of the living God.
As God said:
"I will live in them
and walk among them.
I will be their God,
and they will be my people."
17 So:
"'Come out from among them,
and be separate,'
says the Lord.
'Touch no unclean thing,
and I will receive you.
18 I will be a Father to you.
You will be my sons and daughters,'
says the Lord Almighty."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Yoke means: a wooden bar that joins two animals so they can pull together.

Verse 14: "Unequally yoked" is a picture from farming: You didn't put two very different animals under the same yoke (compare Deuteronomy 22:10). Paul means: Christians should not get so involved with idol worship that their faith suffers.

Important: In 1 Corinthians 7:12–14 Paul clearly said that Christians should stay in a marriage with a partner who is not a Christian. So this verse is not a command to separate from people of other faiths. Nor is it permission to despise people of other faiths.

Verse 15: "Belial" is a Hebrew name for Satan, the power of evil.

Verses 16–18 combine several words from the Bible of Israel: Leviticus 26:11–12, Ezekiel 37:27, Isaiah 52:11 and 2 Samuel 7:14.

Verse 18: Here God clearly also names "daughters." Women and men are equally children of God.

2 CORINTHIANS

Chapter 7

Joy about the reconciliation

Open your hearts to us VERSES 1–4

1 Since we have these promises, beloved,
let's cleanse ourselves
from everything
that makes body and spirit unclean.
And let's make our holiness complete
in the fear of God.
2 Open your hearts to us.
We wronged no one.
We corrupted no one.
We took advantage of no one.
3 I don't say this
to condemn you.
For I have said before:
You are in our hearts
to die together
and live together.
4 I speak to you very openly.
I am very proud of you.
I am filled with comfort.
In all our trouble
I overflow with joy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "These promises" are God's promises from 6:16–18: God wants to live with his people and be their Father.

Verse 2: Paul stresses: He has harmed no one and taken advantage of no one. His opponents had probably accused him of this.

Verse 3: "You are in our hearts to die together and live together": Paul feels very deeply connected with the church.

Titus brings good news VERSES 5–16

5 For even when we came into Macedonia,
our body had no rest.
We were troubled on every side:
fighting outside,
fear inside.
6 But God,
who comforts the downcast,
comforted us
by the coming of Titus.
7 And not only by his coming,
but also by the comfort
he had received from you.
He told us
about your longing,
about your sorrow
and about your zeal for me.
So I rejoiced even more.
8 For even if I made you sad with my letter,
I don't regret it,
even though I did regret it before.
For I see
that this letter made you sad,
though only for a short time.
9 But now I rejoice.
Not
that you were made sad,
but
that your sadness led you to repentance.
For you were made sad in a godly way.
So you suffered no harm from us in anything.
10 For godly sorrow
produces repentance
that leads to salvation
and brings no regret.
But the sorrow of the world produces death.
11 For look
what this godly sorrow
has produced in you:
what earnest care,
yes, what defense,
what indignation,
what fear,
what longing,
what zeal,
what readiness
to set things right!
In everything you have shown
that you are innocent in this matter.
12 So I wrote to you,
but not because of the one
who did the wrong,
nor because of the one
who suffered the wrong.
But your earnest care for us
was to become clear among you in the sight of God.
13 That is why we have been comforted.
And on top of our comfort came a much greater joy:
the joy of Titus.
For his spirit has been refreshed by all of you.
14 For I had boasted to him about you,
and I was not disappointed.
But just as everything we told you was true,
so our boasting about you to Titus also proved true.
15 And his love for you is even greater
when he remembers your obedience,
and how you welcomed him with fear and trembling.
16 I rejoice
that I can be confident about you in everything.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Repentance means: turning away from wrong and turning back to God.

Indignation means: anger about something unjust.

Verses 5–7: Here the story from 2:12–13 continues. Paul was full of fear. Then Titus came with good news from Corinth: The church has made peace with Paul.

Verse 6: "God, who comforts the downcast, comforted us by the coming of Titus." God often comforts through other people, here through Titus.

Verses 8–10: Paul distinguishes two kinds of sadness: a sadness that leads to repentance and a new beginning, and a sadness that only pulls you down.

For today: If you cannot get free of sadness, you may be suffering from depression. Depression is an illness, not a weakness of faith. Help is available from doctors and therapists. In a crisis: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 12: There was one person who did wrong and one who suffered wrong (compare 2:5–11).

Verse 15: "With fear and trembling" here means: with great respect and seriousness.

2 CORINTHIANS

Chapter 8

Giving generously

The example of the churches in Macedonia VERSES 1–7

1 Brothers,
we want to tell you about the grace of God
which has been given to the churches of Macedonia.
2 They were severely tested by great trouble.
But their overflowing joy
and their deep poverty
have overflowed into rich generosity.
3 For I testify:
They gave
as much as they were able,
yes, even beyond their ability,
and they did it of their own free will.
4 They begged us very earnestly
to let them take part in this grace
and in the fellowship of serving the saints.
5 They did more than we had expected.
First they gave themselves to the Lord,
and then to us,
through the will of God.
6 So we urged Titus:
As he had made a beginning before,
so he should also complete this grace among you.
7 You are rich in everything:
in faith,
in speech,
in knowledge,
in all earnestness
and in your love for us.
So see that you are also rich in this grace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Generosity means: being glad to give.

Paul was collecting money for the poor Christians in Jerusalem (compare 1 Corinthians 16:1–4 and Romans 15:25–27).

Verses 2–3: The churches in Macedonia, for example in Philippi and Thessalonica, were poor themselves. Even so, they gave with joy.

Paul calls giving "grace." Generosity is a gift from God.

How Jesus became poor VERSES 8–15

8 I don't say this as a command.
But through the eagerness of others I want to test
whether your love is also genuine.
9 For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ:
He was rich,
yet for your sake he became poor,
so that through his poverty you might become rich.
10 I give you my advice in this.
It is good for you.
For a year ago you were the first to start,
not only to do something,
but also to want to do it.
11 But now finish the work as well.
As you were ready
to want it,
so you should also complete it,
as far as you are able.
12 For if the readiness is there,
the gift is welcome
according to what a person has,
not according to
what he doesn't have.
13 It is not about others having it easy
while you are in need.
14 It is about fairness.
Right now your plenty supplies what they lack,
so that one day their plenty may supply what you lack.
That way there is fairness.
15 As it is written:
"He who gathered much
had nothing left over.
And he who gathered little
had no lack."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Paul doesn't command. Giving should be voluntary.

Verse 9: An important sentence about Jesus: With God he was "rich." But he became a human being, lived poor and died on the cross. In this way he made us rich.

Verse 12: Everyone should give what they can, not more. God looks at the readiness, not at the size of the amount.

Verses 13–14: It is not about givers becoming poor themselves, but about a fair balance between rich and poor.

Verse 15 quotes Exodus 16:18. When God provided manna in the wilderness, everyone had enough.

For today: Christians work for fairness in the world, for example through donations, fair trade and help for people in need.

Titus and his companions VERSES 16–24

16 But thanks be to God,
who puts the same eagerness for you into the heart of Titus.
17 For he accepted our request.
But because he himself is very eager,
he is coming to you of his own accord.
18 We are sending with him the brother
whom all the churches praise for his work for the Good News.
19 And not only that:
The churches also appointed him
to travel with us
to bring this gift.
We do this service for the glory of the Lord
and to show our readiness.
20 In this way we avoid
anyone blaming us
about this large sum
that we are managing.
21 For we pay attention to what is honorable,
not only in the sight of the Lord,
but also in the sight of people.
22 We are sending with them another brother of ours.
We have often tested him in many things,
and he has always been eager.
Now he is even more eager,
because he has great confidence in you.
23 As for Titus:
He is my partner and fellow worker for you.
And as for our brothers:
They are the apostles of the churches,
the glory of Christ.
24 So show them before the churches
the proof of your love
and that we are right to be proud of you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 18 and 22: Paul doesn't name these brothers. We don't know who they were.

Verses 20–21: Paul deals with the money very carefully. Several people travel with the gift. So no one can accuse him of dishonesty.

For today: Whoever manages donations should do so openly and honestly.

Verse 23: The WEB says "apostles." Here this means messengers who were sent by the churches.

2 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 9

God loves a cheerful giver

Be ready VERSES 1–5

1 It is really not necessary
for me to write to you about the service to the saints.
2 For I know your readiness.
I am proud of it,
and I tell the people of Macedonia about it:
Achaia has been ready since last year.
And your zeal has stirred up very many of them.
3 But I have sent the brothers,
so that our boasting about you in this matter may not be empty,
and so that you may be ready,
just as I said.
4 Otherwise it could happen
that people from Macedonia come with me
and find you unprepared.
Then we would be put to shame in our confidence,
to say nothing of you.
5 So I thought it necessary
to ask the brothers
to go ahead to you
and prepare the generous gift
that you promised before.
It should be ready
as a gift given generously
and not out of greed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Paul writes more about the collection for Jerusalem. Achaia is the province in which Corinth lies.

Verses 2–4: Paul has praised the church in Corinth to others. Now he hopes that they will also keep their promise.

Giving with joy VERSES 6–15

6 Remember this:
He who sows sparingly
will also reap sparingly.
And he who sows generously
will also reap generously.
7 Let each one give
as he has decided in his heart,
not reluctantly
or under pressure.
For God loves a cheerful giver.
8 And God is able to give you all grace in rich measure,
so that you always have enough in everything
and have plenty left over for every good work.
9 As it is written:
"He has scattered abroad.
He has given to the poor.
His righteousness remains forever."
10 He who gives seed to the sower
and bread for food

will also give you seed for sowing and multiply it.
And he will increase the fruits of your righteousness.
11 So you will be rich in everything
and can give generously.
And through us this leads
to people giving thanks to God.
12 For this service of giving
not only supplies what the saints lack,
but also overflows in many thanks to God.
13 For through this service it becomes clear
what you are like.
And those who receive it glorify God
because you obey your confession of the Good News of Christ,
and because of your generous sharing with them and with all.
14 And they pray for you
and long for you,
because of the surpassing grace of God
which is in you.
15 Thanks be to God for his gift,
which is too wonderful for words!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sow means: to put seeds in the ground.

Reap means: to harvest.

Verse 6: A picture from farming: Whoever sows a lot can harvest a lot. Generosity bears fruit.

Verse 7: Giving should be voluntary and joyful. No one should be put under pressure.

Important: Some preachers promise that God will make people rich if they give a lot of money to their church. This text doesn't teach that. Paul is concerned with help for the poor, not with wealth for the givers. No one should give more than they can (8:12).

Verse 9 quotes Psalm 112:9. Verse 10 recalls Isaiah 55:10.

Verses 12–14: The gift connects Christians from different peoples. The Christians in Jerusalem thank God and pray for the Christians in Corinth.

Verse 15: "His gift, which is too wonderful for words": Paul probably means Jesus Christ himself.

2 CORINTHIANS

Chapter 10

Paul defends his ministry

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

From chapter 10 on, the tone of the letter changes sharply. Paul becomes harsh and defends himself against opponents in Corinth. That is why some scholars think that chapters 10 to 13 were originally a separate letter, perhaps the letter written *with many tears* (2:4).

The opponents were Christian traveling preachers who praised themselves. Later Paul mockingly calls them the *very best apostles* (11:5).

Our weapons are not human VERSES 1–6

1 I, Paul, myself,
beg you
by the humility and gentleness of Christ.
I am lowly when I am face to face with you,
but bold toward you when I am away.
2 Yes, I beg you:
Don't force me,
when I am with you,
to act with the boldness
with which I intend to stand up against some people.
They think
that we live in a merely human way.
3 For though we live as human beings,
we don't fight in a merely human way.
4 For the weapons of our fight are not human,
but mighty before God
for tearing down strongholds.
5 We tear down arguments
and every proud thing
that rises up against the knowledge of God.
And we take every thought captive
to obey Christ.
6 And we are ready
to punish all disobedience
once your obedience is complete.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Stronghold means: a fortress, a strong building that is hard to capture.

Verse 1: The opponents said about Paul: He writes bold letters, but when he is here, he is weak.

Verses 3–5: Paul speaks of a fight. But that is a picture. His "weapons" are words, truth and prayer. It is about wrong ideas, not about violence against people.

Important: These verses give no one the right to use violence in the name of faith.

Verse 6: "Punish" here means: As an apostle Paul wants to act against wrong developments in the church, with words and warnings.

Letters and presence VERSES 7–11

7 Do you only look at
what is in front of your face?
If anyone is convinced
that he belongs to Christ,
let him think again:
As he belongs to Christ,
so we also belong to Christ.
8 For even if I boast a little too much
about our authority,
which the Lord gave us
to build you up
and not to tear you down,
I will not be ashamed.
9 I don't want to seem
as if I wanted to frighten you with my letters.

10 For some say:
"His letters are weighty and strong.
But when he is here in person,
he is weak,
and his speech is worth nothing."
11 Whoever talks like that
should think about this:
What we say in our letters when we are away,
we will also do
when we are present.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Authority in the church is there to build up, not to tear down. That is still true today for everyone who has responsibility in the church.

Verse 10: Paul was clearly not an impressive speaker. Perhaps he was also ill or looked weak. His opponents made fun of him for it.

For today: A person's worth doesn't depend on how they come across or how they look.

Boast in the Lord VERSES 12–18

12 For we don't dare
to compare ourselves with some of those
who recommend themselves.
They measure themselves by themselves
and compare themselves with themselves.
So they are without understanding.
13 But we will not boast beyond proper limits,
but only within the limits
that God has given us.
And these limits reach even to you.
14 For we are not going too far,
as if we had not reached you.
For we really did come all the way to you
with the Good News of Christ.
15 We don't boast beyond proper limits
about the work of others.
But we hope:
As your faith grows,
our area of work will become much larger through you.
16 Then we can preach the Good News in the regions
beyond you too,
without boasting about
what someone else has already done.
17 But:
"He who boasts,
let him boast in the Lord."
18 For it isn't the one
who recommends himself
who is approved,
but the one
whom the Lord recommends.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: The opponents only compared themselves with themselves and thought they were wonderful.

Verses 13–16: Paul founded the church in Corinth. But the opponents came later and wanted to take credit for someone else's work.

Verse 17 takes up Jeremiah 9:24 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 9:23). Paul already used these words in 1 Corinthians 1:31.

Verse 18: It is not praising yourself that counts, but what God says about a person.

2 CORINTHIANS

Chapter 11

What Paul suffered

Worry for the church VERSES 1–6

1 I wish
that you would put up with a little foolishness from me.
But you are already putting up with me.
2 For I am jealous for you
with a jealousy
that comes from God.
For I promised you in marriage to one husband,
so that I might present you as a pure virgin to Christ.
3 But I am afraid
that somehow your minds might be led astray
and you might lose your simple devotion to Christ,
as the serpent deceived Eve by his cunning.
4 For if someone comes
and preaches another Jesus
whom we didn't preach,
or if you receive a different spirit
which you didn't receive,
or a different "good news"
which you didn't accept,
you put up with that well enough.
5 For I think
that I am not at all behind the "very best apostles."
6 Even if I am unskilled in speech,
I am not unskilled in knowledge.
We have shown you this in every way and in all things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: Paul compares the church to a bride and Christ to the bridegroom. Paul is like the father who leads the bride to the wedding. This picture for God and his people already appears in the prophets (for example Hosea 2).

Verse 3 recalls Genesis 3. Paul names Eve as an example of how one can be deceived. This is no statement that women are more easily deceived. Here Paul is warning the whole church.

Verse 4: The opponents preached a different message. Paul is worried that the church will let itself be led astray.

Verse 5: Paul says "very best apostles" mockingly about his opponents.

Paul preached without charge VERSES 7–15

7 Or did I commit a sin
by humbling myself
so that you might be lifted up?
Because I preached God's Good News to you free of charge?
8 I robbed other churches
by taking wages from them
so that I could serve you.
9 And when I was with you and in need,
I wasn't a burden to anyone.
For the brothers
who came from Macedonia
supplied what I needed.
In everything I kept myself
from being a burden to you,
and I will continue to do so.
10 As surely as the truth of Christ is in me:
No one will take this boasting from me
in the regions of Achaia.
11 Why?
Because I don't love you?
God knows I do.
12 But what I do,
I will continue to do.
That way I take the opportunity away from those
who are looking for an opportunity
to be seen as equal to us
in what they boast about.
13 For such people are false apostles,
deceitful workers.
They disguise themselves as Christ's apostles.
14 And no wonder.
For even Satan disguises himself
as an angel of light.
15 So it is no great thing
if his servants also disguise themselves
as servants of righteousness.
Their end will match their deeds.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–9: Paul took no money from the Corinthians. He lived from his own work and from gifts from other churches. His opponents said this showed that he was not a real apostle.

Verse 8: "Robbed" is a strong exaggeration. Paul means: Other churches paid for me.

Verses 13–15: Paul warns against people who look pious but deceive others.

For today: Today too there are people who pretend to be pious leaders and who use, manipulate or abuse others. If you experience this, you may get help, for example from counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse. If you have experienced sexual abuse: In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

I speak like a fool VERSES 16–21

16 I say again:
Let no one think I am a fool.
But if you do,
then accept me as a fool,
so that I too may boast a little.
17 What I am saying now
I don't say as the Lord would,
but as in foolishness,
in this confident boasting.
18 Since many boast in a human way,
I will boast too.
19 For you gladly put up with fools,
since you are so wise.
20 For you put up with it
if someone makes you slaves,
if someone exploits you,
if someone takes advantage of you,
if someone puts himself above you,
if someone strikes you in the face.
21 To my shame I say:
We were too weak for that!
But in whatever way anyone else is bold,
I speak in foolishness:
I am bold too.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Paul doesn't like to praise himself. But because the opponents boast, he does it too, and he himself calls it "foolishness." That is irony.

Verse 20: The opponents treated the church badly: They exploited them and humiliated them. And the church put up with it.

Important: No one has to let themselves be exploited, humiliated or hit in a church. That is wrong.

The sufferings of the apostle VERSES 22–33

22 Are they Hebrews?
So am I.
Are they Israelites?
So am I.
Are they the offspring of Abraham?
So am I.
23 Are they servants of Christ?
(I speak as if I were out of my mind.)
I am more so:
with far more hard work,
far more often in prisons,
with beatings beyond measure,
often in danger of death.
24 Five times I received 40 lashes minus one
from the Jews.
25 Three times I was beaten with rods.
Once I was stoned.
Three times I was shipwrecked.
I spent a night and a day in the open sea.
26 I have often been on journeys,
in dangers from rivers,
in dangers from robbers,
in dangers from my own people,
in dangers from the Gentiles,
in dangers in the city,
in dangers in the wilderness,
in dangers at sea,
in dangers among false brothers.

27 I have known hard work and toil,
often sleepless nights,
hunger and thirst,
often fasting,
cold and not enough clothing.
28 And besides all that,
there is what presses on me every day:
my worry for all the churches.
29 Who is weak,
and I am not weak?
Who is made to stumble,
and I don't burn inside?
30 If I must boast,
I will boast about my weakness.
31 The God and Father of the Lord Jesus Christ,
who is blessed forever,
knows
that I am not lying.
32 In Damascus the governor under King Aretas
had the city of the Damascenes guarded
in order to arrest me.
33 But I was let down in a basket through a window in the wall.
So I escaped his hands.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Lashes means: blows with a whip.

Verse 22: Paul stresses: He is a Jew, an Israelite, a descendant of Abraham. He is proud of it.

Verse 24: The "40 lashes minus one" were a punishment of the synagogue courts (compare Deuteronomy 25:3). The fact that Paul accepted this punishment shows: He still saw himself as a member of the Jewish community. This verse is not a judgment on the Jewish people.

Verse 25: "Beaten with rods" was a Roman punishment (compare Acts 16:22–23). Acts 14:19 tells about the stoning.

Verse 26: Paul was in danger from his own people and from people of other nations, and even from "false brothers," that is, Christians.

Verses 29–30: Paul doesn't boast about his successes, but about his weakness. Especially in that, God's power shows itself.

Verses 32–33: Acts 9:23–25 also tells about this escape.

2 CORINTHIANS

Chapter 12

Strong in weakness

Paul is caught up into heaven VERSES 1–6

1 It doesn't do me any good
to boast.
But I will come to visions and revelations of the Lord.
2 I know a man in Christ.
He was caught up into the third heaven 14 years ago.
Whether he was in the body,
I don't know.
Or whether he was out of the body,
I don't know.
God knows.
3 And I know this man.
Whether he was in the body
or outside of the body,
I don't know.
God knows.
4 He was caught up into Paradise.
There he heard words
that cannot be spoken.
No human being is allowed to say them.
5 On behalf of such a man I will boast.
But on my own behalf I will not boast,
except about my weaknesses.
6 For if I wanted to boast,
I would not be a fool.
For I would be speaking the truth.
But I hold back.
No one should think more of me
than what he sees in me
or hears from me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Paradise means: here: the place where God is.

Verses 2–4: Paul is speaking about himself, but in the third person, as if it were about someone else. That way he doesn't show off.

"The third heaven" and "Paradise" mean the place where God is. Paul had a special experience of being close to God. He himself cannot say exactly what happened.

Verse 6: Paul doesn't want to be admired because of special experiences, but only for what people see in him and hear from him.

"My grace is sufficient for you" VERSES 7–10

7 So that I would not become too proud
because of these surpassingly great revelations,
a thorn in the flesh was given to me:
a messenger of Satan
to torment me,
so that I would not become too proud.
8 I begged the Lord three times about this,
that it might leave me.
9 But he said to me:
"My grace is sufficient for you,
for my power is made perfect in weakness."
So I will most gladly boast about my weaknesses,
so that the power of Christ may rest on me.
10 So I take pleasure in weaknesses,
in insults,
in hardships,
in persecutions
and in distress,
for Christ's sake.
For when I am weak,
then I am strong.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: We don't know what the "thorn in the flesh" was. Some think of an illness, for example of the eyes, or headaches. Others think of persecution or of his opponents.

Important: Illness or disability are not a punishment from God and not a sign of too little faith. Paul prayed three times for healing and was not healed. Even so, he was an apostle and loved by God.

Verse 9: This is one of the best-known words of the Bible. God doesn't take away every hardship. But he says: My grace is enough. Especially in weakness God's power can work.

Verse 10: "When I am weak, then I am strong": Paul doesn't have to be strong. He trusts in the power of Christ.

Important: This text doesn't mean that you should look for suffering or abuse or put up with it. If you experience violence, you may protect yourself and get help. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Paul's worry for the church VERSES 11–21

11 I have become foolish in boasting.
You forced me to.
For really you should have recommended me.
For I am in no way less than the "very best apostles,"
even though I am nothing.
12 The signs of an apostle
were done among you with all patience,
with signs,
wonders
and mighty works.
13 For in what way were you treated worse
than the other churches?
Only in this:
that I myself was not a burden to you.
Forgive me this wrong!
14 Look,
this is the third time I am ready
to come to you.
And I will not be a burden to you.
For I am not looking for your possessions,
but for you.
For the children ought not to save up for the parents,
but the parents for the children.
15 I will most gladly spend everything for you
and give myself completely for you.
If I love you more,
am I loved less?
16 All right,
I myself was not a burden to you.
But you might say:
I was crafty
and caught you by trickery.
17 Did I take advantage of you through any of those
whom I sent to you?
18 I urged Titus to go,
and I sent the brother with him.
Did Titus take advantage of you?
Didn't we live in the same spirit?
Didn't we walk in the same steps?
19 Do you think again
that we are defending ourselves to you?
In the sight of God we speak in Christ.
But everything,
beloved,
is done
to build you up.
20 For I am afraid
that when I come I might not find you
the way I want,
and that you might not find me
the way you want.
I am afraid
that there may be strife,
jealousy,
outbursts of anger,
factions,
slander,
gossip,
pride
and disorder.
21 I am afraid
that when I come again my God will humble me before
you
and that I will have to mourn over many
who sinned earlier
and have not turned away
from the uncleanness,
sexual immorality
and lust
that they have practiced.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Paul also did miracles in Corinth. But he doesn't boast about them.

Verse 13: "Forgive me this wrong!" is irony: Paul took no money from them.

Verse 14: "The third time": Paul had already been in Corinth twice. He is planning a third visit.

Verses 14–15: Paul loves the church as a father loves his children. He doesn't want to take anything from them, but to give to them.

Verses 20–21: Paul is worried that the problems in Corinth have not yet been solved.

2 CORINTHIANS

CHAPTER 13

Last warning and blessing

Examine yourselves VERSES 1–10

1 This is the third time I am coming to you.
"At the mouth of two or three witnesses
every matter shall be established."
2 I warned you before,
and I warn you again now.
As I said when I was with you the second time,

so now, while I am away, I write it
to those
who sinned before
and to all the rest:
If I come again,
I will not spare anyone.
3 For you are looking for proof
that Christ speaks through me.
He is not weak toward you,
but powerful among you.
4 For he was crucified in weakness,
yet he lives through the power of God.
We also are weak in him.
But we will live with him
through the power of God
toward you.
5 Examine yourselves,
whether you are in the faith.
Test yourselves.
Or don't you realize about yourselves
that Jesus Christ is in you?
Unless, of course,
you fail the test.
6 But I hope
you will realize
that we have not failed the test.
7 Now I pray to God
that you do nothing evil.
Not so that we may appear approved,
but so that you may do what is good,
even if we seem to have failed.
8 For we can do nothing against the truth,
but only for the truth.
9 For we rejoice
when we are weak
and you are strong.
And we also pray for this:
that you may become complete.
10 So I write these things while I am away,
so that I don't have to be harsh
when I am with you.
I want to use the authority
which the Lord gave me
for building up
and not for tearing down.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1 quotes Deuteronomy 19:15. In the law of Israel you needed at least two or three witnesses to find someone guilty. A good protection against false accusations.

Verse 4: Jesus was crucified in weakness, but he lives through God's power. It is the same with Paul: weak, but carried by God.

Verse 5: The Corinthians wanted to examine Paul. Paul says: Rather examine yourselves.

Verse 10: Once more Paul stresses: Authority is there for building up, not for destroying (compare 10:8).

Greeting and blessing VERSES 11–14

11 Finally, brothers:
Rejoice!
Let yourselves be set right.
Let yourselves be comforted.
Be of one mind.
Live in peace.
And the God of love and peace will be with you.
12 Greet one another with a holy kiss.
13 All the saints greet you.
14 The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ,
God's love,
and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit
be with you all.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: After all the hard words, Paul ends with joy, comfort and peace.

Verse 14: This blessing names Jesus Christ, God (the Father) and the Holy Spirit together. It is still spoken in many worship services today.

About verse numbers: The WEB divides the end into verses 12, 13 and 14. Some Bibles have only 13 verses here. There verses 12–13 are one verse, and the blessing is verse 13.

Looking back: What have we read in the second letter to the Corinthians?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A very personal letter: Paul speaks openly about fear, despair, suffering and comfort. He shows his feelings for the church.

The God of all comfort: God comforts us in every trouble, so that we can comfort others (chapter 1).

Reconciliation: After quarrels and hurt, the church makes peace with Paul. God himself has reconciled the world to himself through Christ. Christians are ambassadors of reconciliation (chapters 2, 5 and 7).

A treasure in clay jars: People are weak and fragile. But God's power works through them (chapter 4).

Generosity: The collection for the poor Christians in Jerusalem shows: Christians share with one another, freely and with joy (chapters 8 and 9).

Strong in weakness: Paul doesn't boast about his successes, but about his weaknesses. God says to him: My grace is enough for you (chapters 10 to 13).

Important note: In chapter 3 Paul speaks about the old and the new covenant. These words were often used against Jews. That was wrong. Paul himself is proud to be a Jew (11:22).

For today: No one has to be strong or perfect to be loved and used by God.

What comes next? Next comes Paul's letter to the churches in Galatia. In it Paul fights passionately for the freedom of Christians. A famous thought from it: In Christ all are one, whether Jew or Greek, slave or free, man or woman (Galatians 3:28).

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GALATIANS

6 CHAPTERS

GALATIANS

Chapter 1

There is only one Good News

Before we begin: The letter to the Galatians

Galatia was a region and a Roman province in what is now Turkey. Paul had founded churches there. Most Christians there did not come from Judaism, but from other nations.

After Paul, other Christian teachers came to Galatia. They said: Whoever wants to belong to Christ must also be circumcised and keep the Jewish law. Paul disagrees passionately. He says: People from all nations belong to God through faith in Christ, without first having to become Jews.

The letter was probably written between AD 50 and 55. It is one of Paul's oldest letters.

A very important note: In the letter to the Galatians, Christians argue with Christians. The question is what people from other nations must do when they become Christians. The letter is not an attack on Judaism. Paul was a Jew himself and remained one. Sadly, this letter has often been used in history to speak badly of Judaism, as if Jewish faith consisted only of rules. That is false and unjust. For Jews the Torah is still a gift from God and a way of life today.

The letter to the Galatians has 6 chapters.

Greeting VERSES 1–5

1 Paul,
an apostle,
not sent by people
or through a human being,
but through Jesus Christ
and God the Father,
who raised him from the dead,
2 and all the brothers
who are with me,
write to the churches of Galatia:
3 Grace to you and peace
from God the Father
and our Lord Jesus Christ.
4 He gave himself for our sins,
to rescue us out of this present evil age,
according to the will of our God and Father.
5 To him be the glory forever and ever.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Right at the beginning Paul stresses: My task doesn't come from people, but directly from God. Some in Galatia doubted that.

Verse 4: Jesus gave his life for us. He rescues us out of a world in which evil still has power.

No other Good News VERSES 6–10

6 I am amazed
that you are so quickly turning away
from him
who called you in the grace of Christ,
to a different "good news."
7 But there isn't another "good news."
There are only some
who confuse you
and want to twist the Good News of Christ.
8 But even if we
or an angel from heaven
should preach to you any "good news"
other than the one
that we preached to you,
let him be cursed.
9 As we have said before,
so I now say again:
If anyone preaches to you any "good news"
other than the one
that you received,
let him be cursed.
10 Am I now seeking the approval of people,
or of God?
Or am I trying to please people?
If I were still trying to please people,
I wouldn't be a servant of Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Paul writes this letter without the thanksgiving that usually comes at the beginning. He is upset and worried.

Verses 6–7: For Paul the Good News is clear: God accepts people by grace. Whoever adds extra conditions changes this message.

Verses 8–9: "Cursed" is a very harsh word. It is a fixed formula that leaves the judgment to God. It is no permission to persecute people or to harm them.

How Paul was called VERSES 11–24

11 Brothers,
I make known to you:
The Good News
that I preached
does not come from people.
12 For I didn't receive it from a human being,
and no one taught it to me.
But it came to me through a revelation of Jesus Christ.
13 For you have heard
how I used to live in the Jewish religion.
I persecuted the church of God beyond measure
and tried to destroy it.
14 In the Jewish religion I was ahead of many of my own
age among my people.
I was extremely zealous
for the traditions of my ancestors.

15 But God had set me apart from my mother's womb
and called me through his grace.
When it pleased him
16 to reveal his Son in me,
so that I might preach him among the Gentiles,
I didn't immediately ask any human being for advice.
17 Nor did I go up to Jerusalem
to those
who were apostles before me.
Instead I went away into Arabia
and then returned to Damascus.
18 Only after three years did I go up to Jerusalem
to get to know Peter.
I stayed with him 15 days.
19 I saw none of the other apostles,
except James,
the Lord's brother.
20 About the things I write to you,
I say before God:
I am not lying.
21 Then I came to the regions of Syria and Cilicia.
22 The churches of Judea
that belong to Christ
still didn't know me personally.
23 They only heard:
"He who once persecuted us
now preaches the faith
that he once tried to destroy."
24 And they praised God because of me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Revelation means: something God shows.

Verses 13–14: Paul was a very zealous Jew. He persecuted the Christians because he thought he had to defend God's honor.

Verses 15–16: Paul describes his calling with words that recall the calling of the prophets (for example Jeremiah 1:5 and Isaiah 49:1). He doesn't see himself as someone who changed his religion, but as someone whom God gave the task of telling the nations about Jesus.

Verse 17: "Arabia" probably means the area east and south of Damascus, the kingdom of the Nabataeans.

Verses 18–19: Paul met Peter and James, the brother of Jesus. The churches understand "brother" in different ways (compare 1 Corinthians 9:5).

Verses 23–24: The churches praised God because the persecutor became a preacher. God can change people.

GALATIANS

CHAPTER 2

Agreement in Jerusalem, conflict in Antioch

The meeting in Jerusalem VERSES 1–10

1 Then,
after 14 years,
I went up again to Jerusalem
with Barnabas.
I also took Titus with me.
2 I went up
because God had shown me that I should.
I laid before them the Good News
that I preach among the Gentiles.
But I did it privately,
before those who were respected.
For I didn't want
to be running in vain
or to have run in vain.
3 But not even Titus,
who was with me,
was forced
to be circumcised,
even though he was a Greek.
4 This happened because of the false brothers
who had been secretly brought in.
They slipped in
to spy on our freedom
which we have in Christ Jesus.
They wanted to make us slaves.
5 We did not give in to them for a moment
or submit to them,
so that the truth of the Good News would remain with you.
6 But from those
who were thought to be important
(whatever they were before
makes no difference to me,
for God doesn't show favoritism),
from these respected people I received no new requirements.
7 On the contrary:
They saw
that I had been entrusted with the Good News for the uncircumcised,
just as Peter had been with the Good News for the circumcised.
8 For he who worked through Peter
to make him an apostle to the circumcised
also worked through me
for the Gentiles.
9 When they recognized the grace
that was given to me,
James, Cephas and John,
who were seen as pillars,
gave Barnabas and me the right hand of fellowship.
We were to go to the Gentiles,
and they to the circumcised.
10 They only asked us
to remember the poor.
And that is the very thing I was eager to do.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Circumcised means: here: Jews.

Uncircumcised means: here: people who are not Jews.

Verses 1–10: Paul tells about an important meeting in Jerusalem (compare Acts 15). The leaders of the church in Jerusalem, James, Peter (Cephas) and John, agreed: People from the nations don't have to be circumcised to be Christians.

Verse 3: Titus was a Greek, so not a Jew. He was not forced to be circumcised.

Verses 7–9: The tasks were divided: Peter went mainly to the Jews, Paul mainly to the other nations. Both preached the same Good News.

Verse 9: To give "the right hand of fellowship" was a sign of a firm agreement.

Verse 10: Caring for the poor unites all Christians.

Paul opposes Peter VERSES 11–14

11 But when Peter came to Antioch,
I opposed him to his face.
For he was clearly in the wrong.
12 For before some people came from James,
he ate with the Gentiles.
But when they came,
he drew back and kept himself apart,
because he was afraid of those
who belonged to the circumcision group.
13 And the rest of the Jews joined him in his hypocrisy,
so that even Barnabas was carried away by their
hypocrisy.
14 But when I saw
that they were not walking straight according to the
truth of the Good News,
I said to Peter in front of them all:
"You are a Jew,
yet you live like the Gentiles
and not like the Jews.
How then can you force the Gentiles
to live like the Jews?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Antioch was a large city in Syria. There was a church there with Christians of Jewish background and Christians from other nations. They ate together.

Verse 12: When visitors came from Jerusalem, Peter suddenly stopped eating with the Christians from the nations. In this way he divided the church.

Verse 13: Hypocrisy means: pretending to be different from how you really are.

Verse 13: "The rest of the Jews" here means the other Christians of Jewish background in Antioch, not the Jewish people in general.

For Paul, eating together was very important: It shows that everyone belongs to the church equally.

For today: Church leaders can make mistakes too. It is right to disagree openly and honestly when people are being shut out.

Made right through faith VERSES 15–21

15 "We are Jews by birth
and not Gentile sinners.
16 But we know:
A person is not made righteous by the works of the
law,
but through faith in Jesus Christ.
So we too have believed in Christ Jesus,
so that we might be made righteous by faith in Christ
and not by the works of the law.
For by the works of the law
no one will be made righteous.
17 But if,
while we seek to be made righteous in Christ,
we ourselves are found to be sinners,
is Christ then a servant of sin?
Certainly not!
18 For if I build up again
what I tore down,
I show that I myself am a lawbreaker.
19 For through the law I died to the law,
so that I might live for God.
20 I have been crucified with Christ.
It is no longer I who live,
but Christ lives in me.
And the life
that I now live in the body,
I live by faith in the Son of God,
who loved me
and gave himself for me.
21 I don't reject the grace of God.
For if righteousness could come through the law,
then Christ died for nothing!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Righteous means: living right before God.

Verse 15: "Gentile sinners" was a common way among Jews at that time to speak of people who didn't know God's commandments. Paul quotes it in order to show right away: Before God everyone needs grace.

Verse 16: This is a key sentence of Paul: You are not made righteous before God by your own achievements, but by trusting Jesus Christ. The Greek words for *faith in Jesus Christ* can also be translated as *the faithfulness of Jesus Christ*. Both belong together.

"The works of the law" here means mainly commandments like circumcision and food laws, which set Jews apart from other nations. Paul says: These differences must not divide people in the church.

Important: Paul is not speaking badly about the Torah here. He is asking what people from the nations must do to belong to God.

Verse 20: "Christ lives in me": Faith joins a person so closely to Jesus that their whole life is shaped by him.

Verse 21: It is not quite clear where Paul's speech to Peter ends. The WEB lets the quotation run to verse 21.

GALATIANS

CHAPTER 3

Children of Abraham through faith

How did you receive the Spirit? VERSES 1–5

1 Foolish Galatians!
Who has bewitched you,
so that you no longer obey the truth?
Jesus Christ was clearly portrayed before your eyes
as crucified.
2 I just want to learn this from you:
Did you receive the Spirit
by the works of the law,
or by hearing with faith?
3 Are you so foolish?
You began in the Spirit.
Are you now going to finish in the flesh?
4 Did you suffer so many things in vain?
If it really was in vain!
5 God gives you the Spirit
and does miracles among you.
Does he do it because of the works of the law,
or because of hearing with faith?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Bewitched means: put under a magic spell.

Verse 1: "Bewitched" is a strong picture. Paul is shocked at how quickly the Galatians let themselves be persuaded otherwise.

Verses 2–5: The Galatians received the Holy Spirit when they heard the Good News and believed, not because they had kept commandments. Why should they need something else now?

Verse 3: "Finish in the flesh" here means: by your own human strength, for example through circumcision.

Abraham believed God VERSES 6–14

6 It was the same with Abraham:
"He believed God,
and it was counted to him as righteousness."
7 So understand this:
Those who live by faith
are the children of Abraham.
8 The Scripture foresaw
that God would make the Gentiles righteous by faith.
So it announced the Good News to Abraham
beforehand:
"In you all the nations will be blessed."
9 So those
who live by faith
are blessed together with Abraham, the man of faith.
10 For all
who rely on the works of the law
are under a curse.
For it is written:
"Cursed is everyone
who doesn't continue in all things
that are written in the book of the law,
to do them."
11 Now it is clear
that no one is made righteous before God by the law.
For:
"The righteous will live by faith."
12 The law is not based on faith,
but:
"The man who does them
will live by them."
13 Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law
by becoming a curse for us.
For it is written:
"Cursed is everyone
who hangs on a tree."
14 So the blessing of Abraham was to come to the Gentiles
through Christ Jesus,
so that we might receive the promised Spirit through
faith.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Redeem means: to buy free.

Verse 6 quotes Genesis 15:6. Abraham trusted God long before there was the law at Sinai.

Verse 8 quotes Genesis 12:3 (compare 18:18). Abraham was already told: Through him all nations are to be blessed.

Verse 10 quotes Deuteronomy 27:26. Verse 11 quotes Habakkuk 2:4. Verse 12 quotes Leviticus 18:5. Verse 13 quotes Deuteronomy 21:23.

Verses 10–13 are difficult verses. Paul wants to tell the Galatians: If you rely on the law instead of on Christ, you have to keep everything perfectly. Christ has opened this way for us.

Important: Paul does not say that the Jewish people are under a curse. He is speaking to Christians from the nations who thought they also had to bind themselves to the law. These verses were often used against Jews. That was wrong.

Verse 13: On the cross Jesus was treated like someone cursed. But in exactly this way he brought the blessing to all people.

The law and the promise VERSES 15–25

15 Brothers,
I speak in human terms:
Even if it is only a human agreement,
no one can cancel it or add to it
once it has been confirmed.
16 Now the promises were spoken to Abraham
and to his offspring.
It doesn't say,
"To descendants,"
as if many were meant,
but as if one is meant:
"To your offspring."
That is Christ.
17 Now I mean this:
God confirmed a covenant beforehand in Christ.
The law,
which came 430 years later,
cannot cancel this covenant,
so that the promise would be made useless.
18 For if the inheritance came from the law,
it would no longer come from the promise.
But God gave it to Abraham by a promise.
19 Then why is there the law?
It was added because of wrongdoing,
until the offspring should come
to whom the promise was made.
It was put in place through angels,
by the hand of a go-between.

20 But a go-between doesn't stand for one side only.
But God is one.
21 Is the law then against the promises of God?
Certainly not!
For if a law had been given
that could make alive,
then righteousness would really come from the law.
22 But the Scripture locked up all things under sin,
so that the promise by faith in Jesus Christ
might be given to those
who believe.
23 But before faith came,
we were kept in custody under the law,
locked up
until faith would be revealed.
24 So the law has become our tutor
to bring us to Christ,
so that we might be made righteous by faith.
25 But now that faith has come,
we are no longer under a tutor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Go-between means: someone who stands between two sides, a mediator.

Verse 16: Paul interprets the word "offspring" in the singular (for example Genesis 12:7) as referring to Christ. This is a way of interpreting that Jewish teachers also used at that time.

Verse 17: The promise to Abraham came first. The law came much later, at Sinai. It doesn't cancel the earlier promise.

Verse 21: "Certainly not!" The law is not against God's promises. Paul does not say that the law is bad.

Verse 24: At that time the "tutor" was often a slave who went along with children and looked after them until they were grown up. Paul says: In this way the law had an important task.

All are one in Christ VERSES 26–29

26 For you are all children of God
through faith in Christ Jesus.
27 For all of you
who were baptized into Christ
have put on Christ.
28 There is neither Jew nor Greek,
there is neither slave nor free,
there is neither male nor female.
For you are all one in Christ Jesus.
29 If you belong to Christ,
then you are Abraham's offspring
and heirs according to the promise.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Heirs means: people who receive an inheritance.

Verse 27: "Put on Christ" is a picture: In baptism a person is completely joined to Christ, like putting on new clothes.

Verse 28 is one of the most important verses of the Bible about the equality of people. In Christ, background, social position and sex do not count as a ranking. All have the same dignity.

That doesn't mean that differences disappear: Jews remain Jews, women remain women. But no difference makes one person more valuable before God than another.

For today: This verse encourages Christians to stand up against racism, exploitation and discrimination against women.

Verse 29: Christians from the nations also belong to Abraham's family through Christ.

GALATIANS

CHAPTER 4

Children of God, not slaves

God sent his Son VERSES 1–7

1 But I say:
As long as the heir is a child,
he is no different from a slave,
though he is lord of all.
2 He is under guardians and managers
until the day
set by the father.
3 So we also,
when we were children,
were held as slaves under the elemental powers of the world.
4 But when the fullness of the time came,
God sent his Son,
born to a woman,
born under the law,
5 so that he might redeem those
who were under the law,
so that we might be adopted as children.
6 And because you are children,
God sent the Spirit of his Son into your hearts.
He cries out:
"Abba, Father!"
7 So you are no longer a slave,
but a son.
And if you are a son,
then you are also an heir of God through Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elemental powers means: powers that people felt dependent on.

Adopted means: taken into a family as a child.

Verses 1–2: A child who will one day receive a large inheritance has no say yet while still a child. That is how people were before Jesus came.

Verse 3: "Elemental powers of the world": This probably means powers that people felt dependent on, for example stars, gods or fixed religious rules. Interpreters understand the word in different ways.

Verse 4: "Born to a woman, born under the law": Jesus was a real human being and a Jew who lived according to the Torah.

Verse 6: "Abba" is Aramaic and means *Father*, the way a child lovingly speaks to their father (compare Romans

8:15).

Verse 7: The WEB says "son." This means all Christians, women and men. In chapter 3:28 Paul said: There is neither male nor female.

Don't go back into slavery VERSES 8–11

8 But at that time,
when you didn't know God,
you were slaves to gods
that by nature are not gods.
9 But now you know God,
or rather, God knows you.
How can you turn back again to the weak and
miserable elemental powers?
Do you want to be their slaves all over again?
10 You observe days, months, seasons and years.
11 I am afraid for you,
that I may have worked hard for you in vain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: The Galatians used to worship the gods of their peoples.

Verse 10: The Galatians thought they had to keep certain feast days and times in order to belong to God. Paul says: That doesn't make you more righteous before God.

Important: Paul is not speaking badly about the Jewish feasts here. For Jews, the Sabbath and the feasts are a gift from God. Paul is only against Christians from the nations seeing such rules as a condition for salvation.

Paul's worry for the Galatians VERSES 12–20

12 I beg you, brothers:
Become as I am,
for I also have become as you are.
You did me no wrong.
13 But you know
that I preached the Good News to you the first time
because I was weak in body.
14 My weakness was a test for you.
But you didn't despise me
or reject me.
Instead you welcomed me
like an angel of God,
even like Christ Jesus.
15 What has happened to your joy?
For I testify to you:
If it had been possible,
you would have torn out your eyes
and given them to me.
16 So have I become your enemy
by telling you the truth?
17 They are eager for you,
but not for a good purpose.
They want to separate you from me,
so that you will be eager for them.
18 But it is always good
to be eager for a good cause,
and not only
when I am with you.
19 My little children!
I am again in the pains of childbirth for you
until Christ is formed in you.
20 I wish
I could be with you now
and change my tone.
For I am at a loss about you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–15: Paul came to Galatia because of an illness. Even so, the Galatians welcomed him warmly. Verse 15 makes some people think that Paul had an eye disease.

For today: People with illness or disability deserve respect and welcome, just as the Galatians welcomed Paul.

Verse 19: Paul compares himself to a mother in the pains of childbirth. He worries about the Galatians as a mother worries about her child.

The picture of Hagar and Sarah VERSES 21–31

21 Tell me,
you
who want to be under the law:
Don't you listen to
what the law says?
22 For it is written
that Abraham had two sons:
one by the servant woman
and one by the free woman.
23 The son of the servant woman was born in the natural way,
but the son of the free woman was born through the promise.
24 These things are used as a picture.
For the two women stand for two covenants.
One covenant is from Mount Sinai
and bears children into slavery.
That is Hagar.
25 For Hagar stands for Mount Sinai in Arabia.
She corresponds to the present Jerusalem,
for she is in slavery with her children.
26 But the Jerusalem above is free.
She is the mother of us all.
27 For it is written:
"Rejoice,
you barren woman
who doesn't bear children.
Break out and shout,
you
who don't have labor pains.
For the lonely woman has more children
than the one
who has a husband."
28 Now you, brothers,
like Isaac, are children of the promise.
29 But just as back then the one
who was born in the natural way
persecuted the one
who was born by the Spirit,
so it is now too.
30 But what does the Scripture say?
"Throw out the servant woman and her son,
for the son of the servant woman will not inherit with
the son of the free woman."
31 So, brothers,
we are not children of the servant woman,

but of the free woman.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Barren means: not able to have children.

Verses 21–31: Paul interprets the story of Hagar and Sarah (Genesis 16 and 21) as a picture. This is an unusual interpretation. Paul uses it in his argument with the Christian teachers in Galatia, who demanded circumcision from Christians from the nations.

Very important: This text is not a judgment on the Jewish people or on Judaism. It must not be read as if Jews were *children of the servant woman* and Christians *children of the free woman*. This interpretation has caused much harm in church history. Paul says clearly in the letter to the Romans: God has not rejected his people (Romans 11:1–2).

It is also important: In the Bible God himself cares for Hagar and her son Ishmael. He hears their crying, rescues them and blesses Ishmael (Genesis 16:7–13; 21:17–20). Hagar is the first person in the Bible who gives God a name.

Verse 27 quotes Isaiah 54:1. Verse 30 quotes Genesis 21:10.

Verse 30: This sentence is no call to shut people out or to drive them away.

GALATIANS

CHAPTER 5

Called to freedom

Stay in freedom VERSES 1–12

1 So stand firm in the freedom
for which Christ has set us free.
And don't let yourselves be tied again to a yoke of
slavery.
2 Listen,
I, Paul,
tell you:
If you let yourselves be circumcised,
Christ will be of no use to you.
3 Yes, I testify again to every man
who lets himself be circumcised:
He is obliged
to keep the whole law.
4 You are cut off from Christ,
you
who want to be made righteous by the law.
You have fallen away from grace.
5 For through the Spirit,
by faith,
we wait for the righteousness
that we hope for.
6 For in Christ Jesus neither circumcision
nor uncircumcision counts for anything,
but faith working through love.
7 You were running well!
Who got in your way,
so that you don't obey the truth?
8 This persuasion doesn't come from him
who calls you.
9 A little yeast works through the whole lump of dough.
10 I am confident in the Lord
that you will not think any other way.
But whoever is troubling you
will bear his judgment,
whoever he is.
11 But as for me, brothers:
If I still preached circumcision,
why am I still persecuted?
Then the offense of the cross would be removed.
12 I wish
that those
who are troubling you
would cut themselves off completely!

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Yoke means: a wooden bar put on animals so they can pull loads; here a picture for a heavy burden.

Verse 1: Christ has set us free. Christians should not make themselves dependent again on rules by which they want to earn salvation.

Verses 2–4: Here Paul is speaking to Christians from the nations in Galatia. They thought they also had to be circumcised in order to truly belong to God. Paul says: Whoever does that no longer relies on Christ.

Important: These verses say nothing against the circumcision of Jewish boys. For the Jewish people circumcision is still a sign of the covenant with God today (Genesis 17). Paul himself was circumcised. He also had Timothy circumcised (Acts 16:3).

Verse 6: A key sentence: What matters is "faith working through love."

Verse 12: Here Paul is very angry and uses a crude, biting play on words about circumcision. It shows his anger, but it is no call to harm anyone.

Freedom that serves in love VERSES 13–15

13 For you, brothers,
were called to freedom.
Only don't use your freedom as an excuse for the flesh,
but through love serve one another.
14 For the whole law is fulfilled in one word,
in this:
"You shall love your neighbor as yourself."
15 But if you bite and devour one another,
be careful
that you don't destroy one another.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: Freedom doesn't mean that you can do whatever you want without caring about others. True freedom serves others out of love.

Verse 14 quotes Leviticus 19:18. The commandment to love your neighbor is in the Torah. Paul says: The whole law is summed up in it.

Verse 15: Quarrels in the church can destroy everything.

Spirit and flesh VERSES 16–26

16 But I say:
Walk by the Spirit,
and you won't carry out the desires of the flesh.
17 For the flesh desires what is against the Spirit,
and the Spirit what is against the flesh.
The two are opposed to each other,
so that you don't simply do
what you want.
18 But if you are led by the Spirit,
you are not under the law.
19 The deeds of the flesh are obvious.
They are:
adultery,
sexual immorality,
uncleanness,
wild lust,
20 idolatry,
sorcery,
hatred,
strife,
jealousy,
outbursts of anger,
rivalries,
divisions,
factions,
21 envy,
murders,
drunkenness,
wild parties
and things like these.
I warn you,
as I warned you before:
Those who do such things
will not inherit God's Kingdom.
22 But the fruit of the Spirit is
love,
joy,
peace,
patience,
kindness,
goodness,
faith,
23 gentleness
and self-control.
Against such things there is no law.
24 Those who belong to Christ
have crucified the flesh with its passions and desires.
25 If we live by the Spirit,
let's also walk by the Spirit.
26 Let's not become conceited,
provoking one another
and envying one another.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sorcery means: magic used to harm or control others.

Verses 16–17: "Flesh" here doesn't mean the body, but a life that only looks at itself. "Spirit" means a life led by God's Spirit.

Verses 19–21: Paul lists what destroys community. Many points concern how people live together: hatred, strife, envy, divisions.

Verse 20: "Sorcery" here probably means magical practices used to harm others or to gain power over them.

Verses 22–23: "The fruit of the Spirit": These qualities grow in a person when God's Spirit works in them, like fruit on a tree. You don't have to *make* them by your own strength.

Verse 22: The WEB says "faith." The Greek word can mean *faith* or *faithfulness*. Many interpreters think that in this list it mainly means faithfulness.

Verse 24: "Crucified the flesh" is a picture. It does not mean that you should hurt yourself. If you are thinking about hurting yourself, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

GALATIANS

CHAPTER 6

Carry one another's burdens

Helping one another VERSES 1–10

1 Brothers,
if someone is caught in some wrong,
you
who are spiritual
should gently set that person right again.
And watch yourself,
so that you aren't tempted too.
2 Bear one another's burdens.
In this way you fulfill the law of Christ.
3 For if anyone thinks
that he is something
when he is nothing,
he deceives himself.
4 But each one should examine his own work.
Then he will have a reason to boast in himself,
and not in comparison with someone else.
5 For each one will carry his own load.
6 Whoever is taught the word
should share all good things
with the one
who teaches him.
7 Don't be deceived:
God is not mocked.
For whatever a person sows,
that he will also reap.
8 He who sows to his own flesh
will reap ruin from the flesh.
But he who sows to the Spirit
will reap eternal life from the Spirit.
9 Let's not grow weary
of doing good.
For if we don't give up,
we will reap at the right time.

10 So then,
as long as we have the opportunity,
let's do good to all people,
and especially to those
who belong to the family of faith.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Whoever makes a mistake should not be condemned, but gently brought back onto the right path.

Verse 2: "Bear one another's burdens": Christians help one another in hard times. That is "the law of Christ": the commandment of love.

Verses 2 and 5: This is no contradiction. With heavy burdens we help one another (verse 2). For your own life and actions, everyone is responsible themselves (verse 5).

Verses 7–8: A picture from farming: What you sow, you reap.

Verse 10: Christians should do good to all people, not only to other Christians.

Paul's ending in his own hand VERSES 11–18

11 Look
what large letters I use as I write to you with my own hand!
12 Those
who want to make a good impression outwardly
are forcing you
to be circumcised.
They only do it
so that they won't be persecuted for the cross of Christ.
13 For even those
who are circumcised
don't keep the law themselves.
But they want
you to be circumcised,
so that they can boast about your body.
14 But far be it from me to boast
except in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ.
Through it the world has been crucified to me,
and I to the world.
15 For in Christ Jesus neither circumcision counts for anything,
nor uncircumcision,
but a new creation.
16 As many
as walk by this rule,
peace and mercy be on them,
and on God's Israel.
17 From now on, let no one cause me any trouble.
For I bear the marks of the Lord Jesus on my body.
18 The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit, brothers.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Paul had dictated the letter. He writes the ending himself, with large letters. Perhaps because of poor eyesight (compare 4:15), perhaps to stress his words.

Verses 12–13: Here Paul means the Christian teachers who pressed the Galatians to be circumcised, not the Jewish people in general.

Verse 15: "A new creation": What counts is that God makes people new.

Verse 16: Interpreters understand "God's Israel" in different ways. Some think of Jews who believe in Jesus. Others think of the whole Jewish people, for whom Paul wishes peace and mercy. Still others think of the church made up of Jews and non-Jews.

Important: This verse must not be understood as if the church had replaced Israel. The church claimed this for a long time, and it brought great suffering to the Jewish people. Today the major churches teach: God's covenant with Israel remains valid (compare Romans 11:29).

Verse 17: "The marks of the Lord Jesus" are probably the scars Paul had from beatings and persecution (compare 2 Corinthians 11:23–25).

Looking back: What have we read in the letter to the Galatians?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A passionate letter: Paul writes in great distress to the churches in Galatia. Christian teachers wanted to make circumcision a duty for Christians from the nations.

Good News for everyone: God accepts people from all nations, through faith in Christ, by grace (chapters 1 to 3).

Abraham: Abraham trusted God. All who trust God belong to his family (chapter 3).

All are one: In Christ all are of equal worth, whether Jew or Greek, slave or free, man or woman (3:28).

Freedom: Christ has set us free. This freedom shows itself in serving one another in love (chapter 5).

The fruit of the Spirit: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faith (or: faithfulness), gentleness and self-control (5:22–23).

Carrying one another: Christians help one another in hard times (6:2).

A very important note: The letter to the Galatians is an argument among Christians. It is not an attack on Judaism. Paul remained a Jew. For Jews the Torah is still a gift from God today.

For today: No one has to earn God's love. And no one may shut others out because they are different.

What comes next? Next comes the letter to the Ephesians. It is about the one church made up of Jews and people from all nations, about God's grace and about life as Christians in everyday life.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 49 OF 66

EPHESIANS

6 CHAPTERS

EPHESIANS

Chapter 1

Blessed in Christ

Before we begin: The letter to the Ephesians

Ephesus was a large port city in what is now Turkey. A famous temple of the goddess Artemis stood there. Paul lived and worked in Ephesus for several years (Acts 19).

The letter calls itself a letter from Paul. Many scholars today think that it was written by a student of Paul, in Paul's spirit. Others consider Paul himself to be the author. The letter was probably written in prison (3:1; 4:1). Some old manuscripts don't have the words *at Ephesus* in verse 1. Perhaps the letter was meant for several churches.

The great theme is the one church: Jews and people from all nations have grown together into one people through Christ. Christ has overcome the separation between them.

The second part (chapters 4 to 6) is about life as a Christian in everyday life.

Important note: In chapters 5 and 6 there are rules for married couples, children, parents, slaves and masters. They reflect the order of society at that time. In the boxes we explain how Christians understand them today.

The letter to the Ephesians has 6 chapters.

Greeting VERSES 1–2

1 Paul,
an apostle of Christ Jesus through the will of God,
writes to the saints who are at Ephesus,
the faithful in Christ Jesus.
2 Grace to you and peace
from God our Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Saints" are all Christians. They belong to God.

Praise to God VERSES 3–14

3 Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ.
He has blessed us in Christ
with every spiritual blessing
in the heavenly places.
4 For he chose us in him
before the foundation of the world.
We were to be holy and without fault before him,
in love.
5 He decided beforehand
that we would become his children
through Jesus Christ.
That is what he wanted,
because it gave him joy.
6 This happened to the praise of his glorious grace.
He freely gave us this grace
in the Beloved.
7 In him we have redemption through his blood,
the forgiveness of our wrongs,
according to the riches of his grace.
8 He gave us this grace in rich measure,
with all wisdom and understanding.
9 He made known to us the mystery of his will.
That is how he decided it in Christ,
because it pleased him.
10 He wanted to carry it out
when the times are fulfilled:
All things are to be brought together in Christ,
the things in the heavens and the things on the earth,
in him.
11 In him we have also received an inheritance.
We were chosen for it beforehand
according to the plan of him
who does all things according to the purpose of his will.
12 We are to be to the praise of his glory,
we
who had hoped in Christ before.
13 In him you also,
when you heard the word of the truth,
the Good News of your salvation,
and when you believed,
were sealed with the promised Holy Spirit.
14 He is a pledge of our inheritance,
until God fully sets free his own possession,
to the praise of his glory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Pledge means: something given as a guarantee that a promise will be kept.

In Greek, verses 3–14 are one single very long sentence, a great song of praise to God. We have divided it into short sentences.

Verses 4–5: "Chose" and "decided beforehand": God's love for us was already there before we lived. Christians have thought much about these words and thought differently about them. Here they are mainly meant to comfort: God wanted us.

Verse 10: God wants to bring together again in Christ everything that is broken and separated.

Verses 12–13: "We who had hoped in Christ before" probably means the Christians of Jewish background. "You also" means the Christians from the nations. Both belong together.

Verses 13–14: The Holy Spirit is like a seal and like a down payment: He shows that we belong to God, and he guarantees that God will keep his whole promise.

Prayer for the church VERSES 15–23

15 That is why I too,
since I heard of your faith in the Lord Jesus
and of your love for all the saints,

16 have not stopped
giving thanks for you.
I remember you in my prayers.
17 I pray
that the God of our Lord Jesus Christ,
the Father of glory,
may give you a spirit of wisdom and revelation,
so that you know him.
18 May he enlighten the eyes of your hearts,
so that you know
what the hope of his calling is,
how rich the glory of his inheritance among the saints is,
19 and how surpassingly great his power is toward us
who believe.
This power works with the strength of his might.
20 With this power he worked in Christ
when he raised him from the dead
and seated him at his right hand in the heavenly places,
21 far above all rule,
authority,
power
and dominion,
and above every name
that is named,
not only in this age,
but also in the age to come.
22 He put all things under his feet.
And he gave him to the church as head over all things.
23 The church is his body,
the fullness of him
who fills all in all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: "The eyes of your hearts": There are things you don't see with your eyes, but only recognize with your heart.

Verse 20: "At his right hand" is a picture: Christ has the highest honor and power (compare Psalm 110:1).

Verse 21: Christ stands above all powers that make people afraid.

Verse 22 takes up Psalm 8:6 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 8:7).

Verses 22–23: Christ is the head, the church is his body. It cannot live without him.

EPHESIANS

CHAPTER 2

Saved by grace

Made alive by God VERSES 1–10

1 You too were made alive
when you were dead in your wrongs and sins.
2 You once lived in them,
according to the course of this world,
according to the will of the ruler
who rules over the power of the air.
That is the spirit
who now works in the children of disobedience.
3 We all once lived among them too,
in the desires of our flesh.
We did
what the flesh and the mind wanted.
And we were by nature children of anger,
like the rest.
4 But God is rich in mercy.
He loved us with his great love.
5 Even when we were dead through our wrongs,
he made us alive together with Christ.
By grace you have been saved!
6 He raised us up with him
and seated us with him in the heavenly places,
in Christ Jesus.
7 In this way he wanted to show in the ages to come
how overflowing the riches of his grace are,
in his kindness toward us in Christ Jesus.
8 For by grace you have been saved
through faith.
And that is not from yourselves.
It is the gift of God.
9 It is not from works,
so that no one can boast.
10 For we are his workmanship,
created in Christ Jesus
for good works.
God prepared the good works beforehand,
so that we would walk in them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–3: Without God a person is as if dead, even while living. This is true for everyone, for Jews and for people from the nations ("we all," verse 3).

Verse 2: The ruler "who rules over the power of the air" is the power of evil, Satan. At that time people imagined that evil powers ruled in the air between heaven and earth.

Verse 3: "Children of anger" is a Hebrew way of speaking. It means: people who would have deserved God's judgment.

Verses 8–9 are among the most important verses about grace: Salvation is a gift from God. No one can earn it.

Verse 10: Good works are not the way to salvation, but its fruit. Whoever has received God's gift does good.

Christ breaks down the dividing wall VERSES 11–22

11 So remember:
You were once people from the nations
by birth.
You were called "uncircumcision"
by those
who are called "circumcision,"
with a circumcision in the body,
made by human hands.
12 At that time you were without Christ.
You were shut out from the commonwealth of Israel.

You were strangers to the covenants of the promise.
You had no hope
and were without God in the world.
13 But now in Christ Jesus
you
who once were far off
have been brought near by the blood of Christ.
14 For he is our peace.
He made both one.
He broke down the dividing wall
that stood between them.
15 In his body he did away with the hostility,
the law of commandments contained in ordinances.
In this way he wanted to create in himself one new man of the two
and make peace.
16 And he wanted to reconcile both to God in one body through the cross.
Through the cross he killed the hostility.
17 He came and preached peace
to you
who were far off
and to those
who were near.
18 For through him we both have access
in one Spirit to the Father.
19 So you are no longer strangers and foreigners without rights,
but you are fellow citizens with the saints
and of the household of God.
20 You are built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets.
And the cornerstone is Christ Jesus himself.
21 In him the whole building is fitted together
and grows into a holy temple in the Lord.
22 In him you also are built in
to become a home where God lives in the Spirit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Commonwealth means: a community of citizens who belong together.

Verse 12: The letter reminds the Christians from the nations: Israel had God's covenants and promises. You were once shut out from them. Israel is the starting point.

Verse 13: "Far off" means the people from the nations. Through Christ they have been brought near, near to God and near to Israel.

Verse 14: "The dividing wall": In the temple in Jerusalem there was a wall. Non-Jews were not allowed to go further in. The letter says: In Christ this separation is overcome.

Verse 15: "The law of commandments contained in ordinances" probably means mainly the rules that separated Jews and non-Jews from each other. Interpreters understand this verse in different ways.

Important: The letter does not say that Israel is replaced. It says: The people from the nations are added to Israel. They become "fellow citizens" (verse 19). Jews and Christians from the nations are to live together in peace.

Verse 17 takes up Isaiah 57:19: *Peace, peace, to him who is far off and to him who is near.*

Verse 20: The cornerstone was the most important stone of a building. Everything was lined up by it.

For today: Christ overcomes hostility between people and nations. Christians should tear down walls, not build new ones.

EPHESIANS

CHAPTER 3

God's mystery and his great love

The mystery: All nations belong VERSES 1–13

1 For this reason I, Paul,
am the prisoner of Christ Jesus
for you people from the nations.
2 You have surely heard
what task God in his grace has given me for you.
3 By a revelation the mystery was made known to me,
as I already wrote briefly above.
4 When you read this,
you can understand
how I understand the mystery of Christ.
5 In earlier generations
it was not made known to people.
But now God has revealed it to his holy apostles and prophets
through the Spirit:
6 The people from the nations are fellow heirs.
They are fellow members of the same body.
And they share in the same promise
in Christ Jesus through the Good News.
7 I serve this Good News.
That is a gift of God's grace,
which was given to me through the working of his power.
8 To me,
the very least of all saints,
this grace was given:
I may preach to the nations the unsearchable riches of Christ.
9 I may show all people
how God carries out his mystery.
For ages it was hidden in God,
who created all things through Jesus Christ.
10 So now, through the church,
the many-sided wisdom of God
is to be made known to the rulers and powers in the heavenly places.
11 This is according to the eternal purpose
that God carried out in Christ Jesus our Lord.
12 In him we have boldness
and access to God in confidence
through our faith in him.

13 So I ask you:
Don't lose heart because of my troubles for you.
They are your glory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here, mystery means: God's plan that was hidden for a long time and is now revealed.

Verse 1: The letter was written in prison. Paul was often in prison because he preached the Good News.

Verse 6: The "mystery" is: The people from the nations also belong to God's people. They are "fellow heirs," they inherit together with Israel. They stand beside Israel, not in its place.

Verse 8: "To me, the very least of all saints": Paul sees himself humbly. He knows that he once persecuted Christians.

Verse 10: The church, in which people from all nations live together, is a sign of God's wisdom, even for the invisible powers.

Verse 12: Through Jesus we may come to God boldly and with confidence.

Prayer for strength and love VERSES 14–21

14 For this reason I bow my knees to the Father of our
Lord Jesus Christ.
15 From him every family in heaven and on earth is
named.
16 I pray
that, according to the riches of his glory, he will grant
you
to be strengthened with power through his Spirit in
the inner person,
17 that Christ may live in your hearts through faith,
and that you are rooted and grounded in love.
18 In this way you are to receive strength, together with
all the saints,
to understand
how wide and long and high and deep
19 the love of Christ is.
You are to know it,
even though it surpasses all knowledge.
So may you be filled with all the fullness of God.
20 God is able to do far more
than all that we ask or think,
through the power
that works in us.
21 To him be the glory in the church
and in Christ Jesus,
to all generations,
forever and ever.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: At that time people usually prayed standing. Kneeling showed special reverence and urgency.

Verse 15: In Greek, "Father" (pater) and "family" (patria) sound similar. God is the source of every family and community.

Verse 17: "Rooted and grounded in love": like a tree that has deep roots and therefore stands firm.

Verses 18–19: The love of Christ is so great that you can never fully grasp it. And yet we may experience it.

Verses 20–21: A song of praise at the end of the first part of the letter: God can do much more than we can imagine.

EPHESIANS

CHAPTER 4

One body and a new life

Keep the unity VERSES 1–6

1 So I,
the prisoner in the Lord,
beg you:
Live in a way
that is worthy of the calling
with which you were called.
2 Be completely humble and gentle.
Be patient
and bear with one another in love.
3 Be eager
to keep the unity of the Spirit
in the bond of peace.
4 There is one body and one Spirit,
just as you were also called in one hope.
5 There is one Lord,
one faith,
one baptism,
6 one God and Father of all.
He is over all,
through all
and in all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: "Bear with one another in love": In every community there are differences and sometimes anger. Love helps people put up with one another.

Verses 4–6: Seven times the word "one" appears here: one body, one Spirit, one hope, one Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God. These verses are very important for ecumenism, the way the churches live together. All Christians are connected through the one baptism.

Different gifts for the one body VERSES 7–16

7 But to each one of us grace was given,
according to the measure that Christ gave.
8 That is why it says:
"When he ascended on high,
he led captivity captive,
and gave gifts to people."
9 But what does "He ascended" mean?
Only
that he also first descended
into the lower parts of the earth.
10 He who descended
is also the one

who ascended far above all the heavens,
that he might fill all things.
11 And he gave some to be apostles,
some to be prophets,
some to be evangelists,
some to be shepherds and teachers.
12 They are to equip the saints for the work of serving,
so that the body of Christ is built up,
13 until we all attain to the unity of the faith
and of the knowledge of the Son of God,
to a mature,
full-grown person,
to the full measure of the fullness of Christ.
14 Then we are no longer children
who are tossed back and forth
and carried about by every wind of teaching,
by the trickery of people,
by their craftiness,
with which they lead others astray.
15 But speaking truth in love,
we want to grow up in all things into him
who is the head:
Christ.
16 From him the whole body is fitted
and held together
by every joint
that supplies it.
Each individual part works according to its measure.
In this way the body grows
and builds itself up in love.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Evangelists means: people who spread the Good News.

Verse 8 takes up Psalm 68:18 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 68:19). The letter applies the psalm to Christ.

Verse 9: "The lower parts of the earth": Some understand this as Jesus coming to earth, others as his way into the realm of the dead.

Verses 11–12: Leaders in the church have the task of equipping all the others for their service. Every Christian has a service.

Verse 15: "Speaking truth in love": Truth without love can hurt. Love without truth can deceive. Both belong together.

Verse 16: Every part of the body is important, even the smallest.

The old and the new person VERSES 17–24

17 So this I say
and testify in the Lord:
No longer live
the way the rest of the nations live,
with their empty thinking.
18 Their understanding is darkened.
They are cut off from the life of God
because they are ignorant
and their hearts are hardened.
19 They have become callous
and have given themselves up to lust,
to practice every kind of uncleanness with greed.
20 But you didn't learn Christ that way.
21 You have heard of him
and were taught in him,
just as truth is in Jesus:
22 You are to put away the old man,
who belongs to your former way of life
and is being ruined by deceitful desires.
23 You are to be renewed in the spirit of your mind
24 and put on the new man,
who has been created in the likeness of God,
in true righteousness and holiness.
Righteousness means: living right before God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 17–19: The letter describes the former life of the Christians from the nations without God. This is no judgment on all people of other religions today.

Verses 22–24: A picture from everyday life: You take off old clothes and put on new ones. In the same way a person can begin a new life with Christ.

Verse 24: "In the likeness of God" recalls creation (Genesis 1:27).

How a new person lives VERSES 25–32

25 So put away falsehood
and speak truth,
each one with his neighbor.
For we are members of one another.
26 "Be angry,
and don't sin."
Don't let the sun go down on your anger.
27 And don't give the devil a place.
28 Whoever stole
should steal no more.
Rather he should work
and produce something good with his own hands,
so that he has something
to give to those in need.
29 Let no corrupt speech come out of your mouth,
but only what is good,
what builds others up
where it is needed,
so that it does good
to those
who hear.
30 And don't grieve the Holy Spirit of God.
In him you were sealed for the day of redemption.
31 Let all bitterness,
rage,
anger,
outcry
and slander
be put away from you,
together with all malice.
32 But be kind to one another
and tenderhearted.
Forgive one another,
just as God also forgave you in Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Slander means: saying bad and untrue things about others.

Verse 25 recalls Zechariah 8:16.

Verse 26: "Be angry, and don't sin." These words take up Psalm 4:4 (in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 4:5). Anger in itself is not sin. But you should not hold on to it. Good advice: Settle a quarrel on the same day if you can.

Important: Whoever has experienced injustice or violence may be angry. That is a healthy feeling. Forgiveness often needs time, and it does not mean that you have to accept injustice. If you experience violence at home, you can get help. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 28: Work is not only for yourself, but also to help others.

Verse 29: Words can build up or destroy. That is also true on the internet.

Verse 32: God has forgiven us. That is why we too can forgive one another.

EPHESIANS

CHAPTER 5

Living as children of light

Live in love VERSES 1–7

1 So follow God's example,
as his dearly loved children.
2 Live in love,
just as Christ also loved us.
He gave himself up for us,
as an offering and a sacrifice to God,
like a sweet-smelling fragrance.
3 But sexual immorality,
any kind of uncleanness
or greed
should not even be mentioned among you.
That is fitting for saints.
Saints means: God's holy people.
4 Also no shameful behavior,
no foolish talk
and no crude jokes.
They are not fitting.
Instead, give thanks.
5 For know this for sure:
No sexually immoral person,
no unclean person
and no greedy person
– greed is idolatry –
has an inheritance in the Kingdom of Christ and God.
Idolatry means: worshiping idols, false gods.
6 Let no one deceive you with empty words.
For because of these things God's anger comes
on the people who disobey.
7 So don't join in with them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: Christians are to imitate God, just as children imitate their parents. The most important example is the love of Jesus.

Verse 4: "Crude jokes" means jokes that put others down or hurt them.

Verse 5: "Greed is idolatry": Whoever always wants more makes money and possessions into their god.

Children of light VERSES 8–14

8 For you were once darkness.
But now you are light in the Lord.
Live as children of light.
9 For the fruit of the Spirit shows itself
in all goodness,
righteousness
and truth.
10 Test
what pleases the Lord.
11 Have nothing to do with the deeds of darkness,
which bear no fruit.
Instead, expose them.
12 For what these people do in secret,
it is a shame even to speak of it.
13 But everything
that is exposed
is made visible by the light.
For everything
that makes things visible
is light.
14 That is why it says:
"Wake up,
you who are sleeping,
and rise from the dead,
and Christ will shine on you."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Not only: *You have light*, but: *You are light*. Christians are to make things bright through their lives.

Verse 9: Here it says "the fruit of the Spirit," as in the WEB, our English source text. Some old manuscripts say *the fruit of the light*.

Verses 11–13: Wrong should not be kept quiet, but exposed.

For today: That is also true for wrongdoing and abuse in churches and families. Looking away only helps the abusers. If you experience abuse or know about it, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673.

Verse 14 is perhaps a song of the first Christians that was sung at baptism.

Live wisely VERSES 15–21

15 So watch carefully
how you live:
not as unwise people,
but as wise people.
16 Make good use of the time,
because the days are evil.
17 So don't be foolish,
but understand
what the will of the Lord is.
18 Don't get drunk with wine,
for that leads to a wild life.
Instead, be filled with the Spirit.

19 Speak to one another in psalms,
hymns
and spiritual songs.
Sing and make music to the Lord in your heart.
20 Always give thanks to God the Father
for everything
in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ.
21 Subject yourselves to one another
in the fear of Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: "Make good use of the time": Every day is a chance to do good.

Verse 18: If you have problems with alcohol, you can find help at addiction counseling services. US: SAMHSA 1-800-662-4357. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 19: Singing and music have always been part of Christian worship.

Verse 21 is very important: "Subject yourselves to one another." This applies to all Christians toward each other. This verse is the heading for the following section about marriage.

Husband and wife in marriage VERSES 22–33

22 Wives,
be subject to your own husbands,
as to the Lord.
23 For the husband is the head of the wife,
just as Christ also is the head of the church.
He himself is the Savior of the body.
24 But as the church is subject to Christ,
so the wives are also to be subject to their own
husbands in everything.
25 Husbands,
love your wives,
just as Christ also loved the church
and gave himself up for her.
26 He did this to make her holy.
He cleansed her
by the washing of water with the word.
27 He wanted to present the church to himself in glory,
without spot
or wrinkle
or any such thing,
but holy and without fault.
28 In the same way husbands also ought to love their own
wives
as their own bodies.
He who loves his own wife
loves himself.
29 For no one ever hated his own body.
Instead, he feeds it and takes care of it,
just as the Lord also does for the church.
30 For we are parts of his body,
of his flesh and bones.
31 "For this reason a man will leave his father and mother
and will be joined to his wife.
Then the two will become one flesh."
32 This mystery is great.
But I am speaking about Christ and the church.
33 But each of you must also love his own wife
as himself.
And the wife should respect her husband.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 22–33 are called a "household code." Such rules for living together in the family existed in many writings at that time. In the society of that time, the husband had authority over the wife.

What is new and unusual: Everything stands under verse 21: "Subject yourselves to one another." And much is asked of the husbands: They are to love their wives the way Christ loves the church. He gave his life for her. That is a love that serves, not one that rules.

Verse 23: "Head" can mean *ruler over*, but also *source* or *the one who cares for* (compare verse 29). Interpreters understand it in different ways.

Today many churches and Christians understand marriage as a partnership of two people with equal rights who love and respect each other. Other Christians hold on to a special responsibility of the husband. All stress: It is about love, not about power.

Very important: These verses give no one the right to rule over their spouse, to oppress them or to use violence. Violence in marriage is a serious wrong and a crime. No one has to put up with it. You can get help, also at shelters for women. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 31 quotes Genesis 2:24.

Verse 32: Love in marriage is a picture of the love between Christ and his church.

EPHESIANS

CHAPTER 6

Strong in the power of the Lord

Children and parents VERSES 1–4

1 Children,
obey your parents in the Lord.
For this is right.
2 "Honor your father and mother."
That is the first commandment with a promise:
3 "that it may be well with you,
and you may live long on the earth."
4 And you fathers,
don't provoke your children to anger,
but bring them up in the discipline and instruction of
the Lord.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 2–3 quote the commandment from Exodus 20:12 and Deuteronomy 5:16.

Verse 4: For that time this was new: Fathers also have duties. They must not provoke their children, treat them unfairly or discourage them.

Very important: "Obey your parents in the Lord" does not mean that children have to do everything their parents demand. No child has to put up with violence, abuse or humiliation. In many countries children have a legal right to be raised without violence. Children and young people can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. Parents who need support can also call Childhelp.

Slaves and masters VERSES 5–9

5 Servants,
obey your earthly masters
with fear and trembling,
with a sincere heart,
as to Christ.
6 Don't do it only
when eyes are on you,
to please people,
but as servants of Christ,
doing the will of God from the heart.
7 Serve with good will,
as if you were serving the Lord
and not people.
8 For you know:
Whatever good someone does,
he will receive it back from the Lord,
whether he is a slave or free.
9 And you masters,
treat them the same way.
Stop threatening.
For you know:
You and they have the same Master in heaven.
And there is no partiality with him.
Partiality means: treating some people better than others.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: The WEB says *servants* here. The Greek word means slaves. At the time of the letter there were very many slaves. Christians, too, were slaves or owned slaves.

Verse 9: What was new: The masters are also addressed. They must not threaten. Before God masters and slaves are equal.

Very important: Slavery is a grave injustice. These verses were later misused to justify slavery. That was wrong. Many Christians fought against slavery. Today there is still human trafficking and forced labor. Christians should stand up against it.

For today: These verses also don't mean that employees have to put up with everything. You may speak up about exploitation and injustice at work and fight against them.

The armor of God VERSES 10–20

10 Finally:
Be strong in the Lord
and in the strength of his might.
11 Put on the whole armor of God,
so that you can stand against the tricks of the devil.
Armor is protective clothing for soldiers.
12 For our struggle is not against flesh and blood,
but against the rulers,
against the powers,
against the world's rulers of the darkness of this age,
against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly places.
13 So put on the whole armor of God,
so that you can resist on the evil day
and,
having done everything,
stand firm.
14 So stand firm:
Put on the belt of truth around your waist.
Put on the breastplate of righteousness.
A breastplate is a piece of armor that protects the chest.
15 As shoes for your feet, put on the readiness
to proclaim the Good News of peace.
16 Above all, take up the shield of faith.
With it you can put out all the flaming arrows of the evil one.
17 Also take the helmet of salvation
and the sword of the Spirit.
That is the word of God.
18 Pray at all times in the Spirit
with all prayers and requests.
Stay alert and keep at it,
and pray for all the saints.
19 Pray for me too,
that the right words may be given to me
when I open my mouth,
so that I boldly make known the mystery of the Good News.
20 For this Good News I am an ambassador in chains.
Pray
that I may speak boldly about it,
as I ought to speak.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: "Not against flesh and blood": Christians do not fight against people. They fight against evil, against lies, hatred and injustice.

Verses 13–17: The letter uses the picture of a Roman soldier. But all the "weapons" are spiritual: truth, righteousness, peace, faith, salvation and God's word. Almost all the parts are for protection.

Verses 14–17 recall Isaiah 11:5 and 59:17, where God himself is *armed* with righteousness and salvation.

Very important: This text is no call to violence or war. In history it was sometimes misused that way. That was wrong. The "shoes" are the readiness to proclaim peace (verse 15).

Verses 18–20: Prayer is the most important strength. The author is in prison ("in chains") and asks for prayer.

Greetings and blessing VERSES 21–24

21 So that you also may know
how I am and what I am doing,

Tychicus will tell you everything.
He is a dear brother
and a faithful servant in the Lord.
22 I have sent him to you for this very purpose,
so that you may know
how we are,
and so that he may comfort your hearts.
23 Peace be to the brothers,
and love with faith,
from God the Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ.
24 Grace be with all
who love our Lord Jesus Christ
with undying love.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21: Tychicus was a coworker of Paul (compare Acts 20:4 and Colossians 4:7). He probably delivered the letter.

Looking back: What have we read in the letter to the Ephesians?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God's great plan: God wants to bring together in Christ everything that is separated (chapter 1).

Saved by grace: No one can earn salvation. It is God's gift (chapter 2).

The dividing wall is broken down: People from all nations belong to God's people together with Israel. They are fellow heirs, not a replacement for Israel (chapters 2 and 3).

God's love: It is wider, longer, higher and deeper than we can understand (chapter 3).

One body: One Lord, one faith, one baptism. All Christians belong together (chapter 4).

A new life: Speaking the truth, forgiving, being kind, living as children of light (chapters 4 and 5).

The household code: Rules for marriage, family and work from that time. What matters is: Everyone is to serve one another. No one may use violence (chapters 5 and 6).

The armor of God: Christians do not fight against people, but against evil, with truth, faith and peace (chapter 6).

For today: Christ is our peace. Christians are to tear down walls between people.

What comes next? Next comes the letter to the Philippians. Paul writes it from prison, and yet it is a letter full of joy.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 50 OF 66

PHILIPPIANS

4 CHAPTERS

PHILIPPIANS

Chapter 1

To live is Christ

Before we begin: The letter to the Philippians

Philippi was a Roman city in the north of what is now Greece. There Paul founded the first Christian church in Europe (Acts 16). Among the first Christians there were the businesswoman Lydia and a jailer with his family.

Paul had an especially warm relationship with this church. The Christians in Philippi supported him again and again, also with money.

Paul writes the letter from prison. He doesn't know whether he will be set free or executed. Where the prison was is not certain: perhaps in Rome, perhaps in Ephesus or in Caesarea.

And yet it is a letter full of joy. The words "joy" and "rejoice" appear very often.

In chapter 2 there is a famous song about Jesus, who humbled himself.

The letter to the Philippians has 4 chapters.

Greeting VERSES 1–2

1 Paul and Timothy,
servants of Jesus Christ,
write to all the saints in Christ Jesus
who are at Philippi,
with the overseers and servants:

2 Grace to you and peace
from God our Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Timothy was a close coworker of Paul. He was there when the church in Philippi was founded.

"Saints" are all Christians. They belong to God.

"Overseers and servants": These are leadership roles in the church. Later these words became the offices of *bishop* and *deacon*. At that time they were probably organized more simply.

Thanks and prayer for the church VERSES 3–11

3 I thank my God
every time
I remember you.

4 Always,
when I pray for you all,
I pray with joy.

5 For you are my partners
in the Good News,
from the first day until now.

6 And I am completely sure:
God began a good work in you.
He will also complete it
until the day of Jesus Christ.

7 It is right
for me to think this way about all of you.
For I have you in my heart.
You all share with me in grace:
when I am in chains
and when I defend the Good News
and confirm it.

8 For God is my witness
how I long for all of you
with the tender love of Christ Jesus.

9 And so I pray
that your love may grow richer and richer
in knowledge
and in all discernment.
Discernment means: the ability to judge well what is right.

10 So that you can test
what is truly excellent.
So may you be sincere
and without blame
until the day of Christ,

11 filled with the fruit of righteousness
that comes through Jesus Christ,
to the glory and praise of God.
Righteousness means: living right before God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: Already here we find the word "joy." It runs through the whole letter.

Verse 5: "Partners": The church supported Paul with prayer and with money. It shared in his work (compare 4:15–16).

Verse 6 is a word of comfort: God doesn't give up on what he has begun. Even if we ourselves are not finished yet.

Verses 9–10: Love is not blind. It needs understanding, so that you see what really helps.

Prison helps the Good News VERSES 12–18

12 I want you to know,
brothers:
What has happened to me
has actually helped the Good News.

13 For it has become clear to the whole palace guard
and to all the rest
that I am in chains because of Christ.

14 And most of the brothers in the Lord
have gained confidence through my chains.
They are much bolder
to speak the word of God without fear.

15 Some indeed preach Christ out of envy and strife,
but others out of good will.

16 The former preach Christ insincerely,
out of selfish ambition.
They think
they are making my suffering in chains even harder.

17 The others do it out of love.
They know:
I am appointed
to defend the Good News.

18 What does it matter?
The main thing is
that Christ is proclaimed,
in every way,
whether in pretense or in truth.
I rejoice in this.
Yes,
and I will go on rejoicing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: "Palace guard": These were soldiers who guarded Paul. They learned why he was a prisoner. So they heard about Jesus.

Verses 15–17: Paul names no names. There were probably other preachers who competed with him.

Verse 18: Paul is generous. It doesn't matter to him who is right or becomes famous. What matters to him is that people hear about Jesus.

For today: Among Christians, too, there is envy and competition. Paul shows another way: to rejoice when good things happen, even when others do them.

Life or death VERSES 19–26

19 For I know:
This will turn out for my salvation,
through your prayers
and the help of the Spirit of Jesus Christ.
20 This is my eager expectation and hope:
I will in no way be disappointed.
But with all boldness,
as always,
so now also,
Christ will be honored in my body,
whether by my life
or by my death.
21 For to me to live is Christ,
and to die is gain.
22 But if I go on living in this body,
my work will bear fruit.
Yet I don't know
what I should choose.
23 I am torn between the two.
I have the desire
to depart and be with Christ.
That would be far better.
24 But it is more necessary for your sake
that I remain in this body.
25 And because I am convinced of this,
I know:
I will remain.
Yes,
I will remain with you all,
so that you make progress in the faith
and have joy.
26 So you will have even more reason
to boast in Christ Jesus
because of me,
when I am with you again.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: "Salvation" can mean here: being set free from prison. It can also mean: being saved by God, no matter how the trial ends.

Verse 21: A famous sentence. Paul means: My whole life belongs to Christ. And if I die, I lose nothing, because then I am with Christ.

Verses 22–24: Paul is in prison and has to expect to be executed. He says honestly: To be with Christ would be good. But he chooses life, because others need him.

Very important: These verses are no encouragement to end your own life. Paul chooses life (verses 24–25). If you long for death because life is too hard, you are not alone. Please talk to someone about it. Help is available around the clock. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Stand firm together VERSES 27–30

27 Only one thing:
Let your way of life be worthy of the Good News of Christ.
Whether I come and see you
or am absent:
I want to hear about you,
that you stand firm in one spirit,
that you strive together with one soul
for the faith of the Good News.
28 Don't be frightened in anything by your opponents.
For them this is a sign of destruction,
but for you a sign of salvation,
and that from God.
29 For it has been granted to you
for the sake of Christ:
not only to believe in him,
but also to suffer for him.
30 You have the same struggle
that you saw in me
and now hear
that I am in.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 27: The Greek word for "way of life" here literally means *to live as citizens*. Philippi was proud of its Roman citizenship. Paul says: Live as good citizens of God's Kingdom.

Verse 28: The church in Philippi had opponents in the city. The letter doesn't say exactly who they were.

Verses 29–30: Suffering is not something good in itself. But whoever belongs to Christ can get into trouble for it. Paul himself was beaten in Philippi and thrown into prison (Acts 16:22–24). The church saw this happen.

For today: Today, too, Christians are persecuted for their faith in many countries. We are to pray for them and stand up for freedom of religion for all people.

PHILIPPIANS

CHAPTER 2

The song of Christ

Be one and think of others VERSES 1–4

1 So is there any encouragement in Christ among you?
Is there any comfort from love?
Is there any fellowship in the Spirit?
Is there any tenderness and compassion?
2 Then make my joy full:
Be of one mind.
Have the same love.
Be of one heart
and have the same goal.
3 Do nothing out of rivalry
or out of conceit.
But be humble.
Each one should count others better
than himself.
Conceit means: thinking too highly of yourself.
4 Each of you should not only look to his own things,
but also to the things
of others.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: Paul wishes that the church sticks together. That makes him glad, even though he is in prison.

Verse 3: "Count others better" doesn't mean making yourself small or letting yourself be used. It means: Others matter to me, not just I myself.

Verse 4: A simple sentence for every day: Don't only ask *What do I need?* but also *What does the other person need?*

The song of Christ VERSES 5–11

5 Have the same attitude
that Christ Jesus also had:
6 He existed in the form of God.
But he didn't think of
equality with God
as something to hold on to.
7 Rather, he emptied himself.
He took the form of a servant
and was made like human beings.
8 And when he lived as a human being,
he humbled himself.
He became obedient to the point of death,
yes,
even death on a cross.
9 Therefore God also raised him to the highest place.
He gave him the name
which is above every name.
10 So at the name of Jesus
every knee should bow:
in heaven,
on earth
and under the earth.
11 And every tongue should confess:
Jesus Christ is Lord!
This happens to the glory of God the Father.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–11 are probably a song or poem of the first Christians. Paul quotes it or wrote it himself. It is one of the oldest texts about Jesus.

The song has two parts: First Jesus goes the way down (verses 6–8): from God to human being, from human being to servant, from servant to death on the cross. Then God raises him up high (verses 9–11).

Verse 6: Jesus did not use his power for himself. He did not cling to it like a prize grabbed in war.

Verse 7: "He emptied himself": He gave up his glory and became fully human. Christians have discussed a lot how exactly to understand this.

Verse 8: Death on the cross was the cruelest and most shameful punishment of the Romans. No one could sink lower.

Verses 10–11 take up Isaiah 45:23: "To me every knee will bow, every tongue will swear loyalty." There God speaks, the God of Israel. The song says: Whoever honors Jesus as Lord honors God the Father by doing so.

Verse 5: The beginning is important: This song is to be our example. Christians are not to strive to get to the top, but to serve one another, just as Jesus did.

Live out your faith VERSES 12–18

12 So then,
my dear friends:
You have always obeyed,
not only
when I was with you,
but now much more
when I am absent.
Work out your own salvation
with fear and trembling.
13 For it is God
who works in you.
He gives you the will
and the doing,
as it pleases him.
14 Do all things
without complaining
and arguing,
15 so that you may be blameless and innocent,
children of God without fault,
in the middle of a crooked and twisted generation.
Among them you shine
as lights in the world.
16 Hold up the word of life.
Then I can be proud on the day of Christ
that I didn't run in vain
nor labor in vain.
17 Yes,
and even if my life
is poured out like a drink offering
on the sacrifice and service of your faith:
I am glad and rejoice with you all.
18 In the same way, you also should be glad
and rejoice with me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 12–13: These two verses belong together. We are to make an effort in our faith. But at the same time we know: God himself works in us. Salvation is not earned, but it is to become visible in our lives.

"With fear and trembling" doesn't mean: living in fear of God. It means: taking the matter seriously.

Verse 14 recalls Israel in the wilderness, which often complained (compare Exodus 16). Verse 15 takes up words from Deuteronomy 32:5.

Verse 15: "Lights in the world": Christians are to show through their lives how good God is. This is no arrogance toward others.

Verse 17: A drink offering was wine that was poured out at a sacrifice. Paul is thinking that he might be executed. Still he speaks of joy.

Timothy VERSES 19–24

19 I hope in the Lord Jesus
to send Timothy to you soon.
Then I too will be cheered up
when I learn
how you are doing.
20 For I have no one else
who thinks like me
and who will truly care about you.
21 For they all seek their own interests,
not the things of Jesus Christ.
22 But you know
that Timothy has proved himself.
As a child serves a father,
so he served with me for the Good News.
23 So I hope to send him at once,
as soon as I see
how it will go with me.
24 But I trust in the Lord
that I myself will also come soon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 20–22: Timothy was like a son to Paul. He lives what the song of Christ says: He thinks of others, not of himself.

Verse 21: Paul is disappointed in other coworkers. He doesn't say whom he means.

Verses 23–24: Paul is waiting for the verdict in his trial. He hopes to be set free.

Epaphroditus VERSES 25–30

25 But I thought it necessary
to send Epaphroditus to you.
He is my brother,
my fellow worker
and fellow soldier.
He is your apostle
and has helped me in my need.
26 For he longed for you all.
And he was very troubled
because you had heard
that he was sick.
27 He was indeed sick nearly to death.
But God had mercy on him.
And not only on him,
but on me also,
so that I would not have sorrow on sorrow.
28 That is why I am sending him all the sooner,
so that you may rejoice
when you see him again,
and that I may be less sorrowful.
29 So receive him in the Lord with all joy.
And hold such people in honor.
30 For because of the work of Christ
he came near to death.
He risked his life
to supply what was lacking in your service toward me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 25: Epaphroditus came from Philippi. The church had sent him to Paul with a gift of money (compare 4:18). The WEB calls him "your apostle," that is, the messenger sent by the church.

Verses 26–27: Epaphroditus became seriously ill. Illness is not a punishment. Paul says openly how great his worry was. An apostle, too, feels sorrow and fear for friends.

Verse 27: Paul did not simply heal Epaphroditus. He too depended on God's mercy.

Verse 30: "To supply what was lacking in your service toward me": The church was far away. Epaphroditus was with Paul in its place. This is no reproach to the church.

PHILIPPIANS

CHAPTER 3

Everything for Christ

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

In this chapter Paul argues with other Christian teachers. They demanded that Christians from the nations be circumcised. Paul uses harsh words in doing so. These words are not directed against the Jewish people or the Jewish faith. Paul himself was a Jew and remained one all his life. These verses must never be used against Jews.

Beware of false teachers VERSES 1–3

1 Finally,
my brothers:
Rejoice in the Lord!
To write the same things to you
is not tiresome for me.
And for you it is safe.
2 Beware of the dogs.
Beware of the evil workers.
Beware of the false circumcision.
3 For we are the circumcision:
We worship God in the Spirit.
We rejoice in Christ Jesus.
And we have no confidence in the flesh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "Finally": Paul announces the end, but then writes two more chapters. That is why some interpreters think the letter was put together from several letters.

Verse 2: "Dogs" was a crude insult at that time. Paul means traveling Christian preachers who demanded circumcision from the Christians from the nations. It is an argument among Christians, as in the letter to the Galatians.

Verse 3: "We are the circumcision": Paul means: Whoever serves God through the Spirit belongs to God's people, even without circumcision. This does not mean that Israel is no longer God's people (compare Romans 11:1–2, 29).

"Flesh" here means: human advantages and achievements that people are proud of.

What used to matter to me VERSES 4–11

4 And yet I myself could also have confidence in the flesh.
If anyone else thinks
he has confidence in the flesh,
I have even more:
5 I was circumcised on the eighth day.
I come from the people of Israel,
from the tribe of Benjamin.
I am a Hebrew of Hebrews.
Concerning the law:
I was a Pharisee.
A Pharisee was a member of a Jewish group that took God's law very seriously.
6 Concerning zeal:
I persecuted the church.
Concerning the righteousness in the law:
I was found blameless.
7 But what was gain to me,
I consider a loss for the sake of Christ.
8 Yes,
most certainly:
I count all things to be a loss
compared with the surpassing worth
of knowing Christ Jesus,
my Lord.
For him I have lost all things.
And I count them nothing but refuse.
Refuse means: garbage, trash.
I do this
so that I may gain Christ
9 and be found in him.
I don't have a righteousness of my own
that comes from the law.
But I have the righteousness
that comes through faith in Christ:
the righteousness
that comes from God
by faith.
10 I want to know him
and the power of his resurrection.
I want to share in his sufferings
and become like him in his death,
11 so that by any means
I may reach the resurrection from the dead.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6: Paul lists what he was proud of: his Jewish background, his faithfulness to the law, his zeal. All of this was good. He is not ashamed of it.

Verse 6: "I was found blameless": Paul had no bad conscience as a Jew. He kept the law faithfully. The law was no burden to him.

Verses 7–8: Only when he came to know Christ did all this lose its weight for him. Not because it was bad, but because Christ is so much more valuable. Paul is speaking here about his own life's path.

Verse 8: The WEB says "refuse," that is, garbage or trash. Paul uses a very strong word to show how much Christ surpasses everything else.

Verse 9: Righteousness is a gift from God, not your own achievement. Here it says: "through faith in Christ." The Greek text can also mean: *through the faithfulness of Christ*. Interpreters understand it in different ways.

Verses 10–11: For Paul, knowing Christ means: living with him, suffering with him and rising with him.

I run toward the goal VERSES 12–16

12 Not
that I have already reached it
or am already perfect.
But I press on
to take hold of it.
For I too was taken hold of by Christ Jesus.
13 Brothers,
I don't think
that I have already taken hold of it.
But one thing I do:
I forget
the things that are behind me
and stretch forward to the things
that are before me.
14 I press on toward the goal
to win the prize:
the high calling of God
in Christ Jesus.
15 Let all of us
who are mature
think this way.
And if you think otherwise about something,
God will also reveal that to you.
16 But however far we have come:
Let's live by the same rule.
Let's be of the same mind.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Paul says honestly: I too am not finished yet. Being a Christian is a path, not a finished state.

Verse 12: "I too was taken hold of by Christ Jesus": It was not Paul who first looked for Christ. Christ found him first (compare Acts 9).

Verses 13–14: A picture from sports: A runner doesn't look back, but forward to the goal.

For today: Forgetting what lies behind doesn't mean that you have to push away suffering you have experienced. It means: The past, including your own mistakes, should not hold you captive. God gives a new beginning.

Verse 15: Paul is patient: God himself will show the way to those who think differently.

Our home is in heaven VERSES 17–21

17 Brothers,
together, follow my example.
And pay attention to those
who live this way,
just as you have us for an example.

18 For many live differently.
I have often told you about them,
and now I tell you even weeping:
They live as enemies of the cross of Christ.
19 Their end is destruction.
Their god is the belly.
They are proud of what
they should be ashamed of.
They only think about earthly things.
20 For our citizenship is in heaven.
From there we also wait for a Savior,
the Lord Jesus Christ.
21 He will change our weak and lowly body,
so that it becomes like his glorious body.
He does this by the power
with which he is able even to subject all things to
himself.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Paul can say "Together, follow my example" because he himself follows Christ (compare 1 Corinthians 11:1).

Verse 18: Paul weeps over these people. He doesn't despise them; he is sad about them.

Verse 19: "Their god is the belly": They live only for their own wishes and pleasures. Whom exactly Paul means is disputed among interpreters.

Verse 20: Philippi was a Roman colony. Many inhabitants were proud of their Roman citizenship. Paul says: Our most important citizenship is in heaven.

For today: This doesn't mean that Christians should not care about the world. Whoever is at home in heaven works on earth for justice and peace.

Verse 21: "Our weak and lowly body" is our body that gets sick, grows old and dies. God promises a new, glorious body at the resurrection.

PHILIPPIANS

Chapter 4

Rejoice in the Lord always

Stand firm and stay together VERSES 1–3

1 So,
my dear brothers,
whom I love and long for,
my joy and crown:
Stand firm in the Lord in this way,
my dear friends.
2 I urge Euodia,
and I urge Syntyche:
Be of one mind in the Lord.
3 Yes,
I ask you also,
true partner:
Help these women.
For they struggled with me for the Good News,
together with Clement
and my other fellow workers.
Their names are in the book of life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "Crown": This means the victory wreath that a winner received at a competition. For Paul the church is like a winner's prize.

Verses 2–3: Euodia and Syntyche were two women who had an important role in the church. Paul calls them women who struggled with him for the Good News. Women helped lead and shape the first churches, as Lydia already did in Philippi (Acts 16).

The two probably had a quarrel. Paul doesn't take sides. He asks both of them in the same way and asks a third person for help. That is a good example of settling a dispute.

We don't know who the "true partner" is. The Greek word could also be a name: *Syzygus*.

"Book of life": A picture showing that God knows every person who belongs to him.

Joy, prayer and peace VERSES 4–9

4 Rejoice in the Lord
always!
Again I will say:
"Rejoice!"
5 Let your gentleness be known to all people.
The Lord is at hand.
6 Don't worry about anything.
But in everything bring your requests to God,
by prayer and petition
with thanksgiving.
7 And the peace of God,
which is greater than all understanding,
will guard your hearts and your thoughts
in Christ Jesus.
8 Finally,
brothers:
Whatever is true,
whatever is honorable,
whatever is just,
whatever is pure,
whatever is lovely,
whatever has a good reputation,
if there is any virtue
and anything worthy of praise:
think about these things.
Virtue means: a good quality in a person.
9 What you learned
and received
and heard
and saw in me,
do that.
And the God of peace will be with you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: Paul writes this sentence in prison. Joy "in the Lord" doesn't depend on everything going well. It comes from trusting God.

Important: Christians don't always have to be cheerful. Sadness, fear and lament also have a place before God. The Psalms are full of them.

Verse 5: "The Lord is at hand" can mean: Jesus is coming again soon. It can also mean: God is near to us now.

Verse 6: "Don't worry about anything" is no reproach to people who have worries. It is an invitation: Bring your worries to God. If you suffer from strong fears or worries, you may also get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 7: God's peace is greater than we can understand. It guards our hearts like a guard watches over a city.

Verse 8: Paul lists values that many people outside the church also knew and valued. Christians may value what is good wherever they find it.

Thanks for the church's help VERSES 10–20

10 I rejoice greatly in the Lord
that now at last you could think of me again.
You did indeed think of me,
but you had no opportunity
to show it.
11 I don't say this
because I am in need.
For I have learned
to be content in whatever situation I am.
12 I know how to live with little,
and I know how to live with plenty.
In any and all circumstances
I have learned the secret:
both to be filled and to be hungry,
both to have plenty and to be in need.
13 I can do all things through Christ
who strengthens me.
14 Still, you did well
to share in my trouble.
15 You yourselves know,
you Philippians:
In the beginning of the Good News,
when I left Macedonia,
no church shared with me in giving and receiving
but you only.
16 For even in Thessalonica you sent me something for my needs
more than once.
17 It is not the gift I am looking for.
I am looking for the fruit
that is credited to your account.
18 I have all things,
and more than enough.
I am well supplied,
since I received from Epaphroditus
what you sent.
It is like a sweet-smelling fragrance,
a sacrifice
that pleases God and that he gladly accepts.
19 My God will supply every need of yours
according to his riches in glory
in Christ Jesus.
20 Now to our God and Father
be the glory forever and ever!
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 11–12: Paul experienced hunger and poverty, but also good times. He learned to stay calm in both.

Verse 13 is a very well-known verse. It doesn't mean: With Christ I can reach every goal, win every competition or become rich. It means: With Christ I can endure every situation, even hunger and need (verse 12).

Verses 15–16: The church in Philippi faithfully supported Paul from the beginning. In Corinth, on the other hand, Paul accepted no money (compare 2 Corinthians 11:9).

Verse 18: The church's gift is like a sacrifice to God. Whoever helps others honors God by doing so.

Verse 19: A promise: God provides what you really need. It is no promise of wealth.

Greetings VERSES 21–23

21 Greet every saint in Christ Jesus.
The brothers
who are with me
greet you.
22 All the saints greet you,
especially those of Caesar's household.
23 The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ
be with you all.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: "Those of Caesar's household": This doesn't mean the emperor's family. It means slaves and officials in the emperor's service. Even then there were Christians there. The Good News also reached people close to power.

Looking back: What have we read in the letter to the Philippians?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Joy in spite of prison: Paul is in prison and doesn't know whether he will survive. And yet he writes again and again about joy (chapters 1 to 4).

To live is Christ: Paul holds on to life because others need him. And he is not afraid of death, because then he will be with Christ (chapter 1).

The song of Christ: Jesus humbled himself to the point of death on the cross. God raised him to the highest place. That is the example for all Christians: to serve one another, not to rule (chapter 2).

Good friends: Timothy and Epaphroditus show how to be there for one another (chapter 2).

Everything for Christ: Paul was proud of his Jewish background. But Christ is even more valuable to him. He runs toward the goal like a runner (chapter 3).

Bringing worries to God: prayer, thanks and God's peace, which is greater than our understanding (chapter 4).

Being content: With Christ you can get through good and hard times (chapter 4).

For today: Joy is possible, even in hard times. And Christians should not only think of themselves, but also of others.

What comes next? Next comes the letter to the Colossians. It says: Christ is Lord over all creation.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 51 OF 66

COLOSSIANS

4 CHAPTERS

COLOSSIANS

Chapter 1

Christ, the image of the invisible God

Before we begin: The letter to the Colossians

Colossae was a small town in what is now Turkey, in the valley of the Lycus River. The cities of Laodicea and Hierapolis were nearby.

Paul did not found the church in Colossae himself. His coworker Epaphras preached the Good News there (1:7).

The letter calls itself a letter from Paul and Timothy. It was written in prison (4:18). Many scholars today think that a student of Paul wrote it, in Paul's spirit. Others consider Paul himself to be the author.

In the church there were teachers who thought special rules, festival days and the worship of angels were necessary. The letter says against this: In Christ you already have everything. He is Lord over all creation.

In chapter 1 there is a famous song about Christ. The letter is closely related to the letter to the Ephesians.

Important note: In chapters 3 and 4 there are rules for married couples, children, parents, slaves and masters. They reflect the order of society at that time. In the boxes we explain how Christians understand them today.

The letter to the Colossians has 4 chapters.

Greeting VERSES 1–2

1 Paul,
an apostle of Christ Jesus through the will of God,
and Timothy,
our brother,
2 write to the saints and faithful brothers in Christ
at Colossae:
Grace to you and peace
from God our Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Saints" are all Christians. They belong to God.

Timothy was a close coworker of Paul.

Thanks for the church's faith VERSES 3–8

3 We give thanks to God,
the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ,
and always pray for you.
4 For we have heard of your faith in Christ Jesus
and of your love for all the saints.
5 You believe and love because of the hope
that is laid up for you in the heavens.
You heard of it before,
in the word of the truth,
the Good News.
6 It has come to you.
In all the world it is bearing fruit and growing,
just as it does among you,
since the day
you heard the grace of God
and knew it in truth.
7 That is how you learned it from Epaphras,
our dear fellow servant.
He is a faithful servant of Christ for you.
8 He also told us about your love in the Spirit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 4–5: Faith, love and hope belong together (compare 1 Corinthians 13:13).

Verse 6: The Good News is like a plant. It grows and bears fruit, everywhere in the world.

Verse 7: Epaphras came from Colossae (4:12). He founded the church. Paul knows the church only through him.

Prayer for the church VERSES 9–14

9 For this reason we also have not stopped
praying for you
since the day
we heard about it.
We ask God
that you may be filled with the knowledge of his will,
in all wisdom and understanding
that the Spirit gives.
10 In this way you are to live
in a way worthy of the Lord
and please him in all things.
You are to bear fruit in every good work
and grow in the knowledge of God.
11 You are to be strengthened with all power,
according to the might of his glory,
so that you have endurance and patience,
with joy.
12 Give thanks to the Father.
He has made us fit
to share in the inheritance of the saints in light.
13 He has rescued us from the power of darkness
and brought us into the Kingdom of the Son he loves.
14 In him we have redemption:
the forgiveness of sins.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9–10: Knowledge is not an end in itself. Whoever knows God's will is to live by it.

Verse 11: Patience and endurance don't come from your own strength. God gives the strength for them.

Verse 13: A picture of a change of ruler: Darkness once had power over us. Now we belong to the Kingdom of Jesus.

Verse 14: "Redemption" means: being bought free, the way a prisoner is bought free.

The song of Christ VERSES 15–20

15 He is the image of the invisible God,
the firstborn of all creation.
16 For by him all things were created,
in the heavens and on the earth,

visible things and invisible things:
whether thrones or dominions
or principalities or powers.
Principalities means: rulers, powers.
All things have been created through him and for him.
17 He is before all things.
And in him all things hold together.
18 He is the head of the body,
the church.
He is the beginning,
the firstborn from the dead,
so that in all things he might be first.
19 For all the fullness was pleased
to live in him,
20 and through him to reconcile all things to himself,
whether things on the earth
or things in the heavens.
He made peace
through the blood of his cross.
To reconcile means: to make peace again between people who were apart.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 15–20 are probably a song of the first Christians. It has two parts: Christ and creation (verses 15–17), and Christ and reconciliation (verses 18–20).

Verse 15: "The image of the invisible God": No one can see God. But in Jesus you can see what God is like.

"The firstborn of all creation" doesn't mean that Christ himself was created. At that time the firstborn had the highest rank and the right of the heir. Christ stands above everything that is created.

Verse 16: "Thrones or dominions or principalities or powers": This means invisible powers that people at that time were afraid of. The letter says: They too were created by Christ. No one needs to fear them.

Verse 17: Christ holds the world together.

Verse 20: God wants to reconcile not only people, but "all things," the whole creation. For today: That is why caring for creation is also part of the Christian faith.

You are reconciled VERSES 21–23

21 You too were once far from God.
In your minds you were his enemies,
because you did evil deeds.
22 But now he has reconciled you
in the body of his flesh through death.
In this way he wants to present you holy,
without defect
and blameless before him.
23 But for this you must continue in the faith,
grounded and steadfast.
Don't let yourselves be moved away from the hope of the Good News
that you heard.
It was proclaimed in all creation under heaven.
And I,
Paul,
was made its servant.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 21–22: It was not God who had to be reconciled. God himself reconciled people to himself. He took the first step.

Verse 22: "In the body of his flesh": Jesus was a real human being with a real body. The letter stresses this against teachers who looked down on the physical.

Verse 23: "In all creation" is an exaggeration to show: The Good News is meant for all people.

Paul serves the church VERSES 24–29

24 Now I rejoice in my sufferings for you.
What is still lacking in the sufferings of Christ,
I fill up in my own body
for the sake of his body,
the church.
25 I was made its servant.
God gave me this task for you:
I am to proclaim the word of God fully,
26 the mystery
that has been hidden for ages and generations.
But now it has been revealed to his saints.
27 God wanted to show them
how rich and glorious this mystery is among the nations:
Christ in you,
the hope of glory.
28 We proclaim him.
We admonish every person
and teach every person
in all wisdom,
so that we may present every person
perfect in Christ Jesus.
To admonish means: to warn and advise someone in a serious way.
29 For this I work hard and struggle,
with his power
that works mightily in me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 24 is hard to understand. It doesn't mean that the suffering of Jesus on the cross was not enough. Interpreters usually understand it like this: Christ suffers along with his church. When Paul suffers for the church, he shares in this suffering.

Important: Suffering is not something good in itself. No one should seek suffering or expect others to suffer.

Verse 27: The "mystery" is: Christ is also with the people from the nations, not only with Israel. He is "in you."

Verse 28: Three times it says "every person" here. The Good News is for everyone, not just for an elite with special knowledge.

COLOSSIANS

CHAPTER 2

In Christ you have everything

Paul struggles for the churches VERSES 1–5

1 I want
you to know
how greatly I struggle for you,
for you and for those at Laodicea
and for all
who have never seen me in person.
2 I struggle
so that their hearts may be encouraged,
that they may be knit together in love
and gain all the riches of full understanding.
In this way they are to know the mystery of God,
both of the Father and of Christ.
3 In him all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge are
hidden.
4 I say this
so that no one may deceive you with persuasive-
sounding speech.
5 For even though I am absent in the flesh,
I am with you in the spirit.
I rejoice
when I see
how good your order is
and how firm your faith in Christ is.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Laodicea was a neighboring city of Colossae. Paul did not know the Christians there in person. Still he struggles for them in prayer.

Verse 3: Some teachers claimed they had special, secret knowledge. The letter says: You find all wisdom in Christ. You don't need secret knowledge.

Verse 4: A warning that is also true today: What sounds good doesn't have to be true.

Stay rooted in Christ VERSES 6–15

6 You received Christ Jesus as Lord.
So now live in him,
7 rooted and built up in him.
Stay firm in the faith,
just as you were taught,
and overflow with thanksgiving.
8 Be careful
that no one robs you
through his philosophy and empty deceit.
They are based on human tradition
and on the elemental spirits of the world,
and not on Christ.
9 For in him all the fullness of the Deity lives in bodily
form.
Deity means: God's nature, being God.
10 And in him you too are made full.
He is the head over all rulers and powers.
11 In him you were also circumcised
with a circumcision
not made with hands.
You put off the body of the sins of the flesh,
in the circumcision of Christ.
12 You were buried with him in baptism.
In it you were also raised with him,
through faith in the working of God,
who raised him from the dead.
13 You were dead through your wrongs
and because you were uncircumcised.
But God made you alive together with him.
He forgave us all our wrongs.
14 He wiped out the record of debt
that stood against us with its rules.
He took it away
and nailed it to the cross.
A record of debt is a signed list of what someone owes.
15 He disarmed the rulers and powers
and made a public show of them.
On the cross he triumphed over them.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: Like a tree with deep roots and like a house on a firm foundation: This is how firm faith in Christ should be.

Verse 8: "Philosophy" here doesn't mean thinking in itself. It means certain teachings that lead away from Christ. "Elemental spirits of the world": At that time many believed that the stars and the forces of nature decide people's lives.

Verse 9: One of the most important sentences about Jesus: In him God is fully present, in a human body.

Verses 11–12: The Christians from the nations were not circumcised. The letter says: Through baptism you belong completely to Christ. You don't have to be circumcised in addition.

Verse 14: A picture: God has crossed out the list of our guilt, the "record of debt," and nailed it to the cross.

Verse 15: A picture from Rome: After a victory the general led the defeated enemies through the city in a victory parade. On the cross Christ defeated the evil powers.

Don't let rules be forced on you VERSES 16–23

16 So let no one judge you
about eating or drinking,
or about a feast day,
a new moon
or a Sabbath day.
17 These are a shadow of the things
that are to come.
But the reality belongs to Christ.
18 Let no one rob you of your prize
who delights in self-abasement
and the worshiping of angels.
Self-abasement means: making yourself small and low
in a showy way.
Such a person relies on things
that he has not seen.
He is puffed up for no reason
by his human mind.
19 He doesn't hold firmly to the Head.
From him the whole body is supplied
and held together by joints and ligaments.
So it grows
the way God makes it grow.
20 You died with Christ
and were set free from the elemental spirits of the
world.
Why then do you let rules be made for you,
as though you were still living in the world?

21 "Don't handle!
Don't taste!
Don't touch!"
22 All these things perish
when they are used.
These are commandments and teachings of people.
23 These rules do look wise:
with self-made worship,
with humility
and with severity to the body.
But they are of no value
against the desires of the flesh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: This is about teachers in Colossae who wanted to force strict rules on the Christians from the nations, together with the worship of angels and fasting. It was a mix of different religions.

Very important: This verse is no criticism of the Jewish Sabbath or of Jewish festivals. For Jews they are a gift from God. Many Jewish Christians also continued to keep them. The letter only says: No one may judge Christians from the nations because they don't keep these days.

Verse 17: A picture: A shadow shows that something is there. The reality itself is Christ.

Verse 18: "The worshiping of angels": Some thought you had to worship angels or gain special insight through visions. The letter says: Christ is enough.

Verses 21–23: Strict bans and harshness against your own body don't make a person better.

For today: No person and no group may frighten others with ever new rules. Where groups control people with strict rules and put them under pressure, be careful. Counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse can help.

COLOSSIANS

CHAPTER 3

The new life with Christ

Seek the things above VERSES 1–4

1 So you were raised together with Christ.
Therefore seek
the things that are above,
where Christ is.
He is seated at the right hand of God.
2 Set your mind on the things
that are above,
not on the things
that are on the earth.
3 For you died.
And your life is hidden with Christ in God.
4 When Christ,
our life,
is revealed,
then you will also be revealed with him in glory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "The right hand of God": That is the place of honor next to the king. The picture comes from Psalm 110:1.

Verse 2: "The things that are above" doesn't mean: The earth doesn't matter. It means: Let yourselves be guided by God's values, not by greed, power or fear.

Verse 3: "You died": With baptism a new life has begun. The old life is over. The new life is safely kept with God, even if you can't fully see it yet.

Put away the old life VERSES 5–11

5 So put to death
what is earthly in you:
sexual immorality,
uncleanness,
shameful passion,
evil desire
and greed.
Greed is idolatry.
Idolatry means: worshiping idols, false gods.
6 Because of these things God's anger comes
on the people who disobey.
7 You too once followed these things,
when you lived in them.
8 But now you must put them all away:
anger,
rage,
malice,
slander
and shameful speech from your mouth.
9 Don't lie to one another.
For you have taken off the old self with its deeds
10 and have put on the new self.
This new self is being made new in knowledge,
so that it becomes like the image of its Creator.
11 Here there can't be Greek and Jew,
circumcised and uncircumcised,
foreigner,
Scythian,
slave
or free person.
But Christ is all,
and in all.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: "Put to death" is a picture. It means: Stop these things completely. It does not mean that you should harm your body. If you are thinking about hurting yourself, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 5: "Greed is idolatry": Whoever always wants more makes possessions into their god (compare Ephesians 5:5).

Verses 9–10: Like changing clothes: old clothes off, new ones on. This is a picture of baptism.

Verse 11 is very important: In Christ, background, nation and social rank no longer count. The Scythians were a people near the Black Sea who at that time were seen as especially wild. They belong too.

Important: The words "there can't be Greek and Jew" don't mean that Jews should stop being Jews. They mean: Before Christ all are equally valuable. No one is better or worse (compare Galatians 3:28).

For today: Racism and contempt for other peoples or classes don't fit with the Christian faith.

Put on love VERSES 12–17

12 You are chosen by God,
holy and dearly loved.
So put on:
a heart of compassion,
kindness,
modesty,
humility
and patience.
13 Bear with one another.
And forgive one another
if anyone has a complaint against another.
Just as Christ forgave you,
so you also forgive.
14 But above all these things, live in love.
It is the bond
that holds everything together perfectly.
15 And let the peace of God rule in your hearts.
You were called to it
as one body.
And be thankful.
16 Let the word of Christ live in you richly.
Teach and admonish one another in all wisdom,
with psalms,
hymns
and spiritual songs.
Sing to the Lord with grace in your hearts.
17 And whatever
you do,
in word or in deed,
do all in the name of the Lord Jesus.
And give thanks to God
the Father
through him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Christians are to "put on" good qualities like clothes. They belong to them like a new garment.

Verse 13: Forgiving is hard. But we can forgive because Christ has forgiven us.

Important: Forgiveness doesn't mean that you have to keep putting up with injustice or violence. You may protect yourself. And forgiveness often takes time.

Verse 14: Love is like a belt that holds everything together.

Verse 15: "Let the peace of God rule in your hearts": The Greek word means an umpire. When there is a quarrel, the peace of God is to decide.

Verse 17: All of everyday life can be worship, not only Sunday.

Rules for life in the household VERSES 18–25

18 Wives,
be subject to your husbands,
as is fitting in the Lord.
19 Husbands,
love your wives
and don't be bitter against them.
20 Children,
obey your parents in all things.
For this pleases the Lord.
21 Fathers,
don't provoke your children,
so that they won't be discouraged.
22 Servants,
obey your earthly masters in all things.
Don't do it only
when they are looking,
to please people,
but with a sincere heart,
fearing God.
23 Whatever you do,
work at it from the heart,
as for the Lord
and not for people.
24 For you know:
From the Lord you will receive the inheritance as your reward.
You serve the Lord Christ.
25 But whoever does wrong
will be paid back for the wrong he has done.
And there is no partiality.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 18–25 are a "household code," as in Ephesians 5 and 6. Such rules for living together in the household existed in many writings at that time. They reflect the social order of that time.

What was new: Everyone is addressed, including women, children and slaves, not only the men. And the husbands, fathers and masters also have duties (verses 19, 21 and 4:1).

Verse 18: "As is fitting in the Lord": Everything stands under Christ. Today many Christians understand marriage as a partnership of two people with equal rights. Others hold on to a special responsibility of the husband. All stress: It is about love, not about power.

Very important: These verses give no one the right to rule over others or to use violence. Violence in marriage is a serious wrong and a crime. You can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 20: "Obey your parents in all things" doesn't mean that children have to put up with violence, abuse or humiliation. Children have a right to be raised without violence. Help for children: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. Parents who need support can also call Childhelp.

Verse 22: The WEB says *servants* here. Slaves are meant. Slavery is a grave injustice. These verses were later misused to justify slavery. That was wrong.

Verse 25: God is just. He favors no one, neither masters nor slaves.

Chapter 4

Pray and speak kindly

A word to the masters VERSE 1

1 Masters,
give your servants
what is just and fair.
For you know:
You also have a Master in heaven.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1 still belongs to the household code from chapter 3. The masters are reminded: You are not the highest power. You must answer to God.

The WEB says *servants* here. Slaves are meant. For today: Fair wages and fair working conditions are God's command. Exploitation is wrong.

Pray and live wisely VERSES 2–6

2 Continue steadfastly in prayer.
Stay alert in it with thanksgiving.
3 Pray for us too,
that God may open to us a door for the word,
so that we can speak the mystery of Christ.
Because of it I am also in chains.
4 Pray
that I may make it known clearly,
as I ought to speak.
5 Live wisely toward those
who are outside the church.
Make good use of the time.
6 Let your speech always be kind,
seasoned with salt.
Then you will know
how you ought to answer each one.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: "Open to us a door": A picture for a good opportunity. Paul is in prison. He doesn't first ask for freedom, but for opportunities to tell people about Christ.

Verse 5: Christians are to behave wisely, fairly and kindly toward people outside the church.

Verse 6: "Seasoned with salt": Words should not be bland, but have a good taste. They should be kind, interesting and helpful.

For today: This is also true for conversations about faith. Not pushy, but kind and respectful.

News and greetings VERSES 7–18

7 Tychicus will tell you everything
about how I am doing.
He is a dear brother,
a faithful servant
and fellow servant in the Lord.
8 I am sending him to you for this very purpose,
so that he may know
how you are doing
and may comfort your hearts.
9 He comes together with Onesimus,
the faithful and dear brother.
He is one of you.
The two of them will tell you everything
that is going on here.
10 Aristarchus,
my fellow prisoner,
greets you,
and Mark,
the cousin of Barnabas.
You have already received instructions about him:
"If he comes to you,
receive him."
11 And Jesus,
who is called Justus,
greets you.
Of all my fellow workers for God's Kingdom,
these are the only ones who are of the circumcision.
That means: They are Jews.
They have been a comfort to me.
12 Epaphras greets you.
He is one of you,
a servant of Christ.
He is always struggling for you in his prayers,
so that you may stand mature and complete
in all the will of God.
13 For I testify about him:
He works very hard for you
and for those in Laodicea
and for those in Hierapolis.
14 Luke,
the dear doctor,
and Demas greet you.
15 Greet the brothers in Laodicea,
and Nymphas
and the church in his house.
16 When this letter has been read among you,
make sure
that it is also read in the church of the Laodiceans.
And you also read the letter from Laodicea.
17 And tell Archippus:
"Pay attention to the ministry
that you have received in the Lord,
so that you fulfill it."
18 I,
Paul,
write this greeting with my own hand.
Remember my chains.
Grace be with you.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: Onesimus was a slave from Colossae. The letter to Philemon tells about him. Here it says: Tychicus comes "together with Onesimus, the faithful and dear brother." In the church he is a brother of equal worth.

Verse 10: Mark had once parted from Paul (Acts 15:37–39). Now they are reconciled again. Many connect him with the Gospel of Mark.

Verse 11: "Jesus" was a common Jewish name at that time. Paul is glad about Jewish coworkers who stand by him.

Verse 14: Luke was a doctor. Tradition sees him as the author of the Gospel of Luke and of Acts.

Verse 15: Here it says "Nymphas and the church in his house," as in the WEB. Some old manuscripts say *Nympha* and *in her house*. Then it was a woman who led a house church.

Verse 16: Letters were read aloud in worship and passed on to other churches. The "letter from Laodicea" has not survived. Some interpreters think it could mean the letter to the Ephesians.

Verse 18: Paul usually dictated his letters. He wrote the closing greeting himself, as a sign that the letter was genuine.

Looking back: What have we read in the letter to the Colossians?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Christ above all: Christ is the image of the invisible God. All things were created through him. In him all things hold together (chapter 1).

Reconciliation for all things: Through Christ God wants to reconcile the whole creation (chapter 1).

In Christ you have everything: Christians need no secret knowledge, no worship of angels and no strict special rules. No one may judge them for this (chapter 2).

The new life: Putting away the old and putting on compassion, kindness, patience and above all love (chapter 3).

All are equally valuable: In Christ background and social rank don't count (chapter 3).

The household code: Rules from that time for family and work. What matters is: Everyone stands under Christ. No one may use violence (chapters 3 and 4).

Prayer and kind words: Pray steadfastly and speak kindly with all people (chapter 4).

For today: Christ is greater than all the powers we are afraid of. That is why Christians can live freely and thankfully.

What comes next? Next comes the first letter to the Thessalonians. It is probably the oldest letter of Paul that we know.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 52 OF 66

1 THESSALONIANS

5 CHAPTERS

1 THESSALONIANS

Chapter 1

An example for everyone

Before we begin: The first letter to the Thessalonians

Thessalonica is today's Thessaloniki in Greece. At that time it was a large port city and the capital of the Roman province of Macedonia.

Paul came to Thessalonica with Silas and Timothy and founded a church there (Acts 17:1–9). After a short time he had to leave the city because of unrest.

Paul is worried about the young church. He sends Timothy to it. When Timothy brings good news, Paul writes this letter, probably from Corinth.

The letter is probably the oldest letter of Paul that we have, and so one of the oldest writings of the New Testament. It was written around AD 50.

An important theme is hope: What about the Christians who have already died? Paul comforts the church with the hope that Jesus will come again.

Important note: In chapter 2 there are very harsh words about *the Jews*. In the box we explain why these verses must never be used against Jews.

The first letter to the Thessalonians has 5 chapters.

Greeting VERSE 1

1 Paul,
Silvanus
and Timothy
write to the church of the Thessalonians
in God the Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ:
Grace to you and peace
from God our Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Silvanus is the same man who is called *Silas* in Acts. Silas is the short form. He and Timothy were there when the church was founded.

Thanks for the church VERSES 2–10

2 We always give thanks to God for all of you
when we remember you in our prayers.
3 Without ceasing we remember before our God and Father
your work of faith,
your labor of love
and your perseverance of hope
in our Lord Jesus Christ.
4 Brothers
loved by God:
We know
that you are chosen.
5 For our Good News came to you
not in word only,
but also in power,
in the Holy Spirit
and with full certainty.
You know
how we lived among you
for your sake.
6 And you became imitators of us
and of the Lord.
You received the word in much affliction,
with joy of the Holy Spirit.
7 So you became an example
to all who believe in Macedonia and in Achaia.
8 For from you the word of the Lord has spread,
not only in Macedonia and Achaia.
In every place people have heard
about your faith toward God.
We don't need to say anything more about it.
9 For they themselves report about us
how you welcomed us
and how you turned to God from idols
to serve a living and true God
10 and to wait for his Son from heaven.
God raised him from the dead:
Jesus,
who rescues us from the anger to come.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Affliction means: great trouble and suffering.

Idols means: images of false gods.

Verse 3: Faith, love and hope: For Paul these three always belong together (compare 1 Corinthians 13:13). Here they are named together for the first time. Faith shows itself in deeds, love takes effort, hope gives perseverance.

Verse 5: The Good News is not only a teaching. It has power and changes people.

Verse 6: "In much affliction": The Christians in Thessalonica had opponents from the beginning and faced hostility (Acts 17:5–9). Still they had joy.

Verse 7: Achaia was the Roman province in the south of Greece, with Corinth as its capital.

Verse 9: Most Christians in Thessalonica had worshiped other gods before. They turned to the God of Israel, "a living and true God."

Verse 10: The first Christians strongly hoped that Jesus would come again soon. "The anger to come" means God's judgment on evil. Jesus rescues from it. Christians don't need to be afraid of the judgment.

1 THESSALONIANS

Chapter 2

How Paul worked in Thessalonica

How we came to you VERSES 1–12

1 You yourselves know,
brothers:
Our visit to you was not in vain.
2 Before that we had suffered in Philippi
and had been shamefully treated there.
You know that.
Still, trusting in our God, we grew bold.
We told you the Good News of God,
even though we faced much conflict.
3 For our appeal doesn't come from error,
nor from impure motives,
nor from deception.
4 Rather, God has tested us
and entrusted us with the Good News.
That is why we speak this way:
not to please people,
but God,
who tests our hearts.
5 For we never used words of flattery,
as you know.
And we didn't secretly act out of greed.
God is our witness.
6 We didn't seek glory from people,
neither from you nor from others.
Yet as apostles of Christ
we could have claimed authority.
7 But we were gentle among you,
like a nursing mother
who takes tender care of her own children.
8 That is how much we longed for you.
We wanted to give you not only the Good News of God,
but also our own lives.
For you had become very dear to us.
9 You remember,
brothers,
our labor and toil.
We worked night and day,
so that we would not be a burden to any of you.
That is how we preached the Good News of God to you.
10 You are witnesses,
and God also,
how holy,
righteous
and blameless
we were toward you who believe.
Righteous means: living right before God.
11 For you know:
We urged each one of you,
encouraged you
and pleaded with you,
as a father does with his own children,
12 to live in a way
worthy of God.
He calls you into his own Kingdom
and glory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Flattery means: praise that is not honest, given to win someone over.

Verse 2: In Philippi Paul and Silas were beaten and thrown into prison (Acts 16:22–24).

Verses 3–6: At that time many traveling preachers and speakers went through the cities to win money and fame. Paul says: We were not like that.

Verse 7: Paul compares himself to a mother nursing her baby. And in verse 11 to a father. He cared for the church with a mother's and a father's love.

Verse 9: Paul worked as a tentmaker (Acts 18:3). He didn't want to live at anyone's expense.

For today: Whoever has responsibility in the church should be gentle, honest and unselfish. Power must not be misused.

You received God's word VERSES 13–16

13 That is why we also thank God without ceasing:
You heard from us the word of God's message.
And you accepted it not as a human word,
but as what
it truly is:
God's word.
It works in you
who believe.
14 For you,
brothers,
became imitators of the churches of God in Judea
that are in Christ Jesus.
For you suffered the same things from your own
people
as they did from the Jews
15 who killed both the Lord Jesus
and their own prophets
and drove us out.
They don't please God
and are against all people.
16 They forbid us
to speak to the nations
so that they may be saved.
So they always fill up the measure of their sins.
But anger has come on them in full.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verses 14–16 are among the most difficult verses in the New Testament. In history they were terribly misused to despise, persecute and kill Jews. That was a grave injustice. These verses must never be used against Jews.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Paul himself was a Jew. The churches in Judea (verse 14) that he praises consisted of Jews. Jesus, his disciples and the first Christians were Jews.

Here Paul speaks in anger about a certain group in Judea that persecuted the Christians at that time and had driven him out. He doesn't mean the whole Jewish people. The Greek word can also mean *the Judeans*, that is, the people living in Judea. And the sentence can be read this way: *from those Jews who* …, so only from certain people.

Verse 15: Jesus was crucified by the Romans. Crucifixion was a Roman punishment. The claim that *the Jews* killed Jesus is false and has caused endless suffering.

Verse 16: What Paul means by "anger has come on them in full" is unclear. Some interpreters think that verses 15–16 were added later by someone else, perhaps after the

destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70. Others consider them words of Paul in a moment of great anger.

Later Paul wrote very differently: God has not rejected his people. God does not take back his gifts and his calling. All Israel will be saved (Romans 11:1–2, 26, 29).

For today: Antisemitism is sin. Christians must stand up against hatred of Jews everywhere.

Paul longs for the church VERSES 17–20

17 But we,
brothers,
were separated from you for a short time,
in person,
but not in heart.
All the more we tried
to see you again,
with great longing.
18 For we wanted to come to you.
I,
Paul,
wanted to more than once.
But Satan hindered us.
19 For what is our hope,
our joy
and our crown of rejoicing
that we are proud of?
Isn't it you,
before our Lord Jesus
at his coming?
20 For you are our glory and our joy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Paul had to leave Thessalonica quickly because of unrest (Acts 17:10). He feels like a father whose children were taken away.

Verse 18: Paul doesn't say exactly what hindered him. He sees in it the work of evil.

Verse 19: "At his coming": Here for the first time is the word for the return of Jesus. It is an important theme in this letter.

Verse 20: Paul is proud of the church, not of himself.

1 THESSALONIANS

CHAPTER 3

Good news from Timothy

Paul sends Timothy VERSES 1–5

1 So when we couldn't stand it any longer,
we decided
to be left behind at Athens alone,
2 and we sent Timothy to you.
He is our brother
and God's servant in the Good News of Christ.
He was to strengthen you
and encourage you in your faith,
3 so that no one would be shaken by these afflictions.
For you yourselves know:
We are appointed to this.
4 For even when we were with you,
we told you beforehand
that we would suffer affliction.
And so it happened,
and you know it.
5 That is why I too couldn't stand it any longer
and sent Timothy,
to find out
how your faith was doing.
For I was afraid
that the tempter had somehow tempted you
and that our labor had been in vain.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: After Thessalonica Paul had traveled to Athens by way of Berea (Acts 17:10–15). In Athens he was alone and very worried about the young church.

Verses 3–4: Paul had honestly warned the Christians beforehand: Whoever believes in Jesus may face trouble and hostility because of it.

Verse 5: Paul openly admits that he was afraid. An apostle, too, worries about the people he loves.

"The tempter" is Satan. Paul feared that the Christians would give up their faith under pressure.

Timothy brings good news VERSES 6–10

6 But now Timothy has come back to us from you.
He has brought us glad news
of your faith and your love.
You always have good memories of us
and long
to see us,
just as we also long
to see you.
7 For this reason,
brothers,
we were comforted through your faith,
in all our distress and affliction.
8 For now we live,
if you stand fast in the Lord.
9 How can we thank God enough for you,
for all the joy
that we have because of you before our God?
10 Night and day we pray very earnestly
that we may see you again
and may make complete
what is lacking in your faith.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: Timothy probably came back to Corinth, where Paul was by then (Acts 18:5). There Paul wrote this letter.

Verse 8: "Now we live": The good news gave Paul new courage. The church comforts the apostle, not only the other way around.

Verse 10: "What is lacking in your faith": The church was still young. Paul had only been able to be with it for a short

time. There were still many questions, for example about those who had died (chapter 4).

Prayer for the church VERSES 11–13

11 May our God and Father himself
and our Lord Jesus Christ
direct our way to you.
12 And may the Lord make you grow
and overflow in love for one another
and for all people,
just as we also love you.
13 So may he strengthen your hearts,
so that they are blameless and holy
before our God and Father
at the coming of our Lord Jesus with all his saints.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Love is not to stay only within the church, but is to be for "all people."

Verse 13: "With all his saints": This can mean angels or all who belong to God. The picture recalls Zechariah 14:5. Paul hopes for the return of Jesus. Until then the Christians are to grow in love.

1 THESSALONIANS

CHAPTER 4

Hope for those who have died

A life that pleases God VERSES 1–8

1 Finally,
brothers:
We beg and urge you in the Lord Jesus.
You learned from us
how you ought to live
to please God.
Keep growing in it more and more.
2 For you know
what instructions we gave you through the Lord Jesus.
3 For this is the will of God:
that you live a holy life.
Keep away from sexual immorality.
4 Each one of you should know
how to control his own body
in holiness and honor,
5 not in the passion of lust,
like the nations
who don't know God.
6 No one should take advantage of
a brother or sister in this matter
or wrong them.
For the Lord punishes all these things.
We already told you and warned you about this before.
7 For God did not call us to uncleanness,
but to a holy life.
8 So whoever rejects this
doesn't reject a human being,
but God.
He has also given you his Holy Spirit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 3–5: In the society of that time it was often normal for men to have sex with slave women, prostitutes or other women outside marriage. Paul says: Christians live differently.

Verse 4: The Greek word can mean *body*, but also *vessel*. Some interpreters think it means your own wife. The WEB translates "body."

Verse 6 is very important: Sexuality must never be used to take advantage of others or to wrong them. God stands on the side of those who are wronged.

For today: Sexual violence and abuse are a grave injustice. Whoever has experienced this is not to blame. You can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233.

Love one another and work quietly VERSES 9–12

9 About love for the brothers and sisters
we don't need to write to you.
For you yourselves are taught by God
to love one another.
10 And you are already doing this
toward all the brothers in all Macedonia.
But we urge you,
brothers:
Keep growing in it more and more.
11 Make it your ambition
to lead a quiet life,
to take care of your own affairs
and to work with your own hands,
just as we told you.
12 In this way you are to live properly
toward those
who are outside the church
and not depend on anyone.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: "Taught by God": God himself has put love for one another into the hearts of the Christians.

Verse 11: Some in the church had probably stopped working, perhaps because they thought Jesus would come again soon anyway. Paul says: Go on living calmly and work.

Verse 12: An orderly life is also a good witness to people outside the church.

Important: This is no reproach to people who can't work because they are sick, old or unemployed. The church is to help them.

Hope for those who have died VERSES 13–18

13 But we don't want you to be uninformed,
brothers,
about those
who have fallen asleep,

so that you don't grieve
like the rest,
who have no hope.
14 For we believe
that Jesus died and rose again.
In the same way God will bring with him those
who have fallen asleep in Jesus.
15 For this we tell you by the word of the Lord:
We
who are alive,
who are left until the coming of the Lord,
will in no way go before those
who have fallen asleep.
16 For the Lord himself will come down from heaven,
with a shout,
with the voice of the archangel
and with God's trumpet.
And first the dead
in Christ will rise.
17 Then we
who are alive and are left
will be caught up together with them in the clouds
to meet the Lord in the air.
And so we will be with the Lord forever.
18 So comfort one another with these words.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Archangel means: a leading angel.

Verse 13: Some Christians in Thessalonica had died. The others were afraid: Have those who died now missed the return of Jesus? Paul comforts them.

"Fallen asleep" is a gentle way of saying *died*. It expresses hope: Whoever sleeps will wake up again.

Important: Paul doesn't say: *You should not grieve*. He says: "don't grieve like the rest, who have no hope." Grief is allowed and important. Jesus too wept when his friend Lazarus had died (John 11:35). If you need support in your grief, you can find it, for example, with a grief counselor. If your grief becomes too heavy, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 14: The reason for hope is the resurrection of Jesus.

Verse 15: At that time Paul expected that he would still live to see the return of Jesus ("we who are alive").

Verses 16–17: Paul uses pictures: shout, trumpet and clouds. This is how people at that time described a king coming into a city. The inhabitants go out to meet him, to welcome him and to enter the city with him.

Christians understand verse 17 in different ways. Some expect a *rapture* of believers before a great time of trouble at the end of time. Most churches understand the verse like this: When Jesus comes again, everyone, the living and the dead, will be united with him forever.

Verse 18: The purpose of these verses is comfort, not fear.

1 THESSALONIANS

CHAPTER 5

Children of light

The day of the Lord VERSES 1–11

1 About the times and the seasons,
brothers,
we don't need to write anything to you.
2 For you yourselves know very well:
The day of the Lord comes
like a thief in the night.
3 When people are saying,
"Peace and safety,"
then sudden destruction will come on them,
like birth pains on a pregnant woman.
And they will in no way escape.
4 But you,
brothers,
are not in darkness,
so that the day could surprise you like a thief.
5 You are all children of light
and children of the day.
We don't belong to the night
nor to darkness.
6 So let's not sleep
like the rest do,
but let's stay awake and be sober.
7 For those who sleep
sleep in the night.
And those who get drunk
get drunk in the night.
8 But we belong to the day.
So let's be sober.
Let's put on the breastplate of faith and love,
and for a helmet, the hope of salvation.
9 For God didn't appoint us to anger,
but to receive salvation
through our Lord Jesus Christ.
10 He died for us,
so that we should live together with him,
whether we wake or sleep.
11 So encourage one another
and build each other up,
just as you are already doing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sober means: clear-headed, not drunk.

A breastplate is a piece of armor that protects the chest.

Verses 1–2: No one knows when Jesus will come again. So you should not calculate dates either. Jesus himself used the picture of the thief (Matthew 24:43–44).

Verse 3: "Peace and safety" was a slogan of the Roman Empire. Paul says: True safety is not given by the emperor, but by God.

Verses 5–8: Christians are to live awake and sober, as if it were already day. That means: attentive, sensible, not indifferent.

Verse 8: As in Ephesians 6, the *armor* is a picture: Faith, love and hope protect us. It is no call to violence.

Verse 10: "Whether we wake or sleep" here means: whether we are alive or have died. No one is separated from Christ, not even by death.

Verse 9: This is the heart of it: God wants to save, not to condemn. This section is not meant to make you afraid, but to give you courage.

How Christians live together VERSES 12–22

12 But we ask you,
brothers:
Respect those
who labor among you,
who lead you in the Lord
and admonish you.
13 Honor them very highly in love
because of their work.
Be at peace among yourselves.
14 We urge you,
brothers:
Warn those
who live in a disorderly way.
Encourage the fainthearted.
Support the weak.
Be patient toward all.
15 See to it
that no one returns evil for evil to anyone.
But always pursue what is good,
for one another and for all.
16 Always rejoice.
17 Pray without ceasing.
18 In everything give thanks.
For this is the will of God
in Christ Jesus for you.
19 Don't quench the Spirit.
20 Don't despise prophecies.
21 Test all things,
and hold firmly to what is good.
22 Keep away from every kind of evil.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Fainthearted means: fearful, easily discouraged.

Quench means: to put out, like a fire.

Verses 12–13: The church already had people who carried responsibility. They deserve respect because they work hard. But they too must not misuse their power.

Verse 14: Every person needs something different: Some need a clear word, others encouragement, others support. And everyone needs patience.

Verse 15: Not returning evil for evil: Jesus taught this (Matthew 5:38–48). It applies "for all," not only to Christians.

Verses 16–18: Three short sentences: joy, prayer, thanks. "Pray without ceasing" doesn't mean saying prayers all day long. It means: being connected with God in all of life.

Verse 18: "In everything give thanks" doesn't mean having to be thankful for every bad thing. It means: Even in hard times there is reason to give thanks, because God is with us.

Verses 19–21: The Holy Spirit works in the church. You should not despise prophetic words, but test them. Not everything that someone says in God's name is right.

Blessing and farewell VERSES 23–28

23 May the God of peace himself
make you completely holy.
May your whole spirit,
soul and body
be kept
blameless
at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ.
24 He who calls you
is faithful.
He will also do it.
25 Brothers,
pray for us too.
26 Greet all the brothers with a holy kiss.
27 I solemnly command you by the Lord:
Have this letter read to all the holy brothers.
28 The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ
be with you.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23: Spirit, soul and body: God wants to make the whole person whole, not only the soul. The body matters to God too.

Verse 24: A word of comfort: We don't have to manage everything. God is faithful and completes what he has begun.

Verse 26: The "holy kiss" was a sign of greeting among Christians, like a hug or a handshake today.

Verse 27: At that time many people could not read. That is why the letter was read aloud in worship. That way everyone could hear it.

Looking back: What have we read in the first letter to the Thessalonians?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The oldest letter of Paul: We have probably read the oldest surviving letter of Paul, written around AD 50.

Faith, love and hope: These three shape the young church (chapters 1 and 5).

An example: The church in Thessalonica held on to the faith in spite of hostility and became an example for many (chapter 1).

How Paul worked: Gentle like a mother, encouraging like a father, honest and unselfish (chapter 2).

A difficult passage: The harsh words in 2:14–16 must never be used against Jews. Paul himself was a Jew. Antisemitism is sin.

Worry and joy: Paul worries about the church and rejoices at the good news from Timothy (chapter 3).

Hope for those who have died: Whoever has died in Christ is not lost. We may grieve, but with hope (chapter 4).

Children of light: Living awake and sober, encouraging one another, not returning evil for evil, rejoicing, praying and giving thanks (chapter 5).

For today: Death does not have the last word. That is why Christians can comfort one another.

What comes next? Next comes the second letter to the Thessalonians. It deals once more with the return of Jesus.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 53 OF 66

2 THESSALONIANS

3 CHAPTERS

2 THESSALONIANS

Chapter 1

God is just

Before we begin: The second letter to the Thessalonians

This letter is addressed to the same church as the first letter to the Thessalonians: to the Christians in Thessalonica, today's Thessaloniki in Greece.

The church continued to face hostility and persecution. In addition, some claimed that *the day of the Lord* had already come. That made many afraid. Some even stopped working.

The letter calls itself a letter from Paul, Silvanus and Timothy. Some scholars think that a student of Paul wrote it later. Others consider Paul himself to be the author, shortly after the first letter.

The letter wants to comfort and calm: God is just. Don't let yourselves be confused. Go on living calmly and do good.

Important note: In chapters 1 and 2 there are pictures of God's judgment. They are meant to give courage to persecuted people. They are no invitation to wish evil on other people or to do evil to them.

The second letter to the Thessalonians has 3 chapters.

Greeting VERSES 1–2

1 Paul,
Silvanus
and Timothy
write to the church of the Thessalonians
in God our Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ.
2 Grace to you and peace
from God our Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The greeting is almost exactly as in the first letter. Silvanus is the same man as Silas in Acts.

God is just VERSES 3–12

3 We must always give thanks to God for you,
brothers.
That is fitting.
For your faith is growing greatly,
and the love of each one of you for one another
keeps increasing.
4 So we ourselves boast about you in the churches of
God,
because of your perseverance and faith
in all the persecutions and afflictions
that you endure.
5 This is a clear sign of the just judgment of God.
For you are to be counted worthy
of God's Kingdom,
for which you are also suffering.
6 For it is just for God
to repay with affliction
those who afflict you,
7 and to give relief to you
who are afflicted,
together with us.
That will happen
when the Lord Jesus is revealed from heaven
with his mighty angels
in flaming fire.
8 Then he will punish those
who don't know God,
and those
who don't obey the Good News of our Lord Jesus.
9 They will pay the penalty:
eternal destruction,
far from the face of the Lord
and from the glory of his might.
10 This will happen on that day,
when he comes
to be glorified in his saints
and to be admired among all
who have believed.
And you too believed our testimony.
11 That is why we always pray for you:
May our God count you worthy of your calling.
May he fulfill with his power every desire for goodness
and every work of faith,
12 so that the name of our Lord Jesus
may be glorified in you,
and you in him,
by the grace of our God
and the Lord Jesus Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 3–4: The church is being persecuted. Still its faith and love are growing. Paul is proud of this.

Verses 5–7: The Christians ask: Why does God allow us to suffer? The letter answers: God is just. He sees the injustice. In the end he will comfort the victims and hold the wrongdoers accountable.

Important: The letter leaves revenge to God. Christians are not to return evil for evil themselves (compare 1 Thessalonians 5:15 and Romans 12:19).

Verses 7–9: Fire and angels are pictures from the prophets for God's coming. They describe how seriously God takes injustice.

Verses 8–9: Christians understand in different ways who exactly is meant and what "eternal destruction" means. Many stress: Judgment belongs to God alone. No human being may judge the eternal fate of another. And God wants all people to be saved (1 Timothy 2:4).

Verse 9: "From the face of the Lord": The worst thing is to be separated from God.

Verses 11–12: Paul prays that God himself will complete the good that the Christians want and do.

2 THESSALONIANS

Chapter 2

Don't let yourselves be confused

The day of the Lord is not here yet VERSES 1–12

1 Brothers,
this is about the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ
and about
our gathering together to him.
We ask you:
2 Don't be quickly shaken in your mind
and don't be troubled,
either by a spirit
or by a word
or by a letter
that supposedly comes from us
and claims
that the day of Christ has already come.
3 Let no one deceive you in any way.
For first the rebellion must come.
And the man of sin must be revealed,
the son of destruction.
4 He opposes everything
that is called God
or that is worshiped,
and exalts himself above it.
He even sits in the temple of God
and sets himself up as God.
5 Don't you remember?
I told you these things
when I was still with you.
6 And you know
what is restraining him now,
so that he will be revealed only in his own time.
7 For the mystery of lawlessness is already at work.
Only there is one now
who restrains it,
until he is taken out of the way.
8 Then the lawless one will be revealed.
The Lord will kill him with the breath of his mouth
and destroy him
when he appears and comes.
9 The coming of the lawless one happens through the
working of Satan,
with all power,
with signs
and with lying wonders,
10 and with all the deception of wickedness
for those
who are being lost.
For they didn't receive the love of the truth,
by which they would be saved.
11 That is why God sends them a powerful delusion,
so that they believe a lie.
12 So all are to be judged
who didn't believe the truth,
but took pleasure in doing wrong.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Rebellion means: turning away from God.

Delusion means: a false belief that someone holds on to.

Verse 2: Some in the church claimed that *the day of the Lord* had already come. Perhaps there was even a forged letter in Paul's name. That unsettled people and made them afraid.

Verse 3: The letter says: Stay calm. Some things still have to happen first. The WEB says "man of sin." Some old manuscripts say *man of lawlessness*.

Verse 4: The "man of sin" is a figure who puts himself in God's place. This recalls rulers like the Syrian king Antiochus IV. In 167 BC he had defiled the temple in Jerusalem (compare Daniel 11:36). The Roman emperor Caligula also wanted to have his statue set up in the temple.

Verses 6–7: We don't know what or who is "restraining" the lawless one. Paul had explained it to the church in person. Interpreters have many guesses: the Roman Empire, the order of the state, the preaching of the Good News or God himself.

Verse 8: The lawless one is not all-powerful. Christ defeats him with a single breath. This is meant to give courage, not fear.

Very important: In history Christians again and again called certain people or groups *the lawless one* or *the Antichrist*: popes, reformers, rulers or even Jews. That caused much hatred and suffering. No one should put such a label on any human being.

For today: The text warns against people and powers who let themselves be worshiped like God and lead people astray with lies and false wonders. It calls us to be alert: Love the truth.

Verses 11–12: Whoever rejects the truth again and again eventually loses the ability to recognize it. The letter says this as a warning, not as a threat against particular people.

God has chosen you VERSES 13–17

13 But we must always give thanks to God for you,
brothers
loved by the Lord.
For God chose you from the beginning for salvation,
through the sanctification of the Spirit
and belief in the truth.
14 To this he called you
through our Good News,
so that you may share in the glory
of our Lord Jesus Christ.
15 So then,
brothers:
Stand firm and hold to the traditions
that you were taught by us,
whether by word
or by letter.
16 May our Lord Jesus Christ himself
and God
our Father,
who loved us

and gave us eternal comfort
and good hope through grace,
17 comfort your hearts
and strengthen you
in every good work and word.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sanctification means: being made holy.

Verse 13: After the serious words comes comfort: God has loved and chosen you. You don't need to be afraid.

Verse 15: "Traditions" are the teachings that Paul passed on to the church. Some were written down, others told by word of mouth.

Different churches understand this verse differently: The Catholic and Orthodox churches also see in it a basis for church tradition alongside the Bible. Protestant churches stress that the Bible is the standard for all tradition.

Verses 16–17: A prayer for comfort and strength. God's comfort is "eternal comfort": it never stops.

2 THESSALONIANS

CHAPTER 3

Pray and work quietly

Pray for us VERSES 1–5

1 Finally,
brothers:
Pray for us,
that the word of the Lord may spread rapidly
and be honored,
just as it was with you,
2 and that we may be rescued from unreasonable and evil
people.
For not all have faith.
3 But the Lord is faithful.
He will strengthen you
and guard you from the evil one.
4 We have confidence in the Lord concerning you:
You do
what we command you,
and you will keep doing it.
5 May the Lord direct your hearts
into God's love
and into the perseverance of Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Paul asks the church for prayer. Apostles, too, need the support of others.

Verse 3: "The Lord is faithful": People can disappoint, but God stays faithful.

Verse 5: The Lord is to direct hearts "into the perseverance of Christ." Jesus held out even in suffering. He gives strength to hold out yourself.

Work quietly VERSES 6–15

6 Brothers,
in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ we command
you:
Keep away from every brother
who lives in rebellion
and not according to the tradition
that you received from us.
7 For you yourselves know
how you ought to imitate us.
We didn't live in rebellion among you.
8 We didn't eat anyone's bread without paying for it.
But with labor and toil
we worked night and day,
so that we would not be a burden to any of you.
9 Not
because we don't have the right.
But we wanted to make ourselves an example to you,
so that you would imitate us.
10 For even when we were with you,
we told you this:
"If anyone is not willing to work,
don't let him eat."
11 For we hear
that some among you live in rebellion.
They don't work at all,
but are busybodies.
12 Such people we command
and urge in the Lord Jesus Christ:
They are to work quietly
and eat their own bread.
13 But you,
brothers,
don't be weary in doing
what is right.
14 But if anyone doesn't obey our word in this letter,
take note of that person
and have nothing to do with him,
so that he may be ashamed.
15 Don't count him as an enemy.
Instead, warn him as a brother.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Busybodies means: people who meddle in other people's affairs.

Verses 6–11: Some in the church had stopped working. Perhaps they thought Jesus would come soon anyway. They let others provide for them and meddled in everything.

Verses 8–9: As an apostle Paul would have had the right to be provided for by the church. He gave up this right and worked himself.

Verse 10: Very important: It says here "If anyone is not willing to work," not *if anyone is not able to work*. This sentence is not directed against the sick, people with disabilities, the elderly, children or the unemployed. The church is to help them. The Bible calls again and again for caring for the poor and the weak. This verse must not be used to look down on people in need.

Verse 13: "Don't be weary in doing what is right": Even if some take advantage of people's readiness to help, Christians are to keep helping.

Verses 14–15: The distance is meant to help the person change their mind. But he remains a brother, not an enemy. The goal is reconciliation, not exclusion.

Peace and greeting VERSES 16–18

16 May the Lord of peace himself
give you peace
at all times
and in all ways.
The Lord be with you all.
17 I,
Paul,
write this greeting with my own hand.
This is the sign in every letter.
This is how I write.
18 The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ
be with you all.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Paul dictated his letters. He wrote the closing greeting himself. That way the church could recognize that the letter was genuine. This was important because there were probably forged letters (compare 2:2).

Looking back: What have we read in the second letter to the Thessalonians?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God is just: He sees the suffering of the persecuted. He will comfort them and judge injustice. Revenge belongs to God alone (chapter 1).

Don't let yourselves be confused: The day of the Lord is not here yet. No one should spread fear or calculate dates (chapter 2).

Staying alert: There are powers that let themselves be worshiped like God and lead people astray with lies. Christians are to love the truth. But no one should put the label *Antichrist* on other people (chapter 2).

God has chosen you: Comfort and hope for the church (chapter 2).

Keep working quietly: Waiting for Jesus is no reason to give up normal life. Whoever can work should work. Whoever can't should be helped (chapter 3).

For today: God is faithful. That is why Christians don't need to be afraid of the future. They can live calmly and responsibly and do good.

What comes next? Next comes the first letter to Timothy. It is addressed to a coworker of Paul and gives advice for life in the church.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 54 OF 66

1 TIMOTHY

6 CHAPTERS

1 TIMOTHY

Chapter 1

Christ came to save sinners

Before we begin: The first letter to Timothy

Timothy was a close coworker of Paul. His mother was Jewish and a Christian, his father a Greek (Acts 16:1). Paul calls him his *true child in faith*.

The letter calls itself a letter from Paul to Timothy. Timothy has stayed in Ephesus to lead the church there. The letter gives him advice: how to deal with false teachings, how worship is celebrated and which people should carry responsibility in the church.

The two letters to Timothy and the letter to Titus are together called the *Pastoral Letters*, that is, letters for shepherds of the church. Many scholars today think that they were written later by a student of Paul, in Paul's spirit. Others consider Paul himself to be the author.

Important note: In this letter there are rules about women, slaves and other groups. They reflect the society of that time. Christians and churches understand them in different ways today. We explain this fairly and honestly in the boxes.

The first letter to Timothy has 6 chapters.

Greeting VERSES 1–2

1 Paul,
an apostle of Jesus Christ
by the command of God
our Savior
and of the Lord Jesus Christ,
our hope,
2 writes to Timothy,
his true child in faith:
Grace,
mercy
and peace
from God our Father
and from Christ Jesus our Lord.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "God our Savior": This name for God appears often in the Pastoral Letters.

Verse 2: "True child in faith": Timothy is not Paul's own son. But Paul led him to faith and guides him like a father.

Warning against false teachings VERSES 3–11

3 I urged you
to stay at Ephesus
when I went on to Macedonia.
You were to command certain people
not to teach a different doctrine
4 and not to pay attention to myths
and endless family trees.
These cause disputes
rather than serving God's plan,
which is in faith.
5 But the goal of this command is love
from a pure heart,
a good conscience
and sincere faith.
6 Some have wandered away from these things
and turned to empty talk.
7 They want to be teachers of the law.
But they understand neither
what they are saying
nor the things
they so confidently claim.
8 But we know:
The law is good
if a person uses it properly.
9 You must know this:
The law is not made for a righteous person,
but for the lawless and disobedient,
for the ungodly and sinners,
for the unholy and corrupt,
for those
who kill their fathers or their mothers,
for murderers,
10 for the sexually immoral,
for homosexuals,
for slave-traders,
for liars,
for perjurers,
and for anything else
that is contrary to sound doctrine.
11 This is according to the Good News of the glory of the
blessed God,
which was entrusted to me.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Doctrine means: teaching.

Righteous means: living right before God.

Perjurers means: people who lie under oath.

Verse 4: "Myths and endless family trees": Some teachers busied themselves with speculation and long lists of ancestors. This led to disputes, but not to a better life.

Verse 5 is the heart of it: The goal of all teaching is love.

Verse 8: "The law is good": The law that God gave Israel is good and holy (compare Romans 7:12). This is about people who misuse it.

Verses 9–10: This list roughly follows the Ten Commandments: honoring parents, not killing, not committing adultery, not stealing ("slave-traders" stole people), not giving false testimony.

Verse 10: The WEB translates a difficult Greek word as "homosexuals." It is the same word as in 1 Corinthians 6:9 (*arsenokoitai*). It means roughly: men who sleep with men. The word *homosexual* has only existed since the 19th century. That is why other Bibles translate it in very different ways.

Churches understand this passage in different ways today. Some see in it a lasting command against same-sex sexuality. Others say: What was meant was exploitation and

abuse as it existed at that time, for example in connection with human trafficking and slavery (the next word in the list), not loving, faithful partnerships as we know them today.

Very important: This text gives no one the right to despise people, to insult them or to use violence against them. Every human being has the same dignity before God. If you experience exclusion or violence because of your sexual orientation, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Verse 10: "Slave-traders": Whoever kidnaps and sells people commits a grave injustice. That is also true today of human trafficking and forced labor.

God's grace for Paul VERSES 12–17

12 I thank him
who gave me strength:
Christ Jesus our Lord.
For he counted me faithful
and appointed me to his service,
13 although I used to be a blasphemer,
a persecutor
and a violent man.
But I obtained mercy
because I did it in ignorance,
in unbelief.
14 The grace of our Lord overflowed,
together with the faith and love
that are in Christ Jesus.
15 The saying is trustworthy
and deserves
to be accepted by all:
Christ Jesus came into the world
to save sinners.
And of them I am the worst.
16 But for this very reason I obtained mercy:
In me first
Jesus Christ wanted to show all his patience,
as an example for all
who were going to believe in him
and receive eternal life.
17 Now to the King eternal,
immortal,
invisible,
to God,
who alone is wise,
be honor and glory
forever and ever.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Blasphemer means: someone who mocks or insults God.

Verse 13: Paul once persecuted Christians (Acts 8:3 and 9:1–2). He doesn't hide this.

Verse 15 is one of the most important sentences of the letter: Jesus came to save sinners. No one is too bad for God's grace.

Verse 16: If God forgave even a persecutor like Paul, then every person can have hope.

Verse 17: A short song of praise to God. He is eternal, immortal and invisible.

The good fight VERSES 18–20

18 I give you this instruction,
my child Timothy,
according to the prophecies
that were spoken about you before.
With their help you are to fight the good fight.
19 Hold on to faith and a good conscience.
Some have pushed away a good conscience
and have made a shipwreck of their faith.
20 Among them are Hymenaeus and Alexander.
I handed them over to Satan,
so that they may learn
not to blaspheme anymore.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: "The good fight" is a picture. It means standing up for the faith, not violence against people.

Verse 19: "A shipwreck of their faith": Whoever no longer takes their conscience seriously can lose their faith like a ship that sinks.

Verse 20: Being handed over to Satan probably means: being excluded from the church (compare 1 Corinthians 5:5). The goal was not punishment, but that they would turn back and learn. The door to return stays open.

1 TIMOTHY

CHAPTER 2

Pray for all people

God wants all people to be saved VERSES 1–7

1 So first of all I urge:
Bring requests,
prayers,
intercessions
and thanksgiving before God
for all people,
2 for kings
and for all
who are in high positions.
In this way we can lead a peaceful and quiet life
in all godliness and dignity.
3 For this is good
and pleases God our Savior.
4 He desires
all people to be saved
and to come to full knowledge of the truth.
5 For there is one God
and one mediator between God and people:
the man Christ Jesus.
6 He gave himself as a ransom for all.
This is the testimony

that was given at the proper time.
7 For this I was appointed a preacher and an apostle.
I am telling the truth in Christ,
I am not lying.
I am a teacher of the nations
in faith and truth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Intercessions means: prayers for other people.

Mediator means: someone who brings two sides together.

Ransom means: money paid to set a prisoner or slave free.

Verses 1–2: Christians are to pray for all people, including those who govern. At that time that was the Roman emperor, who was not a Christian and sometimes persecuted Christians. Still they were to pray for him.

For today: Praying for politicians doesn't mean agreeing with everything. You can pray for someone and still criticize them.

Verse 4 is very important: God wants all people to be saved. No one is excluded from God's love.

Verse 5: "One mediator": Christ connects God and people. He himself is "the man Christ Jesus": he knows us.

Verse 6: "Ransom": A picture from that time. Prisoners or slaves were bought free with a ransom. Jesus gave his life to set people free.

How men and women are to pray VERSES 8–15

8 So I want
the men in every place to pray,
lifting up holy hands,
without anger and without doubting.
9 In the same way, the women are to adorn themselves
in decent clothing,
with modesty and good sense,
not with braided hair,
gold,
pearls
or expensive clothing,
10 but with good works.
That is fitting for women
who profess
to honor God.
11 Let a woman learn in quietness
with full submission.
12 But I don't permit a woman
to teach
or to exercise authority over a man,
but to be in quietness.
13 For Adam was formed first,
then Eve.
14 Adam wasn't deceived,
but the woman was deceived
and has fallen into disobedience.
15 But she will be saved
through her childbearing,
if they continue
in faith,
love and holiness
with good sense.

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

Verses 11–15 are among the most disputed verses of the Bible. In history they were often used to keep women down. We render them closely following the WEB and explain them fairly.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: At that time people often prayed standing with raised hands. The men are to pray without quarreling and anger. Apparently there was quarreling in the church.

Verses 9–10: This is not about a ban on jewelry in itself. At that time rich women showed off their wealth with expensive jewelry and elaborate hairstyles. The letter says: In worship the rich are not to show themselves off. Good works are more important.

Verse 11: For that time it was new that women were to learn at all. That was progress.

Verse 12: How to understand this verse is very disputed among Christians:

Some churches still understand it as a general command: Women are not to preach or lead in the church.

Many other churches say: The letter responds to a specific situation in Ephesus. There some women were probably spreading false teachings (compare 5:13 and 2 Timothy 3:6). That is why the rule does not apply for all times. These churches have women pastors, preachers and bishops.

They point out that Paul too worked with women who taught and led: Priscilla, together with her husband, taught the preacher Apollos (Acts 18:26). Phoebe was a servant of the church (Romans 16:1). Junia was highly regarded among the apostles (Romans 16:7). Women prayed and prophesied in worship (1 Corinthians 11:5).

Verses 13–14 refer to the story of creation (Genesis 2 and 3). Important: Elsewhere the Bible says that sin came into the world through Adam (Romans 5:12). Eve is not more guilty than Adam. Women are not easier to deceive than men.

Verse 15 is hard to understand. It doesn't mean that women have to earn salvation through children. Salvation is God's gift through faith. Some interpreters think it is about the birth of Jesus through a woman. Others think: Women are not to look down on their lives as women and mothers, as some false teachers demanded (compare 4:3). Women without children are worth just as much before God.

Very important: These verses give no one the right to put women down, to silence them or to deny them their dignity. Man and woman are both created in God's image (Genesis 1:27) and are of equal worth before God. In Christ they are *one* (Galatians 3:28).

1 TIMOTHY

CHAPTER 3

Those who carry responsibility in the church

The overseers of the church VERSES 1–7

1 This is a trustworthy saying:
Someone who wants to be an overseer in the church
desires a good work.

2 So the overseer must be without reproach,
the husband of one wife,
sober,
sensible,
respectable,
hospitable
and good at teaching.
3 He must not be a drinker,
not violent,
not greedy for money,
but gentle,
not quarrelsome
and not covetous.
4 He must manage his own household well
and guide his children to obey with all respect.
5 For if someone doesn't know how to manage his own household,
how could he take care of God's church?
6 He must not be new in the faith.
Otherwise he might become puffed up
and fall into the same condemnation as the devil.
7 He must also have a good reputation with those outside the church.
Otherwise he will fall into disgrace
and into the snare of the devil.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Overseer means: a leader of the church.

Hospitable means: welcoming guests gladly.

Verse 1: "Overseer" (Greek *episkopos*): Later the word *bishop* came from this word. At that time it probably meant a leader of a local church.

Verses 2–7: The list shows: For leadership, character matters most, not power or wealth. Leaders are to be gentle, honest, not violent and not greedy for money.

Verse 2: "The husband of one wife" is understood in different ways: Some think he should be married only once. Others think he should be faithful to his wife and not have several wives. In the Catholic Church priests today live unmarried. In Orthodox and Protestant churches pastors may be married.

Verse 4: The leader is to raise his children with respect. That does not mean with violence. Violence against children is never right.

Very important: These rules are meant to protect the church. Whoever has responsibility in the church must never misuse it. If you have experienced abuse in a church, you can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673.

The servants of the church VERSES 8–13

8 In the same way, the servants must be respectable,
not double-tongued,
not addicted to much wine
and not greedy for money.
9 They must hold the mystery of the faith
with a pure conscience.
10 They too must first be tested.
Then let them serve
if they are blameless.
11 Their wives in the same way must be respectable,
not slanderers,
sober
and faithful in all things.
12 The servants must be husbands of one wife
and manage their children and their own households well.
13 For those who have served well
gain a good standing
and great boldness in the faith in Christ Jesus.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Double-tongued means: saying one thing to one person and something else to another.

Verse 8: "Servants" (Greek *diakonos*): Later the word *deacon* came from this. Deacons took care of the poor and the sick, for example.

Verse 11: The WEB says "Their wives." But the Greek word can also simply mean *women*. Then this would be about women who were themselves servants of the church. Phoebe too is called a servant of the church (Romans 16:1). Interpreters understand the verse in different ways.

Verse 13: Whoever serves others gains respect and courage in faith. Serving is no small task.

The mystery of faith VERSES 14–16

14 I am writing these things to you,
although I hope
to come to you soon.
15 But if I am delayed,
you should know
how people ought to behave in God's house.
That is the church of the living God,
the pillar and foundation of the truth.
16 Without question,
the mystery of godliness is great:
God was revealed in the flesh,
justified in the spirit,
seen by angels,
preached among the nations,
believed on in the world,
received up in glory.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: The church is like a house and a family of God. It holds up the truth the way a pillar holds up a roof.

Verse 16 is probably an old song of the first Christians about Jesus. In six short lines it tells his path: He became human, God confirmed him, angels saw him, he was preached and believed, and he was taken up into heaven.

The WEB says "God was revealed in the flesh." Many old manuscripts say *He who was revealed in the flesh*. In both cases Jesus Christ is meant.

1 TIMOTHY

CHAPTER 4

Be an example

Everything God created is good VERSES 1–5

1 But the Spirit says clearly:
In later times some will fall away from the faith.
They will listen to deceiving spirits
and to teachings of demons.
2 This happens through the hypocrisy of people
who tell lies.
Their conscience is branded as with a hot iron.
3 They forbid marriage.
And they demand
that people stay away from certain foods.
But God created these
so that those who believe
and know the truth
may receive them with thanksgiving.
4 For everything
that God created
is good.
Nothing is to be rejected
if it is received with thanksgiving.
5 For it is made holy
through the word of God and prayer.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hypocrisy means: pretending to be good while acting differently.

Verses 1–3: There were teachers who forbade marriage and banned certain foods. They thought everything physical was bad.

Verse 4 is very important: Everything God created is good. This recalls the story of creation: *God saw that it was good* (Genesis 1). The body, food and marriage are good gifts from God.

Verse 5: Giving thanks before eating: Saying grace at meals reminds us that food is a gift from God.

For today: Whoever does without certain foods for personal, health or religious reasons is doing nothing wrong. Jewish food laws are not meant here either. The letter is directed against teachers who force bans on others and speak badly of God's creation.

Train yourself in godliness VERSES 6–11

6 If you put these things before the brothers,
you will be a good servant of Christ Jesus.
You are nourished by the words of the faith
and of the good teaching
that you have followed.
7 But reject godless old wives' fables.
Rather, train yourself in godliness.
8 For bodily training has some value.
But godliness has value in all things.
It holds promise for the life that is now
and for the life to come.
9 This saying is trustworthy
and deserves
to be accepted by all.
10 For this is why we labor
and suffer insults:
because we have put our trust in the living God.
He is the Savior of all people,
especially of those who believe.
11 Command and teach these things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Godliness means: a life that honors God.

Verse 7: "Old wives' fables" was a fixed expression at that time for silly, made-up stories. It is no statement about older women. Today we might say *nonsense* or *fairy tales*.

Verses 7–8: A picture from sports: Just as you train your body, you are also to *train* your faith, for example through prayer, reading the Bible and good deeds. Sports are good, but faith is even more important.

Verse 10: God is the "Savior of all people." His love is for everyone, not only for a small group.

Be an example VERSES 12–16

12 Let no one look down on you
because you are young.
But be an example to those who believe:
in speech,
in conduct,
in love,
in spirit,
in faith
and in purity.
13 Until I come,
give attention to the public reading,
to encouraging
and to teaching.
14 Don't neglect the gift
that is in you.
It was given to you through prophecy,
when the elders laid their hands on you.
15 Take care of these things.
Give yourself wholly to them,
so that all may see
your progress.
16 Pay attention to yourself and to your teaching.
Continue in these things.
For if you do this,
you will save both yourself
and those
who hear you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Elders means: leaders of the church.

Verse 12: Timothy was still fairly young. The letter says: Age is not what matters. Young people too can be an example in faith.

Verse 13: "The public reading": In worship the holy Scriptures were read aloud, at that time mainly the Scriptures of Israel, our Old Testament.

Verse 14: The laying on of hands is a sign of blessing and of being sent for a task. To this day many churches bless people for a ministry in this way, for example at ordination.

Verse 16: Whoever teaches others should also pay attention to their own life. Words and deeds should fit together.

Chapter 5

Caring for one another in the church

How to treat one another VERSES 1–2

1 Don't speak harshly to an older man,
but encourage him as a father.
Treat the younger men as brothers,
2 the older women as mothers,
the younger women as sisters,
in all purity.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The church is like a family. Everyone is to treat one another with respect, like fathers, mothers, brothers and sisters.

"In all purity": In dealing with younger women everything is to be proper. No one may take advantage of their position.

Caring for widows VERSES 3–16

3 Honor widows
who are truly widows.
4 But if a widow has children or grandchildren,
they should first learn
to show godliness toward their own family
and to repay their parents.
For this pleases God.
5 A widow
who is truly a widow and all alone
has set her hope on God.
She continues in requests and prayers night and day.
6 But she
who lives only for pleasure
is dead
while she lives.
7 Command these things too,
so that they may be without reproach.
8 But if anyone doesn't provide for his relatives,
and especially for his own household,
he has denied the faith.
He is worse than an unbeliever.
9 Let no one be put on the list of widows
who is under 60 years old,
and she must have been the wife of one man.
10 She must be known for good works:
if she has brought up children,
if she has welcomed strangers,
if she has washed the saints' feet,
if she has helped people in need
and if she has devoted herself to every good work.
11 But refuse younger widows.
For when their desires draw them away from Christ,
they want to marry.
12 Then they bring judgment on themselves,
because they have broken their first pledge.
13 Besides, they learn
to be idle
and go about from house to house.
And not only idle,
but they are also gossips and busybodies,
meddling in other people's affairs
and saying
things they ought not.
14 So I want
the younger widows to marry,
have children,
manage the household
and give the opponent no reason for insults.
15 For some have already turned away
and follow Satan.
16 If any man or woman who believes has widows in the family,
they should help them.
The church should not be burdened,
so that it can help those
who are truly widows.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Pledge means: a solemn promise.

Verse 3: Widows had a very hard life at that time. There was no pension and no social security. Without a husband or children they were often poor. The church took care of them. That was an early social welfare system.

Verses 4 and 8: Children and grandchildren are to take care of their old parents. That is a command of love and recalls the commandment *Honor your father and mother*.

Verses 9–10: Apparently there was a "list of widows." These widows were provided for by the church and probably also had tasks: praying, welcoming guests, helping the sick.

Verses 11–15: These verses reflect the ideas of that time. Younger widows who were put on the list probably promised not to marry again. The letter thinks: That is too hard for younger women. So they should rather marry again.

Important: Today women have other possibilities. Whether a woman marries, has children or lives alone is her own decision. A woman is not worth less if she lives alone or has no children.

Verse 13: The judgment on "gossips" applies to men just as much as to women.

For today: Christians are to care for old, poor and lonely people, in the family and in the church.

The elders of the church VERSES 17–25

17 The elders
who lead well
should be counted worthy of double honor,
especially those
who work hard at preaching and teaching.
18 For the Scripture says:
"You shall not muzzle the ox
when it treads out the grain."
And:
"The laborer
is worthy of his wages."
19 Don't accept an accusation against an elder,
except on the word of two or three witnesses.
20 Those who sin
you are to correct in front of everyone,

so that the others may also be afraid.
21 I solemnly command you before God,
before the Lord Jesus Christ
and before the chosen angels:
Keep these things without prejudice.
Do nothing out of partiality.
22 Don't lay hands on anyone too quickly.
Don't share in other people's sins.
Keep yourself pure.
23 Don't drink only water any longer,
but use a little wine,
for your stomach's sake
and because you are often sick.
24 Some people's sins are obvious.
They go ahead of them to judgment.
With others they only come to light later.
25 In the same way, good works are also obvious.
And those
that are not
can't stay hidden either.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Muzzle means: to tie an animal's mouth shut.

Treads out the grain means: walks on grain to separate the kernels from the stalks.

Verse 17: "Double honor" probably also means pay. Whoever works for the church should be able to live from it.

Verse 18: The first sentence quotes Deuteronomy 25:4 (compare also 1 Corinthians 9:9). The second sentence is a saying of Jesus (Luke 10:7).

Verse 19: Two or three witnesses: This rule comes from Deuteronomy 19:15. It protects against false accusations.

Very important: This rule must not lead to abuse by leaders being covered up. Victims of abuse often have no witnesses. What they say must be taken seriously. Verses 20–21 say clearly: Whoever sins is held accountable, without partiality, even if he is a leader. You can get help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673.

Verse 22: Laying on hands here means: appointing someone to an office. That should not happen too quickly.

Verse 23: A personal piece of advice to Timothy. At that time wine was also considered a medicine, and the water was often not clean. For today: Whoever has problems with alcohol should rather do without it completely. Help is available at addiction counseling services. US: SAMHSA 1-800-662-4357. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verses 24–25: Not everything is visible right away. But God sees everything, the bad and the good.

1 TIMOTHY

CHAPTER 6

Being content and doing good

A word to the slaves VERSES 1–2

1 All
who are slaves under the yoke
are to count their own masters worthy of all honor,
so that the name of God and the teaching are not
insulted.
2 Those who have believing masters
must not look down on them
because they are brothers.
But rather they are to serve them all the more,
because those
who benefit from their service
are believers and dearly loved.
Teach and urge these things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Yoke means: a wooden bar put on animals so they can pull loads; here a picture for slavery.

At the time of the letter there were very many slaves in the Roman Empire. There were slaves and masters in the churches too.

Verse 1: The letter wanted to avoid the young church being seen as a danger to public order and being persecuted.

Verse 2: Even when slave and master were both Christians and so "brothers," slavery continued. That is hard to understand. But the word "brothers" already showed: Before God they are equal.

Very important: Slavery is a grave injustice. These verses were later misused to justify slavery. That was wrong. Many Christians fought against slavery. Today there is still human trafficking and forced labor. Christians should stand up against it.

True godliness and the danger of money VERSES 3–10

3 If anyone teaches a different doctrine
and doesn't hold to sound words,
the words of our Lord Jesus Christ,
and to the teaching
that fits with godliness,
4 he is conceited
and understands nothing.
He is obsessed with arguments and word battles.
From these come envy,
strife,
insults,
evil suspicions
5 and constant friction among people
whose minds are corrupt
and who lack the truth.
They think
that godliness is a means
of making a profit.
Keep away from such people.
6 But godliness with contentment
is great gain.
7 For we brought nothing into the world,
and we certainly can't carry anything out.
8 If we have food and clothing,
we will be content with that.

9 But those
who are determined to be rich
fall into temptation
and a snare
and many foolish and harmful desires.
These plunge people into ruin
and destruction.
10 For the love of money
is a root of all kinds of evil.
Some, in their greed for it,
have been led astray from the faith.
And they have pierced themselves with many sorrows.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Contentment means: being satisfied with what you have.

Snare means: a trap.

Verse 5: There were teachers who wanted to make money from the faith. That exists today too. Whoever promises that God will make you rich if you donate money is misusing the faith.

Verses 6–8: Contentment is a great treasure. Whoever has enough to live on is rich.

Verse 7: A thought that recalls Job 1:21: We come into the world with nothing and leave with nothing.

Verse 10: Money itself is not evil, but the love of money, that is, greed.

Important: These verses are no reproach to people in poverty who want more so that they can live well. Whoever doesn't have enough to live on may seek help. And Christians are to help make sure that all people have enough.

Fight the good fight VERSES 11–16

11 But you,
man of God,
flee these things.
Pursue righteousness,
godliness,
faith,
love,
perseverance
and gentleness.
12 Fight the good fight of faith.
Take hold of the eternal life
to which you were called.
For this you made the good confession before many witnesses.
13 I command you before God,
who gives life to all things,
and before Christ Jesus,
who made the good confession before Pontius Pilate:
14 Keep the commandment
without spot and without blame
until the appearing of our Lord Jesus Christ.
15 He will show this at the right time,
he who is the blessed and only Ruler,
the King of kings
and Lord of lords.
16 He alone is immortal.
He lives in light
that no one can approach.
No human being has seen him,
and no one can see him.
To him be honor and eternal power.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: Gentleness is at the end of the list. The "fight" of faith is fought with gentleness, not with violence.

Verse 12: "Fight the good fight of faith" is a picture from sports. It means standing up for the faith. The "good confession" probably means the confession of faith at baptism.

Verse 13: Jesus stood by his mission before Pilate (John 18:37). He is the example for all who confess their faith.

Verses 15–16: "The King of kings": No emperor and no ruler stands above God. At that time the Roman emperor let himself be worshiped as a god. The letter says: This honor belongs to God alone.

A word to the rich VERSES 17–19

17 Command those who are rich in this world:
They must not be arrogant.
They must not set their hope on uncertain riches,
but on the living God.
He richly provides us with everything to enjoy.
18 They are to do good
and be rich in good works.
They are to give gladly
and be ready to share.
19 In this way they lay up for themselves a good foundation
for the future,
so that they may take hold of eternal life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Wealth is uncertain. It can be lost quickly. Only God is certain.

Verse 17: "Everything to enjoy": God is glad to give us the good things of life. Enjoying them is no sin.

Verse 18: Whoever has much also has much responsibility. The rich are to share.

For today: This also applies to rich countries. Justice between rich and poor in the world is a Christian concern.

Conclusion VERSES 20–21

20 Timothy,
guard
what has been entrusted to you.
Turn away from the empty chatter
and the arguments of what
is falsely called "knowledge."
21 Some have professed it
and so have wandered from the faith.
Grace be with you.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: "What has been entrusted to you": the Good News of Jesus. Timothy is to guard it like a precious treasure.

"Knowledge" (Greek *gnosis*): Some teachers claimed to have special, secret knowledge. Later a movement grew out of this that is called *Gnosticism*.

Looking back: What have we read in the first letter to Timothy?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Christ saves sinners: Jesus came into the world to save sinners. Paul too, the former persecutor, obtained mercy (chapter 1).

God wants all people to be saved: That is why Christians are to pray for all people (chapter 2).

Difficult verses about women: Churches understand chapter 2 in very different ways. Man and woman are of equal worth before God.

Good leaders: Whoever carries responsibility needs good character. Power must not be misused (chapters 3 and 5).

God's creation is good: Food, the body and marriage are gifts from God (chapter 4).

Caring for one another: for widows, the elderly and those in need (chapter 5).

Contentment instead of greed: The love of money leads to ruin. The rich are to share (chapter 6).

Important note: The rules about slaves reflect the time back then. Slavery is a grave injustice.

For today: Faith shows itself in everyday life: in honesty, care, modesty and love.

What comes next? Next comes the second letter to Timothy. It is like a farewell letter from Paul in prison.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 55 OF 66

2 TIMOTHY

4 CHAPTERS

2 TIMOTHY

Chapter 1

Don't be ashamed

Before we begin: The second letter to Timothy

This letter is like a farewell letter. Paul is in prison in Rome (1:17). He expects to be executed soon (4:6). Many have left him. Only Luke is still with him (4:11).

Paul writes to Timothy, his *dear child* in faith. He encourages him to stay faithful, even when it gets hard. And he asks him to come to him soon.

As with the first letter to Timothy, many scholars think that a student of Paul wrote the letter, in Paul's spirit. Others consider Paul himself to be the author. This letter in particular contains many personal details.

The second letter to Timothy has 4 chapters.

Greeting VERSES 1–2

1 Paul,
an apostle of Jesus Christ through the will of God,
according to the promise of the life
which is in Christ Jesus,
2 writes to Timothy,
his dear child:
Grace,
mercy
and peace
from God the Father
and from Christ Jesus our Lord.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "The promise of the life which is in Christ Jesus": Paul expects death. But he knows: In Christ there is life that does not end.

Thanks and encouragement VERSES 3–7

3 I thank God,
whom I serve as my ancestors did,
with a pure conscience.
Without ceasing I remember you in my prayers,
night and day.
4 I long
to see you.
I remember your tears.
When I see you,
I will be filled with joy.
5 I remember your sincere faith.
It lived first in your grandmother Lois
and in your mother Eunice.
And I am convinced:
It lives in you also.
6 That is why I remind you:
Stir up the gift of God
that is in you
since I laid my hands on you.
7 For God didn't give us a spirit of fear,
but of power,
love
and self-control.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: "As my ancestors did": Paul sees himself in the tradition of his Jewish ancestors. He serves the same God as they did.

Verse 4: "Your tears": Probably at their last farewell. Friendship and tears are part of faith.

Verse 5: Faith was passed on in the family, from grandmother Lois to mother Eunice and to Timothy. His mother was Jewish (Acts 16:1). Women passed on the faith.

Verse 6: "Stir up": like a fire that is fanned again. Gifts can fall asleep if they are not used.

Verse 7 is a great verse of comfort: God's Spirit doesn't make us fearful, but brave, loving and self-controlled.

Important: This doesn't mean that Christians are never afraid. Fear is a normal feeling. Whoever suffers from strong fears may seek help. That is no sign of weak faith. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Don't be ashamed of the Good News VERSES 8–14

8 So don't be ashamed of the testimony of our Lord,
nor of me,
his prisoner.
But endure hardship for the Good News,
by the power of God.
9 He saved us
and called us with a holy calling,
not because of our works,
but according to his own purpose and grace.
This grace was given to us in Christ Jesus
before times eternal.
10 But now it has been revealed
by the appearing of our Savior Christ Jesus.
He abolished death
and brought life and immortality to light
through the Good News.
11 For this I was appointed
as a preacher,
an apostle
and a teacher of the nations.
12 That is why I also suffer these things.
Yet I am not ashamed.
For I know him
whom I have believed.
And I am convinced
that he is able to guard
what I have entrusted to him
until that day.
13 Hold to the pattern of sound words
that you heard from me,
in faith and love
which are in Christ Jesus.

14 Guard the good treasure
that was entrusted to you,
through the Holy Spirit
who lives in us.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Immortality means: life that never ends.

Verse 8: At that time being a prisoner was a disgrace. Many were ashamed to be connected with Paul. Paul asks Timothy: Stand by me and by the Good News.

Verse 9: Salvation is God's gift, not something we earn.

Verse 10: "He abolished death": Death no longer has the last word.

Verse 12: "I know him whom I have believed": Paul doesn't trust in an idea, but in a person, in Jesus. He puts his life into God's hands.

Faithfulness and unfaithfulness VERSES 15–18

15 You know
that all who are in Asia have turned away from me,
among them Phygelus and Hermogenes.
16 May the Lord grant mercy to the house of
Onesiphorus.
For he often refreshed me
and was not ashamed of my chain.
17 But when he was in Rome,
he searched for me eagerly
and found me.
18 May the Lord grant him
to find the Lord's mercy on that day.
And how much he helped in Ephesus,
you know very well.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: "Asia" was the Roman province in the west of what is now Turkey, with Ephesus as its capital. Many had let Paul down. That hurt him.

Verses 16–17: Onesiphorus was different. He searched for Paul in Rome, even though it was dangerous, and visited him in prison.

For today: Visiting prisoners, the sick and the lonely is a work of love (compare Matthew 25:36). A visit can mean a lot.

Verse 18: Paul speaks of the "house of Onesiphorus" and prays for him. Some interpreters think that Onesiphorus had already died.

2 TIMOTHY

CHAPTER 2

A good worker for God

Be strong and hold out VERSES 1–7

1 You then,
my child,
be strong in the grace
that is in Christ Jesus.
2 What you have heard from me before many witnesses,
entrust to faithful people
who will be able
to teach others also.
3 So endure hardship
as a good soldier of Christ Jesus.
4 No soldier on duty
gets tangled up in the affairs of everyday life.
He wants to please the one
who enlisted him.
5 And whoever competes in athletics
only receives the victor's wreath
if he competes by the rules.
6 The farmer
who works hard
should be the first to get a share of the crops.
7 Think about
what I am saying.
May the Lord give you understanding in all things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: This is how faith is passed on: from Paul to Timothy, from Timothy to other faithful people, and from them on to others. To this day.

Verses 3–6: Three pictures: the soldier, the athlete and the farmer. All three need commitment, perseverance and patience.

Important: The picture of the soldier doesn't mean that Christians should use violence. It is about faithfulness and devotion.

God's word is not chained VERSES 8–13

8 Remember Jesus Christ,
risen from the dead,
of the offspring of David.
That is what my Good News says.
9 For it I suffer hardship
to the point of chains,
like a criminal.
But God's word isn't chained.
10 That is why I endure all things
for the sake of the chosen ones,
so that they too may obtain the salvation that is in
Christ Jesus,
with eternal glory.
11 This saying is trustworthy:
"For if we died with him,
we will also live with him.
12 If we endure,
we will also reign with him.
If we deny him,
he also will deny us.
13 If we are faithless,
he remains faithful.
For he can't deny himself."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: "Of the offspring of David": Jesus is the Messiah whom God promised to Israel.

Verse 9: Paul is in chains, but no one can chain God's word. It keeps spreading.

Verses 11–13 are probably an old song or confession of the first Christians.

Verse 13 is a great comfort: Even if we are faithless, God remains faithful. His faithfulness does not depend on ours.

A worker who doesn't need to be ashamed VERSES 14–21

14 Remind them of these things.
Warn them before the Lord
not to argue about words.
That does no good,
but harms those
who listen.

15 Do your best
to present yourself to God as approved,
as a worker
who doesn't need to be ashamed,
because he handles the word of truth properly.

16 But avoid empty chatter.
For it leads further and further into ungodliness.

17 And such words spread like gangrene.
Among these are Hymenaeus and Philetus.

18 They have wandered from the truth.
They say
that the resurrection has already happened.
And they are upsetting the faith of some people.

19 However, God's firm foundation stands.
It has this seal:
"The Lord knows those
who are his."
And:
"Let every one
who names the name of the Lord
turn away from doing wrong."

20 In a large house there are not only vessels of gold and silver,
but also of wood and clay.
Some are for honorable use,
others for ordinary use.

21 So whoever cleanses himself from these things
will be a vessel for honorable use,
made holy
and useful to the master of the house,
prepared for every good work.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gangrene means: a disease in which flesh rots and the damage keeps spreading.

Vessels means: containers such as dishes, jars and bowls.

Verse 14: Arguing about words helps no one. It only does harm.

Verse 15: Whoever explains God's word should do it carefully and honestly, like a good craftsman.

Verse 18: Hymenaeus and Philetus taught: The resurrection has already happened, but only spiritually. In this way they denied the hope of a future resurrection.

Verse 19: The first sentence recalls Numbers 16:5. There Moses says: "In the morning the LORD will show who belongs to him." God knows his own, even when people are wrong.

Verses 20–21: A picture from the household: There are valuable dishes and simple ones. But every person can become a "vessel" that God can use.

Be gentle toward all VERSES 22–26

22 Flee from youthful lusts.
Pursue righteousness,
faith,
love
and peace,
together with all
who call on the Lord out of a pure heart.

23 Refuse foolish and senseless arguments.
You know
that they only produce quarrels.

24 The Lord's servant must not quarrel.
But he must be gentle toward all,
able to teach
and patient.

25 He must correct those
who oppose him
with gentleness.
Perhaps God will give them repentance,
so that they come to know the truth

26 and come to their senses again.
Then they can escape from the snare of the devil,
who has taken them captive
to do his will.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Repentance means: turning around, changing your heart and life.

Righteousness means: living right before God.

Verse 22: "Youthful lusts" probably doesn't mean only sexual desires, but also impatience, love of quarreling and ambition.

Verses 24–25: Important advice for everyone who has responsibility in the church: Don't quarrel, but be gentle, patient and kind, even toward opponents.

Verses 25–26: The goal is not to defeat the other person, but to help them find the truth. God gives repentance, not pressure.

2 TIMOTHY

CHAPTER 3

Stay with what you have learned

Hard times VERSES 1–9

1 But know this:
In the last days hard times will come.

2 For people will love themselves
and love money.
They will be boastful,
arrogant

and blasphemers.
They will be disobedient to parents,
unthankful
and unholy,
3 without love for their own families,
unforgiving,
slanderers,
without self-control,
brutal
and not lovers of good.
4 They will be traitors,
headstrong
and conceited.
They love pleasure more than God.
5 They hold a form of godliness,
but they have denied its power.
Turn away from such people.
6 For among them are those
who creep into houses
and take captive gullible women
who are loaded down with sins
and led away by all kinds of desires.
7 They are always learning
and never able to come to the knowledge of the truth.
8 Just as Jannes and Jambres opposed Moses,
so these also oppose the truth.
Their minds are corrupt,
and they have failed in the faith.
9 But they will not get far.
For their foolishness will be obvious to all,
as it was with those two.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Blasphemers means: people who mock or insult God.

Gullible means: easily fooled.

Verse 1: For the New Testament, "the last days" means the whole time since Jesus. It is not about a particular date.

Verses 2–5: The list describes people who think only of themselves. The worst thing: They act pious, but their lives are not changed by God (verse 5).

Verses 6–7: These teachers deliberately looked for people who were unsure or burdened, in order to influence them. At that time women usually had no chance of a good education. That is why they were easier to deceive. This is no judgment about women in themselves.

For today: Today too there are groups and people who deliberately approach people in crisis and make them dependent. Counseling services for cults and spiritual abuse can help.

Verse 8: According to Jewish tradition, Jannes and Jambres are the names of the Egyptian magicians who opposed Moses (compare Exodus 7:11). In the Bible itself their names are mentioned only here.

Stay with what you have learned VERSES 10–17

10 But you have followed my teaching,
my conduct,
my purpose,
my faith,
my patience,
my love
and my steadfastness,
11 also my persecutions and sufferings,
the things that happened to me at Antioch,
at Iconium
and at Lystra.
I endured those persecutions.
And the Lord rescued me out of them all.
12 Yes,
all
who want to live a godly life in Christ Jesus
will be persecuted.
13 But evil people and impostors
will grow worse and worse.
They deceive others
and are deceived themselves.
14 But you must remain in the things
that you have learned
and are sure of.
For you know
from whom you learned them.
15 And from infancy you have known the holy
Scriptures.
They are able to make you wise for salvation
through faith in Christ Jesus.
16 Every Scripture is God-breathed
and useful for teaching,
for showing what is wrong,
for correcting
and for training in righteousness,
17 so that each person
who belongs to God
may be complete
and well equipped for every good work.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Impostors means: people who pretend to be someone they are not.

Verse 11: Paul was persecuted in these cities. In Lystra he was even stoned (Acts 14:19). Timothy came from this region and probably saw it happen.

Verse 12: Whoever takes their faith seriously may face opposition because of it. But that doesn't mean you should seek suffering.

Verses 14–15: Timothy came to know the holy Scriptures as a child, from his mother and grandmother (compare 1:5). This means the Scriptures of Israel, our Old Testament.

Verse 16: The WEB says "God-breathed," that is: *breathed out by God*. The Bible came into being through God's Spirit. But it was written by human beings, in their language and in their time.

Christians understand this verse in different ways: Some stress that every word of the Bible comes exactly from God. Others stress that God speaks through human words that must be understood in their time. Everyone agrees: The Bible is important for faith and life.

Verse 17: The goal of Scripture is that people do good.

2 TIMOTHY

CHAPTER 4

I have finished the race

Preach the word VERSES 1–5

1 I solemnly command you before God
and before the Lord Jesus Christ,
who will judge the living and the dead
at his appearing
and his Kingdom:
2 Preach the word.
Be ready
in season and out of season.
Correct,
rebuke
and encourage,
with all patience and teaching.
3 For the time will come
when people will not put up with sound teaching.
But having itching ears,
they will gather around themselves teachers
who suit their own desires.
4 They will turn their ears away from the truth
and turn to fables.
5 But you must keep a clear head in all things.
Endure hardship.
Do the work of an evangelist.
Fulfill your ministry completely.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: "In season and out of season": You should not pass on the Good News only when it is convenient. But always "with all patience," not pushy or rude.

Verses 3–4: "Itching ears" means: wanting to hear only what you like. That happens in every age.

Verse 5: An "evangelist" is someone who passes on the Good News (in Greek *euangelion*).

Paul says farewell VERSES 6–8

6 For I am already being poured out as an offering.
The time of my departure has come.
7 I have fought the good fight.
I have finished the race.
I have kept the faith.
8 From now on the crown of righteousness is stored up
for me.
The Lord,
the righteous judge,
will give it to me on that day.
And not to me only,
but also to all
who have loved his appearing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: "Poured out as an offering": A picture of the drink offering, in which wine was poured out (compare Philippians 2:17). Paul expects to be executed. According to old tradition, Paul was executed in Rome, probably under Emperor Nero.

"Departure": Paul speaks of death as of a journey. He is going to Christ.

Verse 7: Three pictures: the fight, the race in the stadium and faithfulness. Paul looks back on his life with contentment.

Verse 8: The "crown" was a wreath of leaves that winners received at a competition. God gives this crown not only to Paul, but to all who hope in Jesus.

Personal requests VERSES 9–18

9 Do your best
to come to me soon.
10 For Demas has left me,
because he loved this present world,
and has gone to Thessalonica.
Crescens has gone to Galatia,
Titus to Dalmatia.
11 Only Luke is with me.
Get Mark and bring him with you.
For he is useful to me for service.
12 But I sent Tychicus to Ephesus.
13 When you come,
bring the cloak
that I left at Troas with Carpus,
and the books,
especially the parchments.
14 Alexander,
the coppersmith,
did me much harm.
The Lord will repay him according to his deeds.
15 You too, beware of him.
For he strongly opposed our words.
16 At my first defense in court
no one stood by me.
All left me.
May it not be held against them.
17 But the Lord stood by me
and strengthened me,
so that through me the message might be fully
proclaimed
and all the nations might hear it.
So I was rescued out of the mouth of the lion.
18 And the Lord will rescue me from every evil work
and keep me safe for his heavenly Kingdom.
To him be the glory forever and ever.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Parchments means: writing material made from animal skin.

Verses 10–11: Paul is lonely. Some have left him. Only Luke, the doctor, is with him.

Verse 11: Mark had once parted from Paul (Acts 15:37–39). Now Paul specifically asks for him. Reconciliation is possible.

Verse 13: A very human wish: Paul is cold in prison and needs his cloak. And he wants to read his books.

Verse 16: "May it not be held against them": Paul forgives those who let him down, just as Jesus forgave on the cross (Luke 23:34).

Verse 17: "The mouth of the lion": a picture of great danger to life (compare Psalm 22:21, in the Hebrew Bible and in some Bibles 22:22).

Verse 18: Paul trusts: Even if he dies, he is safe with God.

Last greetings VERSES 19–22

19 Greet Prisca and Aquila
and the house of Onesiphorus.
20 Erastus stayed in Corinth.
But I left Trophimus sick at Miletus.
21 Do your best
to come before winter.
Eubulus greets you,
as do Pudens,
Linus,
Claudia
and all the brothers.
22 The Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit.
Grace be with you.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: Prisca (also called Priscilla) and Aquila were a married couple and close coworkers of Paul. Prisca is often named first. She was probably especially important in the church.

Verse 20: Paul did not heal Trophimus, but left him behind sick. Apostles too could not heal every illness. Illness is not a punishment and not a sign of weak faith.

Verse 21: "Before winter": In winter no ships sailed. Paul hopes to see Timothy one more time.

Among those sending greetings is also a woman: Claudia. According to old tradition, Linus later became a leader of the church in Rome.

Looking back: What have we read in the second letter to Timothy?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A farewell letter: Paul is in prison in Rome and expects to die. He writes to Timothy, his *dear child* in faith.

No spirit of fear: God gives power, love and self-control (chapter 1).

Faith is passed on: from grandmother to mother to son, from Paul to Timothy, from Timothy to others (chapters 1 and 2).

God remains faithful: even when we are faithless (chapter 2).

Staying gentle: God's servants are not to quarrel, but to be patient and gentle (chapter 2).

The holy Scriptures: They are God-breathed and help toward faith and a good life (chapter 3).

Finishing the race: Paul looks back on his life. He has kept the faith (chapter 4).

Loneliness and forgiveness: Many have left Paul. He forgives them and trusts in God (chapter 4).

For today: Even at the end of life we may know that we are safe in God's hands.

What comes next? Next comes the letter to Titus, another coworker of Paul, on the island of Crete.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 56 OF 66

TITUS

3 CHAPTERS

TITUS

Chapter 1

Good leaders for the churches on Crete

Before we begin: The letter to Titus

Titus was a coworker of Paul. He was not a Jew, but a Greek (Galatians 2:3). Paul entrusted him with important tasks, for example in Corinth (2 Corinthians 7 and 8).

According to the letter, Paul left Titus behind on the island of Crete. Titus is to put the young churches in order there and appoint leaders.

Together with the two letters to Timothy, the letter to Titus belongs to the *Pastoral Letters*. Many scholars think that a student of Paul wrote them, in Paul's spirit. Others consider Paul himself to be the author.

The great theme is: God's grace has appeared. It changes life. Christians are to do good.

Important note: In chapter 1 there are harsh words about "those of the circumcision," about "Jewish fables" and about the people of Crete. In the boxes we explain why these words must not be used against Jews or against any people.

The letter to Titus has 3 chapters.

Greeting VERSES 1–4

1 Paul,
a servant of God
and an apostle of Jesus Christ,
for the faith of God's chosen ones
and the knowledge of the truth
which leads to godliness,
2 in hope of eternal life.
God,
who can't lie,
promised it before time began.
3 But in his own time he revealed his word
in the message
with which I was entrusted
by the command of God our Savior.
4 Paul writes to Titus,
his true child in a common faith:
Grace,
mercy
and peace
from God the Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ our Savior.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: "God, who can't lie": You can rely on God's promises.

Verse 4: "In a common faith": Paul was a Jew, Titus was a Greek. Faith in Christ connects them.

Who can be a church leader VERSES 5–9

5 I left you in Crete
so that you would set in order
what was still lacking
and appoint elders in every city,
as I directed you.
6 An elder must be blameless,
the husband of one wife.
He must have children
who believe
and who are not accused of wild or unruly behavior.
7 For the overseer must be blameless,
as God's steward.
He must not be self-pleasing,
not quick-tempered,
not a drinker,
not violent
and not greedy for dishonest gain.
8 But he must be hospitable,
a lover of good,
sensible,
fair,
holy
and self-controlled.
9 He must hold to the trustworthy word
as it was taught.
Then he can encourage with sound teaching
and correct those
who contradict him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Steward means: someone who manages things for the owner.

Verses 5–9: Similar to 1 Timothy 3. For leaders, character counts: not quick-tempered, not violent, not greedy for money, but hospitable, fair and self-controlled.

Verses 5 and 7: "Elders" and "overseer" probably mean the same people here: the leaders of the local church.

Verse 6: The children are not to live in a "wild or unruly" way. That doesn't mean that parents are to blame for everything their adult children do.

Warning against false teachers VERSES 10–16

10 For there are many unruly people,
empty talkers and deceivers,
especially those of the circumcision.
11 They must be silenced.
They upset whole families
and teach
things they ought not,
for the sake of dishonest gain.
12 One of them,
a prophet of their own,
said:
"Cretans are always liars,
evil beasts
and lazy gluttons."
13 This testimony is true.
So correct them sharply,
so that they may be sound in the faith

14 and not pay attention to Jewish fables
and commandments of people
who turn away from the truth.
15 To the pure, all things are pure.
But to those who are defiled and unbelieving nothing is pure.
Instead, both their mind and their conscience are defiled.
16 They claim
that they know God,
but by their deeds they deny him.
They are detestable,
disobedient
and unfit for any good work.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verses 10–16 contain harsh words. They must never be used against Jews or against the people of any nation.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Gluttons means: people who eat far too much.

Defiled means: made unclean.

Verse 10: "Those of the circumcision" were probably teachers within the Christian church who themselves came from Judaism. They demanded certain rules from the Christians from the nations. It is an argument among Christians, as in the letter to the Galatians.

Verse 12: The quotation probably comes from the Greek poet Epimenides, who himself came from Crete. It was a well-known saying at that time.

Very important: Sweeping judgments about the people of a nation are wrong. No people is "always" evil or dishonest. Prejudice against people because of where they come from hurts their dignity. God loves all people equally.

Verse 14: "Jewish fables": This probably means certain speculations and legends that these teachers spread. It is no judgment about the Jewish faith or the holy Scriptures of Israel. Paul himself was a Jew and held the Scriptures of Israel in high esteem (compare 2 Timothy 3:15–16).

Verse 15: "To the pure, all things are pure": similar to what Jesus says: Not what comes from outside makes a person unclean, but what comes out of the heart (Mark 7:15).

Verse 16: Faith shows itself in deeds, not only in words.

TITUS

CHAPTER 2

God's grace has appeared

Advice for old and young VERSES 1–8

1 But as for you, say the things
that fit sound teaching.
2 The older men are to be moderate,
sensible,
clear-minded,
sound in faith,
in love
and in perseverance.
3 In the same way, the older women are to be
reverent in how they behave.
That means: they show deep respect for God.
They must not be slanderers
and not be enslaved to much wine.
They are to be teachers of that which is good,
4 so that they may train the young women
to love their husbands
and to love their children,
5 to be sensible,
pure,
workers at home,
kind
and submit to their own husbands,
so that no one speaks evil of God's word.
6 In the same way, urge the younger men
to be sensible.
7 In all things show yourself an example of good works.
In your teaching show integrity,
seriousness
and incorruptibility,
8 and sound speech
that can't be condemned.
Then the opponent will be ashamed,
because he has nothing bad to say about us.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Incorruptibility means: not letting yourself be bribed or led astray.

Verses 2–6: There is advice for each group: older men, older women, young women and young men. All are to be "sensible."

Verse 3: Older women are to be "teachers of that which is good." Women had an important task as teachers of other women.

Verses 4–5: These roles reflect the family order of that time. The reason is given: "so that no one speaks evil of God's word." The young church did not want to give offense in its surroundings.

Today many Christians understand marriage as a partnership of two people with equal rights. Others hold on to a special responsibility of the husband. All stress: It is about love, not about power.

Very important: These verses give no one the right to rule over their spouse or to use violence. Violence in marriage is a serious wrong and a crime. You can get help. In the US, call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. In the UK, call the National Domestic Abuse Helpline at 0808 2000 247. Men can also call the Men's Advice Line at 0808 801 0327. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

A word to the slaves VERSES 9–10

9 Urge servants
to submit to their own masters.
They are to please them in all things,
not talk back,
10 not steal,
but show complete faithfulness,

so that they may adorn the teaching of God our Savior
in all things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The WEB says *servants* here. Slaves are meant.

Verse 10: It is remarkable: Slaves too can "adorn the teaching of God." They count as valuable witnesses of the faith, not just as property.

Very important: Slavery is a grave injustice. These verses were later misused to justify slavery. That was wrong. Today there is still human trafficking and forced labor. Christians should stand up against it. If you know about trafficking or forced labor, you can get help. In the US, call the National Human Trafficking Hotline at 1-888-373-7888. In the UK, call the Modern Slavery Helpline at 08000 121 700.

The grace of God has appeared VERSES 11–15

11 For the grace of God has appeared.
It brings salvation to all people.
12 It trains us
to say no to ungodliness and worldly desires
and to live sensibly,
justly
and godly in this present age.
13 We are waiting for the blessed hope:
the appearing of the glory of our great God and Savior,
Jesus Christ.
14 He gave himself for us,
to set us free from all wrongdoing
and to purify for himself a people for his own
possession,
a people eager
to do good works.
15 Say these things.
Encourage
and correct
with all authority.
Let no one look down on you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11 is the heart of the letter: God's grace is for all people.

Verse 12: Grace is like a teacher. It helps us to live well. Grace is not only forgiveness, but also strength for a new start.

Verse 13: "Our great God and Savior, Jesus Christ": Many interpreters understand this to mean that Jesus is called God here. Others translate: *the great God and our Savior Jesus Christ*.

Verse 14: Christ gave himself in order to "purify for himself a people for his own possession." These words come from the Scriptures of Israel (compare Exodus 19:5). God chose Israel. Through Christ people from all nations are added. Israel is not replaced by this (compare Romans 11:1–2, 29).

TITUS

CHAPTER 3

Saved by God's kindness

Gentle toward all people VERSES 1–2

1 Remind them
to be subject to rulers and authorities,
to be obedient
and to be ready for every good work.
2 They are to speak evil of no one,
not to be quarrelsome,
but gentle,
showing all humility toward all people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Christians are to keep the order of the state and do good for society (compare Romans 13).

Important: This doesn't mean that you have to do everything the state demands. If a state commands injustice, you must obey God rather than people (Acts 5:29).

Verse 2: "Toward all people": Gentleness is not only for Christians, but for everyone.

God's kindness has saved us VERSES 3–8

3 For we too were once foolish,
disobedient
and led astray.
We were slaves to all kinds of desires and pleasures.
We lived in malice and envy,
were hateful
and hated one another.
4 But then the kindness of God our Savior
and his love toward mankind appeared.
5 He saved us,
not because of right deeds
that we ourselves had done,
but because he is merciful.
He saved us through the washing of new birth
and renewing by the Holy Spirit.
6 He poured out the Spirit on us richly
through Jesus Christ our Savior,
7 so that, being made right with God by his grace,
we might become heirs
according to the hope of eternal life.
8 This saying is trustworthy.
I want
you to insist on these things firmly,
so that those
who have believed God
may be careful
to do good works.
These things are good and useful for people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: "We too": Paul includes himself. No one is better than others by nature.

Verse 4: "His love toward mankind": The Greek word for this is *philanthropia*. Our word *philanthropy*, love for people, comes from it. God is a friend of people.

Verse 5: Salvation is God's gift out of mercy. "The washing of new birth" means baptism. Through it a new life begins.

Verses 4–7 are a short summary of the whole faith: God loves people, he saves by grace, he gives the Holy Spirit and the

hope of eternal life.

Verse 8: We are not saved by good works. But whoever is saved is to do good.

Avoid quarrels VERSES 9–11

9 But avoid foolish arguments,
family trees,
strife
and disputes about the law.
For they are useless and empty.
10 After a first and second warning,
avoid a person
who causes divisions.
11 You know
that such a person is twisted and sinful.
He has condemned himself.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: Quarreling about little things leads nowhere. That is also true today in churches.

Verse 10: Whoever causes division again and again gets two warnings. Only then should you part from him. Patience comes before strictness.

Last instructions and greetings VERSES 12–15

12 When I send Artemas or Tychicus to you,
do your best
to come to me at Nicopolis.
For I have decided
to spend the winter there.
13 Send Zenas the lawyer and Apollos
on their journey quickly,
so that they lack nothing.
14 Our people too are to learn
to do good works,
to help in urgent needs,
so that they will not be unfruitful.
15 All
who are with me
greet you.
Greet those
who love us in faith.
Grace be with you all.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Nicopolis was probably a city on the west coast of Greece.

Verse 13: Apollos was a well-known preacher (Acts 18:24–28). Zenas was a "lawyer," either an expert in the Jewish law or a legal expert.

Verse 14: Good works are very practical: helping people in need.

Looking back: What have we read in the letter to Titus?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Good leaders: Titus is to appoint leaders on Crete who have good character (Chapter 1).

A difficult passage: The harsh words in chapter 1 must not be used against Jews or against any people. Sweeping judgments about people are wrong.

For every age: Advice for old and young, women and men. Some roles reflect the time back then (Chapter 2).

God's grace has appeared: It brings salvation to all people and helps us live well (Chapter 2).

God loves people: He saves not because of our deeds, but out of mercy (Chapter 3).

Good works: Whoever is saved is to help others in their need (Chapter 3).

For today: God is a friend of people. That is why Christians too are to be kind to everyone.

What comes next? Next comes the short letter to Philemon. It is about a runaway slave who has become a brother.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 57 OF 66

PHILEMON

1 CHAPTER

PHILEMON

CHAPTER 1

No longer as a slave, but as a brother

Before we begin: The letter to Philemon

The letter to Philemon is the shortest letter of Paul. It has only one chapter. Almost all scholars agree that Paul wrote it himself.

Philemon was a well-off Christian, probably in Colossae. A church met in his house.

Onesimus was a slave of Philemon. He went away from him, perhaps he ran away. He came to Paul, who was in prison. There Onesimus became a Christian.

Now Paul sends him back to Philemon, with this letter. Paul asks Philemon to receive Onesimus no longer as a slave, but as a beloved brother.

Important note: The letter does not openly demand the end of slavery. But it puts slavery in a new light: A slave is a brother. Later this message led many Christians to fight against slavery.

Greeting VERSES 1–3

1 Paul,
a prisoner of Christ Jesus,
and Timothy,
our brother,
write to Philemon,
our beloved fellow worker,
2 to the beloved Apphia,
to Archippus,
our fellow soldier,
and to the church in your house:
3 Grace to you and peace
from God our Father
and the Lord Jesus Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Paul calls himself "a prisoner of Christ Jesus." He is in prison, but he sees himself as someone who belongs to Christ.

Verse 2: Apphia was probably Philemon's wife. She is named specifically. Archippus is also mentioned in Colossians 4:17.

"The church in your house": The first Christians had no church buildings. They met in private homes.

In verse 2 the WEB says "the beloved Apphia." Some old manuscripts say *Apphia, the sister*.

Thanks for Philemon's love VERSES 4–7

4 I always thank my God
when I remember you in my prayers.
5 For I hear of your love
and of the faith
that you have toward the Lord Jesus
and toward all the saints.
6 I pray
that the fellowship
that comes from your faith
may become effective,
so that you know every good thing
that is ours in Christ Jesus.
7 For we have much joy and comfort in your love.
For through you,
brother,
the hearts of the saints have been refreshed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–7: Philemon is known for his love for other Christians. Paul praises him honestly. Now Philemon is to show this love to Onesimus too.

Verse 7: "Refreshed": Philemon did others good, like a cool drink on a hot day.

Paul appeals for Onesimus VERSES 8–22

8 So in Christ I could boldly command you
to do what is right.
9 But for love's sake I would rather appeal to you,
I,
Paul,
an old man
and now also a prisoner of Jesus Christ.
10 I appeal to you for my child Onesimus.
I became his father in my chains.
11 He was once useless to you,
but now he is useful to you and to me.
12 I am sending him back to you.
Receive him,
for he is my own heart.
13 I would have liked to keep him with me,
so that he might serve me in your place
while I am in chains for the Good News.
14 But I didn't want to do anything without your consent.
For your good deed should not be forced,
but of your own free will.
15 For perhaps he was separated from you for a while for
this reason,
so that you would have him back forever,
16 no longer as a slave,
but more than a slave:
a beloved brother.
He is that especially to me,
but how much more to you,
both as a person and in the Lord.
17 So if you count me a partner,
receive him as you would receive me.
18 But if he has wronged you
or owes you anything,
put that on my account.
19 I,
Paul,
write this with my own hand:
I will repay it.
I won't even mention
that you owe me your very self.
20 Yes,
brother,
let me have joy from you in the Lord.
Refresh my heart in the Lord.
21 I write to you
because I am confident
of your obedience.
I know
that you will do even beyond what I say.
22 Also, prepare a guest room for me.
For I hope
that through your prayers I will be given back to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 8–9: Paul could command. But he appeals. Love does not force.

Verse 10: Onesimus became a Christian in prison through Paul. That is why Paul calls him "my child."

Verse 11: A play on words: The name *Onesimus* means *useful* in Greek. Once he was "useless," now he is truly "useful."

Verse 12: "My own heart": Paul loves Onesimus very much. At that time a slave was considered property. Paul calls him his heart.

Verse 16 is the most important verse: "no longer as a slave, but more than a slave: a beloved brother." In Christ master and slave are brothers and sisters. That changed the relationship from the ground up.

Verse 17: "Receive him as you would receive me": Onesimus is to be treated like Paul, the apostle.

Verses 18–19: Paul wants to pay any debts of Onesimus himself. This recalls how Christ stands up for us.

Verse 21: "Even beyond what I say": Many interpreters understand this as a hint that Philemon should set Onesimus free.

For today: The letter shows how faith changes relationships. No human being may belong to another. Every person is a brother or a sister. Today there is still human trafficking and forced labor. Christians should stand up against it. If you know about trafficking or forced labor, you can get help. In the US, call the National Human Trafficking Hotline at 1-888-373-7888. In the UK, call the Modern Slavery Helpline at 08000 121 700.

Greetings VERSES 23–25

23 Epaphras,
my fellow prisoner in Christ Jesus,
greets you,
24 as do Mark,
Aristarchus,
Demas
and Luke,
my fellow workers.
25 The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ
be with your spirit.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 23–24: Almost the same names also appear in Colossians 4:10–14. That is why many interpreters think that the two letters were written at the same time and taken to Colossae together.

According to an old tradition, an Onesimus later became bishop of Ephesus. We don't know for sure whether it is the same man.

Looking back: What have we read in the letter to Philemon?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A personal letter: Paul writes from prison to his friend Philemon, to Apphia, to Archippus and to the house church.

Appealing instead of commanding: Paul could command, but he appeals out of love. Philemon is to do good of his own free will.

A slave becomes a brother: Onesimus has become a Christian. Philemon is to receive him no longer as a slave, but as a beloved brother.

Paul stands up for Onesimus: He wants to pay himself what Onesimus owes.

For today: Faith changes how we see one another. Every person has the same dignity. No one may belong to another.

What comes next? Next comes the letter to the Hebrews. It explains who Jesus is, with many pictures from the Scriptures of Israel.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 58 OF 66

HEBREWS

13 CHAPTERS

HEBREWS

Chapter 1

God has spoken through his Son

Before we begin: The letter to the Hebrews

We don't know who wrote the letter to the Hebrews. In the past people thought of Paul. Today almost all scholars think that it comes from someone else. Some have thought of Apollos, Barnabas or Priscilla. Already in the early church people said: Only God knows who wrote it.

The letter is more a long sermon than a letter. It is written to Christians who have become tired and are in danger of giving up their faith.

The author knows the Scriptures of Israel very well. He quotes them often and uses their pictures to explain who Jesus is: the Son of God, greater than the angels, the true high priest.

Important note: The letter to the Hebrews often compares the "old" and the "new" covenant. In history it was sometimes read as if God had rejected the Jewish people. That is wrong. Paul writes clearly: God has not rejected his people (Romans 11:1–2, 29). We explain this in the boxes.

The letter to the Hebrews has 13 chapters.

God speaks through his Son VERSES 1–4

1 Long ago God spoke to our ancestors
at many times and in many ways,
through the prophets.
2 Now at the end of these days
he has spoken to us through his Son.
He made him heir of all things.
Through him he also made the worlds.
3 The Son is the radiance of his glory
and the exact image of his being.
He holds up all things by his powerful word.
He himself made us clean from our sins.
After that he sat down
at the right hand of the Majesty on high.
4 He has become as much greater than the angels
as the name
that he has inherited
is greater than their name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: God has always spoken: through the prophets of Israel. That was God truly speaking. It remains valuable.

Verse 2: Now God speaks through his Son Jesus. He is God's most important word to people.

Verse 3: "The radiance of his glory": Just as the rays of the sun belong to the sun, the Son belongs to God. Whoever sees Jesus sees what God is like.

"At the right hand": the place of honor next to the king. The picture comes from Psalm 110:1.

The Son is greater than the angels VERSES 5–14

5 For to which of the angels did God ever say,
"You are my Son.
Today I have become your father"?
And again,
"I will be to him a Father,
and he will be to me a Son."
6 And when he brings the firstborn into the world again,
he says,
"Let all the angels of God worship him."
7 Of the angels he says,
"He makes his angels winds,
and his servants a flame of fire."
8 But of the Son he says,
"Your throne,
O God,
is forever and ever.
The scepter of righteousness
is the scepter of your Kingdom.
9 You have loved righteousness
and hated wrongdoing.
That is why God,
your God,
has anointed you with the oil of gladness
above your companions."
10 And,
"You,
Lord,
in the beginning laid the foundation of the earth.
The heavens are the works of your hands.
11 They will perish,
but you remain.
They will all grow old like a garment.
12 You will roll them up like a cloak,
and they will be changed.
But you are the same.
Your years will not fail."
13 And to which of the angels has he ever said,
"Sit at my right hand,
until I make your enemies
the footstool of your feet"?
14 Aren't they all serving spirits,
sent out
to serve those
who will inherit salvation?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–13: The author quotes seven passages from the Scriptures of Israel. He reads them as words about Jesus:

Verse 5: Psalm 2:7 and 2 Samuel 7:14. At first these are words about the king from David's family.

Verse 6: The quotation follows the Greek translation of Deuteronomy 32:43. It also recalls Psalm 97:7.

Verse 7: Psalm 104:4.

Verses 8–9: Psalm 45:6–7 (in some Bibles 45:7–8). At first a song for the king's wedding. A scepter is the staff of a king. Righteousness means: living right before God.

Verses 10–12: Psalm 102:25–27 (in some Bibles 102:26–28). There God the Creator is meant. The letter applies this to the Son.

Verse 13: Psalm 110:1.

Important: These psalms first had their own meaning for Israel. The Jewish people read them in their own way to this day. The letter to the Hebrews reads them as a Christian in the light of Jesus.

Verse 14: Angels are "serving spirits." They serve God and help people. At that time some people honored angels very much. The letter says: Jesus is greater.

HEBREWS

Chapter 2

Jesus has become our brother

Pay attention to the great salvation VERSES 1–4

1 So we must pay even closer attention
to the things that we have heard,
so that we don't drift away.
2 For even the word
that was spoken through angels
proved firm.
And every wrongdoing and every disobedience
received a just punishment.
3 How will we escape then
if we neglect so great a salvation?
It was first announced by the Lord.
And those
who heard him
confirmed it to us.
4 God himself also gave his testimony to it,
by signs and wonders,
by various mighty works
and by gifts of the Holy Spirit,
as he wanted.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "Drift away" is a picture from sailing: like a boat that slowly drifts away from the shore if it is not tied up. In the same way you can slowly drift away from faith without noticing.

Verse 2: "The word that was spoken through angels": According to Jewish tradition angels took part when the Law was given at Sinai (compare Acts 7:53).

Verse 3: The author already belongs to the second generation. He did not hear Jesus himself, but heard from those who heard him.

Jesus became a human being VERSES 5–9

5 For God didn't put the world to come,
of which we speak,
under the angels.
6 But someone has testified somewhere,
"What is man,
that you think of him?
Or the son of man,
that you care for him?
7 You made him a little lower than the angels.
You crowned him with glory and honor.
8 You have put all things under his feet."
When God put all things under him,
he left nothing
that is not under him.
But now we don't see yet
that all things are under him.
9 But we see Jesus,
who was made a little lower than the angels.
Because of his suffering of death
he is crowned with glory and honor.
For by the grace of God he was to taste death for
everyone.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–8 quote Psalm 8:4–6 (in some Bibles 8:5–7). The psalm is amazed at how important human beings are to God.

Verses 8–9: The author reads the psalm with Jesus in view: He became a human being, "a little lower than the angels." Through his suffering and death he was raised up.

Verse 8: "Now we don't see yet": To be honest: The world is not yet the way God wants it. There is still suffering and injustice. But we already see Jesus.

Verse 9: "For everyone": Jesus died for all people.

Jesus is our brother VERSES 10–18

10 For it was fitting for God,
for whom all things exist
and through whom all things exist:
He wanted to bring many children to glory.
That is why he made the author of their salvation
perfect through sufferings.
11 For he
who makes holy
and those
who are made holy
all come from one.
That is why he is not ashamed
to call them brothers.
12 He says,
"I will declare your name to my brothers.
In the middle of the congregation I will sing your
praise."
13 Again,
"I will put my trust in him."
Again,
"Look,
here I am with the children
whom God has given me."
14 The children share in flesh and blood.
That is why he himself also shared in the same way.
So through death he wanted to destroy the one
who had the power of death,
that is, the devil.
15 And he wanted to free all
who through the fear of death
were slaves all their lives.

16 For certainly he doesn't help angels,
but he helps the offspring of Abraham.
17 That is why he had to be made like his brothers in all things,
so that he might become a merciful and faithful high priest before God,
to make atonement for the sins of the people.
18 For he himself has suffered
and has been tempted.
That is why he is able to help those
who are tempted.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: "Perfect through sufferings": Jesus went all the way through human suffering. So he fully became a Savior who understands us.

Verse 11: Jesus calls us "brothers" (and sisters). He is not ashamed of us.

Verse 12 quotes Psalm 22:22 (in some Bibles 22:23). Verse 13 quotes Isaiah 8:17–18.

Verses 14–15: Many people are afraid of death. Jesus died himself and defeated death. He wants to set us free from this fear.

Verse 16: "The offspring of Abraham": This means Israel and all who believe like Abraham (compare Galatians 3:7).

Verse 17: The "high priest" was the most important priest in the temple in Jerusalem. Once a year, on the Day of Atonement, he brought the sacrifice for the whole people (Leviticus 16). To "make atonement" means: to take away sin and make things right between God and people. The letter to the Hebrews uses this picture for Jesus. It writes a lot about it in the next chapters.

Verse 18: Jesus knows temptation and suffering from his own experience. That is why he understands us when things are hard for us.

HEBREWS

CHAPTER 3

Today, if you hear his voice

Jesus and Moses VERSES 1–6

1 So,
holy brothers,
you who share in the heavenly calling:
Look at the Apostle and High Priest
whom we confess:
look at Jesus.
2 He was faithful to him
who appointed him,
just as Moses also was faithful in all God's house.
3 For Jesus is worthy of more glory than Moses,
just as he
who builds a house
has more honor than the house itself.
4 For every house is built by someone.
But he
who built all things
is God.
5 Moses was faithful in all God's house
as a servant,
as a witness of the things
that were to be spoken later.
6 But Christ is faithful as a Son over God's house.
We are his house,
if we hold on to our confidence
and to the hope
that we are proud of
firm to the end.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 2 and 5: Moses is greatly honored. He was "faithful in all God's house." That is what Numbers 12:7 says. Moses remains a great figure of faith for Jews and Christians.

Verses 3–6: The letter compares Moses to a faithful servant in the house and Jesus to the son of the house. This does not put Moses down. The letter wants to say how great Jesus is.

Verse 6: "We are his house": The church is like a family and a house where God lives.

Don't harden your hearts VERSES 7–19

7 So,
as the Holy Spirit says,
"Today,
if you hear his voice,
8 don't harden your hearts
as in the rebellion,
on the day of testing in the wilderness.
9 There your ancestors put me to the test
and tried me.
And they saw my works for 40 years.
10 That is why I was displeased with that generation.
And I said,
'They always go astray in their heart.
They didn't know my ways.'
11 That is why I swore in my anger,
'They will not enter into my rest.'"
12 Be careful,
brothers,
that none of you has an evil,
unbelieving heart
and turns away from the living God.
13 But encourage one another every day,
as long as it is called "today,"
so that none of you is hardened by the deceitfulness of sin.
14 For we have come to share in Christ,
if we hold on to our first confidence
firm to the end.
15 As it is said,
"Today,
if you hear his voice,
don't harden your hearts
as in the rebellion."

16 For who rebelled
when they heard?
Wasn't it all
who came out of Egypt led by Moses?
17 With whom was God displeased for 40 years?
Wasn't it with those
who sinned
and whose bodies fell in the wilderness?
18 To whom did he swear
that they would not enter into his rest?
Wasn't it to those
who were disobedient?
19 So we see:
They were not able to enter in because of unbelief.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 7–11 quote Psalm 95:7–11. This psalm is prayed in Jewish worship to this day. It is a warning of Israel to itself: Listen to God and trust him.

The story behind it is in Exodus 17 and Numbers 14: The people of Israel went through the wilderness after leaving Egypt. They doubted God again and again. That is why this generation had to stay in the wilderness for 40 years.

Important: The letter to the Hebrews uses this story as a warning for Christians. It does not say: Israel is bad. It says: The same can happen to us Christians if we don't trust God. The Bible tells honestly about the weaknesses of God's people, so that everyone can learn from them.

Verse 13: "Encourage one another every day": Faith needs community. We are to help one another not to become tired.

"Today": Every day is a new chance to listen to God.

"My rest": God's rest at first meant the promised land. In the next chapter the letter understands it more deeply: as rest and peace with God.

HEBREWS

Chapter 4

God's rest

A rest remains for God's people VERSES 1–11

1 So let's be afraid
that any of you might seem to fall short
of the promise
to enter into God's rest.
2 For the Good News was announced to us too,
just as to them.
But the word
that they heard
didn't help them,
because the hearers didn't join it with faith.
3 For we
who have believed
do enter into that rest.
As he has said,
"That is why I swore in my anger,
they will not enter into my rest."
Yet his works were finished from the creation of the world.
4 For he has said somewhere about the seventh day,
"God rested on the seventh day from all his works."
5 And in this place again,
"They will not enter into my rest."
6 So it remains
that some are to enter into the rest.
And those
to whom the Good News was announced first
didn't enter in because of disobedience.
7 That is why God again sets a certain day:
"today."
So he said through David a long time afterward,
as has already been said,
"Today,
if you hear his voice,
don't harden your hearts."
8 For if Joshua had already given them rest,
God would not have spoken afterward of another day.
9 So there remains
a Sabbath rest for the people of God.
10 For whoever has entered into his rest
has also rested from his own works,
as God did from his.
11 So let's be eager
to enter into that rest,
so that no one falls by following the same example of disobedience.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4 takes up Genesis 2:2: "And on the seventh day he rested from all the work he had done." God rested after creation. That is why the Sabbath is a day of rest.

Verse 8: Joshua led the people of Israel into the promised land. But that was not yet the whole rest that God wants to give.

Verse 9: "So there remains a Sabbath rest for the people of God": The Sabbath is a foretaste of the perfect rest with God. For Jews the Sabbath is a great gift of God to this day. Many Christians celebrate Sunday as a day of rest.

Verse 10: God's rest means: peace with God, rest from all toil and fear. We don't have to earn God's love.

For today: People need rest today too. Regular breaks and a day off each week are a gift of God.

God's word is living VERSES 12–13

12 For the word of God is living and active.
It is sharper than any two-edged sword.
It pierces even to the dividing of soul and spirit,
of joints and marrow.
And it is able to judge the thoughts and intentions of the heart.
13 No creature is hidden from his sight.
But all things are naked and laid open before the eyes of him
to whom we must give account.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: God's word is not just an old text. It speaks to us today and reaches us deep inside.

The "sword" is a picture. It is not about violence against others, but about God's word showing us honestly what we are like.

Verse 13: We can hide nothing from God. That can be frightening. But the next verse brings comfort: God is merciful.

Jesus, our high priest VERSES 14–16

14 So we have a great high priest,
who has passed through the heavens:
Jesus,
the Son of God.
So let's hold tightly to what we confess.

15 For we don't have a high priest
who can't feel with us in our weaknesses.
But he was tempted in all things just like we are,
yet without sin.

16 So let's come with confidence to the throne of grace,
so that we may receive mercy
and find grace
that helps us
when we need it.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15 is a great comfort: Jesus understands us. He knows weakness, temptation, fear and pain from his own experience.

Verse 16: "So let's come with confidence to the throne of grace": God's throne is not a place we have to be afraid of. We may come to God boldly and with trust, especially when we need help.

HEBREWS

CHAPTER 5

Jesus, the high priest who feels with us

What a high priest is VERSES 1–4

1 For every high priest is taken from among people.
He is appointed for people,
in things that concern God.
He is to offer both gifts and sacrifices for sins.

2 The high priest can deal gently with those
who are ignorant and go astray.
For he himself is also surrounded by weakness.

3 That is why he must offer sacrifices for sins,
for the people
and also for himself.

4 And nobody takes this honor for himself.
But he is called by God,
just as Aaron was.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The high priest stood between God and the people. He offered sacrifices for the people in the temple.

Verse 2: Because the high priest is himself a human being with weaknesses, he can have understanding for others.

Verse 4: Aaron, the brother of Moses, was the first high priest of Israel (Exodus 28).

Jesus is called by God VERSES 5–10

5 So also Christ didn't take for himself the honor
of becoming high priest.
But God said to him,
"You are my Son.
Today I have become your father."

6 And in another place he says,
"You are a priest forever,
after the order of Melchizedek."

7 When Jesus lived on earth as a human being,
he offered up prayers and petitions to God
with loud crying and tears.
God was able to save him from death.
And God heard him
because of his reverence for God.

8 Although he was a Son,
he learned obedience
by the things
that he suffered.

9 And having been made perfect,
he became the author of eternal salvation
for all
who obey him.

10 God named him a high priest
after the order of Melchizedek.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5 quotes Psalm 2:7. Verse 6 quotes Psalm 110:4.

Verse 6: Melchizedek was a king and priest at the time of Abraham. He blessed Abraham (Genesis 14:18–20). The letter to the Hebrews explains more about him in Chapter 7.

Verse 7: Jesus prayed, wept and cried out. This recalls his prayer in the garden of Gethsemane before his death (Mark 14:32–36). Jesus knows fear and despair.

"God heard him": God did not keep Jesus from death, but saved him out of death, through the resurrection.

Important: We too may pray to God with tears and loud complaints. Jesus did it too.

Verse 8: Suffering is not good. But Jesus stayed faithful through his suffering.

Grow in faith VERSES 11–14

11 We have much to say about him,
and it is hard to explain,
because you have become slow to hear.

12 For by this time you should already be teachers.
But you need someone again
to teach you the first principles of God's words.
You need milk again
and not solid food.

13 For whoever still lives on milk
has no experience in the word of righteousness.
For he is still a baby.
14 But solid food is for grown-ups.
By practice they have trained their senses
to tell the difference between good and evil.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 12–14: A picture: Babies drink milk, grown-ups eat solid food. Faith is to grow in the same way. At the beginning you learn the basics. Later you can understand more deeply.

The author is a little disappointed: The church has not made progress. But he doesn't give up on them. In the next chapter he encourages them.

For today: Faith is a journey. You may have questions and keep on learning. No one has to be ashamed if they are still at the beginning.

HEBREWS

Chapter 6

Hope is an anchor

Growing further in faith VERSES 1–3

1 So let's leave behind the first teaching about Christ
and press on toward perfection.
Let's not lay the foundation again:
turning away from dead works,
faith toward God,
2 the teaching about baptisms,
about laying on of hands,
about the resurrection of the dead
and about eternal judgment.
3 And we will do this
if God permits.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: Here are the basics of faith, as the first Christians learned them: turning back, faith in God, baptism, laying on of hands, resurrection and judgment.

These basics are important. But faith is to keep growing, like a house that is built on a foundation.

A serious warning VERSES 4–8

4 For it is impossible
to bring people back to repentance
who were once enlightened,
who have tasted the heavenly gift,
who have received a share in the Holy Spirit,
5 who have tasted the good word of God
and the powers of the age to come,
6 and who then have fallen away.
For they crucify the Son of God for themselves again
and put him to open shame.
7 For land
that drinks the rain
that often falls on it,
and that produces good plants
for those
who farm it,
receives blessing from God.
8 But if it bears thorns and thistles,
it is rejected
and near being cursed.
In the end it is burned.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 4–6 are among the most difficult verses of the Bible. They speak of people who very deliberately and publicly rejected and mocked Christ after they knew him well.

Christians understand these verses in different ways. Many stress: This is about a deliberate, final turning away from Christ, not about doubt, weakness or sins that people regret.

Very important: Whoever is afraid of being abandoned by God or lost is, in fact, not lost. This worry shows that God matters to them. God accepts everyone who turns back to him (compare Luke 15, the parable of the lost son).

If such thoughts torment you very much, talk to a pastor or a counselor. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verses 7–8: A picture from farming: Good land brings good fruit. The author wants to wake the church up, not frighten it.

God doesn't forget your love VERSES 9–12

9 But,
beloved,
we are persuaded of better things for you,
things that belong to salvation,
even though we speak like this.
10 For God is not unjust.
He doesn't forget your work
and the love
that you showed toward his name.
For you served the saints
and still serve them.
11 We want
each one of you to show the same eagerness,
so that the hope is fully fulfilled,
to the end.
12 Don't become lazy,
but follow the example of those
who through faith and patience
inherited the promises.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: Right after the serious warning comes encouragement: About you I am confident.

Verse 10: God sees and doesn't forget what we do for others out of love. No good deed is in vain.

God's sure promise VERSES 13–20

13 For when God made a promise to Abraham,
he swore by himself,
because he could swear by no one greater.

14 He said,
"I will surely bless you,
and I will surely multiply you."
15 And so Abraham waited patiently
and received the promise.
16 For people swear by someone greater.
And in every dispute the oath is the final
confirmation.
17 In the same way God wanted to show the heirs of the
promise
even more clearly
that his decision cannot change.
That is why he guaranteed it with an oath.
18 Through these two things that cannot change,
in which it is impossible for God to lie,
we are to have strong encouragement.
We have fled for refuge
to take hold of the hope
set before us.
19 We have this hope like an anchor of the soul,
sure and steadfast.
It reaches behind the curtain,
20 where Jesus went in for us
as the one who goes ahead of us.
He has become a high priest forever
after the order of Melchizedek.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–14: God gave Abraham a promise and confirmed it with an oath (Genesis 22:16–17).

Verse 18: "Two things that cannot change": God's promise and God's oath. You can rely completely on both.

Verse 19: A beautiful picture: Hope is like an anchor. An anchor holds a ship firm, even when storm and waves come. In the same way hope holds us firm when life is stormy.

"Behind the curtain": In the temple a curtain separated off the Most Holy Place. Only the high priest was allowed to go in, once a year. Jesus "went in for us," into God's presence.

HEBREWS

Chapter 7

A priest like Melchizedek

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

In this chapter the letter to the Hebrews compares the priesthood in the temple with Jesus. It uses harsh words about the law (verses 18–19). These words are not contempt for the Jewish faith. For Jews the Torah, God's law, is a precious gift to this day. Paul also says: "So the law indeed is holy" (Romans 7:12). The letter wants to show how great Jesus is for Christians, not to put Israel down.

Who Melchizedek was VERSES 1–10

1 This Melchizedek was king of Salem
and priest of God Most High.
He met Abraham
as he came back from defeating the kings,
and blessed him.
2 Abraham gave him a tenth of everything.
His name means first "king of righteousness."
And then he is also "king of Salem,"
which means "king of peace."
3 He is without father,
without mother,
without family tree.
He has neither beginning of days
nor end of life.
So he is made like the Son of God
and remains a priest forever.
4 Now think
how great this man was:
Even Abraham,
the patriarch,
gave him a tenth of the best of the plunder.
5 The descendants of Levi
who receive the priest's office
have a commandment in the law
to take a tenth from the people,
that is, from their brothers,
although these also come from Abraham.
6 But Melchizedek,
whose family does not come from them,
took a tenth from Abraham.
And he blessed him
who had the promises.
7 Without any doubt the lesser
is blessed by the greater.
8 Here people who die receive tithes.
But there one receives them
of whom it is testified
that he lives.
9 We can even say:
Through Abraham also Levi,
who receives tithes,
has paid tithes.
10 For he was still in the body of his ancestor
when Melchizedek met him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: The story is in Genesis 14:17–20. Melchizedek was king of Salem, probably the later Jerusalem. He brought Abraham bread and wine and blessed him.

Verse 3: The Bible tells nothing about Melchizedek's parents, his birth or his death. The letter takes this as a picture: He is like a priest "forever," similar to the Son of God.

Verse 5: The priests in Israel came from the tribe of Levi. They received a tenth of the harvest to live on. Such a tenth is called a tithe.

Verses 9–10: A thought game: Levi descended from Abraham. When Abraham gave Melchizedek a tenth, Levi was, so to speak, already "there."

A new priest VERSES 11–19

11 Now if perfection had come
through the priesthood of the Levites
(for on that basis the people received the law),
why was it still necessary
for another priest to come
after the order of Melchizedek
and not after the order of Aaron?
12 For when the priesthood changes,
the law must change too.
13 For he
of whom these things are said
belongs to another tribe.
No one from that tribe has ever served at the altar.
14 For it is clear
that our Lord came from Judah.
Moses said nothing about priesthood concerning that
tribe.
15 This becomes even clearer
when another priest comes
who is like Melchizedek.
16 He has become a priest,
not by the law of a human rule,
but by the power of an endless life.
17 For it is testified,
"You are a priest forever,
after the order of Melchizedek."
18 For an earlier commandment is set aside
because of its weakness and uselessness
19 (for the law made nothing perfect),
and a better hope is brought in.
Through it we draw near to God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: Jesus came from the tribe of Judah, from the family of King David. According to the law only descendants of Levi could be priests. The letter explains: Jesus is a priest in another, new way.

Verse 17 quotes Psalm 110:4.

Verses 18–19: These words are harsh. The author means: The sacrifices in the temple could not connect people with God completely and forever. For him only Jesus did that.

Important: This is the view of Christian faith. It is not a judgment on Jewish people. God has not canceled his covenant with Israel (compare Romans 11:29). Jews and Christians read the same holy Scriptures of Israel in different ways. Both have reason to meet one another with respect.

Jesus, the eternal high priest VERSES 20–28

20 And this did not happen without an oath.
21 For those became priests without an oath.
But he became a priest with an oath by him
who says to him,
"The Lord swore
and will not change his mind,
'You are a priest forever,
after the order of Melchizedek.'"
22 So Jesus has become the guarantee of a better
covenant.
23 And those became priests in great numbers,
because death kept them
from continuing in office.
24 But he has a priesthood that never changes,
because he lives forever.
25 That is why he is also able to save completely all
who come to God through him.
For he lives forever
to plead for them.
26 For such a high priest was fitting for us:
holy,
without guilt,
pure,
separated from sinners
and higher than the heavens.
27 He doesn't need, like those high priests,
to offer up sacrifices every day,
first for his own sins
and then for the sins of the people.
For he did this once for all
when he offered up himself.
28 For the law appoints people as high priests
who have weaknesses.
But the word of the oath,
which came after the law,
appoints a Son
who is made perfect forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 21 quotes Psalm 110:4 again.

Verse 22: "A better covenant": The letter speaks about it in detail in Chapter 8.

Verse 25: A great comfort: Jesus lives and always pleads for us before God, like a lawyer for his friends.

Verse 27: "Once for all": Jesus gave himself. This does not have to be repeated.

HEBREWS

CHAPTER 8

The new covenant

Jesus serves in the true sanctuary VERSES 1–6

1 The most important point of what we are saying
is this:
We have such a high priest.
He sat down at the right hand of the throne of the
Majesty in the heavens.
2 He serves in the sanctuary,
in the true tent,
which the Lord set up,
not a human being.
3 For every high priest is appointed
to offer both gifts and sacrifices.

That is why this high priest also must have something
to offer.
4 If he were on earth,
he would not be a priest at all.
For there are priests
who offer the gifts according to the law.
5 They serve a copy and shadow of the heavenly things.
This is what God told Moses
when he was about to build the tent.
For God said,
"See
that you make everything according to the pattern
that was shown to you on the mountain."
6 But now Jesus has received a much better ministry,
just as he is also the mediator of a better covenant.
This covenant is founded on better promises.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: "The true tent": During the journey through the wilderness Israel had a holy tent, the tabernacle. There God met his people. The letter says: The tent on earth was a copy of the heavenly sanctuary.

Verse 5 quotes Exodus 25:40.

Verse 6: "A better covenant": For the letter to the Hebrews Jesus is the mediator of the new covenant that God promised through the prophet Jeremiah.

God promises a new covenant VERSES 7–13

7 For if the first covenant had been without fault,
no one would have looked for a place for a second.
8 For God finds fault with them and says,
"Look,
the days are coming,"
says the Lord,
"when I will make a new covenant
with the house of Israel
and with the house of Judah,
9 not like the covenant
that I made with their ancestors
on the day
when I took them by the hand
to lead them out of the land of Egypt.
For they didn't continue in my covenant,
and I no longer cared for them,"
says the Lord.
10 "For this is the covenant
that I will make with the house of Israel after those
days,"
says the Lord:
"I will put my laws into their mind,
and I will also write them on their heart.
I will be their God,
and they will be my people.
11 Then no one will teach his fellow citizen
and no one his brother
and say,
'Know the Lord!'
For all will know me,
from the least to the greatest.
12 For I will be merciful to their unrighteousness.
And I will remember their sins and lawless deeds
no more."
13 When he says,
"a new covenant,"
he has made the first one outdated.
But what is becoming outdated and growing old
is about to disappear.

IMPORTANT NOTE

In history this passage was often understood as if God had canceled the covenant with the Jewish people and put the church in Israel's place. This teaching is called "replacement theology." Today the major churches have clearly rejected it. God has not canceled his covenant with Israel (Romans 11:1–2, 29).

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 8–12 quote Jeremiah 31:31–34. This promise is addressed specifically to "the house of Israel and the house of Judah." God promises his own people renewal and forgiveness.

Verse 9: Here the letter to the Hebrews quotes the old Greek translation. That is why it says "I no longer cared for them." The Hebrew text of Jeremiah says instead: *although I was a husband to them*. God's faithfulness to his people is especially clear in it.

Verse 10: The heart of the new covenant: God's teaching is not only on stone tablets, but in the heart. All people are to know God personally.

Verse 12: God forgives and doesn't remember the sins any more.

Verse 13: Here the author speaks above all about the sacrifices in the temple. For Christians Jesus is the fulfillment of this service. Jewish people live faithfully in their covenant with God to this day. Christians are to meet them with respect and honor.

HEBREWS

CHAPTER 9

Christ, the true high priest

The sanctuary on earth VERSES 1–10

1 The first covenant also had rules for worship
and a sanctuary on earth.
2 For a tent was set up.
In the first part were the lampstand,
the table
and the show bread.
This part is called the Holy Place.
3 Behind the second curtain
was the part of the tent
that is called the Most Holy Place.
4 There was a golden altar of incense
and the ark of the covenant,
covered all around with gold.

In it was a golden jar holding the manna,
Aaron's rod
that had budded,
and the tablets of the covenant.
5 Above the ark were the cherubim of glory.
They overshadowed the mercy seat.
We can't speak about these things in detail now.
6 This is how everything was set up.
The priests always go into the first part of the tent
and carry out the services there.
7 But into the second part only the high priest goes,
once a year,
and not without blood.
He offers it for himself
and for the errors of the people.
8 By this the Holy Spirit shows:
The way into the Holy Place was not yet revealed
while the first tent was still standing.
9 That is a picture for the present time.
At that time gifts and sacrifices were offered
that could not make the one
who serves God
perfect in his conscience.
10 They were only outward rules
about food,
drink
and various washings,
set until the time of renewal.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 2–5: Here the holy tent is described that Israel built in the wilderness (Exodus 25–26). It had two rooms: the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place. In the Most Holy Place stood the ark of the covenant with the tablets of the Ten Commandments. The show bread was holy bread that lay on the table before God. Cherubim are heavenly beings with wings.

"Mercy seat": That was the lid of the ark of the covenant. On the Day of Atonement blood was sprinkled there.

Verse 7: On the Day of Atonement (in Hebrew *Yom Kippur*) the high priest went into the Most Holy Place (Leviticus 16). Yom Kippur is the highest Jewish holy day to this day. Since the destruction of the temple in AD 70, Jews keep it without sacrifices, with fasting, prayer and turning back to God.

Verses 9–10: The author sees the sacrifices as a picture and a preparation for Christ.

Christ brought redemption once for all VERSES 11–15

11 But Christ has come
as high priest of the good things to come.
He went through the greater and more perfect tent,
not made with hands,
that is,
not belonging to this creation.
12 Not with the blood of goats and calves,
but with his own blood
he entered into the Holy Place once for all.
And he obtained eternal redemption.
13 For if the blood of goats and bulls
and the ashes of a young cow
sprinkled on those who are unclean
make them holy,
so that their body becomes clean,
14 how much more will the blood of Christ
cleanse your conscience from dead works
so that you serve the living God!
Through the eternal Spirit he offered himself without defect to God.
15 That is why he is the mediator of a new covenant.
Through his death redemption was to come
from the wrongdoings under the first covenant,
so that those who are called may receive the promised eternal inheritance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: "With his own blood": Jesus did not sacrifice an animal, but gave himself.

Verse 13: The "ashes of a young cow" were used for cleansing (Numbers 19).

Verse 14: Jesus cleanses the conscience. Whoever carries guilt may start anew.

Covenant and will VERSES 16–22

16 For where there is a will,
the death of the one
who made it
must be shown.
17 For a will only takes effect after death.
It is never in force
while the one
who made it is alive.
18 That is why even the first covenant was not put into effect without blood.
19 For after Moses had told the whole people every commandment according to the law,
he took the blood of the calves and the goats,
with water,
scarlet wool
and hyssop.
And he sprinkled the book itself
and all the people.
20 As he did so he said,
"This is the blood of the covenant
which God has commanded you."
21 In the same way he sprinkled the tent
and all the vessels of the service with the blood.
22 According to the law almost everything is cleansed with blood.
And without the shedding of blood
there is no forgiveness.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 16–17: The Greek word *diatheke* can mean "covenant," but also "will." The author plays with both meanings: A will only takes effect after death. In the same way the new covenant came into effect through the death of Jesus.

Verses 19–20: This recalls Exodus 24:6–8. There Moses confirmed the covenant at Sinai with blood. Hyssop is a small bushy plant. It was used for sprinkling.

Verse 22: At that time blood was seen as a sign of life (Leviticus 17:11). The author explains the death of Jesus in this way.

Important: At all times God also forgave those who honestly regretted and turned back to him. The psalms and prophets

bear witness to this (for example Psalm 51). God's mercy is greater than any rule.

Christ appears for us before God VERSES 23–28

23 So the copies of the heavenly things
had to be cleansed in this way.
But the heavenly things themselves had to be cleansed
with better sacrifices than these.
24 For Christ hasn't entered into a holy place
made with hands,
which is only a copy of the true one.
But he entered into heaven itself,
now to appear in the presence of God for us.
25 Nor did he need to offer himself often,
as the high priest enters into the Holy Place every year
with blood not his own.
26 Otherwise he would have had to suffer often since the
creation of the world.
But now,
at the end of the ages,
he has appeared once
to put away sin by the sacrifice of himself.
27 And just as it is appointed for people
to die once,
and after this comes judgment,
28 so Christ also was offered once
to bear the sins of many.
He will appear a second time,
not because of sin,
but to save those
who are eagerly waiting for him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 24: Jesus is with God and pleads for us there.

Verses 26 and 28: "Once": The sacrifice of Jesus does not have to be repeated. It counts forever.

Verse 28: When Jesus comes again, he doesn't come to punish, but to save. That is a message of hope.

HEBREWS

CHAPTER 10

One sacrifice forever

The one sacrifice of Jesus VERSES 1–18

1 For the law has only a shadow of the good things to
come,
not the real form of the things themselves.
That is why it can never make perfect those
who come to God,
with the same sacrifices
that are offered again and again year after year.
2 Otherwise wouldn't people have stopped
offering them?
For those
who serve God
would have been cleansed once for all
and would no longer have had any awareness of sins.
3 But in those sacrifices sins are remembered every year.
4 For it is impossible
for the blood of bulls and goats to take away sins.
5 That is why he says,
when he comes into the world,
"You didn't want sacrifice and offering.
But you prepared a body for me.
6 You had no pleasure in whole burnt offerings and sin
offerings.
7 Then I said,
'Look,
I have come
(in the scroll of the book it is written of me)
to do your will,
O God.'"
8 First he says,
"You didn't want sacrifices and offerings,
whole burnt offerings and sin offerings,
and you had no pleasure in them."
These are the ones offered according to the law.
9 Then he says,
"Look,
I have come
to do your will."
He takes away the first
to set up the second.
10 By this will we have been made holy
through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ
once for all.
11 Every priest stands day by day
serving
and often offering the same sacrifices.
But they can never take away sins.
12 But he offered one sacrifice for sins
forever
and sat down at the right hand of God.
13 Since then he is waiting
until his enemies are made the footstool of his feet.
14 For by one offering
he has made perfect forever those
who are being made holy.
15 The Holy Spirit also testifies to us.
For first he says,
16 "This is the covenant
that I will make with them after those days,"
says the Lord:
"I will put my laws on their heart,
and I will write them on their mind."
17 Then he says,
"I will remember their sins and their unrighteous
deeds
no more."
18 But where there is forgiveness of these,
there is no more offering for sin.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "A shadow": A shadow shows that something is there, but it is not the thing itself. For the author the sacrifices point to Christ.

Verses 5–7 quote Psalm 40:6–8 (in some Bibles 40:7–9), in the form of the old Greek translation. Already the prophets and psalms of Israel said: God doesn't only want sacrifices, but a heart that does his will (compare also Hosea 6:6 and Psalm 51).

Verses 12–13 take up Psalm 110:1. Verses 16–17 take up Jeremiah 31:33–34.

Verses 14 and 18: This is the good news: Jesus has given forgiveness once for all. No one has to buy forgiveness with their own sacrifices.

Come to God and stick together VERSES 19–25

19 So,
brothers,
through the blood of Jesus we have the freedom
to enter into the Holy Place.
20 He opened for us a new and living way,
through the curtain,
that is,
through his body.
21 And we have a great priest over the house of God.
22 So let's come to God with a true heart
and in full assurance of faith.
Our hearts are sprinkled and free from an evil
conscience,
and our body is washed with pure water.
23 Let's hold on to the confession of our hope
without wavering.
For he
who promised
is faithful.
24 And let's pay attention to one another,
to spur one another on to love and good works.
25 Let's not stop meeting together,
as some are in the habit of doing.
But let's encourage one another,
and all the more
as you see the Day coming nearer.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 19–20: In the past only the high priest was allowed to go behind the curtain into the Most Holy Place, once a year. Now all who believe in Jesus may come near to God.

Verse 22: "Washed with pure water": This probably means baptism.

Verses 24–25: Faith needs community. Christians are to meet, encourage one another and spur one another on to good.

A serious warning VERSES 26–31

26 For if we sin on purpose
after we have come to know the truth,
there is no longer any sacrifice for sins,
27 but only a terrible waiting for judgment
and a raging fire
that will consume the enemies.
28 Whoever disregards the law of Moses
must die without mercy
if two or three witnesses confirm it.
29 How much worse punishment will he deserve
who has trampled the Son of God under foot,
who has counted the blood of the covenant,
by which he was made holy,
an unholy thing,
and who has insulted the Spirit of grace?
30 For we know him
who said,
"Vengeance belongs to me.
I will repay,"
says the Lord.
Again,
"The Lord will judge his people."
31 It is a terrible thing
to fall into the hands of the living God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 26–31: As in Chapter 6 this is about people who reject Jesus very deliberately and with contempt ("trampled the Son of God under foot," "insulted"). It is not about people who are weak, doubt or regret mistakes.

Very important: Whoever is afraid of not being forgiven any more may know: God accepts everyone who comes to him. The worry itself shows that God matters to you. If such thoughts torment you, talk to a pastor or a counselor. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 30: "Vengeance belongs to me." This is a quotation from Deuteronomy 32:35–36. It also means: People are not to take revenge themselves (compare Romans 12:19).

Don't throw away your confidence VERSES 32–39

32 But remember the earlier days.
After you had been enlightened,
you endured a hard struggle with sufferings.
33 Partly you were publicly insulted and oppressed.
Partly you stood by those
who were treated this way.
34 For you had compassion on me in my chains.
And you accepted with joy
that your possessions were taken from you.
For you knew
that you have a better and lasting possession in
heaven.
35 So don't throw away your confidence.
It has a great reward.
36 For you need endurance
so that you do the will of God
and receive what was promised.
37 "For in a very little while,
he who comes
will come,
and will not wait.
38 But the righteous one will live by faith.
If he shrinks back,
my soul has no pleasure in him."
39 But we are not of those
who shrink back and are lost,
but of those
who have faith and save their soul.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 32–34: The church had already experienced persecution. Some were insulted, others lost their possessions. And they cared for the author when he was in chains. The author reminds them of their courage.

Verses 37–38 quote Habakkuk 2:3–4 in the form of the old Greek translation. Paul also quotes these words: "But the righteous shall live by faith" (Romans 1:17).

Verse 39: An encouraging ending: You belong to those who trust.

HEBREWS

Chapter 11

People who trusted God

What faith is VERSES 1–3

1 Faith is assurance of things
hoped for,
proof of things
not seen.
2 For by this the elders received God's approval.
3 By faith we understand
that the universe was made by the word of God.
So what is seen was not made out of things that are
visible.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Faith means: trusting God, even when you don't see everything yet. Faith is like a firm hope that already gives support now.

Verse 2: "The elders" are the women and men of Israel who are told about in this chapter. They are examples of faith, for Jews and for Christians.

Verse 3: Recalls Genesis 1: God made the world through his word.

The first people of faith VERSES 4–7

4 By faith Abel offered to God a better sacrifice than Cain.
Through it he received the testimony
that he was righteous.
God himself testified to it with regard to his gifts.
And through faith he still speaks,
though he is dead.
5 By faith Enoch was taken away,
so that he wouldn't see death.
He was not found,
because God had taken him away.
For before he was taken away,
he received the testimony
that he had pleased God.
6 Without faith it is impossible
to please God.
For whoever comes to God
must believe
that he exists
and that he rewards those
who seek him.
7 By faith Noah built a ship
to save his family.
God had warned him about things
not yet seen.
And Noah had reverence for God.
Through his faith he condemned the world
and became heir of the righteousness
that comes from faith.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: The story of Cain and Abel is in Genesis 4.

Verse 5: Genesis 5:24 tells about Enoch: He walked with God, and then he was no longer there.

Verse 6: Faith means: trusting that God is there and that it is worth seeking him.

Verse 7: The story of Noah is in Genesis 6–9.

Abraham and Sarah VERSES 8–19

8 By faith Abraham obeyed
when he was called,
and went out to a place
that he was to receive as an inheritance.
He went out
without knowing
where he was going.
9 By faith he lived as a foreigner in the land of promise,
as in a land that was not his own.
He lived in tents
with Isaac and Jacob,
who were heirs with him of the same promise.
10 For he was waiting for the city
that has firm foundations.
Its builder and maker is God.
11 By faith even Sarah herself received power
to become pregnant.
She bore a child
although she was already too old.
For she considered him faithful
who had promised.
12 That is why from one man,
who was as good as dead,
there came as many descendants
as the stars of the sky
and as the sand on the seashore,
which can't be counted.
13 These all died in faith.
They didn't receive the promises,
but they saw them from far away and welcomed them.
And they confessed
that they were strangers and foreigners on the earth.
14 Whoever says such things
makes it clear
that he is looking for a homeland.
15 If they had been thinking of the land
that they had left,
they would have had enough time
to return there.
16 But now they long for a better homeland,
that is, a heavenly one.

That is why God is not ashamed
to be called their God.
For he has prepared a city for them.
17 By faith Abraham offered up Isaac
when he was put to the test.
Yes,
he
who had gladly received the promises
was ready to offer up his only son.
18 To him it had been said,
"Your offspring will be counted through Isaac."
19 For he thought:
God is able to raise up even from the dead.
That is why he also received him back from the dead,
figuratively speaking.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: Abraham is the father of faith for Jews, Christians and Muslims. He set out without knowing the goal (Genesis 12).

Verse 11: Sarah is specifically named as a woman of faith. She had her son Isaac in old age (Genesis 21).

Verse 13: "Strangers and foreigners on the earth": People of faith know that their final home is with God.

Verses 17–19: The story is in Genesis 22. It is very hard to understand. God prevented the sacrifice. For Jewish and Christian interpreters it shows, among other things: God does not want human sacrifices.

Very important: This story gives no one the right to harm a child. Children must always be protected.

Isaac, Jacob, Joseph and Moses VERSES 20–31

20 By faith Isaac blessed Jacob and Esau,
even concerning the things
that were to come.
21 By faith Jacob,
when he was dying,
blessed each of the sons of Joseph.
And he worshiped,
leaning on the top of his staff.
22 By faith Joseph at the end of his life
spoke of the departure of the people of Israel
and gave instructions about his bones.
23 By faith Moses, when he was born,
was hidden for three months by his parents.
For they saw
that he was a beautiful child.
And they were not afraid of the king's command.
24 By faith Moses,
when he had grown up,
refused to be called the son of Pharaoh's daughter.
25 He chose rather to suffer wrong with God's people
than to enjoy the pleasures of sin for a short time.
26 He considered the disgrace of Christ greater riches
than the treasures of Egypt.
For he looked to the reward.
27 By faith he left Egypt,
not fearing the anger of the king.
For he endured,
as seeing him who is invisible.
28 By faith he kept the Passover
and the sprinkling of the blood,
so that the destroyer of the firstborn would not touch
them.
29 By faith they passed through the Red Sea
as on dry land.
When the Egyptians tried to do the same,
they were swallowed up.
30 By faith the walls of Jericho fell down,
after people had gone around them for seven days.
31 By faith Rahab,
the prostitute,
didn't die with those who were disobedient,
because she had received the spies in peace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 23: Moses' parents bravely resisted Pharaoh's command to kill all the boys (Exodus 1–2). The midwives and Moses' sister also helped.

Verse 26: "The disgrace of Christ": The author already sees Moses' suffering for his people in the light of Christ.

Verse 28: The Passover feast recalls the freeing from Egypt (Exodus 12). Jews celebrate it to this day as a great feast of freedom.

Verses 30–31: The story of Jericho and Rahab is in Joshua 2 and 6. Rahab was a woman from another people. She is named as an example of faith. God's people are open to people from outside.

Important: The war stories from that time give no one the right to use violence in God's name today.

Many more witnesses VERSES 32–40

32 What more should I say?
The time would fail me
if I told
of Gideon,
Barak,
Samson,
Jephthah,
David,
Samuel
and the prophets.
33 Through faith they conquered kingdoms,
did what is right,
obtained promises,
stopped the mouths of lions,
34 quenched the power of fire,
escaped the edge of the sword,
from weakness were made strong,
grew mighty in war
and put foreign armies to flight.
35 Women received their dead back by resurrection.
Others were tortured
and did not accept their release,
so that they might obtain a better resurrection.
36 Others were mocked and whipped,
yes,
even put in chains and thrown into prison.
37 They were stoned.
They were sawn apart.
They were tempted.
They were killed with the sword.
They went around in sheepskins and goatskins,
poor,

oppressed,
mistreated.
38 The world was not worthy of them.
They wandered in deserts and mountains,
in caves and holes in the earth.
39 These all received a good testimony through their faith.
And yet they didn't receive the promise.
40 For God had planned something better for us,
so that they would not be made perfect without us.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 32: These people are in the books of Judges and Samuel. They were not perfect people. Samson and Jephthah also did terrible things. Jephthah's vow cost his daughter her life (Judges 11). That was a great injustice. The letter doesn't praise everything they did, but their trust in God.

Verses 33–34: Here it says: "stopped the mouths of lions" and "quenched the power of fire." The first recalls Daniel in the lions' den (Daniel 6). The second recalls the three men in the fiery furnace (Daniel 3).

Verse 35: Women received their dead back, for example through the prophets Elijah and Elisha (1 Kings 17, 2 Kings 4).

Verses 35–38: Many faithful people of Israel were persecuted, tortured and killed, for example in the time of the Maccabees. Today too people are persecuted because of their faith.

Verse 40: The faithful people of Israel and the Christians belong together. Together they wait for God to make all things complete.

HEBREWS

Chapter 12

Look to Jesus

Run with endurance VERSES 1–3

1 So since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses,
let's also lay aside everything
that weighs us down,
and the sin
that so easily entangles us.
And let's run with endurance the race
that is set before us.
2 Let's look to Jesus,
the author and perfecter of faith.
For the joy
that was set before him
he endured the cross
and despised its shame.
He sat down at the right hand of the throne of God.
3 Think of him
who endured such opposition from sinners against himself,
so that you don't grow weary
and lose heart.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: We are "surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses." These are the people of faith from Chapter 11. They are like spectators in a stadium who cheer us on.

A picture from sports: Whoever wants to run a long race lays aside everything that is heavy.

Verse 2: "Look to Jesus": He has already gone the way and knows the goal.

Verse 3: When we grow weary, we may think of Jesus. He also endured a lot.

God trains his children VERSES 4–13

4 In your struggle against sin
you have not yet resisted to the point of blood.
5 And you have forgotten the encouragement
that speaks to you as to children:
"My son,
don't take the Lord's discipline lightly.
And don't lose heart
when he corrects you.
6 For whom the Lord loves,
he disciplines.
And he punishes every son
whom he receives."
7 Endure,
for it serves your training.
God deals with you as with his children.
For what child is there whom his father doesn't discipline?
8 But if you are without discipline,
which all have received,
then you are illegitimate
and not true children.
9 Besides, we had our earthly fathers
who disciplined us,
and we respected them.
Shouldn't we much more be subject to the Father of spirits
and live?
10 For they disciplined us for a few days,
as seemed good to them.
But he disciplines us for our good,
so that we may share in his holiness.
11 All discipline seems for the moment to be no joy,
but sorrow.
But later it gives those
who have been trained by it
the peaceful fruit of righteousness.
12 So lift up the tired hands
and the weak knees again.
13 And make straight paths for your feet,
so that what is lame is not put out of joint,
but rather healed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6 quote Proverbs 3:11–12.

Verses 5–11: The author compares hard experiences in life with the training by a father. At that time strictness in raising children was normal.

Very important: These verses give no one the right to hit, humiliate or mistreat children. Children have a right to be raised without violence. Help for children and parents: In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453.

Important: Not every suffering is a punishment or training from God. Sickness, misfortune or violence are not a punishment from God. The letter wants to give persecuted Christians courage: Hard times too can make us more mature, and God is with us in them.

Verses 12–13 take up Isaiah 35:3 and Proverbs 4:26: Help one another to get strength again.

Live in peace and holiness VERSES 14–17

14 Pursue peace with all people
and holiness.
Without it no one will see the Lord.
15 Make sure
that no one misses the grace of God,
that no bitter root grows up
and causes trouble,
and that many are not made unclean by it.
16 Make sure
that no one is sexually immoral
or godless like Esau,
who sold his birthright for one meal.
17 For you know:
When he later wanted to inherit the blessing,
he was rejected.
He found no chance for a change of mind,
though he looked for it eagerly with tears.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: "Peace with all people": not only with Christians, but with everyone.

Verse 15: "A bitter root": Bitterness and resentment can grow like weeds and poison a whole community.

Verses 16–17: The story of Esau is in Genesis 25 and 27. Esau sold his right as firstborn son for a bowl of lentils. Later he regretted it, but he could no longer undo it.

Important: Later Esau made peace with his brother Jacob (Genesis 33). God blessed Esau too.

You have come to Mount Zion VERSES 18–29

18 For you have not come to a mountain
that could be touched
and that burned with fire,
to blackness,
darkness
and storm,
19 to the sound of a trumpet
and to a voice
speaking words.
Those who heard it
begged
that not one more word should be spoken to them.
20 For they could not stand
what was commanded:
"If even an animal touches the mountain,
it shall be stoned."
21 And the sight was so terrible
that Moses said,
"I am terrified and trembling."
22 But you have come to Mount Zion,
to the city of the living God,
the heavenly Jerusalem,
to countless angels,
23 to the festal gathering
and the church of the firstborn
whose names are written in heaven,
to God,
the Judge of all,
to the spirits of righteous people made perfect,
24 to Jesus,
the mediator of a new covenant,
and to the blood of sprinkling
that speaks better than the blood of Abel.
25 See
that you don't refuse him
who speaks.
For they didn't escape
when they refused him
who warned on the earth.
How much less will we escape
if we turn away from him
who warns from heaven!
26 His voice shook the earth then.
But now he has promised,
"Yet once more I will shake not only the earth,
but also the heavens."
27 This "yet once more" shows
that what is shaken
is taken away,
because it is created,
so that what can't be shaken
remains.
28 So since we receive a Kingdom
that can't be shaken,
let's be thankful.
So let's serve God
in a way that pleases him,
with reverence and awe.
29 For our God is a consuming fire.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 18–21: This recalls Mount Sinai, where God gave his people Israel the Ten Commandments (Exodus 19–20). The people were frightened by God's greatness.

Verse 22: Mount Zion and Jerusalem are pictures from the Scriptures of Israel for the place where God lives with his people. The letter speaks of the "heavenly Jerusalem": God's presence, where all people of faith come together.

Important: Both Sinai and Zion belong to God's story with Israel. The letter does not set Judaism and Christianity against each other, but two pictures of God's nearness: reverence and joy.

Verse 24: The blood of Abel cried out for revenge (Genesis 4:10). The blood of Jesus speaks of forgiveness and reconciliation.

Verse 26 quotes Haggai 2:6.

Verse 28: We receive a Kingdom "that can't be shaken." Many things in the world are shaky. But God's Kingdom stays firm.

Verse 29 takes up Deuteronomy 4:24. God is holy and mighty. The picture of fire shows his cleansing power.

HEBREWS

Chapter 13

Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today and forever

How Christians are to live VERSES 1–6

1 Let love among brothers and sisters continue.
2 Don't forget to show hospitality to strangers.
For by doing so some have welcomed angels
without knowing it.
3 Remember the prisoners,
as if you were in prison with them.
And remember those
who are mistreated,
for you also live in a body that can be hurt.
4 Let marriage be held in honor among all,
and let the marriage bed stay pure.
For God will judge the sexually immoral and
adulterers.
5 Be free from the love of money.
Be content with what you have.
For he himself has said,
"I will never leave you
and never forsake you."
6 So we can boldly say,
"The Lord is my helper.
I will not fear.
What can a human being do to me?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: Abraham and Sarah welcomed three strangers who turned out to be messengers of God (Genesis 18). Hospitality is an important commandment in the whole Bible.

For today: This also applies to strangers, refugees and people in need.

Verse 3: Christians are to feel with prisoners and with people who are tormented, as if it were happening to them.

Verse 4: Marriage is to be honored. Faithfulness is important.

Verse 5 takes up Deuteronomy 31:6 and Joshua 1:5. Verse 6 quotes Psalm 118:6.

Jesus stays the same VERSES 7–16

7 Remember your leaders,
who spoke the word of God to you.
Look at the outcome of their lives
and imitate their faith.
8 Jesus Christ is the same
yesterday, today,
and forever.
9 Don't be carried away by various and strange teachings.
For it is good
that the heart is made firm by grace,
not by foods.
Those
who were occupied with them
didn't benefit from them.
10 We have an altar
from which those have no right to eat
who serve the tent.
11 For the bodies of the animals
whose blood is brought by the high priest into the
Holy Place as a sin offering
are burned outside the camp.
12 That is why Jesus also suffered outside the gate,
to make the people holy through his own blood.
13 So let's go out to him,
outside the camp,
and bear his disgrace.
14 For we don't have here a lasting city,
but we seek the one to come.
15 Through him let's always offer to God a sacrifice of
praise,
that is, the fruit of lips
that confess his name.
16 But don't forget
to do good and to share with others.
For God is pleased with such sacrifices.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: A famous sentence: Jesus doesn't change. You can rely on him, then, today and tomorrow.

Verses 9–10: The author warns against teachings about certain foods. By the "altar" he probably means Christ himself.

Important: Verse 10 is not a judgment on Jewish people. The letter speaks in pictures of the worship in the holy tent to explain what Christ means for Christians.

Verse 12: Jesus was crucified outside the city wall of Jerusalem, at a place for criminals and outcasts.

Verse 13: "So let's go out to him, outside the camp": Christians are not just to stay in their comfortable world, but to go to the outcasts, like Jesus.

Verses 15–16: The sacrifices that please God are praise, thanks, good deeds and sharing.

Leaders, prayer and blessing VERSES 17–21

17 Obey your leaders
and submit to them.
For they watch over your souls,
as those who must give account.
So they can do it with joy
and not with groaning.
For that would not be good for you.
18 Pray for us.
For we are persuaded
that we have a good conscience.
We want to live honestly in all things.
19 I especially ask you
to do this,

so that I may be given back to you sooner.

20 The God of peace
brought up from the dead the great shepherd of the sheep,
our Lord Jesus,
through the blood of an eternal covenant.

21 May he make you complete in every good work,
so that you do his will.
May he work in you
what pleases him,
through Jesus Christ.
To him be the glory forever and ever.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: Church leaders have a great responsibility. They must give account before God.

Very important: This verse gives no one the right to misuse power in the church. No leader may control people, put them under pressure or exploit them. Whoever experiences spiritual abuse may resist and seek help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673.

Verses 20–21 are a blessing that is spoken in many worship services to this day. Jesus is the "great shepherd" who cares for his sheep.

Greetings VERSES 22–25

22 But I urge you,
brothers:
Bear with this word of encouragement.
For I have written to you only briefly.

23 You should know:
Our brother Timothy has been set free.
If he comes soon,
I will visit you with him.

24 Greet all your leaders and all the saints.
Those from Italy greet you.

25 Grace be with you all.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: "Only briefly": For the author the long letter is more a short sermon. He calls it a "word of encouragement."

Verse 23: Timothy had been in prison and is now free.

Verse 24: "Those from Italy": Perhaps the letter was written in Italy, or Christians from Italy send greetings.

Looking back: What have we read in the letter to the Hebrews?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

God has spoken through his Son: Jesus is the radiance of God's glory, greater than the angels (Chapters 1–2).

Jesus is our brother: He became a human being, suffered and understands our weaknesses (Chapters 2 and 4).

Jesus, the high priest: With pictures from the temple the letter explains what Jesus means for Christians: one sacrifice once for all, forgiveness forever (Chapters 5–10).

The new covenant: The promise from Jeremiah 31. God has not canceled his covenant with Israel. The teaching that the church has replaced Israel is wrong (Chapter 8).

The cloud of witnesses: The great people of faith of Israel are examples for everyone (Chapter 11).

Run with endurance: Look to Jesus and don't give up (Chapter 12).

Love in everyday life: Hospitality, compassion for prisoners, faithfulness, contentment, sharing (Chapter 13).

For today: Jesus Christ is the same yesterday, today and forever. You can rely on him.

What comes next? Next comes the letter of James. It says very practically: Faith shows itself in deeds.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 59 OF 66

JAMES

5 CHAPTERS

JAMES

Chapter 1

Hearing and doing

Before we begin: The letter of James

The letter names itself a letter of James. According to an old tradition this is James, the brother of Jesus. He was an important leader of the church in Jerusalem (Acts 15 and Galatians 1:19). Many scholars think that the letter was written later in the spirit of James. Others consider James himself the author.

The letter is addressed to "the 12 tribes which are in the Dispersion." This probably means Christians who lived outside the land of Israel, above all Christians of Jewish background.

The letter is very practical. It recalls the wisdom books of the Bible, for example Proverbs, and the Sermon on the Mount of Jesus.

The big theme is: Faith shows itself in deeds. The letter stands up strongly for the poor and warns the rich.

At the time of the Reformation people argued about this letter, because it says that faith without works is dead. Today most Christians see: Paul and James complement each other.

The letter of James has 5 chapters.

Joy in trials VERSES 1–8

1 James,
a servant of God
and of the Lord Jesus Christ,
greets the 12 tribes which are in the Dispersion.
2 My brothers,
count it all joy
when you fall into various temptations.
3 For you know:
When your faith is tested,
it produces endurance.
4 Let endurance finish its work,
so that you may be perfect and complete,
lacking in nothing.
5 But if any of you lacks wisdom,
let him ask God for it.
God gives to all gladly
and without blaming.
Then it will be given to him.
6 But let him ask in faith,
without doubting.
For whoever doubts
is like a wave of the sea,
driven by the wind and tossed back and forth.
7 Such a person shouldn't think
that he will receive anything from the Lord.
8 He is a double-minded man,
unstable in all his ways.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "The 12 tribes": Israel was made up of 12 tribes. The letter speaks to the Christians as part of God's people. "The Dispersion" means: living scattered in other lands, outside the land of Israel.

Verse 2: The WEB says "temptations." Here the Greek word means above all trials and hard times.

Verses 2–4: Hard times are not nice. But they can make us stronger. "Joy" doesn't mean that you have to think suffering is good.

Verse 5: God gives gladly and doesn't blame us when we ask him for help.

Verses 6–8: This is about people who don't want to decide whether to trust God. "Double-minded" means: torn between two ways.

Important: Doubts and questions are part of faith. Many people in the Bible doubted too. God is patient with us.

Poor and rich VERSES 9–11

9 Let the brother in humble circumstances
boast in his high position,
10 and the rich in his being made low.
For like a flower in the grass he will pass away.
11 For the sun rises with the scorching wind
and withers the grass.
Its flower falls,
and the beauty of its appearance perishes.
So the rich man will also fade away in his pursuits.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9–10: Before God the poor are not worth less. They have a "high position." And riches don't last.

Verses 10–11: The picture of the grass and the flower comes from Isaiah 40:6–8.

Temptation does not come from God VERSES 12–18

12 Blessed is the person
who endures temptation.
For when he has been approved,
he will receive the crown of life.
The Lord promised it to those
who love him.
13 Let no one say
when he is tempted,
"I am tempted by God."
For God can't be tempted by evil,
and he himself tempts no one.
14 But each one is tempted
when he is drawn away and enticed
by his own desire.
15 Then when the desire has become pregnant,
it gives birth to sin.
And when sin is full grown,
it produces death.
16 Don't be deceived,
my beloved brothers.
17 Every good gift
and every perfect gift
is from above,

from the Father of lights.
With him there is no change
and no shadow cast by turning.
18 By his own will he gave birth to us by the word of truth,
so that we would be a kind of first fruits of his
creatures.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: God doesn't want us to do evil. He tempts no one.

Verses 14–15: Evil deeds often start small, with a wish. If you give in to it, it can grow.

Verse 17: All good comes from God. "Father of lights": God made the sun, the moon and the stars. But unlike them he doesn't change.

Verse 18: "First fruits": The first fruit of the harvest belonged to God. Christians are like a beginning of the new creation.

Not only hearing, but doing VERSES 19–27

19 So,
my beloved brothers:
Let every person be quick to hear,
slow to speak
and slow to anger.
20 For human anger doesn't produce the righteousness of
God.
21 So put away all filthiness
and all the wickedness that overflows.
Receive with humility the word
that is planted in you
and that is able to save your souls.
22 But be doers of the word,
not only hearers.
Otherwise you deceive yourselves.
23 For if anyone only hears the word
but doesn't do it,
he is like a man
who looks at his face in a mirror.
24 He looks at himself,
goes away
and right away forgets
what he looked like.
25 But whoever looks into the perfect law of freedom
and stays with it,
who is not a forgetful hearer
but a doer,
will be blessed in what he does.
26 If anyone thinks
that he is religious,
but doesn't keep his tongue in check,
he deceives his own heart.
His religion is worthless.
27 Pure and spotless religion before God,
the Father,
is this:
to visit orphans and widows in their need
and to keep oneself unstained by the world.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: Good advice for every day: first listen, then speak. And don't get angry quickly. Verse 20: Righteousness means: living right before God.

Verses 22–24: The picture of the mirror: Whoever hears God's word but changes nothing is like someone who sees himself in a mirror and then forgets what he looks like.

Verse 25: "The perfect law of freedom": God's teaching sets us free. It is not a prison, but a way to a good life. The psalms see it this way too (for example Psalm 119).

Verse 27: True faith shows itself in how we treat the weakest. At that time these were above all orphans and widows.

For today: These are all people who have no support: people who are alone, children without a family, refugees, the poor, the lonely.

JAMES

CHAPTER 2

Faith shows itself in deeds

Don't favor anyone VERSES 1–13

1 My brothers,
don't hold the faith of our glorious Lord Jesus Christ
while favoring some people over others.
2 Imagine:
A man with a gold ring
and in fine clothing comes into your synagogue.
And a poor man in dirty clothing also comes in.
3 And you pay special attention to the one in the fine
clothing
and say,
"Sit here in a good place."
But to the poor man you say,
"Stand there,"
or,
"Sit by my footstool."
4 Haven't you then made distinctions among yourselves
and become judges with evil thoughts?
5 Listen,
my beloved brothers:
Didn't God choose those
who are poor in this world
to be rich in faith
and to inherit the Kingdom
that he promised to those
who love him?
6 But you have dishonored the poor man.
Isn't it the rich
who oppress you
and drag you before the courts?
7 Don't they speak evil of the honorable name
by which you are called?
8 However, if you fulfill the royal law,
as the Scripture says,

"You shall love your neighbor as yourself,"
you do well.
9 But if you favor some people over others,
you commit sin.
And the law convicts you as wrongdoers.
10 For whoever keeps the whole law,
but stumbles in one point,
has become guilty of all.
11 For he who said,
"Do not commit adultery,"
also said,
"Do not commit murder."
Now if you do not commit adultery,
but murder,
you have become a breaker of the law.
12 So speak and so act
as people
who will be judged by the law of freedom.
13 For judgment is without mercy to him
who has shown no mercy.
Mercy triumphs over judgment.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: The WEB says "synagogue." The word simply means "gathering." The first Christians of Jewish background often called their gatherings that.

Verses 1–4: No one in the church is to be favored or treated worse because of money or clothing. All are equal before God.

Verse 5: God is on the side of the poor. They are just as precious to him as everyone else.

Verse 8 quotes Leviticus 19:18: "You shall love your neighbor as yourself." Jesus called this commandment one of the two most important commandments (Mark 12:31).

Verse 11 quotes the Ten Commandments (Exodus 20:13–14).

Verse 13: "Mercy triumphs over judgment": A great saying. Whoever is merciful may hope for God's mercy themselves.

For today: Today too people are treated worse because of poverty, background or appearance. That is not to happen in the church.

Faith without deeds is dead VERSES 14–26

14 What good is it,
my brothers,
if someone says
he has faith,
but he has no deeds?
Can that faith save him?
15 If a brother or a sister
has nothing to wear
and not enough food for the day,
16 and one of you says to them,
"Go in peace,
be warmed and filled!"
but you don't give them
what the body needs,
what good is that?
17 In the same way faith,
if it has no deeds,
is dead in itself.
18 Yes,
someone will say,
"You have faith,
and I have deeds."
Show me your faith without deeds,
and I will show you my faith by my deeds.
19 You believe
that God is one.
You do well.
The demons also believe that
and tremble.
20 But do you want to know,
you foolish person,
that faith without deeds is dead?
21 Wasn't Abraham
our father
made righteous by deeds
when he offered up his son Isaac on the altar?
22 You see:
Faith worked together with his deeds.
And by the deeds faith was made perfect.
23 So the Scripture was fulfilled
which says,
"Abraham believed God,
and it was counted to him as righteousness."
And he was called the friend of God.
24 So you see:
A person is made righteous by deeds,
and not only by faith.
25 In the same way, wasn't Rahab
the prostitute
also made righteous by deeds
when she received the messengers
and sent them out another way?
26 For as the body without the spirit is dead,
so faith without deeds is also dead.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 15–16: A very clear example: Nice words don't help a hungry person. He needs food and clothing.

Verse 19: "God is one": This is the confession of faith of Israel, the *Shema Israel* (Deuteronomy 6:4). Jews pray it every day to this day. James says: The confession is right. But it must also be visible in life.

Verse 23 quotes Genesis 15:6. Abraham is called "friend of God" in Isaiah 41:8.

Verse 24: Paul writes: A person is made righteous by faith, not by works of the law (Romans 3:28). That sounds like a contradiction. But the two mean different things: Paul says that we can't earn salvation. James says that true faith always leads to good deeds. Both belong together.

Verse 25: Rahab is again an example (compare Hebrews 11:31). She protected Israel's messengers.

Verse 26: Faith and deeds belong together like body and spirit.

JAMES

CHAPTER 3

The power of words

The tongue is small, but powerful VERSES 1–12

1 My brothers,
not many of you should become teachers.
For you know:
We will be judged more strictly.
2 For we all make many mistakes.
Whoever makes no mistakes in speaking
is a perfect person.
He is able to keep his whole body in check too.
3 We put bits into the mouths of horses
so that they obey us.
So we guide their whole body.
4 Look at the ships too:
They are so big
and are driven by strong winds.
Yet they are guided by a very small rudder
wherever the pilot wants.
5 In the same way the tongue is a small part of the body,
and yet it boasts great things.
See
how a small fire can set a great forest on fire!
6 And the tongue is a fire.
The tongue is a world of wrongdoing among the parts
of our body.
It stains the whole body.
It sets on fire the whole course of life
and is itself set on fire by Gehenna.
7 For every kind of animal,
bird,
creeping thing
and sea creature
is tamed by mankind
and has been tamed.
8 But no one can tame the tongue.
It is a restless evil,
full of deadly poison.
9 With it we bless our God
and Father.
And with it we curse people,
who are made in the image of God.
10 Out of the same mouth come blessing and cursing.
My brothers,
it should not be so.
11 Does a spring send out
fresh and bitter water from the same opening?
12 Can a fig tree,
my brothers,
produce olives,
or a vine figs?
In the same way no spring can give
both salt water and fresh water.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Teachers have a great responsibility, because their words influence many people.

Verses 3–5: Three pictures: The bit guides a big horse, the small rudder a big ship, a small spark can set a whole forest on fire. In the same way the small tongue has great power.

Verse 6: The WEB says "Gehenna." That was a valley near Jerusalem and became a picture for hell. Evil words can destroy a lot.

Verse 9: Every person is created in the image of God (Genesis 1:27). Whoever praises God and at the same time curses people contradicts himself.

For today: This also applies to words on the internet and in social media. Insults, lies and hate can hurt people deeply. If you are insulted or bullied online, you can find help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The wisdom from above VERSES 13–18

13 Who is wise and understanding among you?
Let him show by a good life
that his deeds come from gentle wisdom.
14 But if you have bitter jealousy
and selfish ambition in your heart,
don't boast
and don't lie against the truth.
15 This wisdom doesn't come from above.
But it is earthly,
human
and demonic.
16 For where jealousy and selfish ambition are,
there is confusion
and every evil deed.
17 But the wisdom from above is first pure,
then peaceful,
gentle,
reasonable,
full of mercy and good fruits,
without partiality
and without hypocrisy.
18 And the fruit of righteousness is sown in peace
by those
who make peace.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: True wisdom does not show itself in clever speeches, but in a good, gentle life.

Verses 14–16: Jealousy and selfish ambition destroy every community.

Verse 17: A beautiful description of God's wisdom: pure, peaceful, gentle, reasonable, merciful, fair and honest.

Verse 18: Whoever makes peace sows something good that will grow. Jesus says: "Blessed are those who make peace" (Matthew 5:9).

JAMES

CHAPTER 4

Come near to God

Where conflict comes from VERSES 1–10

1 Where do the wars and fights among you come from?
They come from your desires,
which fight inside your bodies.
2 You want something, but you don't have it.
You murder and you are jealous,
but you still cannot get what you want.
You fight and make war.
You don't have, because you don't ask God.
3 You ask, but you don't receive,
because you ask with wrong motives.
You only want to spend it on your pleasures.
4 You adulterers and adulteresses!
Don't you know that friendship with the world means being against God?
So anyone who wants to be a friend of the world
makes himself an enemy of God.
5 Or do you think the Scripture says this for no reason:
"The Spirit who lives in us yearns jealously"?
To yearn means: to long for something very much.
6 But he gives even more grace.
That is why the Scripture says,
"God resists the proud, but gives grace to the humble."
7 So put yourselves under God.
Stand up against the devil,
and he will run away from you.
8 Come near to God, and he will come near to you.
You sinners, wash your hands!
You who cannot make up your minds, make your hearts pure!
9 Be sad, mourn and cry.
Let your laughter turn into mourning,
and your joy into sadness.
10 Make yourselves low before the Lord,
and he will lift you up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: Conflict and war begin in the heart: with jealousy, greed and the wish to have more and more.

Verse 2: "You murder" is probably a drastic picture. Jesus says: Hatred and anger are already like murder (compare Matthew 5:21–22).

Verse 4: "Adulterers": In the Scriptures of Israel this is a picture for people who become unfaithful to God, as in a marriage. "The world" here means: a life that only asks about power, money and pleasure.

Verse 5: We don't know exactly which passage of Scripture is meant here. The verse is also translated in different ways.

Verse 6 quotes Proverbs 3:34.

Verse 8: A wonderful promise: When we come near to God, he comes to meet us.

Verse 9: This is about true regret for one's own wrongdoing, not about Christians never being allowed to laugh.

Don't judge one another VERSES 11–12

11 Brothers, don't speak against one another.
Whoever speaks against his brother or judges his brother
speaks against the law and judges the law.
But if you judge the law,
you are not doing what the law says.
Instead, you are making yourself its judge.
12 There is only one who gives the law.
He is able to save and to destroy.
So who are you to judge someone else?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 11–12: Only God is judge. We are not to condemn others or speak badly about them. This recalls the words of Jesus: "Don't judge" (compare Matthew 7:1).

That doesn't mean that you may not name wrongdoing. But we are not to look down on other people.

If the Lord wills VERSES 13–17

13 Now listen, you who say,
"Today or tomorrow we will go to this city.
We will spend a year there.
We will do business and make money."
14 You don't even know what your life will be like tomorrow.
What is your life?
You are like a mist.
It appears for a short time, and then it disappears.
15 Instead, you should say,
"If the Lord wills, we will live
and do this or that."
16 But now you are proud of your boasting.
All boasting like this is evil.
17 So if someone knows the right thing to do and doesn't do it,
that is sin for him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–15: Making plans is not wrong. But we are not to act as if we had everything in our hands. Life is precious and fragile.

Verse 15: "If the Lord wills": Many Christians still say or write this today when they plan something.

Verse 17: An important sentence: Not only doing evil is sin, but also not doing good, although you could.

JAMES

CHAPTER 5

Patience and prayer

A warning to the rich VERSES 1–6

1 Now listen, you rich people!
Cry and howl,
because terrible troubles are coming on you.
2 Your riches have rotted.
Moths have eaten your clothes.

3 Your gold and your silver have rusted.
Their rust will be evidence against you.
It will eat your flesh like fire.
You have stored up treasure in the last days.
4 Look!
You cheated the workers who mowed your fields.
You kept back their pay.
That pay cries out against you.
The cries of the people who harvested your crops
have reached the ears of the Lord of Armies.
5 You have lived in luxury on the earth.
You have enjoyed your pleasures.
You have fattened your hearts,
like animals on a day of slaughter.
6 You have condemned the righteous one,
and you have murdered him.
He does not fight back against you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–6: Very harsh words against rich people who gathered their riches at the expense of others. They recall the prophets of Israel, for example Amos, who stood up for the poor.

Verse 4: Keeping back fair wages from workers is a serious injustice. Deuteronomy 24:14–15 already says this. God hears the cries of those who are exploited.

"Lord of Armies": A name of God from the Scriptures of Israel. It shows God's power.

For today: Exploitation, starvation wages and unfair working conditions exist today too, in rich countries and worldwide. Christians are to stand up for fair wages.

Verse 6: "The righteous one": This probably means poor, innocent people who are oppressed by the powerful.

Be patient VERSES 7–12

7 So, brothers, be patient until the Lord comes.
Look at the farmer.
He waits for the precious crop of the land.
He is patient with it,
until it has received the early rain and the late rain.
8 You too must be patient.
Make your hearts strong,
because the Lord will soon come.
9 Brothers, don't complain against one another,
so that you will not be judged.
Look, the judge is standing at the door!
10 Brothers, the prophets spoke in the name of the Lord.
Take them as an example of how to suffer and how to keep going.
11 Look, we call the people who endured blessed.
You have heard how Job kept going.
And you have seen how things turned out for him in the end through the Lord.
The Lord is full of compassion and mercy.
12 But most of all, my brothers, don't swear.
Do not swear by heaven,
or by the earth,
or with any other oath.
Let your "yes" be "yes,"
and your "no" be "no."
Then you will not fall into hypocrisy.
Hypocrisy means: pretending to be better than you are.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: The farmer in the land of Israel waited for two rainy seasons: the early rain in the fall and the late rain in the spring. Without them there was no harvest. In the same way Christians are to wait patiently for God.

Verse 11: Job suffered a lot. He also told God his complaint and his anger. In the end God gave him good things again (Job 42). God is merciful.

Verse 12: This recalls the words of Jesus in the Sermon on the Mount (Matthew 5:33–37). Christians are to be so honest that they need no oath.

That is why some Christians, for example Mennonites and Quakers, still take no oath today. In many countries you can make a solemn affirmation in court instead of an oath.

Pray for one another VERSES 13–20

13 Is anyone among you suffering?
He should pray.
Is anyone happy?
He should sing songs of praise.
14 Is anyone among you sick?
He should call for the elders of the church.
They should pray over him.
And they should anoint him with oil in the name of the Lord.
To anoint means: to rub or pour oil on someone.
15 The prayer of faith will heal the sick person.
The Lord will raise him up.
If he has committed sins, he will be forgiven.
16 Confess your sins to one another.
And pray for one another, so that you may be healed.
The prayer of a righteous person who keeps on praying is very powerful.
17 Elijah was a person like us.
He prayed hard that it would not rain.
And it did not rain on the earth for three years and six months.
18 Then he prayed again.
And the sky gave rain,
and the earth produced its crops.
19 Brothers, someone among you may wander away from the truth.
And someone else may bring him back.
20 Then he should know this:
Whoever brings a sinner back from his wrong way will save that person's soul from death.
And he will cover many sins.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: Praying in suffering, singing in joy: There are words before God for every situation in life.

Verses 14–15: The elders are to pray for the sick and anoint them with oil. At that time oil was also a medicine. The Catholic and the Orthodox churches still celebrate the anointing of the sick as a sacrament today. In many Protestant churches too there are prayers and anointings for the sick.

Very important: Sickness is not a punishment for sin. And prayer does not replace a doctor. Whoever is sick should go to the doctor and may also pray. If someone doesn't get well, it is not because their faith is too weak.

Verse 16: Confessing faults to one another and praying for one another can bring healing. Later confession developed

from this.

Verses 17–18: The story of Elijah is in 1 Kings 17–18. Elijah was a completely ordinary person, and yet God answered his prayer.

Verses 19–20: The letter ends with a task: Take care of one another. If someone goes off the way, lovingly help them back.

Looking back: What have we read in the letter of James?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Hearing and doing: God's word is not only to be heard, but also lived (Chapter 1).

True religion: Caring for orphans, widows and all the weak (Chapter 1).

Not favoring anyone: Poor and rich are equal before God. Love your neighbor as yourself (Chapter 2).

Faith and deeds: Faith without deeds is dead. Paul and James complement each other (Chapter 2).

The power of words: The tongue is small, but powerful. Words can build up or destroy (Chapter 3).

Wisdom from above: It is peaceful, gentle and merciful (Chapter 3).

Humility: Come near to God, and he will come near to you. Don't judge one another (Chapter 4).

Justice for the poor: Harsh words against rich people who cheat workers out of their wages (Chapter 5).

Patience and prayer: For those who suffer, the cheerful and the sick. Praying for one another (Chapter 5).

For today: Faith is practical. It shows itself in how we treat other people, especially the weak.

What comes next? Next comes the first letter of Peter. It encourages Christians who suffer because of their faith.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 60 OF 66

1 PETER

5 CHAPTERS

1 PETER

Chapter 1

A living hope

Before we begin: The first letter of Peter

The letter names itself a letter of Peter, the apostle. Peter was one of the first disciples of Jesus. At the end of the letter Silvanus is named, who helped with the writing (5:12). Many scholars think that the letter was written later in the spirit of Peter. Others consider Peter himself the author.

The letter is written to Christians in several regions of today's Turkey. They were despised and treated with hostility because of their faith. The letter calls them "foreigners" in this world.

The big theme is hope in suffering: Christ suffered and rose again. That is why the Christians also have a living hope.

Important note: In chapters 2 and 3 there are rules for slaves and for wives. They reflect the order of that time. In the boxes we explain how Christians understand them today.

The first letter of Peter has 5 chapters.

Greeting VERSES 1–2

1 Peter,
an apostle of Jesus Christ,
writes to the chosen ones
who live as foreigners in the Dispersion,
in Pontus,
Galatia,
Cappadocia,
Asia
and Bithynia.

2 You are chosen according to the foreknowledge of God
the Father,
through the making holy by the Spirit,
so that you obey Jesus Christ
and are sprinkled with his blood.
May grace and peace be given to you in abundance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The regions named were in the north and west of today's Turkey.

"Foreigners in the Dispersion": The word "Dispersion" (in Greek *Diaspora*) first described Jews who lived outside the land of Israel. The letter uses it for Christians: They feel like strangers in their surroundings, because they live differently.

Verse 2: God the Father, the Spirit and Jesus Christ appear in this verse. Later Christians speak of the Trinity of God.

A living hope VERSES 3–12

3 Blessed be God,
the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ.
In his great mercy
he has given us new birth
to a living hope,
through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead,
4 to an inheritance that can't perish,
that is pure
and that doesn't fade away.
It is kept ready in heaven for you.
5 By the power of God you are guarded through faith
for a salvation
that is ready
to be revealed in the last time.
6 You greatly rejoice in this,
even though now for a little while,
if it must be,
you are grieved by various trials.
7 So your faith is to prove genuine.
It is more precious than gold,
which perishes,
even though it is tested by fire.
It is to lead to praise,
glory and honor
when Jesus Christ is revealed.
8 You have not seen him,
and yet you love him.
You don't see him now,
but you believe in him.
And you rejoice with a joy
that can't be put into words
and that is full of glory.
9 So you reach the goal of your faith:
the salvation of your souls.
10 The prophets searched and inquired about this salvation.
They spoke of the grace
that was meant for you.
11 They searched
to whom or to what time the Spirit of Christ in them pointed
when he testified beforehand about the sufferings of Christ
and the glories that would follow.
12 It was revealed to them
that they were serving not themselves,
but you, with the things
that have now been announced to you.
Those who brought you the Good News announced them to you
by the Holy Spirit
sent from heaven.
Even angels long to look into these things.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: "A living hope": Because Jesus lives, our hope is alive too. It is not just a wish, but has a firm foundation.

Verses 6–7: Just as gold is purified in fire, faith can become stronger in hard times. Still, suffering is not something good. And "for a little while": It comes to an end.

Verse 8: The Christians never saw Jesus and love him anyway. That is true for all Christians to this day.

Verses 10–12: The prophets of Israel announced God's grace. Christians read their words in the light of Jesus.

Live holy lives VERSES 13–25

13 So prepare your minds for action.
Stay clear-minded.
Set your hope fully on the grace
that will be brought to you
when Jesus Christ is revealed.
14 Be obedient children.
Don't shape your lives any more by your former desires
that you had
when you were still ignorant.
15 But just as he
who called you
is holy,
so you also are to be holy in all your way of life.
16 For it is written,
"You shall be holy,
for I am holy."
17 You call on him as Father,
who judges each one according to his work without partiality.
So live in reverence
as long as you live here as foreigners.
18 For you know:
You were redeemed from the empty way of life handed down from your ancestors.
This did not happen with things that perish,
like silver or gold,
19 but with the precious blood of Christ,
as of a lamb
without defect and without spot.
20 God knew him before the creation of the world.
But at the end of the times he was revealed
for your sake.
21 Through him you believe in God,
who raised him from the dead
and gave him glory.
So your faith and hope are in God.
22 You have purified your souls
by obeying the truth through the Spirit,
for sincere love among brothers and sisters.
So love one another from the heart and with all your strength.
23 For you have been born again,
not of seed that perishes,
but of seed that doesn't perish,
through the word of God,
which lives and remains forever.
24 For,
"All people are like grass,
and all their glory is like the flower in the grass.
The grass withers,
and the flower falls.
25 But the Lord's word remains forever."
This is the word of Good News
that was announced to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: "You shall be holy, for I am holy." This is a quotation from Leviticus 11:44–45 and 19:2. This word was first spoken to Israel. The letter invites the Christians from the nations to live this way too.

Verse 18: "The empty way of life handed down from your ancestors": Most of those who received the letter had worshiped other gods before. This former life is meant, not the Jewish faith.

Verse 19: "As of a lamb without defect and without spot": A picture from the Passover feast (Exodus 12) and from Isaiah 53.

Verse 22: Love is to come "from the heart," not just from duty.

Verses 24–25 quote Isaiah 40:6–8. People and their fame pass away, but God's word remains.

1 PETER

CHAPTER 2

Living stones

You are living stones VERSES 1–10

1 So put away all wickedness,
all deceit,
all hypocrisy,
all envy
and all evil talk.
2 Be like newborn babies
and long for the pure spiritual milk,
so that by it you may grow,
3 if you have indeed tasted
that the Lord is kind.
4 Come to him,
the living stone.
People rejected him,
but God chose him,
and he is precious.
5 You also, as living stones,
let yourselves be built up into a spiritual house,
into a holy priesthood.
So you are to offer up spiritual sacrifices
that please God
through Jesus Christ.
6 For it is contained in Scripture,
"Look,
I lay in Zion a chief cornerstone,
chosen and precious.
Whoever believes in him
will not be disappointed."
7 So the honor is for you
who believe.

But for those
who are disobedient
it is true:
"The stone
which the builders rejected
has become the chief cornerstone,"
8 and,
"a stone
that people stumble over,
and a rock
that makes them fall."
They stumble at the word
because they are disobedient.
They were also appointed to this.
9 But you are a chosen race,
a royal priesthood,
a holy nation,
a people
who belong to God.
You are to proclaim the great deeds of him
who called you out of darkness
into his marvelous light.
10 In the past you were not a people,
but now you are God's people.
In the past you had not received mercy,
but now you have received mercy.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: Just as a baby longs for milk, Christians are to long for God's word.

Verses 4–5: A beautiful picture: Every Christian is like a living stone. Together they form a house where God lives.

Verses 5 and 9: "Priesthood": All Christians may come near to God directly and pray for others. Protestant churches speak of the "priesthood of all believers."

Verse 6 quotes Isaiah 28:16. Verse 7 quotes Psalm 118:22. Verse 8 quotes Isaiah 8:14.

Verse 9: God first said these words to Israel at Sinai (Exodus 19:5–6). They are true for Israel to this day.

Important: The letter doesn't say that the Christians replace Israel. It says: The people from the nations who "were not a people" in the past now also belong to God's people (verse 10, compare Hosea 2:23 – in some Bibles 2:25). God has not canceled his covenant with Israel (Romans 11:29).

Live good lives among people VERSES 11–17

11 Beloved,
I urge you as foreigners and strangers:
Keep away from the desires of the body,
which fight against the soul.
12 Live a good life among the nations.
Then those
who now speak against you as evildoers
will see your good deeds
and glorify God on the day of his coming.
13 For the Lord's sake be subject
to every human order:
to the king as the highest,
14 and to the governors
whom he sends
to punish those
who do evil
and to praise those
who do good.
15 For this is God's will:
By doing good
you are to put to silence the ignorance of foolish
people.
16 Live as free people.
But don't use your freedom as a cover for evil,
but live as servants of God.
17 Honor all people.
Love the brothers and sisters.
Fear God.
Honor the king.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: At that time Christians were slandered. The letter says: Answer with good deeds.

Verses 13–14: Christians are to respect the order of the state. At that time the "king" was the Roman emperor.

Important: That doesn't mean that you have to go along with every injustice of the state. If the state commands injustice, you must obey God rather than people (Acts 5:29).

Verse 17: A short, strong sentence: Honor all people. Every person has dignity.

A word to the slaves VERSES 18–25

18 Servants,
be subject to your masters with all respect,
not only to the good and gentle ones,
but also to the wicked ones.
19 For it is commendable
when someone endures pain
and suffers unjustly
because he takes his conscience before God seriously.
20 For what glory is it
if you are beaten
because you have sinned
and you endure it patiently?
But if you do good
and suffer for it and endure it patiently,
that is commendable before God.
21 For you were called to this.
For Christ also suffered for us
and left you an example,
so that you should follow in his steps.
22 He didn't sin,
"and no deceit was found in his mouth."
23 When he was insulted,
he didn't insult back.
When he suffered,
he didn't threaten,
but handed everything over to him
who judges justly.
24 He himself carried our sins
in his body on the tree,
so that we might die to sins
and live for righteousness.
By his wounds you were healed.
25 For you were like sheep
that had gone astray.
But now you have returned
to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verses 18–20 are addressed to slaves who were beaten by their masters. Later these verses were misused to justify slavery, violence and oppression. That was wrong and is a grave injustice.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In verse 18 the WEB says "servants." Slaves are meant. At that time they could hardly defend themselves or run away. The letter wants to give them dignity and comfort: God sees your unjust suffering. Christ also suffered innocently.

Very important: These verses are not a call to endure violence or injustice when you can protect yourself. No one has to accept beatings, abuse or exploitation, neither at work nor in the family. Whoever experiences violence may and should seek help. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK). In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233.

Verses 22–25 take up Isaiah 53: "By his wounds we are healed." The suffering servant of God is applied to Jesus here.

Verse 25: Jesus is like a good shepherd who brings lost sheep back.

1 PETER

CHAPTER 3

Ready to tell about our hope

A word to wives and husbands VERSES 1–7

1 In the same way, you wives, be subject to your own husbands.
If some of them don't obey the word,
they are to be won by the behavior of their wives without a word,
2 when they see your pure life in reverence.
3 Your beauty is not to be outward,
with braided hair,
gold jewelry
or fine clothing.
4 But your beauty is to be the hidden person of the heart,
with the beauty that doesn't perish,
of a gentle and quiet spirit.
That is very precious in God's sight.
5 For this is how the holy women of the past also made themselves beautiful,
who put their hope in God.
They were subject to their own husbands.
6 So Sarah obeyed Abraham
and called him "lord."
You are now her children
if you do good
and are not put in fear by any terror.
7 In the same way, you husbands, live with your wives with understanding.
Give honor to the woman as to the weaker vessel.
For they are heirs with you of the grace of life.
So your prayers will not be hindered.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verses 1–7 reflect the family order of that time. At that time the husband legally had power over his wife. In history these verses were often used to keep women down. That was wrong.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: This is above all about women who had become Christians while their husbands still believed in other gods. That was dangerous for them. The letter advises: Live so well that your husband is won by your example.

Verses 3–4: The letter doesn't forbid jewelry. It says: A good heart is more important than outward beauty.

Verse 6: The women are to be "not put in fear by any terror." They are not to have to be afraid.

Verse 7: New and important for that time: Husbands are to honor their wives. And women are "heirs with you of the grace of life," that is, of equal worth before God. "Weaker vessel" at that time probably meant less physical strength and a weaker legal position, not a lower worth.

Today many Christians understand marriage as a partnership of two people with equal rights. Others hold on to a special responsibility of the husband. All stress: It is about love, not about power.

Very important: These verses give no one the right to rule over their spouse or to use violence. Violence in marriage is a grave injustice and a crime. No one has to endure it. If you experience domestic violence, get help. For domestic violence, US: 1-800-799-7233. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

Bless instead of insulting VERSES 8–12

8 Finally:
Be all of one mind,
compassionate,
love one another as brothers and sisters,
be tenderhearted
and kind.
9 Don't pay back evil for evil
or insult for insult.
But bless,
for you were called to this,
so that you may inherit a blessing.
10 For,
"Whoever wants to love life
and see good days,
let him keep his tongue from evil
and his lips
from speaking deceit.
11 Let him turn away from evil
and do good.

Let him seek peace
and pursue it.
12 For the eyes of the Lord are on the righteous,
and his ears are open to their prayer.
But the face of the Lord is against those
who do evil."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: Not hitting back, but blessing: Jesus taught this too (compare Luke 6:28).

Verses 10–12 quote Psalm 34:12–16 (in some Bibles 34:13–17).

Verse 11: "Let him seek peace and pursue it": Peace doesn't come by itself. You have to work for it actively.

Ready to give an answer VERSES 13–17

13 Who can harm you
if you are eager to do good?
14 But even if you have to suffer for righteousness' sake,
you are blessed.
"Don't fear what they fear,
and don't be troubled."
15 But keep God,
the Lord,
holy in your hearts.
Always be ready
to give an answer to everyone
who asks you the reason for the hope
that is in you.
Do it with humility and reverence
16 and with a good conscience.
Then those will be put to shame
who speak against you as evildoers
and run down your good life in Christ.
17 For it is better,
if it is God's will,
to suffer for doing good
than for doing evil.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14 takes up Isaiah 8:12.

Verse 15 is a well-known verse: Christians are to be able to explain why they hope. But not pushy or arrogant, but "with humility and reverence," that is, with respect for others.

Verse 17: Suffering is not good. But if you have to suffer, then better because you have done good.

Christ suffered and lives VERSES 18–22

18 For Christ also suffered for sins once,
the righteous for the unrighteous,
to bring you to God.
He was put to death in the flesh,
but made alive in the Spirit.
19 In the Spirit he also went
and preached to the spirits in prison.
20 They had been disobedient in the past,
when God waited patiently in the days of Noah,
while the ship was being built.
In it only a few,
that is, eight people,
were saved through water.
21 This is a picture of baptism,
which now saves you.
It is not washing dirt off the body,
but the answer of a good conscience toward God,
through the resurrection of Jesus Christ.
22 He has gone into heaven
and is at the right hand of God.
Angels,
authorities
and powers are subject to him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: "The righteous for the unrighteous": Jesus, who was without guilt, died for everyone.

Verses 19–20 are very hard to understand. Many Christians see in them a hint that after his death Christ also went to the dead. That is why many churches confess in the Creed that Jesus went to the realm of the dead after his death. This shows: No place is so far away that Christ could not go there. Other interpreters understand the verses differently.

Verses 20–21: Noah's ark is a picture of baptism. Just as Noah was saved through the water, a new life begins in baptism.

Verse 22: Christ is Lord over all powers. No one has to be afraid of them.

1 PETER

CHAPTER 4

Serve one another with your gifts

A new life VERSES 1–6

1 Since Christ suffered for us in the body,
arm yourselves also with the same attitude.
For whoever has suffered in the body
has stopped sinning.
2 So you are to live the rest of your time
no longer by the desires of people,
but by the will of God.
3 For it is enough
that in the past you lived
as the Gentiles want:
in wild living,
lusts,
drunkenness,
feasting,
drinking parties
and abominable idol worship.
4 They are surprised
that you no longer join them
in this wild behavior.
That is why they speak evil of you.
5 They will have to give account to him
who is ready
to judge the living and the dead.
6 For this is why the Good News was also preached to the
dead:

They were judged like people in the body,
but they are to live with God in the spirit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 3–4: In the past the Christians had taken part in wild parties and in idol worship. Now they no longer join in. That is why the people around them mock them.

Verse 6: A difficult verse. It says: The Good News is also for the dead. No one is too far away for God, not even through death (compare 3:19).

Love one another and serve one another VERSES 7–11

7 The end of all things is near.
So be sensible and sober,
so that you can pray.
8 Above all, love one another with all your strength.
For love covers a multitude of sins.
9 Be hospitable to one another
without grumbling.
10 Each one has received a gift.
Serve one another with it,
as good managers of the many kinds of God's grace.
11 If anyone speaks,
let him do it
as one passing on God's words.
If anyone serves,
let him do it with the strength
that God gives him.
So in all things God is to be glorified
through Jesus Christ.
To him belong the glory and the power
forever and ever.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: "For love covers a multitude of sins" recalls Proverbs 10:12. Whoever loves is ready to forgive and not to count up every mistake.

Important: This doesn't mean that you should keep violence or abuse secret. Wrongdoing must come to light so that victims are protected.

Verse 10: Every person has received gifts from God. No gift is unimportant. They are there to help others.

Suffering as a Christian VERSES 12–19

12 Beloved,
don't be surprised at the fiery trial
that has come upon you,
as if something strange were happening to you.
13 But rejoice,
because you share in the sufferings of Christ.
Then you will also rejoice
with all your heart
when his glory is revealed.
14 If you are insulted for the name of Christ,
you are blessed.
For the Spirit of glory
and the Spirit of God rests on you.
On their part he is spoken against,
but on your part he is glorified.
15 None of you should suffer
because he is a murderer
or a thief
or an evildoer
or because he meddles in other people's matters.
16 But if someone suffers
because he is a Christian,
let him not be ashamed.
But let him glorify God for it.
17 For the time has come
for judgment to begin with the household of God.
But if it begins first with us,
what will happen to those
who don't obey the Good News of God?
18 "If the righteous is saved only with difficulty,
what will happen to the ungodly and the sinner?"
19 So let those also
who suffer according to the will of God
while doing good
entrust their lives to the faithful Creator.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: "Fiery trial": The Christians experienced hostility and persecution.

Verse 16: Here we find the word "Christian." It appears only three times in the New Testament (compare Acts 11:26). At that time it was often a name used to mock.

Verse 17: The time has come "for judgment to begin with the household of God." That means: The church is first to examine itself honestly, whether it is living rightly.

Verse 18 quotes Proverbs 11:31 in the form of the old Greek translation.

Verse 19: A comfort: God is a faithful Creator. We may put our lives into his hands.

For today: In many countries Christians are still persecuted because of their faith today. Christians are to pray for them and stand up for freedom of religion for all people.

1 PETER

CHAPTER 5

Give your worries to God

A word to the leaders and to everyone VERSES 1–7

1 I urge the elders among you,
as a fellow elder
and a witness of the sufferings of Christ.
I also share in the glory
that will be revealed.
2 Shepherd the flock of God
that is among you.
Take care of it,
not because you are forced,
but willingly,
not to gain money dishonestly,
but gladly from the heart.

3 Don't lord it over those
entrusted to you,
but be examples to the flock.
4 Then when the chief Shepherd appears,
you will receive the crown of glory that doesn't fade
away.
5 In the same way, you younger ones:
Be subject to the elder.
Yes,
all of you are to clothe yourselves with humility
and be subject to one another.
For,
"God resists the proud,
but gives grace to the humble."
6 So humble yourselves under the mighty hand of God,
so that he may lift you up at the right time.
7 Cast all your worries on him,
because he cares for you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Peter calls himself a "fellow elder." He doesn't put himself above the other leaders, but next to them.

Verses 2–3: A picture from the life of shepherds: Leaders are to take care of the church like a good shepherd takes care of his sheep, not because they are forced, not for money and not to rule.

Very important: "Don't lord it over": Whoever has responsibility in the church may not misuse their power. If you experience spiritual or sexual abuse, you can find help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In the US: Childhelp 1-800-422-4453, RAINN 1-800-656-4673.

Verse 4: "The chief Shepherd" is Jesus.

Verse 5: "All of you are to clothe yourselves with humility and be subject to one another": This applies to everyone, toward each other. Then the verse quotes Proverbs 3:34.

Verse 7: A great comfort: We may tell God all our worries and leave them with him. He cares for us. Whoever has heavy worries may also get help from people. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Be watchful VERSES 8–11

8 Be clear-minded and self-controlled.
Be watchful.
Your adversary,
the devil,
walks around like a roaring lion,
looking for
whom he may devour.
9 Resist him,
firm in your faith.
And know:
Your brothers and sisters in the whole world
have to endure the same sufferings.
10 But the God of all grace
has called you in Christ Jesus to his eternal glory.
After you have suffered a little while,
may he himself make you perfect,
establish,
strengthen
and settle you on firm ground.
11 To him belong the glory and the power
forever and ever.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: A picture for the power of evil: like a dangerous lion. That is why Christians are to be watchful.

Verse 9: You are not alone. Christians all over the world experience similar things.

Verse 10: A strong promise: The suffering lasts only "a little while." God will strengthen you and set you on firm ground.

Last greetings VERSES 12–14

12 Through Silvanus,
whom I consider a faithful brother,
I have written to you briefly.
I wanted to encourage you and to testify
that this is the true grace of God
in which you stand.
13 She who is in Babylon,
chosen together with you,
greets you,
and so does Mark,
my son.
14 Greet one another with a kiss of love.
Peace be to all of you
who are in Christ Jesus.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Silvanus (also called Silas) helped with writing or delivering the letter.

Verse 13: "She who is in Babylon": This probably means the church. "Babylon" is probably a code name for Rome here, the capital of the Roman Empire.

"Mark, my son": not his own son, but a close fellow worker. According to an old tradition Mark wrote down Peter's memories in the Gospel of Mark.

Verse 14: The "kiss of love" was a sign of greeting among Christians.

Looking back: What have we read in the first letter of Peter?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

A living hope: Through the resurrection of Jesus, Christians have a hope that lasts (Chapter 1).

Living holy lives: "You shall be holy, for I am holy." This word was first spoken to Israel (Chapter 1).

Living stones: All Christians together build the house of God. The Christians from the nations are added to God's people; they don't replace Israel (Chapter 2).

Living good lives among people: Answering slander with good deeds. Honor all people (Chapter 2).

Difficult rules: The rules for slaves and wives reflect the time back then. No one has to endure violence (Chapters 2 and 3).

Ready to give an answer: Christians are to tell about their hope with respect (Chapter 3).

Serving one another: With love and with the gifts that God has given (Chapter 4).

Suffering as a Christian: Whoever suffers because of their faith is not alone (Chapters 4 and 5).

For today: Cast all your worries on God, because he cares for you.

What comes next? Next comes the second letter of Peter. It warns against false teachers and speaks about the coming again of Jesus.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 61 OF 66

2 PETER

3 CHAPTERS

2 PETER

Chapter 1

Grow in faith

Before we begin: The second letter of Peter

The letter names itself a letter of Simon Peter. It is written like a farewell letter: Peter knows that he will die soon (1:14).

Today many scholars think that the letter was written much later by a student in Peter's name. At that time this was a well-known way to pass on the legacy of a teacher. Others consider Peter himself the author.

The letter warns against false teachers. Some said: Jesus is not coming back at all. The letter answers: God keeps his promises. He is only patient because he wants all people to turn back.

Chapter 2 is very similar to the letter of Jude.

The second letter of Peter has 3 chapters.

Greeting VERSES 1–2

1 Simon Peter,
a servant and apostle of Jesus Christ,
writes to those
who have received the same precious faith as we have,
through the righteousness of our God and Savior
Jesus Christ:

2 May grace and peace be given to you in abundance
through the knowledge of God
and of Jesus our Lord.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: The letter goes to all "who have received the same precious faith as we have." The readers did not see Jesus themselves. But their faith is just as precious as the faith of the apostles.

A ladder of faith VERSES 3–11

3 His divine power has given us all things
that we need for life and godliness.
This happens through the knowledge of him
who called us by his own glory and goodness.

4 Through these he has given us precious and very great promises.
Through them you are to share in the divine nature,
having escaped from the corruption
that is in the world through desire.

5 For this very reason, make every effort
and add to your faith moral excellence,
to moral excellence knowledge,

6 to knowledge self-control,
to self-control endurance,
to endurance godliness,

7 to godliness love for brothers and sisters,
and to love for brothers and sisters love.

8 If you have all these things
and they grow in you,
you will not be idle
or without fruit
in the knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ.

9 But whoever doesn't have them
is blind
and sees only what is near.
He has forgotten
that he was cleansed from his old sins.

10 So,
brothers,
be all the more eager
to make your calling and election sure.
For if you do these things,
you will never stumble.

11 For in this way entrance
into the eternal Kingdom
of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ
will be richly given to you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: "Share in the divine nature": A great saying. Christians don't become equal to God, but God gives them fellowship with himself. In the Orthodox Church this thought is especially important.

Verses 5–7: A kind of ladder: From faith it goes step by step up to love. Love is at the very top.

Verse 9: "Sees only what is near": Whoever only thinks about today loses sight of the goal.

Peter recalls what he experienced VERSES 12–21

12 That is why I will always remind you of these things,
though you know them
and are firmly established in the truth
that you have.

13 I think it right
to keep you awake by reminding you,
as long as I am in this tent.

14 For I know
that I will soon put off my tent,
as our Lord Jesus Christ showed me.

15 But I will make every effort
so that after my departure
you can always remember these things.

16 For we did not follow cleverly invented fables
when we made known to you the power and coming
of our Lord Jesus Christ.
But we saw his majesty with our own eyes.

17 For he received honor and glory
from God the Father
when the voice came to him from the Majestic Glory,
"This is my Son. I love him.
I am very pleased with him."

18 We heard this voice come from heaven
when we were with him on the holy mountain.

19 And we have the word of prophecy made more sure.
You do well
to pay attention to it

as to a lamp
shining in a dark place,
until the day dawns
and the morning star rises in your hearts.
20 For know this above all:
No prophecy of Scripture
comes from someone's own interpretation.
21 For no prophecy ever
came by the will of a human being.
But holy people of God spoke,
moved by the Holy Spirit.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 13–14: "Tent" is a picture for the body. Peter knows that he will die soon. According to an old tradition Peter was crucified in Rome.

Verses 16–18 recall the transfiguration of Jesus on the mountain (Matthew 17:1–8). Peter, James and John saw Jesus in God's glory.

Verse 19: God's word is like a lamp in the dark. "The morning star" is a picture for Christ.

Verses 20–21: The prophets did not tell their own ideas. God's Spirit moved them.

2 PETER

CHAPTER 2

A warning against false teachers

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

This chapter uses very harsh words against false teachers. That is how people wrote about disputes at that time. The harsh words are no permission to insult people today who believe differently. Judgment on people belongs to God alone.

Many parts of this chapter are very similar to the letter of Jude.

False teachers will come VERSES 1–3

1 But there were also false prophets among the people.
In the same way there will be false teachers among you.
They will secretly bring in destructive false teachings.
They even deny the Master
who bought them.
So they bring swift destruction on themselves.
2 Many will follow their immoral ways.
Because of them the way of the truth will be spoken against.
3 Out of greed they will exploit you
with deceptive words.
The judgment on them has long been ready
and doesn't wait.
And their destruction doesn't sleep.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"False prophets among the people": This means the people of Israel. The Hebrew Bible also warns against false prophets.

"The Master who bought them": Jesus has set people free. But the false teachers live as if he had nothing to say.

"Out of greed": One mark of false teachers is that they want to make money with faith. That is a good warning sign today too.

God knows how to rescue and to judge VERSES 4–10A

4 For God didn't spare even angels
when they sinned.
He cast them down to Tartarus
and handed them over to pits of darkness,
where they are kept for judgment.
5 He also didn't spare the ancient world.
But he kept Noah safe,
a preacher of righteousness,
with seven others,
when he brought a flood on the world of the ungodly.
6 And he turned the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah
into ashes
and condemned them to destruction.
So he made them an example
for those who would live ungodly lives.
7 And he rescued righteous Lot,
who suffered greatly from the wild living
of wicked people.
8 For this righteous man lived among them.
And day after day
his righteous soul was tormented
as he saw and heard their lawless deeds.
9 So the Lord knows
how to rescue the godly from temptation
and how to keep the unrighteous
under punishment until the day of judgment,
10 especially those
who follow the desires of the body
and defile themselves
and who despise all authority.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: "Tartarus" is a Greek word. It means a deep, dark place of punishment. Here the letter recalls old Jewish stories about angels who set themselves against God (compare Genesis 6:1–4).

Verses 5–8 recall the flood with Noah (Genesis 6–9) and Sodom and Lot (Genesis 19). The message: God sees evil. But he also doesn't forget those who hold on to him.

Verse 9 is a comfort: Whoever trusts God is not forgotten, even when a lot of evil happens around them.

How the false teachers live VERSES 10B–16

They are bold and self-willed.
They are not afraid
to speak evil of the glorious ones.
11 Yet not even angels,
who are much stronger and more powerful,
bring a slanderous judgment against them before the Lord.

12 But these people
are like animals without reason,
born by nature
to be caught and killed.
They speak evil of things
that they don't understand.
That is why in their destruction
they will surely be destroyed themselves.
13 They receive the wages of their wrongdoing.
For them it is a pleasure
to party in broad daylight.
They are stains and blemishes.
They enjoy their deceptions
while they feast and eat with you.
14 Their eyes are full of adultery.
They can't stop sinning.
They entice people
who are not yet standing firm.
Their heart is trained in greed.
They are children of a curse!
15 They have left the right way
and gone astray.
They have followed the way of Balaam,
the son of Beor.
He loved the wages of wrongdoing.
16 But he was rebuked for his disobedience:
A mute donkey spoke with a human voice
and stopped the madness of the prophet.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 10–11: "The glorious ones" are probably powers of angels. The letter says: Even the angels don't speak without respect. But the false teachers mock everything.

Verse 13: "While they feast and eat with you": This means the shared meals of the church. The false teachers sit at the table too and take advantage of the fellowship.

Verses 15–16 recall Balaam and his talking donkey (Numbers 22). Balaam let himself be hired for money. Of all things, an animal saw more than the prophet.

Empty promises VERSES 17–22

17 These people are springs without water
and clouds driven by a storm.
The blackest darkness
is kept for them forever.
18 For they speak big, boastful words
that are empty.
With the desires of the body
and with wild living
they entice people
who are just escaping from those
who live in error.
19 They promise them freedom.
But they themselves are slaves of corruption.
For a person is a slave of whatever
has overcome him.
20 For they had already escaped the filth of the world
because they came to know the Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.
But if they get entangled in it again
and are overcome,
then in the end things are worse for them
than at the beginning.
21 For it would have been better for them
not to know the way of righteousness at all
than to know it
and then to turn away from the holy commandment
that was given to them.
22 With them it has happened
as the true proverb says,
"The dog turns to his own vomit again,"
and,
"The sow that has washed
goes back to rolling in the mud."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: "Springs without water": They promise a lot, but they give nothing that satisfies life.

Verse 19: An important sentence: Whoever may do everything is not yet free. Whatever rules a person makes them unfree, for example an addiction.

Verses 20–22: These verses are a serious warning to the false teachers. They were not written to frighten people who doubt or have become weak. Whoever worries whether they are "too far away" shows by this very worry that God matters to them. God waits for everyone who comes back (compare Luke 15).

Verse 22: The first proverb is also in Proverbs 26:11.

If you feel weighed down, you can talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

2 PETER

CHAPTER 3

God is patient – Jesus is coming again

Remember VERSES 1–2

1 Beloved,
this is now the second letter
that I have written to you.
In both letters I want to stir up your sincere mind
by reminding you.
2 You are to remember the words
that were spoken before by the holy prophets,
and the commandment
that you received from us,
the apostles of the Lord and Savior.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The second letter": This probably means the first letter of Peter.

The letter puts the prophets and the apostles side by side. Both together are the foundation of faith.

"Where is he?" VERSES 3–7

3 Know this above all:
In the last days mockers will come.
They live by their own desires.
4 And they say,
"Where is the promise
of his coming?
Since our ancestors died,
all things continue
as they were from the beginning of the creation."
5 For they deliberately forget:
Long ago there were heavens
and an earth.
It was formed by the word of God
out of water and in the middle of water.
6 And by water the world of that time
was flooded and destroyed.
7 But the heavens and the earth that exist now
are kept for fire by the same word.
They are reserved for the day of judgment,
when ungodly people are destroyed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: The first Christians hoped that Jesus would come back very soon. When the first generation died, some asked mockingly: "Where is he?"

Verses 5–6: The letter answers: It is not true that everything always stays the same. God created the world (Genesis 1), and there was the great flood (Genesis 6–9).

Verse 7: The "fire" is a picture for God's judgment. The Bible uses such pictures to say: Evil will not remain forever.

God is patient VERSES 8–10

8 But don't forget this one thing,
beloved:
With the Lord one day is like 1,000 years,
and 1,000 years like one day.
9 The Lord is not slow about his promise,
as some think he is slow.
But he is patient with us.
For he doesn't want
anyone to be lost.
He wants
all to turn back.
10 But the day of the Lord will come
like a thief in the night.
On that day the heavens
will pass away with a great noise.
The elements will be dissolved in the heat.
And the earth and the works that are in it
will be burned up.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8 recalls Psalm 90:4: For God 1,000 years are like one day. God measures time differently from us.

Verse 9 is one of the most beautiful sentences in this letter: That Jesus has not come back yet is no sign of weakness. It is patience. God wants **all** people to be saved. He waits for everyone.

Verse 10: "Like a thief in the night": No one knows when the time will come (compare 1 Thessalonians 5:2). That is why no one should calculate a date.

At the end of verse 10 it says: "And the earth and the works that are in it will be burned up." Some old manuscripts say something else there: The earth and everything that people have done on it will be found. That means: It will be uncovered before God.

IMPORTANT NOTE

These verses are no permission not to take care of the earth. God has entrusted creation to people (Genesis 2:15). Christians are to treat it well. The pictures of fire are also not an exact description of how the world will end. They say: God has the last word.

How should we live? VERSES 11–13

11 If all these things will pass away like this,
how much should you then
live holy and godly lives!
12 You are waiting for the coming of the day of God
and longing for it.
On that day the heavens will burn and pass away,
and the elements will melt in the heat.
13 But according to his promise we are waiting
for new heavens and a new earth.
Righteousness lives there.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: "Longing for it": You can't force God's coming. But you can look forward to it and already live now in a way that fits God's new world.

Verse 13: The goal is not destruction, but something new: new heavens and a new earth. This promise is already found in the prophet Isaiah (Isaiah 65:17 and 66:22). At the end of the Bible it comes again (Revelation 21).

"Righteousness lives there": In God's new world there is no more injustice.

Last words VERSES 14–18

14 So,
beloved,
since you are waiting for all these things,
make every effort
to be found by him in peace,
without spot and without blame.
15 Regard the patience of our Lord as salvation.
Our beloved brother Paul also wrote this to you,
with the wisdom
given to him.
16 He speaks of these things
in all his letters.
In them some things are hard to understand.
Ignorant people
who are not standing firm
twist them,
as they also do with the other Scriptures.
In this way they bring destruction on themselves.
17 But you,
beloved,
already know this beforehand.
So be careful
that you are not carried away by the error of the
wicked
and lose your firm footing.

18 But grow in the grace
and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.
To him be the glory,
both now and forever.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: God's patience is a chance. Every day is a gift to turn back.

Verses 15–16: Here Paul is called "our beloved brother." Peter and Paul once had a dispute (Galatians 2:11–14). Here they stand together.

Verse 16: An honest sentence: In the Bible too some things are hard to understand. That is why you shouldn't simply twist the Bible the way you need it at the moment. It helps to read it together with others.

Verse 16 also shows: Paul's letters were already collected at that time and read like "Scriptures."

Verse 18: The letter ends as it began: with growing in faith (compare 1:5–8).

Looking back: What have we read in the second letter of Peter?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Growing in faith: From faith up to love, step by step (Chapter 1).

Eyewitnesses: The apostles did not tell fables. They saw the glory of Jesus (Chapter 1).

God's word like a lamp: It shines in the dark until the day comes (Chapter 1).

A warning against false teachers: They are greedy and promise freedom, but they make people unfree (Chapter 2).

God is patient: He wants all people to turn back and no one to be lost (Chapter 3).

Hope: God creates new heavens and a new earth, where righteousness lives (Chapter 3).

For today: Read the Bible together and honestly. Some things are hard to understand, and that is okay.

What comes next? Next comes the first letter of John. Its big theme is love: God is love.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 62 OF 66

1 JOHN

5 CHAPTERS

1 JOHN

Chapter 1

God is light

Before we begin: The first letter of John

This letter has no sender and no greeting at the beginning. It is more like a sermon or a circular letter to churches.

According to an old tradition the apostle John wrote it. Many scholars think that it comes from the circle of students from which the Gospel of John also comes. Language and thoughts are very similar to the Gospel.

There had been conflict in the church. A group had left the church. Some of them probably said: Jesus was not really a human being of flesh and blood.

The letter answers: Jesus really became a human being. And whoever loves God must also love his brothers and sisters.

The big themes are light, truth and above all love. Here we find the famous sentence: God is love (4:8 and 4:16).

The first letter of John has 5 chapters.

We have seen it and touched it VERSES 1–4

1 We write to you about what was from the beginning.
We have heard it.
We have seen it with our eyes.
We have looked at it,
and our hands have touched it.
It is about the Word of life.
2 And the life was revealed.
We have seen it
and testify to it.
We announce to you the eternal life,
which was with the Father
and was revealed to us.
3 What we have seen and heard
we announce to you,
so that you also may have fellowship with us.
And our fellowship is with the Father
and with his Son Jesus Christ.
4 And we write these things to you,
so that our joy may be complete.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This beginning recalls the beginning of the Gospel of John: "In the beginning was the Word" (John 1:1). The "Word of life" means Jesus.

Verse 1: "Heard, seen, touched": Jesus was a real human being. People could touch him. That is important against the opinion that Jesus only seemed to be a human being.

Verse 3: Faith is not only a private matter. It connects people with one another and with God.

God is light VERSES 5–10

5 This is the message
that we have heard from him
and announce to you:
God is light,
and in him is no darkness at all.
6 If we say
that we have fellowship with him
but live in darkness,
we lie
and don't tell the truth.
7 But if we live in the light,
as he is in the light,
we have fellowship with one another.
And the blood of Jesus Christ, his Son,
cleanses us from all sin.
8 If we say
that we have no sin,
we deceive ourselves,
and the truth is not in us.
9 If we confess our sins,
he is faithful and righteous.
He forgives us our sins
and cleanses us from all unrighteousness.
10 If we say
that we haven't sinned,
we make him a liar,
and his word is not in us.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: "God is light": With God there is nothing evil and nothing hidden. He is completely good.

Verses 6–7: To "live in the light" means: living honestly, hiding nothing, living in a way that fits God.

Verses 8 and 10: No one is without faults. Whoever claims that is fooling themselves.

Verse 9 is a great comfort: Whoever honestly admits their guilt is forgiven by God. You don't have to be perfect. You may be honest. "Righteous" here means: God always does what is right.

"Confessing" can happen in prayer directly before God. In some churches there is also confession to a pastor or priest.

Verse 7: "The blood of Jesus" means his death on the cross. Christians believe: Through his death God gives forgiveness.

1 JOHN

Chapter 2

Staying in the light

Jesus stands up for us VERSES 1–2

1 My little children,
I am writing this to you so that you will not sin.

But if anyone does sin,
we have a Counselor who speaks for us with the Father.
He is Jesus Christ, the righteous one.
2 He is the sacrifice that takes away our sins.
He is the sacrifice not only for our sins, but also for the sins of the whole world.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"My little children": This is how an old teacher speaks lovingly to his church.

Verse 1: A "Counselor" is someone who stands up for another person, like a good lawyer. Whoever makes mistakes is not alone. Jesus stands up for them before God.

Verse 2: "Not only for our sins, but also for the sins of the whole world": What Jesus did is not only for a small group, but for all people.

Whoever knows God lives like Jesus VERSES 3–11

3 This is how we know that we really know him:
We keep his commandments.
4 Someone may say, "I know him."
But if he does not keep his commandments, he is a liar.
The truth is not in him.
5 But if someone keeps his word,
God's love has truly become complete in him.
This is how we know that we are in him:
6 Whoever says that he remains in him
should live just as Jesus lived.
7 Brothers, I am not writing a new commandment to you.
It is an old commandment.
You have had it from the beginning.
This old commandment is the word you heard from the beginning.
8 And yet, I am writing a new commandment to you.
It is true in him and in you.
The darkness is passing away,
and the true light is already shining.
9 Someone may say that he is in the light,
but he hates his brother.
Then he is still in the darkness.
10 Whoever loves his brother remains in the light.
There is nothing in him that makes others stumble.
11 But whoever hates his brother is in the darkness.
He walks around in the darkness.
He does not know where he is going,
because the darkness has made him blind.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 3–6: Knowing God is not just knowledge in the head. It shows itself in life: You live the way Jesus lived.

Verses 7–8: An old and at the same time new commandment: This means the commandment of love. It is old, because the Torah already says: Love your neighbor (Leviticus 19:18). It is new, because Jesus gave it to his disciples anew and lived it himself (John 13:34).

Verses 9–11: "Brother" here means all brothers and sisters in faith, men and women. Whoever hates others lives in the dark, even if he thinks he is godly.

To children, fathers and young men VERSES 12–14

12 Little children, I am writing to you,
because your sins are forgiven for the sake of his name.
13 Fathers, I am writing to you,
because you know him who has been there from the beginning.
Young men, I am writing to you,
because you have won against the evil one.
Little children, I am writing to you,
because you know the Father.
14 Fathers, I have written to you,
because you know him who has been there from the beginning.
Young men, I have written to you,
because you are strong.
The word of God remains in you,
and you have won against the evil one.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the letter speaks to different groups. Perhaps these are age groups. Perhaps they are also stages in faith: beginners, experienced and strong. Everyone in the church is meant, the women too.

Each group is told something good: You are forgiven. You know God. You are strong.

Don't set your heart on the world VERSES 15–17

15 Do not love the world or the things in the world.
If anyone loves the world,
the Father's love is not in him.
16 Everything in the world does not come from the Father.
It comes from the world.
This means: wanting what the body desires,
wanting what the eyes see,
and showing off with what you have.
17 The world is passing away,
and so is everything people desire in it.
But whoever does God's will remains forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"World" here doesn't mean creation and doesn't mean people. God loves the world (John 3:16). It means a life that revolves only around greed, possessions and status.

Verse 16 names three traps: wanting things, wanting what you see, and showing off with what you have.

Verse 17: What you own passes away. What you do out of love remains.

A warning against deceivers VERSES 18–27

18 Little children, these are the end times.
You have heard that the Antichrist is coming.
And even now many antichrists have come.
That is how we know that it is the last hour.
19 They left us,
but they never really belonged to us.
If they had belonged to us,
they would have stayed with us.
But they left.
This made it clear that none of them belong to us.
20 But you have an anointing from the Holy One.
And all of you have knowledge.
To anoint means: to pour oil on someone as a sign that God has chosen them.

21 I am not writing to you because you do not know the truth.
I am writing because you do know it.
And you know that no lie comes from the truth.
22 Who is the liar?
It is the one who denies that Jesus is the Christ.
Whoever denies the Father and the Son is the Antichrist.
23 Whoever denies the Son does not have the Father either.
Whoever confesses the Son has the Father too.
24 So hold on to what you heard from the beginning.
Let it remain in you.
If what you heard from the beginning remains in you,
you will also remain in the Son and in the Father.
25 And this is what he promised us:
eternal life.
26 I have written this to you because of the people who are trying to lead you the wrong way.
27 But as for you:
The anointing you received from him remains in you.
So you do not need anyone to teach you.
His anointing teaches you about everything.
It is true. It is not a lie.
It has taught you,
and so you will remain in him.

IMPORTANT NOTE

The word "Antichrist" appears in the Bible only in the letters of John. It means: someone who is against Christ. Here it means teachers who had left the church and taught wrongly about Jesus.

In the course of history people often used this word to run others down: other churches, rulers or even whole peoples. It was also misused against Jews. That is wrong and has brought great suffering. The letter speaks of a conflict within the Christian church, not of the Jewish people.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 19: There had been a split in the church. A group had left. That made the church unsure.

Verses 20 and 27: "Anointing" probably means the Holy Spirit. Every Christian has received him, not only the teachers. That is why verse 27 doesn't mean that you should never learn anything. It means: You don't depend on deceivers. God's Spirit helps you recognize the truth.

Verses 22–23: For the letter this is important: Whoever rejects Jesus doesn't understand God rightly either. This means the teachers who had turned away from Jesus.

Remain in him VERSES 28–29

28 And now, little children, remain in him.
Then we can be confident when he appears.
We will not have to hide from him in shame when he comes.
29 You know that he is righteous.
So you also know this:
Everyone who does what is right has been born of him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 28: "Remain" is one of John's favorite words. It means: being firmly connected, like a branch with the vine (John 15).

Verse 29: "Born of him": Whoever belongs to God is like his child. This shows itself in doing good.

1 JOHN

CHAPTER 3

We are God's children

Children of God VERSES 1–3

1 See
how great the love is
that the Father has given us:
We should be called children of God!
That is why the world doesn't know us,
because it didn't know him.
2 Dear friends,
now we are children of God.
It is not yet revealed
what we will be.
But we know:
When he appears,
we will be like him.
For we will see him
just as he is.
3 Everyone who has this hope set on him
purifies himself,
just as he is pure.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: A wonderful sentence: God calls people his children. You don't have to earn this. It is a gift of love.

Verse 2: "Already now" and "not yet": We are already God's children. But we don't know yet what it will be like when it is complete. We will see God as he is.

Whoever belongs to God does what is right VERSES 4–10

4 Everyone who sins
also acts against the law.
Sin is lawlessness.
5 You know
that he was revealed
to take away our sins.
And in him is no sin.
6 Whoever remains in him
doesn't sin.
Whoever sins
hasn't seen him
and doesn't know him.
7 Little children,
don't let anyone lead you the wrong way.

Whoever does what is right
is righteous,
just as he is righteous.
8 Whoever sins
is of the devil.
For the devil has been sinning from the beginning.
This is why the Son of God was revealed:
to destroy the works of the devil.
9 Whoever is born of God
doesn't commit sin.
For God's seed remains in him.
And he can't sin,
because he is born of God.
10 This is how it becomes clear
who the children of God are
and who the children of the devil are:
Whoever doesn't do what is right
is not of God.
And neither is he
who doesn't love his brother.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verses 6 and 9 sound as if Christians never make mistakes any more. But in chapter 1:8 the same letter says: Whoever says that he has no sin deceives himself. Both belong together.

What is probably meant: Whoever belongs to God no longer lives in evil constantly and on purpose. He makes mistakes, but he doesn't stay in them. He comes back to God again and again.

No one has to despair because they still make mistakes. God forgives (1:9).

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: Righteous means: living right before God.

Verse 8: Jesus came to defeat evil.

Verse 9: "God's seed" is a picture: God has put something of his life into people. It grows and changes them.

Verse 10: The measure is simple: righteousness and love. That is how you recognize who belongs to God, not by words that only sound religious.

Love one another VERSES 11–18

11 For this is the message
that you heard from the beginning:
We should love one another.
12 We should not be like Cain.
He belonged to the evil one
and killed his brother.
And why did he kill him?
Because his deeds were evil,
but his brother's deeds were righteous.
13 Don't be surprised,
my brothers,
if the world hates you.
14 We know
that we have passed out of death into life,
because we love the brothers.
Whoever doesn't love his brother
remains in death.
15 Whoever hates his brother
is a murderer.
And you know:
No murderer has eternal life
remaining in him.
16 By this we have known love:
He laid down his life for us.
And we also ought to lay down our lives
for the brothers.
17 But if anyone has enough to live on
and sees
that his brother is in need,
and then closes his heart against him,
how can the love of God remain in him?
18 My little children,
let's not love only with words
or only with the tongue,
but in deed and in truth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12 recalls Cain and Abel (Genesis 4). Cain was jealous and killed his brother.

Verse 15: A hard saying: Hatred is the beginning of murder. Jesus says something similar in the Sermon on the Mount (Matthew 5:21–22).

Verse 16: Jesus laid down his life. For us this usually means: using our time, our strength, our money for others.

Verses 17–18: Love is very practical. Whoever has something and sees that someone is hungry or in need is to help. Nice words alone are not love.

IMPORTANT NOTE

"Laying down your life" doesn't mean that you have to endure violence or being exploited. Whoever experiences violence may protect themselves and get help. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK). For domestic violence: US: 1-800-799-7233. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

God is greater than our heart VERSES 19–24

19 By this we know
that we are of the truth.
And so we can reassure our heart before him.
20 For if our heart accuses us:
God is greater than our heart,
and he knows all things.
21 Dear friends,
if our heart doesn't accuse us,
we have boldness toward God.
22 And whatever we ask,
we receive from him.
For we keep his commandments
and do the things that please him.
23 And this is his commandment:
We should believe in the name of his Son Jesus Christ
and love one another,
just as he commanded.
24 Whoever keeps his commandments
remains in God,
and God remains in him.
And by this we know
that he remains in us:

by the Spirit
whom he gave us.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20 is a great comfort for all who blame themselves harshly: God is greater than our heart. He knows us completely and is gracious anyway. Our bad conscience doesn't have the last word.

Whoever feels guilty and worthless all the time can talk about it. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 22: This doesn't mean that God grants every wish. Whoever is connected with God asks for what God also wants.

Verse 23: The whole commandment in one sentence: believing in Jesus and loving one another.

1 JOHN

CHAPTER 4

God is love

Test the spirits VERSES 1–6

1 Dear friends,
do not believe every spirit.
Test the spirits to see whether they come from God.
Many false prophets have gone out into the world.
2 This is how you can recognize the Spirit of God:
Every spirit that says openly
that Jesus Christ has come as a human being of flesh and blood
comes from God.
3 But every spirit that does not say this about Jesus
does not come from God.
This is the spirit of the Antichrist.
You have heard that it is coming.
And now it is already in the world.
4 Little children, you belong to God.
You have won against these false prophets.
The one who is in you is greater
than the one who is in the world.
5 They belong to the world.
That is why they speak the way the world speaks.
And the world listens to them.
6 We belong to God.
Whoever knows God listens to us.
Whoever does not belong to God does not listen to us.
This is how we can tell the spirit of truth
from the spirit of error.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Not everything that sounds religious comes from God. Christians are to test and not believe everything. That applies today too, for example with preachers who frighten people or want money.

Verses 2–3: The test in the letter is: Does someone believe that Jesus really became a human being? The false teachers thought that Jesus only looked like a human being.

Verse 3: On the word "Antichrist" see the note in chapter 2. It is about false teaching in the church, not about a people or a religion.

Verse 4: An encouraging sentence: God in you is stronger than all evil in the world.

God is love VERSES 7–12

7 Dear friends, let us love one another.
Love comes from God.
Everyone who loves has been born of God
and knows God.
8 Whoever does not love does not know God,
because God is love.
9 This is how God showed his love among us:
God sent his only Son into the world,
so that we could live through him.
10 This is what love is:
It is not that we loved God.
It is that he loved us.
He sent his Son as the sacrifice that takes away our sins.
11 Dear friends, God loved us this much.
So we should also love one another.
12 No one has ever seen God.
But if we love one another, God remains in us.
And his love becomes complete in us.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: "God is love": This is one of the most important sentences of the whole Bible. God doesn't just have love sometimes. Love is his nature.

Verse 10: Love doesn't start with us. God loved first. We only answer.

Verse 12: No one can see God. But where people love one another, God becomes visible.

We remain in God VERSES 13–16

13 This is how we know that we remain in him and he remains in us:
He has given us some of his Spirit.
14 We have seen it, and we tell others about it:
The Father sent the Son as the Savior of the world.
15 Someone may say openly that Jesus is the Son of God.
Then God remains in that person,
and that person remains in God.
16 We know the love that God has for us,
and we have believed it.
God is love.
Whoever remains in love remains in God,
and God remains in him.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: "Savior of the world": Jesus did not come only for a few, but for everyone.

Verse 16: Whoever loves is connected with God. God is where love is.

Love drives out fear VERSES 17–21

17 This is how love has become complete among us:
We can be confident on the day of judgment.
For in this world we are just like him.
18 There is no fear in love.
Perfect love drives out fear.
Fear has to do with punishment.
Whoever is afraid has not yet become perfect in love.
19 We love him,
because he loved us first.
20 Someone may say, "I love God,"
but he hates his brother.
Then he is a liar.
He does not love his brother, whom he has seen.
So how can he love God, whom he has not seen?
21 And he has given us this commandment:
Whoever loves God must also love his brother.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18 is an important sentence for all who are afraid of God: God doesn't want to frighten people. His love is stronger than the fear of punishment. Whoever talks about God mainly with threats and fear has not understood this verse.

Whoever is very afraid, also afraid because of questions of faith, can talk about it. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Verse 19: Everything starts with God's love.

Verses 20–21: You can't love God and at the same time hate people. "Brother" here means all brothers and sisters, men and women.

1 JOHN

CHAPTER 5

Faith overcomes the world

Faith is the victory VERSES 1–5

1 Everyone who believes that Jesus is the Christ
has been born of God.
Everyone who loves the Father
also loves the child who is born of him.
2 This is how we know that we love God's children:
We love God and keep his commandments.
3 Loving God means keeping his commandments.
And his commandments are not hard.
4 Everyone who is born of God wins the victory over the world.
Your faith is the victory that has won over the world.
5 Who wins the victory over the world?
Only the one who believes that Jesus is the Son of God.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Whoever loves God also loves the other children of God. You can't love the Father and despise his children.

Verse 3: "His commandments are not hard": God's commandments are not a burden that crushes. They help us to live. And God gives the strength for them.

Verse 4: "The victory over the world" doesn't mean ruling over other people. It means: not letting fear, greed and evil rule you.

Three witnesses VERSES 6–12

6 Jesus Christ is the one who came by water and blood.
He did not come with the water only,
but with the water and with the blood.
And the Spirit tells us that this is true,
because the Spirit is the truth.
7 There are three who tell about it:
8 the Spirit,
the water
and the blood.
And the three agree.
9 We accept what people say about something.
But what God says is greater.
And God has spoken about his Son.
10 Whoever believes in the Son of God
has God's word about him in his own heart.
Whoever does not believe God makes God a liar,
because he has not believed what God has said about his Son.
11 And this is what God has said:
God gave us eternal life,
and this life is in his Son.
12 Whoever has the Son has the life.
Whoever does not have God's Son does not have the life.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: "Water and blood": The water probably recalls the baptism of Jesus in the Jordan. The blood recalls his death on the cross. Both belong to Jesus. The false teachers perhaps said: Christ was only there at the baptism, but not on the cross. The letter says: Yes, Jesus Christ really died.

Verses 7–8: In some later Bibles there is a longer text here about the Father, the Word and the Holy Spirit in heaven. This addition is not in the old Greek manuscripts. It was only added much later. That is why it is not here. The churches still believe in Father, Son and Holy Spirit. This shows in other places of the Bible.

Verse 12: The life that God gives is found in Jesus.

So that you may know VERSES 13–17

13 You believe in the name of the Son of God.
I have written this to you so that you may know
that you have eternal life.
And I want you to keep on believing in the name of the Son of God.
14 This is why we can be confident when we come to God:
If we ask for anything that agrees with his will,
he listens to us.
15 We know that he listens to us,
whatever we ask.
So we also know that we already have what we asked him for.

16 Someone may see his brother commit a sin
that does not lead to death.
Then he should pray for him,
and God will give him life.
This is for those whose sin does not lead to death.
There is a sin that leads to death.
I am not saying that you should pray about that sin.
17 Everything that is wrong is sin.
But there is a sin that does not lead to death.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: The letter wants to give certainty: You may know that you belong to God. You don't have to live in uncertainty.

Verses 14–15: God hears prayers. That doesn't mean that every wish is granted exactly that way. Whoever prays entrusts themselves to God's will.

Verse 16: A beautiful picture: Christians pray for one another when someone makes mistakes.

IMPORTANT NOTE

We don't know for sure what "a sin that leads to death" is exactly. Perhaps the letter means that someone turns away from Jesus very deliberately and for good, like the false teachers who left the church.

If you are afraid that you have committed such a sin: This very fear shows that you have not turned away from God. God forgives everyone who comes to him (1:9). The letter also doesn't forbid praying for someone. You may pray for all people.

If you feel weighed down, you can talk to someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

What we know VERSES 18–21

18 We know that whoever is born of God doesn't sin.
But he who was born of God keeps himself.
And the evil one cannot touch him.
19 We know that we belong to God.
And we know that the whole world is in the power of the evil one.
20 We know that the Son of God has come.
He has given us understanding,
so that we can know the one who is true.
And we are in the one who is true,
in his Son Jesus Christ.
This is the true God and eternal life.
21 Little children,
keep away from idols.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 18: On "doesn't sin" see the note in chapter 3: It means not living in evil constantly and on purpose.

Verse 18: Here it says: "But he who was born of God keeps himself." Some manuscripts say: *He keeps him*. Then Jesus is meant, who protects those who believe.

Verse 20: Here Jesus is probably called "the true God." Some also understand the sentence to mean God the Father.

Verse 21: The last sentence: "Idols" are everything that people put in the place of God, for example money, power or a false picture of Jesus.

Looking back: What have we read in the first letter of John?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus was really a human being: The apostles saw him, heard him and touched him (chapters 1 and 4).

God is light: Whoever belongs to God lives honestly. Whoever confesses their guilt is forgiven by God (chapter 1).

Loving one another: The old and new commandment. Love shows itself in deeds, not only in words (chapters 2 and 3).

Children of God: God gives us the gift of being his children (chapter 3).

God is greater than our heart: Even when we accuse ourselves (chapter 3).

God is love: He loved us first. Love drives out fear (chapter 4).

Certainty: Whoever believes in Jesus may know that he has eternal life (chapter 5).

For today: Whoever loves God also loves the people he sees.

What comes next? Next come two very short letters: the second and the third letter of John. They are the shortest books of the Bible.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 63 OF 66

2 JOHN

1 CHAPTER

2 JOHN

Chapter 1

Remain in truth and in love

Before we begin: The second letter of John

This letter is very short. It has only 13 verses. It probably fit on a single sheet of papyrus.

The sender calls himself "the elder." According to an old tradition this is the apostle John. Many scholars think it was a well-known leader from the circle around John.

The letter is written to a "chosen lady and her children." This probably means a church and its members. But it could also be a woman who led a church in her house.

The themes are the same as in the first letter of John: love, truth and the warning against false teachers.

The second letter of John has only 1 chapter.

Greeting VERSES 1–3

1 The elder writes
to the chosen lady and her children.
I love them in truth.
And not only I,
but also all
who know the truth.
2 We love you because of the truth,
which remains in us
and will be with us forever.
3 Grace, mercy and peace
will be with us
from God the Father
and from the Lord Jesus Christ,
the Son of the Father,
in truth and love.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"The chosen lady": At the end (verse 13) the children of her "chosen sister" send greetings. That is why many think: Two churches are meant, which are like sisters.

Truth and love belong together. Truth without love becomes hard. Love without truth means that anything goes.

Love one another VERSES 4–6

4 I am very glad
that I have found some of your children
living in the truth,
just as we received a commandment from the Father.
5 And now I ask you,
dear lady:
Let's love one another.
I am not writing you a new commandment,
but what we had from the beginning.
6 And this is love:
that we live by his commandments.
And this is the commandment,
just as you heard from the beginning:
that you should live in love.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: Again the old commandment of love, as in the first letter of John (1 John 2:7).

Verse 6: Love and commandments belong together. God's commandments say what love looks like in practice.

Beware of deceivers VERSES 7–11

7 For many deceivers have gone out into the world.
They don't confess
that Jesus Christ has come as a human being of flesh and blood.
This is the deceiver and the Antichrist.
8 Watch yourselves,
so that we don't lose
what we have worked for,
but receive a full reward.
9 Whoever goes beyond it
and doesn't remain in the teaching of Christ
doesn't have God.
Whoever remains in the teaching
has both the Father and the Son.
10 If anyone comes to you
and doesn't bring this teaching,
don't receive him into your house
and don't welcome him.
11 For whoever welcomes him
takes part in his evil deeds.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: As in the first letter of John, this is about teachers who say: Jesus was not really a human being. On the word "Antichrist" see the note at 1 John 2.

Verse 9: "Goes beyond it": The false teachers thought that they were already further along than the simple message of Jesus.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verses 10–11 sound very harsh. At that time teachers traveled from church to church. They stayed with Christians, and the church met in houses. Whoever took in a teacher gave him a stage in the church. So what is meant is: Don't give false teachers a place to teach in your church.

These verses do not give permission to treat people unkindly or to shut out people who believe differently. Jesus ate with everyone. Christians are to respect all people and be kind.

Closing VERSES 12–13

12 I would have much more to write to you.
But I don't want to do it with paper and ink.
Instead I hope
to come to you
and speak with you face to face,
so that our joy may be complete.

13 The children of your chosen sister greet you.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: A very human sentence: Some things are better said in person than in a letter. Nothing can replace meeting in person.

Verse 13: The "chosen sister" is probably another church where the elder is at the moment.

Looking back: What have we read in the second letter of John?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Truth and love: Both belong together (verses 1–3).

The old commandment: Love one another (verses 5–6).

Beware of deceivers: Remain with the message of Jesus, who really became a human being (verses 7–11).

Better in person: Joy becomes complete when people meet (verse 12).

For today: Remain with the truth, but remain loving as you do.

What comes next? Next comes the third letter of John. It is written to a man named Gaius and speaks about hospitality.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 64 OF 66

3 JOHN

1 CHAPTER

3 JOHN

Chapter 1

Hospitality for the messengers

Before we begin: The third letter of John

This is the shortest book of the Bible. In the Greek text it has the fewest words.

Like the second letter it comes from "the elder."

It is written to a man named Gaius. Gaius was a Christian who welcomed guests well.

The letter shows in a very human way what things were like in the first churches: Traveling messengers went from place to place and needed a place to stay. A church leader named Diotrephes didn't want to take them in. There was a struggle for power.

The third letter of John has only 1 chapter.

Greeting and joy VERSES 1–4

1 The elder writes
to my dear friend Gaius,
whom I love in truth.
2 Dear friend,
I pray
that you may prosper in all things
and be healthy,
just as your soul prospers.
3 For I rejoiced greatly
when brothers came
and told about your truth,
how you live in truth.
4 I have no greater joy than this:
to hear
that my children live in the truth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: A completely normal, friendly wish, as people wrote it in letters at that time: I hope you are well and healthy.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Some preachers use verse 2 to say: Whoever believes rightly will always be rich and healthy. That is not what it says here. It is a greeting, not a promise. Poverty and sickness are not a punishment for weak faith. Prayer does not replace a doctor.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: "My children": This is what the elder calls the people who came to faith through him.

Praise for Gaius VERSES 5–8

5 Dear friend,
you act faithfully
in everything you do for the brothers,
even though they are strangers.
6 They have told the church
about your love.
You do well
to send them on their journey
in a way that pleases God.
7 For they went out for the sake of the Name
and took nothing from the Gentiles.
8 That is why we should receive such people,
so that we may become fellow workers for the truth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6: Gaius takes traveling Christians into his home, even when he doesn't know them at all. He gives them food and everything they need for the rest of their journey.

Verse 7: "For the sake of the Name" means: for Jesus. The messengers didn't want to take money from people who didn't believe in Jesus. That way no one would think that they were making money from their faith.

Verse 8: Whoever supports messengers works with them, even if they themselves stay at home.

Trouble with Diotrephes VERSES 9–12

9 I wrote to the church.
But Diotrephes,
who loves to be first among them,
doesn't accept what we say.
10 So,
if I come,
I will call attention to his deeds.
He talks unjustly about us
with wicked words.
And not content with that:
He himself doesn't receive the brothers.
And some people want to receive them.
But he forbids them to do it
and throws them out of the church.
11 Dear friend,
don't imitate what is evil,
but what is good.
Whoever does good
is of God.
Whoever does evil
hasn't seen God.
12 Everyone speaks well of Demetrius,
and the truth itself testifies to it.
We also testify to it,
and you know
that our testimony is true.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9–10: Diotrephes wants power in the church. He speaks badly of others and throws people out. This shows: Even in the first churches power was misused.

Whoever misuses power in a church acts against Jesus. Jesus said: Whoever wants to be first is to serve everyone (compare Mark 10:43–44).

Whoever is put under pressure or shut out in a church may get help, for example from people they trust or from counseling services.

Verse 12: Demetrius perhaps brought this letter to Gaius. The elder recommends him.

Closing VERSES 13–14

13 I would have much more to write to you.
But I don't want to write to you with ink and pen.
14 But I hope
to see you soon.
Then we will speak face to face.
Peace be to you.
The friends greet you.
Greet the friends,
each one by name.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

In some Bibles the last sentence is counted as a separate verse 15.

"The friends": This is what the Christians called themselves here. Jesus called his disciples friends (John 15:15).

"Each one by name": Every person is important and is greeted personally.

Looking back: What have we read in the third letter of John?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Living in the truth: That is the elder's greatest joy (verses 3–4).

Hospitality: Gaius takes in messengers who are strangers and supports them (verses 5–8).

Misuse of power: Diotrephes wants to be first and shuts others out. That is wrong (verses 9–10).

Imitating what is good: Whoever does good is of God (verse 11).

For today: Be hospitable and serve one another instead of ruling over others.

What comes next? Next comes the letter of Jude. It is also very short and warns against false teachers.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 65 OF 66

JUDE

1 CHAPTER

JUDE

CHAPTER 1

Fight for the faith

Before we begin: The letter of Jude

This short letter comes from Jude. He calls himself "brother of James." This probably means James, the brother of Jesus. Then Jude would also be a brother of Jesus (compare Mark 6:3).

Important: This Jude is **not** Judas Iscariot, who betrayed Jesus. Judas or Jude was a very common name at that time. It comes from Judah, one of the sons of Jacob.

The letter warns against people who have crept into the church. They probably said: Because God is gracious, we may do what we want.

The letter uses many examples from the Hebrew Bible. It also quotes old Jewish books that are not in the Bible, for example the Book of Enoch.

The second letter of Peter (chapter 2) is very similar to this letter.

The letter of Jude has only 1 chapter.

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

This letter uses very harsh words against false teachers. That is how people wrote about disputes at that time. The harsh words do not give permission to insult people today who believe differently. Judgment on people belongs to God alone.

Greeting VERSES 1–2

1 Jude,
a servant of Jesus Christ
and brother of James,
writes to those who are called,
made holy by God the Father
and kept for Jesus Christ.
2 May mercy, peace and love
be given to you in abundance.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Kept for Jesus Christ": God watches over those who believe. The word "keep" appears often in this letter, at the beginning and at the end (verse 24).

Fight for the faith VERSES 3–4

3 Dear friends,
I was very eager to write to you
about our common salvation.
But now I must write to you
and urge you:
Fight hard for the faith
that was given once for all to God's holy people.
4 For some people have secretly crept in.
Long ago it was written about them
that they would be condemned.
They are ungodly people.
They turn the grace of our God
into an excuse for wild living.
And they deny our only Master,
God, and Lord,
Jesus Christ.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: "Fight hard" here doesn't mean using violence. It means: standing up for the faith with all your strength and remaining with the truth.

Verse 4: The false teachers probably said: God forgives anyway, so everything is allowed. The letter says: That is a misuse of grace.

At the end of verse 4 it says: "our only Master, God, and Lord, Jesus Christ." Some manuscripts don't have the word "God" there.

Examples from the past VERSES 5–7

5 I want to remind you,
though you already know all this:
The Lord saved a people out of the land of Egypt.
But afterward he destroyed those
who didn't believe.
6 And the angels
who didn't keep their first place,
but left their own home,
he keeps in everlasting chains in darkness
for the judgment of the great day.
7 It is the same with Sodom and Gomorrah
and the cities around them.
In the same way as these, they gave themselves over to
sexual immorality
and went after strange flesh.
They are a warning example
and suffer the punishment of eternal fire.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5 recalls the time in the wilderness after leaving Egypt (Numbers 14). Some manuscripts say "Jesus" instead of "the Lord."

Verse 6 recalls old Jewish stories about angels who set themselves against God (compare Genesis 6:1–4).

Verse 7: "Strange flesh": Many scholars think that this means: The men of Sodom wanted to attack the angels who were Lot's guests (Genesis 19). Like the angels in verse 6 they disregarded the boundary between heaven and earth.

The Hebrew Bible also names as the guilt of Sodom: pride, too much of everything, and that they did not help the poor (Ezekiel 16:49). The story of Sodom is above all about violence against strangers.

What the false teachers are like VERSES 8–13

8 In the same way these people also,
in their dreaming,
defile the body,
despise all authority
and speak evil of heavenly powers.
9 Even Michael, the archangel,
did not dare
to bring a slanderous judgment
when he argued with the devil
and disputed about the body of Moses.
He only said,
"May the Lord rebuke you!"
10 But these people speak evil of whatever
they don't know.
And the things they understand by instinct,
like animals without reason,
are the very things that destroy them.
11 How terrible it will be for them!
For they have gone in the way of Cain.

For money they have run into the error of Balaam.
And they have perished in Korah's rebellion.
12 They are like hidden rocks under water
at your love feasts,
when they feast and eat with you.
They are shepherds
who without fear only feed themselves.
They are like clouds without water,
driven by the winds.
They are like trees in autumn without fruit,
twice dead
and pulled up by the roots.
13 They are like wild waves of the sea,
foaming out their own shame.
They are like wandering stars.
The blackest darkness
is kept for them forever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: This story about the archangel Michael and the body of Moses is not in the Bible. It comes from an old Jewish book. The message: Not even an archangel judges the devil himself. He leaves the judgment to God.

Verse 11 names three examples from the Hebrew Bible: Cain, who killed his brother (Genesis 4). Balaam, who let himself be hired for money (Numbers 22). Korah, who rebelled against Moses and Aaron (Numbers 16).

Verse 12: "Love feasts" were the shared meals of the church. "Hidden rocks" are dangerous because you can't see them. The false teachers seem harmless, but they do damage.

Verses 12–13: Many pictures from nature: They promise something, as clouds promise rain, but they give nothing.

The words of Enoch VERSES 14–16

14 Enoch,
the seventh from Adam,
also prophesied about these people.
He said,
"Look,
the Lord came with tens of thousands of his holy ones,
15 to execute judgment on all.
He will convict all the ungodly
of all their ungodly works
which they have done in an ungodly way,
and of all the hard things
which ungodly sinners have spoken against him."
16 These people are always grumbling and complaining.
They live by their desires.
Their mouth speaks proud words.
And they flatter people
to gain advantage.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: "The seventh from Adam": You count Adam, Seth, Enosh, Kenan, Mahalalel, Jared, Enoch. Enoch appears in Genesis 5:18–24. He lived so closely with God that God took him to himself.

Verses 14–15: This quotation is not in the Bible. It comes from the Book of Enoch, an old Jewish writing. Jude knew and valued this book. In the Ethiopian Orthodox Church the Book of Enoch even belongs to the Bible. In the other churches it does not belong to it.

Verse 16: "And they flatter people to gain advantage": They treat people according to how useful they are to them.

Keep yourselves in God's love VERSES 17–23

17 But you,
dear friends,
remember the words
which were spoken before by the apostles
of our Lord Jesus Christ.
18 They said to you,
"In the last time there will be mockers,
who live by their own ungodly desires."
19 These are the ones
who cause divisions.
They live only by their natural instincts
and don't have the Spirit.
20 But you,
dear friends,
keep building yourselves up
on your most holy faith
and pray in the Holy Spirit.
21 Keep yourselves in the love of God
and wait for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ
that leads to eternal life.
22 On some have compassion,
making a distinction.
23 Save some,
snatching them out of the fire,
with fear.
Hate even the clothing
stained by the body.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 20–21: What Christians are to do: grow in faith, pray and remain in God's love.

Verses 22–23: Very important: Christians are not simply to write others off. They are to have compassion and try to save people. You are to hate evil, but not people.

Verses 22–23 have come down in different forms in the old manuscripts. Some have two groups of people, others three.

Praise to God VERSES 24–25

24 God is able to keep them
from stumbling.
He is able to present you without fault
before his glory,
with great joy.
25 To God,
our Savior,
who alone is wise,
belong glory and majesty,
power and authority,
now and forever.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After all the harsh words the letter ends with wonderful praise. The most important thing: We don't have to hold on to ourselves. God holds on to us and keeps us.

These verses are spoken as a blessing at the end of many worship services.

In many manuscripts verse 25 says more: God is praised through Jesus Christ our Lord. And glory belongs to him already before all time.

Looking back: What have we read in the letter of Jude?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Fight for the faith: Remain with the message that you received (verse 3).

Grace is no excuse: Whoever uses God's grace as a permission for everything misuses it (verse 4).

Examples from the Hebrew Bible: God sees evil and judges it (verses 5–16).

Keep yourselves in God's love: Pray, grow in faith and have compassion on others (verses 20–23).

God keeps you: He holds you firm until you reach the goal (verses 24–25).

For today: Hate evil, but try to save people.

What comes next? Last comes the Revelation to John. It is the last book of the Bible. In pictures it speaks of God's victory over evil and of new heavens and a new earth.

NEW TESTAMENT · BOOK 66 OF 66

REVELATION

22 CHAPTERS

REVELATION

Chapter 1

John sees Jesus in his glory

Before we begin: The Revelation to John

The Revelation is the last book of the Bible.

A man named John wrote it down. He was on the island of Patmos, probably as an exile. According to old tradition, he is the apostle John. Many scholars think it was another Christian prophet with the name John.

The book was probably written around AD 95. At that time the Roman Empire ruled. Christians were put under pressure to worship the emperor like a god. Some were persecuted.

The Revelation is full of pictures and signs: animals, angels, numbers, colors, dragons, trumpets. Books like this are called "apocalypse." The Greek word means: unveiling. God shows what is behind things.

The pictures are not a map and not a timetable for the end of the world. They are like a coded message to people in need. The message is: God has the last word. Evil will not win. Jesus, the Lamb, has already won.

Many pictures come from the Hebrew Bible, especially from the books of Daniel, Ezekiel, Isaiah and Zechariah.

The Revelation has 22 chapters.

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

Some people have used the Revelation to make others afraid, or have calculated the date of the end of the world. All these calculations were wrong. Jesus himself says: No one knows the day and the hour (compare Matthew 24:36).

The Revelation wants to comfort, not to frighten. Whoever becomes very afraid because of this book can talk with someone about it, for example with a pastor or a counselor. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

Be careful also of groups that use the Revelation to put pressure on people and say: Only with us are you safe. That is a warning sign.

The title of the book VERSES 1–3

1 This is the Revelation of Jesus Christ.
God gave it to him,
so that he would show his servants
the things which must happen soon.
He sent his angel
and made it known to his servant John.
2 John testified to God's word
and to the testimony of Jesus Christ,
everything that he saw.
3 Blessed is he
who reads aloud the words of this prophecy,
and blessed are those
who hear them
and keep
what is written in it.
For the time is near.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "Revelation of Jesus Christ": Jesus is the one who shows something, and he is also the one it is about.

Verse 3: The book was read aloud in worship. That is why the reader and the listeners are meant. It is the first of seven "Blessed is …" in the Revelation.

"The time is near": God will soon step in. For the persecuted Christians at that time, this was a comfort.

Greeting to the seven churches VERSES 4–8

4 John writes to the seven churches in the province of
Asia:
Grace to you and peace
from God,
who is and who was and who is to come,
and from the seven Spirits
who are before his throne,
5 and from Jesus Christ.
He is the faithful witness,
the firstborn of the dead
and the ruler of the kings of the earth.
To him who loves us
and washed us from our sins by his blood
6 and who made us to be a Kingdom,
priests to his God and Father,
to him belong the glory and the power
forever and ever.
Amen.
7 Look,
he is coming with the clouds.
Every eye will see him,
including those
who pierced him.
And all the tribes of the earth will mourn over him.
Even so.
Amen.
8 "I am the Alpha and the Omega,"
says the Lord God,
"who is and who was and who is to come,
the Almighty."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: "Asia" here is a Roman province in the west of today's Turkey. The number seven in the Bible means: complete. The seven churches stand for the whole church.

"Who is and who was and who is to come" recalls the name of God that God told Moses (Exodus 3:14).

"The seven Spirits" probably means the Holy Spirit in all his fullness.

Verse 5: "The ruler of the kings of the earth": The Roman emperor doesn't have the highest power. Jesus does.

Verse 6: All Christians are like priests: They may come directly to God. God said this first to Israel (Exodus 19:6).

Verse 7 recalls Daniel 7:13 and Zechariah 12:10.

Verse 8: Alpha is the first letter of the Greek alphabet, Omega the last. That means: God is the beginning and the

end of everything.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verse 7: "Those who pierced him" is not an accusation against the Jewish people. Roman soldiers crucified Jesus. According to Christian faith, Jesus died for the guilt of all people. The mourning concerns "all the tribes of the earth."

John on Patmos VERSES 9–11

9 I, John,
am your brother.
I share with you the oppression,
the Kingdom and the perseverance in Christ Jesus.
I was on the island
that is called Patmos,
because of God's Word
and because of the testimony of Jesus Christ.
10 On the Lord's day
I was in the Spirit.
Then I heard behind me a loud voice,
like a trumpet.
11 It said,
"Write in a book
what you see,
and send it to the seven churches:
to Ephesus, to Smyrna, to Pergamum,
to Thyatira, to Sardis, to Philadelphia
and to Laodicea."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: Patmos is a small island in the Mediterranean Sea. John had probably been banished there because he told people about Jesus.

Verse 10: "On the Lord's day": This means Sunday, the day on which Jesus rose from the dead. The Christians held worship on this day.

Verse 11: The seven cities lie in the west of today's Turkey. A messenger could visit them one after another on a round trip.

John sees Jesus VERSES 12–20

12 I turned around
to see
who was speaking with me.
And when I had turned around,
I saw seven golden lampstands.
13 And among the lampstands
was one
who looked like a son of man.
He wore a long robe reaching down to his feet
and a golden sash around his chest.
14 His head and his hair were white
as white wool,
like snow.
His eyes were like a flame of fire.
15 His feet were like polished brass,
as if it had been refined in a furnace.
His voice was like the voice of many waters.
16 He had seven stars in his right hand.
Out of his mouth came a sharp two-edged sword.
And his face was like the sun
shining at its brightest.
17 When I saw him,
I fell at his feet like a dead man.
He laid his right hand on me
and said,
"Don't be afraid.
I am the first and the last,
18 and the Living one.
I was dead,
and look:
I am alive forever and ever.
Amen.
I have the keys of Death
and of Hades.
19 So write
the things which you have seen,
and the things which are,
and the things which will happen after this.
20 This is the mystery of the seven stars
which you saw in my right hand,
and of the seven golden lampstands:
The seven stars are the angels of the seven churches.
And the seven lampstands are the seven churches."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: "One who looked like a son of man" recalls Daniel 7:13. Jesus is meant.

Verse 14: The white hair recalls God, the "Ancient of Days," in Daniel 7:9. Jesus is described here with the glory of God.

Verse 16: The sword out of his mouth is not a real sword. It is a picture for his word. Jesus doesn't fight with weapons, but with the truth.

Verse 17: "Don't be afraid": That is the first thing Jesus says. His hand on John is a gesture of care.

Verse 18: Hades is the world of the dead. Jesus has the keys of Death. That means: Death doesn't have the last word. Jesus is stronger than death.

Verse 20: Jesus is among his churches. He holds them in his hand. The "angels of the seven churches" are perhaps heavenly protectors, or perhaps the leaders of the churches.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 2

Letters to Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum and Thyatira

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

In Chapters 2 and 3, Jesus dictates seven short letters to seven churches. All the letters have the same structure: Who is speaking? What is good? What is not good? A warning. A promise for those who hold out ("who overcome").

The letters speak into the real situation of these churches at that time. But they are also written for all churches at all times: "Whoever has ears should listen."

The letter to Ephesus VERSES 1–7

1 "Write this to the angel of the church in Ephesus:
'These are the words of the one who holds the seven stars in his right hand.
He walks among the seven golden lampstands.
He says:
2 I know what you do.
I know how hard you work and how you keep going.
I know that you cannot stand evil people.
Some people call themselves apostles, but they are not.
You have tested them,
and you found out that they are liars.
3 You keep going.
You have suffered much for my name.
And you have not grown tired.
4 But I have this against you:
You have left the love you had at first.
5 Remember how far you have fallen.
Turn back to God.
Do the things you did at first.
If you do not turn back, I will come to you soon.
Then I will take your lampstand away from its place.
6 But this is good about you:
You hate what the Nicolaitans do.
I hate it too.
7 Whoever has ears should listen to what the Spirit says to the churches.
To the one who overcomes, I will give food from the tree of life.
The tree of life is in the Paradise of my God.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Ephesus was a large port city with a famous temple. Paul worked there for a long time (Acts 19).

Verses 2–4: The church works hard and holds on to the right teaching. But it has lost love. Right faith without love is empty (compare 1 Corinthians 13).

Verse 5: The lampstand is the church (1:20). Without love, a church can lose its light.

Verse 6: We don't know exactly who the Nicolaitans were. Perhaps a group that thought: Christians may take part in everything, even in feasts for idols.

Verse 7: To overcome means: to win the victory and hold out to the end.

The tree of life stood in the Garden of Eden (Genesis 2:9). At the end of the Bible it stands there again (Chapter 22). God gives the life that was lost at the beginning.

The letter to Smyrna VERSES 8–11

8 And write this to the angel of the church in Smyrna:
'These are the words of the First and the Last.
He was dead, and he has come back to life.
He says:
9 I know what you do.
I know your suffering and your poverty.
But you are rich.
And I know how some people speak evil against you.
They say that they are Jews, but they are not.
They are a synagogue of Satan.
10 Do not be afraid of what you are about to suffer.
Look, the devil is going to throw some of you into prison
to test you.
You will suffer for 10 days.
Be faithful, even if it means dying.
Then I will give you the crown of life.
11 Whoever has ears should listen to what the Spirit says to the churches.
The one who overcomes will not be harmed by the second death.'

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verse 9 is a very difficult verse. In history it was terribly misused to insult and persecute Jews. That is wrong and against the will of God.

John was himself a Jew, like Jesus and all the first apostles. He is speaking here about a conflict in a certain city at a certain time. It was about a group that reported the Christians there to the Roman authorities. John means: Whoever acts like that is not behaving in a way that fits the people of God.

The verse is **not** a statement about the Jewish people or about Jewish communities today. God has not rejected his people Israel (Romans 11:1–2). The gifts and the calling of God cannot be taken back (Romans 11:29).

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Smyrna is today's Izmir in Turkey.

Verse 9: A synagogue is a place where people meet to pray and to hear God's word.

Verse 9: "Poor, but rich": The Christians there had little money, but they were rich with God.

Verse 10: "10 days": a limited time. The suffering has an end. "The crown of life": the victory wreath at sports contests. God gives eternal life.

Verse 11: "The second death" is a picture for being separated from God forever (compare 20:14). Whoever belongs to Jesus doesn't need to be afraid of it.

The letter to Pergamum VERSES 12–17

12 And write this to the angel of the church in Pergamum:
'These are the words of the one who has the sharp sword with two edges.
He says:
13 I know what you do.
And I know where you live.
You live where Satan's throne is.
But you hold on to my name.
You did not deny your faith in me,
not even in the days of Antipas.
Antipas was my faithful witness.
He was killed in your city, where Satan lives.
14 But I have a few things against you.
Some of you there follow the teaching of Balaam.
Balaam taught Balak how to make the people of Israel fall.
So they ate food that was sacrificed to idols,
and they committed sexual immorality.

15 In the same way, some of you follow the teaching of the
Nicolaitans.
16 So turn back to God!
If you do not, I will come to you soon.
I will fight against them with the sword of my mouth.
17 Whoever has ears should listen to what the Spirit says
to the churches.
To the one who overcomes, I will give some of the
hidden manna.
I will also give him a white stone.
A new name is written on the stone.
No one knows this name except the one who receives
it.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: Pergamum was a center of emperor worship. A great altar and a temple for the emperor stood there. That is why John calls it "Satan's throne." Antipas was a Christian who was killed there for his faith.

Verse 14 recalls Numbers 25 and 31:16. Balaam advised leading Israel into worshiping idols.

Verse 16: Jesus fights with "the sword of my mouth," that is, with his word, not with weapons.

Verse 17: The manna was the bread from heaven in the wilderness (Exodus 16). At that time a white stone was often a ticket of entry or a sign of being found not guilty. The new name shows: Every person is personally important to God.

The letter to Thyatira VERSES 18–29

18 And write this to the angel of the church in Thyatira:
'These are the words of the Son of God.
His eyes are like a flame of fire.
His feet are like polished brass.
He says:
19 I know what you do.
I know your love and your faith.
I know how you serve and how patiently you hold out.
And I know that you are doing more now than you did
at first.
20 But I have this against you:
You put up with your woman Jezebel.
She calls herself a prophetess.
With her teaching she leads my servants astray.
She leads them into sexual immorality,
and to eat food that was sacrificed to idols.
21 I gave her time to turn away from her sexual
immorality.
But she refuses to do it.
22 Look!
I will throw her into a bed of great oppression.
I will do the same to those who commit adultery with
her,
unless they turn away from what she does.
23 I will kill her children with Death.
Then all the churches will know
that I am the one who looks deep into minds and
hearts.
I will give each of you what your deeds deserve.
24 But now I speak to the rest of you in Thyatira.
You do not follow this teaching.
You do not know what some people call 'the deep
things of Satan.'
To you I say:
I am not putting any other burden on you.
25 Just hold on to what you have until I come.
26 The one who overcomes
and keeps doing what I want until the end
will receive power over the nations from me.
27 He will rule them with an iron rod.
He will smash them like clay pots.
I have received the same power from my Father.
28 And I will give him the morning star.
29 Whoever has ears should listen to what the Spirit says
to the churches.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Thyatira was a trading city with many craftsmen's guilds. Whoever wanted to belong often had to take part in feasts for gods. Lydia, the seller of purple cloth, also came from Thyatira (Acts 16:14).

Verse 20: "Jezebel" is probably not her real name. It is a code name. It recalls Queen Jezebel, who led Israel into worshiping idols (1 Kings 16 and 21). Some manuscripts have "the woman Jezebel" instead of "your woman Jezebel."

Verse 20: What is criticized is not that a woman speaks as a prophetess. In the Bible there are many prophetesses, for example Miriam, Deborah, Huldah and Anna. What is criticized is what she teaches.

Verse 21: God gives time to repent. He is patient.

Verse 22: "A bed of great oppression" probably means a sickbed or great suffering.

Verses 22–23 use the harsh picture language of the prophets. It is a serious warning. It is not permission for people to punish others or do violence to them. Judgment belongs to God alone. Sickness is not a punishment from God.

Verse 27 recalls Psalm 2:9. Verse 28: "The morning star" is Jesus himself (compare 22:16).

REVELATION

CHAPTER 3

Letters to Sardis, Philadelphia and Laodicea

The letter to Sardis VERSES 1–6

1 And write this to the angel of the church in Sardis:
'These are the words of the one who has the seven
Spirits of God and the seven stars.
He says:
I know what you do.
People say that you are alive.
But you are dead.
2 Wake up!
Make strong what is still left,
before you throw it away too.

I have found that nothing you do is complete in the eyes of my God.
3 So remember what you received and heard.
Hold on to it, and turn back to God.
If you do not stay awake, I will come like a thief.
You will not know at what hour I will come to you.
4 But you have a few people in Sardis
who have not made their clothes dirty.
They will walk with me in white clothes,
because they are worthy.
5 The one who overcomes will be dressed in white clothes.
I will never erase his name from the book of life.
I will say openly before my Father and his angels
that he belongs to me.
6 Whoever has ears should listen to what the Spirit says to the churches.'

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Sardis was once a rich royal city. Its fortress was thought to be impossible to capture. Even so, it was conquered twice because the guards didn't pay attention. That is why the word fits: "Wake up!"

Verse 1: From the outside the church looks alive. But inside, its faith has fallen asleep.

Verses 4–5: White garments are a sign of purity, joy and victory.

"The book of life" is a picture: God knows the names of the people who belong to him. Verse 5 is a promise: He doesn't erase them.

The letter to Philadelphia VERSES 7–13

7 And write this to the angel of the church in Philadelphia:
'These are the words of the one who is holy and true.
He has the key of David.
When he opens a door, no one can shut it.
When he shuts a door, no one can open it.
He says:
8 I know what you do.
Look, I have put an open door in front of you.
No one can shut it.
You have only a little strength.
But you have kept my word,
and you have not denied my name.
9 Look, some people belong to the synagogue of Satan.
They say that they are Jews, but they are not.
They are lying.
Look, I will make them come and worship before your feet.
I will make them know that I have loved you.
10 You kept my command to hold out patiently.
So I will also keep you from the hour of testing.
That hour is coming on the whole world.
It will test the people who live on the earth.
11 I am coming soon!
Hold on to what you have,
so that no one takes your crown.
12 I will make the one who overcomes
a pillar in the temple of my God.
He will never leave it again.
I will write on him the name of my God.
I will write on him the name of the city of my God,
the new Jerusalem.
It comes down out of heaven from my God.
And I will write on him my own new name.
13 Whoever has ears should listen to what the Spirit says to the churches.'

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verse 9 is as difficult as 2:9. In history it was misused to insult Jews. That is wrong.

What is meant is a local conflict at that time in Philadelphia. The verse is not a statement about the Jewish people. John himself was a Jew. God has not rejected his people Israel (Romans 11:1–2).

"Worship before your feet" recalls Isaiah 60:14. There it is a promise for Israel. Here it is spoken to the small, weak church: God sees you and loves you.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Philadelphia means "brotherly love." The city lay in an area with many earthquakes.

Verse 7: "The key of David" recalls Isaiah 22:22. Jesus has the power to open doors.

Verse 8: This church has only a little power, but it stays faithful. Jesus praises it without any blame. Small churches are worth no less to God.

Verse 12: In a city with earthquakes, a firm pillar is a beautiful picture: Whoever belongs to God stands firm and safe. The new Jerusalem comes again in Chapter 21.

The letter to Laodicea VERSES 14–22

14 And write this to the angel of the church in Laodicea:
'These are the words of the Amen,
the Faithful and True Witness,
the Beginning of God's creation.
He says:
15 I know what you do.
You are neither cold nor hot.
I wish you were cold or hot!
16 But you are lukewarm,
neither hot nor cold.
So I will spit you out of my mouth.
17 You say,
"I am rich.
I have become wealthy.
I do not need anything."
But you do not know how wretched you are.
You are miserable, poor, blind and naked.
18 So I give you this advice:
Buy gold from me that has been made pure by fire.
Then you will be rich.
Buy white clothes from me, so that you can dress yourself.
Then no one will see the shame of your nakedness.
And buy salve from me to put on your eyes.
Then you will be able to see.
19 I correct and discipline everyone I love.
So be eager, and turn back to God.
20 Look, I stand at the door and knock.
If anyone hears my voice and opens the door,
I will come in to him.
I will eat with him, and he will eat with me.

21 To the one who overcomes,
I will give a place to sit with me on my throne.
In the same way, I overcame,
and I sat down with my Father on his throne.
22 Whoever has ears should listen to what the Spirit says to the churches.'"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Laodicea was a rich city. It was famous for banks, for black wool and for an eye salve. That is why the pictures in verse 18 fit exactly.

Verses 15–16: Laodicea had no good water of its own. The water came through a pipeline and was lukewarm and tasted bad. Nearby there were hot springs and cold, fresh water. Both are good. Lukewarm water you spit out. What is meant: a faith that helps no one and changes nothing.

Verse 17: Riches can make people blind. They think they need nothing, not even God.

Verse 19: Jesus criticizes out of love, not out of hate.

Verse 20 is a famous picture: Jesus doesn't force himself on anyone. He knocks and waits. Whoever opens the door, he eats with them and shares his life with them.

Verse 21: A great promise: Whoever holds out belongs completely to Jesus.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 4

The throne in heaven

A door opened in heaven VERSES 1–6A

1 After this I looked,
and I saw a door standing open in heaven.
Then I heard the first voice again,
the voice that had spoken to me before.
It sounded like a trumpet.
It said,
"Come up here.
I will show you what must happen after this."
2 At once I was in the Spirit.
Look!
A throne stood in heaven,
and someone was sitting on the throne.
3 The one who sat there looked like a jasper stone and a sardius.
There was a rainbow around the throne.
It looked like an emerald.
Jasper, sardius and emerald are precious stones.
4 Around the throne there were 24 other thrones.
On these thrones sat 24 elders.
They wore white clothes
and had gold crowns on their heads.
5 Lightning, rumbling sounds and thunder came out of the throne.
Seven lamps of fire were burning in front of the throne.
These are the seven Spirits of God.
6 In front of the throne there was something like a sea of glass.
It was clear like crystal.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

After the letters to the churches on earth, John now looks into heaven. Before hard things are told, God shows: He sits on the throne. He rules, not the emperor in Rome.

Verse 3: John doesn't describe God with a face, but only with colors and light. God is greater than any picture. The rainbow recalls God's promise after the flood (Genesis 9:13): God stands by his creation.

Verse 4: The 24 elders perhaps stand for the people of God: the 12 tribes of Israel and the 12 apostles.

Verse 5: Lightning and thunder recall how God appeared at Mount Sinai (Exodus 19:16).

Verse 6: For people at that time, the sea was a picture of chaos and danger. Here it is completely calm, like glass. Before God, chaos has no power.

The four living creatures VERSES 6B–8

In the middle of the throne and around the throne
there were four living creatures.
They were covered with eyes, in front and in back.
7 The first creature was like a lion.
The second creature was like a calf.
The third creature had a face like a man.
The fourth creature was like a flying eagle.
8 Each of the four living creatures had six wings.
They are covered with eyes all around and inside.
Day and night they never stop saying,
"Holy, holy, holy is the Lord God, the Almighty,
who was and who is and who is to come!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The four living creatures recall the beings that the prophet Ezekiel saw (Ezekiel 1), and the seraphim in Isaiah (Isaiah 6).

Lion, calf, man and eagle perhaps stand for the whole living creation: the strongest wild animal, the strongest farm animal, the human being and the strongest bird. The whole creation praises God.

Later, Christians used these four creatures as signs for the four Gospels: Matthew (man), Mark (lion), Luke (calf) and John (eagle).

The many eyes mean: They see everything. God keeps everything in view.

Verse 8: "Holy, holy, holy" is the same song of praise as in Isaiah 6:3. It is still sung today in Jewish and Christian worship.

All worship God VERSES 9–11

9 The living creatures give glory, honor and thanks
to the one who sits on the throne,
who lives forever and ever.
10 Whenever they do this,
the 24 elders fall down before the one who sits on the throne.
They worship him who lives forever and ever.

They throw their crowns down in front of the throne
and say,
11 "Worthy are you, our Lord and God, the Holy One,
to receive the glory, the honor and the power.
For you created all things.
Because of your desire they existed and were created!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 10: The elders throw their crowns down before God. That means: All honor belongs to God, not to us.

Verse 11: "Worthy are you": At that time people cheered the emperor with similar words. The Revelation says: Only God is worthy, not the emperor.

"Because of your desire": The world is not an accident. God wanted it. That is why every creature is wanted and precious.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 5

The Lamb and the scroll

Who can open the scroll? VERSES 1–5

1 I saw a book in the right hand of the one who sat on the throne.
It had writing on the inside and on the outside.
It was sealed shut with seven seals.
2 I saw a mighty angel.
He called out with a loud voice,
"Who is worthy to open the book and to break its seals?"
3 But no one was able to open the book or to look into it.
No one in heaven above could do it,
no one on the earth,
and no one under the earth.
4 I cried and cried,
because no one was found who was worthy to open the book or to look into it.
5 Then one of the elders said to me,
"Don't cry.
Look! The Lion from the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has won the victory.
He is the one who opens the book and its seven seals."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: At that time the "book" was a scroll. The seals were made of wax. Only when all seven seals are broken can you read the whole scroll. The scroll probably contains God's plan for the world.

Verse 4: John cries because it looks as if God's plan can't go on. That is a very human reaction.

Verse 5: "The Lion from the tribe of Judah" and "the Root of David" recall Jacob's blessing for Judah (Genesis 49:9) and Isaiah 11:1–10. Both are pictures for the Messiah from the Jewish people. Jesus came from the tribe of Judah and from the family of David.

The Lamb VERSES 6–10

6 Then I saw a Lamb standing in the middle of the throne and of the four living creatures,
and in the middle of the elders.
The Lamb looked as if it had been killed.
It had seven horns and seven eyes.
These are the seven Spirits of God.
They are sent out into all the earth.
7 The Lamb came.
He took the book out of the right hand of the one who sat on the throne.
8 When he had taken the book,
the four living creatures and the 24 elders bowed down before the Lamb.
Each of them had a harp.
And they had golden bowls full of incense.
The incense is the prayers of the saints.
The saints are the people who belong to God.
9 They sang a new song:
"You are worthy to take the book and to open its seals.
For you were killed.
With your blood you bought us for God.
You bought us from every tribe, language, people, and nation.
10 You made us kings and priests for our God.
And we will rule on the earth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 5–6 are a great surprise: John hears "Lion." But when he looks, he sees a Lamb that had been killed. God doesn't win with violence like a beast of prey, but through Jesus giving himself on the cross. That is the most important message of the whole Revelation.

The Lamb recalls the Passover lamb at the exodus from Egypt (Exodus 12) and the suffering servant of God, who was like a lamb (Isaiah 53:7).

"Seven horns and seven eyes": Horns are a picture for strength, eyes for knowledge. Seven means: perfect.

Verse 8: People's prayers reach God. They are precious like incense in golden bowls.

Verse 9: God's people come from all peoples, languages and cultures. No one is shut out.

Verse 10: Some manuscripts have "we rule" instead of "we will rule."

The whole creation praises God and the Lamb VERSES 11–14

11 I looked, and I heard something like the voice of many angels.
They were around the throne, the living creatures, and the elders.
There were tens of thousands times tens of thousands of them,
and thousands times thousands.
12 They said with a loud voice,
"The Lamb who was killed is worthy!
He is worthy to receive the power, wealth, wisdom, strength, honor, glory, and blessing!"

13 I heard every created thing in heaven, on the earth,
under the earth, and on the sea.
I heard everything in them.
They said,
"To the one who sits on the throne and to the Lamb
be the blessing, the honor, the glory, and the power to
rule, forever and ever!
Amen!"
14 The four living creatures said, "Amen!"
Then the elders bowed down and worshiped.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: The number is unimaginably large. It means: more than anyone can count.

Verse 12: Seven things are given to the Lamb: power, wealth, wisdom, strength, honor, glory and blessing. Seven again means: perfect.

Verse 13: At the end the whole creation joins in. God and the Lamb are praised together. That shows: Jesus belongs completely on God's side.

Many songs and pieces of music have taken up these words. They are still sung in worship today.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 6

The first six seals

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

From now on there are many pictures of war, hunger, disasters and death. That can make people afraid.

These pictures are not a timetable for when and how the world will end. They describe what people experience in all times: war, hunger, plagues and persecution. The Revelation says: Even in all of this, God is in control. The Lamb opens the seals, not chance and not evil.

Whoever becomes very afraid because of these pictures can talk about it. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

The four riders VERSES 1–8

1 I saw the Lamb open one of the seven seals.
And I heard one of the four living creatures speak with
a voice like thunder.
It said, "Come and see!"
2 Then a white horse appeared.
The one who sat on it had a bow.
He was given a crown.
He rode out as a conqueror, to conquer.
3 When the Lamb opened the second seal,
I heard the second living creature say, "Come!"
4 Another horse came out. It was red.
The one who sat on it was given power to take peace
away from the earth,
so that people would kill one another.
He was given a great sword.
5 When the Lamb opened the third seal,
I heard the third living creature say, "Come and see!"
I looked, and there was a black horse.
The one who sat on it had a balance in his hand.
A balance is a scale for weighing.
6 I heard a voice in the middle of the four living
creatures.
It said,
"About a quart of wheat for a denarius,
and about three quarts of barley for a denarius!
Don't harm the oil and the wine!"
7 When the Lamb opened the fourth seal,
I heard the fourth living creature say, "Come and see!"
8 I looked, and there was a pale horse.
The name of the one who sat on it was Death.
Hades followed with him.
He was given authority over one fourth of the earth.
He could kill with the sword, with famine, with death,
and by the wild animals of the earth.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The four riders recall the colored horses in the prophet Zechariah (Zechariah 1 and 6).

Verse 2: The white rider with a bow perhaps recalls the Parthians, a people of horsemen that the Romans were afraid of. He stands for conquest and greed for power.

Verse 4: The red rider stands for war and violence.

Verses 5–6: The black rider stands for hunger and high prices. A denarius was the wage for one day of work. The old measure here is a choenix. A choenix is about a quart. A choenix of wheat was just enough for one person for one day. Nothing was left for a family. But oil and wine, the things of the rich, are spared. That shows injustice.

Verse 8: The pale rider is called Death. "Pale" is the greenish, pale color of sick and dead people. The word "death" appears twice in verse 8. The second time probably means plague, as in Ezekiel 14:21.

Important: The power of the riders is limited. It is only "given" to them. And it is only "one fourth," not everything.

The martyrs under the altar VERSES 9–11

9 When the Lamb opened the fifth seal,
I saw souls under the altar.
They were the souls of people who had been killed
because of the Word of God.
They had been killed because of the testimony of the
Lamb that they held on to.
A testimony is what a witness says.
10 They cried out with a loud voice,
"Master, you are holy and true.
How long will it be until you judge?
How long until you punish those who live on the earth
for spilling our blood?"
11 Each of them was given a long white robe.
They were told to rest a little while longer.
They had to wait until their fellow servants and their
brothers had finished their course.
These would also be killed, just as they had been.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: These people were killed because they believed in Jesus. They are called martyrs. Today, too, people in many countries are persecuted because of their faith.

Verse 10: "How long?": Many psalms ask this question too (for example Psalm 13). It is the cry for justice. You may bring your complaint to God.

"Punish" here means: God is to bring justice. The martyrs don't take revenge themselves. They leave it to God.

Verse 11: God hears their complaint. He gives them white robes, a sign of honor and victory. He asks for patience.

The sixth seal: The world is shaken VERSES 12–17

12 I saw the Lamb open the sixth seal.
There was a great earthquake.
The sun became as black as sackcloth made of hair.
Sackcloth is a rough, dark cloth.
The whole moon became like blood.
13 The stars of the sky fell to the earth.
They fell like unripe figs from a fig tree when a strong wind shakes it.
14 The sky was taken away like a scroll that is rolled up.
Every mountain and island was moved from its place.
15 The kings of the earth hid themselves in the caves and among the rocks of the mountains.
The princes, the commanding officers, the rich, and the strong hid themselves.
Every slave and every free person hid.
16 They said to the mountains and the rocks,
"Fall on us!
Hide us from the face of the one who sits on the throne.
Hide us from the anger of the Lamb.
17 For the great day of his anger has come.
Who is able to stand?"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 12–14: These pictures come from the prophets (for example Isaiah 34:4 and Joel 2:31, in some Bibles Joel 3:4). They say: When God comes, everything that seemed firm is shaken. They are pictures, not a scientific description.

Verse 15: All the powerful people of the world have no more power before God. Before God all are equal, kings and slaves.

Verse 16 recalls Hosea 10:8.

"The anger of the Lamb" is a surprising picture. God's anger is not a fit of rage. It is God's No to injustice and violence.

Verse 17: "Who is able to stand?" The next chapter gives the answer: God's people are kept safe.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 7

God keeps his people safe

The servants of God receive a seal VERSES 1–8

1 After this, I saw four angels.
They were standing at the four corners of the earth.
They were holding back the four winds of the earth, so that no wind would blow on the earth, or on the sea, or on any tree.
2 I saw another angel come up from where the sun rises.
He had the seal of the living God.
The four angels had been given power to harm the earth and the sea.
He called out to them with a loud voice.
3 He said,
"Don't harm the earth, the sea, or the trees until we have put a seal on the foreheads of the servants of our God!"
4 I heard the number of those who were sealed.
It was 144,000.
They were sealed out of every tribe of the people of Israel:
5 From the tribe of Judah 12,000 were sealed.
From the tribe of Reuben 12,000.
From the tribe of Gad 12,000.
6 From the tribe of Asher 12,000.
From the tribe of Naphtali 12,000.
From the tribe of Manasseh 12,000.
7 From the tribe of Simeon 12,000.
From the tribe of Levi 12,000.
From the tribe of Issachar 12,000.
8 From the tribe of Zebulun 12,000.
From the tribe of Joseph 12,000.
And from the tribe of Benjamin 12,000 were sealed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–3: Before the hard things come, God takes care of his own. A seal shows: This belongs to me, this is protected. This recalls Ezekiel 9:4, where the faithful receive a mark on their foreheads.

Verse 4: 144,000 is 12 times 12 times 1,000. It is a number full of meaning: the 12 tribes of Israel, complete and very large. It probably means: God's whole people, no one is missing.

Verses 5–8: Judah comes first, because the Messiah comes from Judah. The tribe of Dan is missing from this list; Manasseh is there instead. We don't know for sure why.

Christians understand this passage in different ways: Some think it means the Jewish people. Others think it means the whole people of God, Jews and non-Jews. What is important: God doesn't forget Israel.

Some groups teach that only exactly 144,000 people will go to heaven. That is not what it says here. Right after this (verse 9), John sees a crowd that no one can count.

A huge multitude from all peoples VERSES 9–12

9 After these things I looked.
I saw a great crowd.
No one could count them.
They came from every nation and from all tribes, peoples, and languages.
They were standing before the throne and before the Lamb.

They were dressed in white robes.
They had palm branches in their hands.
10 They called out with a loud voice,
"Salvation comes from our God, who sits on the throne, and from the Lamb!"
11 All the angels were standing around the throne, the elders, and the four living creatures.
They fell on their faces before his throne and worshiped God.
12 They said,
"Amen!
Blessing, glory, wisdom, thanks, honor, power, and strength
belong to our God forever and ever!
Amen."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 9: John hears a number (144,000), but he sees a crowd that no one can count. This recalls Chapter 5: There he hears "Lion" and sees a Lamb. God's people are much larger than people think.

The people come from all peoples and languages. With God there are no borders of origin, skin color or language.

Palm branches are a sign of victory and joy. They recall the Jewish Feast of Booths and Jesus' entry into Jerusalem (John 12:13).

Verse 10: Salvation comes from God. No one saves himself.

Who are these people? VERSES 13–17

13 Then one of the elders spoke to me.
He asked,
"These people dressed in white robes, who are they?
And where did they come from?"
14 I said to him, "My lord, you know."
He said to me,
"These are the people who came out of the great suffering.
They washed their robes and made them white in the Lamb's blood.
15 That is why they are before the throne of God.
They serve him day and night in his temple.
The one who sits on the throne will spread his tent over them.
16 They will never be hungry or thirsty again.
The sun will not beat down on them.
No heat will burn them.
17 For the Lamb in the middle of the throne is their shepherd.
He leads them to springs of water that give life.
And God will wipe away every tear from their eyes."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: "Made them white in the Lamb's blood" is a surprising picture. Blood doesn't really make things white. What is meant: Through the death of Jesus, people become clean and free from guilt.

Verse 15: "Spread his tent" recalls the holy tent in the wilderness. God lives among his people and protects them.

Verses 16–17 recall Isaiah 49:10 and Isaiah 25:8.

Verse 17: The Lamb is at the same time the shepherd. And God himself wipes away every tear. That is one of the most beautiful sentences of comfort in the Bible. It comes once more at the end of the book (21:4).

Whoever is grieving may know: God sees every tear.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 8

The seventh seal and the first four trumpets

Silence in heaven and the prayers VERSES 1–5

1 When the Lamb opened the seventh seal,
heaven was silent for about half an hour.
2 I saw the seven angels who stand before God.
They were given seven trumpets.
3 Another angel came and stood over the altar.
He had a golden censer.
A censer is a bowl for burning incense.
He was given a lot of incense.
He was to add it to the prayers of all the saints on the golden altar before the throne.
4 The smoke of the incense went up before God out of the angel's hand,
together with the prayers of the saints.
5 The angel took the censer.
He filled it with fire from the altar.
Then he threw it down on the earth.
Thunder, loud sounds, lightning, and an earthquake followed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: After all the noise it suddenly becomes completely still. All of heaven holds its breath. Perhaps it is also the silence so that God can hear the prayers.

Verses 3–4: People's prayers reach God. They rise up to him like incense (compare Psalm 141:2).

Verse 5: The prayers have an effect. God answers people's cry for justice (compare 6:10).

The first four trumpets VERSES 6–12

6 The seven angels who had the seven trumpets got ready to blow them.
7 The first angel blew his trumpet.
Then hail and fire came, mixed with blood.
They were thrown down on the earth.
One third of the earth burned up.
One third of the trees burned up.
And all the green grass burned up.
8 The second angel blew his trumpet.
Then something like a great burning mountain was thrown into the sea.
One third of the sea became blood.

9 One third of the living creatures in the sea died.
One third of the ships were destroyed.
10 The third angel blew his trumpet.
Then a great star fell from the sky.
It was burning like a torch.
It fell on one third of the rivers and on the springs of water.
11 The name of the star is "Wormwood."
One third of the waters became wormwood.
Many people died from the waters, because the waters had become bitter.
12 The fourth angel blew his trumpet.
Then one third of the sun was struck,
and one third of the moon, and one third of the stars.
So one third of them became dark.
For one third of the day there was no light,
and the same happened to the night.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

At that time trumpets were signal horns. They announced something important: a war, a feast or the coming of a king.

The plagues recall the plagues in Egypt (Exodus 7–10): hail, water turning into blood, darkness. Back then, God wanted to free his people. So it is here, too: God frees his people from everything that oppresses them.

"One third": Not everything is destroyed. The plagues are warnings. God still gives people time to repent (compare 9:20–21).

Verse 11: Wormwood is a very bitter plant. In the Bible it is a picture for bitterness and suffering (for example Jeremiah 9:15, in some Bibles 9:14).

These pictures are not a prediction of particular disasters today. Some people have equated them with disasters in our time. That is speculation and only makes people afraid.

An eagle warns VERSE 13

13 I looked, and I heard an eagle flying high in the sky.
It called out with a loud voice,
"How terrible! How terrible! How terrible it will be for those who live on the earth!
For the other three angels are still going to blow their trumpets!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The eagle announces: Even harder things are coming. The three cries of "How terrible!" stand for the three last trumpets.

Some manuscripts have "angel" instead of "eagle."

In the Revelation, "those who live on the earth" often means the people who set themselves against God.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 9

The fifth and the sixth trumpet

The fifth trumpet: Locusts from the abyss VERSES 1–12

1 The fifth angel blew his trumpet.
Then I saw a star that had fallen from the sky to the earth.
He was given the key to the pit of the abyss.
The abyss is a deep pit with no bottom.
2 He opened the pit of the abyss.
Smoke went up out of the pit, like the smoke from a burning furnace.
The sun and the air became dark because of the smoke from the pit.
3 Then locusts came out of the smoke onto the earth.
They were given power like the power of scorpions on the earth.
4 They were told not to hurt the grass of the earth,
or any green plant, or any tree.
They were only to hurt the people who don't have God's seal on their foreheads.
5 They were not given power to kill these people.
They were only allowed to torment them for five months.
The pain was like the pain from a scorpion when it stings a person.
6 In those days people will look for death,
but they will not find it at all.
They will long to die,
but death will run away from them.
7 The locusts looked like horses that are ready for battle.
On their heads they had something like golden crowns.
Their faces were like human faces.
8 They had hair like women's hair.
Their teeth were like lions' teeth.
9 They had breastplates like breastplates of iron.
The sound of their wings was like the sound of many chariots and horses rushing into battle.
10 They have tails with stingers, like scorpions.
In their tails they have power to harm people for five months.
11 They have a king over them.
He is the angel of the abyss.
His name in Hebrew is "Abaddon."
In Greek his name is "Apollyon."
12 The first disaster is over.
Look, two more disasters are still coming after this.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The locusts recall the eighth plague in Egypt (Exodus 10) and the prophet Joel (Joel 1–2). There, locusts fall upon the land like an army.

The description is deliberately frightening and unreal: half animal, half human, half war machine. That is what evil looks like when it is let loose.

Verse 4: Whoever belongs to God has the seal (Chapter 7). These powers can't harm him.

Verses 5 and 10: "Five months" is a limited time. Evil has a limit.

Verse 11: "Abaddon" and "Apollyon" both mean: destruction, destroyer. The destroyer is the king of these powers. God is not.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verse 6 speaks of people who wish to die. Today, too, there are people who are so desperate that they don't want to live any more. If you feel that way: You are not alone, and there is help. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

The sixth trumpet: A huge army of horsemen
VERSES 13–19

13 The sixth angel blew his trumpet.
Then I heard a voice.
It came from the horns of the golden altar that is before God.
14 It said to the sixth angel, who had the trumpet,
"Set free the four angels who are tied up at the great river Euphrates!"
15 So the four angels were set free.
They had been made ready for that hour, that day, that month, and that year.
They were to kill one third of all people.
16 The armies of the horsemen numbered 200 million.
I heard their number.
17 In the vision I saw the horses and their riders like this:
The riders had breastplates that were fiery red, dark blue, and sulfur yellow.
The heads of the horses looked like lions' heads.
Fire, smoke, and sulfur came out of their mouths.
Sulfur is a yellow substance that burns with a bad smell.
18 One third of all people were killed by these three plagues:
by the fire, the smoke, and the sulfur that came out of the horses' mouths.
19 For the power of the horses is in their mouths and in their tails.
Their tails are like snakes.
They have heads, and with them they do harm.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: The Euphrates was the eastern border of the Roman Empire. People feared attacks from enemy peoples of horsemen from there. For the people at that time, this was a picture of the worst danger of war.

Verse 16: 200 million is an unimaginably large number. It means: an army that no one can count. It is a picture, not an exact number.

These pictures show how terrible war is. Violence destroys life.

The people don't repent VERSES 20–21

20 The rest of the people were not killed by these plagues.
But they still did not repent and turn away from the things their hands had made.
They did not stop worshiping demons and idols.
The idols were made of gold, silver, brass, stone, and wood.
They cannot see, hear, or walk.
21 They did not repent of their murders, their magic, their sexual sins, or their stealing.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here it becomes clear what the plagues are for: They are meant to call people to repent. God doesn't want to destroy, but wants people to turn back.

Verse 20 recalls Psalm 115:4–7: Idols have eyes, but don't see. Idols are everything that people live for and worship instead of God.

What is sad: The people still don't repent. Suffering alone doesn't make people better. But God doesn't give up. In the next chapters he keeps calling.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 10

The angel with the little scroll

A mighty angel and seven thunders VERSES 1–7

1 I saw a mighty angel coming down out of the sky.
He was dressed in a cloud.
A rainbow was over his head.
His face was like the sun.
His feet were like pillars of fire.
2 In his hand he had a little book that was open.
He put his right foot on the sea and his left foot on the land.
3 He shouted with a loud voice, like a lion roars.
When he shouted, the seven thunders spoke with their voices.
4 When the seven thunders had spoken, I was about to write.
But I heard a voice from the sky.
It said,
"Keep secret what the seven thunders said.
Don't write it down."
5 The angel I saw standing on the sea and on the land lifted his right hand up to the sky.
6 He made a solemn promise.
He swore by the one who lives forever and ever.
He is the one who created heaven and everything in it,
the earth and everything in it,
and the sea and everything in it.
The angel swore: "There will be no more waiting.
7 The seventh angel will soon blow his trumpet.
In the days when his voice is heard,
God's secret plan will be completed.
It will happen just as God announced it to his servants, the prophets."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: The angel stands on the sea and on the land. That means: His message is for the whole world.

Verse 4: John may not write everything down. There are things that only God knows. We don't have to know everything about the future, and we can't.

Verses 6–7: "There will be no more waiting": For the persecuted Christians who asked "How long?" (6:10), this is an answer. God will finish his work.
"God's secret plan" is his plan to save the world and to make everything good. The prophets already announced it.

John eats the little scroll VERSES 8–11

8 The voice I had heard from heaven spoke with me again.
It said,
"Go and take the book that is open in the hand of the angel.
He is the one who stands on the sea and on the land."
9 So I went to the angel.
I told him to give me the little book.
He said to me,
"Take it and eat it.
It will make your stomach bitter.
But in your mouth it will be as sweet as honey."
10 I took the little book out of the angel's hand and ate it.
In my mouth it was as sweet as honey.
But when I had eaten it, my stomach became bitter.
11 Then they told me,
"You must prophesy again about many peoples, nations, languages, and kings."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

This recalls the prophet Ezekiel. He too had to eat a scroll, and it was as sweet as honey (Ezekiel 2:8–3:3).
"Eating the book" means: taking God's word completely into yourself before you pass it on.
Sweet and bitter at the same time: God's word is beautiful and good. But it can also be hard to pass it on, especially when it is about suffering and judgment.
Verse 11: John receives a new task. His message is for all peoples.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 11

The two witnesses and the seventh trumpet

The temple is measured VERSES 1–2

1 I was given a reed like a measuring stick.
Someone said,
"Get up and measure God's temple and the altar.
And measure the people who worship there.
2 But leave out the courtyard outside the temple.
Don't measure it,
because it has been given to the nations.
They will trample the holy city for 42 months.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: Measuring here means: God knows and protects what belongs to him. This recalls Ezekiel 40–42 and Zechariah 2, where the temple and Jerusalem are measured.
Verse 2: "42 months" are three and a half years. This period of time comes from the book of Daniel (Daniel 7:25 and 12:7). It is a picture for a limited time of distress. It comes up several times in the Revelation: as 42 months, as 1,260 days, or as "a time, times, and half a time."
Many understand the temple here as a picture for the church of God: It is oppressed, but kept safe at its very heart.

The two witnesses VERSES 3–6

3 I will give power to my two witnesses.
They will be dressed in sackcloth,
and they will prophesy for 1,260 days."
4 These two witnesses are the two olive trees and the two lampstands.
They stand before the Lord of the earth.
5 If anyone wants to harm them,
fire comes out of their mouth and burns up their enemies.
Anyone who wants to harm them must be killed in this way.
6 They have the power to shut the sky,
so that no rain falls during the days when they prophesy.
They have power over the waters, to turn them into blood.
And they have power to strike the earth with every kind of plague,
as often as they want.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 3: Sackcloth was a rough garment. People wore it when they were grieving or repenting.
Verse 4: The two olive trees recall Zechariah 4.
Verse 6: The two witnesses recall Elijah, who made the rain stop (1 Kings 17), and Moses, who turned the water into blood (Exodus 7).
It is not certain who the two witnesses are. Many think: They stand for the whole church that bravely tells about God, as Moses and Elijah did.
Verse 5: "Fire comes out of their mouth" is a picture for the power of their words, as in Jeremiah 5:14. It is not permission for violence.

The witnesses are killed and raised VERSES 7–14

7 When they have finished their testimony,
the beast that comes up out of the abyss will make war against them.
It will defeat them and kill them.
8 Their dead bodies will lie in the street of the great city.
In a spiritual sense this city is called Sodom and Egypt.
Their Lord was also crucified there.
9 People from the peoples, tribes, languages, and nations will look at their dead bodies for three and a half days.
They will not allow anyone to bury the bodies in a tomb.
10 Those who live on the earth will be happy about their death and celebrate.

They will send gifts to one another,
because these two prophets tormented those who live on the earth.
11 After the three and a half days, the breath of life from God entered them.
They stood up on their feet.
Great fear came over the people who saw them.
12 I heard a loud voice from heaven say to them, "Come up here!"
They went up into heaven in a cloud,
and their enemies watched them.
13 At that time there was a great earthquake.
A tenth of the city fell.
7,000 people were killed in the earthquake.
The rest were terrified, and they gave glory to the God of heaven.
14 The second disaster is over.
Look, the third disaster is coming soon.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: The "beast" is a picture for an evil, violent power. In Chapter 13 it is described more closely.

Verse 8: "Sodom and Egypt" are names in a spiritual sense. They stand for wickedness and oppression. What is meant is every city and every power that sets itself against God and kills innocent people.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verse 8 says: "Their Lord was also crucified there." That is not an accusation against Jerusalem or against the Jewish people. Jesus was crucified by the Romans. The "great city" is a picture for the world that sets itself against God, everywhere and at every time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: "The breath of life" recalls Ezekiel 37: God makes dead bones alive again. The witnesses are raised like Jesus.

Verse 13: Here there is something new: The people give glory to God. Only a tenth of the city falls; most people stay alive and turn to God. The brave testimony has had an effect.

The seventh trumpet: God reigns VERSES 15–19

15 The seventh angel blew his trumpet.
Then loud voices in heaven said,
"The kingdom of the world has become the Kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ.
He will rule forever and ever!"
16 The 24 elders sit on their thrones before God's throne.
They fell on their faces and worshiped God.
17 They said,
"We thank you, Lord God, the Almighty,
the one who is and who was.
For you have taken your great power and begun to rule.
18 The nations were angry.
But now your anger has come.
The time has come for the dead to be judged.
It is time to give the reward to your servants, the prophets,
and to the saints and those who fear your name,
to the small and the great.
And it is time to destroy those who destroy the earth."
19 Then God's temple in heaven was opened.
The ark of the Lord's covenant could be seen in his temple.
Lightning, loud sounds, thunder, an earthquake, and great hail followed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 15: This is the high point: God rules. In the end all the power of the world belongs to God and his Christ. These words have become well known through famous music.

Verse 17: God is now only called "the one who is and who was." The "who is to come" is missing, because now he has come.

Verse 18: God gives the reward "to the small and the great." Before God every person counts, no matter how important he was in the world.

"To destroy those who destroy the earth": God does care when people destroy his creation. This sentence is important today, too.

Verse 19: The ark of the covenant was the holiest sign of God's presence in Israel. It had been lost since the destruction of the first temple. Here it is shown: God's covenant stands; it is not lost.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 12

The woman and the dragon

The woman, the child and the dragon VERSES 1–6

1 A great sign appeared in heaven:
a woman dressed with the sun.
The moon was under her feet.
On her head was a crown of 12 stars.
2 She was pregnant.
She cried out in pain, because she was in labor and about to give birth.
3 Another sign appeared in heaven.
Look! There was a great red dragon.
He had 7 heads and 10 horns.
On his heads were 7 crowns.
4 His tail swept away one third of the stars of the sky and threw them down to the earth.
The dragon stood in front of the woman who was about to give birth.
He wanted to eat up her child as soon as it was born.
5 She gave birth to a son, a boy.
He will rule all the nations with a rod of iron.
Her child was caught up to God and to his throne.
6 The woman fled into the wilderness.
God has prepared a place for her there.

There they will feed her and take care of her for 1,260 days.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here a new part begins. John now shows what is behind everything: the battle between God and evil.

Verse 1: The woman with 12 stars recalls the people of Israel with its 12 tribes (compare Joseph's dream, Genesis 37:9). The Messiah comes from Israel.

Christians understand the woman in different ways: as a picture for Israel, for the church or for Mary, the mother of Jesus. Especially in the Catholic and Orthodox churches, the woman is often connected with Mary. All these interpretations have something to them.

Verse 3: The dragon is the devil (verse 9). The 7 heads and 10 horns show his great power. Red is the color of blood and violence.

Verse 5: The child is Jesus, the Messiah (compare Psalm 2:9). "Caught up" means his resurrection and ascension into heaven. The dragon can't harm him.

Verse 6: In the Bible, the wilderness is a place where God protects and provides for his people, as for Israel after the exodus from Egypt.

War in heaven VERSES 7–12

7 There was war in the sky.
Michael and his angels fought against the dragon.
The dragon and his angels fought back.
8 But they did not win.
There was no longer any place for them in heaven.
9 The great dragon was thrown down.
He is the old serpent, who is called the devil and Satan.
He leads the whole world astray.
He was thrown down to the earth,
and his angels were thrown down with him.
10 I heard a loud voice in heaven say,
"Now the salvation, the power, and the Kingdom of our God have come,
and the authority of his Christ.
For the accuser of our brothers has been thrown down.
He accused them before our God day and night.
11 They defeated him because of the Lamb's blood
and because of the word of their testimony.
They did not love their own life so much that they were afraid to die.
12 So be glad, you heavens, and you who live in them!
But how terrible it will be for the earth and for the sea!
For the devil has come down to you.
He is very angry,
because he knows that he has only a short time."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: Michael is an archangel. He also appears in the book of Daniel as the protector of the people of Israel (Daniel 12:1).

Verse 9: "The old serpent" recalls the serpent in the Garden of Eden (Genesis 3). Here the devil is also called the one who leads the whole world astray.

Verse 10: "Satan" means in Hebrew: accuser. He accuses people. But he has nothing more to say before God. Whoever belongs to Jesus is no longer condemned.

Verse 11: The victory doesn't come through weapons, but through the Lamb and through the brave testimony of those who believe.

Verse 12: An important comfort: The devil is already defeated. He rages because he knows that his time will soon be over.

The dragon persecutes the woman VERSES 13–17

13 The dragon saw that he had been thrown down to the earth.
So he hunted down the woman who had given birth to the boy.
14 But the woman was given the two wings of the great eagle.
So she could fly into the wilderness to her place.
There she is fed and taken care of for a time, times, and half a time,
far away from the serpent.
15 The serpent spat water out of his mouth after the woman, like a river.
He wanted the flood to sweep her away.
16 But the earth helped the woman.
The earth opened its mouth
and swallowed the river that the dragon had spat out of his mouth.
17 Then the dragon became angry with the woman.
He went away to make war against the rest of her children.
They keep God's commandments and hold on to Jesus' testimony.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: "A time, times, and half a time" are three and a half years, like the 1,260 days in verse 6. It is a limited time. The "wings of the great eagle" recall Exodus 19:4: God carried Israel as on eagles' wings.

Verse 16: Even the creation helps the people of God.

Verse 17: "The rest of her children" are all who believe in Jesus. The dragon attacks them. That is why life as a Christian is sometimes hard. But God protects his people.

In many manuscripts and Bibles there is one more sentence here about the dragon: He stood on the sand of the sea. Sometimes that is verse 18. Other manuscripts have the sentence with "I." That is how the WEB, our English source text, has it. There the sentence stands at the beginning of Chapter 13: "Then I stood on the sand of the sea" (13:1).

REVELATION

CHAPTER 13

The two beasts

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

This chapter is about two "beasts" and about the number 666. There are very many wild guesses about this chapter.

Again and again people have claimed that the beast is a certain politician, a church, a people, a technology, a barcode, a chip or a vaccine. All these claims have made people afraid, and they were wrong.

Many conspiracy myths use this chapter. Some of them are directed against Jews. That is dangerous and wrong.

For the first readers it was clear: The beast is a picture for the Roman Empire and for the emperor who had himself worshiped like a god. But the message is also true today: Christians are not to worship any power that puts itself in the place of God.

The beast from the sea VERSES 1–10

1 Then I stood on the sand of the sea.
I saw a beast coming up out of the sea.
It had 10 horns and 7 heads.
On its horns were 10 crowns.
On its heads were names that insulted God.
2 The beast I saw looked like a leopard.
Its feet were like a bear's feet.
Its mouth was like a lion's mouth.
The dragon gave the beast his power, his throne, and great authority.
3 One of its heads looked as if it had received a deadly wound.
But the deadly wound was healed.
The whole earth was amazed at the beast.
4 People worshiped the dragon, because he had given his authority to the beast.
And they worshiped the beast.
They said,
"Who is like the beast?
Who is able to fight against him?"
5 The beast was given a mouth that spoke proud words and insults against God.
It was given authority to make war for 42 months.
6 It opened its mouth to insult God.
It insulted his name and his dwelling place,
and those who live in heaven.
7 It was allowed to make war against the saints and to defeat them.
It was given authority over every tribe, people, language, and nation.
8 All who live on the earth will worship the beast.
These are all the people whose names have not been written in the book of life of the Lamb who was killed.
Their names have not been written there since the creation of the world.
9 Whoever has ears should listen.
10 If anyone is to be taken away as a prisoner, he will be taken away as a prisoner.
If anyone is to be killed with the sword, he must be killed.
This is where the saints need to endure and keep their faith.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 1–2: The beast recalls the four beasts in the book of Daniel (Daniel 7). There the beasts stand for cruel world empires. Here all the beasts are united in one. For the first readers this was Rome. For them, Rome came "over the sea."

Verse 2: The dragon, that is, the devil, gives the beast its power. When a power oppresses people and has itself worshiped, evil is behind it.

Verse 3: The healed wound: Perhaps a hint at Emperor Nero. After his death people told each other that he would come back. The beast imitates the Lamb: The Lamb was really dead and lives (5:6). The beast only pretends.

Verse 4: "Who is like the beast?" is an evil imitation of the praise for God: "Who is like you, LORD" (compare Exodus 15:11).

Verse 5: The power of the beast is limited: only 42 months. And it is only "given" to it. God stays in control.

Verse 10 recalls Jeremiah 15:2. Christians are not to strike back with violence. They are to stand firm. Some manuscripts say: Whoever kills with the sword must be killed with the sword.

The beast from the earth VERSES 11–18

11 I saw another beast coming up out of the earth.
It had two horns like a lamb,
but it spoke like a dragon.
12 It uses all the authority of the first beast in its presence.
It makes the earth and the people who live on it worship the first beast,
the one whose deadly wound was healed.
13 It does great signs.
It even makes fire come down from the sky to the earth while people watch.
14 It deceives my own people who live on the earth.
It does this with the signs it was allowed to do in front of the beast.
It tells the people who live on the earth to make an image of the beast.
That is the beast that was wounded by the sword and yet lived.
15 It was allowed to give breath to the image of the beast.
So the image of the beast could even speak.
And it could have everyone killed who would not worship the image of the beast.
16 It forces everyone to receive a mark on their right hand or on their forehead:
the small and the great,
the rich and the poor,
the free and the slave.
17 No one can buy or sell unless he has the mark.
The mark is the name of the beast or the number of its name.
18 This calls for wisdom.
Whoever has understanding should figure out the number of the beast.
For it is the number of a man.
Its number is *666*.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 11: The second beast looks harmless like a lamb, but it speaks like the dragon. It is a picture for false prophets and for propaganda. Later it is called "the false prophet" (16:13).

At that time there were priests and officials in the cities who made sure that everyone worshiped the emperor. Whoever didn't take part got into trouble.

Verse 14: The WEB, our English source text, has "my own people." Most manuscripts have only: It deceives those who live on the earth.

Verses 16–17: The "mark" shows whom you belong to. It is the evil imitation of God's seal on the forehead (7:3). Whoever wanted to be part of the guilds and the market often had to take part in emperor worship. Whoever refused lost his work.

Verse 18: In Greek and Hebrew, letters also had number values. Many scholars think: If you write "Emperor Nero" in Hebrew letters, it adds up to 666. Some manuscripts have 616. That also fits another way of spelling Nero.

The number six is one less than seven, the number of perfection. 666 then means: The beast wants to be like God, but it stays imperfect and fails.

REVELATION

Chapter 14

The Lamb on Mount Zion and the harvest

The Lamb and the 144,000 VERSES 1–5

1 I looked, and there was the Lamb standing on Mount Zion.
With him were 144,000 people.
His name and the name of his Father were written on their foreheads.
2 I heard a sound from heaven.
It was like the sound of many waters and like the sound of loud thunder.
The sound I heard was like harpists playing their harps.
3 They sing a new song before the throne,
before the four living creatures, and before the elders.
No one could learn the song except the 144,000.
They had been redeemed from the earth.
Redeemed means: bought free.
4 These are the people who have not made themselves unclean with women,
for they are virgins.
They follow the Lamb wherever he goes.
Jesus redeemed them from among the people.
They are the first fruits for God and for the Lamb.
5 No lie was found in their mouths.
They are without fault.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: After the evil beasts in Chapter 13 comes a contrasting picture: the Lamb on Mount Zion in Jerusalem. The people there don't bear the mark of the beast, but the name of God.

The 144,000 are probably the same as in Chapter 7: God's whole people.

Verse 3: The "new song" is the song of the redeemed.

Verse 4: "First fruits": The first fruits of the harvest belonged to God. In the same way these people belong completely to God.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verse 4 is a difficult verse. It does **not** mean that women are unclean or that sexuality is dirty. God created man and woman and blessed their love (Genesis 1 and 2).

In the Bible, worshiping idols is often called "sexual immorality" or "adultery," for example in the prophets Hosea and Jeremiah. "Virgins" is a picture here: These people have stayed faithful to God. They have not gotten involved with the beast and its idol worship.

Perhaps the verse also hints at the rules for soldiers in holy war (Deuteronomy 23:10–11). God's people here are like an army that follows the Lamb.

Three angels with messages VERSES 6–13

6 I saw an angel flying high in the sky.
He had Good News that lasts forever.
He was to announce it to those who live on the earth:
to every nation, tribe, language, and people.
7 He said with a loud voice,
"Fear the Lord and give him glory,
for the hour of his judgment has come.
Worship the one who made heaven, the earth, the sea, and the springs of water!"
8 Another angel, a second one, followed him.
He said,
"Babylon the great has fallen!
She made all the nations drink the wine of the anger of her sexual immorality."
9 Another angel, a third one, followed them.
He said with a loud voice,
"If anyone worships the beast and his image,
and receives a mark on his forehead or on his hand,
10 he too will drink the wine of God's anger.
It is poured out at full strength into the cup of his anger.
He will be tormented with fire and sulfur
in front of the holy angels and in front of the Lamb.
11 The smoke of their torment goes up forever and ever.
Those who worship the beast and his image have no rest, day or night.
The same is true for anyone who receives the mark of his name.
12 This is where the saints need to endure.
They keep the commandments of God and the faith of Jesus."
13 I heard a voice from heaven say,
"Write this:
'Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord from now on.'"
"Yes," says the Spirit,
"they will rest from their hard work,
for their works go with them."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 6–7: Before the judgment comes, the Good News is proclaimed to all peoples once more. God calls all people. He wants all to repent.

Verse 8: "Babylon" was the great power that had destroyed Jerusalem. In the Revelation, Babylon is a code name for Rome, for every power that leads people astray and oppresses them. More about this in Chapters 17 and 18.

Verses 9–11 are a very serious warning. It was meant to give the Christians at that time courage not to take part in emperor worship, even when it was dangerous.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verses 10–11 use very harsh pictures. They are meant to show: It is serious to whom you give your life. These pictures are not meant to make anyone who is seeking God afraid of God. God is love (1 John 4:8), and he wants all to be saved (2 Peter 3:9).

Whoever is afraid of being lost because of verses like these can talk with someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13 is a great comfort that is often read at funerals: Whoever dies trusting in Jesus may rest. Nothing good that a person has done is lost.

The harvest of the earth VERSES 14–20

14 I looked, and I saw a white cloud.
On the cloud sat one like a son of man.
He had a golden crown on his head and a sharp sickle in his hand.
A sickle is a curved knife for harvesting.
15 Another angel came out of the temple.
He called out with a loud voice to the one who sat on the cloud,
"Swing your sickle and harvest!
For the hour to harvest has come.
The harvest of the earth is ripe!"
16 So the one who sat on the cloud swung his sickle over the earth.
And the earth was harvested.
17 Another angel came out of the temple in heaven.
He too had a sharp sickle.
18 Another angel came out from the altar.
He has power over fire.
He called out with a loud voice to the angel who had the sharp sickle,
"Swing your sharp sickle!
Gather the bunches of grapes from the vine of the earth,
for the earth's grapes are fully ripe!"
19 So the angel swung his sickle over the earth.
He gathered the grapes of the earth.
He threw them into the great winepress of God's anger.
A winepress is a large tub where people crush grapes to make wine.
20 The grapes were crushed in the winepress outside the city.
Blood came out of the winepress.
It was as high as the horses' bridles,
and it spread for about 185 miles.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 14: "One like a son of man" is Jesus (compare 1:13 and Daniel 7:13).

Verses 14–16: The grain harvest is perhaps a picture for God gathering his own. Jesus himself spoke of the harvest as a picture for the end of time (compare Matthew 13:30, 39).

Verses 17–20: The grape harvest is a picture for God's judgment on evil. It recalls Joel 3:13 (in some Bibles Joel 4:13) and Isaiah 63:1–6.

Verse 20: 1,600 stadia are about 185 miles. That is about the length of the land of Israel. The number is a picture: The judgment concerns the whole world. It is not a description of real bloodshed that people are to cause. Judgment belongs to God alone.

"Outside the city": Jesus too was crucified outside the city (Hebrews 13:12).

REVELATION

CHAPTER 15

The song of Moses and of the Lamb

The victors sing VERSES 1–4

1 I saw another sign in the sky.
It was great and amazing.
I saw seven angels with the seven last plagues.
For with them God's anger comes to an end.
2 I saw something like a sea of glass mixed with fire.
I saw the people who had won the victory over the beast,
over his image, and over the number of his name.
They were standing on the sea of glass.
They had harps from God.
3 They sang the song of Moses, the servant of God,
and the song of the Lamb.
They sang,
"Great and amazing are your works, Lord God, the Almighty!
Your ways are right and true, you King of the nations.
4 Who would not fear you, Lord, and give glory to your name?
For only you are holy.
All the nations will come and worship before you.
For your right and just acts have been made known."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "With them God's anger comes to an end": God's anger has an end. After it comes what is new.

Verses 2–3: The sea of glass recalls the Red Sea. Israel went through the sea and was saved. Afterward Moses sang a song with the people (Exodus 15). In the same way, those who are saved sing here by the sea.

"The song of Moses" and "the song of the Lamb": The rescue of Israel out of Egypt and the rescue through Jesus belong together. It is the same God who saves.

Verses 3–4: Many words in this song come from the Psalms and the prophets (for example Psalm 86:9 and Jeremiah 10:7).

Verse 4: "All the nations will come": That is a great hope. In the end all nations are to know God and honor him.

The seven angels with the bowls VERSES 5–8

5 After these things I looked.
The temple in heaven was opened.
It is the tent of the testimony.
6 The seven angels who had the seven plagues came out of the temple.
They were dressed in pure, bright linen.
They wore golden sashes around their chests.
7 One of the four living creatures gave the seven angels seven golden bowls.
The bowls were full of the anger of God, who lives forever and ever.
8 The temple was filled with smoke from the glory of God and from his power.
No one could go into the temple until the seven plagues of the seven angels were finished.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 5: "The tent of the testimony" means the holy tent in the wilderness. In it was the ark of the covenant with the Ten Commandments (Exodus 40).

Verse 8: The smoke recalls how God's glory filled the holy tent and later the temple (Exodus 40:34–35 and 1 Kings 8:10–11). God is very near, but also holy and beyond reach.

The bowls are poured out in the next chapter. Again it is true: These are pictures for God's No to evil, not permission for people to punish others.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 16

The seven bowls

The first three bowls VERSES 1–7

1 I heard a loud voice from the temple.
It said to the seven angels,
"Go and pour out the seven bowls of God's anger on the earth!"
2 The first angel went and poured out his bowl on the earth.
Then bad and painful sores broke out on the people.
These were the people who had the mark of the beast and who worshiped his image.
3 The second angel poured out his bowl into the sea.
The sea turned into blood, like the blood of a dead man.
Every living thing in the sea died.
4 The third angel poured out his bowl into the rivers and springs of water.
They turned into blood.
5 I heard the angel of the waters say,
"You are just and fair, you who are and who were, O Holy One,
because you have judged these things.
6 For they poured out the blood of saints and prophets.
And you have given them blood to drink.
They deserve this."
7 I heard the altar say,
"Yes, Lord God, the Almighty,
your judgments are true and just."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The bowls again recall the plagues in Egypt (Exodus 7–9): sores, water turning into blood.

With the seals, one fourth was affected; with the trumpets, one third. Now it is everything. The warnings become stronger and stronger, because people don't repent.

Verses 5–6: God is righteous. Whoever has poured out innocent blood feels the consequences. For the persecuted Christians this meant: The injustice that you suffer doesn't remain without an answer.

Important: Judgment belongs to God alone. People may not take revenge themselves (compare Romans 12:19).

The fourth and fifth bowls VERSES 8–11

8 The fourth angel poured out his bowl on the sun.
The sun was allowed to burn people with fire.
9 People were burned by the great heat.
They cursed the name of God, who has power over these plagues.
They did not repent and give him glory.
10 The fifth angel poured out his bowl on the throne of the beast.
His kingdom became dark.
People bit their tongues because of the pain.
11 They cursed the God of heaven because of their pains and their sores.
They still did not repent of what they had done.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 9 and 11: What is sad is that the people still don't repent. They know that God has the power. But instead of coming to him, they curse him. The plagues were really meant to call people to repent.

Verse 10: The throne of the beast becomes dark. The power that had itself worshiped like a god collapses.

The sixth bowl: Harmagedon VERSES 12–16

12 The sixth angel poured out his bowl on the great river, the Euphrates.
Its water dried up.
This prepared the way for the kings who come from the east.
13 I saw three unclean spirits that looked like frogs.
They came out of the mouth of the dragon,
out of the mouth of the beast,
and out of the mouth of the false prophet.
14 They are spirits of demons, and they do signs.
They go out to the kings of the whole world.
They gather the kings for the battle on that great day of God, the Almighty.
15 "Look, I am coming like a thief.
Blessed is the one who stays awake and keeps his clothes on.

Then he will not walk around naked, and people will
not see his shame."
16 He gathered them together at the place that is called
"Harmagedon" in Hebrew.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 13: The false prophet is the second beast from Chapter 13. Dragon, beast and false prophet are like an evil imitation of God: Father, Son and Spirit. The frogs again recall a plague in Egypt (Exodus 8).

Verse 15: In the middle of the pictures Jesus himself speaks. He says: Stay awake and faithful. He comes by surprise, "like a thief" (compare Matthew 24:43–44).

Verse 16: "Harmagedon" probably means "Mountain of Megiddo." Megiddo was a city in Israel. Many battles took place there in history. The name is a picture for the last great conflict between good and evil.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Today the word "Armageddon" (Harmagedon) is often used for a great world war or the end of the world. Some people have tried to predict real wars from this passage. That is speculation and has often made people afraid. The Revelation says: The powers of evil gather, but they don't stand a chance. The battle isn't even described. God simply wins (compare 19:19–21).

The seventh bowl: "It is done!" VERSES 17–21

17 The seventh angel poured out his bowl into the air.
A loud voice came out of the temple of heaven, from
the throne.
It said, "It is done!"
18 There was lightning, loud sounds, and thunder.
And there was a great earthquake.
There has never been such an earthquake since there
have been people on the earth.
It was that great and that strong.
19 The great city was split into three parts.
The cities of the nations fell.
God remembered Babylon the great.
He gave her the cup filled with the wine of his fierce
anger.
20 Every island fled away.
The mountains could no longer be found.
21 Huge hailstones fell from the sky on people.
Each one weighed about a talent (about 75 pounds).
People cursed God because of the plague of the hail,
for this plague was terrible.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 17: "It is done!" God's judgment on evil is complete.

Verse 19: "Babylon" is again the code name for Rome and for every evil great power. The next two chapters tell about its fall in detail.

Verse 21: The old measure here is a talent. A talent was a weight of about 75 pounds. That means: unimaginably heavy.

These pictures are not a description of real natural disasters. They show: In the end everything that sets itself against God collapses.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 17

The woman on the beast

IMPORTANT NOTE FIRST

In this chapter a city is shown as a woman, as a "great prostitute." The prophets often used pictures like this when a city was unfaithful to God (for example Isaiah 1:21 and Ezekiel 16).

The picture is about a city and its power, not about women. It says nothing bad about women or about people who work in prostitution. Jesus turned to these very people with love (compare Matthew 21:31).

Verse 16 describes violence against the woman. That is a picture for the downfall of a city. It is never a justification for violence against women. Whoever experiences violence can get help. US: 1-800-799-7233. In an emergency, call your local emergency number (911 in the US, 999 in the UK).

In history, Christians have also used this chapter to speak badly of other churches, for example the Catholic Church. That is unfair. For the first readers it was clear: Rome is meant, the capital of the world empire.

The great prostitute Babylon VERSES 1–6

1 One of the seven angels who had the seven bowls came
and spoke with me.
He said,
"Come here!
I will show you how the great prostitute will be
judged.
She sits on many waters.
2 The kings of the earth committed sexual immorality
with her.
Those who live on the earth became drunk with the
wine of her sexual immorality."
3 Then the Spirit came over me, and the angel carried me
away into a wilderness.
There I saw a woman sitting on a bright red beast.
The beast was covered with names that insulted God.
It had 7 heads and 10 horns.
4 The woman was dressed in purple and bright red.
She was decorated with gold, precious stones, and
pearls.
In her hand she held a golden cup.
It was full of disgusting things and the filth of the
sexual immorality of the earth.
5 A name was written on her forehead:
"MYSTERY,
BABYLON THE GREAT,
THE MOTHER OF THE PROSTITUTES
AND OF THE DISGUSTING THINGS OF THE
EARTH."
6 I saw that the woman was drunk with the blood of the
saints
and with the blood of the martyrs of Jesus.

Martyrs are people who were killed because of their faith.
When I saw her, I was very amazed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: "On many waters": Ancient Babylon lay on the Euphrates with many canals. Verse 15 explains: The waters are the peoples over whom she rules.

Verse 2: "Sexual immorality" here means: The powerful got involved with this city because of money, trade and power. For this they betrayed God and justice.

Verse 4: Purple, gold and pearls show great wealth and luxury. On the outside everything shines. But inside, the cup is full of disgusting things.

Verse 6: This power persecuted and killed Christians. Under Emperor Nero many Christians were killed in Rome.

The woman is the contrasting picture to the woman in Chapter 12 and to the bride of the Lamb in Chapters 19 and 21.

The mystery of the woman and the beast VERSES 7–14

7 The angel said to me,
"Why are you amazed?
I will tell you the secret of the woman,
and the secret of the beast that carries her.
It is the beast with the 7 heads and the 10 horns.
8 The beast you saw was, and is not.
It is about to come up out of the abyss and go to destruction.
Those who live on the earth will be amazed when they see the beast.
For it was, and is not, and will be here again.
These are the people whose names have not been written in the book of life
since the creation of the world.
9 This calls for a mind that has wisdom.
The seven heads are seven mountains.
The woman sits on them.
10 They are also seven kings.
Five have fallen.
One is ruling now.
The other has not come yet.
When he comes, he can only stay for a short time.
11 The beast that was, and is not, is also an eighth king.
He belongs to the seven.
And he is going to destruction.
12 The 10 horns you saw are 10 kings.
They have not received a kingdom yet.
But together with the beast they receive authority as kings for one hour.
13 They all have the same purpose.
They give their power and authority to the beast.
14 They will make war against the Lamb.
But the Lamb will defeat them,
for he is Lord of lords and King of kings.
Those who are with him are called, chosen, and faithful."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: It is said of the beast that it "was, and is not, and will be here again." That is an evil imitation of God, "who is and who was and who is to come" (1:8). The beast pretends to be eternal. But its end is destruction.

Verse 9: Rome is famous as the city on seven hills. For the first readers this was a clear hint.

Verses 10–11: The seven kings are probably Roman emperors. There are many guesses about who exactly is meant. What is important: Their time is limited.

Verse 12: "One hour": Their power is very short.

Verse 14: This is the main message: The Lamb wins. Jesus is "Lord of lords and King of kings," not the emperor. And all who belong to him are with him.

The end of the woman VERSES 15–18

15 He said to me,
"You saw the waters where the prostitute sits.
They are peoples, crowds, nations, and languages.
16 You saw the 10 horns.
They and the beast will hate the prostitute.
They will take everything away from her and leave her alone.
They will strip her naked.
They will eat her flesh,
and they will burn her up completely with fire.
17 For God has put it into their hearts to carry out his plan.
They will have the same purpose.
They will give their kingdom to the beast,
until God's words have come true.
18 The woman you saw is the great city.
It rules over the kings of the earth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: In the end, evil destroys itself. The powers that worked together with the city turn against it. Violence devours itself.

Verse 17: Even the evil powers can't stop God's plan. God keeps the last word.

Verse 18: Here it is said clearly: The woman is the great city which at that time reigned over the kings of the earth. That was Rome. Today we can think of every power that rules with wealth and violence and oppresses people.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 18

Babylon falls

Babylon has fallen VERSES 1–3

1 After these things, I saw another angel coming down from the sky.
He had great authority.
The earth was lit up by his glory.
2 He shouted with a mighty voice,
"Babylon the great has fallen! She has fallen!
She has become a home for demons.

She has become a prison for every unclean spirit,
and a prison for every unclean and hated bird!
3 For all the nations have drunk the wine of the anger of
her sexual immorality.
The kings of the earth committed sexual immorality
with her.
The merchants of the earth grew rich from her great
luxury."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 2: "Babylon the great has fallen" recalls Isaiah 21:9. Ancient Babylon had long been destroyed. Now the new "Babylon" will fall too.

The splendid city becomes a ruin where only wild animals live. The prophets also describe the downfall of cities like this (for example Isaiah 13:21–22).

Verse 3: Babylon stands for an economy that is built only on wealth, luxury and greed.

Come out of her! VERSES 4–8

4 I heard another voice from heaven say,
"Come out of her, my people!
Then you will not take part in her sins,
and you will not receive any of her plagues.
5 For her sins are piled up as high as the sky.
God has remembered the wrong things she has done.
6 Pay her back just as she paid others.
Pay her back double for what she did.
In the cup she mixed for others, mix a double portion
for her.
7 She gave herself glory and lived in luxury.
Give her just as much pain and grief.
For she says in her heart,
'I sit here as a queen.
I am not a widow.
I will never see grief.'
8 That is why her plagues will come in one day:
death, grief, and hunger.
She will be burned up completely with fire.
For the Lord God who has judged her is strong.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: "Come out of her, my people" recalls Jeremiah 51:45. It doesn't necessarily mean that you should move away. It means: Don't take part in greed, exploitation and idol worship.

Verses 6–7: These words are spoken to the powers that carry out God's judgment, not to Christians. Christians are not to take revenge (Romans 12:17–19). The punishment matches what Babylon did to others.

Verse 7: Babylon feels safe and untouchable. She says in her heart: "I sit here as a queen. I am not a widow. I will never see grief." That is how powers talk that raise themselves above all others (compare Isaiah 47:7–8).

The mourning of the kings, merchants and sailors VERSES 9–19

9 The kings of the earth committed sexual immorality
with her and lived in luxury with her.
They will weep and wail over her when they see the
smoke from her burning.
10 They will stand far away, because they are afraid of her
pain.
They will say,
'How terrible, how terrible for the great city!
Babylon, the strong city!
In one hour your judgment has come.'
11 The merchants of the earth weep and mourn over her,
because no one buys their goods anymore.
12 Their goods were gold, silver, precious stones, and
pearls.
They were fine linen, purple cloth, silk, and bright red
cloth.
They were all kinds of expensive wood,
every kind of object made of ivory,
and every kind of object made of very precious wood,
of brass, of iron, and of marble.
13 They were cinnamon, incense, perfume, and
frankincense.
They were wine, olive oil, fine flour, and wheat.
They were cattle, sheep, horses, and chariots.
And they were people's bodies and souls.
14 The fruits you longed for are gone from you.
All your fine and splendid things are lost to you.
You will never find them again.
15 The merchants who sold these things became rich from
her.
They will stand far away, because they are afraid of her
pain.
They will weep and mourn.
16 They will say,
'How terrible, how terrible for the great city!
She was dressed in fine linen, purple, and bright red.
She was decorated with gold, precious stones, and
pearls!
17 In one hour all this great wealth has been destroyed.'
Every ship captain, everyone who travels by ship, the
sailors,
and everyone who earns a living from the sea stood far
away.
18 They saw the smoke from her burning and cried out,
'What city is like the great city?'
19 They threw dust on their heads.
They cried out, weeping and mourning.
They said,
'How terrible, how terrible for the great city!
All who had ships on the sea became rich through her
great wealth!'
For in one hour she has been destroyed.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

These laments recall the lament over the trading city of Tyre in the prophet Ezekiel (Ezekiel 26–27).

Verses 9–19: The kings, merchants and sailors don't really weep for the people in the city. They weep for their money and their business. And they stand "far away": No one helps.

Verse 13: The long list ends with a shocking phrase: "people's bodies and souls." This means slaves. In the Roman Empire people were sold like goods. The Bible names this here clearly as a reason for the judgment.

That is important today, too: Human trafficking and exploitation still exist. God does care about this. If you are affected or notice something, you can call the police (911 in the US, 999 in the UK) or a hotline against human trafficking: in the US, the National Human Trafficking

Hotline at 1-888-373-7888; in the UK, the Modern Slavery Helpline at 08000 121 700.

Babylon will be found no more VERSES 20–24

20 "Be glad over her, O heaven,
you saints, apostles, and prophets!
For God has judged her for what she did to you."
21 A mighty angel picked up a stone like a great millstone.
He threw it into the sea and said,
"In the same way Babylon, the great city, will be
thrown down with violence.
It will never be found again.
22 The sound of harpists, musicians, flute players, and
trumpeters
will never be heard in you again.
No worker of any trade will ever be found in you again.
The sound of a mill will never be heard in you again.
23 The light of a lamp will never shine in you again.
The voice of the bridegroom and of the bride will
never be heard in you again.
For your merchants were the princes of the earth.
And with your magic all the nations were deceived.
24 In her was found the blood of prophets and of saints,
and of all who have been killed on the earth."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 20: That means: God has given you justice against her.

Verse 21: The picture of the stone in the water recalls Jeremiah 51:63–64. As a stone sinks in the sea, so Babylon disappears forever.

Verses 22–23: A sad list: no more music, no work, no light, no weddings. A city without life. That is how a power ends that is built on violence and greed.

Verse 24: Babylon is guilty of the blood of all who were unjustly killed. God forgets no victim of violence.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 19

Hallelujah! The wedding of the Lamb

Hallelujah in heaven VERSES 1–5

1 After these things I heard something like the loud voice
of a great crowd in heaven.
They said,
"Hallelujah!
Salvation, power, and glory belong to our God.
2 For his judgments are true and just.
He has judged the great prostitute.
She ruined the earth with her sexual immorality.
He has made her pay for the blood of his servants that
she shed."
3 A second time they said,
"Hallelujah!
Her smoke goes up forever and ever."
4 The 24 elders and the four living creatures bowed
down.
They worshiped God, who sits on the throne.
They said, "Amen! Hallelujah!"
5 A voice came from the throne.
It said,
"Praise our God, all you his servants,
you who fear him, the small and the great!"

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

"Hallelujah" is Hebrew and means: Praise God! (Hallelu = praise, Jah = short form of the name of God). The word often appears in the Psalms (for example Psalms 146–150). In the New Testament it appears only here in this chapter.

Verse 2: The people in heaven don't rejoice over the suffering, but that injustice has an end. The victims receive justice.

Verse 5: All are to praise God, "the small and the great." With God everyone counts.

The wedding of the Lamb VERSES 6–10

6 I heard something like the voice of a great crowd.
It was like the sound of many waters
and like the sound of loud thunder.
They said,
"Hallelujah!
For the Lord our God, the Almighty, rules as king!
7 Let's be glad and very happy!
Let's give him the glory!
For the time has come for the wedding of the Lamb.
His wife has made herself ready."
8 She was given bright, pure, fine linen to wear.
The fine linen is the good and right deeds of the saints.
9 The angel said to me,
"Write this:
'Blessed are those who are invited to the wedding
supper of the Lamb.'"
He also said to me,
"These are true words of God."
10 I fell down at his feet to worship him.
But he said to me,
"Look! Don't do that!
I am a servant, just like you
and like your brothers who hold on to the testimony of
Jesus.
Worship God!
For the testimony of Jesus is the Spirit of Prophecy."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: The Bible often uses the picture of a wedding for the love between God and his people (for example Isaiah 62:5 and Hosea 2). Jesus compared God's Kingdom to a wedding feast (Matthew 22). The "wife" of the Lamb is the community of all who belong to Jesus.

Verse 8: The bride's dress is a gift ("She was given"). It is made of the good deeds of those who believe. That is the contrasting picture to the splendidly decked prostitute in Chapter 17.

Verse 9: This is the fourth "Blessed" in the Revelation. God invites people to his feast.

Verse 10: Not even an angel may be worshiped. Worship belongs to God alone. That is also true for saints, preachers

or other people.

The rider on the white horse VERSES 11–16

11 I saw heaven standing open.
There was a white horse.
The one who sits on it is called Faithful and True.
He judges and makes war in a just way.
12 His eyes are like a flame of fire.
On his head are many crowns.
He has names written on him.
And he has a name written that no one knows except he himself.
13 He wears a robe that is sprinkled with blood.
His name is "The Word of God."
14 The armies of heaven followed him on white horses.
They were dressed in white, pure, fine linen.
15 A sharp sword with two edges comes out of his mouth.
With it he will strike the nations.
He will rule them with a rod of iron.
He crushes the grapes in the winepress of the fierce anger of God, the Almighty.
16 A name is written on his robe and on his thigh:
"KING OF KINGS AND LORD OF LORDS."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The rider is Jesus. He is called "Faithful and True" (compare 3:14). His name is "The Word of God" (verse 13). Compare John 1:1.

Verse 13: His robe is already sprinkled with blood before the battle begins. Many understand it like this: It is his own blood that he shed on the cross. He wins by giving himself.

Verse 14: The armies carry no weapons and wear no armor, but white clothes. They don't fight themselves.

Verse 15: The sword comes out of his mouth. It is his word, not a real weapon. Jesus wins through the truth.

IMPORTANT NOTE

In the course of history people have used pictures like these to justify wars and violence in the name of Christ, for example in the Crusades. That is a terrible misuse. In the Revelation, Christ alone fights, and he does so with his word. His people carry no weapons. Jesus himself said: "Put your sword back into its place!" (Matthew 26:52).

The beast is defeated VERSES 17–21

17 I saw an angel standing in the sun.
He called out with a loud voice to all the birds that fly in the sky,
"Come!
Gather together for the great supper of God!
18 Come and eat the flesh of kings,
the flesh of captains, and the flesh of mighty men.
Eat the flesh of horses and of their riders.
Eat the flesh of all people, both free and slave, small and great."
19 I saw the beast, the kings of the earth, and their armies.
They had gathered together to make war against the one who sat on the horse,
and against his army.
20 The beast was captured.
The false prophet was captured with him.
The false prophet had done signs in front of the beast.
With these signs he had deceived the people who had received the mark of the beast
and who worshiped his image.
These two were thrown alive into the lake of fire that burns with sulfur.
21 The rest were killed with the sword of the one who sat on the horse.
It was the sword that came out of his mouth.
All the birds ate their fill of their flesh.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 17–18: A terrible contrasting picture to the wedding supper in verse 9. There are two "meals": the feast for those who are invited, and the end of the powers that set themselves against God. The picture comes from Ezekiel 39:17–20.

Verses 19–21: There is no real battle at all. The beast and the false prophet are simply captured. God wins without effort. And he wins with the word from his mouth.

Verse 20: The "lake of fire" is a picture for the final end of evil. The powers that deceived and oppressed people are defeated forever.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 20

The 1,000 years and the last judgment

Satan is bound VERSES 1–3

1 I saw an angel coming down out of heaven.
In his hand he had the key to the abyss and a great chain.
2 He grabbed the dragon, the old serpent.
The dragon is the devil and Satan.
He leads the whole world astray.
The angel tied him up for 1,000 years.
3 He threw him into the abyss.
He shut it and put a seal on it over him.
So the dragon could no longer lead the nations astray until the 1,000 years were over.
After that, he must be set free for a short time.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The devil is bound. He is not as strong as he pretends. A single angel is enough to tie him up.

Verse 3: He may no longer deceive the nations. His power is limited.

The 1,000 years VERSES 4–6

4 I saw thrones.
People sat on them, and they were given the power to judge.

I saw the souls of the people whose heads had been cut off
because of the testimony of Jesus and because of the word of God.
They had not worshiped the beast or his image.
They had not received the mark on their forehead or on their hand.
They came to life and ruled with Christ for 1,000 years.

5 The rest of the dead did not come to life until the 1,000 years were over.
This is the first resurrection.
Resurrection means: rising from the dead.

6 Blessed and holy are those who have a part in the first resurrection.
The second death has no power over them.
They will be priests of God and of Christ.
They will rule with him for 1,000 years.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 4: The martyrs, who were killed because they stayed faithful, are honored. The world condemned them. But God declares them right.

Christians have thought very differently about the "1,000 years":

– Some think: The 1,000 years are a picture for the time of the church now, between the resurrection of Jesus and his coming again. Many large churches see it this way.

– Others think: Jesus comes again and then reigns on earth for 1,000 years.

– Still others think: The world gets better little by little, and after that Jesus comes.

All agree: Christ wins, and the faithful are with him. The number 1,000 means a very long, complete time.

IMPORTANT NOTE

The National Socialists (Nazis) called their state the "Thousand-Year Reich." In doing so they misused this Bible text. Their empire was the opposite of what is meant here: It murdered millions of people, especially 6 million Jews. It has nothing to do with God's Kingdom.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 6: This is the fifth "Blessed" in the Revelation. Whoever belongs to Christ doesn't need to fear the "second death."

The last battle VERSES 7–10

7 After the 1,000 years are over, Satan will be set free from his prison.

8 He will come out to lead the nations astray.
They are in the four corners of the earth: Gog and Magog.
He will gather them together for the battle.
There are as many of them as there is sand by the sea.

9 They marched across the whole earth.
They surrounded the camp of the saints and the city God loves.
But fire came down out of heaven from God and burned them up.

10 The devil who had deceived them was thrown into the lake of fire and sulfur.
The beast and the false prophet are there too.
They will be tormented day and night forever and ever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 8: "Gog and Magog" appear in the prophet Ezekiel (Ezekiel 38–39). There they are pictures for enemy powers from faraway lands. Here they stand for all the powers that set themselves against God. They are not particular countries of today.

Verse 9: Again there is no battle. God ends the attack immediately. The saints don't have to fight themselves.

Verse 10: The devil is defeated for good. He can never deceive again.

The great judgment VERSES 11–15

11 I saw a great white throne and the one who sat on it.
The earth and the sky fled away from his face.
There was no place left for them.

12 I saw the dead, the great and the small, standing before the throne.
Books were opened.
Another book was opened too.
It is the book of life.
The dead were judged by what was written in the books,
according to their works.
That means: by what they had done.

13 The sea gave up the dead who were in it.
Death and Hades gave up the dead who were in them.
Each one was judged according to his works.

14 Death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire.
The lake of fire is the second death.

15 Anyone whose name was not found written in the book of life
was thrown into the lake of fire.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 12: Before God all stand as equals, "the great and the small." No one can buy his way out with money or power.

"According to their works": It is not unimportant how people live. God takes seriously what people do, especially what they have done to others. For the victims of injustice that is a comfort.

But there is also the "book of life." In it are the names of the people who belong to the Lamb (13:8 and 21:27). Salvation doesn't come from your own works, but from God's grace.

Verse 14: A wonderful sentence: Death itself is destroyed. There will never be death again (compare 21:4 and 1 Corinthians 15:26).

IMPORTANT NOTE

These verses are serious. But they are not meant to make anyone afraid who is seeking God. Whoever wants to know whether he is written in the book of life may hold on to Jesus: He promised not to throw out anyone who comes to him (compare John 6:37).

We don't know exactly how God will deal with each person in the end. But we do know: God is just, and God is love.

Whoever is very afraid of the judgment can talk with someone. In the US, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans at 116 123. Elsewhere, find help at findahelpline.com.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 21

The new heaven and the new earth

God makes all things new VERSES 1–8

1 I saw a new heaven and a new earth.
For the first heaven and the first earth had passed away.
And the sea is no more.
2 I saw the holy city, New Jerusalem, coming down out
of heaven from God.
It was made ready like a bride who is dressed
beautifully for her husband.
3 I heard a loud voice from heaven say,
"Look! God's home is with people.
He will live with them.
They will be his people.
God himself will be with them as their God.
4 He will wipe away every tear from their eyes.
There will be no more death.
There will be no more grief, no more crying, and no
more pain.
The first things have passed away."
5 The one who sits on the throne said,
"Look, I am making all things new."
He said,
"Write this down,
for these words of God are trustworthy and true."
6 He said to me,
"I am the Alpha and the Omega, the Beginning and the
End.
I will give water from the spring of the water of life
as a free gift to anyone who is thirsty.
7 Whoever wins the victory will receive these things.
I will be his God, and he will be my son.
8 But there is a place for the cowardly, the unbelieving,
the sinners,
and those who do disgusting things.
It is also for murderers, the sexually immoral, those
who practice magic,
those who worship idols, and all liars.
Their place is in the lake that burns with fire and
sulfur.
That is the second death."

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 1: This is the great goal of the whole Bible. The Bible begins with the creation of heaven and earth (Genesis 1). It ends with a new heaven and a new earth. The promise is already in Isaiah (Isaiah 65:17).

"The sea is no more": The sea was a picture for chaos and danger. The beast came out of the sea (13:1). In God's new world there is nothing threatening any more.

Verse 2: The New Jerusalem comes down from heaven to earth. God doesn't take people away from the earth. He comes to them.

Verse 3: This is the goal of God's whole story with people: God lives with them. He already promised this to Israel (for example Leviticus 26:11–12 and Ezekiel 37:27).

Verse 4 is one of the most comforting sentences in the Bible: God wipes away every tear. No more death, no mourning, no pain. Whoever is grieving may hold on to this hope.

Verse 5: "I am making all things new": God doesn't throw the world away. He makes it new.

Verse 6: Alpha is the first letter of the Greek alphabet, and Omega is the last. God is the beginning and the end of everything.

"As a free gift": You can't buy the water of life. God gives it as a gift.

IMPORTANT NOTE

Verse 8 is a warning, not a verdict on individual people. It is interesting: "The cowardly" come first. This means those who gave up their faith out of fear and took part in emperor worship. It is a call to courage.

None of us is without guilt. Whoever looks at this list and finds himself in it may still come to God. Verse 6 says: Whoever is thirsty receives it as a free gift. God forgives (compare 1 John 1:9).

The holy city VERSES 9–21

9 One of the seven angels came and spoke with me.
He was one of the angels who had the seven bowls full
of the seven last plagues.
He said,
"Come here!
I will show you the bride, the Lamb's wife."
10 Then the Spirit came over me,
and the angel carried me away to a great, high
mountain.
He showed me the holy city, Jerusalem,
coming down out of heaven from God.
11 It had the glory of God.
Its light was like a very precious stone,
like a jasper stone, clear as crystal.
12 It had a great, high wall with 12 gates.
At the gates were 12 angels.
Names were written on the gates.
They are the names of the 12 tribes of the people of
Israel.
13 There were three gates on the east,
three gates on the north,
three gates on the south,
and three gates on the west.
14 The wall of the city had 12 foundation stones.
On them were the 12 names of the 12 Apostles of the
Lamb.
15 The angel who spoke with me had a golden measuring
stick.
He was to measure the city, its gates, and its walls.
16 The city is square.
It is as long as it is wide.
He measured the city with the measuring stick:
It was about 1,400 miles.
Its length, its width, and its height are the same.

17 Its wall is about 216 feet.
That is by a human measure, which the angel was using too.
18 The wall was built of jasper.
The city was pure gold, like clear glass.
19 The foundation stones of the city wall were decorated with all kinds of precious stones.
The first foundation stone was jasper,
the second sapphire,
the third chalcedony,
the fourth emerald,
20 the fifth sardonyx,
the sixth sardius,
the seventh chrysolite,
the eighth beryl,
the ninth topaz,
the tenth chrysoprase,
the eleventh jacinth,
and the twelfth amethyst.
21 The 12 gates were 12 pearls.
Each gate was made of a single pearl.
The street of the city was pure gold, like glass you can see through.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verses 12–14: On the gates are the names of the 12 tribes of Israel. On the foundations are the names of the 12 apostles. Israel and the church both belong to God's city. Israel has not been replaced. God's people are Israel and the church together.

Verse 13: There are gates in every direction. People from the whole world are welcome.

Verse 16: The city is a cube. The Most Holy Place in the temple was also a cube (1 Kings 6:20). The whole city is now like the Most Holy Place: God is very near everywhere.

The old measure is given in stadia. 12,000 stadia are about 1,400 miles. The WEB, our English source text, has 12,012 stadia here. Most manuscripts have 12,000. The number means: unimaginably large, room for everyone.

Verse 17: The wall measures 144 cubits. A cubit is about 18 inches. 144 cubits are about 216 feet. 144 is 12 times 12, again the number of the whole people of God.

Verses 19–20: The precious stones recall the 12 stones on the breastpiece of the high priest (Exodus 28:17–21). The names of some stones are no longer completely certain today.

Verse 21: Each gate is made of a single huge pearl. Here gold is as common as paving stones. What counts most on earth is completely ordinary in God's world.

God and the Lamb are its light VERSES 22–27

22 I saw no temple in the city.
For the Lord God, the Almighty, and the Lamb are its temple.
23 The city does not need the sun or the moon to shine on it.
For the glory of God gives it light,
and the Lamb is its lamp.
24 The nations will walk in its light.
The kings of the earth bring the glory and honor of the nations into it.
25 Its gates will never be shut during the day,
and there will be no night there.
26 People will bring the glory and the honor of the nations into it,
so that they may enter.
27 Nothing unholy will ever enter it.
No one who does disgusting things or tells lies will enter.
Only those whose names are written in the Lamb's book of life will enter.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 22: There is no more temple. You don't need a special place any more to meet God. God is directly present everywhere.

Verse 23 recalls Isaiah 60:19–20.

Verses 24–26: The nations and kings come into the city and bring their treasures with them. The good from all cultures finds a place in God's new world (compare Isaiah 60:3–11).

Verse 25: The gates are always open. There is no more danger. God's city is open and welcoming.

REVELATION

CHAPTER 22

The water of life – Jesus is coming

The river and the tree of life VERSES 1–5

1 The angel showed me a river of the water of life.
It was as clear as crystal.
It flowed out from the throne of God and of the Lamb
2 down the middle of the city's street.
On both sides of the river was the tree of life.
It bears 12 kinds of fruit.
It gives its fruit every month.
The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations.
3 There will be no more curse.
The throne of God and of the Lamb will be in the city.
His servants will serve him.
4 They will see his face.
His name will be on their foreheads.
5 There will be no night.
They will not need the light of a lamp or the light of the sun.
For the Lord God will give them light.
They will rule as kings forever and ever.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Here the circle of the whole Bible closes. At the beginning the tree of life stood in the Garden of Eden (Genesis 2:9). After the curse, people no longer had access to it (Genesis 3:22–24). Now it stands there again, for everyone.

Verses 1–2: The river recalls the river flowing out of the temple in the prophet Ezekiel (Ezekiel 47:1–12). Wherever it flows, everything comes to life.

Verse 2: "For the healing of the nations": God's new world heals all the wounds between the nations.

Verse 3: "No more curse": Everything that has gone wrong since the beginning is healed.

Verse 4: "They will see his face": That is the greatest longing in the Bible. Moses was not allowed to see God's face (Exodus 33:20). Now it becomes possible. There is no more separation between God and people.

Jesus is coming soon VERSES 6–15

6 He said to me,
"These words are trustworthy and true.
The Lord, the God of the spirits of the prophets, sent his angel.
He sent him to show his servants the things that must happen soon."
7 "Look, I am coming soon!
Blessed is the one who keeps the words of the prophecy in this book."
8 I, John, am the one who heard and saw these things.
When I had heard and seen them,
I fell down at the feet of the angel who had shown me these things.
I wanted to worship him.
9 But he said to me,
"You must not do that!
I am a servant, just like you
and like your brothers, the prophets,
and like those who keep the words of this book.
Worship God!"
10 He said to me,
"Don't keep the words of the prophecy of this book secret,
for the time is near.
11 Whoever does wrong, let him keep on doing wrong.
Whoever is filthy, let him keep on being filthy.
Whoever is righteous, let him keep on doing what is right.
Whoever is holy, let him keep on being holy."
12 "Look, I am coming soon!
I bring my reward with me.
I will pay back each person according to what he has done.
13 I am the Alpha and the Omega,
the First and the Last,
the Beginning and the End.
14 Blessed are those who do his commandments.
They will have the right to the tree of life.
They may go through the gates into the city.
15 Outside are the dogs, those who practice magic,
the sexually immoral, the murderers, and those who worship idols.
Outside is everyone who loves lies and tells lies.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 7: This is the sixth "Blessed" in the Revelation. Verse 14 is the seventh and last. Seven is the number of perfection.

Verse 10: In the book of Daniel the words were to be sealed (Daniel 12:4). Not here: The message is to be read openly, now.

Verse 11: This sentence sounds harsh. It probably means: Time is pressing. Every person shows by his life what he decides for. But the door is still open (verse 17).

Verse 14: Here it says: "Blessed are those who do his commandments." Some manuscripts have instead: Blessed are those who wash their robes (compare 7:14).

Verse 15: At that time "dogs" was an insult for people who behaved shamelessly. It is a picture. It is not permission to insult other people. And here too it is true: The gates of the city are never shut (21:25). Everyone may turn back.

Come! VERSES 16–21

16 I, Jesus, have sent my angel to tell you these things for the churches.
I am the root and the offspring of David.
I am the Bright and Morning Star."
17 The Spirit and the bride say, "Come!"
Whoever hears this should say, "Come!"
Whoever is thirsty should come.
Whoever wants it may take the water of life as a free gift.
18 I warn everyone who hears the words of the prophecy of this book:
If anyone adds anything to them,
God will add to him the plagues that are written in this book.
19 If anyone takes anything away from the words of the book of this prophecy,
God will take away his part in the tree of life and in the holy city.
They are written about in this book.
20 The one who tells about these things says,
"Yes, I am coming soon."
Amen! Yes, come, Lord Jesus!
21 May the grace of the Lord Jesus Christ be with all the saints.
Amen.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Verse 16: Jesus himself speaks. He is "the root and the offspring of David": He comes from the Jewish people and is the promised Messiah (compare Isaiah 11:1). He is the "Morning Star," the star that announces the new day.

Verse 17: This is the great invitation at the end of the Bible. Everyone who is thirsty may come. The water of life is free. No one who wants to come is shut out.

Verses 18–19: This warning is for the book of Revelation. At that time books were copied by hand. No one was to change the message. The warning recalls Deuteronomy 4:2. For this translation it was an important rule: No verse and no word is left out.

Verse 20: "Come, Lord Jesus!" is one of the oldest prayers of Christians. In Aramaic, the language of Jesus, it is "Maranatha" (compare 1 Corinthians 16:22).

Verse 21: The Bible ends with a blessing: grace. God's kindness has the last word.

Looking back: What have we read in the Revelation?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

Jesus lives: John sees Jesus in his glory. "Don't be afraid" (Chapter 1).

Seven letters: Jesus knows his churches, praises them, warns them and gives them courage (Chapters 2–3).

God sits on the throne: Not the emperor, but God rules the world (Chapter 4).

The Lamb wins: God doesn't win through violence, but through Jesus giving himself on the cross (Chapter 5).

Seals, trumpets and bowls: Pictures for war, need and judgment. Evil has limits, and God calls people to repent again and again (Chapters 6–16).

Dragon and beasts: Behind violence and oppression is evil. But it is already defeated (Chapters 12–13).

Babylon falls: Every power built on greed, exploitation and violence goes down (Chapters 17–18).

The wedding of the Lamb: God invites people to his feast (Chapter 19).

The judgment: God takes injustice seriously. And death itself is destroyed (Chapter 20).

All things new: God lives with people. No more tears, no death, no pain (Chapters 21–22).

For today: The Revelation doesn't want to make people afraid, but to give hope. No matter how dark it is: God has the last word, and his last word is grace.

Looking back: What have we read in the whole Bible?

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN?

The Bible is not a single story, but a whole library. It has 66 books and 1,189 chapters. Many people wrote it over more than 1,000 years.

In the beginning: God creates heaven and earth. Everything is good. People are created in God's image (Genesis 1–2).

The break: People turn away from God. Suffering, violence and death come into the world (Genesis 3–11).

God's way with Israel: God calls Abraham and promises: Through you all peoples will be blessed. He frees Israel from Egypt, gives the Torah at Sinai and goes with his people through good and hard times. Prophets call people to repent and announce hope. Psalms bring praise and lament before God.

Jesus: God becomes human. Jesus, a Jew from Nazareth, tells about God's Kingdom, heals, forgives, dies on the cross and is raised by God.

The first church: The Holy Spirit comes. The Good News goes from Jerusalem into all the world. Letters encourage the churches.

In the end: God makes all things new. The tree of life, which was lost at the beginning, is there again. God lives with people.

A common thread runs through the whole Bible: God doesn't give up on his people. He seeks them, he saves them, and he stays faithful to his promises, to Israel and to all peoples.

WHAT COMES NEXT?

With this, the whole Bible has been put into plain language, all 66 books and 1,189 chapters, verse by verse, without leaving anything out.

The Bible is not something you read once and then put away. Many people read it again and again all their lives. It is good to read it together with others and to talk about it.

Whoever has questions can turn, for example, to a local church, a pastor, a priest or a counselor.

Help is available

You are not alone.

If you are not doing well, it is okay to ask for help.

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (USA)
Call or text 988
free, 24 hours a day

Childhelp National Child Abuse Hotline (USA)
1-800-422-4453
free, 24 hours a day

National Domestic Violence Hotline (USA)
1-800-799-7233
free, 24 hours a day

RAINN Sexual Assault Hotline (USA)
1-800-656-4673
free, 24 hours a day

Samaritans (UK and Ireland)
116 123
free, 24 hours a day

Childline (UK, for children and young people)
0800 1111
free

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findahelpline.com
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911 (USA) · 999 (UK) · 112 (Europe)
police, ambulance, fire